

The European Civil War 1917–1945

National Socialism and Bolshevism

by Ernst Nolte

Translated and presented by

Theognis of Megara

The Indo-European Friendship Club

CONTENTS

Preface:

In Place of a Foreword to the 5th Edition

Introduction:

Introduction

Chapter I — Final Point and Prelude 1933:

The Anti-Marxist Seizure of Power in Germany

Final Point and Prelude 1933: The Anti-Marxist Seizure of Power in Germany

Chapter II — Looking Back in the Years 1917–32:

Communists, National Socialists, Soviet Russia

Section 1: Russia's Collapse and the Drive towards World Revolution: The February Revolution and the 1917 Bolshevik Seizure of Power

Section 2: The Emergence of the Communist Party of Germany from the World War and the Russian Revolution

Section 3: The Victory of the Bolsheviks and the Defeats of the Communist Party of Germany 1919-1921

Section 4: Early Anti-Bolshevism and the First Rise of Hitler

Section 5: "World Revolution" or "National Government" in Germany? The Crisis Year of 1923

Section 6: The Soviet Union from the Death of Lenin to the Establishment of Stalin's Autocracy

Section 7: The Period of Stabilization of the Weimar Republic 1924-1929

Section 8: State Relations between Germany and the Soviet Union

Section 9: The Limited Civil War in Germany

Section 10: The Eve of the National Socialist Takeover

Chapter III — The Hostile Ideological-States

in Peace 1933–1941

Section 1: National Socialist Germany and the Communist Soviet Union in 1933/34

Section 2: The "Röhm Putsch" and the Assassination of Kirov in 1934

Section 3: World Politics 1935/1936

Section 4: Germany and the Soviet Union in the Spanish Civil War

Section 5: The "Great Purge" and the Construction Pathos in the Soviet Union

Section 6: Hitler's Triumphs and the Consensus of the National-Community (Volksgemeinschaft)

Section 7: The Failure of the Anti-Communist and Anti-Fascist Concepts in Great European Politics

Section 8: The Hitler-Stalin Pact as the Beginning of the European Prelude to World War II

Section 9: The Fragile Alliance: Triumphs, Gains, Tensions

Chapter IV — Structures of Two One-Party States

Section 1: The State Parties and Their Leaders

Section 2: The State Security Organs and Terror

Section 3: The Youth Associations

Section 4: Understanding of Self and Others in Literature and Propaganda

Section 5: The Politicized Culture

Section 6: Law and Lawlessness

Section 7: Emigration and Resistance

Section 8: Total Mobilization

Chapter V — The German-Soviet War 1941–1945

Section 1: The Attack against the Soviet Union: Decisive Battle? —Liberation Campaign? — War of Extermination?

Section 2: Necessities, Coincidences and Alternatives in the German-Soviet War

Section 3: World War of Ideologies?

Section 4: Genocides and “Final Solution to the Jewish Question”

Section 5: The Change of Characteristics and the Paradoxical Victory of the Soviet Union

Conclusion:

Conclusionary Reflection: From the European Civil War 1917-1945 to the World Civil War 1947-1990

Letter from François Furet:

Letter from François Furet to Ernst Nolte

Appendix:

STATEMENT TO MY READERS

Preface

In Place of a Foreword to the 5th Edition

"Dispute", confrontation, is something quite ordinary and endless in science and journalism; where there is no dispute, there is no "spiritual life" and, at best, there is only the inner harmony of a sect. From time to time the term is used with special emphasis, when the major tendencies clash and wrestle with one another for a long time. In German historiography there was the "method controversy" over the sociological or "collectivist" approach of Karl Lamprecht, and later in sociology, the "positivism controversy." Another significant and momentous dispute among historians was the so-called Fischer controversy of the 1960s, which raised the question of the character and extent of Germany's guilt in World War I, but which took its name from the initiator or author. The term "Historians' Dispute" is today almost exclusively associated with the argument that began in 1986 and continued with great and increasingly one-sided bitterness at least until autumn of 1988, when a statement by the then Federal President the Bamberg Historians' Day seemed to mark the end. A 1991 publication listed nearly 1,200 articles and nearly three dozen books that had been published by the end of 1988; only the collapse of the communist regimes in Eastern Europe and the reunification of Germany caused interest to wane. However, it was precisely these revolutionary historical events that raised the question of whether there was an internal connection with the "Historians' Dispute," and whether one could even say that "History" had made a decision that could not be brought about by theses and arguments.

One of the starting points of the dispute was the intention of the Federal Government to build a German Historical Museum in Berlin, and this plan was almost unanimously criticized by the "left-wing intellectuals" in the strongest possible terms, because it seemed to stem from the desire to "dispose" of the German past and to recover a "normal" view of history; but this diverted the view from the singular crimes of National Socialism and pushed the desire for a radical new beginning into the background, which, admittedly, had been neglected in the

history of the Federal Republic from its beginning in comparison with the urge for a revival. This museum was actually established in Berlin in 1991 in the armory on Unter den Linden, where the GDR Historical Museum was located. The other side, which people liked to call "right-wing", had not made the corresponding demand either; if it had done so, the waves of indignation would have been far higher.

In 1986, Jürgen Habermas spoke with a high negativity of the "German-national tinted NATO-philosophy" attributable to the opposing party, and had fought in opposition against a view that instrumentalized the "expulsion of the kulaks" in Stalin's Soviet Union in order to relativize the singularity of the Nazi regime, and to label the Soviet Union as a hostile power that was "still on our doorstep". In 1991, there was general satisfaction that the reunified Germany remained "anchored" in NATO, and no one seriously doubted that the power that was now withdrawing its troops from Germany had really an enemy, an enemy of the whole "West."

In 1986, Hans Mommsen was extremely negative about anti-Bolshevism, about those "anti-communist resentments" which the opponents see as decisive and which find their expression in the "theory of totalitarianism", a theory which considers "merely external similarities to be constitutive" and does not want to admit it that the communist systems of rule, in stark contrast to the fascist ones, are not subject to any process of self-destruction. In 1991, "dissidents" took over the governments everywhere in Eastern Europe and made no secret of their anti-communism, or at least anti-Sovietism; The term "totalitarianism" was used by almost all intellectuals as a matter of course, and by no means only with reference to a "Stalinist" phase; that the events had been preceded by a "self-destruction of communism" had become an obvious insight. The view that the 20th century actually only began in 1917 with the October Revolution of the Bolsheviks and ended with the collapse of the Soviet Union in 1991 also seemed to be gaining ground.

But with all this, the questions that had proven to be the core of the historians' dispute by 1988 were, in fact, not answered: whether between Soviet communism and the militant anti-communism of the fascist movements and regimes, especially the radical fascist National Socialism that came to power in Germany that there was a relationship of action and re-action, of challenge and response, of the original and the copy, and whether a "causal nexus", if it did exist, could also be established between the extermination measures of the two regimes. It was precisely these problems that were articulated in my article "The Past That Will Not Pass" in the *Frankfurter Allgemeine Zeitung* on June 6, 1986, with the question "Was not the Gulag Archipelago more Original than Auschwitz?" with the statement a causal

nexus between the two was probable.

Questions like these could not be decided by historical events alone. They could, however, be explained more comprehensively and justified more clearly. This is exactly what happened from my side in the present book which appeared in 1987, and it was the prerequisite in the matter as the result of that article, which nevertheless may be regarded as its expansion and source-based elaboration. Certainly, even the book alone cannot dispel the counter-arguments, the main point being that National Socialism must be explained from the premises of German history and that this also applies to "Auschwitz," i.e. to the "Final Solution of the Jewish Question" as an absolutely singular, indeed incomparable, event, that lacks the rational connection that existed in the Gulag between real enemies of the regime and their destruction. Furthermore, the physical destruction was not intended in the Gulag, but only formed an incidental, even if terrible and extensive, consequence. Another objection is that the struggle between two ideologies and mass movements, communism and National Socialism, was merely a mask for the power struggle between two great states, so that the term "European civil war" is unjustified. The two declarations do not cancel each other out because they contradict each other, because at least the National Socialist regime must be ascribed state character of a very special kind, if one does not want to arrive at the absurd opinion that there was no "Auschwitz" in the First World War was only by chance. The weight of a third objection cannot be denied either: that the extermination measures against real or alleged enemies, i.e. "the Gulag" and "Auschwitz," were consistent actions of two "cleansing ideologies", but were merely parallel phenomena, between which there were no "causal nexus."

A completely different kind of argument than this one were the allegations and insinuations concerning the motives of the main participants or their effects: the goal to suppress "German crimes," what "we have done," in an apology for the leaders of the Wehrmacht, in the "whitewashing of German industries," in the macabre offsetting of mass crimes against one another; the guiding principle was the desire to make Bolshevism or even Marxism the real culprit for all the crimes of the 20th century, and consequently the intention to promote the great oblivion that has long been around in Germany through "relativization" and "historicization." As far as I know, in all of these polemics the consideration of whether it might not be a matter of more comprehensive and fairer remembrance has not even rudimentarily been raised.

One might have expected, however, that after ten years and after the surprising developments of this decade, some representatives of the "other side" in the historians' dispute would have

asked themselves what balance should now be drawn: whether one should not renounce some of the old arguments and agree with the opponents in one respect or another. If I am not mistaken, this happened on the part of only one of the participants, namely Heinrich August Winkler, who wrote an article in the *Frankfurter Rundschau* of October 29, 1996, titled "Inspection of the Obverse. Ten Years Later: A Retrospective of the German Historians' Dispute." Winkler reproaches himself here for having displayed an unjustified self-assurance ten years ago in another article in the same newspaper and for demanding that the Germans no longer strive for a sovereign nation-state and should therefore recognize the two state system, which was after all a consequence of the fateful role Germany played in both world wars. But his view was based on a "secularized theology of history," which was also decisive for many of the other "left-wing" contributions to the discussion. The conviction that the National Socialist crimes could be atoned for by the division of Germany had become the "great life-lie of the West German left," and today it was time to "question the morality to many moral-sounding and morally cautious arguments from the time of the historians' dispute." In this way, Winkler brings up a considerable amount of self-criticism, but with regard to the adversary who had put forward those objectionable theses about the "causal nexus," he held to his earlier opinion: Ernst Nolte had an "apologetic intention," that he had argued nationalistically and revisionistically. In the "long version" of his article, in the *European Civil War 1917-1945*, he had "taken up" the "theme of the century" of the interrelationships between communism, fascism and democracy, but because of its intent of apology, the ordeal had ended "in an analytical debacle."

In a less direct way, however, other participants have also commented on the topic of the historians' dispute after the course of almost ten years and thus potentially contributed to a balancing that Winkler postulated, but hardly already carried out. The cause was the publication of Daniel Goldhagen's book about "Hitler's Willing Executioners." Goldhagen, the young Jewish-American political scientist, took the "orthodox" view to the extreme, even to the point of caricature: in his presentation essentially only the Germans and the Jews appear, and the relationship between them is reduced entirely to anti-Semitism on the one hand and victim status on the other. Already in the 19th century, and basically since Luther, the Germans, with a few exceptions, were filled with an "eliminator" anti-Semitism, which under Hitler unfolded with all too great consequences into an "exterminatory" will. This had not been so much realized in the gas chambers of Auschwitz and Treblinka (whose "efficiency was greatly exaggerated"), but in the hundreds of thousands of murderous acts carried out with "zeal" and "lust" by the SS, the police battalions, and the Wehrmacht. The Bolsheviks and the Gulag are not mentioned, nor is the international situation of 1939-1941, and nor is the hostility towards Jews that was widespread in the Baltic States and Ukraine.

Only the confrontation between German murderers and murdered Jews is of importance. From this perspective, the thesis of the causal nexus between Gulag and Auschwitz does indeed appear to be utterly absurd. Goldhagen occasionally calls the murderers “Weltanschauung-warriors,” but in connection between anti-Semitism and anti-Bolshevism appears at most for fleeting moments and is further assigned to the “delusions.” Goldhagen emphatically underlines the principle of “understanding” and even emphasizes that the perpetrators considered “the mass extermination of the Jews to be justified,” but his understanding and the perpetrators' self-understanding only coincide with the concept of “delusions.” This means that a very clear verdict of guilt can be reached, and Goldhagen seems to be completely lacking in the awareness that with this collectivist attribution of guilt he is doing nothing other than what the National Socialists had done by blaming “the Jews” for the Red Terror, for the atrocities of the Cheka, and for the “great extermination” in the Gulag.

None of the "left-wing" German participants in the historians' dispute identified with such an extremist, and, for long stretches, a simply ignorant position, not even Jürgen Habermas, who of course praised Goldhagen at the 1997 “Democracy Prize.” Goldhagen had written history from the deeds of the many individuals and not from the constraints of bureaucratic apparatus or from the decisions of a charismatic leader. Hans Mommsen in particular dealt with Goldhagen's views in numerous statements and interviews, and suddenly his long-known and often "revisionist" interpretation, which took the blame away from the “weak dictator” Hitler and assigned it to the “leading classes” of Germany, took on the character of an apology, namely an apology for the German masses, who in Goldhagen appear to be the actual culprits, however much he expresses himself in rather “intentionalist” terms in some places.

Hans-Ulrich Wehler was in favor of welcoming Goldhagen's astonishing public impact as a welcome effect and of respecting his “perceptible moral indignation.” But he noted serious weaknesses that radically discredit Goldhagen's explanation of the properly presented facts, e.g. the diabolization of the Germans and thus the “ethnicization” of the debates, his “terrifying self-righteousness” and also the omission of the “terrible, decades-long murder of millions under Lenin and Stalin's dictatorship” - however, Wehler does not have so much the omissions as such, but rather the possible and quite mistaken derivation of these crimes from a tradition of “Russian barbarism.”

Eberhard Jäckel, on the other hand, who had seen a "miserable practice of undercutters” at work on the other side in the historians' dispute, and had put forward a highly questionable thesis about alleged public announcements of the murder of Jewish women and children by

Hitler, characterized Goldhagen's book as one "thoroughly flawed, unsuccessful dissertation," which falls back to the state of research of the fifties and completely neglects the main task of research, namely "to explain the connections."

But was not the overwhelming success of Goldhagen's book, and was not the author's triumphant tour of Germany's broadcasting studios and auditoriums, the most impressive proof that the Habermas-Wehler assertion was at least in some sense correct, that the attack of national apologetic revisionism had been beaten back and a great victory had been won for the Germans, through "coming to terms with the past"?

It could be, however, that this "fight against forgetting" only served a greater forgetting, that the German self-glorification of the National Socialist era was simply turned into a German self-condemnation, and that that alleged debacle was precisely the way to a deeper self-reflection and to a more adequate understanding of the context of the history of the 20th century. In any case, some publications of the 1990s by world-renowned historians suggested that such a presumption was well-founded.

When Alan Bullock's "Hitler and Stalin" was published in German translation in 1991, the memory of the historians' dispute was still fresh enough that astonishment was often expressed at how little excitement was caused by a topic that bore so much resemblance to the question of "Gulag" and "Auschwitz." In fact, Bullock's preliminary remarks clearly set himself apart from the germanocentric view that had so largely dominated the discussion in Germany. In his search of a frame of reference in which the larger contexts of Europe's recent history could be better understood, he turned to the "German-Russia axis" neglected in Western historiography. This, he said, made possible to compare "between the two revolutionary power systems at home" possible, the Stalinist and the National Socialist. "Both seemed at the same time to stand in irreconcilable opposition and to have many things in common. Both had, each in their own way, challenged the existing order in Europe ideologically and politically. Their simultaneous appearance on the stage of history, embodying their mutual relationships and interactions, it seems to me, embodies the most remarkable and novel phenomenon of the first half of the 20th century, a phenomenon whose aftermath extends far into the second half." This postulates the comparative account of two revolutionary regimes that were fundamentally related and interactive. The first question would have to be whether "revolutionary" meant the same thing in both cases and whether one revolution was also, or initially, in a one-sided relationship to the other, in such way that one would have been the precondition for the existence of the other and thus the relationship of action and re-action would have existed. Such a relationship was, after all, taken for

granted by the two regimes as a matter of course: one, the Bolshevik, always saw itself as the embodiment of the “revolution” which was opposed by the “counter-revolution” in the form of the fascist regimes, and Hitler repeatedly declared that his party was protecting Germany and Europe from the global danger of Bolshevik cultural destruction. Bullock, however, does not take this path of inquiry; instead, as the subtitle suggests, he portrays “parallel lives,” namely the lives of two men who were the almost unlimited rulers of their states for twelve and almost thirty years, respectively, but who had a different relationship to their own “revolution” or “counter-revolution”: Stalin was the successor of the party founder, behind whom he always took a back seat, at least in his official statements; Hitler, on the other hand, was the founder, and to that extent should be seen as the opposite figure or the parallel to Lenin. When Bullock deals in the first three chapters with the “Origin,” the “Early Experiences,” as well with the October Revolution and the November putsch, and contrasts Stalin and Hitler, the of course he also speaks of Lenin, but the early history of the Bolshevik party, up to the coming to power in November 1917 comes only a little into view, while Hitler is almost identical with the early history of his party and the Munich putsch attempt of November 1923 must in no way be put into the parallel with the “October Revolution.” Only in the National Socialist seizure of power in 1933 does the parallel appear, and it takes place in Bullock’s book upon reaching page 409.

Bullock’s book thus consists of several chapters that depict the lives of Stalin and Hitler with strong references to the history of the Russian or German parties and the Russian or German states. The Russian Revolution, the central figures of which were Lenin and Trotsky, is therefore not described in detail, and the reader does not get the impression that Hitler’s early days were significantly influenced by the relationship to this revolution. Only with the 14th chapter, which is devoted to the Hitler-Stalin Pact, does a relevant interaction begin, and it is not told much differently than it would be told in any history of Europe in the 20th century. On the whole, then, the parallelism is certainly there, the reciprocal effect comes into view late, and the originally one-sided relationship, that of “revolution” and “counter-revolution,” as Stalin and Hitler themselves saw the relationship, with opposing values, does not play a role significant role. In this respect, Bullock continues the line of structural-analytical totalitarianism theory, which also understood its double object, the Bolshevik and the National Socialist regimes, primarily as parallels. What was inspiring and attractive for countless people about the two movements and regimes is at most only partially emphasized here and there; what was terrible, on the other hand, is very much emphasized. According to Bullock, Stalin brought his people “suffering and death to an extent for which there is no parallel in history,” and the “slave empire under the rule of the SS” that Hitler brought into existence in Eastern Europe was “in no way inferior in extent or in the horrors it spread,” to

terror regime “that Stalin and the NKVD established in the Soviet Union.” In this respect, Bullock, as Hannah Arendt and Carl J. Friedrich had done, places “kulaks” and “Jews” next to one another. Occasionally, however, there is talk of an intrinsic interrelation of ideologies, which is hardly a mere parallel, as when it is said: “If one replaces ‘race’ with ‘class,’ the ‘racial elite’ with the Communist Party, the subordination of the individual to the ‘Volk’ by subordination to the ‘State’..., one would get the outlines of a worldview that Stalin would have had little fault with.” But Bullock does make an essential distinction: since Hitler's main enemy, “the Jew,” is only the diabolical “invention of a pathological philosophy,” the Holocaust ultimately has a completely different character from the extermination of kulaks, party enemies, and Polish officers. “Here mass murder was not a means to an end, but an end in itself.”

So the “parallel lives” of Stalin and Hitler end not only in the radical opposition of triumph on the one hand and total defeat on the other, but also in that of purpose and rationality or irrationality of the two regimes. But at the very end, Bullock comes to speak of the events of 1989 and 1990, which in his eyes mean a far-reaching reversal of the situation of 1945, because the Soviet people are facing an economic catastrophe and must ask for help from Western states and especially from Germany, which in its western part has reached “a remarkable level of prosperity and stability.” This, the era of Hitler and Stalin is over, but it took 70 years as a result of the survival of Stalinism—until the end of the 1980s. As many questions as Bullock merely hints at and leaves unanswered as a consequence of his approach to the “parallel lives” of two men, it is nevertheless certain that, from his perspective, all attempts to separate “Hitler” from “Stalin” and to make them self-sufficient subjects are, as interpretations of the 20th century, wrong a priori.

Another English historian, Eric Hobsbawm, who for a long time was primarily known as a Marxist and authoritative social historian, after his books on the 19th century, also presented in 1994 a “World History of the 20th Century,” to which he gave the title “The Age of Extremes.” He is far more involved in the whole wealth of events than Bullock, and there is hardly a state or an important political movement that is not mentioned in at least one sentence. But the common thread is never lost. The title seems to imply that the main topic would be the various totalitarianisms and that Hobsbawm, like Bullock, would proceed on the line of structural-analytical theory of totalitarianism. But right from the start it becomes clear that he assigns a place of paramount importance to the Russian Revolution, because according to him in the years 1989/1991 a world, “which was shaped by the effects of the Russian Revolution of 1917” broke up. True, he has “the short 20th century” begin in 1914 with the outbreak of the Great War, and one must speak of a “thirty-one year world war,” since the

Treaty of Versailles had so many injustices and weaknesses that “a new war was practically certain.” Nevertheless, Hobsbawm does not conceive the history of the first half of the century primarily as a history of the declared and undeclared wars between the great states. A new quality emerges from the fact that the opposition to the war, and the will to a completely new structure of life prevailed in one of the states: the October Revolution “was just as central an event for this century as the French Revolution of 1789 was for the 19th century.” The fact that their main intention was “the complete destruction of the Russian and European bourgeoisie” is apparently not seen by Hobsbawm as something negative, but it is not quite clear whether Hobsbawm, despite some self-criticism, is not convinced that Marx will be right in the longer run. In any case, according to his account, Wilson's “Fourteen Points” were already a reaction to the Russian Revolution, because they played the nationalist card against its universal appeal. Likewise, the very moderate stance of the socialist parties was “essentially just a reaction to Bolshevism.” A “causal nexus” is thus self-evident for Hobsbawm, and the same is obviously true of Hitler's National Socialism, which was counter-revolutionary and “a kind of right-wing extremist equivalent to international communism, with Berlin as its Moscow.” However, an extraordinary complication arises from the fact that for Stalin the revolution was more and more “just rhetoric” and that the fascists showed themselves able to mobilize the masses from below; hence these are to be called “the revolutionaries of the counter-revolution.” Despite such reversals, the fascist movements and regimes remained essentially different from the communist ones, for they were a response to the real danger of a powerful social revolution and a strong working class, and Nazism plagiarized the Soviet regime to a considerable extent. The epoch can consequently be best understood as an “international ideological civil war,” and in the end Hobsbawm even defines the entire “short 20th century” as an “age of wars of religion,” and among the secular religions he includes socialism as well as nationalism. But in the second half of the century these religious wars obviously took place outside of Europe and America, for example, around the “deeply murderous dictatorships” of Stalin, Mao, Kim Il Sung and, admittedly, Ceausescu. The main characteristic of European-American development were precisely the “golden years” of capitalism between 1950 and 1973, whose reality evidently represents a phenomenon difficult to explain for Hobsbawm, since he is by no means inclined to agree with the “theologians of the free market” like Hayek and Friedman. But since 1973, a new age of crisis has been approaching, and it seems that for Hobsbawm “the extreme” does not lose its significance even after 1989 and the end of the “short 20th century.” The extreme horrors of the “age of modern religious wars” therefore have a place only in Asia and Africa in the second half of the century, while in the first half, the epoch of the actual ideological civil war, both in Stalin's Bolshevik Russia and in Hitler's National Socialist Germany. Hobsbawm while mentioning the “Holocaust” right at the beginning, conflates it with the

starvation deaths of several hundred thousand residents of Leningrad and the 3.5 million victims among Russian prisoners of war. “Auschwitz,” which does not even appear as a name, apparently does not occupy a completely singular place in the abundance of events, and as much as Hobsbawm sees himself as an “anti-fascist,” his judgment is in many places distant and unemotional, for example, as when he attributes to “Nazi Germany” the merit of being the only western state to have overcome unemployment between 1933 and 1938, and when he makes a very critical judgment of Zionism.

François Furet, who was a member of the French Communist Party for some time in the 1950s, in his 1995 book “Le Passé d'une illusion,” which intends to be an “essay on the communist idea in the 20th century” and yet in no way absorbed by it, emphasizes the central importance of the Russian Revolution, the “charme universel d’Octobre,” even more strongly than Hobsbawm does, and makes this fascination much vivid because he exemplifies with some important men such as the left-wing Catholic Pierre Pascal, the Russian-Jewish petty bourgeois Boris Souvarine, and Georg Lukács the son of the Jewish upper middle class in Hungary. For these three men, as for numerous others, the Russian Revolution was the “lighthouse” in the darkness of the period marked by the First World War; it appealed to passions even more than to ideas; it making sense of the apparently senseless took hold of the whole human being and not just the intellect. For Pierre Pascal, Bolshevism is by no means anti-Christian, but “the revenge of the humiliated”; Boris Souvarine is filled with deep sympathy for the little people in Russia who have not yet been touched by Western individualism; for Georg Lukács a double self-hatred plays an important role: “the self-hatred of the Jew and that of the bourgeois.” Pascal and Souvarine moved away from the Soviet system after a few years, albeit hardly from the idea of communism which here and elsewhere underlies the criticism of empirical aberrations, and even Lukács became a dissident in 1956, although he remained convinced that Stalin was the Incarnated Reason of world-history. For French intellectuals, one of the main attractions of communism was the fact that the Russian Revolution was traced back to the French Revolution in the influential works by eminent historians such as Aulard and Mathiez, and thus was a further stage in the triumphant advance of equality, emancipation, freedom and fraternity. Only Solzhenitsyn's

“Gulag Archipelago” finally broke this fascination, a fascination which had been as conspicuous in England and even in America between the wars, as it had been in France.

But Furet is not satisfied with describing this gradual disappearance of the communist faith. In its heyday it have rise to another ideology, the fascist ideology, which Furet, like so many authors before him, characterizes as a “reaction” and which he regards as “the other great

myth of the century”: “Fascism arises as a reaction of the particular against the universal, of the people against the class, of the national against the international. It is in its beginnings inseparable from communism, whose aims it combats by imitating its methods.” In all its forms, however, it is not a mere reaction, no mere counter-revolution, it has its own “magic of the future,” it is as fascinating for quite a few intellectuals as communism is for many others; it can give meaning to the lives of individuals. Thus fascism appears as an almost equal counterpart to communism in the “European tragedy,” and as little as Furet denies his own past and the anti-fascist past, the principle of “understanding” comes to the fore, which keeps away from hasty moral judgments. The goal is to “understand the 20th century,” and this results in much more of “mourning” than partisan accusation. Sometimes it even looks as if Furet regards it as a misguided and deplorable development that the idea of fascism has become after the war the object of a “forbidden radical” and that a demonization ensures it an afterlife, but only an afterlife that serves to guarantee the victors the perpetuation of their triumph and which compels Germany to pay for all the crimes of the century. But this judgment is not an absolute one, it only refers to the apparent triumph of the communist view, which prevented the decisive insight that communism, like fascism, constituted “one of the great anti-liberal and anti-democratic reactions in European history of the 20th century.” Communism and fascism are therefore both similar and dissimilar to one another, and the movements as well as the regimes waged a struggle against each other which can with good reason be described as an European Civil War. But through such a distant understanding, those crimes, which in a certain way represent the climax and at the same time the self-refutation of the two ideologies, do not get out of sight: the great crime against the Russian and Ukrainian peasants, which was absolutely singular because never before History a state had set the goal of “killing, deporting, or enslaving its farmers,” and a decade later the National Socialist crime against the Jews, which was no less singular, although or because for Furet it was not caused by any “causal nexus” to the Gulag and Collectivization. As the final result of the history of the 20th century, Furet notes the victory of the “third” side, the “capitalist” side, which was sometimes barely visible in the struggle of the two great “ideo-cratic regimes,” the victory of private property, the market, and human rights. But as much more understanding of fascism as he is than Hobsbawm, so much less does he seem to be convinced that this victory could only be a temporary one.

Neither Bullock nor Hobsbawm nor Furet accept the reason given by Stalin and many Western European intellectuals for the war of extermination against the kulaks: it was indispensable for the modernization and industrialization of the country. One of the three takes even less seriously the justification put forward by Hitler and not a few National Socialists for the (initially only aimed at separation) for the war of extermination against the

Jews: the Jews are “all communists” and therefore responsible for the Cheka terror and the Gulag, and, on top of that, for Western capitalism. For Furet, however, the narrative itself shows that in fact an unusually high percentage of Jews did indeed occupy leading positions in Marxists or communist movements in France and elsewhere. But Furet would also undoubtedly agree with the following thesis: even if all the accusations made against the kulaks by the Communist Party of the Soviet Union had been correct, and even if all the allegations made by the NSDAP about the Jews had been true, it would to be morally condemnable to kill defenseless men and women without legal trials, even children, or even to simply deport them into the unknown would be morally condemnable. Only from a historical point of view would distinctions possibly have to be made, for there is an unmistakable difference between kulaks, who refuse a reasonable delivery of grain, and German or French Jews, who do not differ in any way from their German or French compatriots.

In order to make such differences and at the same time the fate of the “collectivist attribution of guilt” clearer, I take a look at the diaries that the novelist Victor Klemperer wrote during the years 1933-1941, and which were published in 1995 under the title “I Will Bear Witness.”

If anyone was allowed to feel completely German, it was Victor Klemperer—personally a Protestant, holder of a chair in Romance languages at the Technical University of Dresden, exemplary intellectual and cultural man, frontline fighter in the World War, married to an “Aryan woman” —even if he was the son of a rabbi. But immediately after January 30, 1933, the anti-Jewish campaign of the NSDAP, the legal exclusion of Jewish civil servants, and the boycott of Jewish businesses hit him with terrible force, although he was initially spared like the other frontline fighters. The hatred he felt for the National Socialists from the beginning is the hatred of the educated citizen and intellectual for the demagoguery and irrationalism of a mass movement, among whose components he counts “Americanism, technicism, automatism and deification (of the Führer).” He feels a similar aversion to communism and even to Zionism, which, with its racial doctrine, is a “source of the Nazis” and which discriminated against the Aryans in Jerusalem in the same way as it does against the Jews in Germany. In 1935 he was compulsorily retired and his previous colleagues avoided him “like a plague corpse.” Yet, for him, there is absolutely no “Jewish question” in Germany at all, because in his opinion the friction between Jews and “Aryans” was not half as great as, say, between Protestants and Catholics or between employers and employees or between East Prussia and southern Bavaria. There was only one solution to the German or Western European Jewish question, he writes, namely “the mating of its inventors.” However, he obviously considers an “Eastern Jewish question” to be real, and even when the “yellow Jewish band” was introduced in 1941, when he was forced to live in a “Jewish house,” he sees the reason not

merely as arbitrariness and torture, but rather the fear of “Jewish criticism.” In all of this, nothing would be more natural than for him to condemn the entire German people who so unflinchingly follow Hitler. Indeed, some of the phrases actually sound as if they were an endorsement of Goldhagen, for example: The situation is bleak, Hitler really corresponds to the German people’s will, as a reason for this people’s will he mentions not anti-Semitism, but the fear of communism and communist Russia. All of Germany prefers Hitler to the communists, he remarks, although both movements are materialistic and lead to slavery; even some Jews protect the Nazis to a certain extent, because they fear communism, that Hitler is the savior, from Russia, is certainly the opinion of 79.5 million Germans. Even in the “Jewish house” there is a man who, as a former officer, “is in the monomania of German soldiering and acts more nationalist than any Nazi.” On the other hand, Klemperer notices next to nothing of anti-Semitism when he has to bear the name ‘Victor Israel’ and wear the Star of David: “I often wonder where the wild anti-Semitism is. For my part, I encounter a lot of sympathy, they help me out, but of course fearfully...The officials in the tax office are exemplary polite...The passers-by sympathized with the star-bearers...The people undoubtedly feel the persecution of the Jews as a sin.” An apartment neighbor thinks that every Jew has an Aryan angel, and, as is well known, Heinrich Himmler said exactly the same thing in one of his speeches, albeit in a tone of criticism and accusation. The consequence of this exclusion and collectivist attribution of guilt, which affects people who, according to Klemperer, “would be Nazis if they were not affected as Jews” is, in the eyes of this German Jew, extremely paradoxical and at the same time fatal: Hitler is the most important supporter of Zionism, he literally created the “people of the Jews,” “world Jewry,” THE Jews. But this strange fact is only a result of National Socialism; its elementary prerequisite, however, according to Klemperer, is nothing else than the relationship to communism, which, unlike the Jews, was threatening and frightening for the great majority of the German people.

It should now have become clear what the “European Civil War 1917-1945” and also the article about the “The Past That Will Not Pass” was about, even to some extent the “Fascism in its Epoch” was about: not about exculpation or incriminations, burden or exoneration, accusation or apology; but to one of the possible conceptions or paradigms or interpretative guidelines of European history and world history in the 20th century. The main question to be addressed to it is whether it grasps the context or fails to do so, whether it illuminates or obscures, expands or narrows it. A possible restriction of political or propagandistic guilty verdicts, a different distribution of light and shadow will only result from this; but it must not be the prerequisite, however certain the individual historian will have his preferences and dislikes. The only scientifically legitimate dislike, however, is that which applies to the will to achieve political goals, which ruthlessly ignores unsuitable facts. However, each paradigm

inherently has its own limitations. Precisely for this reason, there must be no strict closure from one another. The number of possible paradigms is small, however, and numerous examples from historiography can be cited for them.

The national paradigm may claim practical priority. For centuries, states, whether monarchical-aristocratic states or nation-states, have been the supreme and most capable political units; nothing was more natural than that historiography made them its main theme as soon as overarching concepts and realities such as "Christianity" ceased to be prominent. The story of the "Great Rebellion" of Lord Clarendon has as its subject an important period in English history; Voltaire's story of the age of Louis XIV, despite all its tendencies towards cultural and moral history, is nevertheless largely devoted to the development of the French state system. The English and French states, however, were older than the historiography on which they became the subject; in Germany and Italy, however, historiography preceded the formation of states, and the historians of the small-German-school such as Sybel, Treitschke and Droysen did not hide their desire to promote the emergence of a Prussian-German nation state through their work. The same applies to Italians like Carlo Botta and Cesare Balbo.

The fact that Bismarck's Germany was structured differently than that of Gladstone's England and even the France of the Third Republic, namely constitutional instead of parliamentary, was considered a positive fact and was not infrequently viewed as a special path that took Germany away from the weaknesses and deterioration of "Western" liberalism and parliamentarism. The strong monarchy was seen as the root of Germany's rise, and the concept of the positive German special path [*Sonderweg*] reached its culmination in the so-called Ideas of 1914. The defeat in World War I brought about no significant change, and for the few National Socialists among the German historians, "Germany" is hardly more in the center than for the German Nationalists. Nothing was more obvious than that after the second defeat in 1945 the positive accent should be replaced by a negative one and the German special path understood as the origin of National Socialism: the difference between industrial modernity and the premodern political system, which differed from the conditions in the "West," had first prevented the political rule of the bourgeoisie and then the development towards a democratic revolution; thus the feudal authoritarian state plunged into the world war in 1914, and after 1918 only the aristocratic warrior ethos was democratized and vulgarized, so that the National Socialist state, contrary to the spirit of the times, had been able to launch its war of conquest and exploitation against the other states of Europe. The present task was to end the special path and to join the Western or democratic system without reservation.

There is no doubt that this national-German paradigm, both in its negative and in its positive form, has or had considerable explanatory value. Since 1870, all major decisions had been made in the capital Berlin, and they had all wished to serve the good of the people or the nation. Two world wars, for which Germany was responsible, seemed to prove irrefutably that these decisions and developments had in truth not been for the good, but for the disaster of the nation. After 1945, therefore, positive nationalism could at best still be used in a historicizing way to correct the excesses of the negative special path thesis, and the National Socialist interpretation was to be completely discredited: to continue to allow Hitler the peaceful intentions that he had often proclaimed was simply no longer an option, and it was obviously wrong to make him a victim of treachery of diplomats and generals by emphasizing the lack of adequate war preparations. The only possibility of a “neo-National Socialist” historiography was probably that which an English historian, namely David Irving, had more hinted than explicitly outlined: the cooperation between the “leading classes” and Hitler, which was so strongly attacked by the advocates of the negatively formulated special path thesis, was not condemnable, but had even been the only future possibility, provided that it had developed into a compromise between Germany and England in 1940, which, however, had been prevented by Churchill and his kind. If it had come about, the Holocaust would not have taken place and England would not have lost its Empire. But even if this interpretation were given a truth value, it could only have a nostalgic character today, and Hitler himself had far exceeded the national-German paradigm by considering himself the leader of “all Teutons” or even “all Aryans.” In the context of the national-German conception after 1945, only the negatively accentuated Sonderweg thesis was of practical importance, and this gained inner strength because it was connected with the tendency towards “social historiography,” which went back to Karl Lamprecht and had produced great achievements in the form of the “Annales” school in France.

But there was a more original social historiography or conception of social history, which strove with much more decisiveness to transcend national borders and made the concept of class far more exclusively its center. This was the Marxist paradigm, which was based on a universalist philosophy of history and which had already produced historiographical works such as the “18th Brumaire by Louis Bonaparte” by Marx himself. Here, the starting point is not a particular state, but the overarching process of the industrial revolution, from which a powerful international movement emerges, namely the workers’ movement. Its destiny is to fulfill the unrealized postulates of the bourgeois-liberal revolution, namely freedom, equality and fraternity, and to lead the hitherto capitalist modernity to the insurmountable summit of global society without classes and states. In this perspective, the German special path became irrelevant because it did not differ in essence from the path of the “Western nations,” and the

task was much more ambitious than the modernization or even the democratization of existing class structures could ever be. Although the suspicion soon arose that the Marxist vision of the future was not “modern” at all, but archaic in its orientation towards the conception of the human family and the individuals existing in complete reciprocity without alienation and objectification, the harmony with the universalizing tendencies of the modernity was nevertheless so palpable that pre-1914 Marxism could with good reason consider itself the “party of progress” and the “wave of the future.” The historiographical work of Franz Mehring was also borne by this enthusiastic confidence, and in his old age he welcomed the Bolshevik revolution as the decisive step towards the reality of a socialist world.

But the historians of the Soviet Union soon faced a serious dilemma. With M. N. Pokrowski at the helm, they followed the tendency to condemn the Russian “special path,” which the Slavophiles had praised so much, as backwardness and barbarism much more strongly than anyone had ever condemned the German special path, but necessities of state-politics, strongly emphasized by Stalin, soon resulted in a glorification of large parts of the tsarist and “feudal” past, which in the eyes of not a few Western Marxists was all too similar to the positive nationalist view of history in other states. In this respect, the historians of the German Democratic Republic were in a better position after 1945, as they were able to draw far clearer lines from the Bismarck’s anti-working-class oppressive state via the reactionary regime of the Weimar Republic and the barbaric, because anti-communist, Third Reich to the GDR, in which the entire positive heritage of the progressive part of the German past was inextricably linked with the future world of the socialist bloc led by the USSR. To their great surprise, during the years of the so-called student revolution from 1968 onwards, all historians of the Federal Republic, including the representatives of the special path thesis, experienced firsthand what attraction this historical image of the simple lines of a black and white painting was able to exert.

What seemed to have been finally marginalized or even made to disappear in these years was the “theory of totalitarianism,” which was now more and more attacked as the ideology of the Western world in the Cold War against the Soviet Union and its satellites—not least probably because it shared the overarching character with Marxism. Hannah Arendt, Carl J. Friedrich, Zbigniew Brzezinski, and the historians who followed in their footsteps brought together what for all communists, insofar as they did not belong to heterodox currents, the absolute opposites, namely the Communist Soviet Union and National Socialist Germany. And it was difficult to deny the common traits they worked out: the single ruling party with its almost all-powerful top, the terrorist secret police, the ideology that pervades all areas of life, the economy that is almost completely subjected to planning and withdrawn from the laws of

the market. Both regimes were apparently separated from the system of the “Western constitutional state” by an abyss, and both expressed this hostility undisguised. Moreover, it was indeed extremely striking that there was a great deal of polemics against National Socialism on the Soviet side, but no detailed presentation and analysis—presumably because the similarities that the theory of totalitarianism emphasized so much could hardly have remained hidden. The strongest counter-argument of Soviet Marxism could only be the reference to—even during the time of the Hitler-Stalin Pact—the indissoluble enmity between two regimes and ideologies, which despite certain similarities had opposite goals and therefore opposed each other like light and darkness, like humanity and barbarism. Very few authors in the West followed this view, but the argument gained more and more weight, since the totalitarianism of the Stalinist epoch was transforming itself into an authoritarianism and thus taking a development that a possibly victorious National Socialist regime would not have been capable of.

Before the question can be asked whether another version of the theory of totalitarianism and the historiography that arises from it should not be given a rank of its own, for which the enmity between the two movements and regimes would not be superficial, but which would not attribute to either of them had the quality of the “victor of History” or the “wave of the future,” one must speak of the “Jewish paradigm.” This paradigm, which at first glance could be called “national” or “national-religious” or “Zionist,” is to be given a prominent position because it is based on a very extraordinary experience, namely the extermination of millions of Jews, obviously intended by the spite of the National Socialist state, in which basically every single Jew within the huge sphere of power of National Socialist Germany should be included, so that an escape was only possible through fortunate and fortuitous circumstances. This monstrous event could by no means be deduced from the most unfortunate “German special path,” because during the First World War the German Reich had pursued an decidedly pro-Jewish policy with its Turkish ally and in the occupied eastern territories, and the anti-Semitic parties, which had no major influence than the corresponding groupings and tendencies in France, Russia, and Romania, had all but disappeared in the years before 1914. Something very special must have happened that such a radical hostility towards Jews as that of Hitler and Rosenberg could arise. It was obvious for both Jewish and German interpreters to simply blame a phenomenon that has been known for thousands of years, namely anti-Semitism, and to sharpen the special path thesis that the entire German people was at one with Hitler on this anti-Semitism. But this interpretation can at best make the “Zionist” aspect of National Socialism understandable, namely the demand for the “removal” of the Jews after coexistence had allegedly proven impossible. However, it cannot take account of facts such as the fact that even Heinrich Himmler rejected the extermination of a people as “Bolshevik”

and “un-Germanic” as late as 1940 and that even Joseph Goebbels was very surprised when he first learned in March 1942 what methods in were used in the East against the Jewish population. There can only be one sufficient explanation, namely the following: that in the mind of the only person who was able to set in motion such an extraordinary process, which none of the subordinate participants even thought possible as late as 1940, the conviction, expressed early on, of that the Jews were the authors of Bolshevism and, beyond that, of all the evils of modern times, was no longer only “guiding knowledge,” but also became “guiding action” with the beginning of the planning for the war of aggression against Bolshevik Russia. The only open question can be whether Hitler actually saw the Jews as merely “scapegoats” onto whom he projected his (albeit initially only minor) failures, or whether he perceived and hated in them “something” whose protagonists had long been not all Jews, but nevertheless, many of them were: the idea of international socialism or humanitarianism or, as Victor Klemperer puts it at one point, “the eternal mission, the championhood of the Jewish spirit.” The first view easily leads to the claim that the Jews were brought “like sheep to the slaughter”; from the second, on the other hand, the thesis can be derived that they died “not as the unfortunate victim of a repugnant crime, but as deputies in the most desperate attack ever carried out against human nature and the transcendence within him.” Which of the two interpretations gives greater honor to the dead Jews should be out of the question.

The phrase quoted can be found in my 1963 book “Fascism in Its Epoch.” By emphasizing the singularity of “Auschwitz,” it took a very distant position vis-à-vis communism from the start, because all Soviet communist accounts were guided by the view that the real struggle of the National Socialists was directed against the communists and that the emphasis was on the Jewish victims mean a nationalist narrowing, even if they come from non-Jews. It was just as important that Marxism was not understood as “absolute truth” but as a fallible, albeit outstanding, ideology among other ideologies. National Socialism, however, was proven wrong to an even greater extent by being defined as “anti-Marxism,” “which seeks to destroy the opponent by developing a radically opposing and yet neighboring ideology and using almost identical and yet characteristically re-shaped methods...”

These judgments were based on the concept of the “liberal system,” which sees its essence, the essence of this conflict society, in the peaceful settlement of such conflicts and thus in the prevention of bloody processes of annihilation. The Marxist concept of “class struggle” is ambiguous and therefore potentially integrable into this system; but as soon as the aspect of civil war emerges and is even made independent by a seizure of power, a process of annihilation is set in motion that cannot take place in a liberal system (which may also exist as

a “pluralist party state”). Such an upheaval can only be based on historical processes of paramount importance: the convincing electoral victory of the “proletarian party,” which, according to certain indications by Marx and Engels, entails the use of the earlier entrepreneurs for the purposes of the planned economy, and to that extent a purely social and even bloodless annihilation means, or else the violent seizure of power by a minority party of professional revolutionaries, which is able to ride the wave of widespread mass emotions for a moment. In this second case, the result is most likely an open civil war with the largely physical annihilation of the “class enemies” and, one day, a violent struggle aimed at annihilation against the leading group of the country's self-sustaining farmer majority. In this respect, Bolshevism marks the beginning of the ideologically justified measures of extermination by totalitarian regimes that shaped the face of the century so much. But it is inappropriate to use the term “guilt” here, although a party and even a class can after all be ascribed “guilt” with more justification than a people or cultural group.

By attributing to Bolshevism more original intention and action of extermination than to National Socialism and by conceiving its intention and action of extermination as a response or re-action, the struggle between the two regimes is taken much more seriously than on the part of the structural-analytical theory of totalitarianism, and the “Western constitutional state” is not glorified, but was seen as the contrast of the totalitarian regimes, but also as their top native. The historical-genetic version of the theory of totalitarianism is thus in its own paradigm, and it cannot be denied that it is closer to both communism and national socialism than the structural-analytic version, since it takes over what is common to both movements and regimes, namely their self-understanding as an “action” or as a “re-action.” Nothing follows from it more compellingly than the thesis that the “Gulag” was more original than “Auschwitz.” Anyone who needs simple historical images may claim that the Bolsheviks or even the Marxists are made the “first culprits” in the calamities of the 20th century, while the National Socialists as the “second culprits” are downright exculpated or trivialized. But the “guilt” that consists in the attribution of guilt to an entire people is historically more serious than the guilt that results from the struggle against a class. That is why I avoided the term “crime” or “mass crime” in relation to “Auschwitz” and spoke of an “atrocities.” The restriction of absolute-sounding statements also applies to the above sentence about the Jews as “deputies”. If it only meant that the Jews, as champions of world unity, humanity and socialism, had been fought and largely killed by Hitler, it would be a mere reversal of the “collectivist attribution of guilt” to a “collectivist attribution of merit.” But Grigory Zinoviev was indeed guilty also in a narrow and individually attributable sense when he demanded the extermination of ten million people—however, he did not speak to Jews as a Jew, but to as a communist to communists.

And for some time now, “modernity” has not been understood as an all-round positive term, even by many representatives of the progressivist tradition. Things are inherently more complicated, and they are subject to far more reversals than the political and ideological struggle would have us believe. In this respect, the historian, who wants to think through contexts and not just describe processes, is in a lost position in public from the start, since certain aspects of his topic, which are articulated in isolatable sentences, can always lead to political consequences, which politicians and political writers defend themselves with counter-claims and often with allegations as well as defamation. But he must also not hide his own weaknesses and the vicissitudes of life. I was probably the first in scientific literature to describe the war of aggression against the Soviet Union as “the most monstrous war of conquest, enslavement and annihilation” “known to modern history”; I do not deny, however, that I am far from inner approval 35 years later when it is converted into an exhibition in a propagandistically elaborate and one-sided manner.

However, whatever the individual preferences and inclinations may be: the historical-genetic version of the totalitarianism theory is essentially independent of it in its basic features, and in the future it will play a role again and again, explicitly or not explicitly, in historical representations of the 20th century and in the corresponding attempts at thinking in one form or another; it can actually only be astonishing that it took so long before it came to existence as a historiography beyond merely suggestive or essayistic ideas of “world civil war.” The cause is likely to be that indisputable closeness to a basic conception of National Socialism, which at the same time and to an even greater extent means a closeness to the basic conception of Soviet communism. Both were questionable and offensive in the Cold War era; in a time when capitalist globalization and philo-socialist anti-fascism tend to merge into a new kind of unity, only one thing is apparently still offensive, even damnable. But this conception is by no means the invention or speculation of an aloof “maverick”; as has been shown, the books by Bullock, Hobsbawm, and Furet point in the same direction, although considerable differences between the authors are undoubtedly evident.

The book, which in the preliminary form of an article caused so much excitement and indignation and which then, as it were, fell into its shadow, is now, after ten years, presented anew in its fifth edition unchanged except for a new “Concluding Observation” and expanded only by this “Balance Sheet After Ten Years.” Perhaps this time it will succeed primarily in provoking reflection rather than mere contradiction. The correspondence between François Furet and myself, which was published in German in 1998 and one letter of which is printed in the “Appendix,” could also contribute to this. For my part, I am aware of the fact that the present framework should be inserted into an even larger framework, which, with the question

of “Historical Existence,” will be the last—in the meantime largely completed—work of my life.

In June 1997

Ernst Nolte

Introduction

Nothing seems more trivial and yet is less self-evident than the thesis that the most appropriate perspective in which to view Bolshevism and the Soviet Union, National Socialism and the Third Reich, is that of a *European civil war* .

It is common knowledge that immediately after seizing power in November 1917, the Bolshevik Party called on the proletarians and the oppressed all over the world to revolt against the capitalist system, which was responsible for the war. And it is not specialist knowledge that the newly founded Communist Party of Germany saw itself at the beginning of 1919 in "the most violent civil war in world history." Again a few months later, the Third International even believed it could proclaim that May 1, 1919 must be the day of the proletarian revolution all throughout Europe. Thus, there had been a state since 1917, and an international party since 1919, calling everywhere for an "armed insurrection" and consequently for a *world civil war* everywhere, and since these were obviously not the fantasies of powerless sectarians, a fundamental new reality had in this manner entered into historical existence. If a strong group calls for civil war, then a civil war situation is in any case a given, even if bloody battles do not take place immediately or constantly. Stefan Possony described the epoch as the "century of turmoil"; Hanno Kesting reached far back into intellectual history treated the subject of "Philosophy of History and World Civil War"; Roman Schnur, in turn, traced the "overture" of the world civil war in the age of the French Revolution.

Such a comprehensive concept must, of course, raise concerns. The concept of civil war seems to include the fact that within a state two groups of citizens face each other, armed; be it insurgents fighting the government, be it that both parties have their own territory and there is a clear analogy to the war of states. The most appropriate example is the American Civil

War of 1861-1865, which from the beginning consisted of warfare by organized armies. On the other hand, one speaks of the age of the English Civil War 1640-1660, although by no means did armed confrontations take place in every one of these years, and although the party that was victorious ultimately did not possess armed forces at the beginning of 1660. And even this insular civil war was not purely domestic, for which both the Puritans and the royalists found sympathy and support across the Channel. In the age of the French Revolution and Napoleon, civil war and war between states were often hardly distinguishable: a state that writes the motto *War on Palaces, Peace on Cottages* is itself a civil war party, provided that enemy states also have numerous *houses* and not just a few palaces next to millions of cottages. Therefore, according to all presumptions, the narrowest concept of civil war is not the most appropriate.

But is it therefore justified to speak of a *European Civil War* of between 1917 and 1945? There was the Russian Civil War from 1918 to 1920, and there was the Spanish Civil War from 1936 to 1939, there were attempts at revolution and uprisings in Germany, Estonia, Bulgaria and elsewhere. But the January uprising of 1919, the March action of 1921, the Reval coup at the end of 1924 were put down by the governments under attack with the help of the police and the military, and just as one should not underestimate the severity of the domestic struggles in France and England, even the most comprehensive concept of civil war does not allow one to perceive anything in these countries other than fierce party struggles, occasional riots, and isolated political strikes. A communist party existed here and there, i.e. a party oriented towards armed insurrection, but it had the government and such a large majority of the population against it that there was only *one* civil war party, which got caught up, as it were, in an overpowering net. This, while there is no doubt that one must speak of "Europe in Crisis", there can be no mention of a *European Civil War* if one looks at the individual countries of Europe equally, and above all, in terms of their mutual relations.

But even in a completely conventional and merely narrative history of Europe in the age of the world wars, it must be stated as a new and completely unexpected phenomenon that, first of all in Italy a party was formed; which, like the long-standing parties in close or distant association with the government, did not simply oppose the party of revolutionary socialism or communism, in order to leave it to its own further development after defending against the actual or at least projected grip on power; but which saw itself as a second and radically opposed *party of the civil war*. Therefore, the seizure of power by the fascist party in October 1922 meant; although not immediately, but as a logical consequence of its basic approach; the political annihilation of the communist party and ultimately even the annihilation of all other parties.

Nevertheless, it is by no means certain that one can even speak of an *Italian civil war*. The term would only be indisputable and legitimate if it had ultimately been the fascist party that had crushed a national uprising of the communists. However, such an uprising had *not* taken place, and the attempts to do so had been nipped in the bud by the government or the party system; therefore, it has often been claimed that the fascist party only came on the scene after the fact and should be considered as a kind of parasite which gave a superfluous kick to the already defeated revolution and then pushed its own breadwinner, the *system*, off the political table.

But this view was by no means universally considered to be correct, and in any case, since 1922, two parties had existed that were oriented towards the civil war and that gave ideological justification to this orientation. Both parties had taken possession of a state, and both had sympathizers and supporters in many countries. As a result, the situation in Europe was very different from what it had been before the World War I. Nevertheless, by the end of the 1920s, the opinion was widespread that these two ideological countries were marginalized states that lagged far behind the great central powers of Europe, behind England, France and Germany in terms of productivity and genuine dynamism, and whose international following consisted only of meaningless sects. Indeed, in France the Communist Party, which was formed in 1920 from the great majority of the Socialist Party, lost its supporters to an almost alarming degree, and only small groups like the Action Française sympathized with the Italian fascists. The Soviet Union, on the other hand, was widely believed to have abandoned its revolutionary character and was in the process of building *socialism in one country*. Anyone who traveled in Europe in 1929 was nowhere confronted anywhere with civil war-like conditions, and only in Russia and Italy did he come across one-party regimes that had crushed all their opponents in a civil war-like manner, albeit in very different ways.

When the global economic crisis had left its mark on countries, however, the foreign visitor saw a different picture. At least in Germany, he had to ask himself whether the revolutionary situation of 1919-1920 had not been resurrected. Almost one-fifth of German voters seemed to identify with the Soviet Union, as the "Rote Fahne" [*Red Flag, socialist newspaper*] had already done in a particularly pronounced form in 1920, when it recast a well-known line of poetry by Heinrich Lersch into the astonishing formulation: "Soviet Russia must live, even if we have to die." More than one-third supported a party which, through the mouths of its leader, often expressed its admiration for Italian fascism and its Duce. The unrest on the streets of the cities was so great that there was constant talk of the impending or imminent civil war. The seizure of power by the NSDAP was a event in which the state power and a

huge party overthrew their main enemy in a very civil war-like manner and forced all other opponents to surrender. Whether here, as in Italy, an already won victory was merely reproduced in an exorbitant manner, must be doubtful. In any case, from that moment on it became probable that Europe had finally entered a new epoch which, according to its most novel and henceforth most decisive manifestation, must be called the *epoch of fascism* and which was precisely for this reason the epoch of the European Civil War; a *world civil war* had not yet been able to develop, since the United States of America had experienced the brief and violent panic of the *red scare* and had refused diplomatic recognition to the Soviet Union until 1933, but had not yet really entered the conflict. If this character is to become visible, then it is not enough just to make the subject *fascism in its epoch*, but it is necessary to keep an eye on its most elementary presupposition, namely Bolshevism or Soviet Communism. If the mutual enmity of these two state parties, which at least saw themselves as civil war parties, was serious and not merely a relic from the half-forgotten early days, long since repealed by *peaceful reconstruction work*, then it was bound to one day develop into a state war, which would at the same time bear the essential characteristics of an international civil war.

But only a very decisive and therefore controversial selection can focus this character into view. Anyone who writes a European history of the World War Era has to do with so many relations between states and internal conditions of individual states that the Soviet Union and Germany only become an eminent topic in 1941 and at most in 1939. Whoever follows the development of the fascist movements perceives what is specifically new and, to that extent, the peculiar character of the epoch, but cannot describe in a vivid way its most important precondition: the anti-Bolshevism of these movements. A history of the Soviet Union, on the other hand, is either predominantly preoccupied with internal developments, or it becomes a succession of revolutionary failures, to which a deeper and more positive meaning may be ascribed. The era can only appear as a European Civil War if the focus is on the two main antagonists: Bolshevism, which had been a state since 1917, and National Socialism, which became a state in 1933.

Certainly, it cannot be ruled out that this perspective is precisely misleading, and it is certainly no coincidence that it has never been chosen so far. Contemporary communist authors will object to the fact that here a short-lived and reactionary phenomenon seems to be placed on the same level as the secular world movement, which was temporarily *deformed* but never lost its *progressive* character. Liberals will wonder whether, in the context of this question, the democratic and liberal states or tendencies do not fade too much into the background. For the anti-communist it will be extremely uncomfortable to see the resistance

of the Western world in the Cold War era and in the present seemingly in line with what he believes to be the utterly different anti-communism of the Third Reich. By no means only the survivors of the *Final Solution* and the citizens of Israel will have to ask themselves whether, from this perspective, the anti-Semitism of the National Socialists does not sink into a accidental concomitant.

All these questions can be clarified only by the presentation and therefore can be answered only after the presentation, which includes methodical discussions, but must quickly reach the descriptive description and the essential details. In doing so, National Socialism may claim priority of the cognitive interest.

Bolshevism was certainly a confusing and controversial phenomenon for contemporaries as early as 1917/18. That *the workers' movement* would seize power in at least one country or another in Western or Central Europe after the First World War was likely for not only the supporters of socialism. But what did it mean that the event took place, of all places, *backward* Russia, whose population was overwhelmingly consisted of peasants? Did the socialist party, which seized power here against other socialist parties, ultimately degrade itself into an instrument of self-assertion for the Russian multi-ethnic state? Or did Russia become the mere material of the world-revolutionary will of Marxist intellectuals who, in their first exuberance overestimated the possibilities offered to them in Europe and in the world, but who steadfastly held to their goal, the revolutionary transformation of the whole earth into a human community without classes and without states? From the beginning there was no shortage of enemies who had previously been friends, and even resolute supporters found themselves in grave doubts early on.

Nevertheless, there is no phenomenon in modern world history that has been condemned from so many sides, for so long and so intensely as German National Socialism and the Third Reich; But there is also no regime that has been characterized in such contradictory ways and that has given the critics so much opportunity to attack one another indirectly by stating a close kinship between National Socialism and one of the powers or ways of thinking that just now seemed to belong to the unanimous front of opponents. It is controversial whether National Socialism was similar to capitalism or communism, whether it must be considered German or un-German, whether it turned out to be anti-modern or modernizing, whether it was revolutionary or counter-revolutionary, whether it suppressed or unleashed the tribe, whether it had *clients* or not, whether it created a monolithic system or a polycracy, whether its mass base was formed by the petty bourgeoisie or to a considerable extent also by the workers, whether it was supported by world-historical tendencies or whether it was a last

revolt against the course of the History.

This fact is a basic fact for science and at the same time a challenge. A scientific approach first of all requires a distance to each of the interpretations that have been sufficiently elaborated up to now, and it must therefore strive above all to do justice to the inner complexity of the phenomenon that has been assessed in so many ways; in its view of complexity and contradictions, however, it must not lose sight of the unanimity that is also a fundamental fact. If it has to be willing to carry out those revisions that may result from the weighing of opposing views and the formation of new questions, it cannot simply reject the consensus that has been able to span so many contradictions. If it pursued apology, it would become a party itself. But for party opinions, often what takes the opposing opinion into consideration already counts as an apology. When American scholars such as Harry Elmer Barnes and Charles C. Tansill in the second half of the 1920s, questioned the hitherto undisputed thesis that the German Reich was solely responsible for war, they were accused of advocating for the enemy, but in reality they paved the way for a more comprehensive approach that integrated the opposing thesis of war propaganda on both sides into an overall picture, for the result of an equal distance from both starting points.

Perspective means looking through, and no kind of historiography is not possible with perspectives that take in more than the immediate object. Even the historian, who wants to describe the events on a remote island, cannot do without a concept of non-insularity, from which what is peculiar, island-like, in these events can be better understood. Much more frequent, however, are phenomena that have their reason for existence in relation to other phenomena. The Counter-Reformation presupposes the Reformation, and a history of the Counter-Reformation that is not, at least in glimpses, also a history of the Reformation is inconceivable. The perspectives by means of which National Socialism is related to a more original or superordinate reality are numerous, but manageable. The most important of them are by no means based on learned theories, but are based on the concrete experiences of many hundreds of thousands of people.

1. The oldest and most obvious perspective is to view National Socialist rule as a stage of German history. Almost all states in the world had fought in the First World War against the German Reich, and it was the almost universal conviction that this state in the center of Europe had ignited the world conflagration through its militarism and its expansionist drive. The National Socialist Party was seen early on, especially by the French, as the spearhead of German revisionism and revanchism, on which almost all Germans agreed. After Hitler came to power, the party was even more identical with *Germany*, and the most important lines of

German history seemed to lead directly to it from Luther and probably even from Hermann the Cheruscan. The contrast to this National Socialist Germany was the rest of Europe, with its culture shaped by ancient and especially Roman tradition. This view seemed to find definitive confirmation with the outbreak of World War II, which, as in 1914, exposed the European powers, France and England, to the attack of concentrated German military power. This time France even suffered a heavy defeat, and once again the help of the whole world was required until the strongest of all military states was overthrown. Hitler and his party were just a new manifestation of that Pan-German striving for world domination, which before 1914 had already been combined with social Darwinist ideas of the relentless struggle of biological forces and which had become the real antithesis of the peace-loving and democratic tendencies in Europe. The only solution was to break up this concentration of power and integrate the re-educated Germans into an association of states in Europe or the world. The Germans were also able to accept this perspective; it made it easier for them to say farewell to the power, indeed to the nation state, although or because it was still, in its inversion, a Teutonocentric perspective.

2. This view, however, always presupposes an inner cohesion that *modern society* does not have. Modern society proves for the sociologist to be manifoldly structured or fragmented. If, however, German society is made up of entrepreneurs and workers, educated citizens and small traders, civil servants and the liberal professions, just like the French and English society is, then it is not the modifications that are decisive, but basic character is what counts. And then it turns out that the economic system in all European countries with the exception of the Soviet Union was the same, namely the *capitalist* one, that England and France were no less imperialist than Germany, that they were subject to the same shocks, that they looked for ways out in a similar way, and that movements and parties appeared everywhere that wanted to face the great crisis in a manner similar to that of the National Socialist Party in Germany. The sociological perspective is therefore an international one, and where it appeared in a Marxist form, its representatives were convinced that only an international measure could remedy the situation, namely the replacement of the anarchic and crisis-generating economic system of capitalism by a socialist planned economy, which should at least encompass Europe and if possible the world. However, only a part of the Marxists saw the Soviet planned economy as a model worthy of imitation, and the Social Democrats flatly denied it the quality of *socialism*. But they, too, perceived dangerous tendencies among the employers and especially the petty bourgeoisie, which amounted to a violent defense of the historically obsolete system and which, in the form of Italian fascism, had already seized power in a large state. National Socialism was thus to be seen as a manifestation of the international movement of *fascism*.

3. A theory that understands National Socialism as fascism should only be mentioned if this movement is not seen merely as an instrument in the hands of well-known forces, such as heavy industry or finance capital. It must therefore be understood as something new, arising from historically new circumstances or from the reaction against them: the collapse of the Central Powers, the Russian Revolution, the *socialist wave* in most European states during the years 1919 and 1920. But whether Marxists see the *existential fears* of the middle class or the petty bourgeoisie negatively, or whether non-Marxists refrain from passing judgment on an entire social class, the antagonism of the fascist movement against communism and socialism is regarded by both as fundamental.

4. Early in the twenties, however, the view emerged that this opposition was a pseudo-contradiction, which would prove to be a match if the correct perspective was chosen. From the point of view of democracy, which has only just made such great progress in Europe and the world, the fascist and communist parties were seen as reactions that strive for a dictatorship and endangering, through their respective claims to exclusivity, that civilized coexistence of the various strata, parties and classes, which is the prerequisite and the consequence of the freedom of the individual and the real distinction of the modern type of society. The *totalitarianism* of the Russian Bolsheviks was spoken of with a negative connotation as early as 1918, and it was only necessary to add the opposite emphasis to the word often used by Mussolini in order to contrast the totalitarianism of the dictatorial regimes with the liberal and democratic states. The Hitler-Stalin Pact greatly encouraged the scientific elaboration of this opposition, and there is no doubt that it could be based on a powerful tradition of thought which, since the beginning of modern times, has rejected tyranny, dictatorship and despotism and set against them the doctrine of the separation of powers as a safeguard of freedom. After the interruption by the wartime coalition, the *theory of totalitarianism* became something like the official self-image of the West from the end of the 1940s, and at least in its popular versions it tended to equate the regimes of Hitler and Stalin, which were based on terror and oppression. However, their influence declined since the beginning of the 1960s, as the consolidation of the balance of power and further *de-Stalinization* in the Soviet Union brought about a phase of *détente*.

It was precisely because of this that self-criticism became possible again in the West, which in the decade of acute disputes seemed almost forgotten, and a younger generation linked new questions with old theses. Had not the leading classes in Germany cooperated with the National Socialists in a variety of ways and thereby incurred serious guilt? Didn't the USA play a disastrous role in the Third World through its imperialism by supporting dictatorships in many places and opposing the emancipation efforts of ordinary people? Weren't they even

committing a genuine genocide through their intervention in Vietnam? And the younger generation in Israel also asked very critical questions: Hadn't the established circles of European Jewry contributed by their behavior to the fact that millions of victims could be led "like sheep to the slaughter"?

So the traditional self-image of the western world seemed to have been shaken in the most lasting way, and from the newly acquired perspective of a world without political and sexual repression, which was based particularly on the Freudo-Marxism of Wilhelm Reich and Herbert Marcuse; National Socialists and bourgeois resistance fighters, American capitalists and Italian fascists, Stalinists and sometimes Leninists moved closely together as representatives of a repressive society. In the Federal Republic of Germany, this anarchist tendency was combined with a Teutonocentrism reduced to the indictment of the leading classes of now and then to form a kind of ruling legend, the champions of which rejected an identification with the state myth of German Democratic Republic, but were highly sensitive to any kind of *anti-communism* because this seemed to disturb the coexistence that had finally achieved. After all, research and questioning continued in the field of science, and it was possible, with reference to the ever increasing distance in time, to call for a *historicization* of National Socialism as well, to emphasize its revolutionary traits more strongly than had been customary until then, and even to ascribe to it a positive role in the modernization of German society. It also became more and more difficult to uphold the warnings of a resurgence of National Socialism or even to declare incessant public education *enlightenment* to be indispensable in order to make the repetition of the terrible events impossible. At the same time, profound changes in world politics stimulated the raising of new questions.

The development towards a *permissive society*, towards a highly complex and differentiated welfare state, has continued almost everywhere in the West, generating serious reactions. The abandonment of the allies in South Vietnam in 1975 and the fearful reluctance of the USA when large African states were conquered by *Marxist* liberation movements in the fight against *Western* liberation movements made the weakness of *imperialism* clear as never before, and the conservative wave that brought Ronald Reagan to the presidency only set itself the goal of preventing an impending global political imbalance. However, the Soviet Union was now defending a weak and dependent regime through a protracted war in Afghanistan; a communist regime that was in danger from within was asserting itself with great decisiveness and initial brutality through a seizure of power by the party military; to the astonishment of the world, a very peculiar, but in appearance almost classic revolution took place in Iran, which according to widespread notions had to be called *progressive* as the

elimination of American influence and quite *reactionary* as the establishment of the rule of a high priest; and this revolutionary country was struck by a neighboring state with a war that was already in 1985 equaled World War II in duration, without the supposedly all-powerful United Nations Security Council and world public opinion showing anything other than helplessness. Rather, this public weeping came more into play when Israel waged a blitzkrieg against Lebanon, or more precisely, against its enemy's strong base in Lebanon, and when the world press not infrequently spoke about "genocide," and occasionally even of a resemblance between Zionists and National Socialists. In the meantime, the reunified Vietnam had conquered Cambodia and was in turn the subject of a *punitive expedition* by the People's Republic of China. In the Federal Republic of Germany the social-liberal coalition dissolved a little later, but the postulated "turning point" made itself felt mainly in the fact that a new party which was extremely critical of technology and showed not only formal similarities with National Socialism, which it nevertheless opposed in the most abrupt way on the main points, emerged and became influential. In the Soviet Union, on the other hand, a new wave of reforms got under way, which already in 1987 meant more than the periodic *thaw* and which in any case gave room for criticism of Stalin and certain features of its own past in a remarkable way.

The world situation has therefore not only changed so much in 1989/1991 that the assumption of an essential similarity of conditions, which alone can justify the fear of the repetition of certain events, no longer has any basis. The assumption that one day the new Hitler would lure large masses into dangerous ways in Germany and even set a new version of Auschwitz in motion was always unfounded and today now only foolish.

If, therefore, the fear of repetition is groundless and popular educational concerns are superfluous, then it should finally be allowed to take the step of making the National Socialist past an issue in its central point, and this central point is neither in *criminal tendencies* nor in *anti-Semitic obsessions*. The most essential thing about National Socialism is its relationship to Marxism and especially to communism in the form that it had gained through the victory of the Bolsheviks in the Russian Revolution. This is not a new insight, but its meaning is obscured by two assumptions that are all too common. The communists themselves put forward the thesis that National Socialism only meant a futile and therefore criminal reluctance against the will of history, namely against the socialist revolution; the liberal opponents of the communists, on the other hand, are largely of the opinion that Hitler and his people used the unfounded fear of communism to gain power as a bogeyman and a specter, and precisely in this way established a regime that was all too similar to that of Stalin.

The present book is based on the assumption that the fear and hate-filled relationship with communism was indeed the moving center of Hitler's feelings and of Hitler's ideology, that he articulated only in a particularly intense way what many German and non-German contemporaries felt, and that all these feelings and fears were not only understandable, but also largely understandable and even, up to a certain point, justified. At a time in which the communist parties of several countries are or have been interested in participating in government and where they are all, at least in Europe, trying to work together with non-terrorist left-wing forces in a very civil way, it takes a mental effort if one is to remember that "the same" communist parties between 1919 and 1935 were everywhere the parties of the "armed insurrection," that Lenin thought that "the bourgeoisie" was "embittered to the point of madness" all over the world, that it was perceived Europe was still *trembling with fear* as late as 1930, and that the Deputy War Commissioner Frunze wrote in 1924: "To all by the very fact of our existence we undermine their (the old, bourgeois world) foundations, we destroy their stability and thereby instill in their representatives the feeling of bitter hatred, senseless fear and inveterate hostility against everything Soviet." The astonishing thing is, in truth, that by far no means all the citizens and petty bourgeoisie of Europe and America were filled with this feeling of fear and hatred, and that on the contrary, the *great social experiment* in Russia was met with sympathetic interest from many quarters. But if Lenin's and Frunze's statements were not true in this generality, nothing would be more foolish than the assumption that only Hitler and a small group of people around him were plagued by imaginary nightmares. Anyone who believes that Hitler was primarily a pan-German, who only used the *specter of communism* to disguise his intentions to conquer, should read the book by Otto Richard Tannenberg, published in 1911, "Greater Germany. The work of the 20th century" with his naive and cocky optimism and then read "Mein Kampf," and he should ask himself what makes the profound difference, since the pan-German goals are so largely the same.

Since it was already unmistakably evident at the end of the 1980s that the expectations cherished by Lenin and Frunze were not fulfilled, it cannot and must not be ruled out from the outset that the anti-communist passion of the National Socialists was genuine and that it was not opposed to the development which history actually took. The decisive question then is why a predictable reaction, justified in essence by the later course of history, has assumed such an excessive character that it led not only to the greatest war in world history, but also to singular mass crimes. This question can be answered in an anticipatory and abbreviated way, that *overshooting* is the basic character of every ideology and that it is unavoidable even and precisely when overshooting that an ideology gives rise to a counter-ideology. The fact that this counter-ideology came to victory in a large state, although the most momentous

overshooting, namely the anti-Semitic interpretation of the anti-communist experience, was only plausible and moving for a small part of the nation, can only be made understandable if Hitler was able to convincingly combine other, simpler and far more popular motifs with that basic ideological motif, for example the motif of the revision of Versailles or the motif of the unification of all Germans. But such theses can only be suggestive and anticipatory; they cannot replace the full account.

The present book aims to focus on the relationship between Communists and National Socialists and furthermore on the relationship between the Soviet Union and the Third Reich as the most important of all relationships for Germany, for the Soviet Union and for the whole world. In doing so, it remains on the basis of the phenomenological theory of fascism insofar as it starts from the essential hostility between Communists and National Socialists and does not consider equation to be justified at any point in time. But it nevertheless does not leave the framework of totalitarianism, because it is oriented to the concept and reality of the *liberal system*, which, with its safeguarding of the economic and intellectual freedom of movement of individuals, is *not* determined by the rule of an ideology and is nevertheless the origin of both the communist and the communist system of the National Socialist ideology. But because the approach of the fascism theory is preserved, one of the two ideologies is assigned priority, and the theory of totalitarianism thus acquires a historical-genetic dimension that it has previously lacked. Part of the historical movement, however, that the original and the reactive ideology do not remain mere complexes of ideas, that they are already rooted as such in real relationships, that they take the form of movements and, ultimately, of regimes, that they are in a relationship of interaction and change as a result. Thus, when the history of ideology is being written here, it is far from being a mere history of ideas. It is also a history of the interrelationships between two great states, but it belongs no less to the genre of comparative historiography.

It can only rely on predecessors to a small extent. The studies on the theory of totalitarianism, especially the classical works by Hannah Arendt and Friedrich/Brzezinski, are comparative in political terms, but not actually historical, and historiography has so far only made one of the two phenomena its subject, but not their internal and external relationship. Detailed studies of the struggles between Communists and National Socialists during the Weimar period are few in number. It was only in the area of international relations, and insofar as the German-Soviet war, which of course found numerous representations as a whole and in individual aspects, that topics such as "Germany and the Soviet Union" or "Stalin and Hitler" were often dealt with. These questions are, however, too limited to be able to even tend to bring into view that *whole* which, in my opinion, can be better understood by emphasizing

the question of National Socialism and Communism in the form of the Soviet Union and the Third International than by describing the diverse events in world history in modern times or even just in the 20th century.

This is not to suggest that the literature does not contain numerous important and thought-provoking statements about the reciprocal relationship. In scholarly studies of National Socialism, Hitler's takeover of power is often referred to as an apparent or spurious revolution, and this is usually explicitly or implicitly linked to the opinion that, in contrast, the Bolsheviks' seizure of power was a genuine revolution based on the example of the French Revolution. Not infrequently, however, comparisons are expressly rejected on the grounds that the circumstances were all too different. Apparently the opinion is very widespread that references to the Soviet Union or Stalinism could lead to an *apology* or impair the *incomparability* of the National Socialist crimes. Far more frequently and with greater impartiality, such references are made in literature that are devoted to Bolshevism or the Soviet Union. Louis Fischer, himself a former communist and close connoisseur of Soviet conditions, writes that Stalin's purges had only one rival in history, namely Hitler's gas chambers; the recently emigrated Soviet historians Michail Heller and Alexander Nekrich describe Stalin's system as "the most anti-human system" that ever existed on earth, for Milovan Djilas there was never a "more brutal and cynical despot than Stalin" and Nikolaj Tolstoy; brings up the most important implication when he says that Hitler was almost law-abiding when compared to Stalin. Leonard Schapiro, on the other hand, suggests a comparison between Lenin and Hitler when he suggests that obsession with power was the only lasting element in Lenin's thought, and that this resulted in his will to never compromise. Adam Ulam, on the other hand, restricts his testimony to a relatively short period of time when he claims that Stalin's regime in 1936/1939 was undoubtedly the most tyrannical in the world. But the Bolshevik leaders themselves, through early statements, made such comparisons, so to speak, in the mouths of those who came after them, for example Trotsky, who wrote in 1924 that the revolution was proceeding with the "methods of cruelest surgery," or Stalin, who stated without any emotion, that the landowners, kulaks, capitalists and traders had been "eliminated" in the Soviet Union. Some of the harshest utterances in particular come from former communists and therefore arose from revisionary reflection and not from a *bourgeois anti-communism* that was given from the beginning. For Leopold Trepper, the former "Big Boss" of the "Red Orchestra", in retrospect, Stalinism and fascism are equally "monsters", and in the estate of Hans Jaeger, who wrote articles for *Inprekorr* in 1932, the following sentence can be found: "Marxism is indirectly to blame for the six million dead Jews. It preached hatred first, it first demonstrated the extermination of a class. "

But other former communists evidently took no morally justified offense at Stalin's extermination measures even after 1945, because they considered them to be historically unavoidable and justified: Stalin was, despite his inhumanity, was a great revolutionary leader, wrote Isaac Deutscher, while Hitler was only a sterile counterrevolutionary. Among the non-communist authors, Walter Laqueur also makes a moral difference, when he speaks out against a comparison of the National Socialist death camps with Stalin *forced labor camps* . Adam Ulam, on the other hand, sees the difference above all in the greater wisdom of Stalin, who always pursued an extremely cautious foreign policy. Quite a few of the fellow travelers and authors, however, allow Stalin in particular to abolish the original distinction between communism and fascism: Walter Krivitsky, Vladimir Antonov-Ovsejenko and Franz Borkenau said that through Stalin, Bolshevism had assumed the form of its enemy, namely fascism .

I believe that these very different statements are not absolutely irreconcilable and that even those that were already negative for Lenin do not arise simply from ignorance, incomprehension or mere hostility. In the following I start from the simple basic premise that the revolution of the Bolsheviks in 1917 created a completely new type of situation in world history, because for the first time in modern history an ideological party seized power in a large state and credibly demonstrated its intention to unleash civil wars throughout the world, which would bring about the fulfillment of the hopes of the early labor movement and the fulfillment of the predictions of Marxism. Nothing was more evident to the Bolsheviks themselves than that such a monstrous undertaking would have to arouse extremely fierce opposition, especially since practice had shown that after the violent seizure of power the party fought, with the greatest determination, even exterminated, its numerous opponents both on the front of the civil war and in the rear through an unprecedented *class war* .

The most peculiar and earliest successful *resistance movement* was the Fascist Party of Italy, headed by the former leader of the revolutionary wing of the country's Socialist Party, Benito Mussolini. This made it clear that the opposition was sharper and that there had to be far more inner kinship than in the case of the bourgeois parties, which trusted that they could meet the first and second challenges according to the usual rules of the parliamentary system. Mussolini was a role model for Hitler from the very beginning, and his party too, felt from the outset that it was an answer to the communist challenge, no matter how much it did not go into mere reaction and had historical roots of its own, such as the pan-German doctrine. But from an early stage this response also had the characteristics of a copy, as was already evident in the merely modified adoption of the red flag. With the assumption of power, this symbolic aspect became more prominent, and as early as 1933, enemies and friends were

using the word *Cheka* to denote the method of combating opponents. Yet Hitler was undoubtedly convinced that he had found an answer to the communist challenge that was better and more permanent than that of the *western democracies*. But even in the so-called Röhm affair there was no longer an answer and not even a correspondence, but an over-correspondence. During the war, Bolshevism became a more and more unmistakable model for Hitler in important areas, and in the area of extermination measures it achieved an over-equivalence.

In the following, the history of the interrelationships between the two movements or regimes is described with the help of these terms: Challenge and Response, Origin and Copy, Correspondence and Over-correspondence. In the first and suggestive summary it can be said: For National Socialism, Bolshevism was both a horror and a role model. The civil war that both waged against each other, however, differed most strikingly from ordinary civil wars.

A vision of horror is different from a *nightmare*. A nightmare can be unreal and a mere idea; a horror-sight, however, has a solid foundation in reality, although from the outset it includes that tendency to exaggerate, which is also the main characteristic of all ideologies. Only if it were proven that the early anti-Bolshevik literature, which found its way into the last village in pamphlets and newspaper articles, was in itself nothing but interest-driven propaganda and an appreciable content of reality, would we be able to speak of nightmares and scare fantasies. It will be shown that the opposite was the case. Anyone who had the feeling at the time that the Bolshevik Revolution had stepped into a new world-historical dimension, the dimension of the social annihilation of large numbers of people and, of course, that of a different kind of industrial revolution, was not wrong. Anyone who was of the opinion that all of this was happening in a *semi-Asiatic* country and that it could not have any noticeable effects in the context of European civilization was not necessarily right. That social annihilation was finally followed by biological and *transcendental* annihilation, that the copy exceeded the model in intensity in some areas, can hardly be adequately described in terms of ordinary life such as *crime*. Whether one can use the term "tragedy" as George Kennan suggested is questionable for other reasons. But it is definitely wrong if, even in this age between 1917 and 1945, one sees only interests at work everywhere. Interest-psychology, first developed by French aristocrats of the 18th century and then by English utilitarianism, is of great use wherever there is calculation, measurement and weighting. But the human being is essentially not a calculating being: he fears for his existence, he fears the future, he feels hatred of his enemies, he is ready to sacrifice his life when a great cause is at stake. Where powerful emotions of this kind are decisive for larger groups of people, one should speak of

basic emotions. One such *basic emotion* was the indignation of numerous workers and unemployed at the injustices and inequalities of the *capitalist system* ; but a basic emotion was also the passionate anger of numerous French against the *Boches* , who had stolen two of its most beautiful provinces from the fatherland in 1871. In everyday life, politics may be a matter of calculating interests and balancing interests; but as soon as something unusual and threatening occurs, emotions are far more important than interests for many people, even if these emotions are only in rare cases directly opposed to the presented or imaginable interests: indignation, anger, grief, hatred, contempt, fear, but also enthusiasm, hope, belief in a great task.

Such basic emotions moved the masses of Russian soldiers in 1917, who feared that they would have to sacrifice their lives senselessly in a war that had already been lost; such basic emotions also determined officers, freikorps fighters and members of the bourgeoisie in Italy and Germany, who knew very well their kind had been treated in Russia. The active cores of the communist and fascist parties were still filled with basic emotions in later times, even though a vast number of opportunists, interested parties and also common criminals had attached themselves to them. In the following, the a history of two most important parties of two world movements is will be written as a history of the basic emotions and their ideological formations, one of which was more original and therefore primarily a horror for the other, but which nevertheless became more and more a horror and a role model each other. The National Socialist takeover of power on January 30, 1933 is therefore only a preliminary starting point, and as much space is devoted to the history of the Soviet Union as to the story of the struggle between Communists and National Socialists in the Weimar Republic and the history of National Socialist Germany.

If communism and National Socialism are primarily understood as ideologies and, above all, if their leaders are understood as ideologists, then Hitler is no more properly seen as a German politician than Lenin is seen as a Russian statesman. That doesn't mean that one was not *also* a German politician and the other also a Russian statesman. But the question always is first and foremost about the *overshooting* , about the *newness* , about the *hiatus* , which constitute what is actually ideological, from which the most important actions emerge. Ideologies can be very different, but each one is characterized by this excess and by a core of what is justified and timely, which perhaps can only be brought to existence through ideological excess, but which can also be ruined by it. In Theodor Herzl's "Zionist Diary" one can follow the development of a concept that later became effective in world-history, but what exorbitant hopes and unreal ideas it is clothed in! And yet Herzl would probably have thrown in the towel very quickly if he had only thought pragmatically and rationally. Only a

new situation can enable those who are born later to distinguish between the *real* core and the *unreal* exaggeration; contemporaries, on the other hand, seize or reject the whole thing with all passion, and only in these struggles can it gradually become clear what is core and what is overshoot. Hitler did not see himself as a successor to Stresemann or Papen, but as an anti-Lenin, and in this view he agreed with Trotsky, who called him the "super-Wrangel of the world bourgeoisie."

For Trotsky, of course, Lenin was completely right, and Hitler was completely wrong; but whoever does not share the conviction of the absolute truth of an ideology will certainly have to be of the opinion that Hitler could not be wrong in every respect, but that in his views and actions there are also cores in which something came to light that was timely and, at least for numerous people, insightful and moving. When he postulated the amalgamation of all Germans into one state, he basically demanded nothing other than what Mazzini had successfully demanded for all Italians, and he was just as moving along the lines of nation-state thinking as most of his contemporaries. The fact that this unification as such had to arouse much stronger resistance than the unification of all Italians was due to the special circumstances of the situation of the Germans in Europe and Hitler was not responsible for it. The fact that the greater German unification was not an end in itself, but a step towards a greater goal, and that he gave a very specific and universal interpretation of the resistance he encountered in the process, was actually ideological and formed a new dimension.

The task of the historian, and especially the historian of ideology, is to follow these connections. He has to accept that he is criticized by those who want to be confronted with *absolute evil* in the retrospect and who believe that they are in the service of *absolute good*. In the painting he has to paint, only shades of gray of various kinds have a place; he is as well denied the use of white as that of black. Only through the depiction itself, and not through predetermined creeds and assurances, can he convince his readers that his shades of gray have gradations. He is well aware that there is no fundamental difference between historical thinking and ideologies inasmuch as both have to abstract and generalize and do not take into account the richness of the multifaceted reality. Because man is a thinking being, he must develop ideologies and thus be unjust. According to the theologians, only God is just, because he creates individual things by thinking them and therefore does not need to distort them with concepts. But historical thinking, out of a new time situation, can weigh up different ideologies against one another in their content and pursue them in their effectiveness, and it should be guided by the determination not to yield to the will to realize ends, which is the basic will of every ideology. It must indeed make a selection already through its questioning, but within the scope of this selection it must not have a

higher goal than to produce a picture of the object that is as comprehensive and truthful as possible. It was not Hitler who was first called the enemy of humanity, the embodiment of evil, the destroyer of civilization, but the historian knows and must therefore also say that all these expressions were used by serious observers on Bolshevism when hardly anyone knew anything about Hitler; Hitler was not the first to publicly declare from a position of power that he and his party could not live on a planet with a group people numbering in millions, and that they must therefore be exterminated. These statements are true; whoever knows and hides them acts unscientifically and immorally, because he wants to allow only individual groups of countless victims to be valid. Moreover, he acts inconsistently in declaring people so unequal that he rules out the possibility that he and his kind might have been just as guilty in the same situation as those whom he accuses. It goes without saying that differences are not denied, for difference is the essence of reality. But historical thinking must oppose the tendency of ideological and emotional thinking to solidify the differences, to ignore the connections and to exclude the "other side," the opposing side, from consideration.

The intentional *impartiality* of historical thought cannot be God-like and therefore error-free. It is not exempt from the danger of merely taking sides in particularly covert or subtle ways. But in a juridical picture it is nothing else than the demand that regular court proceedings take the place of the summary courts and show trials, i.e. court proceedings in which exonerating witnesses are also seriously heard and the judges are not just formally different from the prosecutors. The individual verdicts will still be very different, but unlike those of the drumhead courts, they will have intermediate stages between the death penalty and acquittal. Nevertheless, they are not free of errors and therefore do not preclude revision.

Historical thinking, too, must be ready to revise itself, provided that good reasons are put forward and not merely indignant outcries that refuse to admit that everything must be made understandable if possible, but that not everything that can be understood is understandable and that not everything that is understandable is justified. But it cannot be willing to ever renounce its own existence, and only then does an immediate and concrete partisanship result. If Hitler had won, in German-ruled Europe and probably also in large parts of the rest of the world, historiography would persist for centuries in praising the Führer's deeds. *Dehitlerization* would not be possible by all human standards. Perhaps people—apart from the victims who would not be talked about—would be happier because they would be relieved of the need to compare and to weigh and measure; many of the late-born *anti-fascists* of today would certainly be staunch and esteemed supporters of the regime. Only for historical thinking and revising there would be no place, and therefore historical thinkers would be counted as *counter-types* in this system and would have no right to exist.

But not even this knowledge must cause them to join the ranks of their fighting contemporaries at a later date.

Chapter I

Final Point and Prelude 1933: The Anti-Marxist Seizure of Power in Germany

The story of the National Socialist takeover of power can be written as a story of intrigues and crimes: There Adolf Hitler, the leader of a weakened party in inexorable decline, is "brought to power" by the deceitfulness of the former Reich Chancellor von Papen, in the interest of the agrarians threatened by the East aid scandal, by threats against the son of the Reich President von Hindenburg, or by the intervention of heavy industrial circles, and he consolidates this power by having his political opponents arrested and finally by having the Reichstag set on fire. In this context, conversations in the house of the Koln banker von Schroder, in the Dahlem villa of the von Ribbentrop family and people like Werner von Alvensleben, play a major role, while Ernst Thalmann's name does not appear in general, as in most memoirs of the participating contemporaries.

If the historian withdraws from this all too close proximity to the greatest possible distance, a different picture emerges. Since the Reichstag elections on July 31, 1932, the NSDAP had become by far the strongest party, after an unprecedented rise in German parliamentary history with 230 seats and almost 38% of the votes. If one party is considerably stronger than the others in the parliamentary system, a coalition of all or almost all of the other parties can be formed against them. This is not in accordance with the nature of the system and is difficult to maintain in the long run, but it can be necessary if the party concerned is anti-constitutional. Then the most important task must be to protect the majority of the people from a mass minority, which is presumably characterized by particularly strong convictions and has a particularly high level of energy. If, however, the majority is unable to form such a coalition, the government, as the trustee of the popular majority, has only two options: to openly fight this large party or to try to decisively weaken and perhaps split it. The open

struggle inevitably arises when the party takes to the streets and calls for the overthrow of the government. This was the situation at the turn of the year 1918/19, when the Council of People's Deputies had to use military force against the almost overwhelming mass minority in the capital, which wanted to prevent the elections to the Constituent National Assembly. However, although the National Socialists did not infrequently threaten to seize power by force, they did not carry out the threat and persisted with their legalistic tactics. Thus, on August 13, 1932, Reich President von Hindenburg refused the leader of the strongest party the government leadership he had undoubtedly been entitled to claim if he had not, according to the official account, demanded all the power. He himself denied having made such a claim; but hadn't Alfred Rosenberg insisted on June 1st in the *Volkischer Beobachter* "All power to Adolf Hitler," and weren't all of the party's rallies filled with the most violent attacks against the system? The struggle could only be waged as an appeal to the people and in fact the National Socialists lost no less than two million votes in the Reichstag elections of November 1932.

But with 196 seats, they were still by far the strongest party. Chancellor von Papen now called for a renewed dissolution of the Reichstag and for a non-partisan government of national dictatorship, which, however, received little support from the electorate. But Hindenburg refused to take this route because he feared a civil war would break out. So he entrusted the government to the previous Reichswehrminister von Schleicher, who seemed to know a peaceful way out, the way out of a split in the NSDAP with the help of the second man in the party, Gregor Strasser, and a new kind of coalition formation with the support of the trade unions. But after only a few weeks this plan had failed as a result of the machinations of Hitler and the Social Democratic Party, and there was no longer a third possible solution; Hitler had to get the job if he could prove that he was not striving for full power and was content to be the chancellor of a cabinet in which his supporters were only a minority and in which he himself was virtually placed under guardianship by a quite unusual provision, namely the provision that he was only allowed to lecture the Reich President in the presence of Vice-Chancellor von Papen. If anything was illegal in this government formation, then it was an illegality, or at least an irregularity, which was directed against Hitler. The tamed or framed Hitler meant the imperative slogan in an unprecedented crisis.

It can be assumed that the first view is too much attached to the superficial appearance and the moralistic impulse of condemnation of persons or groups. There is no doubt that the other interpretation is too deterministic and distant in character. But it is obvious that the situation in Germany was particularly difficult. There were even, according to official statistics, more than six million unemployed, who had to live to no small extent on the tiny support provided

by public welfare, and if the United States was hit even harder by the world economic crisis, there were no anti-constitutional parties there, although criticism of the capitalist system was gaining more and more strength, especially among the intellectuals of the East Coast. In Germany, however, not only was there the anti-constitutional party of the National Socialists, which directed its propaganda primarily against the Weimar parliamentarism and the Versailles system, but alongside it and even before it was the Communist Party, which agitated for the overthrow of capitalism as a whole and, as a section of the Communist International, wanted to establish the dictatorship of the proletariat through an armed uprising, following the example of the Russian Revolution. This party was the only one that had consistently won the four Reichstag elections since 1928, so that it had risen from 54 seats in May 1928 to 100 seats in November 1932. It is true that there were voices claiming that the KPD was predominantly a protest party of the unemployed and that its everyday threats were nothing more than revolutionary rhetoric that emerged from a feeling of powerlessness. But why then shouldn't Hitler's announcements on January 30th, that he would destroy Marxism and even the other parties, be taken for propaganda or encouraging phrases?

In any case, Hugenberg and Papen had good reason to believe that Hitler would quickly come to his senses and work soberly in a cabinet where, apart from him, only two other National Socialists held a seat and whose most important positions - the Foreign Ministry and the Ministry of the Reich Armed Forces - had been filled directly by the Reich President. But they had hardly expected the cheering and excitement that broke out across Germany at the news of Hitler's appointment. Never before had any cabinet from the Weimar period been welcomed and cheered by large crowds. But then, even in small towns in the most distant province, torchlight processions were formed, numerous spectators stood on the side enthusiastically, huge columns streamed through the streets in Berlin without needing police protection, surrounded by the sympathy of the spectators, and they marched through the Brandenburg Gate with their torches, in uniforms and in military order, past the offices of the Reich President and the new Reich Chancellor. This torchlight procession soon became a legend and a favorite subject for literature and film, but as certainly as it was organized and then stylized, the descriptions of Nazi contemporaries reveal much of the spontaneity, moods, and interpretations that also characterized the evening of January 30.:

“They did not say that Hitler became Chancellor of the Reich; they just said: Hitler. They said it to one another in the street, in front of the shops, at the counter, called it to one another on the subway, on the bus. It jumped from person to person like an electric spark, igniting a whole huge city, igniting millions of hearts ... It was like the year [19]14, when the pulse of an entire people was pounding... Alarm! It jumped from street to street. The SA, the SS

rushed into their rooms. The steel helmets gathered: Torchlight procession ... It took four hours.. New cohorts, always new ... then the first steel helmet in field gray: the face of the German Front ... They did not speak it out and they all knew it: What they experienced today on this burning night was the awakening of the nation, was the counter-revolution, was the price paid for November 9th. "

The 30th of January was actually and initially perceived as: the day of the national uprising, the answer to the shame of the collapse of 1918 - by no means by all Germans, but by the nation OF Germany, which considered the August days of 1914 as the final breakthrough to the truth of the nation and believed only in the victories that followed, but not in the defeats, not in the gradually spreading war fatigue among the people and certainly not in the "Fourteen Points" of the American Wilson.. This national Germany, however, potentially reached down into the hearts of most Germans, because the enthusiasm of the August days had indeed been as good as general, and if the Social Democrats had striven for a peace of understanding in the early days, it was precisely the Social Democratic Reich Minister President Scheidemann who, in 1919, preferred to see his hand withered rather than the unjust Treaty of Versailles signed. What won on January 30 was initially not so much Hitler, but it was the conception of history, the historical legend of national Germany with all the persuasive power that belongs to the very simple and the very emotional. The first call of the new Reich government on February 1st was tuned to this tone, and there is no reason to believe that Hitler merely hyped and did not sympathize with these very conservative and generally national trends.

But this national Germany had long since excluded a large part of those who had agreed with it in August 1914: not only the Social Democrats, but also the Catholics and the Liberals who had participated in the 1917 peace resolution of the Reichstag, i.e. all of these establishment parties that had supported the Weimar Republic. Even under the already irregular conditions of the Reichstag election of March 5, 1933, these parties received not very much less votes than the NSDAP, and if the Communists had been allowed to be added to them, it would have been about half of the people. Why did this half remain so passive and hardly make itself felt? It was only the enthusiasm of the national Germany that had caused so much paralysis and immobility; but the Germany of the turn of 1932/33 was more violently shaken by the consequences of the great crisis of the world economy than any other nation. In such a situation, every event that falls out of everyday routine is greeted with hope or at least with the willingness to give it a chance. Many unemployed people who voted in protest and desperation for the PCF in November now want to assume that Hitler might know a way out after all. The farmers, whose hopes were threatened by the foreclosure auction, the artisans whose order backlog had continued to decline, the small traders who didn't know how to meet

their payment obligations: none of them put any more trust in the stimulus measures or the tax vouchers from Papen and Schleicher, nor had they yet been persuaded by Thalmann's radical proposals, which for better or worse would have to bind Germany to the Soviet Union. So they trusted the one who was full of determination and yet refused the revolutionary measures, the consequences of which would be incalculable, and even if they remained merely passive, they crippled those who called for a resistance that would lead to a complete overthrow.

The fear that such an overthrow was possible and that it would be sought for by strong forces was probably the most powerful driving force behind the national uprising that so quickly turned into the "National Socialist Revolution". Even more fundamental than the enthusiasm for national Germany and the hopes of the population shaken by the crisis was the fear of bourgeois Germany of an imminent communist revolution. In fact, the PCF was the strongest party in the capital of the Reich, and throughout February the air was full of rumors about the communists' preparations for civil war, about secret arms shipments, and even about plans to set fire to German churches and museums. It is hard to doubt that Hitler shared the widespread worries and fears. Although the executive committee of the Social Democratic Party rejected the communists' proposal to call a joint general strike as early as January 30, which was not surprising given the mutual hostility, a number of serious clashes took place throughout the Reich, and the national socialists were not always the aggressors. During the march back from the torchlight procession on January 30, the leader of the notorious Communist murder storm 33, Eberhard Maikowski, was shot, and a little later, according to a report by the Red Flag, armed workers dominated the street during a 24-hour general strike in Lubeck. From the beginning there could be no doubt about the determination of Hitler and Goring, who now had the power of command over the Prussian police, to assert himself by all means. The fire in the Reichstag on February 27 accelerated the development, but it by no means brought it about. The lists on the basis of which almost all Communist members of the Reichstag and Landtag as well as numerous other functionaries were arrested had already been prepared by the police during the last Weimar years, and Goring's shooting decree was dated February 17.

An opportunity to declare a state of emergency would certainly have been found if the emergency decree of the President of the Reich for the protection of the people and the state had not already been issued on February 28. Presumably, without the Reichstag fire, Hitler's government would not have received an absolute majority in the elections of March 5, but even without a majority of seats, it was able to put the newly elected Reichstag under such pressure that it passed the Enabling Act with a two-thirds majority, and with it its

self-disempowerment, as the deputies actually did on March 23, under the impression of the marching SA, but even more so in view of the expectations of the public. The still unanswered question about the originator (s) of the Reichstag fire is only important in connection with the overarching question of whether genuine emotions existed on the part of the ruling National Socialists or whether cynical people in power did not even shy away from an extremely risky crime in order to establish sole rule that they otherwise could not have won. Everything speaks for the fact that the leading National Socialists were dominated by convictions and emotions that made such a crime unnecessary, whatever the specific process may have been. The strongest of these convictions and emotions now all related to November 1918 in Germany and to the revolution in Russia; they were anti-Bolshevik emotions, and they saw themselves as anti-Marxist so naturally that they were obviously rooted in bourgeois sentiments, but nonetheless went beyond them.

On February 10th Hitler spoke at the Berlin Sportpalast. Above the lectern the sentence could be read in large letters: "Marxism must die." And the whole speech revolved around this motto, the central sentences of which were as follows: "Marxism means the perpetual tearing apart of the nation..outwardly pacifist, inwardly terrorist - only in this way alone could this worldview of destruction and eternal negation assert itself...Either Marxism triumphs or the German people, and Germany will triumph." On March 2nd, he gave another speech in the Sportpalast, and this time there was no statesmanlike caution holding him back, but instead he looked beyond the German borders: "Has this Marxism eliminated misery where it has won one hundred percent, where it really and invariably rules, in Russia? The reality here speaks a shocking language. Millions of people have starved to death in a country that could have been a granary for the whole world...You say brotherhood. We know this brotherhood. Hundreds of thousands of people, even millions, had to be shot in the name of this brotherhood and as a result of the Great Gluck...They go on to say that capitalism has been overcome by it...The capitalist world has to come up with its credits, supply the machines and set up the factories, provide the engineers, the foremen, everything has to be done by this other world. You cannot deny that. And I would only recommend the work system in the Siberian woodlands for a week to those who rave about this principle in Germany ... If a weak bourgeoisie surrendered to this madness - we take up the fight against this madness"

In the same issue of the *Völkischer Beobachter* there was a large advertisement in which 22 workers who had returned from Russia called for the election of Adolf Hitler, arguing that Soviet Russia was hell for the workers and peasants because they had to endure miserable starvation while working hard.

Again and again in Hitler's speeches during these months the one basic demand appears, to destroy Marxism, to exterminate it consistently and mercilessly. But this demand is not infrequently linked with the memory of the rucksack Spartacists of 1918, and when Hermann Goring declared on March 3 that he had only to destroy and exterminate, he turned a few days later to his opponents with the passionate accusation: "When we came back from the front 14 years ago, they kicked our hats and badges of honor, they kicked us into the dirt, they burned the flags that victoriously defied a world. You have abused our deepest hearts, and then you trampled it, as you have trampled Germany."

In fact, his question to the communists was justified: "What had they done when they had conquered power in our place? They had made us a head shorter without much thought."

The social democratic President of the Reichstag, Paul Lobe, had expressed the same meaning in 1929, but he had credited his party with preventing the mutual annihilation of the two extreme parties. And Hitler, too, in the speech of March 2, had so strongly distinguished the alleged wretchedness of dismissed Social Democratic police chiefs, now fearing for their pensions, from the determination and bloodthirstiness of the Communists that it seemed almost incomprehensible how two such different phenomena could be brought under the same concept of Marxism. But it was precisely this anti-Marxism that was the main characteristic of National Socialist ideology, and it was precisely for this reason that it turned against the bourgeoisie, whose emotions it so largely shared, and it was precisely for this reason that it extended itself once again to the whole of modern history, as when Rudolf Hess, for example, turned against SA outcries in July with the following justification: "The Jewish-Bolshevik Russian revolution echoes with millionfold cries from Chekist blood cellars. No revolution in the world was as disciplined as the National Socialist one...Everyone must know that we are far from treating the enemy with leniency. He must know that every murder committed by Communists or Marxists against a National Socialist will be punished tenfold by us against Communist or Marxist leaders...But every National Socialist must also be aware that mistreatment of opponents corresponds to Judaeo-Bolshevist sentiments and is unworthy of National Socialism.."

But what was the positive thing that you could hold onto when you saw so many negative things? Most likely it was the unity and health of the people secured against all dangers, which, of course, could only be achieved by a long road. Far from all of the former officers and hardly even the majority of the German national citizens, not even all of the Nazi old fighters wanted to go with them, but they could not easily resist the consequences with which all parties were dissolved step by step by July or were forced to dissolve themselves, with

which the Aryan principle was enforced and the law for the prevention of hereditary offspring was passed. If the national uprising wanted to be consistently anti-Marxist, then it had to become a National Socialist revolution, and the National Socialist revolution in turn had to be declared over by Adolf Hitler in the summer of 1933 because it only wanted to be a political upheaval in which all power was held in the hand of one party and its leader, but not an economic overthrow along the lines of the Russian model, which had by no means been disastrous only in Hitler's eyes even in the country of origin and would have even worse consequences in the industrialized countries of the world. For Hitler and all the champions of national uprising, the Soviet Union in 1933 was entirely a horror. But was it not nevertheless to some extent a model in the National Socialist revolution?

In an interview with a German diplomat, Foreign Minister Litvinov is reported to have said that the Soviet Union understands that Germany treats its communists as the Soviet Union treated its enemies of the state. In any case, harsh measures against communists and the communist press were one of the main characteristics of the National Socialist regime from the very first day, and Goring's shooting decree of February 17 and the establishment of an auxiliary police consisting of SA and SS on February 22 were directed against the communists: Even now, "ruthless use of the gun" was being made, and prisoners were already being "shot on the run." But terror can only be talked about after the Reichstag fire, and it immediately spread far beyond the ranks of the communists, even though the ordinance on the protection of people and state was only intended to "ward off communist acts of violence that endanger the state". Social democrats and some bourgeois politicians were also taken into protective custody and sent to the concentration camps that were sprouting up everywhere- only a few of which were state-run, but most of which were set up and run by SA or SS departments under their own direction. Apart from the Dachau camp near Munich, which was after all nominally state-run, unauthorized [*wilde*] camps such as the Columbia Haus in Berlin, Oranienburg, Kemna in Wuppertal and others became particularly well known. Their main characteristics were improvisation and the often personal, but in any case concrete, hatred that emerged in the behavior of the guards towards the prisoners. The Oranienburg camp was built in a factory that had originally been a brewery, and the prisoners' bedrooms were in the former bottled beer cellar, where at first only straw sacks were available. Kemna, too, was an abandoned factory, and it took a long time to create the necessary conditions for the accommodation of a considerable number of prisoners. Everywhere, however, there was a harsh and one-sided confrontation between political opponents who knew each other only too well, especially in small camps, and who a few weeks or months ago had faced bitter battles on the streets. So political and private bills were settled in large numbers, and several hundred prisoners lost their lives during the first few

years under the beatings and sometimes sadistic tortures. Abuses were soon publicly complained about and remedial promises were made, but initially the judiciary rarely succeeded in freeing victims or bringing those responsible to justice. There were around 30,000 prisoners in custody in 1933, and anyone released from a camp had to undertake in writing not to reveal anything about their experiences. Nevertheless, rumors soon began to circulate and the first authentic reports appeared in 1934 of escaped prisoners, such as that of Gerhart Seger, who had been a member of the Reichstag for the SPD for many years, at Oranienburg.

Here, in a credible manner, which carefully avoided exaggerations and smears, were reports of the torture chamber in the interrogation room, where prisoners were beaten so terribly that several of them died of the consequences, about the humiliations, to which especially prominent prisoners were locked up for days and nights as in standing stone coffins, if they had violated the camp rules. But Seger also knew of the continuing hatred between the communist and social democratic prisoners, which led the communists to applause when the commandant announced the imminent arrival of new "Social Democratic Bigwigs", and he altered an old dislike when he stated that that the punishment exercise at the Prussian commissioner was a humane institution "if one compares it" with the meanness of the corresponding SA events. " These concentration camps were, so to speak, the end of a civil war in which the victorious party displayed extraordinary brutality and cruelty precisely because they had the impression that they themselves were nearly defeated. It was not incomprehensible that the prisoners, who in the beginning had been transported to Dachau under the supervision of the police, sometimes singing the International and shouting cheers for the KPD, were informed in the camp that they were now being treated according to their own recipe but it was nevertheless a symptomatic step forward when the first commandant of Dachau, Hilmar Wackerle, expressly demanded of his SS men that they should become for Germany what the Cheka was for Russia.

And the atrocities often took on a character that, even with the most generous interpretation, shook the basis on which even the sharpest and one-sided civil war terror must still stand: the basis for preserving one's own identity. It was not a fugitive opponent, but the Reich Minister of Justice, Dr. Gurtner, who in 1935 wrote the following about the events in the savage concentration camps before their dissolution at the beginning of 1934: "In the concentration camp Hohnstein in Saxony, prisoners had to stand under a drip apparatus specially constructed for this purpose until their scalps showed severe purulent injuries from the drops of water falling at regular intervals. In a concentration camp in Hamburg, four prisoners were tied to a grate in the shape of a cross for days - once for three days and nights, once for five

days and nights - without interruption, and were fed so meagerly with dry bread that they almost starved to death. These few examples show such a degree of cruelty that makes a mockery of every German sensibility that it is impossible to consider them here.

And there is yet another fact that makes it impossible to regard the SA terror of the first year merely as the excessive final phase of a civil war that had only just begun, and which after a number of months was either stopped or at least brought under control by the state authorities. Although the first head of the Secret State Police Office, Rudolf Diels, founded at the end of April 1933, was later able to report with pride that he had succeeded, in cooperation with other authorities, in reducing the number of protective custody prisoners to 2800 and replacing the 50 or so wild concentration camps with a few state institutions, it was precisely the largest of the camps, Dachau, remained under the rule of the SS, which, by means of the skilful tactics of its Reichsfuhrer, took over ever greater police powers in the wake of Himmler's position as Political Police Commander of Bavaria, so that the terror was reduced in quantity but also systematized and continued to elude effective control by the judiciary. On the other hand, in some camps so-called *Judenkompanien* had been formed, which were subjected to a particularly harsh regiment. It is true that these too were political opponents, communists and social democrats, and apparently no Jew was admitted as a Jew, but after the arrest Jews were identified and were treated differently. Thus the transition was made to punishment for being and not for doing, and this transition was also carried out at the same time in other forms, which were not punitive or terrorist in the strict sense, but still had to be regarded as acts of persecution or oppression. First and foremost, the "Gesetz zur Wiederherstellung des Berufsbeamtentums" (Law for the Restoration of the Civil Service) of April 7, 1933, stipulated in its third paragraph: "Civil servants of non-Aryan descent are to be retired. Insofar as they are honorary civil servants, they are to be dismissed from office." Thus, into a law which, according to its title, was directed against party civil service, a completely different principle was introduced, the principle of group membership or race, which could at most be justified as a proportionality requirement, but which nevertheless necessarily had to appear as a measure of religious persecution, since no other criterion than that of membership in the "Mosaic religion" existed.

It was therefore not surprising that the persecution of the Jews immediately came to the fore in the reports of the foreign press, and presumably no special facts were needed for this, for it was the first time in world history that a party came to power in a large state which already emphatically declared itself to be anti-Semitic in its program. The reports published in the foreign press were to a large extent undoubtedly exaggerated, for example when the Herald Tribune reported as early as March 3 that the "mass murder of German Jews" was imminent,

or when the Daily Herald published an article from the "Land of the Slaughterers of the Jews" at the end of April. Equally questionable was the confluence of anti-fascist and pro-Jewish propaganda, which made it possible to carry Hitler dolls hanging from the gallows in public demonstrations. It was not much different with the movement to boycott German goods, which was set in motion only a few weeks after the seizure of power. But in all this was reflected, albeit in an exaggerated or anticipatory way, only the fact that in Germany had begun something that was unprecedented in the world: the fight against and disenfranchisement of the Jews as Jews in a modern state in which their emancipation, i.e. the legal and de facto equality with the other citizens of the state, had been completed for some time.

The extent to which this was about the contrast between the taking off National Socialist revolution and the national uprising was made clear by a book published on May 15, 1933 by Jakow Trachtenberg's publishing house, which had become known for the publication of anti-Bolshevik literature . It contains a number of statements by Jewish organizations and personalities, which are directed against the foreign "atrocities propaganda". Most of them are worded carefully, as was to be expected in view of the pressure exerted by the National Socialists; they mention "mistreatment", "riot" or "excess" but reject the news of genuine atrocities. But at various points it becomes obvious how much the largest organizations and some of the most important men were national-German and bourgeois. The Reichsbund of Jewish Front-Line Soldiers pulled back with great swiftness from the "irresponsible agitation" which "is being carried out against Germany by so-called Jewish intellectuals abroad," the Honorary Chairman of the Association of National German Jews, Dr. Max Naumann sees in the atrocity propaganda "nothing more than a new edition of the war agitation against Germany and its allies of yore," and the chairman of the German Rabbis Association, Leo Baeck, explains the main program points of the national German revolution, namely the overcoming of Bolshevism and the Renewal of Germany are also goals of the German Jews, which are not so deeply and so lively connected with any other country in Europe as with Germany. Trachtenberg himself speaks in his preface that the agitation because of the alleged atrocities in Germany could ultimately lead to actual atrocities, as the unscrupulous authors of the Lugen Campaign wanted to "evoke a new war." If the National Socialists had been nothing more than German nationalists or mere anti-communists, they would have obviously been able to communicate easily with a large part of the German Jews.

Most foreign press organs interpreted Hitler's takeover as the triumph of a new German nationalism, even if the news about the persecution of the Jews was given a lot of space. The Manchester Guardian feared and hated above all "Junkers and reactionaries," seeing in Hitler

merely an instrument of these people, and the Times did not believe that Hitler would outplay his allies in the Mussolini manner because he lacked the “extraordinary skills” of the Italian dictator. The French, too, feared the Reichswehr or the Crown Prince far more than Hitler, who was often compared disparagingly to General Boulanger. So in both countries the left and the right agreed that they did not see anything really new in Hitler, but still believed they were confronted with the reactionaries or the militarists against whom they had to fight so hard in the World War. Only Lord Rothermere's *Daily Mail* saw Hitler primarily as an anti-communist, and in October it was able to give space to a highly prominent author for the thesis that communism must follow suit if Hitler failed, namely the wartime Prime Minister Lloyd George. Comparisons with the Russian Revolution were quite rare, but at the review of the “Brown Book on Reichstag Fire and Hitler Terror” on September 8, Berlingske Tidende remarked that much more appalling things were happening where communists were in power. Even rarer were remarks such as that Hitler was not really an anti-Communist and just as little a conservative. If there was considerable anxiety and a wide variety of opinions, none of the foreign newspapers interpreted Hitler's seizure of power as an event that would have world-historical consequences.

Not only did their contemporaries deal superficially with Hitler and National Socialism. The innermost tendency of science [*tr. wissenschaft*] can lead to a similar result after more than half a century. The more carefully the individual processes that immediately preceded or followed the seizure of power are investigated, the less clear or conventional the background can become, and the greater the scope for entirely subjective assessments of the authors. Anyone who tries to follow the political events in their daily course and in all their complexity will be easily inclined to regard ideological statements, which he only occasionally comes across, as irrelevant, and whoever viewed Hermann Goring primarily from the point of view of drug addiction, will presumably dismiss the sentence that the revolutionaries of 1918 had “crushed the heart” of him and his kind as a sentimental phrase. Those familiar with parliamentary politics may declare the communists to be hooligans who only occasionally made themselves noticeable through making noise and unrealistic motions. Those who have focused their attention on the Hitler-Stalin Pact will probably see in Hitler's speech of March 2 a disingenuous and demagogic agitation. But from time to time, out of a scientific spirit, this innermost tendency of science, the tendency to ever-advancing specialization, must be countered, however great the risk. If the various statements of Hitler at the time of his takeover and the different tendencies of the National Socialist movement are to be brought into a hierarchy of the central and the marginal, the genuine impulses and tactical aids, the deeper and the less deep motives, if much-used terms such as a long look back is required, and this look back should not only extend to the World War and the German

November Revolution, but also explicitly and with characteristic details to the Russian Revolution, to which Hitler and the Volkischer Beobachter and numerous others referred Party leaders referred so often. Only then will it become clear to what extent the National Socialist takeover of power was a final point, the final point of the Weimar period, to which almost no one wanted to return in 1933, and to what extent it could at the same time be a prelude to the most revolutionary events in world history, although even the most intelligent among contemporaries considered it a mere episode.

Chapter II, Section 1

Russia's Collapse and the Drive towards World Revolution: The February Revolution and the 1917 Bolshevik Seizure of Power

Russia's Collapse and the drive Towards World Revolution: The February Revolution and the 1917 Bolshevik Seizure of power.

The revolution of the military collapse, to which the National Socialists referred again and again with words and actions, had already taken place in Russia a year and a half earlier than in Germany, in March 1917, but it was a longer and more painful process, because it could not assume the final defeat, but at first just wanted to prevent it. The seizure of power by the Bolsheviks in November meant, on the one hand, the continuation and completion of this process, but it was also the beginning of a countermovement to the dissolution of power and the cohesion of the vast empire, as would become apparent after a relatively short time.

The Bolsheviks, however, understood their “ *October Revolution* ” as the fulfillment and realization of the intentions that had guided not the politicians, but the great masses of soldiers and people already during the *February Revolution* , namely the longing for peace, social justice and freedom. The relationship of the seizure of power to the people's revolution was thus ambivalent, while the National Socialist takeover of power in Germany wanted to have a merely negative relationship to the so much more distant revolutionary collapse.

On March 8, 1917, in Petrograd, where strikes had already been going on for several days in important factories, protest demonstrations over bread shortage developed and quickly gained momentum, renewing themselves on the following days in ever greater proportions. Even from the outset, the President of the Parliament had urged the tsar, who for some time had been the personal commander-in-chief of the armies and was in his headquarters near Mogilev, to form a cabinet of general confidence as soon as possible, because the reserve

battalions of the guards' regiments were already killing their officers and, on the other hand, numerous sergeants were involved in the demonstrations.

However, Nicholas II did not agree, and a few days later most of the troops in the capital had taken the side of the demonstrators, almost all of Petersburg's police stations had been burned down, red flags were fluttering everywhere and also on the roof of the Winter Palace, the Romanov dynasty was overthrown, huge crowds drunk with joy were roaming the main streets, and next to a weak "Provisional Government" formed by members of the "Progressive Bloc" in Parliament, a "Soviet of Soldiers' and Workers' Deputies" was meeting. The latter's "Order No. 1" stipulated that councils of soldiers were to be formed in all military units and that they were to have the power of command in all political matters. Even though "the strictest military discipline" was imposed on the soldiers in the performance of their duties, the authority of the officers everywhere was permanently weakened by this order. Reports of insubordination, desertions, and assassinations of superiors piled up; the fabric of the giant Russian army was shaken. As early as March, the army leadership received the news that 90% of the officers had been arrested and were under guard, and that free officers could not walk around with shoulder patches because they were immediately torn off "by the worst elements of the crew." In April, an assembly of sailors and soldiers from Helsingfors drafted a resolution protesting "against all the war slogans spread by the bourgeoisie" and declaring the current lack of ammunition to be the "fault of the businessmen." Soldiers' letters from the front, which were held back by the censors, spoke more and more frequently of the imminent conclusion of peace and of the imminent distribution of the land of the landlords, and alongside stirring testimonies of greater self-confidence, the censors could also read phrases of terrifying ferocity: "The old power did not allow us to be considered human beings...now we are all awakened to life." In our country, all the committees are working and have already worked out projects to give the land to the people for free, without a kopeck. And if someone resists and goes against the new law, we will slaughter and destroy him, and if I had to, I would not spare even my own parents."

It became clear very early on that it was a political revolution of war-weary soldiers and, to a certain extent, a social revolution of the majority of the peasants, who wanted to see their old desire to take possession of the nobility's estates fulfilled. At the same time, in Petrograd and the few other industrial centers, the first demands of workers for the socialization of industry appeared. The Soviet of Workers' and Soldiers' Deputies was not expected to fundamentally oppose these demands, since it was largely composed of members of the peasant party of the Social Revolutionaries and the Marxist workers' party of the Mensheviks, while the Bolsheviks were still relatively weak. But the Soviet, of course, knew full well that the peace

question far surpassed all other questions in topical importance, and so he addressed impassioned appeals to the "proletarians of all countries," and especially to the German workers and soldiers: they should exert all their forces to compel their governments to conclude a general peace, now that autocracy had been overthrown in Russia and the argument of defending Europe against asiatic despotism no longer had any validity. This Soviet did not want immediate transformation, and it did not claim for itself autocracy. Rather, it was convinced that Russia could be saved only through the cooperation of all leftist parties, including the bourgeois party of "constitutional democrats" (*Kadetten*), and therefore it considered itself most like The Provisional Parliament of the Provisional Government, which it had sent representatives to from the beginning.

In so doing, of course, he took a path that had been hotly disputed even among the Western European Socialists up to the outbreak of the war, the path of collaboration with the *class enemy* , the bourgeoisie; but he believed, with good reason, that any other path must lead to the disaster of a separate peace, for the constant defeats of the Russian troops by the German armies were the real cause of the desire for peace, and the armies of the Central Powers were deep in Russia: They had occupied all of Poland and large parts of the Baltic provinces, and they were knocking at the gates of Ukraine. If the Russian army disbanded, the country would be at the mercy of German military power, and only the early conclusion of a general peace could protect the socialist forces from the accusation of having led the country into defeat. Therefore, even the Bolsheviks sided with the government, which had to save the country "from decline and collapse," now that the way was clear for a "democratic republic" and the convening of the Constituent Assembly. The first great paradox of this revolution in the desire for peace was that it was only possible because the public opinion had demanded victories and had become more and more suspicious of the Tsar's court, where Tsarina Maria Feodorovna, a German princess by birth, was supposedly working for a separate peace with the German emperor and was spreading the spirit of defeatism through her favorite Rasputin. Rasputin was indeed an opponent of this war, and his assassination in December 1916 was a victory for the war party at court, which also had numerous champions in parliament and in the Duma. After all, the war was waged in alliance with the western democracies of France and England, and the Russian *intelligentsia* and the strong industrial bourgeoisie in Petersburg had long since promised an end to autocracy and the transformation of Russia into a constitutional monarchy.

Therefore, a powerful part of public opinion welcomed the revolution as a transformation that would lead a free Russia, strengthened by freedom, to the final victory over Prussian-German militarism, at the side of the free peoples of the West. This was how the

revolution was often seen abroad, and some Americans compared the new prime minister, Georgy Lvov, to George Washington. However, not all representatives of the Allies were so optimistic. The secretary of the French legation, Count Louis de Robien, for example, already suspected in March and April what the outcome would be when he had to write in his diary that his good friend, General Stackelberg, had refused to comply with the demands of the soldiery and had been slaughtered in front of his wife and thrown into the Neva. Robien was equally disturbed when he noticed a little later that among the soldiers were "badly shaven students with long hair and green caps...all typical Russian nihilists." After all, he knew as well as all his colleagues that the Germans expected a separate peace from the revolution and had been trying for some time to exert a corresponding influence through money and agents. It probably served not least to reassure the Allies that the new foreign minister and leader of the *Kadetten*, Paul Miliukov, underlined the Russian will to win in a note and reminded them of the Russian war goals, including Constantinople.

After all, he knew as well as all his colleagues that the Germans expected a separate peace from the revolution and had been trying for some time to exert a corresponding influence through money and agents. It probably served not least to reassure the Allies that the new foreign minister and leader of the cadets, Paul Miliukov, underlined the Russian will to win in a note and reminded them of the Russian war goals, including Constantinople. In this way, against his will, he caused the second and even greater paradox: that the leader of the Bolsheviks, Vladimir Ilyich Lenin, who had returned to Petersburg from exile in Zurich in mid-April and had been received there with great ceremony, was gaining more and more support with his "April Theses". The Mensheviks, as well as many of their own party comrades, had at first taken note with bewilderment of Lenin's opinion that the provisional government was a bourgeois government, a government of the capitalists, and that the genuine socialists had to wage the fiercest struggle against it, but also against the "defenders of the fatherland" or "social chauvinists" among the "petty-bourgeois" Mensheviks and Social Revolutionaries, in order to establish a "commune" or soviet state that would "abolish the police, the army, the bureaucracy" and represent the immediate transition to socialism. But that the polemic against the capitalists and the "bourgeoisie" was popular was already evident from the fact that Milyukov had to resign after large demonstrations, and it was soon impossible to overlook the fact that Lenin had given voice to a strong popular sentiment when he tore open a huge rift within *revolutionary democracy*. On the one side were the Social Revolutionaries and Mensheviks, as well as some smaller socialist parties, which - at first still the great majority - under the leadership of Alexander Kerensky sought to narrow the distance between the Soviet and the government, so that the Provisional Government soon consisted of about half socialists. On the other side were the Bolsheviks and the

so-called internationalist Mensheviks around Julius Martov, as well as the small group of Leon Trotsky, who had returned to Russia from America. They all demanded that "all power be given to the Soviets," since only a government free of capitalists and paternalists could make a credible appeal to the people of the warring states and thus bring about a general peace.

Of course, this was by no means the first rift that Vladimir Ulyanov, the son of an ennobled inspector from Simbirsk, had torn open between himself and other socialists. In 1903, he had brought about the split of the barely founded Russian Social Democratic Workers' Party into Bolsheviks and Mensheviks, because he wanted to assert his concept of the party as a "stable and continuity-preserving leadership organization" and a "closely-knit group" of professional revolutionaries against the more democratic ideas of Martov, for whom the spontaneity of mass action was more important than the consciousness and leadership of socialist intellectuals. After that, Lenin had fought relentlessly against *liquidators*, *fideists*, and other deviations, and after the outbreak of the war, he was the only one among all the socialists of Europe who virtually demanded the defeat of his own country and demanded the "transformation of the imperialist war into a civil war. And at the same time, this friend of peace had spoken with such abysmal contempt against the whining Petty Bourgeois and their abhorrence of blood and the use of weapons that an observer had good reason to suspect that a completely new kind of socialism was being born in this man's mind. Neither Kautsky nor Rosa Luxemburg, however, had regarded him quite as one of their own, since his tactics seemed far too adapted to the specific conditions of the Russian autocracy, and the number of his followers was still very small in 1914 compared to the members and voters of German Social Democracy. At the beginning of 1917, the number of party members was only about 50,000, but in no other socialist party in Europe was the authority of a single man so great and unquestioned.

What this might mean in an extreme situation became clear to the public at large when Lenin gave a speech at the first All-Russian Congress of Soviets in June 1917 in which he not only explicitly declared himself ready to "take over all power" with his party, but also announced that he would have the biggest capitalists arrested immediately after his victory, since they, like their French and English counterparts, were nothing but robbers and dangerous schemers. Kerensky still received great applause when, with all the pathos of humanitarian socialism, he denounced as *oriental* the suggestion that people should be arrested and punished merely for their class allegiance. Lenin's old teacher, Georgy Plekhanov, the founder of Russian Marxism, polemicized against him no less harshly when he denounced "the almost pathological striving of the Bolsheviks for the seizure of power" and declared

that Lenin was by nature incapable of understanding that the defeat of Russia must also mean the defeat of Russian freedom.

Meanwhile, the masses' urge to find and attack identifiable culprits grew stronger, and in the speeches Lenin delivered from the balcony of the Palace of the Dancer Kshesinskaya, his headquarters, he bluntly propagated the popular principle of "rob the robbed," and he invoked the Red Rooster, which must be placed on the houses of the landowners. This was already happening throughout Russia, and in some places trade and commerce had come to a virtual standstill as peasants withheld shipments of timber or grain destined for distant areas and already paid for, simply to meet local needs. But the difference between unavoidable or obvious social tensions and their deliberate demand and aggravation became symptomatically apparent in a letter sent in June by the colonel of a Siberian regiment to his army high command: "It only remains for me and the officers to save ourselves because a Lenin devotee, a soldier of the 5th Company, has arrived from Petrograd. A meeting will be held at 4 p.m. It has already been decided to hang me, Morozko and Egorov, to arrest the officers and settle accounts with them. I'm going to Lozhany...Many of the best soldiers and officers have already escaped."

It is almost unbelievable that an army in such a state of disintegration still had the strength to undertake a major and initially successful offensive against the enemy in early July, the so-called Burssilov offensive. The minister of war, Kerensky, had ordered it not least to counter the growing doubts that the allies had about Russia's loyalty to the alliance and its reliability. But the advance was soon followed by retreat and catastrophic defeat, and the number of soldiers leaving the front on their own grew inexorably. The extent to which the Bolsheviks' propaganda played a part in these events cannot be determined with precision, but there can be no doubt that it was considerable.

Nevertheless, an uprising in Petrograd, which was only mildly supported by the party and resulted in several hundred deaths, seemed to undo all the successes in July, and when the government issued arrest warrants against the leading Bolsheviks and had several of them taken to prison, Lenin said before going into hiding: "Now they will shoot us one by one." But the Humanitarian Socialists were still in power, and in prison Leon Trotsky wrote article after article for the numerous organs of the party, which merely changed their names, while Lenin took lodgings in Helsingfors with the city's police chief, who sympathized with the Bolsheviks. In fact, the situation of the party would have been hopeless if the government and the Soviet had decided to take up the struggle with all their forces, because the Bolshevik party had a weakness that could be decisive. Lenin had returned home with a number of his

most important tours through Germany, and it was obvious that the German government had been guided by certain intentions when it gave its consent to such an unusual operation. Moreover, the party had conspicuously large funds at its disposal. What could be more obvious than that Lenin was working on behalf of the Germans for an early Russian withdrawal from the war? Indeed, it has long been no secret that this very idea had been decisive for the German leadership and, not least, for General Ludendorff, and that substantial sums of money had already been flowing to Russia since 1915 for revolutionary agitation, through the mediation of the former left-wing socialist Alexander Parvus Helphand, who had become a *social patriot* as a result of the war but remained a hater of tsarism. With good reason, therefore, von Kuhlmann, the secretary of state, could write in September that without the steady and extensive support of the German government, the Bolshevik movement would never have been able to assume the size and influence that it has today. In July, however, the masses, especially the soldiers in Petersburg, were still very patriotic despite the war weariness, probably not least because the government had guaranteed the garrison that it would not be transferred to the front, since it had to secure the revolution in the capital. The soldiers were therefore much easier to rally against *German agents* than against *rich capitalists*. But the social revolutionaries and the Mensheviks seized this opportunity only half-heartedly at best, and it was not only humanitarianism that was decisive, but also the feeling that they could not do without the Bolsheviks as allies for fear of the reaction.

This reaction, however, consisted primarily of a desperate effort on the part of army headquarters to control the tendencies toward disintegration in the army and the fleet and to restore the command of the officers as the indispensable precondition of resistance against the *German hereditary enemy*. In principle, the generals were under the control of the government, and the death penalty was reintroduced at the end of July. Apparently Kerensky, who had been prime minister since July and was under constant pressure from allied ambassadors, was now seriously considering establishing a kind of dictatorship in this emergency situation, and in this his wishes apparently coincided with those of the commander-in-chief, Cossack General Lavr Kornilov. But Kerensky wanted to be dictator himself, and among the officers an abundance of distrust had accumulated against him. Thus, a few accidental and yet obvious misunderstandings resulted in September in the so-called *Kornilov coup*, which Kerensky, in order to keep himself in power, qualified as an anti-government enterprise and thus as high treason. Immediately all the left-wing parties united against the attempt at *revolution*, and the Bolsheviks took the leading role, circulating such effective slogans as the following: "A triumph of Kornilov would be the downfall of freedom, the loss of the country, the victory and omnipotence of the landowner over the

peasant, of the capitalist over the worker, of the general over the soldier." They threw a whole army of agitators at the onrushing troops of the commander-in-chief to convince them that if they obeyed the orders of their officers they would act against their own interests, demand war, and pave the way for a restoration of tsarism. In fact, not only on the roads to Petrograd, but in many parts of the country, the troops succumbed to the persuasive power of arguments that articulated only their own and still half-hidden desires and fears. None of the officers concerned would ever be able to forget how his soldiers slipped away from him, not under the fire of the grenadiers, but in the storm of words, and everyone would understand by Bolshevism, first and foremost, the activation of the loss of authority to which he had been exposed since the beginning of the revolution. Now there was no stopping it. The front broke up more and more; not only countless individuals, as before, but entire *units* deserted. The talk of the imminent distribution of the land of the landowners seized the minds of the peasant-soldiers with irresistible force. The influence of the Mensheviks declined rapidly, and among the Social Revolutionaries the left wing became ever stronger. More and more the conviction spread among the masses that the capitalists and the *cadets* were to blame for the fact that the war had not yet come to an end, and the reintroduction of the death penalty was now seen, in a paroxysm of fear and hatred, as one of the proofs of the government's intention "to exterminate the soldiers, workers and peasants."

Now the third great paradox of the March People's Revolution and its consequences became manifest. The second All-Russian Congress of Soviets had to be held at the beginning of November, and the elections resulted in overwhelming majorities for the socialist parties. It was generally expected that the congress would dismiss the Kerensky government and immediately initiate elections to the constituent assembly, but then an appeal for peace would be made with full authority to the people of the world and the distribution of the land of the landlords could be started in an orderly manner. At this very moment, when the victory of his program seemed inevitable, Lenin demanded from the central bodies of his party a decision on armed insurrection and thus on the seizure of power by the party before the meeting of the Soviet Congress, with ever greater insistence, even declaring that a drawdown would be fatal. At a meeting of the Central Committee, which he attended in disguise - an assembly of twelve men - he pushed through this decision on October 23, even though his closest associates Zinoviev and Kamenev saw in it an obstruction and also made their misgivings public. Once again, a coincidence came to his rescue. The government announced that it would send the main part of the Petrograd garrison to the front. Thus it broke its solemn promise, and once again a large-scale agitation was able to declare the revolution in danger. The Central Executive Committee of the Soviet constituted a "military-revolutionary committee," which, taking advantage of and ostensibly defending the "Soviet legality" under

the leadership of Trotsky, but without the participation of the Social Revolutionaries and Mensheviks, prepared with great energy the armed uprising against the government. It quickly became apparent that, while most of the garrison declared itself merely neutral, the government had virtually no reliable units. Symptomatically, the Winter Palace, the seat of government, was defended mainly by a battalion of women. Hardly any revolution was less like a people's revolution, with large crowds of people engaged in a fierce struggle against the encroachments of a domineering government: Nevsky Prospekt was bustling with traffic, the streetcars were running, and the theaters were packed. But individual units and detachments of the *Red Guard*, the party army of the Bolsheviks, occupied the Peter and Paul Fortress and the bridges, and the cruiser Aurora fired a few rounds that caused no significant damage, the government troops in the Winter Palace withdrew mostly without incident, leaving their place to the slowly infiltrating insurgents, who arrested the provisional government, including the socialist ministers, albeit without Kerensky, who had escaped in time. When the Second Soviet Congress opened, posters announcing the fall of the Provisional Government could already be read, and delegates were greeted with the announcement that a new Provisional Government had been formed from members of the Bolshevik Party under Lenin's chairmanship. The delegates of the Social Revolutionaries and the Mensheviks protested most vehemently against the *criminal seizure of power* by a party which was presenting the Congress with a *fait accompli*, and they left the hall, while Trotsky sneeringly shouted after them that they belonged on the garbage heap of world opinion. Thus, the *October Revolution* was, in fact, first and foremost the coup of a socialist party against the other socialist parties and, not least, against the intentions of the Soviet Congress, which would undoubtedly have responded to the overwhelming mass desire and formed a Soviet government from the socialist parties to the exclusion of the bourgeois. Lenin's motive could only have been the conviction that the advance of anarchy and dissolution, which had begun in March, would become unstoppable if he were bound in a cabinet to Julius Martov and Viktor Chernov, and that only a dictatorship of his party could now do what was necessary, namely save Russia and set the world revolution in motion. Nothing was really new compared to March and summer: not the red flags, not the speeches about peace and land distribution, not the impassioned appeal to the people of the whole world; but what was new was the firm will of the Council of People's Commissars and its chairman, and in this respect the proclamations and decrees about land and peace, which were adopted by the Congress in the early morning of November 8 with great enthusiasm, were also new.

And yet the events of November 6 and 7 did not represent a mere hand coup by the Bolsheviks against their socialist allies, and certainly not a clearly recognizable counterrevolution. Apparently, the People's Commissars were recognized throughout Russia

by countless people and especially by the front-line soldiers as credible representatives of the demands already raised in March, and within a few days and weeks they had asserted themselves in the most important parts of the Russian Empire. John Reed recounts how, at the close of the Second Congress of Soviets, the Internationale was sung in rapt credulity by all the participants, and how a young soldier beside him kept bursting out the words under trances, "The war is over, the war is over." An old worker, in turn, whom he met on the outskirts of Petrograd, after the troops gathered by Kerensky had dissolved before the force of the agitation just as those of Kornilov had done before, turned to the city with a beatified face, spread his arms and said: "My Petrograd, it is all mine now." This urge to take possession of what had hitherto been withheld from them - self-respect, participation, education - took the most diverse forms, and even if Lenin had wanted it, he could hardly have prevented that soon the workers, too, placed the factories under their control, and that there was more and more talk of *socialism*, which had to be brought about by the nationalization of industry and which would soon spread victoriously over the whole world. The idea quickly spread that in this revolution the great uprising of all slaves against all masters was taking place and that it would spread to all countries of the world; but whoever stood in the way of the liberation of the workers and peasants to peace was an enemy of humanity and guilty of death.

If the great revolution, which was to lead to world peace and the liberation of the masses, was not to consist in the free election of a Constituent Assembly, in the cooperation of all progressive or socialist parties, in a regulated reorganization of land relations and in the opening of a period of free economic development, but if it was to be identical with the seizure of power on November 6 and 7, then it had to suppress the bourgeois press and the *hostile* press in general, and then it had to fight all other parties ruthlessly. Conversely, the other parties had to see in the Bolsheviks the party of civil war, which, through its program of action, declared war on the other political and social forces. In this sense, in the first days after the overthrow, the representatives of all parties, from the Cadets to the Social Revolutionaries, expressed themselves: The Petrograd City Duma deplored the "civil war started by the Bolsheviks," the right-wing Social Revolutionaries declared that the Bolsheviks were doing everything in their power to bring about a bloody civil war, and the left-wing Social Revolutionaries, a mere 10 days after the overthrow, turned against "the treacherous system of terror," which had come to light with the banning of numerous newspapers and was bound to lead to civil war. But strong opposition also arose within the Bolshevik Party, and a number of People's Commissars and members of the Central Committee, including Zinoviev, Kamenev, Rykov, Ryazanov, and Nogin, resigned from their posts on the grounds that a purely Bolshevik government could hold on to power only by

means of political terror. For Lenin, the situation was just the opposite: since those classes and parties opposed the Bolsheviks, they were already judged by history, and the sentence had to be carried out. Thus, in the uprising of the officers' school, which was merely a continuation of the resistance of November 7, it was crushed with extraordinary brutality in the very first days, with Trotsky establishing the principle that five of the captured Junkers had to be shot for each fallen Bolshevik. Even Lenin's wife Krupskaya, who was certainly far from bloodthirsty, in her memoirs as late as 1934, without any disapproval of the event, reproduced the exclamation of a neighbor: "They bayoneted a Junker like a beetle." It did not take the creation of the Cheka, the "Extraordinary Commission for Combating Counterrevolution and Sabotage," to set the terror in motion; it was, after all, little more than the Council of People's Commissars' benevolent approval and demand of mass anger against the Bourgeoisie and their parties. The elections to the Constituent Assembly, which took place soon after the seizure of power, showed that not only the right-wing social revolutionaries had won a considerable majority, but also that the cadet party had won a surprisingly large share of the vote, which could not have come only from rich bourgeois. On December 11, the members of the National Assembly, who had arrived in Petrograd by then, moved to their meeting place, the Tauride Palace, accompanied by a huge crowd, which, according to some reports, numbered no less than 200,000 people, and the guards did not dare to deny them entry. The opening ceremony could not take place because the number of deputies was too small, but Lenin apparently saw a serious threat in the event and had the Cadet Party considered hostile to the people because it was involved in conspiracies and supported the insurgent Cossacks. A number of cadets were arrested, including the highly respected former ministers Shingarev and Kokoshkin. A few weeks later, the two were murdered in the prison hospital by infiltrating sailors, and the government declared that the perpetrators were anarchists who would be punished as soon as they were caught. But the end of the Constituent Assembly was not due to anarchy and popular anger, but was brought about by a government decision on January 21, after the deputies had met for a single day under the threatening guns of the guards and elected the leader of the right-wing Social Revolutionaries, Viktor Chernov, as president.

A little later, the Council of People's Commissars canceled all external and internal debts, thus dealing a very significant blow to the Allied powers, but at the same time completely ruining the Russian bourgeoisie by ordering it to pay wages and at the same time blocking its accounts. Nothing was less surprising than the fact that resistance began to make itself felt in many places and that, in particular, the tendencies toward secession or at least autonomy strengthened in many peripheral areas, such as the Don region, Ukraine, the Caucasus and the eastern provinces. These tendencies, however, were encouraged by the Bolsheviks

themselves, and Lenin spoke of Russia's readiness to renounce its great power status, since the tsars had created and maintained the giant empire only through conquest and oppression. However, wherever there were efforts to break away, there were also Bolshevik partisans, and in the case of the Don Cossacks, the Bolsheviks early on asserted themselves on their own against the government of Hetman Kaledin. A new period of turmoil had begun, and Russia would not have been spared the disintegration of the empire into its constituent parts even if the Constituent Assembly had prevailed and if the party of *total power* had not been able to maintain its position.

It quickly became apparent that the party of the civil war was also the party of the separatist peace. As early as November 22, Lenin called on the soldiers and sailors to independently negotiate armistice with the enemy, and in this proclamation were the following sentences: "Soldiers, the cause of peace is in your hands. Do not allow counterrevolutionary generals to trample on the great cause of peace. Surround them with guards to prevent lynch law, which is not worthy of a revolutionary army, and do not deprive them of the sentence that will be passed upon them." A few days later, a group of soldiers interpreted the hint quite incorrectly and barbarically killed the commander-in-chief, General Duchonin, in spite of the presence of his successor, the bannerman Krylenko. The government's subsequent decrees on the "democratization of the army" even made one of the very few generals who had sided with Soviet power, Michael Bonch-Bruyevich, realize to his horror that the government was deliberately destroying the last remnants of the old army still facing the enemy. How could the Germans now doubt that they had won a complete victory in the Eastern theater of war? They formally accepted the Soviet government's proposal to participate in a general peace conference, but after the Allies rejected it, mere negotiations for a separate peace took place in Brest-Litovsk. When the Soviet delegates, headed by Abram Joffe and the new Foreign Minister Trotsky, appealed urgently to "the German proletariat," they were obviously filled with hopes for an early revolution in Germany, but they also used these hopes as a justification for action that would bring about a "treacherous peace of servitude. Lenin obtained the approval of the highest bodies only with the greatest difficulty, arguing that no sacrifice was too great to preserve the only socialist state on earth until the imminent outbreak of revolution in Germany and throughout the West, but he had himself given the authority on the 7th Party Day to tear up all peace treaties and declare war on the whole world when the appropriate time came.

Only now Lenin's government got into a really dangerous situation. It was severely criticized by the Left faction of its own party, the Left Social Revolutionaries, who had finally entered the government, were now preparing an uprising, former officers were conspiring,

counter-governments were forming in various parts of the country. The decisive factor, however, was the undiminished hostility of the Allies, who saw the Brest-Litovsk peace treaty as a breach of international treaties and supported with large sums of money any opposition that they thought would lead Russia back to war against Duchy. Due to the influence of the Allies, but also to hasty disarmament orders of Trotsky, who had been appointed war commissar and was building up a "Red Army", the uprising of the Czechoslovaks, former Austrian prisoners of war, who tried to get to the front in France via Vladivostok and who now seized almost all of Siberia within a short time.

Lenin saw in all this the *World Bourgeoisie* at work, and he was determined not only to destroy the Russian bourgeoisie, the main *tangible enemy*, as a class, but also to follow it up with the physical extermination of numerous individuals. The fundamental disenfranchisement, indeed the practical expulsion from the community of staatsburgers, received constitutional status as early as July 1918. At the same time, the resistance of this already hard-hit and miserable burghers, and even that of their militant elite, the former tsarist officers, was conspicuous. Claude Anet tells the story of a general who had to accompany the armistice delegation to brest-litovsk and who committed suicide out of despair over the preparations for the separate peace, but who did not think of turning the gun on the leaders of the delegation. In July 1918, during the uprising of the leftist social revolutionaries, when the fate of the government was hanging by a thread and only a few regiments of Latvian soldiers were still providing protection, there were at least 20,000 former officers in Moscow, but they were apparently so worn down by living conditions that they did not retreat. The influx into the *volunteer armies* of General Denikin in the south and Admiral Kolchak in the east fell short of expectations, and the few intervention troops sent by the Allies to Arkhangelsk and other places were essentially limited to securing previously supplied war material. But if the actual war and civil war operations remained relatively small in scope at first, the danger was great, and the Bolshevik government displayed the utmost determination, making its opponents wonder whether it was the will to win of credible ideologues or the desperation of brutal power hungry men in a hopeless situation.

When in July the Czech legions advanced from Siberia to Ekaterinburg, where the tsar and his family were imprisoned, the Uralsoviet had Nicholas II executed, and with him were shot his wife, son, daughter, personal physician, cook, servants and chambermaids; but the government in Moscow expressly approved the deed, although it tried to keep the murder of the tsarina and the children secret for a while. There had never been such an act in European history; the executions of Charles I and Louis XVI could not be compared, because the English king had fought at gunpoint against Cromwell's Puritans and the Frenchman had

actually colluded with foreign countries; moreover, trials had been held, and only the French *Terreur* offered a distant analogy to the destruction of families. Calls for "mass terror against the bourgeoisie" piled up, but it was the social revolutionaries Leonid Kannegiesser and Fannija Kaplan who carried out assassinations against Cheka chief Uritzki in Petrograd and against Lenin in Moscow on August 30. Uritzki was killed and Lenin only relatively lightly wounded, but immediately many hundreds of captured officials and bourgeois in both capitals and countless others in the rest of the country were shot, because anyone who resisted had to be a mere agent of the bourgeoisie, the real enemy. The decree on "red terror" of September 5 was the final stage in a class annihilation for which there was no precedent in European history, any more than for the murder of the tsar's family, and it is not surprising that the word "asiatic" kept coming to the lips of observers. The decree stipulated "that it is essential to strengthen the Soviet Republic against its class enemies by means of their isolation in concentration camps and that all persons in contact with the organizations, conspiracies and mutinies of the White Guards must be shot..." A few days earlier it had been announced that all counterrevolutionaries and all inspirers of counterrevolutionaries would be held responsible. The definition was thus so vague that anyone could be shot by the Cheka without trial, and it was not even a genuine innovation, since since the beginning of the year the guards who supervised the bourgeois conscripted into forced labor had been ordered to use the gun in case of resistance or even opposition.

So it would not be correct to say that the Bolshevik regime was harassed by its opponents and engaged in a civil war, and in its defense showed great harshness and sometimes terrible cruelty. On the contrary, from the very beginning the regime was an active force which, based on a momentary mass mood, declared war on all its political opponents and on all social forces that were not among the *poor* or *bondsmen*, and declared annihilation. And it quickly became clear that even workers were not exempt from the war and annihilation if they did not submit to the party dictatorship. The day after the dissolution of the Constituent Assembly, when a protest meeting was formed, the Red Guard fired into the crowd, leaving about twenty dead in the streets. The official report claimed that they were *petty bourgeois*. But when an independent workers' movement developed in the following months, one could read in its illegal publications sentences like the following: "The worker standing at the gate replied (to the commissar) by pulling out his revolver and shooting the worker." Another worker's early report on his stay in the Cheka's Taganka prison concludes with the sentence that such "graveyards of the living" were spread all over Russia, where people were shot day after day under the threat of truck engines.

The most moving testimony to the survival and then the eventual death of the impulses of

"humanitarian socialism" are the "Untimely Masses of Thoughts on Culture and Revolution" published by Maxim Gorky in his newspaper *Novaya Zhizny* in 1917 and 1918. As early as November 20, 1917, he notes that Lenin, Trotsky, and their dangers were infected "by the rotten poison of power"; a few days later, he complains that "insane dogmatists" regarded the people as material for social experimentation, and that Lenin was not by chance a Russian nobleman who had a "decidedly uncompassionate attitude toward the life of the masses"; the "elimination of the cadet party 'was' an attack against the most cultured people of our country." In January 1918, he pointed out the ominous consequences of the unrelenting attacks against "the bourgeoisie": already, in the factories, the unskilled workers had claimed that the locksmiths and foundrymen were "bourgeois," and in *Pravda*, madmen were agitating: "Beat the bourgeoisie to death. Beat the Caledin-Cossacks to death." In all this, Gorki sees the deplorable consequences of old traditions in Russia, which is still shaped by "asiatic" notions of the insignificance of individuals, where the "mass extermination of dissidents" was a tried and tested method and where today a sailor is allowed to say that if the welfare of the Russian people is at stake, one can go ahead and kill a million people. Only from "the most sinful people on earth" could have arisen the arithmetic of madness that declares "for each of us, a hundred heads of the bourgeoisie fall."

Gorky finally sided with the Bolsheviks after his newspaper was banned, and the observation that the Bolsheviks' fiercest enemies increasingly declared *the Jews* to be the sole culprits instead of the bourgeoisie seems to have been decisive in this. Among the few representatives of the foreign press who were in Petrograd and Moscow, the path went rather the other way around, from initial sympathy to sheer horror. Thus, Alfons Paquet, the reporter for the *Frankfurter Zeitung*, who was later removed from the Prussian academy of poetry by the national socialists for cultural Bolshevik tendencies, wrote in August 1918 that the terror was shaking Moscow like a fever and that the moment had come "to call upon mankind to protest against the savagery now going on in all the cities of Russia: the systematic destruction of an entire class of society, the destruction of countless human lives linked by a thousand threads of education and profession to the rest of the peoples of the earth." The correspondent of the *Berliner Tageblatt*, Hans Vorst, saw in the mass terror a staging by the party that wanted to "stir up the political passions of the tired working class anew. Reports like these were widely circulated in Germany, but also in the Allied countries, despite the difficulties of news transmission; in the fall of 1918, every newspaper reader in Europe knew in great detail that something qualitatively new was happening in Russia, something unprecedented in Europe. On September 3, 1918, the *Vorwärts* wrote: "To hold a class responsible for the acts of individuals with such severity is a novelty in criminal law and could probably serve as a justification for holding the working class responsible for the acts of a fanatic in another

social stratification, as has often been done in a milder form.”

And yet even Louis de Robien, who was already considering the idea of a common defensive front of all European states against the destruction of civilization in the east, confessed that he could not suppress a strange sympathy for Lenin and Trotsky, and countless soldiers and workers in Germany and France found it plausible when the Bolsheviks declared the war to be a "millionfold class murder" committed by the bourgeoisie against the *mass of the population*, and they drew hope from phrases like “win Russia and then the world.” If the Bolsheviks were power hungry, it was mainly because they were ideologues who believed they had a remedy for the world mired in the morass of state slavery: the unification of all *slaves* against all *masters*, to whom the sole blame for the sufferings endured by many millions of people in all countries could be attributed. In an almost classic way, Cheka-Magazine expressed the new ethos by writing: "Our humanitarianism is absolute; it is based on the ideals of the destruction of all coercion and all printing. For the first time in the world we raise the sword...in the name of universal freedom and liberation from slavery."

In this context there is also a statement, which at first sounds unbelievable in its monstrosity, namely those sentences which Gregory Zinoviev formulated on September 17, 1918 in a party meeting in Petrograd: "Of the hundred million of the population in Soviet Russia we must win ninety for ourselves. We have nothing to say to the rest, we must exterminate them."

In 1917 in Russia, as later in 1933 in Germany, it was a matter of a party seizing and asserting power, a party revolution, as one might say. But in Russia, all the events were more elementary and monumental. The Bolsheviks' repeatedly proclaimed goal was eternal peace in a world that would have neither states nor classes, because only under this condition would lasting peace be possible at all; the National Socialists' openly announced goal was the liberation of Germany from the shackles of the Treaty of Versailles and, internally, the harmony of a *national community*. The Bolsheviks seized power in a moment of defeat amidst threatened dissolution of the state; the National Socialists followed the former government in an almost entirely legal manner, and despite the world economic crisis, a modern and diverse social life took place in many aspects in Germany. In Russia, a genuine civil war emerged; in Germany, opponents of the ruling party were completely crushed with a few hard blows, and the death toll among non-combatants was far lower. Nevertheless, Hitler met with far less sympathy and understanding abroad than Lenin, and it is to be assumed that not only the old fear of most Europeans of Deutschland played a part in this, but not least anti-Semitism, which was not based on any directly social principle and appeared particularly repugnant and medieval against the background of the broad normality

of life. However, the mere parallelizing comparison is not enough, but the main difference is that in the Germany of 1933 the Russia of 1917 was known and perceived only as a horror image, while the Bolsheviks in 1917 had the German Reich of Wilhelm II and Ludendorff as a helper and enemy in their own country.

The situation changed fundamentally when in November 1918 Germany asked the Western Allies for an armistice and had to withdraw its troops from the depths of the Russian territory, which it had occupied beyond Rostov and Kharkov. It could now seem that a larger, older and more respected force was coming to the forefront of the struggle for peace and socialism, namely the mass of Germany's industrial workers who had gathered before the war in the Social Democratic Party of Germany. Lenin was apparently convinced that the Bolsheviks had only asserted themselves for a moment and that hegemony would soon return to the German workers' movement, which had been the great model for him until the outbreak of the war. In fact, the Bolsheviks in Russia had not been able to assert themselves at all until the February Revolution, and afterwards their own actions had seemed necessary but also irregular. What kind of a phenomenon they actually were can be seen better in the party which was the first in the center of Europe to profess Marxism, which Hitler opposed with his anti-Marxism.

Chapter II, Section 2

The Emergence of the Communist Party of Germany from the World War and the Russian Revolution

Marxism did not create the *workers' movement*, but in a certain way it was itself a product of English Chartism. But it meant the most important advanced formation, even where it merely adopted certain lines of thought: it gave the words *worker* and *working class* a weight that made one forget the close genetic connection with the ideas and ways of thinking of journeyman craftsmen; it opposed *the workers* to *capital* in the harshest manner and declared the conflicts between *labor* and *capital* to be the main antagonism of the epoch; it saw the workers grow to an “immense majority” who would one day soon —simultaneously in all advanced countries of Western and Central Europe—eliminate the few remaining “capital magnates” as such and make them their “paid servants.” In doing so it placed itself completely in the objective movement which, from the beginning of the Industrial Revolution, had created a new class of people out of peasants, journeymen artisans, and poor people of all kinds, the workers of great industry; which had first transformed the face of England and in the second half of the 19th century spread more and more to the rest of Europe. When, toward the end of the eighties, it became clear that Marxism had prevailed against its competitors in the most important countries of continental Europe—against the anarchism of Bakunin and the syndicalism of Proudhon, against the reformism of the French Possibilists, against the state socialism of Lassalle, against the insurrection theory of Blanqui—, it could rightly be regarded as a phenomenon of world history, even though it was nowhere involved in a government: if there was a unified workers' party, it had to determine the future more than any other party, because throughout Europe the tendency towards universal suffrage seemed irresistible after the French had stepped into the tracks of the Americans in a peculiar way, and the German Empire had followed Bismarck's example. As soon as universal suffrage had been established and maintained everywhere, according to widespread opinion, the workers' parties had to win a majority or at least play a decisive role

in all European countries.

All workers' parties, including the non-Marxist ones, saw themselves as parties of peace that opposed the operations of imperialism which endangered peace, such as the conquest of colonial areas or the rape of small states and, in general, the power politics of the great powers. Here, too, they were as little isolated as they were in their conviction of the future political role of the workers: that the increasing importance of trade and industry would more and more displace the traditional *feudal classes* with their warlike inclinations was an old doctrine of liberalism, and to everyone's surprise, the Russian tsar gave the first impetus to convene those peace conferences in the Dutch Hague, which should pave the way to a limitation of the sovereignty of the states and thus to the safeguarding of world peace. But Marxism in particular was not content with being merely an important partial phenomenon within the world change, which led from the agrarian to the industrial situation, which gave the hitherto silent or powerless masses a say in all affairs, which restricted the sovereignty of states and one day that would make a great war technically impossible, but it believed that one day the workers would have *all the power* in their hands everywhere and would use it precisely to abolish forever the power of men over men, as well as exploitation, misery, national enmities, states, classes, professionalization of activities, bureaucracy, and in general, all separations of man from man. Hopes of this kind, however, were in no way characteristically modern— like the orientation towards large-scale industry or the anticipation of a fundamental change in the relationship between states— but they were ancient, in some ways as old as humanity itself, and they ultimately ran towards the idea of a primordial state which the social philosophers of the 17th and 18th centuries had called the “natural society” (*societas naturalis*) as opposed to “bourgeois society” (*societas civilis*) and had almost always regarded it — with great exceptions, such as the young Rousseau—as an irretrievable starting point. But it was only the turning to an original state that opposed the alienation and estrangement of modern life and that could be regained *at a higher level* (original communism) that made Marxism a faith, an ideology that radially rejected the whole present of *capitalism* and envisaged a completely different of a future that would be *socialist* for all of humanity. Marxism thus constituted the great party of protest and hope which inevitably had to form wherever the upheavals of the Industrial Revolution destroyed traditional ways of life and forced large masses of people into unfamiliar conditions—insofar as these experiences were able to articulate themselves and gain free opportunities for action.

But Marx and Engels were by no means lacking a sense of how closely this protest and this hope were often connected with reactionary or primitivist ideas—for example, as in Bakunin, and therefore they wanted to make it the unmistakable main characteristic of their doctrine,

that socialism, as the dissolution of all dissonances in definitive harmony, presupposed precisely the sharpest formation of the divisions and conflicts that have hitherto been characterized the modern world, and that socialism can therefore only follow a fully developed capitalism that is incapable of further development. Thus, on the one hand, Marxism was the basis of the party of protest and hope, of the industrial age, which was based on an ancient dream of mankind, and, on the other hand, it justified the convictions of a rising class of skilled workers who demanded the right of participation in a new civilization, but hardly seriously envisaged their autocratic sole rule as a preliminary stage to global rulelessness. Many contemporary observers, Max Weber among them, perceived this class and this character, and not infrequently they spoke disdainfully of *philistines* who made themselves felt in the labor movement. But these philistines had their own masterminds who were called *revisionists* by their orthodox opponents and who were often accused of having a bourgeois way of thinking. The revisionists, for their part, invoked time as the most powerful enforcer of revisions: contrary to what Marx assumed, the number of *citizens*, i.e., of those who were not engaged in direct production and who devoted themselves to manifold kind of mediation were not diminishing in number, but were growing to an astonishing rate; the opposition between capitalists and workers is not rigid and merely negative, for there is a labor of capital (i.e. the entrepreneurs) as in capital of (qualified and indispensable) labor, and only this contrast makes genuine trade unions and the participation of workers in determining the rate of investment of the national economy possible; the postulated homogeneity of the proletariat does not even exist in the industrialized countries themselves and certainly not in the world; the fate of each worker is closely related to the fate of his state; capitalism is by no means on the verge of collapse, but still has a great future ahead of it, in which, however, it will transform itself more and more in the direction of the welfare state and only come to socialism after a long period of transition.

Certainly the revisionists, Bernstein, Schippel, Vollmar and others, were *ideologists*, i.e. people who tried to make the incomprehensible whole of historical development comprehensible through selection and combination, but they nevertheless detached the workers' movement from the utopian and actually ideological impulse, which includes a socio-religious belief in sudden redemption and final salvation and they declared that doctrine of evolution to be the core of Marxism, which, in truth, was merely one of its components.

The final triumph of revisionism seemed to be demonstrated by the behavior of the workers in all countries when the war broke out. In Germany in particular the workers, like all other citizens, answered the call to the flag with a unanimity, indeed with an enthusiasm, that

showed how little they regarded the *world proletariat* as their real fatherland and how well they were aware that the conditions in Germany, despite *feudalism* and perhaps even because of it, were better for them than the conditions in the far more unfettered capitalism of England, or in the absolutist tsarist monarchy. If the parliamentary group of the Social Democratic Party had refused to approve the war credits on August 4, 1914, it would, in all probability, have been swept away by the indignation of party members, and soon some of the once most radical representatives of the left wing of the party turned themselves into champions of a will to war which very emphatically linked to certain but little-known ideas of Marx and interpreted the class struggle as *a class struggle of nations* in which the primacy of English capitalism, having become obsolete, would be fought down by Germany as the more modern and stronger industrial power. Thus, in the world revolution of war, a system of world states would be formed, in which Germany would rise to the natural center of non-Russian and non-English Europe, and was already through the mere self-assertion, which does not require political conquest and could therefore be accepted by the other peoples of Central Europe as a protection as a starting point for federal unions. In the opinion of men like Paul Lensch, however, this development presupposed that the Social Democratic Party would not merely half-heartedly abandon its previous oppositional stance and see itself as a leading force of present and future Germany, without, of course raising the unrealistic claim to sole rule; it was also dependent on the previous opponents, especially the East Elbe Junkers, coming to terms with the diminution of their position and not making territorial demands for national-egoistic reasons that would make Germany hated by its neighbors. Another precondition for the success of this concept was that an overpowering coalition would not be formed against Germany, the firmest cement of which would have to be resistance to German *claims to world power*, which, in their ostentatious grandiloquence, would be as dangerous as they would be superfluous, since an undefeated Germany as a state of the "great central people of Europe" would be one of the world powers anyway. Whether this concept of defensively winning German supremacy in Europe and a no-longer-Marxist further development of Social Democracy had any prospect of realization, therefore, had to depend on its opponents, the opponents on the pan-German right and the opponents on the *ideological* wing of the Social Democrats.

On the evening of August 4th, all hopes of this wing of the party seemed to be shattered, and it was only a small group of deputies who met in Rosa Luxemburg's apartment to discuss the situation. Basically, Karl Liebknecht, Rosa Luxemburg, Franz Mehring, and at that time, Paul Lensch, could not hide the fact that the masses themselves had betrayed the world mission to which they ascribed to them and that the real struggle had to be waged against the *nationalist ideology* which (as it was said in an early leaflet by the Spartacus group) had

changed people “deep into our ranks” in a frightening way, in such a way that they had completely forgotten the feeling of brotherhood towards their class-comrades from other nations and saw only the Russian or French or English enemy. Nevertheless, the small group never refrained from attacking the members of the executive committee and the Reichstag faction of the Social Democratic Party in the harshest and extremely personal terms such as traitors, who had separated themselves from the old faith of all Socialists and sullied the purity of the doctrine. In this respect, the opposition of those who soon published the first and only number of the journal *Die Internationale* and then the *Spartacus Letters* was nothing more than the opposition of the traditionalists in the Social Democratic Party, who were not shaken in their old belief by the new and disconcerting events. Thus, something strongly defensive can be seen in the great pathos with which Karl Liebknecht justified his refusal to approve new war credits or, after his arrest in May 1916, commented on the accusations of having committed treason as follows: “*Treason* is complete nonsense for the international Socialist...To break all imperialist powers at once in international interaction with the socialists of other countries is the quintessence of his endeavors.” But the longer the war lasted, the more this old and initially largely defensive pathos had to be heard among the people whose fathers, brothers and sons were filling the mass graves on the battlefields in even greater numbers, and who themselves were suffering bitter hunger while they had long and hard labor to do in the war industries or in the countryside. And so the leaflets which the “Gruppe Internationale” illegally printed were read more and more, and the authorities were seriously alarmed. How could it not have made a great impression when, at the end of 1915, No. 11 of the *Political Letters* said: “The world is spewing blood. The number of dead killed by the strangle-war in the east and west has already risen to more than a million, that of the wounded to three times that number...that war spares the peaceful citizen has become a laughable phrase on sea as well as on land, international law has shattered into a thousand pieces under war’s rough fist, and from the broth of blood and ashes the cloud of hatred rises ever thicker, which clouds the conscience of humanity rising to socialist solidarity.”

Rosa Luxemburg and Karl Liebknecht therefore regarded the war as the “greatest of all crimes” and not as a *link in God's world-order*, as their opponents on the Right did, but also not as an unavoidable phase in the mighty class struggle of nations that would bring about a new and lasting world condition of large states and associations of states. From the perspective of the second half of the 20th century, they were undoubtedly right insofar as the technical means with which this war was waged had already tended to reach the quality that would make the self-destruction of humanity possible within a few decades, and, in any case, had already led to the threshold of intolerable losses and the annihilation of what was called European culture, especially when one considers that this war, an early end which did no

serious injustice to any nation or large group, was bound to generate so much continuing hatred that, in the opinion of observers from all camps, it would lead to further wars. The Spartacus League and those internationalist socialists who gathered in the Swiss villages of Zimmerwald and Kienthal in 1915 and 1916 were thus on a firm foundation of future and partially current law. Their right was only partial, because the complete rejection of the war also included the negation of personal bravery and the willingness to protect women and children, which were still possible in this two-sided war, and because opposition to the war could also arise from sheer cowardice. Of course, they shared their right with pacifists of all shades, and their prevailing view can be summarized as follows: the real crime is the adherence of all those involved to the idea of unlimited sovereignty of states, because this inevitably results in larger conflicts only be decided by war. It is therefore essential that, after the end of the world war, this unconditional sovereignty of individual states should be renounced and a League of Nations should be established, whose primary task must be to secure peace. The introduction of universal suffrage in all important countries will create the guarantee that any belligerence on the part of the military or individual factions of the ruling classes will not prevail, because the overwhelming majority of the people everywhere has become peace-loving at the latest as a result of this war and it will not permit the inevitable conflicts to be resolved by military means.

But for the Spartacus League and the two other international socialists, the right to oppose the war was intimately bound up with a certain interpretation of current events, which could be derived from Marx's "Capital" with great difficulty at best. In a leaflet distributed on May 1, 1916, it was said: "For the second time the day of May 1 rises above the sea of blood of mass slaughter...And for whose benefit and piety, for what purpose all these horrors and bestialities? So that the East Elbian Junkers and the capitalist profiteers associated with them can fill their pockets by subjugating and exploiting new countries. So that the agitators from heavy industry, the army suppliers from the bloody fields of corpses drag golden harvests into their barns. So that stock market jobbers do usurious business with war bonds. So that food speculators fatten themselves at the expense of the starving people..." in short "Millions of men have already given their lives at the behest of the bourgeoisie."

These statements apparently apply to all countries. In them war does not appear as a crime because it is opposed to the objectively already possible, indeed necessary, world peace, but rather it presents itself as the crime of concrete criminals who are guided by selfish purposes. This *gang of criminals* is essentially the *bourgeoisie*, even if the term is only used in other leaflets to refer to the alleged *instigators* in Germany and Austria-Hungary.

Here it is necessary to pause for a moment. No doubt there were war profiteers, food pushers, stock market speculators, *sharks* (as they said in Italy) everywhere, and they were extremely hateful to ordinary people everywhere. In some cases, these phenomena were unavoidable, since the economic freedom of movement of individuals and companies, as well as the reward for special achievements, were as little completely eliminated even in the German war economy as the price system as indicators of scarcity. But it was a very bold, indeed untenable, thesis that this very narrow class had instigated the war in order to satisfy their greed. If one spoke of the bourgeoisie, one found oneself, of course, on the familiar terrain of Marx's *main antagonism* between the bourgeoisie and the proletariat, between capital and labor. But it was impossible to limit the bourgeoisie to that small class. At the very least, it included all entrepreneurs and presumably also all those who were in the service of the entrepreneurs and the capitalist state: the officer corps, the civil servants, teachers of all branches, the liberal professions. And to this bourgeoisie might even include those *labor aristocrats* who always appeared when a sociological explanation of the August 4th *betrayal* was sought. *This* bourgeoisie, certainly a minority, but in all western and central European states a comparatively very strong minority compared to the common workers and farm workers, did *not* benefit from the war. Indeed, it sent its sons out just as all the other members of the nation did; practically all reserve officers came from its ranks, and the officers' corps as a whole suffered twice as many casualties as the men. No statement could be more unjust than that this officer corps were *murdering* the men, let alone for the sake of material advantages.

Here, too, the writers of the articles and pamphlets of the Spartacus League confused the actual cause and mere accompanying circumstances, just as in the case of the *betrayal* of the Social Democratic leaders. Human *originators* and thus *criminals* took the place of the great supra-personal system characteristics, which one tried to encompass at best with the term "capitalism" and which, however, were far more correctly to be characterized by the term *unconditional sovereignty of the individual states*. But according to the traditional Marxist doctrine, the world revolution of the proletariat would not only eliminate this unconditionality, but would also eliminate the states in general and with them the classes and with them the solidified division of labor, so that the masses themselves exercise rule through the mediation by professionalized apparatuses and create a harmonious world without state and national borders, yes even without different languages.

The pacifism of the internationalist socialists thus was very different from that of the rest of the *bourgeois* pacifists: it was in unrestricted and militant universalism, and this made it possible for it to come into sharp opposition to the bourgeoisie in yet another different and

broader sense, namely to all who did not share the belief in the imminent advent of the one, peaceful, undivided and harmonious humanity, which was in fact an ancient belief and had already found a well-known expression in some books of the Bible. Thus the Spartacus League and the internationalist socialists were the party of a faith, the party of the fighters of God, as one could say using obvious analogies, or at least the fighters for justice. But from time immemorial, fighters of God have always had the will to exterminate the wicked and to wipe out the empire of injustice from the face of the earth. Thus the great right to oppose war was linked to a belief that necessarily sought, with Karl Liebknecht, to replace the castle-peace with *castle-war* or, with Lenin, to transform war into civil war. If this party persisted in not blaming the original crime of war on system characteristics or a historical phase of development, but instead hitting human originators as *criminals* with the charge of guilt and a corresponding intention annihilation, then paradoxically it would have to become a war party of a special kind if it did not succeed in asserting itself quickly and completely and everywhere.

Once again a new level was entered when the party abandoned from the universal accusation of guilt in practice and directed its fight against some particularly guilty parties. From the outset there was the great danger that not all socialists in all warring countries would fight their struggle with equal energy and with equal success, and that precisely the state which had the strongest and most active socialist party would then suffer a defeat. This was an argument which was put forward by all *defenders of the fatherland* or *social patriots* within the socialist parties and which for a long time seemed far more plausible to the masses of German workers than the stigmatization of war profiteers or the militarists or the bourgeoisie as criminals. But the longer the war lasted, the more clearly the propaganda of the Spartacus League turned primarily against the German Reich, which apparently had considerable chances of victory in the first half of 1918. In *Spartacus Letter* No. 9 of June 1918, Rosa Luxemburg, who was in prison but engaged in an intense agitational activity under the rule of *Prussian militarism*, as Trotsky did in Kerensky's prison, took up a distinction from Paul Lensch with the opposite valence: "English and French imperialism are rooted in an old colonial policy, tied to traditional trajectories; the German imperialism was in the embryonic stage until the outbreak of the world war, only grew to monstrous dimensions in the course of the war, is still growing every day and is filling itself with the bloodlust of the slaughter of millions with a world-conquering urge that has no traditions, no fetters and no considerations." But can a small layer of Junkers, war profiteers, and stock market speculators accomplish such monstrous deeds? What would they be able to do without the *field grays* who, in the opinion of the Spartacus League, were only disguised proletarians, and yet who, in the opinion of their opponents of the war, such as Louis de Robiens and

shortly afterwards Churchill, were eagerly awaited by large parts of the population in the Ukraine and Russia because they brought *order* ? Never did any Junker or bourgeois insulted the German workers with harsher words and worse metaphors than they were to be read in the 10th *Spartacus Letter* : “The German proletariat truly surpasses the most famous example of true servility: the Swiss Guard who stands in front of the palace of the last Bourbons and lets itself be cut down by storming revolutionaries...If a second Thorwaldsen should be found, who will carve the image of this poignant slave loyalty after four years of world war for the benefit and piety of distant generations in marble, he will definitely choose not a lion as a symbol, but a dog!”

But these harsh words were not only the expression of a deceived trust, which in Rosa Luxemburg’s opinion would one day be justified after all, but they also presupposed “the great Russian Revolution,” as the March Revolution had been called by the Spartacus League, and they were spoken with knowledge of the Bolsheviks’ seizure of power. They were preceded by the mutiny on the German fleet, which had so encouraged Lenin’s decisions in the autumn of 1917, the January strikes of 1918 in Berlin, the leaflets and pamphlets that had been brought to Germany via Norway and contained exhortations such as the following: “The victorious revolution will not require so much victims as a single day’s fighting out in the field of madness. Kill the war-beasts, hang your executioners, and you will be redeemed, free and happy with your brothers all over the world.” They also presupposed the news of the mass shootings by the Cheka and of the atrocities of which the Bolsheviks were guilty and Rosa Luxemburg had indeed written very critical remarks about the authoritarian dictatorship of Lenin and Trotsky. But it self-evident to her and her fellow militants that all *barbarism* and all *chaos* stemmed predominantly from the resistance of the enemy and that the Russian revolution would become *European* and *Marxist* at the moment when the revolution would finally break out in the developed capitalist countries and would free the hard-oppressed Russian comrades from their fatal isolation. That is why, after their release from prison, she and Karl Liebknecht worked together with full of determination with the so-called revolutionary stewards and with parts of the “Independent Social Democrats” that had existed since March 1917, but also with the Soviet Russian embassy in Berlin, to bring about this peaceful and world-redeeming revolution.

What happened was the German military collapse in November, and no one can determine with certainty how great, apart from the failure of the offensives of spring and summer 1918 in France, was the share of the revolutionaries on the one hand, and Ludendorff's share on the other, who wanted to shift the responsibility to the new regime of parliamentary monarchy. In any case, Karl Liebknecht and Rosa Luxemburg were convinced that the German

revolution—undoubtedly a revolution of collapse like the Russian one of March 1917—had now entered its Kerensky stage under the government of the People's Deputies as majority Social Democrats and Independents, and that it was necessary to push it forward to socialism as the ruleless rule of the working masses themselves. But if Friedrich Ebert was the German Kerensky, he, unlike his Russian counterpart, had brought about peace, and never tired of pointing out the *Russian chaos* and the *Bolshevik horrors* that would ruin Germany and deliver her to occupation by the Allies when *Spartacus* gained the upper hand. In the unrest of November and December the Spartacists were at least as much victims as perpetrators, but the fear of *Russian conditions* had a decisive effect, although it cannot be denied that some lumpenproletarian and merely militant elements had joined in and contributed to it. to increase aversion and hatred of Spartacus. It was an extremely symptomatic fact that Karl Liebknecht and Rosa Luxemburg were unable to obtain a mandate to participate in the first Reich Congress of Workers' and Soldiers' Councils, which took place in Berlin in mid-December. Nevertheless, it was a highly publicized event when the delegates of the Spartacus League met from December 30, 1918 to January 1, 1919 in the Prussian House of Representatives to found the "Communist Party of Germany (Spartacus League)."

That not just a German party was gathering here became symbolically clear when an important representative of the Bolshevik Party, Karl Radek, gave a major speech. And it was also characteristic that he explicitly described the German workers as the *older brother* of the much younger and organizationally far less experienced workers in Russia, whose appearance on the world-historical stage fills the Russian workers with deep joy. In fact, since his public protest against the war on May 1, 1916, at least until the Bolsheviks came to power, Karl Liebknecht had been a much better known name than Vladimir Ilyich Lenin among the opponents of war in all countries. So it was only consistent when Radek expressed the hope that the international workers' council would soon meet in Berlin, the body of the final victory of the anti-war party, because Bolshevism was essentially nothing other than "the tears of widows and children, the pain for those killed and the despair of those who returned." But the party by no means wanted to be merely or primarily a pacifist party, as this moving phrase of Radek might have suggested. The program that it adopted and which Rosa Luxemburg had written included a host of very far-reaching demands.

It starts from a pronounced thesis of guilt: bourgeois class rule is the real culprit of the world war in Germany as in France, in Russia as in England, in Europe as in America. It, and by no means just the feudal Junker rule in Germany, forfeited its right to exist with production of the world war. From the yawning abyss that it has created there is no salvation except socialism, and therefore the slogan of the hour must be: "Down with the wage system!" But

socialism could achieve victory only through the most tremendous civil war in the history of the world against the bitter resistance of the “imperialist capitalist class” which would use the peasants and the officers to preserve wage slavery and would even incite “backward working classes” against the socialist vanguard. The Spartacus League should therefore on no account be prepared to share government power with “stooges of the bourgeoisie, with Scheidemann-Ebert.” Therefore, the immediate demands included, among others, were: disarming the entire police force, disarming all officers and non-proletarian soldiers, forming a Red Guard, setting up a revolutionary tribunal, a six-hour maximum working day, cancellation of the state and other public debts, confiscation of all assets from a certain amount. All of this must be carried out “with an iron determination.” It was also said that the proletarian revolution did not need terror for its aims, that it hated and abhorred the murder of human beings. But that sounded very different from the similar formulations of humanitarian socialism, such as those put forward by Kurt Eisner in Bavaria, when it was seen together with the closing sentences: “Up, proletarians! To the fight! It is a matter of conquering a world and fighting against a world. In this last class struggle in world history for the highest goals of mankind. The word is to the enemy: thumb on the eye, and knee on the chest!”

With the adoption of this program, a very special kind of party had come into being indeed.

No party can undertake anything more extraordinary and serious than “a complete restructuring of the state and a complete revolution in the economic and social foundations of society,” i.e. ultimately the abolition of private ownership in the means of production, of the state and of the class structure of society. Such a program puts the entire national wealth and all state positions at the disposal of a single group, at least for a transitional period, and thus sets itself a fighting goal which is incomparably greater than that of any other party and which can nevertheless be reconciled with “the highest idealism” because it sets as its goal precisely the elimination of all individual and group interests. Formally, it was nothing else than the old, pre-revisionist program of the Social Democrats, but in the post-war situation it had become something new. It had severed the connection with that consciousness of advancement of the skilled workers and the practical reformism of the trade unions, so that the ideological-utopian stood out much more strongly. But it also differed from the Bolsheviks' program because it arose out of that *classical-Marxist* situation that simply did not exist in Russia. This party could ascribe itself the merit of the end of the war or at least the distinction of a proven opponent of war and thereby gain an approval that went far beyond the ranks of the proletarians. It could attract all those who revolted against the pressures and crises of modern life under the banner of *anti-capitalism*. It could make demands like the one after the six-hour day, which every other party had to call unreal and

demagogic. It was not only the great party of protest and hope, but the party of an ancient and for that reason alone questionable faith, the party of a great right that threatened to turn into injustice through the personalization of the causes of war, and the party of national and international civil war. Precisely for this reason it must arouse the bitter enmity of all those who owned or hoped to acquire any property, and that warned the *citizens* in a very broad sense; in particular it must have drawn the irrepressible hatred of almost all officers who could boast of having made greater blood sacrifices than any other group for the protection of their homeland, and who had all followed the news from Russia closely enough to know what the demand “thumb on eye and knee on the chest” meant for them; it must have caused at least a cautious distancing from those who did not believe that the destruction of order in an extremely complex industrial state would somehow and inevitably result in a better order. Tendentially and in a certain way, this party had almost all Germans on its side; tendentially and in other ways, it had almost all Germans against it.

Above all, however, unlike the pre-war Social Democrat Party, it was in the completely new situation of looking towards a brother party that was already running the government in a large state—the largest state in the world —although it was younger and more immature in Marxist terms and actually shouldn't have *seized* power yet. If the Communist Party of Germany was really “the older brother,” then it would soon have to win and come to the aid of Lenin's party, which was no longer against the “giants” of German militarism, but which was engaged in a severe struggle against the *white armies* and against intervention troops of the Allied and Associated Powers.

Chapter II, Section 3

The Victory of the Bolsheviks and the Defeats of the Communist Party of Germany 1919-1921

Towards the end of December 1918, the external picture in Germany was still very similar to that in Russia during the months after the February Revolution: the discipline of the army was largely dissolving, soldiers' councils had formed everywhere, the officers had lost the undisputed power of command and often had their epaulets torn off, demonstration marches moved through the streets, red flags were flying in many places, the garrison in the capital was unreliable, a workers' and soldiers' council headed by an executive council functioned alongside the government.

But unlike in Russia, there was no overwhelming desire for peace directed against the government, and the army at the front was returned home in an orderly manner under the leadership of the officers and with the cooperation of the soldiers' councils. Here and there there were clashes with soldiers' councils on the home routes, and the first complaints about an impending *counter-revolution* were heard. But nowhere were officers killed, nowhere were landowners expelled, and the administration continued to function smoothly despite all the difficulties. The headquarters under the unchanged Hindenburg-Groener army command had *grounded itself in the facts*, and consequently the officers, who always form a spearhead of *democratization* after a great war, remained a potentially significant force, provided that revolution were to be understood as something other than democracy in the sense of popular sovereignty and election of a national assembly.

Now, the *National Assembly* had been an undisputed slogan in Russia even after the October revolution. In Germany, on the other hand, it was fiercely opposed by the Spartacus League, but also by parts of the Revolutionary Stewards and the Independent Social Democratic Party. Rosa Luxemburg, in the *Rote Fahne* on November 20, called it a "surviving heirloom

of bourgeois revolutions” and a “prop from the times of petty-bourgeois illusions about the unity of the people”; in present-day Germany, however, it can and must be a matter of “socialist democracy,” which was opposed to “bourgeois democracy.” Formally, this was the well Marxist claim that the majority of the proletariat, as the majority of the people, should exercise immediate autocracy in the form of councils; but in fact it was a matter of the will of an activist minority to exercise power alone, for Rosa Luxemburg knew very well that her party, even together with the Independent Social Democratic Party, by no means comprised the majority of the German working class and certainly not the majority of the people. Therefore, the *Vorwärts* could and had to oppose her as the slogan of the majority social democracy: “Not terror, but freedom; not dictatorship, but democracy.” In fact, with its appeal to *the National Assembly*, the Ebert government represented the claim of the *empirical people* and thus the concept of *Western democracy*. The Central Council of Workers’ and Soldiers’ Councils joined it, but the most active minority continued to oppose it, attributing to the German situation a maturity that must lead beyond bourgeois or formal democracy.

But the main difference between Germany and Russia was a political one. For the Russian revolutionaries, there was no event in another country that could have been a model or a nightmare. In Germany, on the other hand, there came from the government and the press constant warnings such as the following: “Let the German workers look to Russia and be warned!”, “Then there will be Russian chaos,” Spartacus said, “the establishment of an Asiatic and reign of terror and hunger like in Russia,” a “blood dictatorship of the Spartacus League” was planned. Such twists could not have emerged from the German situation alone; but since exaggerations in the press reports had not been necessary during the last few months to convey to the German public the awareness that the Bolsheviks were in fact exercising an unprecedented regime of terror in Russia, such statements and assumptions warranted credence.

They became all the more credible because there was no doubt that the Soviet government would intervene. As early as November 11, the Council of People’s Commissars addressed the German workers with a telegram and urged them not to allow themselves to be “talked into” a national assembly, and at the same time grain shipments were promised, although everyone knew that hunger was raging in Russia. Several passages in Radek’s speech on December 30 were in the same vein: nothing evokes such enthusiasm among the Russian workers as when they are told that the time may come “when the German workers will call for your help and where you must fight with them on the Rhine, as they will fight in our place on the Urals.” But had not the longing for peace been the most powerful impulse of the

Russian revolution? If Radek was serious, the same impulse would work in Ebert's favor in Germany.

Nevertheless, during the first days of January 1919, a situation in Berlin arose in which the majority of the proletariat and thus possibly the majority of the capital's population opposed the government, which, with its call for elections to the National Assembly, represented the majority of the German people, but had little power. This was the so-called *January Uprising*.

In its early days, it was nothing more than a huge protest demonstration against the dismissal of the police chief Emil Eichhorn, who belonged to the Independent Social Democracy, which had been decreed by the now purely majority socialist government. But against Rosa Luxemburg's wishes, the decision was made in the relevant bodies to bring about the overthrow of the government, and the document was also signed by Karl Liebknecht, so that the government, for its part, could announce on January 8, with a clever restriction to the already most hated of its opponents: "Spartacus is now fighting for all power...The people shall not be allowed to speak..." Since any reliable *republican* troops were scarce, the People's Commissioner Gustav Noske, in cooperation with General von Lüttwitz, had to resort to the units of the old army and the newly formed Freikorps. The situation might be compared to that which would have arisen in Russia if Kerensky and Kornilov had worked together. In any case, the *Rote Fahne* and Rosa Luxemburg took the side of the fighters with one caveat: Friedrich Ebert was described as the "mortal enemy of the revolution," and the newspaper turned with the greatest vehemence against the "plum-soft elements" who were willing to negotiate. The reports of the fighting read very much like army reports, but they were dominated by an incomparably stronger moral pathos, based on the conviction that the workers were historically right in relation to the bourgeoisie, which must therefore resort to desperate atrocities such as shooting of parliamentarians by government troops. On January 14, Rosa Luxemburg's last editorial was published under the heading "Order Reigns in Berlin," brimming with anger and contempt for the "Berlin petty-bourgeois mob" and the "miserable defeats of Flanders and the Argonnes," ending with the expression of an unbreakable faith to the eventual triumph of the revolution: "The leadership has failed. But the masses are the decisive factor, they are the rock on which the final victory of the revolution will be built... 'Order reigns in Berlin,' you dull henchmen. Your 'order' is built on sand. Tomorrow the revolution will already 'rattle up again' and to your horror announce with the sound of trumpets: 'I was, I am, I will be!'"

One day later Karl Liebknecht and Rosa Luxemburg were dead. The fact that attempts were

made to conceal the circumstances of these deaths, and that until 1933 the opponents spoke of a *murder* by a few soldiers and officers of the Guards Cavalry Rifle Division, is convincing proof of how strong the consciousness of the rule of law still was in Germany, and how little one saw oneself in a genuine civil war, which was a continuation of the Russian one. When, a few months later, Eugen Leviné, the leading man in the Munich Soviet Republic, was sentenced to death and executed, the Independent Social Democratic Party newspaper complained that it was a socialist government of all things that had carried out the first political death sentence in Germany since 1848. The action of the hunter Otto Runge and his instigators could not be morally or legally justified, because it meant the killing of defenseless prisoners. But whoever speaks this truth is nevertheless lying if he does not add that Karl Liebknecht and Rosa Luxemburg, although wholly or partly against their original will, had led an uprising against the government, that for a year in Russia hundreds and thousands of arrested and therefore defenseless opponents, among them the 350 prisoners of the uprising of Yaroslavl had been shot by the Cheka in a trial, and that the officers, who instigated the hunter Runge to his crime, knew this. Far more appropriate than the correct and at the same time mostly untrue statements about the “murder of Karl Liebknecht and Rosa Luxemburg” are sentences that can be found in an announcement by the Communist Party of Germany from April 1921 about the alleged betrayal of Paul Levi, which reads as follows: Paul Levi stabbed his fighting comrades in the back. Karl Liebknecht and Rosa Luxemburg were completely different. They were against the uprising of January 1919, but they fought along with it and fell.

The March fighting of 1919 also took place in a very dangerous situation for the government: severe unrest and large-scale strikes shook central Germany and the Ruhr, and they were motivated not least by anger at a government that failed to advance the promised socialization. But meanwhile, after the January 19 elections, which—unlike in Russia—gained the socialist parties only about 45% of the votes, the National Assembly was constituted in Weimar. Thus, the suspicion is perhaps not unfounded that the government now wanted to finally bring the situation in Berlin under control and literally had the city conquered militarily, with a total of 1,200 people being killed, and the government troops particularly displayed the brutality that relatively small formations of troops often display in confronting large numbers of poorly armed civilians. Lieutenant Marloh, for example, had 29 sailors shot without sufficient cause. Exaggerated rumors of atrocities committed by the Spartacists in Lichtenberg had aroused the troops to great excitement, and further summary executions in turn generated indelible bitterness against the “Noskedians” (*translator: communist slur for supporters of Gustav Noske*) or “Noske-hounds” in the great mass of the population of East Berlin. However, the *Rote Fahne* was by no means merely defensive in its

appeals and proclaimed: "The revolution can only advance over the grave of that majority Social Democracy...Down with the National Assembly...Your brothers are on strike. The capitalists are faltering. The government is about to topple."

No sooner had the government in Berlin prevailed than, following the assassination of Kurt Eisner, the Munich Soviet Republic was proclaimed, which was initially ruled by libertarian socialists like Gustav Landauer and Erich Mühsam for a week, until April 14, with communists like Eugen Leviné, Max Levien and Tobias Axelrod taking their place. There were no serious bloodshed, with the exception of the shooting of several hostages in the Luitpoldgymnasium, but the anarchist *sham soviet republic* had already frightened *the bourgeoisie* when it announced on April 10 that revolutionary tribunals would be set up, the verdicts of which would be "immediately executed" with no possibility of appeal. And here the *Russian example* was overwhelming. The government of the Social Democrat Hoffmann, which had fled to Bamberg, issued an proclamation in which it stated: "Russian terror is raging in Munich, unleashed by elements foreign to the country..." It was certainly more a threat than a reality. But on April 27, Lenin sent a letter of welcome to the Bavarian Soviet Republic, in which he gave very far-reaching instructions in the form of questions: "...what measures (have) you take to fight the bourgeois hangmen Scheidemann and co.? Have you...armed the workers, disarmed the bourgeoisie...restricted the living quarters of the bourgeoisie in Munich for the immediate admission of workers to the homes of the rich...(and) taken hostages from the bourgeoisie?" That antipathy to *foreigners* and *foreign interference* was not limited to the right, however, is evident even from the example of Ernst Toller, who said at a crucial meeting of the governing bodies on April 26 that the present government is a misfortune because it always operated on the argument: "In Russia we did it differently." But "we Bavarians" do not see any Russians! Even more characteristic is a sentence that Thomas Mann entered in his diary on May 2, 1919, when shots could still be heard everywhere being exchanged by the invading Freikorps and the retreating Spartacists: "We talked about (whether it was still possible to save European culture)...or whether the Kyrgyz idea of razing and destroying would prevail...We also spoke of the type of the Russian Jew, the leader of the world movement, this explosive mixture of Jewish intellectual radicalism and Slavic fanaticism for Christ. A world that still possesses the instinct of self-preservation must take action against this race of people with all the energy and utmost brevity that can be mustered..."

In Russia, March and April 1919 marked the first peak of hope for the imminent world revolution. For Lenin, the emergence of the Communist Party of Germany "with such world-renowned and world-renowned leaders as Liebknecht, Rosa Luxemburg, Clara Zetkin

and Franz Mehring” already meant, in effect, the beginning of the new Communist International, and the founding meeting in Moscow at the beginning of March was for him that just a kind of formal enactment. However, it took place in an extremely modest setting and with almost one delegate from the relevant parties, but above all against the will of Rosa Luxemburg, who had not yet considered the time to be ripe. Indeed, Soviet Russia was in a very difficult position: facing various Allied interventions and the deployment of powerful White armies, it was all but cut off from the rest of the world and faced with a completely disorganized economy. But rarely in history has the discrepancy between an exceedingly meager material base and an enthusiastic, overarching, universal belief been so great. The manifestos and appeals addressed to the whole world by this small gathering of 51 *delegates*, most of whom were Russians, were imbued with such fire and such force of enthusiasm that no Allied victory proclamation, nor any well-meaning Wilson’s plan for the future, could be addressed to them put aside. In the “Guidelines of the Communist International” written by Bukharin it said: “The new epoch is born. The epoch of the dissolution of capitalism, its internal decomposition, the epoch of the communist revolution of the proletariat...It must break the rule of capital, make wars impossible, abolish the borders of states, transform the whole world into a community working for itself, bring about the brotherhood and liberation of peoples.” And at the same time, these demands of militant universalism were placed in a great historical line: “Rejecting the half-measures, mendacity and rottenness of the official socialist parties that have survived, we, the communists united in the Third International, feel ourselves to be the direct continuers of the heroic efforts and martyrdom of a long line of revolutionary generations, from Babeuf to Karl Marx and Rosa Luxemburg.” But these confident hopes and predictions reached their highest point in the May Day appeal which the Executive Committee of the International, aware that it was now honoring the Hungarian and Bavarian Soviet Republics along with the Russian, addressed the communists in Bavaria: “The storm begins. The conflagration of the proletarian revolution is blazing with unstoppable force across Europe. The moment is approaching that our predecessors and teachers awaited...The dream of the best representatives of humanity is becoming a reality...The hour of our oppressors has come. May 1, 1919 must be the day of the advance, the day of the proletarian revolution throughout Europe...In 1919 the great Communist International was born. In 1920 the great International Soviet Republic will be born.”

To a skeptical observer, however, it would have been more likely that the year 1919 would spell the end of the Soviet Republic. In southern Russia, General Denikin’s volunteer army advanced far north, supported by the Allies and especially by the new British Secretary of War, Winston Churchill, with much material and military missions. In Siberia, Admiral Kolchak had overthrown the party government, and his troops, joined by the Czechoslovaks,

were outside Samara and not far from Simbirsk by the end of April. In the former Baltic provinces, German troops and the *Baltische Landeswehr* were still fighting both against the Bolsheviks and against the bourgeois-nationalist Latvians and Estonians; Petrograd remained threatened. To the north, Allied troops remained at Arkhangelsk, striving to install a Russian regime under a Social Revolutionary. The *red* area was now barely larger than the Grand Duchy of Moscow had been before Peter the Great, and it suffered terribly from starvation, being cut off from the main grain areas and unable to supply its peasants with industrial goods, so that Lenin was forced to send requisition squads of workers from the towns to the villages, who there sought to unite with the *village poor* in a merciless raid against the *kulaks* .

Thus, the external civil war ran parallel to the internal class war, and this was the characteristic and unprecedented thing, for never before in modern history had the head of government treated large groups of his own population as “the dogs and pigs of the dying bourgeoisie” or as “spiders” and “parasites” against which a merciless fight had to be fought. On the fronts, however, the fighting was equally bitter on both sides, and even neutral observers frequently reported that it was waged whites with greater ferocity by the Whites than by the Reds, because the latter often only killed the captured officers and treated the men as *class brothers* and set them at freedom. Indeed, the passage of entire units to the enemy contributed greatly to the defeat suffered by the Kolchak army in May and June before it could establish contact with Denikin, and after a heavy defeat of the Czechoslovaks, the retreat turned into that dramatic escape across the thousands of kilometers of the Trans-Siberian railroad line, in which hundreds of thousands fell and hundreds of thousands more fleeing civilians died of exhaustion.

By the time Denikin advanced toward of Moscow, Kolchak was already defeated, and by the time General Yudenich’s North-West Army reached the outskirts of Petrograd in October, Denikin had already been forced to retreat. The White armies, the Allies, the nationalist Latvians and Estonians, the peasant anarchists of Makhno in the Ukraine and the Ukrainian nationalists under Petlyura, the Poles and the Caucasians fought together against the Bolsheviks and at the same time secretly and partly openly against each other, since some wanted to restore the Russian empire and others wanted to weaken it, as some fought for their own independence and others for acquiring land or securing supplies of raw materials. Moreover, both in Soviet territory and behind the White fronts, Social Revolutionaries and Mensheviks effectively sided with the Bolsheviks when the danger seemed great that a reactionary general would enter Moscow victoriously. Lenin well full knew that he owed his victory in the civil war as much to the disunity of his opponents, just as the triumph of his

revolution was due to the adoption of the land program of the Social Revolutionaries. Thus, although by the end of 1919, large parts of the former Tsarist Empire had made themselves independent—in addition to the new Baltic Sea states and Finland, not least Georgia—but only Denikin's troops in the area north of the Crimea whose supreme command soon passed to General von Wrangel, were to be regarded as an efficient and not yet completely discouraged civil war army. Only the Poles, dreaming of a restoration of the borders of 1772, were a threatening external power. But the Russian bourgeoisie and the Russian nobility no longer existed, even if numerous individuals escaped physical annihilation and hid somewhere in the mighty Soviet bureaucracy: the *exploiting classes* were *liquidated*, in accordance with the party's program, and far more than a million of their members found poor shelter in the countries of Europe in one of the largest flight movements the world had seen up to that point. However, the *world revolution* in 1919 had lost two countries, namely Hungary and Bavaria. But the main reason why Churchill had not been able to prevail against Lloyd George in his demands for stronger White support was that the Prime Minister was greatly disturbed by revolutionary tendencies in England and preferred to have a Bolshevik Russia than a Bolshevik England. And the year 1920 was to bring another push of *revolution* very soon.

In Germany, in the second half of 1919, there had not been much talk about the Communist Party, but all the more of the intolerable conditions of the Peace of Versailles, of the "war guilt lie" of Article 231, of the shameful demand of the Allies for the extradition of the German *war criminals* and in particular the former Kaiser. The party had been banned, and at an illegal party conference in Heidelberg, it broke away from those left-wing radicals who had outvoted Rosa Luxemburg at the first party conference on the issue of election participation, and who were now partly drifting into *National Bolshevik* waters like the two Hamburgers, Heinrich Laufenberg and Fritz Wolffheim. Still, it is not unbelievable that General von Lüttwitz, whose troops had saved the Social Democratic Party government a year earlier, was worried not only by the reduction in army strength demanded by the Allies, but also by the growth of *Bolshevism*, for he had his eye primarily on the Independent Social Democratic Party of Germany, which seemed to be getting stronger. These concerns and also the understandable desire to see the first Reichstag elections scheduled soon resulted in the so-called Kapp Putsch, which brought Berlin under the power of the mutinous "Brigade Ehrhardt" for a few days and forced the Reich government to go first to Dresden and then to Stuttgart.

In addition to the resistance of the Berlin civil service and the neutrality of the majority of the Reichswehr, the decisive factor in the early resignation of the Putsch Reich Chancellor

Wolfgang Kapp, who had found a lot of support above all in East Germany, was the political general strike, which the Social Democratic members of the Reich government called for to the workers. This appeal basically spoke the language of the proletarian revolution: "We didn't make the revolution in order to recognize the bloody Landsknecht regiment again today. We do not make pacts with the Baltic criminals...Workers, comrades...Use every means to destroy this return of bloody reaction...Strike, lay down work and cut the air off to this military dictatorship...Proletarians, unite!"

It was not surprising that this general strike was now also directed against the government, of which Gustav Noske was a member, and that the left wing of the Independent Social Democratic Party was now sought to make up for the failure of 1918. Nevertheless, the government was obviously surprised at how quickly Red Army detachments were formed in many places in Germany and how successful the unification was, at least in one region, namely the Ruhr area. Here, not only Reichswehr units but also police detachments were defeated, and there was good reason to speak of a German "March Revolution." The Communist Party of Germany, however, was only slightly involved in this, and at first it had even wanted to maintain a gleeful neutrality in the struggle of the "Ebertines" and the "Lüttwitze," but rumors soon ascribed them and even to *Russians* a leading role, and this also aggravated the fighting, in which the government even had to resort to the troops against which their Social Democratic members had called for a general strike. For a good two weeks Germany was a kind of Russia, where a genuine civil war raged between large armed formations, and a speech made by Gustav Stresemann to the Executive Committee of his party on March 28, 1920, referred entirely to the Russian example: it had been established that officers of the Russian Red Army had stayed here in Berlin and that Lenin had sent popular speakers to Germany. Conditions in Germany developed with photographic truth like those in Russia. "Just as in our country they want to disarm troops and create workers' battalions, as exactly how Kerensky did it, and Lenin was his successor. If it continues like this, Bolshevism will be the sea in which we will finally drown." But the worst thing he said, was that the Democratic Party was now taking part in attacks on the Reichswehr and was thereby denying the interests of the bourgeoisie. "Can one be surprised if officers waver in the fight against Bolshevism?"

Ultimately, the Reichswehr did not falter and they crushed the uprising, sometimes with great brutality, so that the young soldier confided in his diary: "In the field we were much more humane towards the French." Thus this short German civil war intensified the hatred on both sides, and it robbed the center even more of self-confidence and moral authority: it intensified the hatred of numerous independents and communists against the *soldiery* and the

Social Democratic Party government, which had once again betrayed the revolution; it intensified the soldiers' hatred of the *Bolsheviks* and above all of the social-democratic Marxists, who again and again allowed themselves to be rescued by the soldiers and yet again and again insulted and offended their rescuers. But a deep dislike was now also directed—as with the Russian *Whites* —against the bourgeoisie, who had proven to be philistine and lacking in energy, although Max Hölz had posters put up during the fighting in the Vogtland on which he threatened to set fire to the whole city at once and slaughter the bourgeoisie immediately upon the arrival of the Reichswehr, regardless of sex or age.

The consequences of the Kapp putsch were strange. The Reichstag elections took place on June 6, 1920, and they cost the Weimar coalition its majority. The Independent Social Democratic Party grew tremendously and was now almost as strong as the Social Democrats, but the German Nationalists also made significant gains. The Social Democrat Hermann Müller first negotiated with the leader of the Independents, Arthur Crispien, but the latter turned down the offer to participate in the government because his party wanted the “possession of political power by the proletariat and its autocracy until the realization of socialism.” In the end a bourgeois government was formed under the center politician Fehrenbach, and since in Bavaria the Social Democrat Hoffmann was replaced by Gustav von Kahr immediately after the putsch, it was ultimately the bourgeois parties that drew the greatest profits from the civil war, even though they had basically only watched it.

The communists thus found their minimum demand fulfilled, namely the end of the social-democratic-bourgeois coalition, but in a completely different way than they had imagined. An alliance of all socialist parties and government leadership by a representative of the trade unions would at least have been a step in the Soviet direction, towards that situation which the Bolsheviks by seizing power had not allowed to develop further. But it now looked as if parliamentary maneuvers were no longer needed to bring about a breakthrough in the world revolution in Germany. In the spring, Josef Pilsudski, once leader of the Polish Socialist Party and now founder of a state not yet defined in its borders and role, had attacked Soviet Russia in alliance with the Ukrainian nationalists Petliura in order to create a large Eastern European federation from the Baltic to the Black Sea that would render Soviet Russia harmless to *civilized Europe*. But on June 11 Kiev, which had just been conquered, had to be evacuated again, and then the allied Poles and Ukrainians suffered one defeat after another. The question was whether to stop at the so-called Curzon Line, but Lenin got his way, and for the first time the Red Army crossed the borders of their country to bring freedom to the workers and peasants of Poland oppressed by the *Pany* —the feudal lords—as a precautionary new government announced. But Lenin's real goal was Germany,

that is, revolution in Germany, and Trotsky too now saw the moment approaching when Russians and Germans would join forces in the great battle of the Rhine against the Entente. The hatred of Poland among many German nationalists was so strong that this prospect was greeted with enthusiasm, and the press reports on the Soviet troops now standing on the borders of East Prussia were generally very positive. Western Europe held its breath and seemed completely paralyzed for a time, especially as the Soviet government's appeals to workers to stop all shipments of munitions and materials to Poland fell on fertile ground, particularly among the English trade unions. Articles in the press often portrayed Poland as an all too weak bulwark trying desperately bravely to save the whole of Europe from the onslaught of eastern hordes. Americans were content with a note from Secretary of State Colby equating militant Communism with *military autocracy* and harshly opposing *Americanism*. The French supported General Wrangel in the last offensive undertaken in the Russian Civil War, which brought some relief to the Poles. But even General Weygand's military mission could not have turned the tide of fate if the traditional hatred of the Russians had not been stronger among the Polish workers and peasants than their aversion to the ruling class, which had long since ceased to hold the reins alone. This allowed Pilsudski to reorganize his army and win the Battle of Warsaw. In the preliminary peace of Riga he was promised western Ukraine and large parts of Belarus, and in exchange he let Petlyura and Wrangel fall, just as the Allies had dropped Kolchak in the beginning of the year. Wrangel embarked with his troops from the Crimea for Constantinople in November, and with that the Russian civil war came to an end, which many emigrants considered to be only a temporary end.

Around the same time, the German Communist Party became a mass party, merging with the left wing of the Independent Social Democratic Party to form the United Communist Party of Germany. The prerequisite for this had been the decisions of the Second World Congress of the Communist International, which had been meeting in Moscow during the decisive period of the Soviet-Polish war and whose delegates had followed with the greatest enthusiasm the constant advance of the front lines on the large wall map displayed in the Congress building. Here Lenin had those 21 conditions passed, which now also brought the split to the large left-wing socialist parties in Europe, namely the German Independent Social Democratic Party, the Italian Socialist Party and the French Section of the Workers' International. These conditions constituted the Communist International as a centralized world party, divided into *sections*, excluding from itself all *reformists*, *centrists*, *social-pacifists* and even the supporters of the *yellow trade union federations*, even if they, like the Italian Filippo Turati, had been staunch opponents of the war. They required of each of the sections to create illegal parallel apparatuses in preparation for the civil war phase, to practice systematic propaganda

of disintegration in the armies, to undertake the obligation to provide unconditional support to “every Soviet republic” (i.e. practically Soviet Russia), and to leave no doubt by their entire behavior that the Communist International had “declared war on the whole bourgeois world and on all yellow social-democratic parties.” (*translator: “yellow” as in coward.*) To all incredulous observers, these conditions could mean nothing else than that Russia, defeated in the world war, was seeking, in a manner as subtle as it was insidious, to secure its self-assertion and to prepare its revenge by trying to incite the masses of workers and peasants in the enemy states against the ruling class of their country by taking advantage of freedom of propaganda and freedom of organization, which they withheld from the surviving opponents. The right-wing socialists, on the other hand, had to admit that Lenin obviously equated *Western imperialism* with the inclusion of a large part of the socialists in the parliamentary system, which had begun in France around 1900 and which even seemed to be gaining acceptance in Russia in 1917, the inclusion that had deep roots in European history and which, by all human judgement, would have prevented another great war if carried out by a large majority and without reservations. But the strong left wings in all parties evidently shared Lenin’s conviction that socialists should not participate, but rule alone, because only then could all rule be abolished. Only this third interpretation could arouse enthusiasm, and in fact no party could raise a higher claim than that expressed in the last sentence of the manifesto passed by the Congress: “Workers and working women! On earth there is only one sign worthy of fighting and dying under: that sign is the Communist International.” And it wasn’t a baseless enthusiasm. Where else in the world could the delegates have been shown a royal palace which, like the tsar’s palace in Tsarskoye Selo, had been converted into a children’s home, where else was there so much effort to eliminate illiteracy, where did ordinary workers have such unlimited opportunities to develop their literary talents or to hold the highest positions in the state? Had not, indeed, the *party of progress* actually seized power in Soviet Russia?

The tremendous prestige that Soviet communism had won through its victory was nowhere more evident than in Germany. When the Independent Social Democratic Party delegates met in Halle in October 1920 to decide whether or not to accept the 21 conditions, the Comintern emissary, Grigory Zinoviev, was greeted with a roar of rapturous applause, although a strong minority did not raise a hand in greeting. And then Zinoviev spoke for several hours with such captivating persuasiveness that some newspapers in their reports called him the greatest orator of the century. With the strongest emphasis he accused the right-wingers around Crispian and Hilferding with the fact that the fear of the revolution running through their entire policy, and contrasted this with his own faith, which had brought tears to his eyes when a few weeks ago at the Congress of the Awakening Peoples of Asia in Baku, hundreds

of Turks and Persians had joined in the singing of the Internationale. Thus, for all mankind, the light would come from the East and the opponents of unification were completely wrong when they complain about the naiveté of the masses, because “the so-called naive, religious belief of the proletarian masses” is “in fact the most important revolutionary factor in world history.” Now in this thesis a very strong change, even a reversal of Marxism, could undoubtedly be seen. But the orthodox Marxists, among them Rudolf Hilferding and Julius Martov, did not find nearly as much support with their speeches “against the Moscow dictate,” although cries of indignation were audible when Martov described the tactics of the Cheka tactics and added that he was ashamed of his country where such things are possible. The majority of the delegates agreed with the decision, which Zinoviev immediately placed in a very broad historical perspective when he said at the end of his speech: “A great united Communist Party will now be formed in Germany, and that is the greatest historical event these days.” Thus the small “Communist Party of Germany, Section of the Communist International” became the large “United Communist Party of Germany,” which of course was also a section of the Communist International. 300,000 members of the Independent Social Democratic Party went along with the move, while 300,000 remained with the old party, which two years later reunited with the Majority Social Democratic Party of Germany (*translator: the name officially used by the Social Democratic Party 1917-1922*) . The United Communist Party of Germany now had about 350,000 members, and was headed by co-chairmen Paul Levi, a very cultured lawyer and student of Rosa Luxemburg, and Ernst Däumig of the Independent Social Democratic Party.

A little later, Zinoviev published a report on his “Twelve Days in Germany.” Not without good reason could he assert that the vast majority of German workers were on the side of the Russian revolution and that the propaganda of right-wing intellectuals and petty-bourgeois labor aristocrats against the “Moscow scourge” or the “Moscow despots” had fallen on barren ground. Even more interesting, however, were the impressions that the party leader of Petrograd, which according to all reports was desolate and starving, had gained in Germany, impressions of the “lavish shops, bursting with delicacies” and of the “sated, stupid bourgeois” who were masters of the situation. “When will it finally end? When, when will the giant, the German proletarian, stretch his shoulders and shake off all this bourgeois filth that occupies the top of the pyramid? Curse it, thrice curse it, the ‘civilized’ capitalist world that crushes the living soul and turns millions of people into slaves...Only when not one stone is left upon another by German Menshevism will the way be clear; only then will the powerful workers’ organizations in Germany...become powerful lever, with which the German working class overthrows the old Germany and finishes off the bourgeoisie.” Rarely has the inner connection between the criticism of civilization and the intention of annihilation, which

is one of the hallmarks of early Bolshevism, been formulated as clearly as here by the chairman of the Communist International. Zinoviev named the complete abolition of money and the naturalization of wages as the remedy that had almost been realized in Russia. But just a few months later this remedy was thrown into the scrap heap in Soviet Russia.

The period of the Russian civil war had been, after all, a time of *wartime communism*, which on the one hand was associated with great hopes for the imminent realization of a no-longer-capitalist way of life of “everything belongs to everyone” and was characterized by great agitation and cultural impetus, but which nevertheless, already meant a clear suppression of the spontaneous and strengthening of the party and state headquarters as well as disciplining in the army and industry. This raised the question of what role the unions should play in the *workers’ state*: would they continue to be a representative body of the workers’ interests, or organs of the arbiters for the self-government of industry, or would they be the *transmission belts* for the party, which might one day have labor requisitioned in much the same way as it requisitioned the peasants’ grain? As early as 1919 and 1920, the beginnings of a *workers’ opposition* became apparent, and various groups attempted to constitute themselves as an opposition or as a faction. The strongest impetus was the complaint about the Soviet bureaucracy, but also about one-man management, the role of specialists, conformism and opportunism. All of this leads to the paradoxical result that (as Alexandra Kollontai put it) “only the most important class of the Soviet Republic...in its masses leads a shamefully miserable existence in forced labor.”

Lenin, for his part, had a keen sense of the unsustainability and the hopelessness of the situation. He sought to remedy this by giving economic leeway to spontaneity by replacing requisitions with taxes in kind, thereby giving the peasants the opportunity to sell their surpluses on the open market. Now a certain degree of free trade and a class of businessmen and merchants capable of *capitalist* activity in a variety of ways had to necessarily emerge. This is exactly what Lenin called the “New Economic Policy” (NEP), and he had its main features decided upon at the Tenth Party Congress, which began to meet at the beginning of March. But all the more firmly he stuck to the principle of political party dictatorship and did not hesitate to use the term “state capitalism.” In fact, as early as 1918, he had made very peculiar statements which he now emphatically repeated in his essay “On the Tax in Kind”: “If the revolution in Germany is still hesitant to ‘break out,’ then it is our task to learn the state capitalism of the Germans, to take it over with all our might, to spare no dictatorial methods in order to accelerate this transfer of Western culture to barbaric Russia, without shrinking from barbaric methods of fighting against barbarism.” Now, at the beginning of 1921, the revolution in Germany had not yet *broken out*. If Russia, however, became a

development-dictatorship, over whose nationalized large-scale industry the top body of the party had unconditional control, while below that level the situation was largely determined by free trade and small-capitalist traders and entrepreneurs, then the anarchist-utopian pathos that seemed to be at the core of communism qua Soviet rule had to be directed with redoubled force against a situation that was by all accounts worse than the high capitalism that prevailed in the West.

The first and most powerful expression of this criticism, because it was organized and armed, and was directed primarily against certain manifestations of War Communism, was the uprising of the sailors and the population of Kronstadt. It coincided with the Tenth Party Congress, and probably not entirely by chance, because there had been numerous unrests and strikes beforehand, especially in Petrograd, and conversely, the forthcoming relaxation of the rules had already made itself felt in various hints.

The following demands were made by the plenary assembly of the crews of the first and second brigades of battleships on March 1, 1921: new elections to the soviets on the terms of secret ballot; freedom of speech and of the press for workers and peasants, anarchists and left-wing socialist parties; freedom of assembly; freedom of trade unions and peasant associations; liberation of all political prisoners belonging to socialist parties; election of a commission to review the trial records of all those locked up in prisons and concentration camps; freedom of peasants to dispose of their land provided they do not use wage labor; free artisanal production based on their own work.

To a large extent, then, these were the demands of 1917, which the Russian Communist Party claimed to have carried out. But this was precisely what Lenin and the party evidently took as an intolerable threat. Immediately preparations were made for the military suppression of the *mutiny*, and with it the tone of the Kronstadters became even sharper: "To everyone, everyone, everyone!...Wading up to his hips in the fraternal blood of the working people, the bloodthirsty Field Marshal Trotsky was the first to open fire on revolutionary Kronstadt for rebelling against the rule of Communists in order to restore real power of the soviets...In this sea of blood the Communists are drowning all the great and luminous promises and slogans of the workers' revolution...Life under the yoke has become more terrible than death...Here in Kronstadt the cornerstone of the Third Revolution was laid...which will open a new broad path to creative activity in the spirit of socialism."

When one considers how central the concepts of the masses, self-activity, liberation, and absence of domination had been in the Russian revolution and how they were invoked here as

testimony *against* that revolution, then it was all too understandable that the Communist International gave the order in Germany to finally achieve a breakthrough with the new mass party and either force victory or at least divert the world's attention from Kronstadt. In fact, during Easter week, in the midst of the extremely difficult situation in which the bourgeois Fehrenbach government found itself as a result of the excessive reparation demands of the Entente and impotent attempts at resistance, the so-called "March Action" broke out, which was in fact a large-scale uprising in the central German industrial area and also could be described as a "March Revolution," especially since violent actions also took place in Hamburg and other large cities while the Communist Party of Germany called for a political general strike. However, a police action by Oberpresident Hörsing interfered with the preparations that were made as a result of the so-called theory of the revolutionary offensive, so that there could also be talk of provocation and resistance. The *Rote Fahne* used extraordinarily sharp language: "The German bourgeoisie and their social-democratic rabble of leaders have wrested the weapons from the hands of the proletariat...Like Kahr on the one hand, the proletariat must on the other: whistle at the law. Every counter-revolutionary has his weapon. The workers must not be worse revolutionaries than those counter-revolutionaries are."

The difference, however, was that this time the *counter-revolutionaries*, who were particularly identified as the Bavarian self-defense organization "Organization Escherich," had *not* staged a putsch as they had the year before. And there was not nearly as much spontaneous agitation among the workers as in March 1920, so that the party had to resort to a multitude of artificial means: assassinations, demolitions, inciting the security police with slogans like: "Overturn the streetcars, throw hand grenades!" According to the party, hundreds of thousands went into battle, more than the year before in the Ruhr, but not millions, and only with millions could this civil war have been victorious. Therefore, there had been strong resistance in the party leadership, and the delegates of the Comintern, among them Matias Rakosi and Bela Kun, had to use all their authority to get their way.

The worst thing about this defeat, however, was that the previous party leader Paul Levi published a document already in April in which he described the action as "the greatest Bakuninist putsch in history so far," as a war by the communists against four-fifths of the German workers who had been outrageously insulted by the *Rote Fahne*. Levi named the envoys of the Comintern as those actually responsible, and characterized them with the evil expression "Turkestan."

For this, of course, he was expelled from the party, but with the founding of the "Communist

Working Group” he completed the first split from the United Communist Party of Germany. Thus, a *Western European* communism seemed to oppose Soviet communism, and not entirely infrequently the *anti-Bolshevism* of heterodox communists was spoken of.

Thus, in the spring of 1921, the Communist Party of Soviet Russia had definitely won the great civil war, but at the same time it seemed to have changed in a strange way with the introduction of the NEP. During the war it had been part of the great pan-European party of protest and hope, and afterwards it had won a world-historical triumph as the Russian party of civil war and the social annihilation of hostile classes, which admittedly also included the suppression of massive peasant uprisings, which were hardly be attributed merely to the activity of kulaks. Would it not now either have to expand to all of Europe as a *party of world revolution* , or else transform itself into a *party of industrialization*, treading a path that no one before it had ever trodden? Or would it even become a “war party,” as the Menshevik Noe Jordania accused it after Soviet troops crossed a border recognized under international law for the second time in February 1921 and subjugated Georgia?

The fact that it got into this dilemma was due to the defeats suffered by the German party and the German revolution. The transition to the NEP meant only gaining a breathing space, and the new decision-making situation came about in 1923, the year of the great German crisis. But if there was *anti-Bolshevism* even in the ranks of the communists in 1920 and 1921, then it would have been more than strange if a much more pronounced anti-Bolshevism had not arisen in the meantime on the soil of that *bourgeois world* , whose executioner communism wanted to be, which would have a word and would also throw a sword into the balance for all future decisions.

Chapter II, Section 4

Early Anti-Bolshevism and the First Rise of Hitler

More astonishing than anti-Bolshevism is, of course, philo-Bolshevism, which became noticeable early on the bourgeois, i.e. here the non-socialist side. In its beginnings it has as little to do with social motives as the first anti-Bolshevism: it refers to the Bolsheviks as the peace party, which had to evoke a natural sympathy among all those who criticized the war and the warring parties. In America and England it was the anti-imperialist wing of the Liberals and the Labor Party. However, the clear fronts blurred when the Brest-Litovsk peace agreement made it obvious that the peace of the Bolsheviks implied a tremendous advantage for the war party in Germany; but after the end of the war that sympathy was partly restored, not least because the liberal and working-class spirit of progress often did not doubt the inner kinship even when one expressed great misgivings about the methods of the Bolsheviks. Men like the Americans William Bullitt and Raymond Robins or the Englishmen M. Phillips Price of the *Manchester Guardian* and Arthur Ransome from the London *Daily News* preserved their sympathy for the Bolsheviks always, or at least for a long time, because they clearly recognized what was world-historically new and wanted to see it as world-historically positive. Immediately after the October revolution, the *Berliner Tageblatt*, too, by no means perceived only the national aspect, but emphasized that this event “would bring the social question to the fore in a huge way” and some of the headlines that covered the reports of the Russian civil war seemed to express an even broader sympathy for the Bolsheviks. By no means all pacifist and socially-minded Liberals and Labor politicians allowed their dislike of the *reactionaries* and *imperialists* of their own country in the first instance to determine their approval of even what was very early called the *policy of extermination* of the Bolsheviks, but Bernard Shaw nonetheless voiced a symptomatic point of view when he said, with only slight detachment, that the Bolsheviks had raised the right questions and shot the right people.

The strangest form of philo-Bolshevism was bourgeois national-Bolshevism in Germany, which arose from the horror of the Versailles peace terms and saw only *one* means that could help, namely, Bolshevism, which would have a less despotic character in Germany than in Russia, provided it came to power with the support of *wealthy and educated circles*. At least Paul Elzbacher, with whose name this tendency was earliest connected, showed a certain domestic political sympathy because he found it welcomed that Lenin had spoken out “in favor of the merciless punishment of dissolute and lazy workers,” and he hoped that cooperation at least would give protection against the destruction of ancient cultures “from the shallow ‘civilization’ of England and America.”

But if by no means all of the bourgeoisie were anti-Bolsheviks, then even less all socialists were philo-Bolsheviks; it was precisely among them that a sharp enmity quickly developed, which was certainly more pronounced in the leading groups than in the *proletarian masses*. Besides, nothing is less surprising when one keeps in mind that the Bolsheviks' seizure of power primarily served to eliminate the other socialist parties.

Lenin's oldest comrade-in-arms, the former members of the *Iskra* editorial team, saw this seizure of power as nothing more than the consistent continuation of Lenin's well-known tactic of creating a party of devoted followers by pushing out the genuine Marxists and independent thinkers. Plekhanov's sentence about the “insatiable striving to seize power” has already been quoted. Martov called the Bolsheviks an “hangman's party” as early as 1918, and the harshest criticism was made by Pavel B. Axelrod. For him, Bolshevism was “Asiatic,” a betrayal of the most elementary principles of Marxism, a “dictatorship over the proletariat (and the peasantry),” a group “which was resurrecting the barbarism, cruelty and inhumanity of times long past” which constitutes itself as the “new ruling class” within the framework of a new type of “slave regime.” Therefore, Axelrod saw confirmation of the thesis that he had already put forward before the outbreak of the World War, namely that “the Lenin clique should be characterized as a gang of the ‘Black Hundreds’ and as common criminals within the Social Democrats.”

The anarchists made an even more fundamental criticism than the Mensheviks. While they could not deny that the ultimate goals of the Bolsheviks were identical to their own goals—the establishment of a world society of free individuals—they rejected the means used by the Bolsheviks, namely the development of an outrageously strong state power; and they did not believe that this remedy, early or late, would produce its own opposite. Thus the American anarchist Alexander Berkman, a friend of the better known Emma Goldman, wrote immediately after the overthrow of Kronstadt: “The experience of Kronstadt proves anew that

the government, the state—whatever its name or form—is always the mortal enemy of the freedom and self-determination. The state has no soul, no principle. It has only one goal—to secure the power and keep it at all costs. This is the political lesson of Kronstadt.”

Rosa Luxemburg, like her friend Paul Levi, would probably have been accused of anti-Bolshevism by Lenin's orthodox followers in 1921. Her pamphlet on the Russian Revolution, written in prison in 1918 and published by Levi in 1922, with all due respect to Lenin and Trotsky, raised a number of objections that were fundamental in character. Admittedly, when Rosa Luxemburg described freedom as the “freedom of those who think differently,” she hardly meant the liberal freedom of every citizen and therefore also of “reactionaries,” but the connection between “life in the soviets” and “general elections, unrestrained freedom of the press and of assembly, and free struggle of opinion” nevertheless included the principled rejection of party dictatorship, and was a plea for that Soviet democracy of all socialist working people, as the Petersburg masses had wanted to implement in October 1917 and as the Kronstadt rebels demanded again in 1921. Indeed, it did not take long before the Communist Party of Germany launched a struggle against “Luxemburgism,” which was accused of overestimating the spontaneity of the masses and neglecting the role of the party.

All of this involved *intra-communist* disputes. A different tone is perceptible in the social democratic criticism, which although it still sees itself in part as *intra-socialist*, also shows an unmistakable tendency to expel Bolshevism from the socialist camp and subsume it under the term *bourgeois*.

Thus, according to Otto Bauer, the Bolshevik Revolution accomplished what the bourgeois revolutions had achieved in Western Europe: the destruction of the feudal agricultural system and the establishment of the bourgeois property system in the countryside. In Russia the proletarians now ruled, and one worker vote was therefore equal to five peasant votes in the elections. But the party leaders very quickly became more and more preponderant, so that one can at best speak of a *despotic socialism*. This path is not without historical consequence and necessity, but it can never be the path of the western European industrial countries, which must represent a gradual further development of bourgeois democracy. On the other hand, Russian communism is closely related to Spengler's *Prussian socialism*, because both are caught in the state-believing delusion that “the omnipotence of a ruling minority can and should force the obeying masses to adopt higher forms of life.”

The man who had been the supreme authority on all questions of doctrine in the pre-war

social democracy, Karl Kautsky, expressed himself far more sharply, not only in newspaper articles but also in several treatises. For him, Marxism is part of the humanization process that has led the workers' movement out of its original savagery and also out of its inner proximity to the terrorist phase of the French Revolution. Bolshevism therefore meant a relapse into bestiality, because it wanted to replace the Marxist class struggle with civil war. The ultimate reason for this was the immaturity of Russian conditions. The Bolsheviks allowed themselves to be carried away by a mass psychosis, and therefore they understood the social quality of the *citizen* as a biological one, against which they proceeded with the savagery and brutality of the rising workers' movement. Hence the victory of Bolshevism was a defeat of socialism, and this was also shown in the emergence of a new bureaucracy, a new ruling class, bringing back militarism and installing terrorism: "Shoot them—this has become the be-all and end-all of communist governmental wisdom." This Bolshevism was an anti-human and anti-socialist relapse into barbaric conditions, and that is why Kautsky finally calls it a "Tatar socialism."

But whether the leading Social Democrats see Bolshevism primarily as a *Russian special path* or as a *barbaric regression*, they always place it in stark contrast to *Europe*, and in the travelogue of one Social Democrat the wish is expressed "to leave the borders of Soviet Russia behind me as soon as possible," since the monotony and poverty of life, the hunger, the absence of freedom of the press and the constant horror at the deeds of the new "Holy Inquisition," the Cheka, was simply unbearable. But the question is hardly ever suggested whether the *European* might perhaps be related to the free existence even of *reactionary* tendencies and whether the non-Bolshevik socialists in Russia might not have done better to ally themselves with Kolchak and Denikin, because only then would they have a chance would have existed to create a *society of productive social differences* like in Europe. On the contrary, an equidistance from the Bolsheviks and the reactionaries remains, expressly or not, the characteristic of all Social Democrats, and this equidistance had indeed determined the practical policy of the Mensheviks and Social Revolutionaries until they were finally eliminated in 1921.

The diverse European liberalism was more inclined to identify with European culture or at least with Western civilization, unless as a pronounced left-wing liberalism it did not focus on criticism of the injustices of an all too opaque society. For the *Times* there was "not enough room in the world for Bolshevism and civilization." In terms of its meaning, the term *totalitarianism* or *totalism* was already familiar as an antithesis. The insecure borderline between right-wing liberals and conservatives was probably most easily recognizable by whether one noted the *foreign peoples* as having a particularly large share in the Russian

revolution or whether one saw the Jews as a cause of a special kind. Already in the first months after the February Revolution it had irritated numerous observers, especially in France and Italy, that the champions of a peace treaty so often carried or had carried German names such as Zederbaum, Apfelbaum, or Sobelsohn. Later, some authors linked this observation with old ideas that had been common among conservatives as early as the first half of the 19th century. None other than Winston Churchill wrote in one of his essays: "This movement among the Jews is not new. From the days of Spartacus Weishaupt [*translator: founder of the Bavarian Illuminati in 1776*] to those of Karl Marx and down to Trotsky (Russia), Bela Kun (Hungary), Rosa Luxemburg (Germany) and Emma Goldman (United States), this worldwide conspiracy has been growing to overthrow civilization and remake society on the basis of arrested development, envious resentment and impossible equality...(This movement) was the mainspring behind every *subversive* movement of the 19th century, and now this gang of extraordinary personalities from the underworld of the great cities of Europe and America's has grabbed the Russian people by the collar and have practically become the undisputed master of a vast empire." But if one may sense in such sentences an echo of the fear of conspiracies of the Abbé Barrel or Prince Metternich; Churchill, far from attributing the subversive tendencies of many Jews to the immutable racial characteristics of all Jews, emphasized the Zionist aspirations of Dr. Weizmann, which were "in particular harmony with the truest interests of the British Empire."

The political interests of the British Empire were even more clearly in the foreground for Churchill when he advocated the idea that Germany, after its defeat, must now be made a solid bulwark against the dangers of Bolshevism, a "dam of peaceful, lawful and patient strength against the tide of red barbarism that is surging from the East" and this point of view could just as well give rise to the hope that the establishment of trade relations would lead to a mitigation of that despotism, which was frightening in European eyes. This view was championed by Lloyd George, and as early as 1921 he pushed for the establishment of trade relations with Soviet Russia.

Thus each of the established ideologies and parties developed its own anti-Bolshevism, right up to the USPD (Independent Social Democratic Party of Germany) and even into the ranks of the Communist Party of Germany, and nothing was more understandable, since Bolshevism, according to its own self-image, had declared war on *the whole world* and had accused each of the existing parties of lackeys toward the *international bourgeoisie*. But an important transition was made when entire organizations made anti-Bolshevism the main focus of their efforts.

The earliest of these organizations was the “General Secretariat for the Study and Combat of Bolshevism.” The founder was Eduard Stadtler, who had been a leader in the youth wing of the Centre Party before the war and was then taken as a prisoner of war in Russia, from which, however, he returned before the end of the war. According to his later report, he threw himself into hectic activity as early as November 1918 to save Germany from the fate of Russia, and found the support of authoritative politicians such as Friedrich Naumann and Karl Helfferich. On January 10, 1919, he gave a speech in the Aviators’ Club at a meeting of the business leaders, attended by captains of industry and banking magnates such as Hugo Stinnes, Albert Vögler, Felix Deutsch, Arthur Salomonsohn and others. Stadtler’s invocations had the extraordinary success of creating an *anti-Bolshevik fund*, into which, according to his claim, no less than 500 million marks were paid; and these funds then flowed through all possible channels into the “powerful anti-Bolshevik movement” that began in early January, such as the Freikorps, which used large posters and expensive newspaper advertisements, to recruit volunteers to protect their homeland from Bolshevism and from the Poles, in the Citizens’ Council movement, the “Anti-Bolshevik League,” the “Association for Combating Bolshevism,” and similar organizations. Stadtler himself wrote a brochure entitled “Bolshevism and Overcoming It.” In it he displays a surprisingly high degree of appreciation and objectivity, and only at the very end does the word *pestilence* appear. No anti-Semitism is perceptible, as the list of donors probably already suggests. And this pronounced anti-Bolshevism was only a soon to be temporary phase in Stadtler’s activity, in his eyes obviously the result of a temporary emergency situation.

Another militant anti-Bolshevik organization, which was mentioned by the communists themselves much more frequently than, for example, the “Anti-Bolshevik League” and whose name was often used as a collective name for Freikorps, self-defense groups, etc. was the “Organization Escherich.” In its beginnings and its basic character, it was a bourgeois self-defense organization that was not to be limited to Bavaria and which made the following main demands: safeguarding the constitution; protection of persons, work and property; preservation of the German Reich and rejection of any attempts at secession; maintenance of peace and order, and defending against any right-wing or left-wing coup. The main practical task was certainly only formulated in the last demand. Also among the ten theses that were put forward in October 1920, “combating Bolshevism and National Bolshevism; rejection of all efforts aimed at the decomposition of the people” is only the third item. But here this point is particularly emphasized, as the explanation already shows, in which numerous subversive statements by leaders of the Communist Party of Germany are cited. Escherich’s particular merit is emphasized, however, that he had succeeded in “what in Bavaria was a feat of strength, to keep anti-Semitism at bay.”

If one wants to visualize the prerequisites from which grew the anti-Bolshevik organization that was soon to become the best known and historically most important, then one must not limit oneself to the excited nationalism of officers like Ernst Röhm and to the anti-Marxist socialism of Gottfried Feder, but one has to look at the circle of Baltic and Russian emigrants and people close to them who had found a rallying point in Munich. The most important man among them was the poet Dietrich Eckart, who had already advocated a kind of mystical anti-Judaism in his magazine *Auf gut deutsch* from the end of 1918, but was only driven to practical and party-like activity through the experience of the Bavarian Soviet Republic. In the starting point, this was guided by feelings very similar to those expressed in those sentences of Thomas Mann. The core of the experience was the same for both: the fear of annihilation of the bourgeois and educated minority in the face of the threatening proletarian masses, and in both cases this was connected with an interpretation, with which one tried to make this threat understandable and controllable, namely the challenge of a foreigner leadership class. But what was the momentary mood and temporary impulse for Thomas Mann became for Dietrich Eckart the center of a worldview and the political activity resulting from it.

It is very doubtful, however, whether the threat of the revolutionary tribunal and even the murder of the hostages in the Luitpold Gymnasium would have had such grave consequences if the concrete presence of Russian experiences had not given this fear of annihilation a monumental and convincing background. One of the men who was able to pass this experience on to Eckart was Dr. Max Erwin von Scheubner-Richter, who had been active for a time as the German vice-consul in Erzurum during the World War and had tried with all his might to oppose the expulsion and extermination of the Armenian population by the Turks, which he evidently perceived as *asiatic*. But in 1918 he returned to his homeland in Riga, and here he had seen how the Baltic aristocracy, and, in practice, the Baltic Germans as a whole were declared *outlaws* by the invading Bolsheviks from Russia and by the native Bolsheviks and made the object of a policy of extermination, which did not seem to differ fundamentally from those Armenian massacres, although of course Scheubner-Richter also knew that these Baltic Germans were a numerically small upper class. Then he went to Munich, where in 1921 he founded his “Economic and Political Reconstruction Correspondence on Eastern Issues and Their Significance for Germany,” which closely followed the events in Russia and produced numerous translations from the Russian émigré press. He also organized the emigre congress in Bad Reichenhall, which in June 1921 brought together numerous monarchists who, in their speeches, spoke out most sharply against the Bolsheviks as a “gang of foreign criminals and fanatics,” but also against the Cadets [*translator: the Constitutional Democratic Party in Russia; not military cadets*]

because they had betrayed Russia together with the the British and the French. In the German press, this congress was met mainly with the worried contempt which is often shown to the defeated who do not want to admit their defeat, and even the *Neue Zürcher Zeitung* spoke of the “right-wing Bolsheviks” had gathered in the Bavarian spa town with the tolerance of the von Kahr government, while the *Vorwärts* [newspaper of the Social Democratic Party] saw “new Koblenz” [city in Germany that was a gathering point for French royalists emigres during the French Revolution] emerge from reactionaries. But there is no doubt that to these men the reports that many contemporaries regarded as gross exaggerations were credible, such as those that the rule of Bolshevism, including those who died from starvation, claimed no fewer than 35 million victims. And just as credible for them was the news that *Berlingske Tidende* had brought a few months earlier and which appeared a little later in the *Völkischer Beobachter* was: the *Chinese Cheka* was now committing the worst of all atrocities imaginable: they were placing a rat in a pipe or in a cage placed on the body of a convict and by igniting a fire forcing the animal to eat its way through.

But in principle, Winston Churchill and Thomas Mann could also have believed such reports. A qualitatively new interpretation becomes visible, however, if one looks at the brochure of another Baltic who also belonged to Dietrich Eckart's circle: Alfred Rosenberg's “Plague in Russia.” Its core is the combination of two facts, which cannot be denied as such, but rather need to be corrected in their detail: the downfall of the “national Russian intelligentsia” and the bourgeoisie, on the one hand, and the high proportion of “Jews,” i.e. people of Jewish origin, in the leading positions of the party and the Soviet government, on the other hand. From this Rosenberg turns the planned extermination of all culture and all freedom through “foreigner” elements and especially Judaism. Unlike the Latvians, Chinese and Caucasians, in fact, the Jews, as a “red International,” are only adopting the principle of their own “golden International,” capitalism, with the aim of creating “a centralized and organized slave state.” However, one must go deeper into history. The Cheka, for example, is certainly linked with the tsarist Okhrana in some respects, but it was far from being able to “operate so coldly, organize it in such a planned manner and carry it out so systematically and soullessly” because it was still allowed to ascribe to a “European character.” The Jews of the Cheka, however, are resuming the old struggle of Islam and the Mongol armies and are nothing other than a “new deployment of the Near Eastern spirit against Europe.” This attack now puts Germany back in the center of world events, because the plague that destroyed Russia will now also destroy Germany, if a new and yet again old-Germanic worldview of German men does not in time confront the “un-Völkish internationalism” and conquer the “Asiatic-Syrian spirit hostile to us all” by tearing Germany out of the fateful path of “Kerensky fiasco” and making possible the “atonement for the atrocities of the Jewish terrorists.”

Nothing would be more unfounded than to assert that the anti-Bolshevism of Eckart, Scheubner-Richter and Rosenberg were isolated, curious or even incomprehensible in the contemporary world. But at the same time it has specific characteristics that do not allow similar-sounding statements by Thomas Mann, Churchill or Kautsky to be used for comparison without restrictions. The peculiarity lies above all in the historical-theoretical explanatory value that is ascribed to anti-Semitism, so that a historical mythology has to emerge that aims to be a counter-image to the Marxist theory of history and can only all too easily come into opposition to all that really characterizes Europe in history: to Christianity and the Renaissance, to the Enlightenment and German idealism, to capitalism *and* socialism. But another new quality was achieved when this theory, which was already far removed from its empirical basis, was made the source of an agitational and mass-effective worldview. It is precisely here that Adolf Hitler's typological place can be found.

Adolf Hitler adored no one as much as Dietrich Eckart, only Scheubner-Richter he called "irreplaceable" with strong emphasis after his death at the Feldherrnhalle, only with Alfred Rosenberg he was in permanent contact throughout his whole life as the leading head of the *Völkischer Beobachter*, even if he denied him a powerful government position for a long time. Yet there is no doubt that Hitler's anti-Semitism pre-dated his acquaintance with these men. In some accounts, he looks like a relic of Lueger's anti-Semitism and Schönerer's anti-Habsburg yearning for a Greater Germany; Walter Laqueur even claimed that anti-Bolshevism was not even present in Hitler during the post-war years and that he did not pay much attention to Russia.

In fact, the first conclusive document from Hitler's own hand, the letter to a certain Gemlich, which he wrote at the request of his superior as an *education officer* of the Reichswehr on September 16, 1919, i.e. before his *party days*, is almost entirely filled with conventional anti-Semitism: Judaism is characterized above all by the "dance around the golden calf," and as the main power of "mammonism," it represents the "racial tuberculosis of the peoples," which can only be successfully fought by a "government of national force" whose ultimate goal is "unalterable" to remove the Jews altogether. Only towards the end is there a comment in a subordinate clause that the Jews "were also the driving forces behind the revolution."

Furthermore, it cannot be denied that in the speeches from 1919 to 1921, which Hitler held for the still quite insignificant "German Workers' Party" or the NSDAP, the dictates of Versailles and slogans such as "Germany alone" were quantitatively in the foreground.

But the question is where the most moving impulse appears. And there is much to suggest that

the recurring “annihilation of the intelligentsia” or the “mass murder of the intelligentsia” was such an impulse and that no warning was meant more urgently than the one that in Germany no conditions like those in Russia should arise with the “300,000 executions” of the recent years; the “slaughter of the intellectuals” in the “Russian charnel house” would find its repetition in Germany if a national “counter-dictatorship” did not remedy the “unfortunate tearing apart of the nation into two classes that are now deadly hostile to each other.” The interpretation and explanation almost always follow immediately: that it is a question of a “Jewish blood dictatorship,” that the Jew is “the leech” and the “strangler.”

But now and then a different tone becomes audible. In a report on a speech given in May 1921 it says: “Hitler addresses words of deepest seriousness to his handicraft brothers: Let go of your prejudice against the other classes of your people, the bourgeoisie that you see on the big screen does not live with champagne and parties, the officer that is portrayed to you in your Jewish newspapers does not exist, it is not the student who would like to force you under a knot, see the reality...this is what the healthy sections of the bourgeoisie looks like. And the rest of you, do not see the worker as the fatherless journeyman...it is not the German worker who robs and plunders, free him from his seducers. The hour of birth of the new German people strikes in deep distress.”

There is almost no anti-Semitism to be felt here. Here and elsewhere, Hitler presents himself as a champion of *class reconciliation* in the interests of the national power or even welfare state, from the standpoint of the *national intelligentsia*, which he apparently counts himself as a member. The turning against the Marxist doctrine of class struggle is the decisive factor and the view of the destruction of the intelligentsia by Bolshevism is the most moving. It is quite possible that such anti-Marxism was in line with history; at least that is how it has developed in all Western states. Certainly this core is also passionate in itself. This is clearly evident in the issue of the *Völkischer Beobachter* of April 10, 1920, where it says under the headline “The Outlawed Bourgeoisie”: “Let the Bolsheviks do whatever they want with the ‘Burschoa,’ the Chancellor (Müller) will not lift the smallest finger for them...There is no point in somehow covering up the hard facts or even glossing over them. The bourgeoisie has now got under the wheels and will be crushed more and more every day if it does not pull itself out of its inactivity by force.” As a clear example from a somewhat later time is an appeal by the party leadership of the NSDAP shortly after the Rathenau murder: “Do you want to see thousands of Germans at the lampposts in every city first? Do you want to wait until, like in Russia, Bolshevik murder squads become operational in every city and transports anyone who does not want to submit to the dictatorship to kingdom come as a ‘counter-revolutionary’? Do you want to stumble over the corpses of your wives and

children, who, just as in Moscow and Petersburg, must be neutralized because they are the 'multipliers of the bourgeoisie'? 'No,' you will yell. And yet we say to you: all of this will happen here with the same regularity as in Russia, if you don't remember that you must fight now if you want to live."

One word in this appeal has been omitted. Without this word, these sentences, like the previous ones, would be a call for decisive self-defense, as is obvious and fully justified in a civil war, as soon as this civil war has actually started or even threatens to start. This is the rational core, admittedly under a condition that was not really given even in Germany, and certainly not in the other Western states, and gained credibility only through the Russian example. But the word *Jewish* before *dictatorship* is already an interpretation that closes itself around the core, so to speak.

Apparently, the party of the counter-dictatorship and of the counter-civil war party could not gain any real counter-belief, any excessive counter-passion, which was on a level with the belief and passion of the enemy, from the German threat alone and even from the presence of the Russian example. This is especially true of Adolf Hitler. He was driven to an extraordinary degree by the need to find a fundamental cause, a pathogen, a culprit, and he discovered this culprit in *the Jew*. In doing so, he took a further step on the way of the concretization on which the communists had gone when they replaced the historically outdated system of fully sovereign states with the morally guilty *bourgeoisie*. And Hitler's step was not an arbitrary and merely an accidental one. In a similar way, only in the opposite direction, Karl Marx had made the transition from *the Jews*, who were still considered the cause of mammonism by many early socialists, to *the capitalists* and ultimately to the *capitalist system*, and in connection with this he had transformed the old concept of extermination into the idea of merely pushing away a small group of *capital magnates* who had become an obstacle. So in a certain way Hitler went back to the early socialists and thereby created the possibility of countering the universal doctrine of Marxism not only with the serious and possibly correct words just cited, but also with a passionate and passion-generating doctrine of the calamities of the present world and of its causes stemming from a distant history. This anti-Semitism, however, necessarily led to the equation of capitalism and Bolshevism or of liberalism and socialism as equally international phenomena and thus tended to reject the bourgeoisie it had started from. As a result, however, simple nationalism, the other starting point, was set against opponents so strong and so many that it had to look for a stronger base, for example the *Germanic race*. In a sense, bourgeoisie and nationalism turned against themselves and became an anti-bourgeois and anti-national doctrine, which could thus step onto the same broad level as Marxism.

The real and most moving experience of Hitler, reinforced but not generated by the environment of Eckart, Scheubner-Richter and Rosenberg, was thus in all probability the experience of Bolshevism or communism, which, according to Hitler's understanding, caused the German defeat through its agitation, which divided the nation through its doctrine of the irreducible opposition between *bourgeoisie* and *proletariat*, and which, following the Russian example, threatened the bourgeoisie or the national intelligentsia with extermination. The expansion to anti-Marxism was obvious, despite the social-democratic hostility to the communists, and was also carried out by Mussolini and Italian fascism. Anti-Semitism, on the other hand, was an interpretation, a key, which on the one hand merely exaggerated and visualized a genuine peculiarity of the enemy, namely the difference between the mostly intellectual leadership and the masses, but which above all allowed the formation of a counter-ideology that tended to universality, and made possible the development of a fanatical counter-passion which Mussolini always stayed away from. As anti-Bolshevism and anti-Marxism, National Socialism belongs to the type of fascist movements; as a doctrine of the Jews as the universally guilty, it represents the most radical manifestation of this type, i.e. it is radical fascism. All of its main features can already be grasped in Hitler's early speeches during 1920 and 1921.

One possible objection is that Hitler was an anti-Semite in Vienna even before the war, that is, that his anti-Semitism was more original than its alleged core, anti-Bolshevism. But from Hitler's later account in "Mein Kampf" it emerges with great clarity that the reason for the experience here, too, was a great and vivid social event, namely the massive demonstrations by the socialist workers. And a look at the anti-Bolshevism of contemporaries proves that at least one logical distinction can be made between fear-inducing experience and ideology-producing key.

Undoubtedly correct would be the objection that even in his early days Hitler was by no means *only* an anti-Semitic anti-Bolshevik or anti-Marxist, but that his motives were diverse and connected to his contemporaries to a very different extent.

He shared the motive for the struggle against Versailles with almost all Germans and beyond that with all *revisionists* in Europe, not least with Soviet Russia, where Lenin emphasized no less emphatically than Hitler that Versailles was far worse than Brest-Litovsk.

Just as clearly recognizable, but no longer shared by all Germans, was the Greater Germany motif, which in Hitler's case often implied the invocation of the right to self-determination.

Only in 1919 and 1920 the motif of living space hinted at became noticeable, linked to a Darwinian-radical-liberal conception of natural law: it was unjust that a Russian should have 18 times as much space as a German. Probably very few of his compatriots would have agreed with the equation of farmland and tundra on which the argument depended, but nevertheless a genuine experience lay at the bottom of it, the experience of the English blockade and German rule in Russia between Brest-Litovsk and the collapse.

The anti-Bolshevik motif was the most European among Hitler's motives; he shared it with almost all bourgeois Europeans and Americans, and the term *bourgeois* must be understood in the broad sense that includes the Social Democrats or right-wing socialists. But in his case it was particularly sharply opposed to philo-Bolshevism, which was also a bourgeois phenomenon, albeit a marginal one. Above all, it was so sharpened and exacerbated by its extension to anti-Marxism and even anti-liberalism, that it was far removed from generality.

An extraordinary concretization took place through the anti-Semitic motive, which allowed a synthesis: the Jews were to be seen as the cause of Germany's defeat and, above all, of its internal turmoil, which prevented the natural relationship of German rule over Europe from being realized and a definitive security against the Jew-induced threats of annihilation by Bolshevism and Americanism from being achieved. With this motive as well, Hitler was isolated neither in Germany nor in Europe, for strong traditions of both the left and the right pointed in this direction. But in their totality, their inner allocation and above all in the unbridled passion that they generated and by which they were in turn sustained, they were nevertheless something individual. If one were to say that Hitler was even more of a German, indeed a European citizen, than a bourgeois German, then something right would be struck and yet again a wrong way be taken, because he would be identified with too many other people. In the inner necessity of opposing the communist main opponent with an adequate counter-belief, Hitler was in some ways anti-bourgeois and anti-German at the same time: unacknowledgedly, the hated horror-vision was for him, in a certain way, at the same time, the guiding role model.

But for the first two motives it is already true that in the radical form that Hitler's passion gave them, they could only be implemented in reality through a "revolutionary totalism," and if they are all taken together, then there is no doubt that a kind of affirmation of war that was alien, indeed unknown, to the German Kaiser and the Russian Tsar in 1914, and to which only the affirmation of war and civil war by the Bolsheviks was analogous, which, however, in terms of purpose and ideological background, represented the exact opposite.

Thus, even in those early years, when hardly anyone in Germany knew him and when even in Munich he was regarded just as a drummer and demagogue, Adolf Hitler occupied a distinctive typological place within the framework of anti-Bolshevism, which was by no means merely a German, but a pan-European, yes, even a *pan-Western* phenomenon. But until July 1921 he was only the *promoter* of a tiny party, while the Communists had been the focus of public attention for three years. Then, however, he demanded and received *dictatorial powers*. As the strongest embodiment of a counter-belief and a counter-passion, he was able to create the Führer-party, which could oppose that other “vanguard party” (as Lenin had put it) as a tendentious peer and strive for its destruction. The year 1923 was the year of the greatest crisis in the German Reich and its capitalist or bourgeois system, and it was to bring the opposing possibilities of destruction to light just as clearly as the survival of the system and the mere and temporally limited ban of the two extreme wings of its party landscape.

Chapter II, Section 5

“World Revolution” or “National Government” in Germany? The Crisis Year of 1923

The defeat of the German Reich in the World War was not completed with the request for an armistice and the acceptance of the Versailles Peace. It was renewed twice more through attempts to resist further demands or measures by the opponents: in 1921, when the Fehrenbach government broke off negotiations after the first fixing of an outrageous amount of reparation and the Allies then forced the Wirth government to *accept* their ultimatum; and in 1923, when the French and Belgians occupied the Ruhr area with a justification that was little more than a pretext and thus began something like a war in peace. The decidedly bourgeois government of the Hamburg industrialist Cuno was in office in Berlin, although a sharp jolt to the left had passed across the country twice: after August 1921, because of the assassination of Erzberger; and after June 24, 1922 as a result of the assassination of Rathenau. Nevertheless, the Cuno government felt that it was strong enough to call for “passive resistance” and to appeal to the “national community.” In substance, this meant a general strike sanctioned and paid for by the state, which the French and Belgians, who now hardly received any coal deliveries, tried to counter with an host of coercive measures. The communists, however, called for the beating of Poincaré on the Ruhr and Cuno on the Spree. They thus excluded themselves from the national community as the Spartacus League had done during the World War, and again demanded a castle-war to replace the castle-peace [*translator: i.e. calling for a civil war*]. As early as April and May, they were able to take the lead in many places, not just in the Ruhr, in “wage movements, strikes, hunger demonstrations, looting of stores, food requisitions by urban workers in the countryside,” as Clara Zetkin later told the participants in the 5th World Congress of the Comintern in June/July of 1924. As inflation—caused primarily by extraordinary government spending but boosted by stock market maneuvers by German entrepreneurs and speculators—was spreading ever further and faster, and as separatist tendencies were emerging, the

Communists believed the situation was revolutionary, and with great energy they began to prepare for civil war. This was also reported on with great frankness at the 5th Congress: "We organized combat cadres, we set up schools in the form of red officers to train our comrades with military skills, we formed partisan groups, special commissions for railroad workers, we went to organize for the first time an Intelligence service ... which had as its task counter-espionage, spy detection, etc..." In fact, a so-called M (military) and an N (intelligence) apparatus was set up on behalf of the Comintern, as well as a special military-political (MP) Organization launched as a cadre organization for a Red Army. A Soviet general became MP national leader, and Germany was divided into six MP upper districts, headed by Soviet generals as advisors in addition to the German officers. At the same time a terror (T) apparatus was created to eliminate informers and organize individual attacks in preparation for mass terror.

However, the communists were not the only ones who acted in a violent manner or prepared for military conflict. Sabotage squads of former Freikorps fighters went over to active resistance in the Ruhr area, and in Bavaria numerous *national associations*, among them the SA of the NSDAP, prepared for the civil war. In May, the French sentenced to death one of the men who had blown up bridges, former Baltic fighter Albert Leo Schlageter, and shot him near Düsseldorf despite vehement German protests. The unmistakable strength of the Right now prompted the communists to supplement their preparations with a new kind of political line, the so-called Schlageter course. On June 20, 1923, Karl Radek gave his famous speech "Leo Schlageter, the wanderer into nowhere" in Moscow, with which he tried to convince the activist Right that they must take the side of the fighting workers if they really wanted to initiate national liberation along the lines of Gneisenau and Scharnhorst [*translator: Prussian generals during the War of Liberation against Napoleon*]. Only when the cause of the people is made the cause of the nation can the cause of the nation become the cause of the people, because only then would that *iron phalanx* of intellectuals and manual laborers arise, which belong in the camp of labor and not in the camp of capital. Throughout the summer, communists and representatives of the national Right then discussed with each other, and Radek put forward extremely interesting theses such as the following: "...if the German working class will not be able to convince the great petty-bourgeois masses of this belief (in overcoming of hardship together as the only way out), it will be defeated or at least have to postpone its victory for a long time." Radek named the "workers' government" as the correct method, which would include left-wing socialists as well as communists and would win above all the sympathy of those petty-bourgeois masses, because it would "courageously prepare also, if necessary, the armed struggle against the Versailles bailiffs." Even towards the actual fascists, the followers of Hitler and Ludendorff, Radek showed a certain respect:

while the communists were approaching the conquest of the majority of the most active arbiters in Germany by constantly holding countless meetings, the Social Democrats were deathly quiet, and active force of counter-revolution was now among the fascists.

Here and there, in the context of the Schlageter course, there were even outright offers of alliance. Ruth Fischer, one of the main representative of the left in the party, is said to have said to students on July 25, 1923 in the auditorium of the Dorotheenstädtisches Gymnasium: "Anyone who calls against Jewish capital is already a class fighter, even if he doesn't know it...That's right! Trample down the Jewish capitalists, hang them on the lamppost, tread on them. But, gentlemen, what is your position on the big capitalists, Stinnes and Klöckner?" It may be that the reporter Franz Pfemfert allowed poetic license in his rendering of the expressions, but there are enough comparable statements both in 1923 and later, to justify the claim that in unguarded moments many communists would have considered National Socialist anti-Semitism welcome, insofar as it applied to bourgeois Jews, as an early and minor form of the actual communist intention of extermination.

But on the whole there can be no doubt that the Communist Party of Germany did not simply want to neutralize the actual fascists, the followers of Hitler and Ludendorff, but rather to exterminate them, although Radek, like Hitler and Ludendorff, saw Germany "in the deepest impotence and humiliation" and declared "pacifist phrases in the mouths of the representatives of a subjugated and dismembered people" to be "cowardice or a lie" which all healthy instincts of the people would have to revolt against. Thus, on July 12, the party leadership demanded that every fifth fascist be put up against the wall if the fascists wanted to shoot every tenth striking worker, and in April the *Rote Fahne* published the long report of a communist who had fled to Russia, which made it clear that the impending revolution was not viewed as a mere internal German event: "the Russian bourgeoisie in its hour of death" also tried with exactly the same means as the German bourgeoisie is doing today, namely with a nationalistic appeal to the proletariat to extend their lives for a reprieve. In conversation with the commander-in-chief of the Western Front, Comrade Tukhachevsky, the reporter, as the representative of the headquarters of the Communist Party of Germany, had convinced himself that the Red Army was enthusiastically ready to come to the aid of the German proletariat and that there were no obstacles whatsoever for it in doing so: "The Russian army will trample like a stalk the Polish rampart that would separate it from the German proletariat in the hour of destiny."

The Communist Party achieved its greatest success when the mass strikes and demonstrations it led forced the resignation of the Cuno government on August 12. It seems that Gustav

Stresemann, who succeeded him with the help of the Social Democrats, saw himself as the *last card* in a situation that could shortly bring about a revolutionary overthrow and thus the disintegration of the German Reich. But precisely because the Social Democrats were so heavily involved in the government, the resolute Right around the German Nationalists sought a more energetic *government of the national dictatorship* .

Thus three preparatory strands ran side by side. Stresemann broke off the passive resistance, which in the meantime had completely shattered the German currency on September 26th, and created great and general hope with the announcement of new and stable money. The German Nationalists put their trust in General von Seeckt, counted on Bavaria of the State Commissioner General von Kahr, or drafted plans for the *National Directory* . Heinrich Brandler went to Moscow and held long discussions with the Soviet leaders, who were equally enthusiastic about the impending German revolution. So the *German October* came.

Encouraging letters from Trotsky, Zinoviev, Bukharin and Stalin appeared in the *Rote Fahne* . Stalin's letter was addressed to August Thalheimer and read as follows: "The coming revolution in Germany is the most important world event of our day. The victory of the revolution in Germany will have greater significance for the proletariat in Europe and America than the victory of the Russian revolution six years ago. The victory of the German proletariat will undoubtedly move the center of the world revolution from Moscow to Berlin..." Zinoviev published a long series of articles in the *Inprekorr* on "Problems of the German Revolution," which in an almost touching manner speaks about the relief of the Marxists who have fallen into "underdeveloped conditions" to see a "classic proletarian revolution" is at last imminent, and so he managed to utter a sentence which may look generous from the Russian perspective, and yet demonstrates in clear light the profound implausibility of Radek's wooing of the petty bourgeois or national masses: precisely because Germany has a majority of proletarians, the German proletariat, "at least in the beginning," would not brutally disregard the vital interests of the urban petty bourgeoisie.

At the beginning of October, the communists joined the *workers' governments* in Saxony and Thuringia, where *proletarian hundred-men squads* had already been formed for some time. The party leader Heinrich Brandler then, in his new capacity as ministerial director of the State Chancellery in Dresden, according to his own later testimony, thereafter dealt almost exclusively with the procurement of weapons. At a work council conference in Chemnitz on October 21, the general strike was to be called, setting into motion the struggle for power. But although the slogans of defense against the "Bavarian Fascists" were very popular, the allied left-socialists and basically also the masses refused to start a civil war with the

offensive intention that was guiding the Soviet as well as the German party leadership. Only in Hamburg did the uprising break out as a result of an error in information transmission, which the local police were able to put down, though with difficulty and with considerable losses. Stresemann acted quickly and with great decisiveness: he ordered Reichswehr troops to deploy into Saxony and Thuringia and put a Reich commissar in the place of the Saxon government of the left-wing Social Democrat Dr. Pointer. 23 people died in Freiberg when an excited crowd insulted the Reichswehr troops and tried to attack them with their bare hands or with primitive weapons. Meanwhile, there was no significant active resistance offered. An important consequence, however, was that now the Social Democrats left the Stresemann government because they were offended by the fact that Stresemann did not act as vigorously against the Bavarian reactionaries and National Socialists as he did against the Saxon communists and left-wing Social Democrats. But the planned *national revolution* in Bavaria failed, as did the *German October*. However, one was related to the other, and both attempts at revolution were both offensive as well as defensive. Whoever focuses only on one of them, sees only the half of the most crisis-ridden years of the German nation-state.

Admittedly, there is a great temptation to view the Hitler putsch and its prehistory as a local Bavarian event and, in this context, even as a kind of macabre celebration: the English term "beer hall putsch" inevitably leads in this direction. And the events cannot be recounted in detail if one does not look at the names and the location of certain brewhouses i.e. taverns: the Löwenbräukeller was not far from the main train station, the Hofbräuhaus was near the town hall, the Bürgerbräukeller was across the Isar between the Deutsches Museum and the Maximilianeum. Here a good part of Bavarian politics was actually made at regulars' tables and in large gatherings, their popular outer skin, so to speak, was full of local color. In truth, however, Bavarian politics was always German and European politics at the same time, also in its monarchist and separatist tendencies, which were generally geared towards something like a Danube alliance. Between the end of the soviet government and the Hitler putsch, a plethora of *patriotic associations* of very different character were active: the Teutonic Order, the Thule Society, the Bavarian League, the Bavaria and Reich League, the German People's Protection and Defense League, the Oberland League, the Reich Flag, the Organization Escherich, etc. In this context, the NSDAP was only a small component, which, however, from mid-1922 onwards, through stronger militancy, more and more achieved a certain, but by no means unambiguously clear, predominance. Nevertheless, hardly more than half of the Munich population sympathized with it, even if you include the ruling Bavarian People's Party, because even after May 1919 Marxism remained a strong force, and the communists had by no means disappeared. On May 1, 1923, they dared to unfurl Soviet flags inside the trains of demonstrating trade union members, the stars of which were mistaken for *Jewish*

stars not only by Adolf Hitler. The mass meetings of the NSDAP had longed since ceased to be disturbed by them, but in the spring of 1922 there were still heated discussion and that Adolf Hitler turned to a "comrade of the German Communist Party" to enlighten him.

The *entire Ministry* of the Free State of Bavaria was therefore involved in a struggle on three fronts: against the encroachments of the Reich government on Bavarian statehood, against *Marxism*, which was constantly viewed as a great danger, and finally against the nationalist combat groups, including the NSDAP. They came to terms with the Reich again and again: in 1921, the Bavarian People's Party replaced Prime Minister von Kahr with Count Lerchenfeld, because he had taken too harsh a position, and at the end of 1922, Lerchenfeld was replaced with von Killing because the shift towards Reich piety had gone too far. There were no great differences between social democrats and communists, and that is why the Bavarian People's Party politician Fritz Schäffer could say that he did not love the NSDAP, but that he was in full agreement with them in their opposition to Marxism. The government considered Ludendorff, the Quartermaster General of the World War, to be the greater danger because all the military associations seemed to listen to him, and the only really good relationship was with the emphatically federalist associations such as the "the Bavaria and Reich League" of the Pittinger Medical Council.

All the events of 1923 actually took place in close connection with the events in the Reich.

Hitler took an extreme position on the occupation of the Ruhr, which was an exact complement to the communist demand for civil war: first a general settlement of accounts with the "November criminals," the "louts in their own country," was necessary, and only then could the defensive fight against France have a prospect of success.

On May 1, 1923, there was almost a serious clashes between the national associations, the Reichswehr and the demonstrating trade unionists, and Hitler suffered a considerable loss of prestige.

On September 1 and 2, "German Day" took place in Nuremberg with great pomp. After that, a "combat alliance" of several military associations was created, including the SA of the NSDAP, which had developed more and more into a military association since its beginnings as a hall protection and "gymnastics and sports department." Lieutenant Colonel Kriebel became military leader and Adolf Hitler took over political leadership. At the same time, *military* divisions were made by two *civilian* sides, by the Communists and by the National Socialists.

On September 26th, von Kahr was appointed "General State Commissioner," i.e. dictator alongside the continuing government within the non-military state of emergency. The corresponding state of emergency in the Reich followed immediately on its heels, and severe tensions developed between Munich and Berlin. The crux of the matter was that several concepts of *national government* existed side by side. Should it come about in the extremely difficult situation through a reshuffle of the Stresemann government, should Stresemann be replaced by a "national directorate," or should a "march on Berlin" from Bavaria under the orders of Kahrs and the commander of the Bavarian Reichswehr Division von Lossow be set in motion? In the third case, what would the position of Hitler and Ludendorff be, without whose support the enterprise could not succeed?

Hitler was convinced that only he was up to the situation, because he already felt that he was no longer merely a "drummer." In his speeches one can still distinguish between the rationally conceived experience and the interpretation that goes beyond it and is used as a *key*. At the end of October 1922, for example, he said that the members of the people who had a Marxist stance were not less than 40%, and that they were the most active and energetic. In doing so, he was essentially claiming the same thing as Radek: the active majority of the working class had already been conquered by the communists. A statement made at the beginning of September 1923 had the same meaning: the will of the communists directed by Moscow was tougher than that of such squishy philistines as Stresemann. Communist statements also corresponded to the statement that for Marxists, as Russia shows, there were only the winners and the exterminated. It can be assumed that Hitler was really convinced that a Kerensky government was at the helm in Berlin and that in Central Germany there was already the Soviet Saxony. Nevertheless, he always insisted that this truly desperate situation had the Jews as its originators.

Also informative is an article by Max von Scheubner-Richter, which the *Völkischer Beobachter* published on September 21 under the title "Germany's Bolshevization" in four columns on the first page. Scheubner-Richter begins by expressing his deep bitterness over the blindness of the leading German men who do not want to see "how dangerously and systematically the Bolshevization of Germany is from Moscow by the Moscow representative, Mr. Radek." He said that this danger had been clear to him since he noticed in the last year of the war what dangerous effects the German propaganda for the disintegration of the Russian army must have on his own soldiers. His urgent advice to set up a friendly Russian national government was not heeded. Since then, the internal enemy has been spreading its poison almost unhindered, and business circles are heavily to blame. So today the day is probably not far off "when the blood-red banner of Mr. Radek will rise on the

palace of the Reich President in place of the black-red-yellow standard of Mr. Ebert." But in the last hour a new prophet had arisen for "volkish Germany," namely Adolf Hitler, and so the closing words sound confident in spite of everything: "And the battle will be fought under the slogan 'Here the Soviet star—here the swastika.' And the swastika will win."

Almost on the same day, September 26th, the *Inprekorr* carried the following sentence: "The Soviet star is already gaining more and more weight over the swastika."

Hitler took no notice of the far-reaching measures taken by Stresemann regarding Saxony and Thuringia: he lived in the dichotomy, no different from the communists.

His coup on the evening of November 8 must be seen as an attempt to shift the leadership of the struggle from the incompetent hands of the Kahr, Lossow and Seisser to those of the *prophet* i.e. into his own. The curious circumstances and the inadequate preparation of this coup should not lead to the judgment that it was hopeless from the outset and that it was merely a local event. In the rest of Germany, too, quite a few men and units were ready to join a *march on Berlin*, and no one knows with certainty whether this time there would have been "Reichswehr on Reichswehr" fire if the Bavarian division had moved north. Undoubtedly, remarkable analogies can be drawn to the coup d'état by the Bolsheviki in Petrograd, although in Munich the main motive was not a yearning for peace, but a national and social self-assertion in a dangerous situation. Even Hitler's repeatedly attested fear that his people might "radicalize themselves to the left" and go over to the communists had a counterpart in Petrograd insofar as Lenin apparently not a little feared the prevalence of an unconquerable wave of anarchism and separatism. The failure was by no means inevitable; its immediate cause was the frivolous trust Ludendorff placed in von Lossow's word of honor of an officer that that he do nothing against the "new government." But if Hitler, as a far more popular Kapp, had actually been able to establish himself in Berlin alongside Ludendorff, the commander-in-chief of the army, the Western Allies would undoubtedly have intervened, and the German Reich did not have the Russian spaces to successfully defend itself against well-armed intervention troops. The alternative given of *the Soviet star* or *the swastika* turned out to be wrong, but the result of the fight that did not take place was, figuratively speaking, far closer to Munich than to Dresden or Moscow: On the evening of November 8, based on the news about the Hitler coup, Berlin implemented a version of those *national* plans, namely the transfer of executive power to the chief of army command. In the four months during which von Seeckt exercised the dictatorship, the new currency unit of the Rentenmark was introduced, separatism was crushed and a kind of liberating capitulation was made to France: the Weimar Republic embarked on the path of stabilization.

Chapter II, Section 6

The Soviet Union from the Death of Lenin to the Establishment of Stalin's Autocracy

The stabilization of the Weimar Republic meant the preservation and further development of a social system which, despite all the differences in detail, was common to the German Reich and the states of the West and to whose creation and development the Germans had made an important contribution. The popular word *capitalism* aimed at one part or aspect of the system, namely the world market economy of its economy. Russia, on the other hand, had followed a path since November 1917 that from the beginning was dissimilar to this system, so much so that there was no convincing analogy in the history of Europe. Since the development of Russia was in this respect *new*, it is appropriate to consider it before the further history of Germany.

The fact that Bolshevik Russia of 1923 represented a phenomenon that was unprecedented was easily explained by the doctrine of the ruling party: it showed Europe its own future in an as yet unformed shape; it constituted the paradigmatic impetus through which Europe would arrive at its own future of a classless society by finally leaving its past behind and thus also helping Russia to develop a complete communist society. In the last years of his life, however, Lenin came closer and closer to an almost opposite view, according to which his work appeared to him as the opening of a special path for Russia to modernity, which was essentially different from the main path taken in Europe because the conditions were different, above all the backwardness of the country the unsophisticated nature of its inhabitants. *That is why* the European multi-party system, universal suffrage and the national parliament were incapable of solving the tasks at hand, and that is why Lenin unabashedly placed himself and his party in parallel with the tsar and his nobility, that is why he oriented himself towards the German war economy and that is why he could no longer see in Marx an advisor and helper. Nevertheless, he did not come to the obvious conclusion that Russia,

through him and the Bolshevik party, had become a developmental dictatorship, which must follow Europe in other ways and which one day in the distant future would be reconciled and reunited with Europe on a new basis. Rather, he held firmly to the negative part of Marx's teaching, namely the critique of "old Europe" and the conviction of the imminent "downfall of the world bourgeoisie," but the Russian Revolution was no longer the paradigmatic impetus for the classic Marxist revolution in Europe, but for a new kind of upheaval in the colonial and semicolonial areas of the world rising up against the "imperialist plundering and oppression of the majority of the world's population." Thus Lenin did not abandon the term *world revolution*, even though he had a clear view of the Russian special path and although the old hostility to the bourgeoisie was transformed into a new contrast to the *old* or *bourgeois* Europe, including its *worker aristocracy*.

Nobody knows what advice Lenin would have given his students and followers if he had not already been terminally ill by the autumn of 1923. This much is certain, that the hope of a return to the original concept through the victory of the revolution in Germany was the last emotion in which Trotsky and Stalin, Zinoviev and Bukharin agreed. Immediately after the German October, the dispute over Lenin's succession broke out openly, and it took place first as a dispute over the Russian October, which itself became controversial in light of the *lessons of the German events*. Trotsky on the one hand, Zinoviev and Stalin on the other, took sides with one or the other grouping of the Communist Party of Germany, Trotsky like Radek first for Brandler, Zinoviev for Ruth Fischer and the leftists, and then in the fall of 1924 Trotsky with his *lessons of October*, opened the attack on the triumvirate of Zinoviev, Stalin and Kamenev, who had taken advantage of Trotsky's illness to seize the reins. Trotsky presented himself here as Lenin's best pupil, in some respects even his teacher, and opened old wounds by denouncing Stalin's non-Leninist attitude in the weeks after the February Revolution and Zinoviev's and Kamenev's resistance to Lenin's will for an armed insurrection in October. For its part, the triumvirate, allied with men like Bukharin, Bela Kun and Otto Kuusinen, led a violent attack not only against Trotsky, but against "Trotskyism," which has always been something different from Leninism and which today must even be regarded as an "hostile system."

This struggle of the top party leaders against each other was mainly conducted as a dispute over party history and party doctrine, with often strange details: Trotsky denied the role of the peasantry, his method was eclectic and not dialectical, his true teacher and pioneer was Parvus; he had taken a wrong position both toward Brest-Litovsk and the NEP, which did not allow a *respite* and which would have brought about defeat; he denied the party's role as the bearer of the consciousness of the proletariat, he was making the "monstrous attempt to use

the German October defeat to pillory the chairman of the Comintern.” Trotsky, for his part, criticized the bureaucracy, the rule of the apparatus, the lack of internal party democracy, and there was no doubt that he had many supporters among the officers of the Red Army and among the student youth. But he was the one who had wanted to *militarize* the trade unions during wartime communism, and many of his arguments could be viewed as mere means by which he wanted to advance his own and all-too-dictatorial pretensions. The distrust that confronted him as a potential *Napoleon* was genuine, and on his side there was a discernible reluctance to take steps that must have given new nourishment to this distrust of the old Bolsheviks. But at its core, the dispute was rooted in the matter and not in personal rivalries, because it revolved around Trotsky’s concept of “permanent revolution” and that of Stalin’s “socialism in one country” which was opposed to it. Ultimately, the question was whether the Communist Party of the Soviet Union could, after the failure of the revolution in Germany, retain power in good conscience and fight for its goal, socialism, or whether it should continue to make its own fate dependent on the success of the Western European *Marxist* revolution. It can be taken as certain that it was Stalin who followed in Lenin's footsteps here, and so it was therefore no mere maneuver in the struggle for succession that Zinoviev, as the pronounced internationalist that he was, joined with Trotsky and Kamenev at the end of 1925 united to form the *new opposition* to Stalin, which was to a special degree an opposition of intellectuals and which Stalin also opposed as a group which, as a small minority, broke away from the current of the party will. There were wider, major factual questions up for decision: the question of a hostile or friendly relationship with the peasantry, the question of the pace of industrialization, the question of bureaucracy, etc. This opposition was emphatically left-wing and had friends among many left-communists in Europe; Stalin, on the other hand, appeared in alliance with Bukharin as a representative of the right, which advocated a slow expansion of the state-economic and industrial sector and in friendly relations with the *middle sized farmers* as allies of the proletariat. In doing so, he prevailed, and certainly not only because he was preparing the apparatus and the party congresses, but also because the *intellectuals* faced much antipathy from the party’s mass following, which the opposition members themselves characterized as “anti-Semitism” in their draft program for the 15th Party Congress. The demand for “free discussion” within the party culminated in street demonstrations in November 1927, and immediately afterwards the party congress expelled the most important members of the Trotskyist opposition from the party. Trotsky himself was exiled to Central Asia shortly thereafter and expelled from the USSR in early 1929.

These years of struggle between Stalin and Trotsky, which occupy a large part in the histories of the party, were, as should not be overlooked, the *good years* of the Soviet Union. The NEP

and the work of the *new bourgeoisie* had led to an astonishing upswing, and compared to the terrible famine of 1920/21, the population was doing very well, because food was now in abundance. Admittedly, industrial production was relatively small, and there was again talk of the gap between the prices of agricultural goods and those of industrial goods. The unemployment rate was quite high. On the whole, however, one could trust in a continuation of the upswing. However, the tone in which the *peasantry* was spoken of in the party discussions of these years was a sign of things to come. According to a statistical compilation from a Soviet work on the "Liquidation of the Exploiting Classes in the USSR," in 1913 there were in Russia 17 million industrial proletarians, 90 million simple peasants, and 22 million *exploiters*, of whom 17 million were *kulaks*. Of these, the bourgeois and landlords were now wiped out, but despite all the losses in war and civil war (which, according to some estimates, amounted to more than 20 million people) the number of kulaks, i.e. the wealthier farmers, were still about the same size as those of the industrial proletarians, and the simple peasants still constituted the vast majority. But even the *rightists* consistently referred to the kulaks as "enemies," and if they called the simple peasants their "allies," it became all too clear that the majority of the population was practically without any representation and that they were regarded by the ruling party as an object to be treated well out of prudence, but to be fought ruthlessly in case of need. And even in the *good years* a peasant would pay a much higher tax than workers for the same amount of income, and one worker's vote counted as much as five peasant votes in the local soviet elections. On the way of indirect elections to higher bodies, the weight of the peasant votes diminished to the point of complete insignificance, and thus the great majority of the inhabitants of the country were like wax in the hands of that "grain," like Lenin had called the all-transforming and even the proletarians "walking and ruffling" party, that is, the all-powerful party leadership. From the socioeconomic point of view, the Bolshevik regime was a harsh dictatorship of the urban proletariat over the peasantry, a regime of severe exploitation and extensive disenfranchisement.

And yet peasants and numerous workers thought longingly back to that time when Stalin had given the go-ahead for the beginning of the "attack on the kulaks" and when all forces were strained to overcome the "petty-bourgeois sentiments that had spread among the working class." Stalin adopted the leftist demands for the elimination of the kulaks as well as the NEP bourgeoisie and for rapid industrialization of the country as soon as Trotsky had been eliminated and the doctrine of *permanent revolution* had been pushed back; this made the struggle against the right wing of the party, which he had been allied until now, inevitable. This time too, Stalin turned out to be Lenin's best student. Bukharin, in spite of all his dissociation from the kulaks, had so resolutely represented the program of *welfare*

communism that he even believed in the abolition of all military orders and only had in mind only the mutually beneficial cooperation between agriculture and industry. In this way, the standard of living was to be raised continuously and the peasants were to “slowly” “grow” into socialism. But this had to mean that the party, which was above all a militant party, no longer had an *enemy* in its own country and would have been restricted in its exercise of power if cooperation and not class struggle had been the slogan. Thus, even in the confrontation with the Right, Stalin had clearly grasped the main Leninist point of view, namely that of preserving, consolidating and maintaining the power of the party, and both his autocracy and collectivization and industrialization would be the direct consequences of the main goals. Thus, in November 1928, Stalin demanded that the rapid pace of development of industry in general, and in particular the production of the means of production, should become the basic principle of the transformation of the entire national economy, and that even the most extreme tension should not be shied away from. Only then would it be possible to catch up with “the advanced technology of the capitalist countries” and overtake it: the aspect of the military self-assertion of the country thus immediately came to the fore, and Stalin cited Germany three times in a row as an example of an advanced capitalist country. If one keeps in mind that the 6th World Congress of the Comintern had just proclaimed the end of capitalist stabilization and had seen the dawn of a new era of wars and revolutions, then one could arrive at the thesis that Stalin had wanted to set in motion preparations for a defensive war against Germany at the end of 1928, although the fear of war, which was consciously nurtured, referred predominantly to Japan and England as the most hostile powers of *capitalist encirclement*. Or did he want to prepare for the day when he would have to defend a *Soviet Germany* against the Western powers? But in any case, this industrialization could not be carried out without the provision of huge investment funds. Where would these funds come from? If Russia, under a constitutional tsar, had remained at the side of her allies until the victorious end of the war, she would undoubtedly have been granted huge credits with which she could have continued the industrialization that was already well underway. But the Bolsheviks had canceled Russia's national debt, and they had to pay in cash for basically whatever industrial equipment they bought in the West. If industrialization was to take place “quickly” and “with extreme exertion,” then there was only the path of “socialist accumulation,” which the right-wing groups around Bukharin and Rykov called the “military-feudal exploitation of the peasantry.” Just as foreign debts had been cancelled and the bourgeoisie and the Orthodox Church had expropriated, so now it was necessary to take property away from the relatively wealthy part of the peasantry, it was necessary to export millions of tons of grain, even if the whole population of the country was starving because it, and it was necessary to cut down the forests of the country to a large extent in order to get hold of the necessary capital goods and to be able to pay foreign

specialists . And so the world experienced the example of an industrial revolution the likes of which had never existed in history, an industrial revolution ordered by the head of state, the most elementary basis of which was the *class struggle* against a large and completely defenseless minority of its own population.

The policy of the *liquidation of the kulaks as a class* and the collectivization of agriculture meant that a tremendous expropriation campaign was set in motion all over the country, that the kulaks were expelled from their estates and deported with women and children to distant places, where they died of starvation in large part or worked themselves to death in the forest camps of the Urals and in construction of the White Sea Canal. Reports of the experiences of such peasants have only come to light indirectly, but from the so-called Smolensk Archives, which fell into the hands of the German troops in 1941 and later reached America, a detailed picture of the events in this western region of Russia can be obtained, which Merle Fainsod has drawn in his book "Smolensk under Soviet Rule." First of all, the delegations of party members and GPU men (*translator: State Political Directorate: successor to the Cheka, predecessor of the NKVD*) come to the villages and ruthlessly requisition all the grain of the kulaks, who, as a rule, do not represent a clearly defined class, but are connected to the *middle sized farmers* and also the village poor by many times; poor villagers are also arrested on the grounds that they are *ideological* kulaks, and even warm underwear of the kulaks and their wives are taken away, and they are driven into wastelands and swamps; hundreds and thousands of them are collected in the larger cities to be loaded into cattle wagons and transported to Karelia or the Urals on journeys that often take weeks. Panic grips large swathes of the urban population and, according to GPU reports, phrases like the following from the mouths of poor peasants and workers are numerous: "Our turn will come soon as well," and "Hunger will kill us all." Indeed, millions of people cannot be deprived of their property and freedom without any resistance. Quite a few party members fell victim to *acts of terrorism* , and millions of head of cattle were slaughtered. The result was the great famine of 1931/1933, in which several millions perished and, especially in Ukraine, entire villages died out. All the sufferings and agonies that the industrial revolution in England or Germany had brought to the workers seemed insignificant against this background. And in Germany in particular, people were relatively well informed because quite a few peasants of German descent were affected, whose shocking cries for help were spread by the "Relief for Brothers in Need."

But unlike in England and Germany, no definable class of people drew visible advantages from the misery of others: the already pitifully low standard of living of the general population fell by a full third between 1928 and 1932, and even the wives of the deputy

commissars had to queue for food, despite certain privileges; apparently only the very top of the party did not suffer from hunger, and their full labor was indeed most essential to keep the process going. The obvious question is whether, in the presence of identifiable beneficiaries, exploitation can ever reach such a high level. And yet the jubilant reports in the communist and philocommunist press abroad about the *great feats of socialism* in the construction of the Dnieprostroy and Magnitogorsk were not entirely unfounded, because never before had a country industrialized so quickly, and never before was this industrialization borne of the genuine enthusiasm of a *mass minority*, which had long since ceased to be a mere *grain*, but rather attracted large sections of the youth through its call for sacrifice and *stormy labor*. The terrible and the extraordinary arose from the root of will and enthusiasm; only both halves make up the whole of the completely new picture.

Therefore, the period of the first Five-Year Plan and collectivization could indeed be seen as the accelerated catching-up of a universal process and as the establishment of a large-scale collectivist agriculture, which was appropriate to Russian traditions and conditions. The sacrifices then appear as a deplorable but unavoidable expense, and the claim to totality of the party and its leader are considered justified because it accomplished what was necessary, and was therefore rational.

But it is at least as probable that the will to physically exterminate a class regarded as *hostile* was the actual motive of the party, and that in doing so it struck precisely at the most active and efficient members of the peasantry, so that damage was inflicted on agriculture which could not be repaired for decades and which was, consequently, by no means *rational*.

The extent to which the aim was to destroy classes and traditions that were considered reactionary, but were in fact were not reactionary at all or at most partially reactionary, is already proven by the title of a book that appeared in Berlin in 1931 and had as its author the Jewish communist Otto Heller. It was called "The Downfall of Jewry." This did not mean physical annihilation, but rather the end of the "small Jewish town with its filth, its desolations, its lack of culture" through the construction of Soviet socialism, which opened up new and modern possibilities of life for the Jewish nationality, and settlement in Birobidjan, freed from the pressure of a dead tradition. But according to Heller, Western Jewry is also in decline, albeit in a completely different way: through assimilation, through a declining birth rate, through intermarriage. Thus, Judaism in the Soviet Union becomes a beneficiary and in the West a victim of the consequences of that "fall of mankind," the transition from the communal production of primitive times to the commodity-producing society, in which the Jews, as the "first city dwellers" and as a trading people, played such a large part and which is

canceled today in socialism. Therefore, in the Soviet Union, the initially far disproportionate share of Jews in party membership is becoming more and more normalized; in the West, however, “the last, most desperate and strangest nationalism breathes its meagre soul,” namely Zionism, that “product of the petty bourgeoisie.”

Thus the same concept of progress and of the “iron course of history,” condemned to death, after the landlords and the bourgeoisie, also the independently farming peasants and the trading Jews, a death that did not *have to* mean physical extermination, but *could* all too easily mean it, and it was not without good reason that Heller pointed out that the great majority of Jewish intellectuals had opted for Menshevism. According to this concept of progress, the social democrats and right-wing socialists were doomed, and the same was true of the Western social order as a whole, the social order of productive differences that made the concept of progress possible in the first place.

And couldn't a similar consequence and paradox also be seen in Soviet industrialization? Was not, on the one hand, Stalin's remark in his famous speech about the tasks of the economists correct, that old Russia had been continually defeated because of its backwardness and that this was the reason “why we must not lag behind any longer,” provided that it is confined to the first fifth of the twentieth century? But did not the largest state in the world, if it developed its heavy industry and thus its armaments production under extreme strain, very soon have to become again that overpowering threat for equality, indeed even for the independent existence of its neighbors, such as Karl Marx had perceived in the tsarist monarchy of nineteenth century, especially since it now had his own parties in those countries who wanted to see their fatherland in the Soviets?

Neither question was frequently asked in Germany between the years of 1924 and 1929. And yet the background to the new phenomenon was already present in the East when the *old conditions* stabilized again in the German Reich, which were essentially the conditions of the whole of the West.

Chapter II, Section 7

The Period of Stabilization of the Weimar Republic 1924-1929

The stabilization of the currency was not enough to magically stabilize the situation in Germany: The Reichstag elections of May 4, 1924 were still dominated by a deeply agitated mood, and the Volkish parties achieved considerable successes, as did the Communist Party of Germany. The National Socialist Freedom Party, a new entity made up of Volkisch and Hitler supporters, now had 32 seats, but the Communists significantly outnumbered them with 62 seats. The Social Democratic Party only had 100 seats, and the German Nationalists were about as strong. Nevertheless, the center politician Wilhelm Marx, who had replaced Stresemann in December 1923, was able to continue to govern and, with the help of some of the German Nationalists, to push the Dawes laws through, which put German reparation obligations on a new basis and started the influx of foreign credits into Germany. The government knew how to take advantage of the improvement in the situation, and in the Reichstag elections of December 7, 1924, the Communists fell to 45 and the Volkish to 14 seats, while the Social Democratic Party won back 30 seats and the German National People's Party maintained its position. But the Social Democrats continued to remain outside the government, and until 1928 a *bourgeois bloc* of changing composition under the Reich Chancellors Luther and Marx formed the governments, which the German Nationalists belonged first in 1925 until their departure as a result of the Locarno Treaties and then belonged again in 1927/28. The Reichstag election of May 20, 1928 brought substantial gains for both the Social Democrats and the Communists and led to the formation of a Grand Coalition cabinet under the Social Democrat Hermann Müller, which had after a year and a half, at the end of 1929, already been severely shaken by the effects of the deepening global economic crisis, before the era of genuinely parliamentary governments came to an end in March 1930 with the appointment of the presidential cabinet of Brüning.

If one does not focus primarily on the election results and the events in the Reichstag, one can see the end of the crisis of 1923 and the beginning of stabilization symbolized in two

trials that pronounced judgment on the behavior of the National Socialists and the Communists, the Hitler trial in Munich and the *Cheka trial* in Leipzig. Both trials ended very lightly for the defendants, but the statement is only correct because the Leipzig trial was joined by a trial in Moscow, the so-called Student Trial.

The trial of Adolf Hitler, Erich Ludendorff and several other defendants took place from the end of February to the end of March 1924 before the People's Court in Munich. It quickly became clear that Hitler played the leading role and attributed to himself the main responsibility for the events of November 8th and 9th. His defense consisted in the thesis that he had the same goal as the Bavarian rulers Kahr, Lossow and Seisser and that the motive of all those involved was the love of the fatherland, which was in mortal danger as a result of the communist attempts at revolution and the weakness of the bourgeois-Marxist Berlin government. The partners only differed in the extent of their energy and determination, and the chance of this national rescue attempt lay in the fact that he and his party had pulled together the Bavarian state, the Reichswehr and the police forward on their common path. Mussolini and Kemal Pasha were role models for him, and he did not consider the pursuit of ministerial posts worthy of "a great man." "What I wanted to become was the breaker of Marxism," because Marxism had caused the defeat in the world war through its activities for disintegration and was standing in the way of that "last judgment of God" to which "we are ready and willing" to go under the old flags.

Hitler's closing speech, which evidently made a deep impression both on the court and on the audience, thus was, above all, an accusatory speech, directed largely against the same men who were also accused by the communists, namely "Ebert, Scheidemann and comrades," but from a radically opposite impulse, not because of alleged *social treason*, but because of treason against the country and high treason. On the whole, it was nothing more than a potential declaration of war on a hostile world and, moreover, an affirmation of war in general. It thus formed the sharpest contrast to the internationalist passion of that First World Congress of the Communist International. But undoubtedly there was also in it the breath of a great passion capable of sweeping away vast masses, a nationalistic and state passion, in the background of which, however, a *social* passion was easily discernible. Attack and defense were closely linked, and since the court was evidently permeated by similar sentiments, Hitler, with express recognition of his "patriotic merits," was sentenced to a minimum term of five years imprisonment at the fortress for high treason, and he was promised the prospect of an early suspension of his sentence on probation.

The so-called *Cheka trial*, which took place a year later, from February 10 to April 22, 1925,

before the State Court for the Protection of the Republic in Leipzig, had a completely different result. Its real subject was the communist attempt to seize power in 1923, and the occasion was that the authorities had succeeded in arresting the head of the T-(terror)group, Felix Neumann, and even the Soviet supreme military leader for the uprising, Alexander Skoblewsky (alias Rose, Gorev or “Helmut”). Neumann made a comprehensive confession, referring mainly to the murder of a *traitor* and a planned assassination attempt against General von Seeckt. This trial was also highly political and propagandistic, as the lawyers were either communists or openly showed their sympathy for communism. The presiding judge, on the other hand, showed no leniency whatsoever, and frequent clashes occurred.

The court considered it proven that the *Cheka group* had acted on behalf of the relevant party authorities, and the defense’s objection that the Communist Party did not support *individual terror* was rejected with good arguments. But only a small part of the great revolutionary movement of 1923 was made the subject of the trial, although the public prosecutor’s thesis was not contradicted, that for the communists the constitutional powers were also *fascist* and the appeal to the will to defend the legal workers’ governments was one been a mere concealment of the intent to go on the offensive. Three of the main defendants, including Neumann and Skoblewsky, were sentenced to death, the rest of them received long prison sentences.

Certainly, the two trials, also in the way they were conducted, were remarkable examples of the difference in behavior towards the right and the left, which was then particularly denounced by Emil Julius Gumbel and today almost universally. But surely the first question to be asked is whether in the history of the world an attacked system has treated its enemies and those who wanted to help it according to the same standards, and whether one does not rob the communists of the honor that they can claim if one does denies that the violent overthrow of the capitalist, i.e., the European-industrial system, had to be a far more serious and revolutionary event than the establishment of an anti-parliamentary dictatorship to repel this attack. And the most remarkable thing is that the Reich government did not initiate any further trials against those actually found guilty, namely the leadership of the Communist Party, and that the death sentences were not carried out. General political and foreign policy considerations may have been decisive for first, but the second cannot be understood without a third trial, the so-called Student Trial in Moscow in June and July 1925.

The accused were the German students Dr. Kindermann, Wolscht and von Ditmar. In September 1924, with regular papers and after lengthy negotiations with the Soviet embassy, they had started a research and lecture tour to the Soviet Union, and after a 14-day stay in

Moscow they had been arrested by the GPU and taken to the Lubyanka. After the trial had been prepared over a long period of time, the charge was brought that the three students had been sent to Russia by the "Consul Organization" to spy and shoot "Stalin and Trotsky." During the trial, cartoons appeared in *Pravda* and *Izvestia* ; one of them showed the massive, brutal figure of a student at arms with a swastika band on his arm, shooting at pictures of Stalin and Trotsky with his pistol. The trial reports claimed that this was the "first shock troop of fascism" that had invaded the Soviet Union and that it had to be rendered harmless. The embassy counselor Hilger, the editor-in-chief of the *Berliner Tageblatt* Theodor Wolff and even the former Reich Chancellor Michaelis were named as those behind the attack. Mainly, however, Captain Ehrhardt and the (long since disbanded) "Organization Consul" were targeted. Initially, Ambassador von Brockdorff-Rantzau placed so much trust in the investigating authorities that he believed their claim that these "murderous fellows" had been sent to kill him as well, but then he did not fail to act in their defense. The German press also paid great attention to the trial. It quickly became apparent how meager or trivial were the realities viewed by the prosecution as evidence of a widespread anti-Soviet conspiracy, such as Theodor Wolff's money payments. Gustav Hilger was also able to refute the suspicions in a convincing manner. Nevertheless, the defendants were sentenced to death. The outrage over the "Moscow Shameful Justice" was enormous in Germany. The *Vossische Zeitung* recalled the principles of revolutionary judgment developed by the Frenchman Sadoul during the trial of the Social Revolutionaries in 1922, which contradicted all conceptions of the rule of law because they made "the good of the revolution alone" and not the individual guilt of the defendants as the criterion; the *Vorwärts* turned sharply against "the eastern direction in the Foreign Office," which wanted to avoid at all costs a German-Russian disgruntlement. Friends of Kindermann testified that he went to Russia with strong illusionary sympathies and that he could not have had any connection with right-wing radical organizations simply because he was Jewish. But for the insiders very early on, there was no doubt that the students had been arrested as objects of exchange; for in February 1925 the President of the Council of People's Commissars Rykow had told Brockdorff-Rantzau that the charges against the students would be put down if the proceedings in Leipzig were abandoned. In the end, things came to just that: in October, Skoblewsky and Kindermann and their comrades were pardoned at the same time. In the end, the Weimar judicial authorities were no harsher against the Soviet communist Alexander Skoblewsky than they had been against the Austrian National Socialist Adolf Hitler.

The further development of the Communist Party of Germany during the period of prohibition from November 1923 to March 1924 and afterwards was primarily determined by the disputes over the *October defeat* , which in turn were closely intertwined with the first

disputes between Stalin, Zinoviev and Trotsky in the Russian party leadership. It was quite natural that the *leftists*, who had sharply criticized Brandler's united-front policy, i.e., his cooperation with the left Social Democrats, now came to the fore. After every failure of the attempts to expand *right* to the social-democratic workers and to some of their leaders, the pendulum regularly swung back to the *left* -wing demarcation of all waverers and the undecided. Thus, at the 9th Party Congress in Frankfurt in April 1924, a radical change was made: the left took over the party leadership, i.e. Ruth Fischer, Arkadij Maslow, Werner Scholem, Ernst Thälmann, Arthur Rosenberg, Iwan Katz, etc. The rightists or Brandlerians were completely eliminated. The emerging talk of a *stabilization of capitalism* was not believed, and the new program of action, while it proclaimed a *united front from below*, which was to also include proletarian middle-classes, demanded with even greater determination the arming of the proletariat and the disarming of both the legal and illegal bourgeoisie state organs, i.e. the preparation of the masses for the impending final battle. Indeed, the party's call for the Reichstag elections in May 1924 obviously appealed to many people because it directed an extremely violent indictment against the Weimar system and, of course, against the capitalist system as a whole. In the foreground of the indictment, besides the capitalists, "Christian as well as Jewish," are the Social Democrats, who have once again stabbed the fighting proletariat in the back. Hitler is mentioned only in passing, with a contemptuous expression, as a "megalomaniac philistine," and as a creature of big business, while the Communist Party is again apostrophized as the "leader in this struggle for liberation of all the oppressed"

But after the second Reichstag elections of the year, there was no mistaking that stabilization had actually occurred, and while Weimar Germany, under the leadership of Foreign Minister Stresemann, was working towards a reconciliation with the Western powers and entry into the League of Nations, the Communists seemed to be tearing each other apart. In fact, the party leadership launched a fierce struggle against *Trotskyism* and *Luxemburgism* in the party, and in return an ultra-left opposition formed, which increasingly came to take *anti-Bolshevik* or *anti-Stalinist* positions because it criticized the NEP and the prevalence of the foreign policy interests of the Russian *peasant state* in the Comintern policy.

Particularly characteristic of this stage was the writing of the young Heinz Neumann, the intellectual son of a wealthy Jewish home, "What is Bolshevization?" which appeared in early 1925. In the present age of "incessant national struggles and civil wars," according to Neumann, the Communist Party of Germany's struggle against Social Democracy becomes a class struggle which must be "fought to the knife against the opportunist party of the labor aristocracy." But only with the strictest unity and centralization can the party really be the

section of a world party; only then can it prepare itself efficiently for the armed insurrection and have military formations as well as an intelligence apparatus that informs the party headquarters about “where the police stations and barracks, the positions and forces of the enemy are,” what are the militarily important factories and the course of their manufacturing system. Only then can it effectively work towards the disorganization of the capitalist state apparatus and disturb the “peace of the production process” sought by the capitalists. The Communist Party will only achieve victory in absolute Bolshevik unity, nevertheless with perseverance and in complete harmony with the international headquarters: “Give us a Bolshevik party in Germany and we will unhinge Germany.”

It was not surprising that these views aroused opposition in the party and that they led the opponents, not least the Social Democrats, who were counted among the bourgeoisie and thus threatened with extermination, to the thesis that this Communist Party of Germany was nothing more than the fighting machine and espionage organization of a foreign power. And when, in the spring of 1925, after the death of Friedrich Ebert, whom it was still cursing in his grave, the party held on to its candidate Thälmann in the second round of the Reich presidential elections, it in fact actually secured Hindenburg’s victory, although it received only just under 2 million votes, far fewer than in the Reichstag elections. It thus became apparent that at the moment when it was a question of trusting a specific person rather than approval of a radical protest program, the Communists were only able to win over a small minority of little more than 5% of the electorate. The candidate of the National Socialists, Ludendorff, received fewer than 300,000 votes: in the spring of 1925, Hitler and his party were, so to speak, no longer perceptible.

It would, of course, be a great mistake to think that Hitler and his party were over immediately after November 9, 1923. For many weeks after the putsch, the people of Munich and Bavaria were in a state of intense anti-government agitation; Alfred Rosenberg founded a substitute organization on Hitler's behalf, the Großdeutsche Volksgemeinschaft (Greater German National Community); the public took the liveliest interest in the Hitler’s trial; a postcard depicting Hitler as a lonely prisoner in Landsberg was distributed in millions of copies; Hitler had become a national figure for the first time, albeit for a short period of time. The electoral successes of the “Volkish Block” in Bavaria and the “National Socialist Freedom Party” in the Reich far exceeded expectations. But Hitler soon realized that he could not control the various successor organizations from Landsberg, and he therefore withdrew completely from day-to-day politics in order to devote himself exclusively to work on the book that was later to be named “Mein Kampf.” After his release at Christmas of 1924, he found the situation much changed, and paid a visit to the new Bavarian Prime Minister Held

to assure him that he did not want to fight against the government, but only against Marxism. On February 27, 1925, he then re-established his party by a speech in the Bürgerbräukeller. He succeeded to put those present into a frenzy of enthusiasm and to bring about a touching scene of reconciliation among the quarreling followers. This time it was completely clear from the outset that he would be the alone at the head of the party and would have no Ludendorff beside him. However, the Bavarian authorities imposed a ban on his speaking, which most of the German states joined, and thus he was deprived of his best and most important weapon. But on July 18, 1925, the first volume of *Mein Kampf* was published by Eher-Verlag. In the present context it is not appropriate to give an account of the contents, an analysis or a critique, but it is still central to ask the question of how the relationship between the basic motifs is compared to the early speeches and whether anti-Marxism or anti-Bolshevism is still the main focus.

The *life story* is completely new, and then becomes the starting point of a party history, which in turn is repeatedly interrupted by diverse reflections on questions of a general political and anthropological nature. From the life story it is clear that the Greater German motif emerges already on the first pages and that Hitler appears above all as an *Austrian German*. But the account on his experiences in Vienna, despite all the self-stylization, makes clear in an almost striking way how much he felt like an *European citizen*. This is already proven by his story of the first encounter with Social Democrats at the construction site, and even more conclusive is the report of how one day he encountered a mass demonstration by Social Democratic workers and watched “with bated breath the monstrous human dragon worm” that slowly rolled by. “I finally left the square in fearful depression and wandered home.” That was, in an almost paradigmatic way, a “bourgeois” reaction, but by no means “the” bourgeois reaction, because men like Max Weber or Clement Attlee reacted quite differently. The fact that Hitler was outraged by an early and overlooked claim to totality by the labor movement, namely by the “brutal demands” to attend only red meetings and read only red books, cannot be denied, but it is precisely at this point that he puts forward the equally totalitarian postulate of opposing social democracy with “a doctrine of better truthfulness, but the same brutality of execution.” Nevertheless, it is not without consequence when, in the same context, he sharply criticizes the bourgeoisie’s lack of understanding of social issues, which is clearly burdened with responsibility for the disastrous development. But a few pages later Hitler writes: “When I recognized the Jew as the leader of Social Democracy, scales began to fall from my eyes...The names of Austerlitz, David, Adler, Ellenbogen will stay in my memory forever.” Obviously, Hitler makes a concomitant phenomenon the cause here, fundamentally no different than the war profiteers and speculators who are accused in the *Spartacus letters* as the originators of the war. It is

certainly no coincidence that the “scales falling from the eyes” appear so often in the life accounts of Marxists. But with Hitler the accusation against “pathogens” and “originators” of the disaster is still much more intense, presumably because it is less plausible and precisely because of this reason it can lead to downright monstrous statements, such as the one that the planet will again move through the ether deserted as it was millions of years ago, if the Jew succeeds in triumphing over the peoples of this world with the help of his Marxist creed. But only in this way does Hitler gain a mission for himself and his imagined “Germanic Reich of the German Nation,” a mission which in its own way is supposed to be as universal as the one that Marxism ascribed to itself: “By defending myself against the Jew, I fight for the work of the Lord.” And so, in addition to the long narratives and reflections on the “aristocratic principle of nature” or the “free play of forces,” one also finds in *Mein Kampf*, quite as in the early speeches, there is on the one hand the affirmative and national pathos of the positive world war experience and, on the other hand, the negative and social pathos that arising from the continuing horror of the “Russian example” and the “annihilation of the national intelligentsia”: “Now the great last revolution begins. By gaining political power, the Jew throws off the few covers he still wears. The democratic Jew of the people becomes the Jew of blood and the tyrant of the people. In a few years he tries to exterminate the national bearers of the intelligence...The most terrible example of this kind is Russia...”

Around the same time, one of Hitler's best known brother-in-arms, Colonel Max Bauer, wrote a travelogue from the “Land of the Red Tsars,” in which he frankly admitted that he had changed his opinions about the Soviet Union and the leading men of its state party after he had seen too much there that conflicted with his conservative and military principles. Hitler, too, was the traditionalist of an old faith, as Rosa Luxemburg had been in her very different way, and by keeping the past alive, he wrote a *Bible* for his movement that differed in characteristic ways from the basic books that Karl Marx had written for the workers' movement in 1867 and Lenin had written for young Bolshevism in 1902. None of the three books was a reflection of reality or an accurate blueprint of the future, but each stood positively in the midst of powerful historical developments. Yet the situation in which and for which *Mein Kampf* was written was the most particular and least repeatable. This, even for those who had not joined in the mockery of Hitler's *ramblings* but took his book seriously, the probability had to be high that this man and this party would be no match with their democratic and Marxist opponents. Perhaps at no moment was the presumption better founded than in 1926, when the Communists brought the question of the *expropriation* of the princes to the general public, and a large part of the Democrats and Republicans went in the same direction.

In and of itself, the *united-front policy*, which was the precondition of this success, was not to be expected from a left party leadership. But the Fifth Congress of the Communist International in the summer of 1924 had sharply condemned the right, but at the same time it had prescribed the line of *mass struggle*, which would certainly take the form of a *united front from below*, but which nevertheless offered many opportunities for conciliatory gestures toward the Social Democrats. In addition, the party leadership was increasingly harassed by the ultra-leftists, and it in turn adopted some of their theses, so that fears arose in the Comintern that, in connection with Stresemann's turn to the West, anti-Bolshevik or Western European tendencies were gaining strength within the Communist Party of Germany. Stalin forced Zinoviev to send an "Open Letter" to the members and organizations of the Communist Party of Germany, dated September 1, 1925, which Ruth Fischer also had to sign, even though it meant the end of her party career. The long letter already exhibited a number of features of the future *Chinese Party*, but its meaning was clear. It emphatically demanded the implementation of a practical Bolshevization of the party in the sense of the struggle against the formation of factions and anti-Bolshevik tendencies, as well as the clear subordination of party work to the main point of view of the interests of the Soviet Union, but also a stronger turn toward mass struggle. This Open Letter became the starting point of fierce disputes, and the apostasy of the left and ultra-left communists soon emerged, but the party leadership reacted as it was expected: Ernst Thälmann's group took over the party leadership. A short time later, it was presented with a great opportunity to launch a mass struggle.

The overthrow of the monarchies in Germany in 1918/19 had not lead to the radical consequence that had been chosen in Austria, namely the confiscation of the entire property of the ruling dynasties. Rather, as was the tradition, a distinction had been made between state and private assets and the delimitation was left to the federal states and the courts. After the end of the inflation, some new court rulings caused considerable stir within the disputes, some of which were still ongoing, and the disquiet was heightened because some princes made revaluation claims for their pensions etc., which had been destroyed by the inflation, and which went far beyond what the small pensioners and savers had been granted in appreciation. In December 1925 the Communist Party of Germany therefore introduced a bill that provided for the expropriation of all assets of the former royal houses without compensation.

Undoubtedly, this demand, which came under the slogan "Not a penny for the princes!" was extremely popular among those who had suffered by revaluation and no less with the unemployed and war-disabled, who, according to the bill, were to benefit from the proceeds.

On the other hand, a right to expropriate entire groups without compensation for political reasons could not be derived from the constitution, and the Communists made no secret of the fact that what was to be made was only the first breach in the property system as such. However, they proceeded very cleverly, and had a non-partisan committee under the leadership of the left-liberal professor Robert René Kuczynski take the initiative for a referendum. This put the Social Democratic Party leadership in a difficult situation and, for fear of losing numerous supporters, it had to agree to act jointly with the Communist Party of Germany. The referendum achieved the astonishingly high number of votes of 12.5 million votes, far more than was required, and this cleared the way for a referendum after the Reichstag, as was to be expected, had rejected the bill. Now a passionate public debate developed, in which the Reich President von Hindenburg also intervened. Since the bill was constitution-amending, 20 million votes were required for its adoption, and on June 20, 1926, only 14.5 million yes-votes were cast. Nevertheless, it was a great success for the Communist Party of Germany. It had forced the Social Democratic Party leadership into her tow and also managed to get a large number of center voters to vote “yes” as well. For the first time, the deterrent force of the *Russian example* seemed to have been lost, and voters largely voted according to sociological lines: communist, social democratic and Christian workers seemed to be on the same front under communist leadership.

Nevertheless, the following was the main result: with the most popular and apparently most moderate of all conceivable slogans, the Communist Party of Germany had brought the Social Democratic Party into line and appealed not only to the *centrist proletarians* but to a large number of left-wing democrats (including probably all left-wing intellectuals), but it still did not get more than 40% of the vote. It was virtually impossible that it would ever legally enforce its own slogans, such as that of the dictatorship of the proletariat. It was undoubtedly right in saying that even in the face of a serious crisis, only “armed insurrection” would lead to victory.

The counteraction of the National Socialists in the context of these important and, above all, symptomatic events was merely episodic and contributed to making deputies Frick and his comrades appear as comic as they were insignificant. They introduced a motion in the Reichstag for the expropriation of the property of “the bank and stock exchange princes and other parasites of the people,” which was an exact counterpart to the communist-social-democratic bill and of course had no prospect of even being seriously discussed. But subversive it undoubtedly was, and in future this party could hardly count on the natural sympathies of the capitalists. If the referendum was ultimately a failure for the communists, they had won a triumph over their most radical enemies that was not merely

quantitative or material.

But they hardly took these enemies seriously anymore, and the intra-communist clashes that took place over the next few years were unambiguous proof of this. They were not at all about the relationship to *fascism* and the best methods to fight it. Rather, it continued to be about the *Bolshevization* of the party, which Thälmann and his supporters were only able to push through and enforce after difficult struggles. The fiercest opponents were the ultra-leftists, who were joined by a section of the left around Ruth Fischer and Arkadij Maslow after the loss of the party leadership. The earliest group formed in 1925 around Werner Scholem, Iwan Katz and Arthur Rosenberg. It leveled accusations against the communist leaders, who seemed to believe “that the Prussian army before the war was roughly the embodied ideal of a Leninist party.” The counter-accusations were that the ultra-leftists viewed Bolshevism as a *bourgeois aberration*, and this undoubtedly hit on something correct. But since Katz, Rosenberg, and Scholem were “Jewish intellectuals,” some observers believed they perceived anti-Semitic undertones in the campaign against the intellectuals launched by the Thälmann group on the model of Stalin’s polemics against Trotsky, Zinoviev, and Kamenev. The intellectuals were by no means united among themselves, however, and there were also a number of workers among the opposition’s champions. At times there were no fewer than ten opposition groups, and nearly a dozen members of the Reichstag were *left-communists*. The party leadership proceeded tactically very cleverly and excluded one of the opposition groups after the other. The first to suffer this fate was the group around the former head of the municipal department in the Communist Party of Germany headquarters, Iwan Katz. It was very radical indeed, wanting it to be considered an honor to be called anti-Bolshevik as long as it was Bolshevik to set aside “the interests of the international proletariat in favor of the Russian state, that is, the Russian capitalist peasant majority” and to replace party discipline with cadre obedience within the Communist Party of Germany. Later the group joined the *council communists* around Franz Pfemfert, who called Stalin a “peasant Napoleon” and even believed to recognize in Russia the “last bulwark of the bourgeoisie,” namely a national-capitalist great power and enemy of the proletariat.

Leftists and ultra-leftists such as Karl Korsch, Hugo Urbahns, Arthur Rosenberg, Arkadij Maslow and Ruth Fischer took different, yet similar paths: some of them moved away from communism and even from Marxism, others later returned to the party. The splits and disputes are not to be traced in detail here, because in the present context it comes down to one observation: none of these groups took credit for themselves for being closer to National Socialism or fascism than the party leadership, despite serious differences. And the same

applies to polemics. Even if Stalin's "socialism in one country" was fiercely opposed, it was not called *fascist*, and even when Trotsky applied the term "National Socialism" to Stalin's practice in 1930, he did not want to establish any connection with the Hitler's party, which remained for him in result of counter-revolution, while Stalin was, after all, a *Thermidorian*. This was considerably different in the disputes that took place within the NSDAP at around the same time, and in this, too, one can see evidence of the priority and of the far greater importance of communism up to 1930.

This is the dispute between *right-wing* and *left-wing* National Socialists that began soon after the re-establishment of the party and lasted until 1930. The North German party organization, the establishment of which Hitler had entrusted to Gregor Straßer, a pharmacist and highly decorated front-line officer from Landshut, was considered left-wing. He was joined by his brother Otto, who had been a member of the Social Democratic Party and had led a student company against the Kapp troops. The potential from which this wing had to draw was to a large extent *volkish-Protestant*. On the other hand, the *proletarian masses* in the Ruhr area and in Berlin could only be won over to nationalistic socialism if *capitalism* and at least *the philistines* were opposed. Both of these potentially contained a conflict with Munich, because it was not without reason that Hitler made his *peace with Rome* and was looking for contacts with leading business circles. In any case, a "Working Group of the North and West German Districts" was formed in September 1925 and published as its organ the *National Socialist Letter* from October 1st, published by Gregor Straßer and edited by Dr. Joseph Goebbels, the managing director of the Rhineland district in Elberfeld. An initial draft of the program envisaged the transfer of large-scale industry into partial state and municipal property and the conversion of all landowners into leaseholders. There was just as little applause in Munich as an initial and positive resolution on the expropriation of the princes, and at a Führer-meeting in Bamberg on February 14, 1926, Hitler prevailed completely with a speech lasting several hours and won over Goebbels in particular, whom he made Gauleiter (*translator: district leader*) of Berlin at the end of the year. In spite of this, the north German party wing retained its own and predominantly left-wing characteristics, and in the *Kampf-Verlag* publishing house it created a strong power base for itself. In its newspapers and in the Nazi letters the war of extermination against (international) capitalism could be proclaimed, and here there was a great deal of understanding for the Marxist class struggle doctrine, which was therefore by no means considered a Jewish invention in accordance with Hitler. Above all, however, there was a pronounced orientation towards the East, because the ultimate goal of tearing apart the dictates of Versailles and Saint-Germain could not be achieved without the help of the Soviet Union and without an alliance with all the oppressed peoples of the world. Bolshevism as such is firmly rejected, mostly on anti-Semitic grounds, but in the speech

“Lenin or Hitler?” which Goebbels first delivered in Königsberg in February 1926, Bolshevism and National Socialism as the two revolutionary movements of the twentieth century were paralleled to such an extent that the contrast was ultimately only seen in the fact that Lenin wanted to redeem Germany through the world, while Adolf Hitler’s aim was to redeem the world through Germany. Some left-wing National Socialists went so far as to make outright offers of alliance to the Communist Party of Germany, because they believed that the Communist Party of Germany and the Soviet Union saw “in the present situation, as far as possible, our allies against Weimar, Versailles and Wall Street,” although they ultimately pursued other goals. The Social Democrats, in turn, relied on such statements to prove the close kinship of Communists and National Socialists.

It can be assumed that Adolf Hitler had not least the left-wing National Socialists in mind when he wrote the second volume of *Mein Kampf* in 1925 and 1926, which appeared in December 1926. Here he made it clear once again that for him the anti-bourgeois polemics did not in the least mean a weakening of radical anti-Bolshevism, and above all he worked out the hitherto only rudimentary theory of living space in a way that made any compromise with the concept of eastward orientation impossible. But the strong emphasis on racial doctrine should also be seen in this context. An alliance with the oppressed nations can therefore be completely ruled out because their situation is due to racial inferiority. Thus the second volume is filled much more strongly than the first with that pointed and hardened “Europeanism” which regards the rule of the English master people and the Germans allied with them as a “racial” determination of nature and derives from this the right to “land policy of the future,” which will mean the end of the Russian state, since after the fall of the Bolsheviks, those “blood-stained common criminals,” there will no longer be a leadership class who could hold the state together. However, the extent to which Hitler is still oriented towards the situation of the Russian civil war can be seen in the “Political Testament” with which he closes Chapter 14 on “Orientation towards the East or Eastern Policy”: “Never tolerate the emergence of two continental powers in Europe. See in every attempt to organize a second military power on the German borders...an attack against Germany...see to it that the strength of our people is based not in colonies but in the soil of our homeland in Europe...” Just as Hitler wants to fix the English supremacy in the world during the second half of the 19th century through a racial doctrine and thus the inclusion of Germany, so he wants to fix at this point the situation of the years 1917/18, when the second, the Russian military power on the borders of Germany had ceased to exist, which had been a self-evident fact throughout the 18th and 19th centuries. The fear of one’s own annihilation, which had so strongly marked the early speeches and the first volume of *Mein Kampf*, now results in a foreign policy and state will to annihilate, which was far removed from the left National

Socialists with regard to Russia.

There were thus genuine differences between Munich and northern Germany. In 1928, it had not yet been decided whether Hitler's concept of identifying nationalism and socialism or Strasser's *national socialism* was more promising. It was also uncertain whether the party would eventually split or there would only a small group of people turning away. An important preliminary decision was the Reichstag elections of 1928, which meant a defeat for the National Socialists and a considerable success for the Communists.

The main winner, however, was the Social Democratic Party. It won 152 seats, and was thus stronger than in any of the previous parliaments with the exception of the National Assembly. In contrast, the German Nationalists fell from over 100 to 78, and the center parties also lost a number of seats. The communists rose from 45 to 54 seats, and despite the greatest propaganda efforts, and the NSDAP, despite its greatest propagandistic efforts, was only able to conquer 12 seats, while it had previously had 14. But these 12 were now all Hitler supporters, and there was no longer any *left-communists* among the communists. Nevertheless, the result of December 1924 seemed to be confirmed insofar as the National Socialists looked like an insignificant splinter party compared to the Communists. In fact, they received little attention from the new government of the *grand coalition*, and the Prussian government lifted the party ban it had pronounced for Berlin. It seemed much more important that a more radical tendency was now rapidly establishing itself among the German Nationalists, which in October led to the election of the press magnate Alfred Hugenberg as party chairman, while the more moderate forces were pushed onto the path of secession.

In retrospect, the time of the grand coalition from summer 1928 to spring 1930 often appears to be the last good time of the Weimar Republic. Contemporaries, however, did not always feel that way, and a symptomatic sign of weakness in the government was the dispute over the "armored cruiser A," which brought the Social Democratic ministers and the Reichstag faction into a very peculiar opposition. But the so-called "Bloody May" of 1929, which gave popular sanction, so to speak, to the ultra-left turn of Stalin and the Comintern of 1928, was a downright ominous sign.

The dispute over the construction of a new armored cruiser had already started in 1927, and the main arguments had already been exchanged at that time: the armored cruiser was unnecessary and merely a dangerous toy, since disarmament and not armament had to be on the program, said the representatives of the Social Democratic Party and the German Democratic Party; it was a matter of a replacement construction provided for in the Versailles

Treaty, which was indispensable for the defense of East Prussia, replied German Nationalists and People's Party members. Proponents prevailed, and so the warship was drawn into the election campaign. The Social Democrats led it partly with the slogan *food for children instead of armored cruiser*, which probably contributed significantly to the election victory. But in August 1928, the Social Democratic ministers, together with the other cabinet members, decided to begin construction in order to avoid rupture of the coalition, which was still very fragile. In the new parliamentary disputes, however, the Social Democratic ministers, as members of parliament, voted against the decision they had made as members of the cabinet. The communists, in turn, introduced a referendum in September that consisted of a single sentence: "The building of armored ships and cruisers of any kind is forbidden." This time, however, their votes were far below those they had received in the Reichstag elections. Thus their motion was not popular, presumably for several reasons and not least because of the suspicion that the section of the Communist International wanted to give its state, the USSR, an armaments advantage. Characteristic, however, was also the attitude of the Social Democrats, which had to nourish the suspicion in the right half of the German people that this large party had still not found a relationship with the elementary state necessities, because their arguments against the armored cruiser could also be carried on to the thesis that the Reichswehr was superfluous and that its budget could be directed towards unemployment aid or feeding children. The old assertion that there was a *total Marxism* thus received new nourishment.

At about the same time, however, the old opposition within this overall Marxism found a new and extremely bloody expression in the May events.

In December 1928, the Social Democratic police chief of Berlin, the former cooper Karl Friedrich Zörgiebel, banned all outdoor demonstrations and gatherings because of recent heavy clashes between the Red Front Fighters League and the SA. The Prussian Minister of the Interior, Albert Grzesinski, published a "final warning" on March 29, 1929, in which he almost openly threatened to ban the Communist Party of Germany. It was very understandable, however, that the Communist Party of Germany agitated the strongest against the decision, because the marches on May 1st were a particularly old and venerable heritage of the entire workers' movement. In fact, the authorities were considering lifting the ban on demonstrations on May 1st, but the murder of two Reichsbanner (*translator: veterans' federation*) people aggravated the situation anew. And the agitation of the Communist Party of Germany was not far from calling for an armed insurrection: "The revolutionary élan and the will to fight of the German workers will show the social-democratic police minister of the trust-bourgeoisie that the proletariat doesn't give a

damn about their prohibitions.” The Social Democratic Party, on the other hand, circulated phrases like “The Communist Party of Germany needs corpses” or “On Moscow’s orders,” and thereby aggravated the situation on its part. The communists, in, had several hundred Red Front Fighters League members and Party Youth attacked traffic policemen at intersections on the evening of April 30th, and on the morning of May 1st the *Rote Fahne* with the headline “May Fight 1929,” while the editorial spoke the “signals of a new rising wave of the proletarian revolution.” However, only a few thousand demonstrators gathered in the streets, and it is therefore doubtful whether the party mobilized even all Red Front Fighters League members and prepared them in civilian clothes to enforce the demonstration. This is what the police apparently assumed, and they used very sharp methods to break up the marches. The first shots were fired around noon in the main trouble spots on Kösliner Street in Wedding and on Hermannplatz in Neukölln, presumably by the police, who were greeted with a hail of stones and bottles and outraged shouts like “bloodhounds.” The response consisted of the use of armored vehicles, the storming of the barricades and the dreaded shout “Get away from the windows,” since open windows were immediately shot at because of fear of snipers. Already in the evening of the first day there were 9 dead and 63 seriously injured. Up until May 4, there were repeated serious clashes, which were particularly caused by groups of youths, and which sparked shows of sympathy among the population. On May 2, the *Rote Fahne* had brought passionate denunciations against the “murderous party” and the “bloodstained coalition government” and brought a call for a “mass strike,” which, however, was hardly heeded. Excited scenes took place in the Prussian state parliament: Deputy Jendretzky appeared in full Red Front Fighters League uniform, Wilhelm Pieck hurled the word “Murderer gang!” in the faces of the Social Democrats, the parliamentary group sang the Internationale standing up, and then marched out of parliament. In all, more than 30 deaths were reported, most of them bystanders, including women; the police, on the other hand, suffered no fatalities and only one of their wounded received a bullet wound. Nonetheless, the Red Front Fighters League, the Red Young Front and the Red Navy were banned on May 6th.

From the bourgeoisie, too, there was much criticism of the harsh actions of the police, who behaved “as if they were in enemy territory,” and not just from the *Frankfurter Zeitung* and the *Berliner Tageblatt*. The *Vorwärts*, on the other hand, expressed itself in a militant manner: “The communists needed corpses and mobilized the lumpenproletariat...Down with the communist pests of the workers’ movement!” One could indeed assume without any particular malice that the Communists did not want to carry out in this occasion the armed insurrection they invoked again and again, but wanted to rehearse it and that the deep indignation which now filled considerable parts of Berlin population against the “Zörgiebel

Cossacks” and the “police beast” was very welcome to them and was certainly shared by them. The language of the right-wing newspapers, for their part, was of the utmost vehemence: again and again there was talk of the German Kerensky epoch into which one had apparently entered anew, the *Deutsche Zeitung* spoke of the “agglomerated depravity of the dregs of humanity of our machine century,” and the *Deutsche Tageszeitung* demanded that “the criminal nests of the troublemakers be so thoroughly fumigated that no one can again establish himself in them.” The old fear of civil war and memories of the years from 1918 to 1923 came back to life, especially since the first signs of the looming global economic crisis were becoming apparent. However, the communists still saw the social democrats and the Weimar *state of the trust-bourgeoisie* as their future main opponents in the civil war, according to the Russian example. But another party, which, like the Communists, but for opposite reasons, shouted their “Away with Grzesinski, Severing, Zörgiebel!” and was already in ascendancy, and it would not be long before Germany’s streets, but in a different way Germany’s newspapers and theaters, also became the scenes of a civil war, which of course remained limited because the government, police and Reichswehr essentially kept the reins in their hands. However, it was not easy for them to achieve the required *equidistance*, because until then they had been attacked primarily by one and by far the stronger of the two parties.

But there was also a second state involved, and just on May 1, 1929, it interfered in Germany’s affairs with a serious way through a speech by its war commissioner. These influences, however, were not all negative and hostile. It is time to take a look at the state relations between the German Reich and the Soviet Union before making that internal German civil war the subject.

Chapter II, Section 8

State Relations between Germany and the Soviet Union

8. State relations between Germany and the Soviet Union

German-Soviet relations have attracted much attention in the literature, far more than the relationship between Communists and National Socialists. If this relationship is in the foreground of interest, those relations must take a back seat, at least until 1933, because the National Socialists were the main representatives of the *socio-political line* in German policy towards the Soviet Union and Communism, i.e. the line that perceived above all the world-revolutionary will and the intention to annihilate the bourgeoisie, and in this respect agreed with the communists in the opposite assessment. But the *state-policy line* was not simply opposed to the socio-political line; there were manifold entanglements and tensions, but hardly ever an exclusionary contradiction.

In a way, the state-policy line was even the older one: by strategically promoting revolutionary propaganda during the war and especially by allowing Lenin to travel through, Germany was in a way the founder of Soviet Russia and, after Brest-Litovsk, its preserver for decisive months,. The perception of the Red Terror, the cries for help of many representatives of the bourgeoisie, the revolutionary propaganda in the German army and behind the front did not remain without influence on the leading men, and both the Kaiser and the Reich Chancellor Hertling as well as the chief of staff from Oberost, General Max Hoffmann, seriously considered marching German troops to Petrograd and Moscow to install a pro-German *White* government. But the *Whites* were not uniformly pro-German, and a good part of them were *Red* : no party was more resolutely on the side of the Entente than the Social Revolutionaries, and the assassination of the German envoy, Count Mirbach, by leftist Social Revolutionaries clarified this for the German government that the Bolsheviks were the only strong and organized force in Russia radically opposed to resuming the war. Thus the new State Secretary for Foreign Affairs, von Hintze, prevailed against all other efforts and

concluded the so-called “supplementary treaties” with the Soviet government at the end of August 1918, which meant a new *breathing space* for Lenin.

A little more than two months later, full of relief and triumph, the leading men in Moscow were able to make their first contact with the revolutionary German government, and the disappointment was great when the People’s Commissioner Haase behaved coolly and reservedly and when a little later, the Ebert government protested sharply against the interference in Germany’s internal affairs which had been brought about by the various appeals and proclamations of the Soviet government. Consequently, diplomatic relations, which the Imperial Government had broken off in one of its last official acts, were not resumed, and after the deaths of Rosa Luxemburg and Karl Liebknecht, who had already been expected to be the future President of the German Soviet Republic, relations deteriorated more and more, not least because of the resistance that the German troops in the Baltics continued to put up against the advance of the Russian and native Reds. But at the same time, Mann and the Foreign Minister Count Brockdorff-Rantzau, saw quite clearly how great a trump card the Bolshevik government could have in the hands of the defeated Germany: by linking it to the *socio-political* concerns of the Allies who could make Germany a valued ally, or allying closely with Russia against the Entente.

Both possibilities arose inevitably from the state-political situation and the geographical position of Germany: western orientation with an anti-Bolshevik accent, i.e. adaptation of the state-political line to the socio-political line, or eastern orientation as agreement with Bolshevik Russia. The deep disappointment and humiliation that Brockdorff had to endure in Versailles made him a champion of the second line, even if he never went as far in the eastern orientation as General von Seeckt, who was primarily concerned with the destruction of Poland and who wanted to make considerable domestic political concessions in return. Ebert and almost all the Social Democrats, on the other hand, unflinchingly advocated the line of western orientation, which for them was the only possibility of self-assertion against the communists.

But a third line also came into play, the economic-political line taken by many German entrepreneurs and which did not have to be apolitical or philo-Bolshevik under all circumstances, as it could be linked to the conviction that the establishment of trade relations would mitigate the *barbaric* or *Asiatic* character of Bolshevism. The same conviction was represented in England by Lloyd George, and as early as 1920 the English and Germans began to compete for the Russian market. From the Soviet side, Karl Radek was the first to make a move in the direction of a pragmatic understanding with the bourgeois German

government, which for him was of course only intended as a prelude to the ideological and material unity of the Russian and German Soviet countries: "I am not too little of a diplomat to pretend that I believe in the longevity of the German state of today. The German bourgeoisie does not believe in longevity of our life. So we are of one mind. But why shouldn't we exchange linen for medicines, wood for electrical appliances? Surely you don't demand a certificate of immortality from people you sell underwear to!"

The first formal contacts between the two governments served to solve the problem of the mutual prisoners of war. There were over a million Russian prisoners of war in Germany, and in Russia, alongside the considerable number of German prisoners of war, there were numerous civilian internees. In early 1919, for example, a "Reich Central Office for Prisoners of War and Civilians" was created, with a former vice sergeant named Moritz Schlesinger appointed as its head. With the backing of Brockdorff-Rantzau, he thwarted Allied plans to recruit an anti-Bolshevik army from the POWs, and in November 1919 Viktor Kopp arrived in Berlin as a confidante of the Soviet government to deal with the prisoner of war issue and, if possible, to establish further contacts. In April 1920 an agreement was concluded and the representatives of both sides, Viktor Kopp in Berlin and Gustav Hilger in Moscow, were given certain consular powers and personal immunity after some time.

Rumors were constantly circulating in Germany of Russian participation in revolutionary movements, especially after the Kapp Putsch, but no compelling evidence was presented. The months of July and August 1920 marked a high point in relations, which were not yet official, when Lenin wanted above all to establish a common border with Germany. The German government declared itself neutral, but the anti-Western, anti-Polish line of not a few right-wing politicians also had considerable influence in the Reich Ministry of Defense and the Foreign Office: not only Seeckt, but also the diplomat Ago von Maltzan and the later Reich Chancellor Josef Wirth adopted it. The strength of the Russophile Prussian-German tradition and the confidence to regain political power by exploiting the East-West antagonism was thus impressively demonstrated, because after the formation of the Unified Communist Party of Germany in December 1920 at the latest, nobody could overlook the fact that the situation was completely different from before the war, because now Soviet Russia could now think it had its own party in Germany with much better reason than Germany thought it had in 1917-18 in the form of the Bolsheviks in Russia. But Lenin stubbornly strived for state rapprochement, because he too hoped to profit from divisions and because, like many Russians, he held German organization and technology in very high esteem. On the German side, in turn, there were not only the strategic considerations of Seeckt and Maltzan, but also the interests of many entrepreneurs in the resumption of trade, that is, the pressure of that

relatively independent *economic policy line*. Thus, in the spring of 1921, Foreign Minister Simons found kind words about Soviet Russia: despite the ideological opposition, both sides could deal with one another in a *realpolitik* way. The March Action did not fundamentally change this attitude either, although this time the influence of the Comintern was beyond doubt. A major reason for this was certainly concern about Section 116 of the Versailles Treaty, which reserved the right for Russia to assert claims for reparations. Moreover, the *fulfillment chancellor*, Wirth, was an outspoken enemy of the *robber state* of Poland. In September 1921 mutual representatives were appointed, admittedly still below full diplomatic status: Professor Kurt Wiedefeld in Moscow and Nikolaj Krestinski in Berlin. After the Allied decision on Upper Silesia, which was deeply disappointing for Germany, Ago von Maltzan was appointed head of the Eastern Department of the Foreign Office. At about the same time, the first contacts between the Reichswehr and the Red Army were established. On the other hand, various plans were made in the West for the formation of an international financial consortium for the purpose of Russia's economic reconstruction, among whose exponents were Lloyd George and also the Western-oriented Reich Foreign Minister Walther Rathenau. Lenin saw in this an attack by capitalism against the independence of his country, and gave his delegation highly revealing instructions when Russia was invited, like Germany, to take part in a world economic conference in Genoa. Its most important and most sensational result was the Treaty of Rapallo, which was signed on April 16, 1922. The immediate history of its creation was strange and has not been fully clarified to this day due to the inaccessibility of the Soviet files. Basically, the treaty was signed against the will of Rathenau and Ebert, but it was nevertheless a consistent event: the two great defeated nations of the world war found each other, mutually renounced highly uncertain, albeit fundamentally important claims—the Russians the section 116, the Germans compensation for the nationalizations of German property—and they established full diplomatic relations. The signing of the treaty came as a real shock to the Western powers, because a new possibility in international politics now came into view: Germany and Russia might one day form a genuine alliance against the West. The radical alternative that Churchill had championed against Lloyd George seemed irretrievably vanished: making Germany an ally in an anti-Bolshevik war of liberation. How deep would the shock have been if a Soviet Germany had actually signed a much more far-reaching treaty! Indeed, among the German Communists there was a mixture of triumph and disappointment, for while the treaty broke the isolation of Soviet Russia, it also strengthened German bourgeois government and thereby resistance to the revolution. Was it really a *stage* on the right road? Wasn't the Ebert government of 1918/19 wrongly called a stage, i.e., mistaken for a Kerensky government? It sounded neither convincing nor really convinced when the *Rote Fahne* made the following statement on April 18 under the heading "German-Russian Peace Treaty": "For Germany, the

present turn in her policy *can* have important consequences. If Rathenau seizes the moment and continues the policy he has begun, then all questions between Germany and the Entente states *can* be asked *anew*. We do not want to hide the fact that we do not trust Mr. Rathenau to consistently continue this policy. We also do not believe that a bourgeois government could do it.”

The *Völkischer Beobachter*, on the other hand, spoke of a “bartering away of the German people” and of the “crime of Rapallo,” and after Rathenau’s assassination, wrote on June 28, 1922: “Rathenau stepped up in Cannes for a supranational banker government. The name of the same man stands but also on the Treaty of Rapallo, which binds Germany to the Bolshevik, allegedly anti-capitalist Russia to the core. Here we have the personal union between international Jewish high finance and international Jewish Bolshevism.”

The state-political line was thus a middle line, and it served to maintain Germany’s middle position. Although Brockdorff-Rantzau was proud of the relationship of trust that he felt bound him to Ischitscherin, he never lost the conviction that he was dealing with “unscrupulous fanatics” in Moscow whose intention it was one day to advance the “borders of Asia” as far as the Rhine. Stresemann, on the other hand, covered up all the efforts of his officials to protect Russian-German relations from damage, even if it meant yielding to blackmail, but in his eyes a *marriage* to Soviet Russia would have meant “getting into bed with the murderer of one’s own people.” Brockdorff-Rantzau and Stresemann continued the Rapallo policy only because Germany’s position as a great power seemed tied to maintaining maneuvering room vis-à-vis the Western Allies, and they did the Soviet Union a great service in supporting the policy of accommodation with the West with the “Berlin Treaty” of April 1926 which counterbalanced the possibility that Germany could ever be used by England or France as a staging area for a war against the Soviet Union. The policy of the Communist Party of Germany leadership in those years also served the goal of preventing Germany from becoming definitively oriented towards the West and counteracting “Western European” tendencies within communism itself. It is doubtful whether the Soviet government actually believed in the danger of war, which it painted on the wall in garish colors, because there were good reasons for the correctness of an assumption shared by supporters and opponents alike, namely that in the event of an aggressive war of the western powers against the Soviet Union, an insurmountable resistance would develop behind the front and in the homeland. But relations had been extremely strained since the Baldwin government, threatened by the great general strike of May 1926, took very energetic action against the Soviet system of influence and espionage in the country and finally broke off diplomatic relations in the spring of 1927. Titles like “Soviet versus Civilization” were no longer unusual in England, and

theses were heard again that had been advocated almost exclusively by Winston Churchill after 1920: there was a virtual state of war between Moscow and the capitalist states, in which the Bolsheviks attacked all the time, while the bourgeois side—Great Britain today, maybe the United States tomorrow—so far has only been a *victim* and hasn't even started to seriously defend itself. A little later, the French ambassador in Moscow was faced with a situation similar to that of General Hoffmann in the summer of 1918: in the Soviet Union, a new revolution was taking place against the peasants and the last remnants of the bourgeoisie, which was “carried out in cold blood in a state of complete external peace and full of internal order, in order to eradicate whatever remains of personal liberty and private property.” Jean Herbette therefore suggested to his foreign minister, Aristide Briand, that it would be better to consider breaking off relations than to show “yielding to evil.” So the desire to go on a *crusade* was certainly present in England and France, but it never developed into a will, because in the end the prevailing consciousness was that the structure of society would not permit a war of this particular kind.

Obstacles included not only the existence of a strong socialist movement, which was in significant parts pro-Soviet, but also the German middle position policy. Within this policy, it was precisely the Reichswehr that formed the left wing, so to speak, and was most closely allied with the Soviet Union. When they crushed the threatening uprising of the communists in Central Germany in 1923, there was already a “Sonderstab R” in the Reichswehr Ministry, German and Russian officers had been conducting negotiations behind the ambassador’s back, and a German aircraft factory was already under construction near Moscow. Cooperation continued after 1923, and the Lipetsk Aviation School near Voronezh, a gas combat school near Saratov and a training ground for combat vehicles near Kazan were established. Even when the *Manchester Guardian* and a few days later Philipp Scheidemann in his Reichstag speech of December 16, 1926 brought the hitherto strictly secret cooperation out into the open and both the Social Democratic Party and the Communist Workers’ Party began a violent campaign against the *Soviet shells*, nothing essential changed. In Reichswehr circles in particular, an image of the Soviet Union and its army spread that was far more positive than that of the German Nationalists or even the National Socialists. Whereas communist publications praised the unity and inner strength of the Red Army “of which a bourgeois army cannot even dream,” the Chief of the Troops Office, General von Blomberg, came to a not so dissimilar conclusion in 1928 after an extensive inspection trip, and he could not praise enough the warm commitment of War Commissar Voroshilov “for maintenance of close military relations with the Reichswehr.”

But it was Voroshilov who caused a serious disruption in German-Soviet relations in the next

year.

On May 1, 1929, Brockdorff's successor, Herbert von Dirksen, had to report that a replica of the armored cruiser had been carried along at the May parade in Moscow, with an inscription affixed to it saying that Germany was sacrificing 80 million for the armored cruiser, but was letting the unemployed starve. Caricatures moved on the ship, which was marked by the German colors and which, according to inscriptions, represented the Social Democratic Reich Ministers, the Reich Minister of Defense, the Prussian Minister of the Interior and the Chief of Police of Berlin. Voroshilov explained in his speech that in so-called democratic Germany, the social democratic police chief Zörgiebel had banned May Day demonstrations, but despite this ban the working people were taking to the streets to demonstrate for their goals. This time Stresemann did not mince his words and instructed the ambassador to protest sharply against the "impudent mockery of the Reich flag" and against Voroshilov's inadmissible interference in domestic German affairs. In a conversation with Stresemann, Ambassador Krestinski explained the events in such a way that the parades for May Day were being prepared for months in workers' circles, with not even the party authorities and certainly not the government being able to get involved. But Voroshilov had actually only polemicized against the Social Democratic Party and not against the German government. The German government was satisfied with this not very credible explanation; but it could hardly have had any doubt that *friendly* state relations rested on exceedingly fragile foundations. At the same time, the state of the Soviet Union wanted to identify itself with a German party, and this German party had in the meantime built up a comprehensive intelligence apparatus, the management of which was entirely in the hands of Soviet specialists and which tended to turn German industry into a glass house, the interior of which was well known to Moscow. It is true that German engineers who were active in the Soviet Union also allegedly worked for the German intelligence service, as was alleged in the so-called Shakhty trial of 1928, but whoever looks at the gigantic apparatuses of the Communist Party of Germany and the intelligence service of the Red Army and the almost complete closure of the The Soviet Union on the one hand, and the corresponding institutions on the German side, could not have the slightest doubt about the enormous disproportionality. However, the best non-communist friends of the Soviet Union in Germany, in a seemingly paradoxical way, were the representatives of the *monopoly bourgeoisie*, along with the Reichswehr and intellectuals such as Thomas and Heinrich Mann who formed the "Society of Friends of the Soviet Union." Some of them—including such influential men as Peter Klöckner, Ernst von Borsig and Ernst Poensgen—set out on a trip to Russia in the spring of 1931, from which they returned with great hopes and expectations, for they had been promised that the Soviet Union would buy even larger part of the industrial

equipment that it needed to fulfill the five-year plan than it had already done. Admittedly, this trip in particular was sharply criticized in the German press, and state relations were once again put to the test when the Soviet Union signed non-aggression treaties with Poland and France in January and November 1932, thereby appearing to strengthen the Versailles system, among whose harshest critics it had belonged to since 1919 and, according to Stalin, wanted to continue to belong. A more peculiar relationship between two states had not existed in world history up to that point: Germany's economic and political hopes of overcoming the world economic crisis rested to a large extent on *orders from the Russians* ; in terms of state-policy, the country's middle position *between East and West* was linked to the existence of the Soviet Union; socio-politically, however, the Soviet Union was a party to the civil war that began to unfold in Germany after the *Bloody May* , when *Black Friday* on the New York Stock Exchange in October 1929 brought about an analogue of the post-war crisis of 1919-1923.

Chapter II, Section 9

The Limited Civil War in Germany

9. The limited civil war in Germany

It was only the world economic crisis that created the conditions in Germany under which two civil war parties could win large numbers of supporters, but it did not create these parties themselves. Rather, both had a special relationship to the crisis, and nothing was more likely than that they would now find a wide hearing.

The Communist Party was the embodied doctrine of the general crisis of *capitalism*. It could claim to be vindicated by world developments when, on *Black Friday*, October 24, 1929, stocks and other securities on the New York Stock Exchange experienced an unprecedented plunge and as a result there was an equally unprecedented decline in production, which quickly spread to other industrialized countries and dovetailed with a severe agricultural crisis that had been looming for some time. It had caused surprise and even ridicule when the Sixth Congress of the Comintern, in the summer of 1928, announced the end of the stabilization phase of capitalism, for at that time the world economy was still in a period of boom; at the beginning of 1930, however, unemployment was rising steadily, especially in Germany, and the partners in the grand coalition could not agree on whether the employers, who were squeezed by high wages and non-wage costs and whose competitiveness on the world market had been weakened, or the workers, whose incomes were often not far from the subsistence level, should bear the brunt of the crisis. This led to the fall of the Müller government and the formation of a presidential government under Heinrich Brüning at the end of March 1930. Ernst Thälmann claimed that fascism had thus taken over Germany as a result, but if the Reich President, through the Reich Chancellor on the basis of Article 48, practiced a kind of dictatorship, it was undoubtedly a provisional dictatorship, which differed from normal party democracy no more than the crisis state of the economy differed from the normal state of a medium-sized business cycle. And looked at in the light of day, there was

no fundamental difference between a boom and a crisis; in the capitalist system, i.e. in the world market economy, production and consumption are not directly related to each other as they are on a self-sufficient farm or in an isolated rural community, but are linked to one another through numerous intermediate stages of independently acting actors. The system is therefore in itself a permanent crisis, i.e. in an incessant process of adaptation and development, in which larger crises occur again and again like knots in a net. But since the communists oriented themselves to that farm and rural community as a model and wished to make them a reality anew *at a higher level* by means of a planned economy, they were the best spokesmen and champions of all those who suffered most from the crisis or who took the greatest offense at the injustices and inequalities which necessarily resulted from the *individualism* of this system, i.e. from the freedom of movement of individuals and companies aimed at *profit*. The question of whether the system, in its overall character, which was not merely economic and determined by many hundred years of history, was nevertheless able to grant all individuals a higher degree of security and prosperity than any other, provided that it was on the way to being more fully formed, was not asked by the communists; for they took it as self-evident that the replacement of this unjust, chaotic, opaque, and inefficient system with *socialism* would end misery and exploitation, hostility between nations, and war, forever. In the world economic crisis, therefore, they were once again able to become the *great party of protest and hope* that they had been at the end of the war with their rejection of the *massacre of nations*.

But there were undoubtedly also special causes which perhaps explained the unusual severity of the crisis. Already in the early 1920s, none other than John Maynard Keynes wrote a booklet about the economic consequences of the peace treaty, in which he warned of the incalculable consequences that would have to result from the German reparations payments, since these were politically justified thus as non-systemic capital transfers. Wouldn't the crisis be greatly alleviated if *tribute payments* stopped? If this smaller solution was probably more realistic, it also presented extraordinary difficulties, since the reparation creditors England and France were themselves obliged to repay large amounts of war loans to the USA. If America was not willing to renounce its claims, then National Socialist agitation against the tribute payments would have to amount to the establishment of German autarky. The German Nationalists and National Socialists did not shy away from this consequence when, even before that Black Friday, they unleashed large-scale agitation against the *Young Plan*, which the Allies and the German government wanted to replace the Dawes Plan. It offered considerable benefits to Germany, but also set an end date for reparations payments, 1988, which seemed to imply the *enslavement* of the German people for two generations.

Opposition to this plan was unavoidable and in line with the system, but the way in which the *Reich Committee for the German People's Initiative*, in which Hugenberg and Hitler worked together on an equal footing with representatives of the *Stahlhelm* and the *Pan-German Association*, exercised this opposition, contributed significantly with its demagogic intensity to the NSDAP's rise to national prominence and its ability to significantly increase its number of votes in state and local elections. Although the referendum in December failed miserably, it nevertheless showed in a strange way what demagogic agitation was capable of despite obvious folly, because a rejection of the Young Plan by the German people would not have eliminated the tribute payments but merely left the Dawes Plan in force. But when the Reich President dissolved the Reichstag in July 1930, which had demanded the repeal of an important emergency decree, the Communist Party of Germany published its "program statement for the national and social liberation of the German people" in August 1930 for the new elections, which considerably exceeded the National Socialist in radicalism and irresponsible demagogy. The party solemnly pledged that in the event of its seizure of power it would declare null and void all obligations arising from the Treaty of Versailles and would not pay a penny of interest on imperialist loans, credits and capital investments. It also demanded the introduction of the seven-hour day and the four-day work week and promised to ensure that those German areas that would express the wish (including South Tyrol and the Sudeten areas) the possibility of annexation to Soviet Germany, "in agreement with the revolutionary workers France, England, Poland, Italy, Czechoslovakia, etc." Demagoguery and naiveté could not reach a higher degree, and Hitler, who always advocated for the payment of private debts, had to appear in comparison as a measured and reasonable man, or at least as a Western-oriented politician who did not want to tear apart Germany's connection with the world economy from the outset, while the communists demanded a German-Russian world domination, provided that they did merely instrumentalize nationalistic phrases. Nevertheless, the elections of September 14 brought them a great success and they never tired of celebrating their electoral victory, which made them the strongest party in Berlin and increased their number of seats to 77. But the success of the National Socialists was even greater; 6.5 million voters brought more than 100 National Socialist deputies to the Reichstag, and no party in German parliamentary history had ever made such a leap—from 12 to 107 deputies.

The *Rote Fahne* was able to proudly print the congratulations of *Pravda* and the Comintern, and its leading article of September 16 spoke confidently of the preparations for the storm for Soviet Germany, "in which no Hitler and Goebbels, but also no social-fascist pioneers of fascism" would exist.

The National Socialists, in turn, saw in the election result as “a verdict of annihilation for the entire policy of compliance,” and on September 25 they were allowed to publish an article by Lord Rothermere, which the press magnate had written for his Daily Mail, and which ascribed to the National Socialists the task of definitively protecting all of Europe from Bolshevism, for which they might expect considerable concessions from Poland and also from Czechoslovakia.

When the Reichstag opened on October 13, 1930, the 107 National Socialists in their brown uniforms moved in and, as a conspicuous splash of color, took up by far the most space on the right-hand side of the building. But even two and a half years earlier, at the opening of the Reichstag in 1928, the observers were no less struck by the Red Front Fighter uniforms in the ranks of the Communists and the powerful figures of many of their deputies. In fact, violent scenes of noise immediately ensued. Two parties of civil war, intent on annihilating one another and by no means merely *German* in importance and purpose, now faced one another in considerable strength in Parliament, and it is time to take a look at the civil war that was unfolding in the streets Germany, but also in a different way at the newspaper stands and in the bookshops, and last but not least within the parliaments.

The first thing to emphasize, however, is that this civil war was only a *limited* one, because the government, despite all the street fighting and all the verbal violence in brochures and magazines, ultimately held the reins firmly in its hands. In Russia, after the Bolsheviks seized power, a real civil war had raged between large armed formations which had no higher authority over them, mainly because the country was still at war and was too large spatially for the victorious party in the capitals to have prevailed everywhere right away. But also in Italy, where for the first time in world history a parliamentary government had been confronted with two strong civil war parties during the years 1920-1922, the struggles between socialists and fascists had completely dominated some regions at times, with the virtual elimination of the state. In Germany, on the other hand, Brüning's presidential government and the long-established government of the Weimar coalition in Prussia held their own during the crisis with police operations, newspapers confiscations, bans on uniforms, restrictions on the right to demonstrate, and even with forced newspaper circulations. In Prussia, for example, all newspapers had to print a government statement when a referendum was held in August 1931 on the dissolution of the Prussian state parliament, which was supported by the Stahlhelm and the NSDAP and which the communists joined in the last hour under the quickly invented name “Red Referendum.” The high point of this self-assertion was the ban on the SA and SS issued by Interior Minister General Groener, after Hindenburg, through Brüning's efforts and after a symptomatic

change of heart by the Social Democratic Party, had been elected Reich President for the second time in April 1932 and had prevailed over Hitler by a considerable margin. The history of this government has often been told, and it is therefore sufficient to cite a few keywords here: the support of the Social Democratic Party, which made it its primary aim to prevent a “Italian-style fascist government against the working class,” the increased credit withdrawals after the September elections, the policy of austerity and deflation, which aggravated the crisis but brought closer the foreign policy goal of canceling reparations, the rise in unemployment to 6 million in 1932, the failure of the planned German-Austrian customs union as a result of French counteractions, the “Hoover Moratorium” in July 1931, the challenge of the “Harzburg Front” to *national Germany* in October 1931, the surge in National Socialist votes up to the culmination of the elections to the Prussian state parliament on April 24, 1932, the increasing loss of confidence in Hindenburg and the Chancellor’s resignation on May 30 1932. At none of these times was there a danger that the government would lose control, but neither there yet was any fear that Communists and National Socialists might come together in anything other than negative voting unions in the parliaments.

But even if the civil war was limited, it did not only take place in street fights, but also and even primarily in theoretical treatises, in polemical pamphlets and in combative newspaper articles, and as an intellectual civil war it certainly did not begin with the Brüning government, but from the very beginning of the republic it took place apart from the normal disputes between the *state-supporting* parties as the mutual negation of the right to exist between communists and militant anti-communists.

These beginnings have already been described, but even during the phase of stabilization and then during the crisis, the starting point and the most important basic component remained completely unchanged: the talk of the communists about the death sentence, executioner and grave, which were identical with their belief in the imminent end of the capitalist system. The descriptions of the successes of socialist construction in Russia, where the workers could finally feel like masters of the state, served this belief; that prediction was to be confirmed by the voyages of delegations, who, on returning from chosen routes and given special treatment, would find that the villas of the German capitalists might soon be turned into children’s homes and schools like the palaces of the Russian nobles. How could it not have aroused indignation when it was pointed out that Otto Wolff’s Mansfelder mining company received 7 million marks from taxpayers’ pockets just because the multimillionaire threatened to lay off workers, because “millionaires who lay off workers belong to be put up against the wall, not be rewarded more.” No distinction can be made between Christian and Jewish capitalists in

the struggle to liberate and secure the workers, as the National Socialists want, for both are equally exploiters and equally condemned to death by history, while German and Jewish proletarians (if any) belong together.

Thus, between 1925 and 1933, despite the strong emergence of the National Socialists, there was basically only a slight shift in emphasis, since the real enemy remained the capitalist system, and within the system, social democracy attracted the most attention for a long time. In 1925, Karl Radek made no less use of the Barmat affair than the National Socialists did, and in his brochure "The Barmat Social Democracy" he also spoke of the "Polish-Jewish-Dutch-German speculators" who were particularly obliging towards social democracy, while Stresemann, for example, relied heavily on the concern of the "Russian Jew Litvin." According to Radek, however, the deepest reason for all corruption is that social democracy supports capitalism. Therefore, only the elimination of the leaders of this party can create uncorrupted, i.e. create healthy conditions: "If the German revolution hangs the Scheidemanns and the entire social-democratic Barmat clique, then...it may carve out a marble monument for them: a dog that unselfishly licks its master's whip."

Walter Ulbricht, on the other hand, did not overlook in 1932 (as did Radek in other passages) that some of the workers were also bribed by the bourgeoisie with higher wages and that the Nazis, due to the coalition policy of the Social Democratic Party and the General German Trade Union Federation, were able to "gain influence in the petty-bourgeois and sometimes even the working class strata," and therefore he postulated "the expulsion of the capitalist parasites, the big industrialists, bankers, Junkers, large merchants, bourgeois politicians, worker traitors, speculators and profiteers" after the "shining example" of the Soviet Union.

It is not difficult to see why the German public was not particularly excited about Hitler's "heads will roll" and even about his anti-Semitism: even Radek tried to use anti-Semitic emotions, and Ulbricht's monumental concept of annihilation also had to victimize the majority of Jews, albeit only in the manner of total expropriation.

Despite all this, the attraction of communism, especially for intellectuals and ethically minded people, was hardly diminished. For example, the city pastor Eckert in Mannheim justified his conversion from the Social Democratic Party to the Communist Party of Germany by saying that he had gone where people really tried to help the weary and the burdened: "Capitalism must die so that the people can live." Only through Bolshevism could the enormous mass impoverishment be put to an end to, for Bolshevism today was nothing other than the working, suffering people themselves.

It was not easy for National Socialist propaganda to counter such simple and moving arguments. The Russian example was not a deterrent even for all peasants from the outset, especially since the Communist Party of Germany was careful not to speak of *collectivization*, but the workers could not fail to see how deeply *Marxist* views were, so to speak, innate in them; therefore, the “National Socialist Factory Cell Organization” criticized exploitation, entrepreneurial arbitrariness and capitalism in general no less harshly than the Marxists did, and they sought merely to substitute a national concept in the place of the international one.

The task was easier when it came to maintaining the traditional values. Thus Hans Schemm in his pamphlet “The Red War. Mother or Comrade?” set to the readers the alternatives “Christian affirmation of life or barbaric annihilation!...Hitler or Stalin!” and he asked them to say the emergency prayer at the end of the day: “Protect us, God, from pestilence, from annihilation by Bolshevik animals.”

Joseph Goebbels expressed himself a good deal more crudely in his work “The Nazi-Socialist,” where the anti-bourgeois polemics are just as prominent as the anti-Jewish ones, without an identity being made plausible: “There is nothing more mendacious than a fat, well-fed man bourgeois who protests against the proletarian idea of class warfare...Certainly the Jew is also a human being. But the flea is also an animal and not a pleasant one. And since the flea is not a pleasant animal, we...have no duty to kill it to guard and protect...but to render him harmless.”

How strong the internal dependency was can already be seen in titles such as “The Communist Servants of Capitalists,” which took its evidence from the advertisements of large department stores in the *Rote Fahne*, but also from Wall Street loans to the Soviet Union.

As for the Soviet Union itself, it was of course easy to emphasize the *other side* to the communist eulogies, not least by quoting and reprinting from the writings of disappointed communists such as Panait Istrati’s “Russia Naked,” where a picture is developed from personal experience and from Soviet newspaper literature that no longer primarily focuses on the Cheka atrocities, but rather on working conditions and wages.

The events of the agitprop groups had no equivalent on the National Socialist side, since one can hardly cite the first attempts with Thingstätten (*translator: outdoor amphitheaters*) or the *fight for German culture*. It was characteristic of the recitation evenings and theatrical performances of these groups that they were by no means content with attacking the National

Socialists, but attacked everything connected with *capitalism*. A mocking song entitled "Suleika Destapar" about the "German State Party," the successor organization to the German Democratic Party, says:

"...The mixture is very fatal So volkish-Jewish-national! The Beene are rachitic, The Neese is Semitic, The Oogen are blue and purebred And no one claims it was."

In the same example of the *Rote Sprachrohr* (translator: *communist agitprop theatre*) a stage scene is reproduced in which Hitler, Goebbels and a few simple Nazis utter the cry "die Judah." On the other side of the stage are capitalists, among them Jews, and one of them says: "It will cost me but so what, the money will come back." At the end, the *Nazi actors* tear off their armbands, hold communist emblems in their hands and sing: "...And the Jews are also tolerable if they donate something for your fund; if you also want to risk a few pogroms, it must not end in class hatred." Obviously, National Socialism is conceived here as a deficient mode of Communism, and anti-Semitism is regarded as a first step on the right path, as far as it relates to the Jewish capitalists.

Strikingly often the *priests* and the center were mocked, apparently in context of *protecting the Soviet Union*. The positive resolution was formulated in a "troop song" like this:

"We protect the Soviet Union, You, our red fatherland ...Fascism threatens the whole world... Prole, there is only one way, the red avenger republic."

The direction of the domestic political attack was expressed with just as much emphasis: "Death to the bourgeoisie!...Civil war!...Our fatherland is the Soviet Union."

According to police reports, extremely violent songs were often sung by groups of children: "We incite, we're rushing to class warfare, fists ready, a kick in the body of the bourgeoisie...Grab the throats of the bourgeois state..." At the end of the chanting, the Red Pioneers attacked the members of the ensemble, who were dressed up as police officers, and knocked them to the ground to thunderous applause from the spectators. After that, some portraits were put up on the wall and the question was asked: "Who do we want to fire the first shot at? At Hitler...at Goebbels...at Brüning...at Severing...at Grzesinski."

As a rule, such bloodthirsty speeches and scenes did not take place at National Socialist meetings, and it is not at all incomprehensible that the Prussian police during the years 1930-1933 sometimes also regarded the Communists as the main enemy and the National

Socialists almost as allies, especially since extensive *dismantling work* , which was only successful with a small part of the troops, came only from the communist side. It was just as unsurprising that an Social Democratic Party functionary was of the opinion that the fascist spook would disappear, but that the decisive question for the future was: “For or against Bolshevism.”

Nevertheless, the most disturbing expression of this intellectual civil war is found not in communist literature, but in the organ of the left-wing intellectuals, the *Weltbühne* , and the attack was not directed against the National Socialists but against the German educated classes in general. Under the heading “Danish fields” Kurt Tucholsky wrote in the summer of 1927: “May the gas creep into your children’s playrooms! May they slowly sink, the little dolls. I wish the wife of the church councilor and the editor-in-chief and the mother of the sculptor and the sister of the banker that they will meet a bitter, agonizing death, all together. Because they want it that way, without wanting it. Because they are lazy. Because they don’t hear and don’t see and don’t feel.” There is no doubt that Tucholsky was guided here by the noblest pacifist motives. But what is bad is never a consequence of average feelings and seldom the consequence of base sentiments. Tucholsky adopted a collectivist attribution of guilt that made it all too likely that the extermination measures of a civil war would not stop with the popular speculators or even *the bourgeoisie* , indeed that they would not even spare women and children.

To his credit, however, Tucholsky knew of the brutalities of the *Landsknechts* , which must have had a far more bitter effect than even the *femicides* of alleged or actual traitors. In any case, as early as 1928 he could have read the description of a truly repulsive situation given by the former Freikorps officer and current high SA leader Manfred von Killinger in his booklet “Serious and Cheerful Stories from the Life of a Putsch.” Here Killinger tells how, during the fighting in Munich in 1919, a *Malweibchen* (translator: *art hoe*) who had behaved rebelliously had been brought to him. He then ordered a non-commissioned officer, with the help of two soldiers, to push up her skirts and to give her salutary lashes with a whip on her bare buttocks. Indeed, it is difficult to decide whether the unrestrained imagination of Tucholsky or the all-too-real brutality of Killinger must have evoked the deeper resentment and unbridled hatred within the groups denounced and threatened with annihilation.

It was extraordinarily difficult for those who, in the midst of these orgies of hatred, trusted in reason and strove for objectivity, to take a superior yet politically effective stand, when they themselves were being violently attacked. Social Democrats tended to direct their polemics against the pre-1914 ruling classes who today were constituting the real force of the brown

ranks, while the middle class and workers really belonged on the side of the Social Democrats. Anton Erkelenz, member of the Reichstag, wrote that the Prussian Junker and the backwoodsman from Pomerania smelled like Asia. But although he declared the communists to be the stirrup holders of fascism, he wanted to oppose the old battle cry “war on the palaces” to the carnage of the war of nations that the browns were planning.

Very rare are the words of understanding and approval of the German conditions as a whole. Herbert and Elisabeth Weichmann found such a word at the end of their travelogue about the Soviet Union, in which they described “everyday life in the Soviet state” in a way that was both non-polemical and credible: the uniform classless misery, the absence of any tranquility and leisure after the destruction of the old intelligentsia, the “hurrying, smoky everyday life filled with the noise of the machines and the struggles of the people.” So they returned with a new insight: “...that we can have a little more patience and love for our own conditions in Germany, knowing how much freer and more humane our existence is than we sometimes imagine.”

But Herbert and Elisabeth Weichmann were also nothing more than *social fascists* in the eyes of the communists. Even in the realm of theory and seemingly detached reflection, the intellectual civil war was taking place. However, the concept of social fascism did not emerge primarily from theoretical considerations, it was deeply and emotionally anchored in early experiences and evaluations, namely in the hatred of the orthodox Marxists for the *reformists* and then, during the war, for the *traitors*, the social patriots and social chauvinists. Nevertheless, a new dimension of polemics was reached when, after the German October defeat, Zinoviev declared the left-wing Social Democrats to be a “wing of fascism” in January 1924, and Stalin followed him in September 1924 with the thesis that fascism and social democracy were twins. It was a logical step when, after the September 1930 elections, it was claimed that “Brüning fascism” now ruled and that everyone who opposed the proletarian revolution was on the side of fascism. In fact, the question arose as to what could still be characteristic of fascism when *bourgeois democracy* is nothing other than the *dictatorship of the bourgeoisie* and when only one of the two *main classes* can exercise the dictatorship. So the simultaneous struggle against both auxiliaries of the bourgeoisie had to be the order of the day: against the NSDAP as *national fascism* and against the Social Democratic Party as *social fascism*, and in doing so the main thrust had been to target social democracy as the more insidious of the two hostile forces.

It was the opposition groups of the Communist Party of Germany who saw fate in this view and, starting in the early 1930s, told the party leadership: “Under this sign—the concept of

social fascism—you will succumb.” The most important of these groups was the Communist Party of Germany Opposition, in which the right-wingers expelled from the party gathered, headed by Heinrich Brandler and August Thalheimer. But the *Red Fighters* also made important contributions, all of which the communists tried to bring back into the unity of the workers’ movement, although the sharp criticism of bureaucracy and party dependence, as well as their own adherence to the concept of the “dictatorship of the proletariat” made the attempt seem hopeless from the start.

The critics of the theory of social fascism received a powerful comrade in Leon Trotsky, who after 1929 could be counted among the Russian emigrants. Far more sharply than anyone else, Trotsky saw the danger by the communists’ struggle against social fascism that the seizure of power would be suggested to National Socialism and that Hitler would then not be overthrown after a few weeks or months by the proletarians, who had finally united under the leadership of the Communist Party of Germany, as was expected in the Comintern. Rather, the National Socialist government would be the only one of all bourgeois governments capable of waging a war against the USSR, and in this war Hitler would be the executive of all world capitalism, the “Over-Wrangel of the world bourgeoisie.”

This was an amazing prophecy, but Trotsky, in fact, needed only to project his own case against Social Revolutionaries and Mensheviks onto *bourgeois* Germany, and his wars of aggression against Poland and Georgia, to arrive at this prediction. Trotsky again derived his hopes from an analogy to the Russian revolution, namely from his contempt for a quantitative preponderance of votes: "On the scales of electoral statistics, a thousand fascist votes weigh as much as a thousand communist votes. But on the scales of revolutionary struggle, a thousand workers in a large company weigh a hundred times greater force than a thousand officials and clerks with their wives and mothers-in-law. The bulk of the fascists consist of human dust."

Here Trotsky, for his part, was wrong, for he neglected the fact that, while many millions of *petty bourgeois* and *unenlightened workers* had flocked to the NSDAP, the nucleus of the party consisted of a large number of World War officers, whose Russian counterparts had been destroyed by the Bolshevik Party or forced to join the Red Army. But there could not be the slightest doubt about Trotsky’s opposition to National Socialism, any more than there could be about the opposition to the Communist Party of Germany Opposition or the Red Fighters.

It was different with the opposition groups within National Socialism or on its fringes. They,

too, took offense at the party's bureaucracy and bigwigs, and not least at Hitler's tactics of legality, but they did not conclude from this that the party had to wage a more decisive and promising struggle against communism. Rather, they called for more decisive action against Versailles, the Western powers and capitalism, and in doing so they approached or even went over to the Communist Party of Germany. The most famous example was Ernst Niekisch, who in his magazine *Widerstand* fought the National Socialists as a Romanized enemy power on German soil, which was breaking off the fight against Versailles, the big city, bourgeois decadence and the capitalist money economy by negating with Bolshevism the Russian-Asiatic way of life, in which alone the hope for a liberation of Germany from the "cesspool of English prostitution" was founded. The greatest sensation, however, was caused by Richard Scheringer's transition to communism, one of the three lieutenants from Colonel Ludwig Beck's regiment stationed in Ulm, who had been sentenced to imprisonment in 1930 for National Socialist subversion of the Reichswehr. Hitler had sworn his oath of legality in these proceedings, and Scheringer vehemently rejected the legality tactics after he had entered a kind of communist university at the Gollnow Fortress and had understood there that a real "policy of violence against the western powers" was only possible if liberalism, pacifism and western decadence had first met their end with capitalism. For a while after April 1931, the Communist Party of Germany followed the so-called *Scheringer Line*, which roughly corresponded to Radek's Schlageter course of 1923, and it attracted quite a few National Socialists and National Revolutionaries, including Bodo Uhse, the former leader of the Bund Oberland, Captain Beppo Römer and Count Stenbock-Fermor. All of them, like Richard Scheringer himself, were filled with the feeling that they had moved from a merely pseudo-radical party to a genuinely radical party. And there was not a single prominent communist who would have gone to the National Socialists with the corresponding reason. It was obvious that the fight against the Jews was just a weak partial and diversionary maneuver when the real task was the fight against capitalism or *the West*.

But wasn't anti-Semitism a sign of self-deception and complacency, when the main concern was the fight against communism? In any case, Scheringer could afford to point out that not a single Jew sat on the Central Committee of the Communist Party of Germany, while there were several at the top of the Hugenberg-concern. Perhaps the phenomenon of communism was not really acknowledged if it was given the easy interpretation that a specific and easily identifiable group of people as its originator? But it could also be asked whether this simplified concretization did not correspond to the other concretization of *the capitalists* or even *the speculators* and only showed a lower degree of abstraction.

In any case, where the spiritual civil war presented itself as an instruction for violent civil

war, the communists had a great advantage. Since 1923 they had circulated a periodical entitled *On Civil War*, which later became *Oktober*; they published books containing specific advice on armed insurrection, although mostly in the form of accounts of past civil wars, successful or unsuccessful, such as the Russian October, but also the uprisings of Reval 1924 or Canton at the end of 1927. In the book by "A. Neuberg" from 1928, "The Armed Uprising," on which Erich Wollenberg and Hans Kippenberger, Mikhail Tukhachevsky and Ho Chi Minh also worked, the various problems of a violent seizure of power are discussed most carefully. For example, the Hamburg uprising of 1923 is described in detail, and is considered as a whole as a not entirely successful replica of the revolution in Petrograd; individual terror is fully affirmed for revolutionary times, and the demand, citing Lenin, is "to liquidate the leaders of the counter-revolution" or "to get finish off the enemy's top leadership in good time." All in all, what is decisive is that "the enemy's living power is liquidated," and this also includes the use of "class terror" against the bourgeoisie. All of this advice could be based on actual events; there was not the slightest doubt that the writers were experienced fighters and really meant what they expressed in words.

In contrast, the so-called Boxheim documents, which caused a stir at the end of 1931 and were regarded as evidence of the preparations for civil war by the National Socialists, were little more than a thought experiment. The author, Dr. Werner Best, by no means drew up plans for a violent seizure of power, but he proceeded from the hypothetical and not impossible situation that after a communist uprising, the supreme state authorities that had existed since then would *disappear*, so that the nation could only be represented and protected by the other militant party (SA, Landeswehr). In this case, a course of action is envisaged which is very harsh, but which goes little beyond what the military authorities would do in the event of an insurrection. The most striking difference is that only "every German (not Jew)" from the age of 16 is obliged to serve as ordered by the authorities. As certainly as the document shows a radical determination to fight, it is not appropriate to equate it with the *Armed Insurrection* or similar publications of the communists.

In the concrete descriptions of the limited civil war on the streets and in the statements, declarations and demands on it, a broad similarity can be observed in the main organs of the two parties.

A selection of keywords, headlines and short statements from the *Roten Fahne* might be as follows: "Murderers of the swastika... murder bandits... Zörgiebel Soldiers' Association... Nazis and police soldiers shoot at the Liebknechthaus... Nazi hordes attack red students... Orgy of murderous incitement (through the bourgeois press after the murder of the police

officers Lenk and Anlauf)... Nazi murder den... principal murder den... march into the district of the warmongers... in the west, the residential districts of the warmongers and fascists... They (the members of the Chinese Red Army) put the Chinese Siemens and the Chinese police officers and generals against the wall... In the Berlin police headquarters the communists are seen as the enemy par excellence (quote from an article by Ossietzky)... Our leader: Stalin... (Pictures from Siemensstadt) Works from the future Leninstadt... Today Siemens-Schaltwerk. In the future Marx plant. Today still Wernerwerk. In the future Stalinwerk... SA civil war against working-class districts of Berlin... brown killers.”

In the *Völkischer Beobachter*, the corresponding formulations are as follows: “Desert murder raids by the Bolshevik rabble... Red murder continues to rage... The Bolshevik underworld in Berlin... Communists shoot at National Socialists... Representatives of the Soviet Russian Foreign Legion... The Reds want civil war... red murder bandits... beastly atrocities by red beasts... Hörsing-bandits... the bloodstream of Marxism: 8359 dead and badly injured National Socialists.” “...Hitler Youth Herbert Norkus stabbed to death by communists... bloodlust of the Marxist ‘Iron Front’... Moscow cavalry general Thälmann... red murder in Upper Silesia... red sub-humanity... the murderous Reichsbanner.”

Despite all the similarities, the differences are nonetheless remarkable: neither of the two parties fights exclusively against the other, but the communists also count the police among their opponents (“Zörgiebel bandits”), while the National Socialists align the Reichsbanner with the communists. The communists take great advantage in making a sociological characterization and charging as a *worker-killer* any policeman who has used self-defense against a threatening mob; the Nazis, on the other hand, can bring into play the communists’ self-identification with Moscow and the fact that the *lumpenproletariat* sided predominantly with the communists. (However, the communists also made use of this well Marxist term and applied it to the unemployed SA men.)

Three examples will illustrate this civil war.

On March 20, 1927, the Berlin SA (then barely a tenth of the strength of the Red Front Fighters’ League) celebrated its one-year anniversary with a night-time event in Trebbin (Mark) with a fiery speech by Gauleiter Dr. Goebbels. On the return trip the next evening, the SA men noticed that the front compartments of the arriving train were occupied by Red Front Fighters’ League men. They greet them with clenched fists, and the SA men perceive this as a provocation, so they try to break into the compartment. The Red Front Fighters’ League people draw pistols and thus hold their opponents back. Their excitement is tremendous.

Wherever the train stops, they open a stone bombardment on the wagons. The SA got off the train at the Lichterfelde-Ost station and tried to storm the communist compartment. The Standartenführer received a shot in the stomach. Another SA man falls under the shots. But the communists' car, who are very much outnumbered, is now badly damaged by stones thrown, and when a police ambulance finally arrives, it turns out that almost all of the 23 communists are seriously injured. From the train station, around 1,000 SA men march through Steglitz and Friedenau to Wittenbergplatz. "Insolent Jews were beaten up without further ado." But already on the following day no uniformed SA man was allowed to be seen in the streets of Berlin. The Prussian government banned the Berlin branch of the NSDAP.

On July 17, 1932, the Hamburg SA carried out a demonstration march under the protection of the police, which was mainly intended to move through the working-class district of Altona. This intention was perceived as a provocation by the communists and apparently by large sections of the population. It was not clarified who fired the first shot, but in any case the SA and the police were exposed to violent attacks from all sides, just as they were in enemy territory, which they responded to in a similar way as the police had done in the *bloody May* of 1929. 18 dead and 16 seriously injured were the victims of a process that was at the mercy of the communists when the *right to demonstrate* was undisputed, and for which the National Socialists were responsible, when a march of uniformed and presumably armed men in hostile neighborhoods was not a demonstration but a constitutes an intolerable provocation.

When the newly elected Prussian state parliament, the majority of which consisted of the communists and the three times stronger National Socialists, convened for its first session on May 25, 1932, a heated debate quickly erupted about the Prussian judiciary, which was accused with great passion by both sides of partisanship and bias, and when Wilhelm Pieck had taken the floor, he shouted at the National Socialists: "The mass murder of revolutionary workers was only introduced when your party appeared in political life. There are an enormous number of murderers in your ranks:" As a result, National Socialist deputies rushed to the lectern to drag Pieck down; members of the communist faction came to his aid and a regular battle ensued in which the outnumbered communists were soon driven out of the hall and several were seriously injured. The Social Democrats, like the center faction, had left the meeting room when the violence began, and the Communists reproached them severely for this, which in the meantime was answered with the counter-question whether one could fight for those of whom one so often referred to as "worker murderers" and threatened with "short trials."

For the *bloody Sunday of Alton* , however, one could with good reason assign the real blame

to the new Reich government, the Reich government of von Papen, which had been formed after Brüning's dismissal under the significant influence of the chief of the ministerial office in the Reich Ministry of Defense, Lieutenant General von Schleicher. It was the first government in the Reich whose formation was based on the limited civil war between the communists and the National Socialists, and it was the first government that had to seriously reckon with the possibility of an unlimited civil war against both extremist parties. With it began the eve of the National Socialist takeover of power.

Chapter II, Section 10

The Eve of the National Socialist Takeover

There were many reasons why the Reich President withdrew his confidence in his chancellor on May 30, 1932, not least because Hindenburg felt resentment towards Brüning precisely *because* of the election that had made him the candidate of the *Reds* and the *Catholics* and thereby alienated him from the right. That is why he pushed all the more for a right turn, which Brüning resisted. One of the other main reasons was the ban on the SA, with which the government had just demonstrated its impartiality after the Red Front Fighters' League had already been banned since May 1929. But Hindenburg and Groener were not convinced that Communists and National Socialists could be equated since they had very different relationships to the state, to national ideas and to the will to fight. Therefore, the ban was not imposed without a kind of pedagogical intention, namely to separate the "wonderful human material" that had gathered in the SA from those who were basically Bolsheviks, and thereby to win them over for cooperation in the state. The ban, however, still went too far for Hindenburg, especially because the military associations of other parties were not affected. He primarily had the Reichsbanner in mind, which according to his own self-image was non-partisan and republican. Thus, to everyone's surprise, Franz von Papen, a little-known centrist deputy, was appointed Chancellor on June 1. He formed a government made up largely of nobles, and not merely apostrophized by Social Democrats, as *the Barons' Cabinet*. They immediately made two far-reaching decisions: lifting the ban on the SA and also on uniforms and dissolving the Reichstag. The new elections were set for July 31. In and of themselves, these decisions were democratic, and they thus stood in contrast to Brüning's policy, who had emphasized when forming his second cabinet in October 1931 that he would now be even more independent of the parties. After the elections of the last few months there could be no doubt that the Reichstag elected in September 1930 no longer reflected the popular mood. However, more democracy at this point necessarily meant more radicalization, and in this respect the decision was again *non* -democratic. A similar paradox can be seen in the coup d'état of July 20, with which the Braun government in Prussia was

deposed, so that a Reich Commissioner took its place, namely the Reich Chancellor von Papen himself. After its heavy electoral defeat on April 24th the Braun government was only the caretaker government, and that too only because the old state parliament had made a very controversial change in the rules of procedure at the last minute. In this respect, it was in an undemocratic position, and signs of resignation were unmistakable. But the dismissal was justified by the disturbances in public order, which the Braun government was allegedly no longer able to control, and these disturbances, such as the Bloody Sunday in Altona in particular, were primarily the responsibility of the Reich government, because they made such a march of the uniformed SA through hostile neighborhoods possible in the first place. The real reasons, however, were of a different nature, namely the old dislike of the right-wing parties for the *Red Tsar* Otto Braun and to the *cultural Bolshevism* which the Prussian government was allegedly promoting, but above all the concern about certain *anti-fascist* tendencies as they had come to light in discussions that the State Secretary Abegg had held with communists. But also at work it was probably the will to deprive the National Socialists of the control of the Prussian police if they took over the government after a possible agreement with the Center. In this authoritarian act, too, democratic and anti-democratic aspects were linked in a peculiar way, and it was not surprising that there was no resistance from the Braun government or the Social Democratic Party. The situation was quite different from when the general strike against Kapp was called in March 1920, not least because of the six million unemployed, and of course also because this time one had to expect that the communists would take advantage of it for their purposes from the outset. For this reason the Prussian police could by no means be regarded as absolutely reliable. At the end of August 1931, the Prussian Minister of the Interior, Severing, had expressly pointed out in a decree that the increasing disturbances and raids were mainly due to communist squads, which were recruited primarily from members of the dissolved Red Front Fighters' League, but presumably also from the ranks of the "Combat League Against Fascism." Thus the *capitulation* of the Prussian government on July 20 was neither groundless nor incomprehensible, but in fact it was an important step on the way that came to its temporary end with the election of July 31 and now also created a situation in the Reich which there had never been a precedent in a modern large state. The National Socialists achieved an unprecedented triumph, which was by no means unexpected after the presidential elections and the results in Prussia: they received almost 14 million votes and 230 seats. But it was not without reason that the communists could claim to have won a major electoral victory: 5.3 million votes and 89 Reichstag seats were on their list, and they were now stronger than the Social Democrats not only in Berlin, but in larger parts of the Ruhr area and central Germany. But were they really on the way to becoming the *party of the German working class*, as they had aspired to since the beginning of the republic? In the constituency of

Chemnitz-Zwickau, one of the oldest strongholds of the labor movement, the National Socialists received around 550,000 votes, the Social Democrats 260,000 and the Communists 230,000, while all other parties together could hardly win more than 80,000. In any case, no government could have a majority in this Reichstag if the National Socialists were in opposition, since together with the Communists they held a negative majority of 52% of the seats. The only way out seemed to be a coalition between the National Socialists and the Center, and Hitler's chancellorship was seriously considered on many sides, apparently also by the Reichswehr Minister von Schleicher, who came more and more to the fore. But the party negotiations did not make much headway, and the decision was made by Hindenburg, who did not want a party government and was even more opposed to a party dictatorship. Papen, for his part, was striving to involve the National Socialists, but did not want to grant them leadership. The result was the famous parley of August 13, in which the Reich President gave the leader of by far the strongest party a brief and ungracious refusal, on the grounds that he could not, in his conscience, take responsibility for appointing as Reich Chancellor a man who demanded *all power* for himself and his party. This refusal was probably at the same time an interpretation that was justified on the merits, but not in the wording of the demand, and which, it seems, left a long-lasting trauma in Hitler. The authoritarian Papen government now had to set about resisting the divided will of the people, which it had helped to break through in the first place. Thus, it issued the August 9 Ordinance Against Political Terror, which provided for the death penalty for politically motivated homicides. This immediately put itself in a difficult position when the special court in Beuthen imposed five death sentences on National Socialists who had brutally killed a communist, and when Hitler promised "his comrades" in a telegram unconditional solidarity against the "monstrous blood sentence." The fact that the perpetrators were pardoned had to have the effect of acquiescence, although it was justified in the matter at hand, since the convicts had not yet been aware of the ordinance. The history of the hitherto short-lived Reichstag of the Republic was just as symptomatic as it was curious. On August 30, it was opened by the senior president, Clara Zetkin, who gave a communist-anti-fascist combat speech and concluded with the expression of the hope that the senior president would soon be able to open Soviet Germany's first council congress. Then the dissolution took place in a very strange way: under irregular circumstances, the National Socialist President of the Reichstag, Goering, brought a motion of no confidence from the Communists to the vote, which was accepted by 512 votes to 42 (German nationalists). This was the greatest triumph of the teamwork, despite mutual deadly enmity, between Communists and National Socialists, but it did not last, since the legality of the Reich President's order of dissolution had to be recognized. Papen now emphasized the principle of authoritarian government all the more, but he could not avoid calling new elections, and November 6 was set as the date

for this. With these elections began the immediate eve of Hitler's assumption of power.

It is appropriate to pause here once more to ask the following question: what were the alternatives in this extraordinary situation, which had had some parallel only in Italy during 1922, although there existed only a relatively small Communist Party and also Mussolini's party, although very strong in the streets, only had a very limited number of deputies in Parliament?

The earliest, and in 1918/19 seemingly overwhelming, of the fundamental alternatives was that of *capitalism or socialism*, of *bourgeois or socialist democracy*. However, it was soon greatly weakened by the Russian events and the positive use of the concept of dictatorship by the communists. As early as 1918 and 1919, Karl Kautsky, Otto Bauer, Friedrich Stampfer and basically all Social Democrats formulated the postulate "democracy, not dictatorship." They did mean to abandon the first alternative, but they firmly defended the opinion against the Bolsheviks that progress towards socialism was only possible along the path of formal or bourgeois democracy. Already during the first years after the war, terms such as *totalism* or the *claim to exclusivity* were in use as opposing terms to dictatorship, and with thus one found oneself on the main line of European state thinking since Montesquieu; for many years they were chiefly directed against Bolshevism, which for that very reason was often called *asiatic* from many sides and very often. However, around 1920 the term "*right-wing Bolsheviks*" also appeared, and in 1929 the President of the Reichstag, Paul Löbe, vividly expressed the emerging "concept of totalitarianism" by addressing the communists and the National Socialists with the following sentences: "If the state-will of the gentlemen had been carried out from the right, then you (the communists) would have been given the prospect of being put against the wall. If your state-will had been carried out, then you would have put the gentlemen from the right against the wall. We first have given you and the others civil rights. Perhaps we will get around to granting Mr. Trotsky free asylum in Germany." But even Alfred Hugenberg did not speak differently on the matter to Adolf Hitler in March 1932, when he emphatically rejected a unification of all positions of power in Hitler's hands, on the grounds that something of the sort had "never before occurred under any emperor or king in Germanic lands." In a different and yet similar way, the Prussian government, in its appeal of August 1931, spoke out against the referendum of the Stahlhelm and the National Socialists, which was also supposed to be in the Red Referendum: "National Socialists and Communists want chaos, want the overthrow of the status quo. Both each thinks of putting his rule in the place of the overthrown and to be able to trample the others—who were just welcome confederates in the referendum." What is unusual about this view, which justifies its precedence, is that it also takes a positive view of one's own opponents, who are to be

prevented the mutual annihilation struggle, because their existence is also considered worth preserving and necessary to the system. But the prerequisite for the realization was that one clearly wanted what was already in place, i.e. the non-revolutionary further development of the given conditions of the *liberal system*, and it was precisely here that the difficulty for social democracy lied. Again and again the older alternative proved powerful, and leading representatives of the party often spoke out against the capitalist system with such vehemence that they seemed almost indistinguishable from the communists. Thus, an appeal by the party executive of the Social Democratic Party on the banking crisis in July 1931 stated that the lie of “Marxist mismanagement” was only made up to “divert attention from the real culprits: the capitalist system and its representatives.” The ambivalence became particularly clear in a speech by Deputy Sollmann during a Reichstag debate in February 1931. On the one hand, he noted that the living conditions of the masses in the two dictatorially ruled countries, Russia and Italy, were far below the living conditions in the countries of all democracies the whole globe. However, that did not prevent him from making the claim shortly thereafter: “It was not Marxism that failed, but capitalism.”

So if the traditional alternative of *socialism or capitalism* could weaken the first of the real post-war alternatives, namely *democracy against totalitarian dictatorship*, this in turn could be included in the second alternative, which was called *authority or chaos*. It was Papen’s motto, and even Brüning’s, and both could claim that democracy can no longer be a useful counter-reality to dictatorship if the democratic method leads to the destruction of democracy because it is rejected by a strong minority or even by a majority of the voters. Then obviously only an independent force can help, namely the popularly elected Reich President and the government supported by his confidence, which preserves the best elements of democracy, e.g. the rule of law, but suspends its bad and dangerous components, e.g. the unbridled party agitation and the civil war slogans at least for a certain time. Only a strong state would then be able to retain the unleashed society and protect it from self-destruction. However, this view, which gave rise to a whole doctrine of the *New State*, also revealed serious contradictions. If it really made an unlimited equation of the forces geared towards dictatorship, its chances of assertion in an age of press freedom were slim. For this reason, Franz von Papen emphatically opposed the equation of communists and National Socialists in his radio address on July 20: “Because influential political circles cannot decide to give up the political and moral equation of communists and National Socialists, that unnatural formation of fronts has come into being which places the anti-state forces of communism in a united front against the rising movement of the NSDAP.” But it wasn’t even three months before the Reich Chancellor said in a speech that Hitler had laid claim to the chancellorship on August 13 “out of the principle of ‘totality,’ of ‘exclusiveness,’” to which his party paid

homage. This claim to totality, however, was rejected by the Reich President and by himself on the grounds of principle, because there was an unbridgeable difference between a conservative policy based on faith and a National Socialist faith based on policy. But could a merely conservative and Christian state leadership be strong enough to prevail against two totalitarian movements with their mutually negating claims of exclusivity? It would certainly have been able to do that if there had been a constitutional provision obliging all constitutional parties to combine as soon as the totalitarian parties' share of the votes exceed a certain limit. Such a provision did not exist, however, and it must have been very doubtful whether an emphatically Christian government could get the Social Democrats and the Democrats behind it. The only remaining option to avoid the third alternative was large-scale prohibition measures through the full deployment of the Reichswehr and the police, and that ultimately means a willingness to engage in civil war.

The third alternative was: *Soviet star or swastika* . It had been formulated as early as 1923, and it was widespread and popular during Brüning's reign. To be sure, it was always understood by the communists as a mere transformation of the form of the unbreakable opposition between socialism and capitalism. Thus the deputy Koenen said in the Reichstag in July 1930: "The struggle between communism and fascism will take place under the sign of the political mass strike, the unification of all reactionary forces from the Social Democratic Party bureaucrats to the Nazis under the leadership of finance capital. This road to financial dictatorship will fail because of the iron will of the Communist Party, which, at the head of the working class, will open the struggle for a Soviet Germany with political mass strikes." A year later Hermann Remmele said: "Today it is certain: the dying, sinking capitalist world no longer has any means of saving or maintaining itself. No means of power can help it. We are the victors of tomorrow, and the question stands no longer: who, whom? That question has already been decided." And against this reiteration of Lenin's death promising civil war alternative, "Kto kogo" [*translator: russian for who (rules) whom*] the lines of the Horst Wessel song, which were sung again and again, opposed themselves with similar certainty and determination: "Hitler flags are already fluttering over all streets, slavery will only last a short time" and just as much Hitler's repeated assurances that he would destroy *Marxism* and that the Soviet star must sink into the dust before the swastika. Despite contradictory statements, the victory of the swastika was not understood as a mere transformation of the form of capitalism, but was obviously intended to lead to a national path of socialism against the "Red Front *and* reaction." Abroad, too, the situation was often seen quite similarly, for example by the American journalist H. R. Knickerbocker, who wrote in his book "Deutschland so oder so?" (i.e. under a swastika or hammer and sickle) in addition to vivid descriptions of the plight of the poor and the opulence of large sections of

the business bourgeoisie, gave Hitler far better chances than the communists as the representative of the “German resistance,” but ended with the gloomy statement that America could be grateful to the Atlantic Ocean, but there was no ocean between Western Europe and the Soviet Union.

The simplest hope for a return of Germany to *normality* was dashed on November 6. In 1924, too, two Reichstag elections had taken place in one year, and both the number of votes for the Communists and the number of votes for the Volkish and the National Socialists had fallen considerably in the second election, as had been the government’s expectations and intentions. This time, however, only a few optimists were able to perceive a noticeable improvement in the economic situation, and in truth it was not the second but the fifth major election of the year. The result was very different from that in 1924. The National Socialists lost two million votes and went from 230 to 196 seats. Some of their opponents already believed that they could confidently await the time when the party would vanish into thin air again, just as it seemed to have emerged from thin air in 1930. But the NSDAP had lost comparatively fewer votes than it had in 1924, and it had retained its position as by far the largest party. Most of the votes it had lost had stayed on the right and benefited Hugenberg’s German Nationalists. However, the hope of ever being able to win an absolute majority on its own had to be definitively abandoned, and to that extent the result could be described as a strengthening of the non-radical forces within the hardly weakened Right, which, however, as a whole could have formed a parliamentary majority only together with the Center. Far more novel and disturbing must have been the election result that had emerged within the Left. The communists had continued their rise and now had 100 seats. They had made their gains at the expense of the Social Democratic Party, which had lost 12 seats. Within the Left, then, the radical forces had been strengthened, and the most remarkable thing about the whole election was the fact that the Communists in Berlin, having gained about 140,000 votes, had far outstripped the Social Democratic Party and were now almost as strong in the Reich capital Social Democrats and National Socialists combined. Moreover, they were now stronger than the Social Democratic Party in a number of other constituencies, particularly in the Ruhr and central Germany. They had thus come a great step closer to their goal of turning the Social Democratic Party into a small party of *labor aristocrats* and constituting themselves as the party of the German proletariat. As the example of Berlin showed, the entire Social Democratic Party could now be viewed as a potential electoral reservoir for the Communists.

But even more exciting for the public than the election results was an extra-parliamentary event that took place between November 3 and November 7, namely the strike in the Berlin transport company. It was a *wildcat* strike called against the will of the union leadership,

jointly by the communist Red Trade Union Opposition (RGO) and the National Socialist Factory Cell Organization (NSBO). The leading committee included eight members of the RGO and four of the NSBO, in addition to three free trade unionists. The strike was so popular that the balloting nearly achieved the required three-quarters majority. It was directed against a planned reduction in wages that the local authorities wanted to implement in order to equalize wages in the various municipal companies; it was therefore a strike to preserve inequality. Despite this, or because of this, radicalization was considerable, and by most accounts the National Socialists were even more violent than the communists. In the lists compiled by the police about those who threw stones at streetcars and about those who took part in erecting barricades, etc. there are almost as many members of the NSDAP as of the Communist Party of Germany. Only with great effort the Berlin transport company was able to maintain partial operation; on the election day itself, the Berlin transport network was almost completely at a standstill. The RGO called for a political mass strike to “make the ruling system ripe for overthrowing,” evoking those that strikes “swept away Cuno and Kapp.” However, it soon became apparent that the other employees of the municipal companies did not join the strike, which was in a way directed against them, and neither did workers in large private companies. But when on November 8 the stream of those willing to return to work could no longer be stopped, the 400 National Socialists present at a meeting in the Hohenzollern halls voted to continue the strike, while the RGO advocated a termination. According to reports from police officers about later meetings of the RGO officials, there was a lot of self-criticism, but mostly “from the left,” and complaints were also made “that the management has been sending instructors all the time lately...who could not even speak German properly.” In response, the leader of the meeting then declared “that the cooperation of the Russian comrades could not be dispensed with, because they saw the most suitable elements for bringing the right revolutionary momentum into the spirit of the working masses.”

In any case, it served no propaganda purpose that the Berlin police chief reported to the Minister of the Interior on January 14, 1933 about a questionnaire campaign by the Communist Party of Germany in the factories, describing it as one of the many preparatory efforts by the Communist Party of Germany to successfully carry out the decisive battles expected of it in the foreseeable future. The report then continued: “However, since the radicalization of the working class is now taking on ever greater proportions, the Communist Party of Germany is certainly reckoning with the possibility of being able to take power in Germany in the near future. It is again making preparations in order to be able to successfully withstand a civil war.”

So the confident, even triumphant words that the Central Committee of the Communist Party of Germany had found after the election were by no means unfounded. Self-confidence and hope had to result from the fact that not only had the “breaking into the working masses of Social Democracy” continued mightily, but that “significant masses of National Socialist workers and other working class supporters of the Hitler movement” had also been conquered. Admittedly, there was one major weakness that was not hidden, which was expressed more bluntly by an RGO official at an internal meeting than was possible in public: he was not sure whether his colleagues no longer had any revolutionary feeling at all or whether they were so dominated by fear for their jobs that they wanted nothing to do with a general strike. This lack of revolutionary enthusiasm among the German workers was to be countered by Russian comrades, but the real breakthrough was obviously not expected from a general strike to prevent a Hugenberg or Hitler government, but from the enormous potential of National Socialist working class votes who, after a few weeks or at most months of such a government, would be disappointed and embittered, and join the Communist Party of Germany in hundreds of thousands, just as thousands of National Socialist Berlin Transport Company workers had gone on strike together with the RGO. Only then would the *armed uprising* be as successful in Germany as it had been in Russia in 1917.

Communists, National Socialists, the role model or the nightmare of the Soviet Union, but also the direct instructions and influence of the Comintern: this field of force and tension was not the only one in Germany in the last months of 1932, but it was the most important one alongside the police and the Reichswehr and was certainly more important than the only defensively thinking middle parties from the Social Democratic Party to the Center to the German Nationalists, two of which were oriented to the right, while the third and largest had to look anxiously to the left in order not to lose even more supporters to the communists.

There is no doubt that this situation was clearly known to the politicians who had to make the decision about the future of Germany after this truly *catastrophic*. Adolf Hitler may have been guided by tactical objectives when he claimed during the negotiations with the Reich President in November 1932 that the Bolshevization of the broad masses was progressing rapidly and that if his movement perished there would be “18 million Marxists in Germany and among them there are perhaps 14 to 15 million Communists,” but the statement by Prelate Kaas, the leader of the Center, was quite credible, telling Hindenburg on November 18: “We are facing a bad winter; on the one hand there are 12 Millions of Germans in the right-wing opposition, on the other hand 13.5 million in the left-wing opposition. That is why the goal of national concentration, including the National Socialists, is a necessity.” Again it was Hindenburg, no doubt encouraged by those closest to him, who refused to entrust the

leader of what was still by far the strongest party with the formation of a presidential cabinet, this time on the more general grounds that the NSDAP as such had always reemphasized its exclusivity, so that the establishment of a party dictatorship was to be feared. But at the end of his answer he also expressed the hope that in time it would still be possible to persuade Hitler and his movement “to cooperate with all other forces of the nation willing to build up,” i.e. he referred him to the path of coalition-building and the willingness to compromise. But Hindenburg, in perhaps the most terrible aporia ever faced by an 85-year-old statesman, also decided against the first alternative solution to avoiding Hitler, which Papen suggested to him: to take up the fight against “the militant forces of the Communists and the National Socialists” at the same time and not to shy away from the danger that this would result in a civil war. According to Papen’s report, the Reich President replied with tears in his eyes that he had grown too old to take responsibility for a civil war at the end of his life and that therefore he had to let Herr von Schleicher try his luck in God’s name.

Kurt von Schleicher also had a concept, the second of three possible ones. He wanted to rely on the trade unions and at the same time bring together with them the parts of the National Socialists that were willing to cooperate. That was the so-called “cross-front conception,” which resulted from the impossibility of taking the apparently most obvious path and bringing together the democratic parties from the German National People’s Party to the Social Democratic Party in a closed defensive front against totalitarianism from the right and from the left. If the Social Democratic Party was immobile, then the General German Trade Union Federation was to take action, and since Hitler apparently could not be dissuaded from his demand of *all or nothing*, hope had to be placed in the second man of the party, the Reich organization leader Gregor Strasser. Until then, Strasser had always been considered one of the radicals in the party, and the payments made by some industrialists to the NSDAP were largely for the very purpose of supporting Hitler as the *moderate* against Strasser’s socialist tendencies, but Schleicher was considered a *social general*, and Strasser thought it appropriate to accommodate his plans. Schleicher was also listened to by the trade unions, and for a moment it looked as if the path had been taken that would enable Germany to emerge from the political and then also from the economic crisis. However, Strasser was too much of a convinced National Socialist to want to rebel against Hitler and split the party; the representatives of the General German Trade Union Federation, however, were too close to Social Democracy not to obtain the vote of the party leadership. The vote was negative and Schleicher lost his big game after just a few weeks. At best, he could still fall back on Papen’s plan, namely to have Hindenburg authorize him to dissolve the Reichstag and face a possible civil war.

It was quite natural that in this situation many different combinations of ideas were made and that all sorts of interested parties made themselves felt in order to have a say, since this is precisely the rule before any normal formation of a government. But all interested parties could only speak out in favor of Papen's alternative, which Schleicher or other military or politicians would adopt, or in favor toward a parliamentary tendency and compromise "Hitler's solution," as Meissner had suggested in Hindenburg's name. And all those who took the floor or exercised influence were under the impression of events and possibilities that were present to them even if they did not expressly speak of them or if one or the other event had even remained unknown to them. Thus, on January 27, *Inprekorr* published a speech made by a leading member of the Executive Committee of the Comintern in Moscow, which said: "At least 200,000 workers belong to the National Socialist Party and its storm troopers. It is said that among the Nazi voters are more than two million workers, many of whom are unemployed. They have been infatuated with the anti-capitalist demagoguery of the Nazis...It is unthinkable that they will follow the National Socialists permanently. Signs of disintegration are already evident everywhere." In fact, the next day the *Rote Fahne* in great splendor reported that no fewer than 1,500 Berlin SA men were about to leave. This corresponded to repeated reports that people from the Reichsbanner had joined to the Communist Party of Germany or had at least declared their willingness to take up the fight together as part of the *Anti-Fascist Action*. Even more impressive, however, was the news which the communist press was able to publish about what was happening on the streets. On January 22, the SA organized a large march on Bülowplatz, facing the *Karl Liebknecht House*, the party headquarters of the Communist Party of Germany. But the 20,000 SA men had been accompanied and protected by an extraordinarily large police force; in parts they had had to move along stretches of hostile crowds through a guard of honor, and elsewhere streets and squares were deserted. Nowhere did they encounter even the slightest sign of sympathy, not even—if the *Rote Fahne* report is to be believed—in the west of the city, where "petty-bourgeois groups" expressed mute disapproval. The mood of the marchers was "frozen" and at Bülowplatz they had to impotently notice that "the Soviet flag was waving defiantly" on the roof of the enemy party headquarters. The situation was completely different three days later at the counter-rally of the Communist Party of Germany, and the *Rote Fahne* proudly headlined its report: "This is the Commune." For four hours, the fighters of Red Berlin flooded Bülowplatz to march past the Central Committee and the leader of the party, Ernst Thälmann, well over a hundred thousand in number, cheered by the population, without police protection, among them "the self-defense columns of the masses who already smothered the first wave of terror by the Nazis with an iron hand and who will also strangle the new wave of terror with the force of their mass."

Those who consider the communists to be the somewhat more radical part of *the labor movement* ; who believe that Hitler had unequivocally identified himself as the future author of the *final solution* ; who think that the Soviet Union, in the interest of undisturbed industrialization, wanted to prevent a communist revolution in Germany, may be pleased to know that the NSDAP has been in decline since November and that at the next election it would again have lost a few million. Contemporaries did not see things that way, and as a rule, they *could* not see them that way. They perceived two parties that made radical demands and were undoubtedly anti-constitutional. But one wanted to eliminate *the capitalist system* and the other wanted to eliminate the *Versailles system* . One was hostile to the Weimar state and the other to statehood in general. The one demanded the cessation of all *tributes* , the other wanted to eliminate all external and internal debts, i.e. to remove Germany from the context of the world economy. One demanded that the citizenship status of a small minority, which had only been fully naturalized in the second half of the 19th century, be revoked; the other postulated the social annihilation of the entire bourgeoisie, including the officers and the large farmers, and identified unreservedly with a neighboring state that had largely also physically exterminated these classes or at least disenfranchised and persecuted them in a way that was inconceivable to anyone in Germany. Contemporaries *must* have seen in the Communists the far more extreme of the two radical parties, and it must have filled them with the gravest concern that the larger and less extreme party appeared to be on the verge of a disintegration, the consequences of which were incalculable, while the smaller and more extreme seemed able to attract large sections of both Social Democratic Party and NSDAP voters. Admittedly, those who thought that former NSDAP voters would return to the German National People's Party and the liberal parties might consider their fears to be far exaggerated, and anyone who thought the goals of the Communist Party of Germany to be just and timely might indict the prospective victims with moral indignation. But the vast majority of people who had something to lose, or who were concerned above all about the functioning of a highly complex industrialized country with many different links to the world economy, necessarily saw things differently.

However, it was not impossible for them to make a counter-calculation. For example, Adolf Hitler's New Year's appeal of January 1, 1932, was aimed entirely at fighting communism and was otherwise quite optimistic; A year later, however, tones were again noticeable which were by no means merely anti-Jewish in the sense described above, but which again brought to the fore a historical-theoretical, even anthropological radicalism which was equal in intensity to that of the communists and yet was to be completely different in content: "The religiously and ideologically rootless liberal mankind is at the end of its age...The international Jew as an intellectual inspirer is leading in almost all countries of the world this

fight of poorly qualified, primitive sub-races against the...culture-creating...ability of a higher humanity whose powers of resistance slackened in liberalism...In a state that has 6 million communists, 7.5 million social democrats and 6 million other more or less pacifist-infected elements, one should better stop talking about equality and not more from “armament” talk...In the face of this tremendous need, only a defense that is just as powerful can be of use.” If Hitler’s calculation was correct, he would have to rob about four-tenths of the people of their inner conviction, even if he left all their external possessions untouched, and he would have to bring Germany into abysmal opposition not only to the Soviet Union but also to England and the *Western world* in general, with which, after all, he wanted to ally himself. And wouldn’t there be a similar result if he put the 500,000 Jews back under alien law, since they were so much closer to their relatives and friends than the many millions of Russian citizens and kulaks? And what would happen if the anti-pacifist radicalism expressed in the appeal was not just a threatening gesture, but expressed the will for a great war?

Thus, in retrospect, *Papen’s solution* must appear to be the better one, which accepted a civil war against both extremes, but did not inevitably bring about it. However, it must also be remembered that the civil war, *if* it came to pass, could very easily result in the division of Germany. France would not have stopped at its borders if the communists had threatened to seize power in Berlin, and after the end of the first five-year plan the Soviet army was in a position, indeed, to “trample Poland like a straw” and to advance at least as far as the Elbe. Germany was still the continent’s most powerful industrial power, and if Europe was to succeed in asserting itself as an equal world power, then Germany had to be the nucleus of the new “United States,” but as soon as anything unusual happened within its borders, given its current military weakness, it would be the object of serious precautionary measures by its neighbors. And its neighbors were as *bourgeois* as itself: the threat of a Communist seizure of power would cause them to intervene farther than a Nazi seizure of power. But if the danger of division actually existed, the vast majority of Germans would certainly have preferred war to civil war.

Thus, there is no clear answer to the question posed at the beginning. The tales of the guilt of the schemers are not entirely unfounded: Schleicher made his friend “Fränzchen” chancellor, although he considered him “a hat, not a head,” and he himself thought far too optimistically and militarily to be a statesman of distinction. Next to Brüning, the aged Hindenburg cut the best figure among all those involved in the last Weimar years. But even if all the contributors had been brilliant statesmen and almost as wise as their descendants can be, they would have seriously considered the solution to which Hindenburg agreed when Schleicher on January 28 asked him to share the same responsibility Papen had on December 2 for a possible civil

war. He no longer stood in Hitler's way when Hitler appeared to have fulfilled the postulate of November 24 and, despite far-reaching safeguards, was willing to cooperate with other forces *willing to build up* the country. Admittedly, Hindenburg had not considered one thing: Mussolini, too, had worked with similar forces in the early days of his reign. If Zinoviev was right about a side remark he had already made in 1922, i.e. if Europe had really entered an *epoch of fascism* , then Hitler would have to cover the road to autocracy even faster and more radically than Mussolini had done, and then he would have to confront in a special way the state that had ushered in the *epoch of proletarian world revolution* .

In Europe, two large *ideological states* now faced each other, whose actions were ultimately determined by conceptions that interpreted the past and future course of world history and interpreted the meaning of human life. Almost all of the accusations they leveled at one another were pointed and propagandistic in nature, but they were based on real facts that inflamed the passions of countless people on both sides. Both had ideological allies throughout the continent and beyond: the Soviet Union had the communist parties, Germany, with much greater ambivalence, the mostly still small fascist movements, and potentially the fascist regime in Italy. Both were, of course, part of a whole network of relationships and circumstances, and for many years it could still appear as if the relationship between Germany and the Soviet Union or between the fascist movements and the communist regimes was a subordinate issue in world history. In the end, however, it proved to be the decisive contrast that determined the fate of the world to a far greater extent than, say, the war between Japan and China, the conquest of Ethiopia by Italy, or Roosevelt's efforts to bring the United States back into world politics.

Chapter III, Section 1

National Socialist Germany and the Communist Soviet Union in 1933/34

1. National Socialist Germany and the communist Soviet Union in 1933/34

How quickly Germany became a National Socialist state after Hitler came to power was seen with stunned amazement by numerous contemporaries at home and abroad. The Bolsheviks had in fact eliminated the other socialist parties very quickly, but they were not formally banned until 1921; Mussolini had only been pushed by events of a serious nature, such as the Matteotti crisis, to put an end to other parties in the fourth year after the *March on Rome*. In Germany, however, the process of conquest of power by a single party came to an end as early as July 14, 1933, through a legislative act, namely through the “Law Against the Re-Formation of Parties.” And it this was not a mere superficial overpowering. In each of the parties, including the German National People’s Party, there was reluctance and even resistance; but in each of the parties, including the Social Democratic Party, not only resignation was widespread, but so was also a willingness to collaborate in the new *national community*, as well as insight into one’s own failures or undesirable developments in the Weimar Republic. The behavior of the leadership and the members of the center and the remnants of the liberal parties, but also of the Catholic and Protestant churches, made it seem justified to assume that they were not unwilling to be forced into an agreement, to which there had previously been no little inclination, although the increasing emergence of the *National Socialist revolution* gave rise to new resistance movements. Even for the Communists, the months after January 30 meant not only external persecution, but also internal confusion and helplessness, caused not only by the unexpected ferocity of the blows that fell on the party. Herbert Wehner’s memoirs give a vivid picture of this confusion and of a widespread tendency among officials and members to throw in the towel or even capitulate.

Masses of disillusioned members flocked into the NSDAP and the SA, two formerly particularly radical functionaries published a brochure entitled "From the Soviet Star through the Concentration Camp to the Swastika," several top functionaries collaborated with the Gestapo. Ernst Thälmann was arrested, and the rumor soon spread that he had been betrayed by one of his closest associates. The workers' poet Max Barthel, who had been a close friend and comrade-in-arms of Willi Münzenberg for years and had been a member of the Social Democratic Party since 1923, published a "Letter to Friends Who Crossed the Border" in Goebbels' *Angriff*, which contained the sentence: "Compared to the old workers' parties, the NSDAP is a blossoming spring meadow." In the summer, the Comintern journal admitted that in March-April there had been a "flow of working class masses to fascism" and that "feelings of panic" were widespread, indeed that the first impression was of a "colossal triumph of fascism." But now the party had rallied again and it had turned out that although the National Socialist Factory Cell Organization had indeed captured a large part of the working class, only a small fraction was "really National Socialist, fanatically Hitlerite." Strikes and demonstrations were already taking place in many places, and in Chemnitz even a group of armed workers had taken the lead in a demonstration procession. Therefore, he said, the hopes for an early unification of the entire working class under the banner of the Communist Party have grown strong again, and in countless workers the conviction is alive and well: "Bolshevism must come after Hitler, and the Soviet star will shine victoriously over the rotting ruins of the swastika dictatorship." The statements made by leading Comintern officials sounded quite similar, emphatically declaring the party's previous policy, and in particular its struggle against *social-fascism*, to be correct and unwaveringly endorsing the maxim that the party must show recognizable activity. It soon became apparent, however, that all attempts by the communists to regroup and to prove their continued existence through leaflets and slogans were quickly crushed by the Secret State Police and again brought heavy losses to the party. On the other hand, those Social Democrats who had not withdrawn in resignation merely tried to maintain contact with each other and wait for better times. It was not long before the "Germany Reports" were distributed from the headquarters of the émigré party executive in Prague, proving how carefully conditions in Germany were being observed by numerous members of the banned party. Of course, they not only registered voices of discontent in all sections of the population, because the *labor battle* had achieved more apparent than real successes and because the standard of living had gotten worse than better, because they had to state again and again that Hitler was far more popular than the NSDAP, especially in large circles of the working class.

So in the course of a few months, Hitler had achieved something that no *bourgeois* politician before him had even remotely come close to achieving: he had eliminated the Communist

and Social Democratic parties and the trade unions, but yet found so much support among the workers that the *milieu* of the working-class quarters began to dissolve and even the *neighborhoods* were no longer safe havens for persecuted communists. Here, and also in the *colonies* of the Ruhr area, there lived at least one convinced or even fanatical National Socialist in almost every house, who worked as a “janitor” or “block leader” and exercised a surveillance function that even the most perfect police in a hostile environment could not have performed.

Germany had thus become an ideological state in which political power was undivided in the hands of one man and one party, with the enthusiastic approval of a sizeable section of the population. Nevertheless, the “Germany Reports” were able to defend with good arguments the assertion that basically little had changed in Germany, because the real masters were still the big industrialists, the landowners of the East and the generals of the Reichswehr, Hitler was merely carrying out their will. In fact, Hitler had already declared the revolution to be over in July 1933, and if a large number of those who had *fallen in March* poured into the NSDAP, the old civil service remained essentially the same for that very reason; there had been no significant change in the leadership of the Reichswehr; the industry’s umbrella organization had only changed its name and some officials; the Catholic Church had abandoned political Catholicism with the conclusion of the Concordat, but had consolidated its legal position; major changes were taking place in the Protestant Church, but the protest against the introduction of the Aryan paragraph and against the nationalist tendencies of the “German Christians” went almost unchecked. While one might see in the passing of the Enabling Act of March 23 a counterpart to the dissolution of the Constituent Assembly in January 1918, especially since direct threats of violence had also played a role, but even the persecution of the communists could not be equated with an attack on *the bourgeoisie*. Admittedly, in addition to the murders in the concentration camps, there was the terrible *Köpenick’s week of bloodshed*, but mass shootings did not take place anywhere, and there were only very distant and weak analogies to the nationalization of businesses, to the expropriation of land ownership, to the evictions from apartments, to blocking of accounts for entire population groups. The most conspicuous measure was the boycott of Jewish businesses from April 1, which, however, met with little public approval and was called off after three days. Therefore, it has often been rightly said that the National Socialists’ takeover of power was, in its further course, a political upheaval, but not a social revolution. This means, however, that it was a revolution that did not result from a war, did not lead to a civil war, and did not sever economic and political ties with the rest of the world. Within this framework and under these conditions, however, it was the most extensive and profound political revolution that had ever taken place in a European state during the 19th and 20th

centuries.

The same could be said of foreign policy. After Hitler came to power, not a single one of the many diplomatic relations that connected Germany with the countries of the world was broken off; no thought was further from the mind of Foreign Minister Neurath than that of “closing the deal” (as Trotsky had wanted to do as Foreign Commissar in 1917); the concerns, which were certainly great in Paris and London, were largely dispelled by Hitler’s “Peace speech” of May 17, which the Social Democrats also agreed to, and the conclusion of the “Four-Power Pact” in July 1933, much encouraged by Mussolini, meant that Germany placed itself on an equal footing with the great Western European powers of England, France and Italy. But on the other hand, Germany withdrew from the League of Nations in a spectacular act in November 1933, and that too was unprecedented in Europe, because until then only Japan (in March 1933) had set an example, and Japan was in fact already at war with China involved in Manchuria. Even in terms of foreign policy, National Socialist Germany was far less revolutionary than the Soviet Union, which had signed the Versailles Treaty even after the fact, which in 1918, through the mouth of Lenin, had announced its intention to “declare war on the whole world” when the opportunity arose, and which, while recognizing the independence of their former Baltic provinces, but never ceased protesting against the separation of Bessarabia. If Germany had become an *ideological state* under Hitler, then the term did not have the same comprehensive meaning as in the case of the Soviet Union.

The extent to which Hitler’s ideology was primarily determined negatively by opposition to the Soviet Union and to communism was revealed on two occasions during 1932 even more unequivocally than by the statements he made soon after coming to power. In his speech to industrialists in Düsseldorf on January 27, 1932, he had assumed that actual dominance of the white race over the world and traced it back to hereditary superiority, which is therefore a right, but an endangered right. For against it a world view has arisen which had already conquered a state and which would bring the whole world to collapse if it is not destroyed in time: “In 300 years, if this movement develops further, one will see in Lenin not only a revolutionary of the year 1917, but the founder of a new world doctrine, with a worship perhaps like Buddha.” Obviously, Hitler did not treat such a “gigantic phenomenon” with contempt, and polemicized explicitly against those entrepreneurs who did not consider a comprehensive industrialization of Russia to be possible. Rather, he sees himself quite unmistakably as anti-Lenin, as the only man capable of stopping this development, fundamentally exactly as Trotsky did when he called him the “Over-Wrangel of the world bourgeoisie.” But everything that is progress and emancipation for Trotsky is human decay

and decadence in his eyes, because the industrialization of Russia and the presumed spread of Bolshevism to Asia can only be based on the exploitation of Western achievements and on the ruthlessly lowering of the living standards of Russian and Asian masses. Admittedly, Hitler does not credit the Western world with having improved the living conditions of the Asians and other peoples, and he does not shy away from declaring himself to be the champion of Western or occidental egoism, which for him is nothing other than the natural dominance of the higher and more cultivated humanity over the lower and the barbaric. But whether that is a hitherto unimaginable commitment to the most *reactionary imperialism* or whether it is an exaggeration of an insight that is essentially correct: in any case, a man can undertake nothing greater than to play a decisive role in the service of a cause in the overarching world-historical process, and therefore any view that wants to see Hitler merely as a German nationalist must be considered insufficient. A mere nationalist would certainly not have said something like Hitler did to Colonel von Reichenau in December 1932: he considered Soviet diplomacy to be incapable of negotiation and contract, because contracts could only be concluded between opponents on the same ideological level.

Consequently, the manifold relationships that Hitler entered into as a statesman with France and England, with Italy and the USA, with Poland and the Vatican, had to have only a subordinate status, intended only to ward off momentary dangers, and the relationship with the world-historical adversary had to gain paramount importance, even if not the diplomatic relationship. But even the Soviet Union must have realized that the global political situation had changed completely since there was a second and hostile ideological state of comparable potential strength in Europe. The diplomats on both sides tried to have a calming effect, but Hitler's speech of March 2 already roused violent protest, and then a chain of incidents continued, in which Soviet trade missions and, above all, the extensive network of "Derop" gas stations became objects by sometimes violent attacks by the SA and SS. Hitler, however, had hardly expressed himself more sharply than Soviet politicians were in the habit of expounding on conditions in the capitalist countries, and even Soviet diplomats could not deny that Derop's employees were often communists, but relations were now deteriorating rapidly, cooperation between the Reichswehr and the Red Army was coming to an end, Karl Radek suddenly expressed himself in *Pravda* very resolutely against revisionism as a threat to peace, and the French were exploiting their opportunities with great skill.

However, there was not a complete lack of counteraction: after March 2, Hitler avoided sharp statements in public, he even received Ambassador Chinchuk for a talk, and above all he declared his readiness to ratify the protocol to the extension of the Berlin Treaty, which had been in effect since 1931 but had not yet acquired legal force. According to a May 15 report

by the German Ambassador in Moscow, Herbert von Dirksens, there were also different tendencies on the other side: the Red Army and politicians close to it were still positive and friendly towards Germany, while among the intellectual Soviet politicians there continued to be a “dogged and bitter mood against Germany.” But the peculiar, special relationship between Germany and Russia, which was based on common *revisionism*, had unmistakably come to an end, and on August 14 Dirksen even wrote of the “increasing concern, almost fear, of the ideological repercussions of the National Socialist victory in Germany on Bolshevism and world revolution” and of the “suspicion that has increased to the point of hysteria as to whether the Germany of the national revolution, despite all official assurances, is not pursuing or will not soon pursue hostile plans against the Soviet Union (severing the Ukraine).”

If, therefore, the motives of the Soviet Union were quite different from those of France, the two powers were now drawing more and more unmistakably closer together, and Germany, after leaving the League of Nations, found herself almost completely isolated. In January 1934, Hitler signed a non-aggression pact with Poland, who had been toying with the idea of a preventive war in the spring of 1933, thereby proving that he was firmly in the saddle and that at the head of the German ideological state it was possible to make decisions that throughout the Weimar Republic would have immediately led to the fall of the government because they seemed to imply a recognition of the eastern borders. But Hitler was able to be guided to a large extent by his sympathy for Marshal Pilsudski, which was rooted on the common anti-Bolshevism. He was not a politician with ideological convictions, as Stresemann and Brüning had been, but an ideologue with political will and tactical versatility, whose decisions alone were decisive in all questions of major politics from the beginning of 1934.

At the same time the Soviet Union underwent a change in its foreign policy of an even more profound kind. For fifteen years its reason for existence had been the denunciation of *the imperialists*, of Versailles, and of capitalism in general, of which France, England and the USA had to be regarded as the main representatives. The non-aggression pacts with Poland and France were not to mean fundamental change, but after Hitler came to power the tone of the Soviet press changed very soon, and Foreign Minister Maxim Litvinov became the chief spokesman—though certainly not the originator—of that new *Western* line which the Soviet Union was associating with the anti-revisionist powers and which was soon to culminate in entry into the League of Nations, which had so long been regarded as an association of anti-Soviet warmongers. Any resistance to the swing was not discernible, for it virtually imposed itself, and it was apparently already taken for granted that Stalin said his policy was oriented “toward the USSR and only to the USSR.” If the Soviet Union was not an ordinary

state, as Stalin adamantly believed, then it was not a question of mere nationalism, and Lenin could be invoked in exploiting divisions and difficulties of the *imperialist enemy*. Moreover, Stalin did not commit himself unconditionally, but tried not to sever all ties with Germany, and on the other hand mistrust of the Soviet Union remained alive in France and especially in England.

The most significant change in the situation, therefore, lay in the successful implementation of Lenin's plan to *electrify*, i.e. industrialize, the country through communism. The triumphant reports of the completion of huge industrial buildings and the maps of the *giants of the Five Year Plan*—such as the Stalingrad tractor plants, the Magnitogorsk ironworks, the Molotov sawmill near Arkhangelsk, the Stalinsk chemical combine, the blast furnaces near Dnepropetrovsk—at first met in the West with great skepticism, and there was no lack of awareness that these marvels of modern technology were built to a large extent from the forced labor of hundreds of thousands of deported kulaks, the starvation of the entire population and the agonizing deaths of several million peasants, and that the benefits of the Baltic-White Sea Canal and even the Dnieprostroy power plant was by no means out of the question. The year 1932 in particular was extremely difficult and gloomy in the Soviet Union. The suicide of Stalin's wife Nadezhda Alliluyeva should probably be seen in this context, and opposition movements arose in the party that saw Stalin as the cause of the disaster. Could there be a more extreme measure than the "Law on the Protection of Property of State-Owned Enterprises and Collective Farms," which gave the death penalty for petty theft? The same applies to the introduction of domestic passports at the end of 1932, which created a new inequality unimaginable in Western Europe, since the collective farmers were not given passports and were thus tied to the soil like their ancestors. As compensation, the population was offered a resurgence of national feeling and pride in Russian history, as Stalin had already released in a letter to Demjan Bedny as early as 1930, when he wrote reproachfully to the *proletarian poet* that in his poems the Russia of the past appeared as "a vessel of abomination and uncleanness." A little later, the Marxist view of the leading historian Pokrovsky was replaced by a much more positive assessment of Russia's past, including some tsars and generals, and ostracized concepts made their return in June 1934 when the law on "treason to the homeland" was issued, which threatened the attempts to flee the Soviet Union with death and all members of the *traitor's* family were sent to a camp, even if they had not known about the plans.

What was going on in the Soviet Union, then, was industrialization under wartime conditions on the basis of a doctrine that called itself *Marxist*. In both its violence and its rapidity it contrasted sharply with the Industrial Revolution as it had unfolded first in England and then

in the rest of the West for long decades. Since it necessarily meant, with its primacy of heavy industry, that the largest country in the world in terms of area was building up a vast armaments potential, it was bound to arouse concern and fear throughout the West, but it also found much sympathy among intellectuals, who sometimes criticized the decadence, sometimes the alienation, and sometimes the bellicosity of Western states, but sometimes all at once. Sidney and Beatrice Webb wrote a book about the Soviet Union as “a new civilization,” and Bernard Shaw believed he was returning from a “land of hope” to a world region of hopelessness as he made the journey back to London from Moscow.

So some spoke of the country of state slavery and the new-old despotism, and others of the completely new ethos of the Russian workers who expected from their labor “something better and greater than money can buy.” Both parts were right in their own way: there had never been an industrialization like this in the world before.

When the harvest of 1933 had turned out well and people were able to breathe more freely again for the first time, Stalin was able to present a record of success at the XVII. Party Congress in January 1934, the “Party Congress of the Victors,” a track record that definitively confirmed what had not yet found universal credence in the world when he had spoke in January 1933 about the “results of the first Five-Year Plan” and said: “We had no iron and steel industry, the basis of the industrialization of the country. Now we have it...We didn’t have the tractor industry. Now we have it...We didn’t have the machine tool industry. Now we have it...We didn’t have the aircraft industry. Now we have it...All of this has resulted in our country changing from an agricultural country to an industrial one.” Now he presented figures intended to show that the Soviet Union had quadrupled its industrial production compared to 1913, while the USA and France had remained at about the same level, and England and Germany had not even reached the pre-war levels.

As questionable as the individual figures were in detail, there was still little doubt that a new industrial superpower had emerged whose development did not depend on the crisis-generating and thereby balancing effect of a *global economy* and was therefore on the way to becoming a politico-military world power. Thus, Hitler’s “political testament” in “Mein Kampf” had actually had a solid basis in reality even as late as 1926, despite all the assurances in the communist press of the time that the Soviet Union was a world power, but it had now become obsolete, and there were even good reasons for fearing that Germany would now fall further and further behind in the military field. And if Stalin may not have had Hitler’s speech of January 27, 1932 in mind when he gave his grand report to the party congress, he confronted it directly when he was dealing with the theory of the *superior* and

inferior races. He said: “As is well known, ancient Rome looked at the ancestors of today’s Germans and French in the same way as the representatives of the “higher race” now look at the Slavic tribes...The result was that the non-Romans, i.e. all “barbarians,” banded together against the common enemy and ran over Rome...Where is the guarantee that the writing fascist politicians in Berlin will have better luck than the old, battle-hardened conquerors in Rome? Wouldn’t it be more correct to assume the opposite?”

In May 1933, in an interview with Raymond Robins, who, since the 1917 revolution, had led what was finally a successful campaign for US recognition of the Soviet Union, Stalin had expressed the same idea in a more general form with the phrase: “The question of how the workers of this or that nation master technology, is not a biological question, not a question of genetic endowments, but a question of time: if one has not mastered it today, one will learn it and master it tomorrow. Anyone can master the technique, including the bushman, if you help him.” Hitler, on the other hand, had spoken of the fact that industry in Bohemia had only been set up by the Germans, and had overlooked the fact that between 1800 and 1850 the industry in Germany had been built up to a considerable extent by the English. Stalin, then, despite all his recourse to Russian history, still maintained the position of temporal universalism, while Hitler championed the immutability of different racial substances. There is a high probability that Stalin was right. But the worldview of the self-assertion of the Slavic *barbarians* against the onslaught of the *superior races* bore little resemblance to the ideas of Marx and Engels, and it may have had a sinister portent that Stalin alone named Churchill among bourgeois politicians whose war plans were doomed to failure. And possibly his confidence was already obsolete that in a war against the USSR the battle would also take place “in the enemy’s rear.” The GPU saw to it that in the Soviet Union there would be no battle behind the lines. But wasn’t the GPU or the Cheka the model for the Gestapo, at least objectively and presumably also in the minds of those involved?

Meanwhile, could Stalin be sure that the GPU would obey *him* unconditionally? Weren’t there still numerous Trotskyists and Bukharinists in his state who now advocated peace and reconciliation? What did it mean that Kirov, the Leningrad party secretary, received more votes than he did in the elections held by the party congress? Of course, Kirov’s personal loyalty was beyond question, and it was precisely at this party congress that he called Stalin “the greatest man of all times and peoples.” But the enemies might hide behind him, and Stalin still saw enemies in great numbers. Presumably, in his congratulatory telegram on the 15th anniversary of the GPU in December 1932, he did not call the “work of exterminating the enemies of the proletariat” completed, but “complicated.”

The kulaks had been destroyed, but he gave a new target to the Party's hostility in the "warehouse managers, economic managers, accountants, secretaries, etc." of the collective farms, a good part of whom were representatives of the "former," the "dying classes." He was angry with those members of the Politburo and the Central Committee who had prevented him from shooting those *enemies of the Party* who were hiding within the Party itself. For almost a decade, statues of Stalin had stood all over the country, he was called the "great leader of the peoples" in a constant stream of flattering addresses, major cities and countless streets bore his name, but he had not become definitively the autocrat, while he still had enemies in the party.

But even Hitler was not the sole ruler during the first half of 1934. The determination with which he then got rid of his enemies seems to have made a strong impression on Stalin. It was a mere copy of the Soviet model when pictures could be seen everywhere in Nazi Germany that showed Hitler alongside Frederick the Great, Bismarck and Hindenburg as the consummator of national unification, just as in the Soviet Union Stalin was pictured next to Marx, Engels and Lenin as the champion of the working class. But with the Röhm affair, Hitler became a role model for the first time, at least objectively and presumably also in the mind of his opponent.

Chapter III, Section 2

The "Röhm Putsch" and the Assassination of Kirov in 1934

Ernst Röhm, the chief of staff of the SA, was no mere henchman of Hitler, he had once in Munich been one of the most powerful Reichswehr officers of his protectors, and the SA was not simply a "subdivision" of the NSDAP, but until January 30, 1933, it was in the eyes of the public the visible and activist party itself; its brown uniforms then formed the dominant color in the national uprising and even more so in the National Socialist revolution. But this fighting army of the ruling party did not replace the old army, as the Red Guard had done in Soviet Russia, and Hitler was far from wanting to lead an annihilation attack, following Lenin's example, against the armed might of the state. The situation, after all, was completely different, because the Reichswehr had long since overcome the consequences of the war, and no politician in Germany could take power against their will. The SA, for its part, was not hostile to the Reichswehr from the outset, since its leadership corps, like that of the Reichswehr, consisted largely of World War officers and Freikorps fighters, only in a different proportion, and it was therefore just as much a product of the *positive war experience* of the representatives in Russia who had succumbed to the onslaught of the masses who hated war, or at least the war of *the tsar and the landlords*. Nevertheless, the SA was a force that did not consider the National Socialist revolution completed with July 14, 1933. In their ranks, therefore, there was talk of the second revolution, which would have to eliminate the still numerous reactionaries in the Wehrmacht and the economy and create the National Socialist People's Army, whose Minister of War would be Ernst Röhm. So that, at the same time, the SA presented itself as a new manifestation of the left or socialism in the NSDAP, and it was no coincidence that Otto Straßer had many good connections to high SA leaders. Of course, none of this meant hostility towards Adolf Hitler; it was rather felt that the Führer had to be freed from the alliance with *the reaction*, which he had turned to in the interests of gaining power.

Nothing was more natural than that those threatened formed an informal alliance: the

Reichswehr under Minister Blomberg and his chief of staff Reichenau, the German Nationalists in the cabinet headed by Papen, and the industrialists under the leadership of Krupp and Thyssen. Of the National Socialist ministers, Göring and Frick sided with the opponents of the SA, probably out of conviction; Goebbels seemed to falter. With the announcement of the "end of the revolution" in July 1933, Hitler made a preliminary decision, but he continued to seek to mediate between the two groups and reserved the office of arbitrator for himself. But while the Reichswehr initially remained in place, the SA expanded extraordinarily in 1933: it incorporated the entire "Stahlhelm," subjugated the universities by setting up "SA university offices," created its own "SA field police" and set up armed staff guards in many places, not infrequently in connection with SA relief camps. In July, a provisional arrangement was made between the Reichswehr and the SA: Obergruppenführer Friedrich Wilhelm Krüger was appointed chief of training, and thus the SA had become the umbrella organization for all paramilitary training. For the SA units in the East, a long-awaited goal was realized: they were given access to the border guard weapons depots. The total strength of the SA at the end of 1933 was about four million men: it thus had a starting position which the communists, when they called for civil war, could not even have dreamed of. Nevertheless, the Reichswehr was generally considered to be even stronger.

But how long would that last? After all, wouldn't the sheer numbers carry the decisive factor in the end? Was Hitler perhaps, as was then claimed in national-Bolshevik circles, the Kerensky of the German revolution or the most important of its Girondist leaders? However, it could have been argued with better justification and with reference to Mussolini that all the analogies drawn from the previous history of revolution were wrong, because it was a question of a new and therefore different type of revolution, namely the fascist type.

The situation at the beginning of 1934 was not easy for Hitler. The millenarian hopes of the national uprising were far from being realized, unemployment had fallen only relatively slowly and largely through extension measures, and the beginnings of the church struggle and the travel ban against Austria created much concern. Real wages fell rather than rose. Goebbels had to launch a propaganda campaign against "whiners and defeatists" who were obviously able to move quite freely. If the SA was restless, wide conservative circles were dissatisfied. The fact that Röhm, together with Hess, was appointed Reich Minister without portfolio on December 1, 1933, was to be seen only as a consolation prize. However, Röhm now also developed diplomatic activities, e.g. met with the French Ambassador François-Poncet and on April 18 gave a big speech to the diplomatic corps and the foreign press in Berlin, in which he said: "...The SA stands as an unshakable bulwark against reaction, bourgeoisie and sycophants—because it embodies everything that makes up the

concept of revolution!...The National Socialist revolution in Germany is the breakthrough of a new world view. The racial conditionality of its core problem, the national community (*volksgemeinschaft*) , proves that the new German idealistic nationalism has no desire for conquest, but turns his energies inward..."

Here was the crucial point. Röhm was nowhere near as feared by foreign diplomats as by German conservatives, because the transformation of the Reichswehr into a militia army would delay, if not prevent, serious rearmament. The *reaction* was also attacked in the Horst Wessel song, which was now part of the national anthem, and the peace-loving, domestic-political interpretation of racial theory was often expressed by Hitler himself, but rapid and efficient rearmament was Hitler's most important program point at the moment, and he would not let anyone jeopardize it. But even if he had not seen himself under time pressure, he would hardly have sided with Röhm, for his party as a whole was by no means revolutionary in Röhm's sense, and he himself was not unaware that numerous Communists had flocked to the SA and possibly hoped to push an SA revolution to an even more complete upheaval. He could count on the support of Röhm's Unterführers Himmler and Lutze, and Göring and the Gestapo were on his side anyway. Disturbing reports of alleged SA preparations for insurrection were being circulated by the Reichswehr, and at the center of the network was Hitler's most trusted supporter among senior officers, General von Reichenau. But Hitler seemed to be slow in coming to a final decision.

At the beginning of June he had another long conversation with Röhm, during which he apparently suggested that he go on vacation. Röhm did so and even ordered a general SA leave, but he issued a threatening daily order on June 8 in which—incomprehensible folly—he did not mention Hitler's name. But he did speak of the enemies of the SA and their vain hopes, and he ends with the pathetic sentence: "The SA is and will remain Germany's destiny."

On June 17, independently of Hitler, an important counterpoint was set. At the invitation of the University Association, Vice-Chancellor von Papen gave a speech in Marburg in which he spoke of the "dross" of the revolutionary state, once again opposed an anti-Christian claim to totality, and warned against dividing the people into Spartans and Helots. The decisive sentences are the following: "Anyone who irresponsibly plays with such thoughts (of the second revolution) should not hide from himself that a second wave can easily be followed by a third, that whoever threatens the guillotine is most likely to fall under the guillotine...There is much talk of the coming socialization. Have we seen an anti-Marxist revolution to carry out the program of Marxism?...No people can afford perpetual revolt from below if they want to

stand before history...You cannot shape things with eternal dynamism. Germany must not be in a trek into the blue, that nobody knows when it is going to stop..."

Hitler took this speech not as support but as a challenge. Its distribution was forbidden, and its author Edgar Jung, once a prominent champion of the *conservative revolution*, is arrested. Hitler decides for an two front fight.

On June 28, he had an SA leaders' conference convened in Bad Wiessee and announced his attendance. On June 30, after a visit to Essen, he flew from Hangelar to Munich together with Goebbels and Lutze. A lot of sensational news had reached him immediately beforehand, e.g. about the planning of an assassination attempt against him by the Standartenführer Uhl and about preparations for an uprising by the Berlin SA-führer Ernst (who in truth was going on his honeymoon). To what extent Hitler took them seriously and let them determine his actions is still unclear. In any case, several SA leaders were arrested as soon as they arrived in Munich, and in Wiessee the completely surprised Röhm, is taken into custody with his most important followers. The prisoners are taken to Stadelheim prison by bus. On the way, other SA leaders who are on their way to Wiessee are arrested. The Bavarian Minister of Justice, Frank, initially reassured Röhm by saying that he was, after all, in a courthouse, but on a note signed by Hitler he handed over 19 men to the SS, who were immediately shot. Röhm is given the opportunity to commit suicide, and when he fails to take it, he is killed on July 1 by Theodor Eicke, the second in command of Dachau and later inspector of the concentration camps. In the meantime in Berlin, Göring and Himmler are independently expanding their orders, and Gregor Straßer and Generals von Schleicher and von Bredow are also shot. The victims also include Papen's associates von Bose and Jung, and the Vice Chancellor himself is placed under house arrest.

Hitler received telegrams of thanks from Blomberg and Hindenburg. On July 3, a "Law on the Measures of State Emergency Defense" is published, which states that the measures taken on June 30, July 1 and 2 to suppress high and national traitorous attacks were "lawful" as state emergency defense. And in his Reichstag speech of July 13, Hitler gave the following explanation: "If, however, three high traitors in Germany arrange and hold a meeting with a foreign statesman, which they themselves describe as 'official,' holding it while keeping the staff away and conceal from me by the strictest orders, then I will have such men shot dead, even if it should be true that during a consultation that was so hidden from me, only the weather, old coins and the like were said to have been discussed."

That was an incredible justification for an incredible event. All states have treason laws, and

they often have death as the penalty, but only after a trial! The SA had killed several hundred of its opponents since January 30, but there was talk of *excesses*, and most of the time the judiciary took action. In the Soviet Union, millions of *enemies* had been annihilated, but a *revolutionary right* was invoked and found various infestations even in the old constitutional states of the West. But there had never been such a massacre within a state leadership in modern history, not even within the Soviet Union. The accusations of gluttony and homosexuality, prepared to infuriate the general public and moreover insincere, carried even less weight than that of conspiracy, which in regard to General von Schleicher was at least not entirely implausible. And there were still immensely aggravating circumstances. A number of men had been shot out of revenge or as a warning, although they had no connection to the SA or possible planning by conservative circles: 73-year-old Gustav von Kahr and the chairman of the Catholic Action, Klausener, were among them, and von Schleichers' wife had met her death alongside him. There was no fundamental difference to the mass shootings after the assassination attempts of Lenin and Uritzki, and not even an acute civil war situation could be cited as an excuse. Thus, in the center of Europe, a regime had come into being that not only shot its political opponents without sparing family members and without legal proceedings, but also destroyed the opposition within its own leadership in a mass bloodbath. It could now also be said of the National Socialist regime that shooting was the be-all and end-all of its governing wisdom.

If one does not want to be satisfied with the term "gang of criminals," as the Russian emigres had done for years in relation to the Bolsheviks, only one serious justification can be found, and it was put forward by Hitler himself in that Reichstag speech: "In this hour I was responsible for the fate of the German nation and thus the supreme judge of the German people. Mutiny divisions have always been called to order by decimation. Only one state has not made use of its articles of war, and this state has also collapsed for it: Germany. I did not want to hand over the young Reich to the fate of the old one."

But even if one wrongly assumes that the leaders of the SA actually wanted to refuse obedience, the premise of the argument was that a state of war prevailed. Therefore, by Hitler's own words, the regime revealed itself to be in a state of war in peacetime.

And precisely at that moment, following the death of Reich President von Hindenburg, Hitler was able to establish the autocracy that Mussolini was never able to achieve and that even Stalin did not yet have, formally or factually, at that point in time. In addition, the Reichswehr Minister von Blomberg eliminated the internal independence of the Wehrmacht through a coup d'état-like amendment by changing the oath of allegiance.

As early as August 1, 1934, the day before Hindenburg's death, the Reich government decided that the office of Reich President should be combined with that of Reich Chancellor, although even the Enabling Act gave no basis for this. More importantly, Blomberg introduced by decree the new oath swearing the Wehrmacht to personal loyalty to the "Führer of the German Reich and people, Adolf Hitler." This change, too, was unlawful and, to that extent, revolutionary. But taking the personal oath meant a connection to the monarchical tradition, and it was therefore gladly accepted by the officers. That it was a kind of barter transaction became evident when Hitler sent a letter of thanks to Blomberg on August 20, in which he gave the solemn assurance that "in fulfillment of the will of the immortalized Field Marshal," he would always regard as his highest duty "to enshrine the Army as the nation's sole bearer of arms."

In doing so, Hitler gave the Wehrmacht a kind of guarantee against certain tendencies of his own party, but he himself had become an autocrat such as the history of the German Reich had never known: not a *substitute monarch*, as Hindenburg allegedly was during the Weimar period, but to a supreme-monarch, in addition to "the Führer of the German Reich and people" with unlimited powers.

From then on he did not even have a vice chancellor at his side: despite the deep humiliation he had suffered, von Papen took over the post of extraordinary envoy in Vienna to mitigate the consequences of the National Socialist assassination attempt on Chancellor Dollfuss on July 25, 1934, which consisted mainly in a serious conflict with Mussolini. The behavior of the Reichswehr can only be explained by the fact that they saw Hitler as "their man" who guaranteed them the realization of their highest wish: the achievement of "military freedom." In fact, there was no longer any force that could have opposed an increased and efficient rearmament. The increase in the army to 300,000 men, which Schleicher had planned to complete only in 1938, was brought forward by Hitler to autumn of 1934. However, it took some time before the leadership of the Wehrmacht understood that the exorbitant fulfillment of wishes is dangerous for those who wished them: the concept of the National Socialist People's Army had been done away with, but under the influx of the masses the Wehrmacht itself changed its face and lost the old solidity. In addition, contrary to the promise, the formation of armed SS units was now beginning, and it was probable that the Wehrmacht would face new competition in the foreseeable future.

Among the German people, Hitler's measures against the SA had been surprisingly well received, apparently because the party army was seen as a menacing and revolutionary force. Nevertheless, there was no lack of feeling of what it meant that, after a year and a half, the

National Socialist revolution had taken total control of the top leadership of the state and thus become practically uncontrollable: when the successor law was presented to the people for decision on August 19, despite various tricks and manipulations, 4.5 million voted "No," which was more than 10% of the electorate. This was a result without parallel in the absence of any legal counter-propaganda in a totalitarian state.

It was not surprising that numerous observers around the world viewed the Röhm affair as a serious shake-up of the National Socialist regime, probably even as the beginning of its end. Stalin, however was not among them. According to the report of Walter Krivitsky, who later became the head of Soviet military intelligence in Western Europe, Stalin was "deeply impressed by the manner in which Hitler exterminated his opposition. He studied down to the minutest detail every report our agents from Germany related to the events that night." His superior, General Bersin, the head of the intelligence service, came out of the Politburo meeting dealing with the events with Stalin the guiding principle that the events in Germany in no way indicated the collapse of the Nazi regime; on the contrary, they must lead to a consolidation of the regime and a strengthening of Hitler. At least since Khrushchev's revelations at the XXth Party Congress, there can hardly be any doubt that the assassination of Kirov on December 1, 1934, goes back to Stalin himself and that this created the conditions for a party purge which was intended to shrink Hitler's model to an almost microscopic size.

Yet things had started very differently in the Soviet Union than in Germany. If the triumphant unity of the national uprising was revealed in a bloody explosion as a quarrel of irreconcilable concepts and tendencies, then in 1934 in the Soviet Union something like reconciliation finally seemed to want to emerge from a long dispute, the reconciliation between the party majority and the opposition, which had for so long wrestled with each other about the right attitude towards socialism in a country, towards the international revolution, towards the peasants and above all towards the industrialization of the country. A high point of this struggle was the so-called "Ryutin's platform" in 1932, which saw in Stalin the sole culprit for the country's catastrophic situation and to which Stalin would have gladly responded with death sentences if he could have prevailed. But Lenin's legacy was still too keenly heard, namely that the Bolsheviks must on no account repeat the mistake of the Jacobins and engage in a war of extermination among themselves; therefore, in all the violent disputes with Trotskyites and Zinovievites, no death sentence had ever been pronounced, and when a party member was executed, such as Blumkin the murderer of Count Mirbach, who had played an important role again for a long time, then there had to be facts that could be interpreted as "treason" or something similar. Even Trotsky had merely been expelled. Ryutin, meanwhile, seemed to represent only the tip of the iceberg. The GPU had reported

time and again that tendencies were spreading among young people who wanted to continue the tradition of the Narodnaya Volgya and other terrorist organizations. In 1934, in a penal camp in the far north, Ivan Solonevich met students of this type, sons of high Party officials, who openly told him about their attempt to assassinate Stalin while visiting the theater. It seems that Kirov was among those who spoke most strongly against the death penalty for *intellectual authors* which Stalin had called for, although he was undoubtedly a true supporter of Stalin and had earned great merit as Zinoviev's successor in Leningrad in the Secretary-General's mind. From the summer of 1933 onwards, however, the situation eased considerably, not least because a good harvest was expected. No one could any longer doubt that the first Five-Year Plan had actually been brought to a successful conclusion in four years, and confidence grew that in the future millions of people would no longer have to die of starvation in order to achieve the great goals of the party and the state. Rather, a slowdown in the pace and tangible relief for the people now seemed to be possible. It seemed that Stalin himself did not want to escape this mood, and at the XVII. Party Congress, some former members of the opposition were allowed to speak, including Kamenev. At the same time, Maxim Gorky, who had a lot of influence with Stalin at the time, made great efforts to bring about reconciliation with the party intelligentsia and to support Kirov's "liberalism." On the other hand, Stalin's immediate circle, led by Kaganovich and Yezhov, opposed this tendency and sought to strengthen the suspicion that showed Stalin everywhere the activity of *enemies*. It is probable that this suspicion was aroused again when the plenary session of the Central Committee decided in November 1934 to speed up the transfer of Kirov from Leningrad to Moscow, which had already been envisaged by the Party Congress, in order to take up the post of Party Secretary alongside Stalin.

On December 1, 1934, Kirov was shot dead in his Leningrad official residence, the Smolny, by a young communist named Nikolayev. Stalin immediately traveled to Leningrad to personally direct the investigation. It quickly became apparent that the men of the NKVD (as the GPU was recently called) had neglected their duties, i.e. protecting Kirov, in a most conspicuous way. Despite this, they were only sentenced to light sentences, or they fell victim to traffic accidents. Nikolayev himself was a deserving party member, but he had long been one of the dissatisfied because he took offense at the increasing bureaucratization and bemoaned the loss of those personal and vital relationships within the party that had been a hallmark of the fighting years of the civil war and the first years that followed. He, too, had then turned back to the more distant past and immersed himself in the literature of nineteenth-century Russian terrorists. To all appearances he had had no accomplices, but, as his diary shows, he had frequently spoken to former members of the opposition, who made no secret of their critical attitude towards the current policies of the party leadership. It had been

Kirov himself, however, who had treated the remnants of the Zinovievite opposition leniently, wanting to draw them back into the regime; for example, he had allowed one of the oldest and most stubborn opposition figures, David Ryazanov, the former editor of the Complete Edition of Marx and Engels, to stay in Leningrad again. Should Zinoviev's successor nevertheless have been one of the traitors to the revolution for the disappointed old communist? Who then could have had an interest in leaving the champion of Stalinist liberalism (as one might put it) unprotected and, so to speak, exposed to his opponent's revolver? Was it really the critical members of the opposition, or was it not actually Stalin himself who wanted to have a reason to thoroughly clean up with his old opponents? Today there can hardly be any doubt, although some things remain puzzling about the matter, which also in this respect shows unmistakable similarities with the Reichstag fire affair.

Admittedly, a third explanation was possible, namely that a foreign power had guided Nikolayev's hand, and Radek in particular advocated the thesis of the "hand of the Gestapo," which offered the advantage of bringing the former oppositionists out of the line of fire, and above all not getting close to all too dangerous questions. In fact, the *thaw* did end immediately, although inner-party polemics against the opposition intensified and even a first trial was conducted against Zinoviev and Kamenev, which ended with the defendants being sentenced to prison terms. The party directive, which went out on the day of the assassination and ordered the immediate acceleration of the trials of all those accused of preparing or carrying out terrorist acts, remained secret and was initially applied only to arrested "White Guards" as a true "charter of lawlessness."

More importantly, Stalin gained reason to suspect that Kamenev had concealed many things from him in a personal conversation which ended in complete submission, and it seems that Stalin regarded such concealment as a crime worthy of death as much as Hitler did with respect to Röhm. But in the immediate aftermath of the assassination of Kirov, Stalin only set the conditions for the great purge; for the time being, however, the policy of mitigation and reconciliation appeared to be going on. The first preparations were made for the adoption of a new constitution, which was to be "the most democratic in the world," with the substantial cooperation of Bukharin. Bukharin was even allowed to travel to Paris, where he held the long talks with Boris Nikolayevsky, which resulted in the "Letter from an Old Bolshevik" to which most of the information about the Soviet scene associated with the Kirov assassination is owed. Stalin had just finally made the change in foreign policy which implied cooperation with the Western powers, and much negative publicity in the Western press would have been highly detrimental to the attainment of this goal.

Chapter III, Section 3

World Politics 1935/1936

When Trotsky took over the Foreign Commissariat in 1917, he was therefore convinced that his main task was to “close the shop” because foreign policy in the traditional sense would no longer exist. Rather, the domestic policy of Soviet Russia, the overthrow of capitalism, would soon become the real content of world politics, in which the proletariat would annihilate capitalism throughout Europe and then in the world. Hitler’s views were opposed to those of Trotsky, but for him, too, there was no sharp distinction between domestic politics and world politics. Most Europeans saw in him and his regime above all the spearhead of German revisionism and thus a power that threatened peace; the more emphatically he emphasized his desire for peace or the more convincingly Rudolf Hess described the horrors of war, the greater the chances that the “liberation from the shackles of the Versailles dictate,” which was undoubtedly one of his main goals in world politics, could be achieved peacefully at a later date by the mere pressure of the Reich regaining its strength. But peace speeches and diplomatic declarations were not the only facts that mattered. Since Germany, as the great state in the center of Europe, was most closely connected with the rest of the world and was far from being able to carry out an almost complete closure of its borders on the model of the Soviet Union, everything that happened in its domestic policy had to have direct or indirect repercussions on world politics. Thus the parties that Hitler had banned or forced to dissolve continued to exist in one form or another in the rest of Europe, and it would have been strange if feelings of solidarity had not arisen. Some of the German parties even lived on as such, with the historically conditioned modifications, in parts of the German-speaking area: the Center in Austria and in the Saar region, the Social Democracy also in Czechoslovakia and, despite the government leadership by the National Socialists, even in Danzig. The Russian Mensheviks had contributed significantly to the anti-Bolshevik position of the European Social Democratic parties after 1918; how could the émigré party executive of the Social Democratic Party of Germany in Prague not have exerted a corresponding influence on the other parties of the Socialist Workers’ International? But feelings of solidarity and thus the

repercussions on world politics in the churches and denominations were even stronger than in the parties.

Here, admittedly, an ambivalence was even more pronounced, which made itself felt in some of the parties, for the Austrian Christian Social Party, like the NSDAP, was an opponent of social democracy and as friendly with Mussolini as Hitler would have liked to be. For both the Catholic and the Protestant Church, National Socialism was on the one hand a threat and on the other hand a promise.

The Catholic Church had initially been more acutely aware of the threat contained in Article 24 of the party program, which tied the party's "positive Christianity" to the "ethical life and moral sense of the Germanic race." This called into question the absoluteness and universality of church teaching, and it was only logical that the church forbade its believers to become members of the NSDAP until 1933. On the other hand, however, there was good reason for the Church to sympathize with the national uprising, and the earlier bans were lifted in March 1933, though not without an unmistakable tone of concern. The Concordat of July 20, 1933 grew out of these contrasting sentiments: the Church abandoned political Catholicism in order to obtain a firm legal position for the defense of the spiritual core. For Hitler, in turn, recognition by the international power of the Vatican was a major global political success, which brought him more prestige than the extension of the German-Soviet neutrality treaty in May and the initialing of the Four-Power Pact in June. But as early as 1934 and 1935 strong tensions developed, which found expression to a large extent in the church's struggle against Alfred Rosenberg's "Myth of the 20th Century" and against "neo-paganism." But the element of patriotic and anti-communist affinity was always maintained and proved to be effective not only in the Saar referendum in January 1935, but also in the countless sermons that denounced the Soviet concentration camps, although the German ones were always included.

Among the Protestants, both the affinity and the opposition were different. They were much more open than the Catholics about modern thought tendencies and thus also about nationalistic-volkish ideas, but on the other hand they had a much closer relationship to the Old Testament. Thus, tendencies towards renewal, which remained marginal in the Catholic Church, became a very strong force within the Protestant regional churches in the form of the "German Christians," and they wanted to understand National Socialism as a "second reformation," as a repetition of the deed of the "German man Luther." The resistance they found was orthodox and, to a certain extent, reactionary, directed against the democratization and parliamentarization and the associated centralization that the "German Christians" were striving for. But the fight against the Aryan Paragraph and discrimination against Jewish

Christians then came more and more to the fore on the part of the “Pfarrernotbund” (*Emergency Covenant of Pastors*) and the “Confessing Church,” and not a few of the German Christians approached the anti-Christian “German Faith Movement,” where turns like “the poisonous weed of Asian, Jewish-Marxist Christianity” were common. Nevertheless, hardly anyone could be more nationally minded than the former U-boat commander and Freikorps fighter Martin Niemöller, who soon became the world’s best-known figure of the church resistance.

But not even among the Jewish opponents and victims of National Socialist anti-Semitism was the element of affinity completely absent, so it is certainly not just Jews who felt threatened by this anti-Semitism. It too was a complex phenomenon and four main themes can be distinguished, each with different historical origins:

National Socialist anti-Semitism was a kind of narrow-gauge socialism that focused on the Jews all the accusations made by the socialists against capitalism: the accusations of exploitation, parasitism, alienation from the people. But many of the early socialists had fought Rothschild and the Jews first and foremost as “kings of the age;” it was not until Karl Marx had transferred the critique to the far broader subject of *capitalism*, although he too had declared the modern world to be “Jewish to its innermost heart.”

In addition to the social motive, National Socialist anti-Semitism also contained a national motive which showed an unmistakable agreement with its counterpart on the Jewish side, namely Zionism. While Zionism was in its turn essentially a reaction to anti-Semitism, particularly Russian and French anti-Semitism, it had an independent root in the emergence of national sentiment as manifested in the Italian liberation and unification movement, and the connection is evident in the fundamental book of Zionism, Moses Hess’s “Rome and Jerusalem” of 1862. Therefore, it was not *only* a defensive measure when the German Zionists, even before 1914, made the will to emigrate to Palestine a condition of membership.

The historical reason for National Socialist hostility to Jews was a version of the stab-in-the-back legend: during the World War, Jews had evaded service with arms and committed treason even before the collapse; however, the moving core of the motive was apparently not the questionable or false claims about percentages and bureaucracy of the war economy, but the memory of the role of Jews like Leviné, Levien, Eisner and Rosa Luxemburg in the German revolution; it was thus already a question of the motive of *Jewish Bolshevism*, which was directly opposed to the first two motives.

The climax of National Socialist anti-Semitism was represented by the ideological and at the same time mythologizing theory of causes, which derived all misfortune in world history from the workings of a demonic force, namely *the Jew*. Thus, in a public lecture on “The Schutzstaffel as an anti-Bolshevik combat organization” in 1935, Reichsführer-SS Heinrich Himmler saw “the relentless executioner’s sword of Cannstatt and Verden flashing in the course of time,” the pyres of the witch trials blazing, the Inquisition depopulating Spain and the reign of terror of the French Revolution slaughtering the best sons of the French people, and in all this, in his opinion, “our common eternal enemy, the Jew, had a hand in some cloak or through some of his organizations.” The same man, in the same lecture, at the same time, derived all the difficulties and catastrophes of German history in a comparatively rational way from the Germanic urge for freedom and individualism, thereby making it clear that the underlying experience was exclusively that of Bolshevism, and that he transformed Lenin’s “Who, whom?” into the thesis that in these race struggles there are no peace agreements, and to be defeated here for the people meant to be dead.

The first and most *real* motive showed the least impact and power. The boycott of April 1st, directed not least against the Jewish department stores, was quickly called off, and until 1938 the activity of Jews in the economy was relatively unhindered, not least because of the protection by the Reich Minister of Economics Schacht.

The second motive laid behind the “Nuremberg Laws” of September 15, 1935, which made the Jews mere “national subjects” and, however, went far beyond this aspect of constitutional law insofar as they introduced into legislation the concept of “blood” following the feudal and also, admittedly, the American model, and criminalized marriages and extramarital affairs between Jews and Germans. However, the Transfer (Haavara) Agreement, which was intended to facilitate the emigration of Jews to Palestine, was entirely *Zionist*.

The third motive remained an enduring but primarily propagandistic topos.

In its consequences, the fourth motive was the peak of the revolutionary character of National Socialism, and the question arises as to whether it did not represent a real declaration of war on “the Occident,” whose protectors, in contrast to Ernst Niekisch and other national revolutionaries, one expressly wanted to be.

The fact that Hitler, through the Church struggle and through discrimination against the Jews, created for himself opponents in many countries, especially in England, who would have been neutral in the face of mere German nationalism can be illustrated by the statement of an

Englishwoman who said: "I thought that racial persecution belonged to another age." On the other hand, even Nahum Goldman reports in his memoirs that although he had proclaimed "the Jewish boycott against Nazi Germany" at the World Jewish Congress, he had energetically supported the Transfer Agreement despite violent attacks.

Thus, everything seemed to indicate that a regime which had already created such powerful opponents for itself through its domestic policy would encounter the united resistance of all states as soon as it no merely advocated its revisionist claims merely through propaganda and diplomacy, backed them up with a strong rearmament. Europe was still the authoritative continent, however much its world dominance had been weakened by World War I and the rise of non-European powers such as the United States and Japan, and Germany was potentially the strongest but also the most feared power on the continent, and even the *German culture* had few friends and lovers since an anti-Semitic movement took over. Nothing was therefore more natural than for the war coalition to renew itself and for a *policy of great resistance* to be pursued. But the basic condition of this policy was that the Soviet Union should join it. Indeed, the Soviet Union was prepared to do so, feeling more threatened than any other country. But had she not once solemnly proclaimed through the mouths of her followers that she wanted to be "the gravedigger of bourgeois society"? Had she not championed a harsh revisionism for fifteen years? Had she not persecuted the Christian churches much earlier, harder and more effectively than the National Socialists did? Had she not taken away from Zionism all possibilities of movement and activity, while in Germany the Jewish communities led to a vigorous inner life and Zionism was even promoted? Briand was no longer alive, but Jean Herbette's warnings about "evil" were hardly forgotten in the Foreign Ministry in Paris, and many Englishmen continued to think like "Augur." When in September 1934 the question of the entry of the Soviet Union into the bodies of the League of Nations was discussed, the Swiss Federal Councilor Motta expressed the deepest distrust in which some of the experiences of the first post-war period had remained alive: "Our embassy in Petersburg was plundered in 1918, one of their officials was massacred. We never heard even the slightest apology. When in 1918 an attempt at a general strike threatened us with the horrors of civil war, we had to use military force to remove a Soviet mission which we had tolerated in Bern, because it was involved in the agitation...Communism means in every field...the most thorough negation of all ideas on which our being and our lives are based...The spread beyond political boundaries is its (communism's) life spirit. If it renounces it, it denies itself. If it remains faithful to it, it becomes the enemy of all, because it threatens us all."

Motta was not able to prevent the Soviet Union from being admitted to the League of

Nations, but despite all of Litvinov's speeches and efforts, the radical counter-possibility that communist theorists had for so long considered the most important, indeed unavoidable, did not completely disappear: the *politics of the great agreement* between the capitalist powers, i.e. the consent of the establishment of German domination in Eastern Europe after the annihilation of the communist regime. It evidently corresponded to Hitler's real intentions and it appeared that it would imply the safeguarding of the colonial empires of England and France. It therefore met with sympathy in influential circles of the western powers. Although it failed to articulate itself much in public, it weakened the policy of the great resistance to a considerable extent, and although France's Foreign Minister Pierre Laval concluded a defensive alliance with the Soviet Union in May 1935, his intentions were primarily domestic in getting Stalin to publicly praise France's armaments efforts. In doing so, he dealt a severe blow to the violent anti-militarist agitation of the French communists and at the same time unwillingly prepared the Popular Front alliance which, over the course of the next twelve months, brought the communists together with the socialists and the left-bourgeois radical socialists under the banner of a new concept of "anti-fascism." But he did nothing to bring the agreement to ratification in the House and Senate, for in fact he had already become a champion of *small resistance* .

The pivot of this policy was Mussolini's fascist Italy. If it was possible to make Mussolini a reliable partner for the Western powers, then Hitler would be pinned down, forced to stand still, without the need to include the Soviet Union, which was unforeseeable in its consequences and feared especially by England. In April 1935, the Three Powers Conference in Stresa marked the culmination of this policy: a firm stand was taken against the violation of the Versailles Treaty of which Hitler was guilty when, on March 16, 1935, ostensibly in response to the extension of military service in France to two years, he proclaimed the introduction of general conscription and thus putting beyond all doubt the fact of extensive German rearmament. But Mussolini felt he could exact a heavy price for his cooperation from the Western powers, namely, toleration of his intention to model Italy as a major colonial power and to conquer Ethiopia, which had been a member of the League of Nations since 1923 and therefore enjoyed the protection of *collective security* . Although he received no assurances, the Duce dared, on October 2, 1935, to summon millions of people to the squares of Italy and to appeal to "proletarian and fascist Italy" to finally acquire, through a campaign in East Africa, the "place in the sun" so long denied to her by the bourgeois nations of the West. In so doing he ruined the policy of small resistance in a short space of time, but its remnants proved to be strong enough to assure him eventual success.

But meanwhile Great Britain had taken serious steps into the realm of the second *small*

possibility of world politics, the *politics of small consensus*. Shortly after the introduction of general conscription in Germany, the British cabinet had asked Hitler whether the visit by Foreign Secretary Sir John Simon and Lord Privy Seal Anthony Eden, which had been planned for some time, was still welcome. Hitler, understandably, did not say no, and at the talks of March 25 and 26 he apparently made a very good impression on the English guests, who had thought they were meeting a demagogue and who now came to believe that a statesman was sitting opposite of them. Although Simon and Eden traveled on to Moscow of all places, they took up a suggestion from Hitler on their return, and in rapid negotiations conducted by the special ambassador Joachim von Ribbentrop, a naval agreement was prepared, which was presented to the surprised world public on June 18. The total strength of the German naval fleet was set at 35% of that of the British, and parity was even granted for U-Boats. Although Great Britain thereby achieved her goal of binding Hitler with new treaties after the Versailles provisions had become obsolete, she also retrospectively sanctioned earlier breaches of the treaties and gave Hitler the impression that he could not expect any decisive resistance, even if he did throw off the last and most important fetters that had been placed on Germany after the defeat.

Mussolini created the conditions for this. He encountered unexpectedly fierce resistance when he deployed his troops against Ethiopia, and within weeks sanctions were imposed on Italy by 50 countries. But the Duce displayed great nerve, and the League of Nations did not carry their measures to the point where they would have become dangerous to the regime. As late as March 2, 1936, the new French Foreign Minister Flandin, by means of a “last appeal,” obtained a further postponement to delay the decision on an oil embargo again.

Meanwhile the French government, whose attention was always primarily focused on Germany, had forwarded the pact with the Soviet Union to the legislature, thereby reverting to the policy of great resistance. But domestic opposition from the right and sections of the center was extremely fierce, and Hitler was convinced with a sure psychological instinct that the French, especially on the eve of crucial parliamentary elections which the “Popular Front” hoped to win, would not be inclined to make any serious decisions. Moreover, he was also probably right in thinking that the Franco-Russian pact, despite its reference to the League of Nations statute, represented a novel fact which had not been foreseen when Stresemann had agreed in Locarno in 1925 to agree to the “demilitarization” of the Rhineland, i.e. to accept an extraordinary loss of sovereignty for an indefinite future in order to appease France. Thus, shortly after the ratification of the pact by the French chamber on March 7, 1936, Hitler allowed German troops to move into the Rhineland, thereby committing by far the most serious of his breaches of the treaty to date. That he was exceedingly nervous during the first

48 hours is well documented, and the troops were instructed to withdraw if necessary. It is an open question whether the National Socialist regime would have survived the occupation of Mainz and Cologne.

But it was now evident that the French military was no less frightened than the Germans. Without mobilization measures, they did not believe they could be responsible for an action, and the politicians did not want to agree to this, so that they were content with an appeal to the League of Nations. In England, according to the report of the German military attaché, the opinion of the little man on the street was that they were not crazy after all and would not go back to the Somme and Passchendaele again because the Germans were occupying their own country. Thus Hitler once again retained the upper hand and achieved a real triumph in the quickly announced Reichstag elections on March 28, with a turnout of over 99%, 98.8% of those entitled to vote voted for the National Socialist ticket.

In the meantime, Mussolini was also on the road to victory. On May 5, 1936, the Italians, under the leadership of the Commander-in-Chief, Marshal Badoglio, entered Addis Ababa, and it was no longer of any use when the Ethiopian delegate, in an impassioned speech to the League of Nations on May 11, denounced the “crime” by which the Italians “with the most cruel means of modern civilization” robbed the Ethiopians of their freedom and “exterminated” considerable parts of the population. It was not long before the sanctions were lifted, and the western powers indicated that they would try to revive the policy of small resistance, despite the Franco-Soviet pact. But Hitler had made possible Mussolini’s triumph possible, and Mussolini had made Hitler’s success possible. It was no wonder that the two were now moving more and more towards one another, since Hitler’s admiration for Mussolini and fascism had always been evident, and since Mussolini, for his part, even in times of sharp power-political tensions between the two states, showed the ideological affinity and often emphasized the structural similarity of the regimes. A tip from Mussolini gave Hitler the opportunity to conclude an agreement with Austria on July 11, 1936, which confirmed state independence and nevertheless forced Dollfuss’s successor, Kurt von Schuschnigg, to agree to a kind of Gleichschaltung. Hitler was no longer isolated, for the three main realistic options for the policy to be pursued towards him had shown so many interferences that none could be consistently implemented.

But what about the fourth and oldest basic possibility, that of great agreement? There is little positive evidence of this kind to be found in official statements by Western statesmen, but Laval at least seems to have given serious thought to whether it might not be best to direct German momentum eastward, and there were various hints in leading circles in Western

states and talks that went in this direction, which in turn filled the American ambassador in Berlin, William Dodd, with great indignation. The counter-tendencies were certainly much stronger, although they were often represented in public by writers who were sympathetic to the *great social experiment* in the Soviet Union. In France, the Popular Front was victorious in the May 3 general election, and in England, too, anti-fascism gained ground despite the Conservatives enjoying a secure parliamentary majority. The diplomacy of Foreign Commissar Litvinov corresponded perfectly with these tendencies. It was so different in character and intonation from the pronouncements of the 1920s that something extraordinary must have happened to bring about this change. However, it is highly questionable whether Stalin expressed his real fears when, at the 17th Party Congress, he distinguished between an “old” and a “new” line of German policy, which would have been in contention even before Hitler came to power, namely the Rapallo policy on the one hand, and the tendency to resume the policy of the former German Emperor on the other, “who for a time occupied the Ukraine, undertook a campaign against Leningrad and turned the Baltic countries into a staging area for such a campaign.” It was all too understandable that he announced to the representatives of this new policy, using a drastic metaphor, that the new industrial and military strength of the Soviet Union would prevent them from “sticking their pig snout into our Soviet garden.” But was his real fear not that the Western powers would take *his* new line, the Litvinov policy, for a mere stratagem and would eventually switch to the policy of the grand agreement after all? But then, in the future, the campaign of the German ruler and the intervention of the Allies would no longer be directed against each other as in 1918, but would be coordinated. Germany, then, had to be the center of his concerns, and two hopes presented themselves: Germany’s return to the Rapallo policy on the one hand, and the paradoxical separation of capitalist Germany, pronounced in its fascism, from the less active capitalist states. In any case, he had to press ahead with armaments, and he had already laid the foundation for this in 1928 with the first five-year plan. In May 1935, he was able to give the most convincing interpretation of collectivization, even for Western ears, when he said in a speech to Red Army graduates that the task had been to free a technically backward and almost destitute country with a semi-illiterate population “from the tracks of the Middle Ages and ignorance onto the tracks of modern industry and mechanized agriculture.” This had been accomplished, he said, and now the Soviet Union had a powerful and first-class industry and an organized and technically superbly equipped Red Army. Shortly before, the Deputy War Commissar Mikhail N. Tukhachevsky had announced more precisely at the Seventh Congress of Councils in January 1935: the expenditure of the People’s Commissariat for Defense in 1934 had amounted to about five billion rubles and for 1935 6.5 billion rubles had been estimated. The effective strength of the Red Army at the present time is 960,000 men and the goal was “that there shall be no other army equal to it in the world.”

If Germany was the center of attention for Stalin, the Soviet Union in turn must have been the main object of Hitler's focus, even if he was primarily concerned with Italy and France, with England and Poland. Although Stalin's claim that the Soviet Union's rearmament was a reaction to Hitler's seizure of power, its origins go back much further, and in any case it was so far ahead of the German one that any government in Berlin would have been extremely alarmed. In 1934 Hitler by no means spent more than 3 billion marks on armaments, 5 billion rubles was at least four times as much, and the statistics of a planned economy do not reveal the indirect armaments expenditure.

There can be no doubt that the Soviet Union and Bolshevism also occupied the emotional center of Hitler's thinking in 1935-36. Speaking to Sir John Simon and Anthony Eden, according to interpreter Paul Schmidt, "his nostrils trembled slightly with excitement as he described the dangers of Bolshevism to Europe." With "passionate excitement" he emphasized that hundreds of his party comrades had been murdered by the Bolsheviks and that many German soldiers and civilians had lost their lives fighting Bolshevik uprisings. According to Schmidt, his "favorite topic, the Soviet Union," took up a lot of time during the conversation, and Hitler, full of anger, called Czechoslovakia, which was just negotiating a mutual assistance pact with Moscow, the "advanced arm of Russia."

All of this was not *mere tactics*, but a thinly veiled plea for Hitler's real foreign policy conception, the conception of a policy of great agreement that corresponded exactly to his domestic policy: the alliance with Papen and Hugenberg for the purpose of defeating the common enemy. This alliance, too, was more than mere tactics for Hitler; it corresponded to some of his deepest convictions.

Therefore, the major confrontation with the Soviet Union and Bolshevism, which Hitler undertook in the Reichstag speech of May 21, 1935, should not only be seen in the context of short-term foreign policy goals. Hardly anywhere else has he presented himself and his movement so unequivocally as a *response* to Bolshevism.

As a doctrine, National Socialism refers exclusively to the German people, while Bolshevism emphasizes its international mission; it was a National Socialist conviction that Europe's happiness and achievements were inseparably linked to the existence of a system of independent, free national states, but Bolshevism preached the establishment of a world empire and knew only sections of a central International; Bolshevism is pursuing the international world revolution with the weapons of terror and violence, National Socialism is fighting for the consistent balancing of life contradictions and for the bringing together of all

to achieve common achievements; Bolshevism sacrifices millions of people and immeasurable values of traditional culture for the sake of a theory and yet achieves only a very low standard of living, while National Socialist Germany is happy to belong to a European cultural community which has stamped its spirit on the contemporary world to such a great extent; National Socialism sees in private property a "higher development of human economic development," but Bolshevism not only destroys private property, but also private initiative and the the joy of responsibility.

These were certainly to a large extent commonplaces in contemporary thought in Europe and America. But nothing to say against the fact that they also represented Hitler's sincere convictions. Without genuine common ground, a policy of consensus could not be pursued. The German answer had to be, for the most part, the answer of both Europe and the United States. But its peculiarity had already become tangible for everyone at the beginning of 1934 in another Reichstag speech by Hitler, namely the peculiarity that this answer was at the same time at least a rudimentary copy: "When Herr Stalin expressed his fear in his last big speech that anti-Soviet forces might be active in Germany, I have to correct this opinion to the effect that just as little as in Russia a German National Socialist tendency would be tolerated, so little will Germany tolerate a Communist tendency or even propaganda." Did not the *freedom* of the European cultural community consist precisely in the fact that it tolerated hostile propaganda and even activity, because it gave space to all opinions and activities and had hitherto been strong enough to draw profit from it for its development? Was there not the danger that *all* free activity and *every* private expression of opinion would have to be suppressed if this demand for exact correspondence was carried to further consequences? Should not the fate of Papen and Hugenberg be a lesson and a warning for Simon and Eden? Did not Hitler himself stand in the way of the policy he most strove for? Was not Bertrand Russell right when he said, albeit with a defeatist undertone, "In trying to stop them, we shall become like them"? Not only did the old anti-German sentiments come into play, but also the anti-totalitarian beliefs deeply rooted in Western culture. The obstacles piling up before the policy of great agreement were at least as great as those before the policy of great resistance.

In any case, by the middle of 1936 it had become an indisputable fact that the two defeated sides of the World War were once again great military powers and that they had good reason to feel threatened by one another. It had not yet been definitively decided which of the four major world policy options that emerged after Hitler came to power would be realized. The fifth main possibility, to which Stalin had alluded with nostalgia in his speech, no longer seemed to exist: the possibility of Germany and the Soviet Union finding one another along

the lines of the Rapallo Treaty. On the contrary, both powers let weapons do the talking, albeit outside their sovereign territories, as they intervened on opposite fronts in the Spanish Civil War after the revolt of General Franco.

Chapter III, Section 4

Germany and the Soviet Union in the Spanish Civil War

Rumors about the arrival of Soviet ships bringing weapons for the planned seizure of power by the Bolshevik forces were, according to those involved, major motive for triggering the uprising of the Spanish army against the Popular Front government on 17-18 July 1936; allegations of Hitler's involvement in the preparations are still making the rounds today. One is untrue, the other highly improbable. The Spanish Civil War grew out of Spanish roots. But early on, and not without reason, the events in Spain between 1931 and 1936 were compared with those in Russia between February and October 1917, and in November 1936 Soviet and German planes and tanks, manned or at least directed by German and Soviet soldiers, engaged in a bitter fight for Madrid. The decision was made by Fascist Italy's heavy deployment of regular army and militia units, and joint intervention brought Germany and Italy together to form the "Axis." Secretly, and at first scarcely noticed by the world public, a struggle of a very different kind was being waged on the side of the *Republicans* or the *Reds*, a struggle between Bolsheviks and Mensheviks with an inverted front, which can be seen as the result of the contrast between the early and late phases of the Russian revolution.

The Spanish state, like the Russian, had been formed in a struggle against a non-Christian power, and where the rule of the Moors preceded that of the *Tartars*, the memory was still strong, and one of the after-effects was, as in Russia, the great importance of a state religion. In Spain, too, industry had developed very unevenly up to the First World War, the largest part of the country was still entirely agrarian, and in many regions the majority of the population was made up of landless or land-poor farmers. Among the intellectuals in Spain, too, *Europeanizers* took a harsh stance against *traditionalists*, and this alone proves that Spain, like Russia, had a difficult relationship with *Europe*. In Spain, too, social unrest was combined in a variety of ways with regional aspirations for independence, which in the case of the Basques and Catalans almost took on the character of national liberation struggles against Castilian domination.

Admittedly, the differences were also considerable. Spain had been part of the liberal monarchies since the end of the first Carlist War in 1839; it had repeatedly experienced revolutionary upheavals, most of them triggered or ended by the army's *pronunciamento* ; since 1889 parliamentary elections had been held by universal suffrage; the Socialist Workers' Party had a legal existence, and the anarchists spread their doctrine not only among the peasants of Andalusia but also among the factory workers of Catalonia. Thus, in 1931, as a result of elections, the monarchy was replaced by the Second Republic, which not only adopted a constitution modeled on the Weimar Republic, but its party system seemed to differ little from that of the other European states, except for the unusual strength of the anarchists.

It was not surprising that the new state found harsh opponents on both the monarchist right and the anarchist left, for it was initially governed by left-bourgeois forces who wanted to continue the work of repressing the Church, reducing the army and reducing large-scale land ownership. What was even more serious was that the Socialists, under the leadership of Largo Caballero, who had worked closely with the dictator Primo de Rivera until 1930, developed more and more into a revolutionary party, and that Gil Robles' Christian Democratic Party did not give up its fundamental reservations. For the one and for the other event, however, international conditions were already decisive: for the socialists, Hitler's seizure of power and the violent defeat of the Austrian Social Democrats in February 1934, for the Christian party, the *CEDA* , the atmosphere of the cult of the leader and the uniformed associations, which hardly remained anywhere without effects. The Asturian uprising of 1934, which was crushed in bloody battles by the Foreign Legionnaires under General Franco, contributed immensely to sharpening the antagonism: Largo Caballero was now not averse to being called the "Spanish Lenin," and considerable sections of the *CEDA* now sympathized with the newly founded "Falange" and its leader José Antonio Primo de Rivera.

The elections of February 16, 1936 showed that two roughly equal blocs of right and left constituency were facing each other and that the center was almost destroyed, but as a result of the electoral system a great victory for the Popular Front was produced, which now also included the anarchists. The result was severe social unrest in large parts of the country, since the agricultural workers in particular demanded the immediate fulfillment of the election promises and in many places occupied the land of the large landowners without any fuss. Dozens of churches were set on fire across town and country, and the death toll ran into the hundreds. There was much talk in the socialist press of the impending proletarian revolution, and with some justification observers perceived the hand of the Comintern behind the unification of the socialist and communist youth leagues. On the other hand, the Falange did

their best to provoke by assassinations, and the Carlists in Navarre prepared almost openly for civil war. But more and more generals in the army, both republicans and monarchists, became convinced that the country was threatened with disintegration by social and separatist agitation and that President Manuel Azaña, the model of the leftist educated citizen, was the Kerensky of a Spanish revolution.

Thus, preparations were made for the uprising, which the leaders were convinced would not be a revolt, but rather a seizure of power and the restoration of order along the lines of the nineteenth-century *pronunciamentos* or the coup d'état of Primo de Rivera in 1923. The assassination of the monarchist politician Calvo Sotelo by members of a kind of regime police was probably more cause than reason, and on the evening of July 17, 1936, the most powerful units of the Spanish army, stationed in North Africa, where they had experienced heavy defeats and great victories, took control of the colony, while the next day many army units rose up in the motherland. But only in the north and in the extreme south of the country did the soldiers prevail with the consent and participation of the population or by surprise attack; in the big cities, on the other hand, excited crowds quickly assembled and demanded arms from the government. Although considerable parts of the army and police forces, and almost all the air force and navy, remained loyal, the government gave way under a new prime minister, and within a few days the army insurrection was crushed in Madrid and in Barcelona, in Valencia and in Badajoz, in Catalonia and in Extremadura. At the same time, however, the revolution spread like wildfire in *loyalist* Spain and reduced the power of the left-bourgeois government to nothing. Armed masses filled the streets, burned down churches, drove out or killed the businessmen and especially priests and monks, set up cooperatives and organized defenses. The mood was festive almost everywhere: here, too, the *slaves* had chased the masters away and were now setting up a life of equality, often with touching recourses to older times, as in Catalonia in particular, where many village communities behaved like independent states and abolished all the symptoms of luxury and vice, such as coffee and alcohol, but also now and then experimented with a large-scale planned economy. The Left around the world saw the liberation and the serenity, the new beginning and the mass enthusiasm; everywhere the Right looked with horror at the murders, the disorder and the dispossession, and they immediately spoke of *Bolshevism* in Spain. The Left denounced the mass shootings carried out by the *Whites* in many places, and the Right spread reports of the crucifixion of priests and the horrific drownings of innocent people by the Reds. Public opinion became even more polarized than during the Russian Civil War. More clearly than then, Liberal voices were in favor of the Republicans and Loyalists, but even the *New York Times* expressed fears in early August that if the government won, Communism would soon take over, and in England it was not just conservatives who were

outraged about the fact that the sailors on some ships of the Spanish Navy had thrown their officers overboard, just as Sergej Eisenstein had depicted in his “Battleship Potemkin.”

Events like these could not leave any state indifferent. As early as the evening of July 23, reports in the French right-wing press made it known that the French government had received a request from the Spanish Prime Minister Giral for arms deliveries and that it intended to fulfill this request. In France, however, Léon Blum was now at the helm as head of the Popular Front cabinet. One could guess that there was an ideological affinity here, even if one did not know that Giral had ended his telegram “with brotherly greetings.” That this affinity would soon have consequences in France similar to those in Spain was the thesis of the French Right, which therefore opposed such an intervention with the utmost vigor and dire threats. Thus, the newspaper reports probably would not have been needed to persuade Hitler to accept Franco’s request for the delivery of 20 transport planes, which were conveyed to him by two German businessmen in Bayreuth on the evening of July 25. This request bore all the signs of improvisation, and it would certainly have been rejected by the Foreign Office because the risks were considered too great and, moreover, they did not want to endanger the lives of the Germans in Republican Spain. But Hitler was immediately convinced that Bolshevism was reaching for Spain and that its path had to be blocked. None of his advisers dared to disagree, and from the beginning of August Junker planes played a key role in transporting Moroccan troops and Franco’s Foreign Legionnaires across the Strait of Gibraltar to Andalusia. Only this made it possible to continue the civil war, which now presented itself as an armed conflict between regions and, to a certain extent, between classes. Catalonia, ruled by the anarchist trade union CNT, was in a front with the predominantly socialist-ruled Madrid and the Catholic, non-revolutionary Basque Country, against Navarre, with its Carlist militias, and Old Castile, where the Falange was strong, as well as those parts of Andalusia, where the urban and rural workers had been surprised by a coup d’état by General Queipo de Llano, who was a staunch and proven Republican.

Just as early as Hitler and Mussolini, who also sent some planes, but with more determination, the Communist International intervened in the struggle, and it would have been powerless without the organization and funds placed at its disposal by the Red Army Intelligence and the GPU. In truth, then, it was a matter of Soviet intervention, but this intervention would not have been possible in such a form unless a large number of men, and by no means only communists, had not been ready to risk their lives to prevent the “attack of fascism.” Thus, in France and England, for example, numerous volunteers flocked to the assembly points, German and Italian emigrants joined them, men came secretly from Yugoslavia and Greece, and so many even came from America that they were finally able to form their own

battalions. The opposing side also not without volunteers from foreign nations: French, English, Irish; but it was characteristic of the anti-fascist climate of the time that not a single American was among them. After the completion of the extensive preparatory work and transports, the “International Brigades” were set up in October; all accounts agreed that the troops, so diverse in nationalities and convictions, were filled with great enthusiasm, and that they did really understand the “Internationale,” which they sang in many languages, as the anthem of a new and better humanity. The upper ranks of the officers, of course, were almost exclusively occupied by communists, and the “Fifth Regiment” was considered the most useful instrument of the party, which, with its demand for “discipline, hierarchy, organization” differed from the anarchists and their undisciplined militias.

While France supported the “Loyalists” in many ways, it had officially closed its borders when England made a strong suggestion that it work towards a general policy of non-intervention. For England, it was certainly not only the view of the policy of small resistance that was decisive, which could now perhaps be brought to a new beginning after the end of Mussolini’s Ethiopian campaign, but also the thought of the enormous English investments in Spain, which would presumably be endangered if the Madrid government, i.e. the revolutionary forces, were victorious, undoubtedly played a role. In fact, almost all the countries of Europe subscribed to this policy, which one might well call a policy of limiting intervention, for no one doubted that German, Soviet, and Italian arms were entering Spain and would continue to do so.

Meanwhile the *national* troops had managed to establish a link between their northern and southern territories at Badajoz, and at the end of September they relieved the officers and cadets who had been defending themselves against overwhelming odds for two months in the Alcázar of Toledo. The fall of Madrid seemed imminent.

In the Soviet Union, very soon after the outbreak of the civil war, large solidarity and protest events and fundraising events were held, and many sharp speeches were made against the peace-threatening actions of fascism, but at first Stalin seems to have thought that the organization of the international brigades would suffice as immediate help. Nothing should have been more unpleasant for him in the given world political situation than the proof that he was in the process of setting in motion a Bolshevik revolution in Spain on the model of the Russian one. Even the well-founded suspicion would have destroyed all chances of a policy of great resistance and created the danger of an agreement between England and Germany, which he had just wanted to counter by announcing the popular front policy at the 7th Congress of the Comintern in July/August 1935. But he could not remain idle when Germany

sent arms to Spain.

Thus, as early as September, reports were received from foreign missions in Berlin that Russian troops with weapons on board had sailed from Odessa or had arrived in Spanish ports and that a lot of gold was being transported from Spain, which was apparently intended to pay for war material deliveries. Almost simultaneously in October, German and Italian and Soviet tanks appeared on the two sides. When the fighting around Madrid began in early November, a number of German and Soviet aircraft took part in the fighting. The Russian advisers did not take part directly in the fighting, but the Russian *Ratas* proved superior to the German He 51s unexpectedly, and the same was true of the tanks. The air supremacy of the *Nationals* soon came to an end, and when the XI. and the XII. International Brigade marched through the city to the cheers of the population and intervened in the fighting on November 10, the Moroccans advancing on the outskirts of the city were stopped and the city remained in the hands of the government, headed by Largo Caballero at the beginning of December.

But around the same time, German aid assumed a large-scale and systematic character for the first time, both as a result of Soviet support and, in turn, as a cause of its further reinforcement. As of mid-November there was a large air force unit in Spain called the "Condor Legion," consisting of about 5,000 men who were nominally volunteers, reinforced by some armored detachments and ground troops who were mostly engaged in giving combat training to Spaniards. Deliveries of a few Messerschmitt fighters largely restored the earlier superiority; but that military successes were only partial moments in a great struggle, the Legion and the German leadership had to learn when at the end of April 1937, in connection with Franco's offensive on the northern front, the city of Guernica was destroyed by German planes and a wave of indignation swept the western countries. The Italians had an even harder experience, having brought to Spain since December whole divisions totaling some 50,000 men. Although the "Blackshirts" conquered Malaga on February 8, not least because of the failure of the militias stationed there, they suffered a noticeable setback at the end of March when they encountered the international brigades near Guadalajara, which included the Italian "Garibaldi" battalion. The fact that they had to give up most of the land they had conquered was less important than the fact that their opponents' fighting morale proved to be stronger. None other than General Mario Roatta admitted that the International Brigades fought "skillfully and above all with fanaticism and hatred" while the Blackshirts apparently lacked motivation. The worst thing was that the Italian anti-fascists were able to reach the ears of the militiamen with their propaganda and that whole units of troops surrendered without necessity or even defected. On the other hand, the appeal to *proletarian solidarity* and the propaganda against the senselessness and injustice of this war made no

impression on the officers and soldiers of the Condor Legion—apart from the exceptional traps of a few prisoners. In so far as they did not see themselves as pure war technicians, for whom Spain was a maneuvering field, they more or less shared the belief that they were defending culture against malicious attack, and throughout they were imbued with a secure sense of belonging to a higher order, so that they often looked down with contempt on the Spaniards of both sides. Doubts were occasionally raised, and it is by no means unbelievable when a post-war witness claims that the National Socialists among the legionnaires in particular often wondered whether they weren't fighting on the wrong side. However, such questions did not result from genuine sympathy for the opponent, but from aversion to the *reactionary* and overly cautious generals and to the major role of the Catholic Church on the national Spanish side.

If the Russians had asked themselves without prejudice what conclusions should be drawn during this first combat operation against Germans since the end of the First World War, they would probably have stated that the troops of National Socialist Germany were even less affected by a propaganda storm along the lines of the victory over Kornilov than the German army of 1918, that perhaps victory had been the exception dependent on very specific circumstances, since while then all "Kornilovs" from Horthy to Franco had won or at least had good chances of winning, not to mention such unexpected figures as Mussolini and Hitler. For the Germans, on the other hand, much food for thought might have been given by the simple fact that the Spanish masses who created the *Bolshevik chaos* could not have been incited by Jewish agitators, as might have been the case in Russia, for a Jewish minority was almost non-existent in Spain. So it was not surprising that at the "Party Congress of Honour" in September 1936 there was a great deal of talk about Spain and that Rudolf Hess described it as the aim of the congress to "develop the great thesis and antithesis of the century, Bolshevism and National Socialism," but it must have been very disturbing for the wiser ones among the National Socialists that Alfred Rosenberg took up again the old talk about "Soviet Judea" and that Goebbels again called Bolshevism the "dictatorship of the inferior." If the impressions of 1917/18 were perpetuated in such an unchanged way, there was a very great danger of misjudging an opponent whose industry supplied such excellent weapons and whose followers in the International Brigades, to no small extent Jews, accomplished achievements that *inferiors* and *subhumans* could not even have dreamed of. For the traditional views of both sides, however, it should have been a shock that Joseph Goebbels in Nuremberg singled out a man as a particularly bad representative of Bolshevism, who disappeared without a trace a few months later after being violently attacked by the communist press: Andrés Nin, the main leader of the left-wing communist party *POUM*.

What the outside world perceived in Red Spain, insofar as it did not sympathize, was above all the *Bolshevik chaos* and *Bolshevik terror* : the poorly dressed masses armed with rifle in the streets, the *walks* where opponents were shot, the undisciplined mobs of the anarchists, the mummies of nuns torn from the graves and placed in the streets, the violent seizures of property, the forced collectivizations. But in the midst of this *chaos* there was a force that stood for *order* from the start, that spoke out against *socialization* and that held and killed in its own prisons not only big capitalists or officers but also *Bolsheviks* in particular: the Spanish Communist Party. Certainly it was not the only one who held the view that the war had to be won and therefore waged efficiently. Largo Caballero as prime minister also worked to ensure that the anarchist militias were placed under a unified leadership, he too advocated for the creation of a regular army with ranks and strict discipline, he also advocated the abolition of the soldiers' councils and, in general, the "rule of the committees." But the Communists not only set an excellent example of their own, but from the outset they championed theses which aroused great uneasiness among their socialist allies, and even more so among the anarchists: the Spanish people were not fighting for the establishment of the dictatorship of the proletariat, but for the defense of the republican order, which included respect for small and medium-sized property; compulsory collectivization in the manner of the anarchists was to be rejected; churches should be reopened and freedom of worship publicly guaranteed; not only must fascism be eradicated, but so must Trotskyists and the "uncontrollables" (i.e., radical anarchists). A letter signed by Stalin, Voroshilov and Molotov, which Ambassador Marcel Rosenberg handed to Prime Minister Caballero in December, was written along these lines: it was important to win over the lower and middle bourgeoisie, they must be protected from confiscation and freedom of trade must be ensured if possible. A good relationship with the left-bourgeois forces around President Azaña was of crucial importance; for the worst danger to the victory of the common cause was the creation of the impression that Spain was to be regarded as a communist republic.

The close connection between the internal policy of the Spanish Communist Party and Stalin's foreign policy is striking, and it cannot be denied that Lenin's party had opposed the anarchists and lack of discipline during the Russian Civil War with no less determination. Nevertheless, it is fair to say that the Communist Party in Spain defended the theses which the Mensheviks had championed in Russia: the theses that the conditions were not ripe for socialism, that it was necessary to cooperate with the bourgeoisie, that it was only possible to carry out a *bourgeois revolution* . It was therefore not surprising that the Communist Party in Spain became the protector of independent farmers and tradesmen and that the enormous increase in its membership was due not least to the influx from these circles. Nor is it surprising that Camillo Berneri, an emigrant from Italy and intellectual spokesman for the

Catalan anarchists, accused the Communist Party of being the “Foreign Legion of Spanish democracy and Spanish liberalism.” In this *Bolshevism*, then, there were at least two parties filled with deadly hatred for one another. The Communists were the aggressors, and the accusations they made especially against the *POUM*, the left-communist or right-anarchist party of Andrés Nin, were in themselves a death threat: the party was Trotskyist and infiltrated by people from the Falange, they took a negative stance on Russian aid and counteracted the war effort through their strong position in Catalonia. Then, in early May 1937, civil war in civil war did indeed break out in Barcelona: supporters of the *CNT* and the *POUM* violently resisted orders to evacuate the telephone exchange they controlled, and they returned the city to their absolute power for a few days, but eventually they succumbed quickly to the rapidly approaching and mostly Communist government troops. At least 500 dead were counted. Andrés Nin was arrested and, after being severely tortured, murdered like Berneri.

This shattered the power of Catalan anarchism, but it also shattered the power of revolutionary impetus and spontaneity. From then on, two regular armies fought each other in Spain, and after Caballero’s replacement, Juan Negrin was at the head of the government, a man who was considered a liberal and cultivated intellectual. But the Communists and the Soviet advisers had a much stronger influence on him than the German and Italian officers were able to win over General Franco. The latter thus evaded adequate payment for the huge deliveries he had received, while the *Red* Spaniards paid for the Soviet aid on with the gold reserves of the state bank to the last penny. Germans and Italians remained foreign auxiliaries and very few of their officers had experience dating back to 1918-1920. The Russian officers, on the other hand, and the leaders of the International Brigades were largely veterans of the Revolution and the Civil War, e.g. the Soviet Consul General in Barcelona Antonow-Owsejenko, the generals “Kleber” and “Lukacz,” the commanders Ludwig Renn and Hans Kahle. That they were still firmly rooted in their old faith cannot be doubted, and neither the struggle against the anarchists nor the support of the Spanish comrades for the bourgeois republic changed that. They certainly did not lose the conviction that they were on the right side, when facts such as that Franco and his German and Italian auxiliary troops had greater military successes to show, that Germany and Italy as “Axis Powers” were moving ever closer together in great politics, and that Mussolini, on his triumphant visit to Germany towards the end of September 1937, called Bolshevism “the modern form of the darkest Byzantine tyranny” and dared to prophesy that Europe of tomorrow would be Fascist. But the news from the Soviet Union must have worried them.

Ilja Ehrenburg visited the XII. International Brigade on the Aragon front, while also speaking

to a “short, stocky, and exceedingly scowling man,” apparently a high-ranking officer from the ranks of the Soviet advisers, who had a copy of *Pravda* in front of him. The man drank cold tea and suddenly he asked: “Do you know the latest? Tukhachevsky, Yakir and Uborevich have been sentenced to death by firing squad. They are enemies of the people.”

While not a few of his best soldiers and the flower of the Communist International were fighting in Spain, Stalin had launched the great “purge” in Moscow. Many of the Spanish fighters fell victim to it, among them Antonov-Owseyenko, who was famous in the Soviet Union as the conqueror of the Winter Palace. Hitler was either a collaborator or a dupe. Nevertheless, the great reconstruction pathos that had dominated the country from the beginning and especially since 1928 did not die out in the Soviet Union.

Chapter III, Section 5

The “Great Purge” and the Construction Pathos in the Soviet Union

The “great purge” began for the eyes of the world public on August 19, 1936, when a trial of a number of old Bolsheviks was opened in the October Hall of the Moscow Trade Union House, which had been prepared by a large press campaign and was attended by foreign reporters, and a selected Soviet audience had been admitted. In the dock sat former opposition figures, including Grigory Zinoviev and Lev Kamenev, who had once been Lenin’s closest collaborators and who, together with Stalin, had formed the country’s leadership troika in the 1924-1926 front against Trotsky. Now, however, they made the confession that as members of the *Trotskyist-Zinovievite center*, they had planned assassination attempts against the leading men of the Soviet Union and against Stalin in particular. In the case of Kirov, according to their statement, they had actually achieved their goal. Almost all of the defendants confessed. Zinoviev even admitted that he came to fascism via Trotskyism, and Kamenev called on the people to follow Stalin because the verdict on himself and his comrades was just. An Old Bolshevik named Mrachkovsky—no doubt a man of similar determination and bravery as the fighters in Spain—even demanded to be shot himself, since his example had shown that workers too could become counter-revolutionaries. In fact, the prosecutor Vyshinsky demanded “that these mad dogs all be shot,” and the court granted his request. It was barely 24 hours before word came that the accused had been executed.

Public opinion in the Soviet Union was satisfied. The newspapers had waged a hate campaign, and mass meetings all across the country had passed resolutions calling for death for these traitors. In the West, on the other hand, many doubts were voiced. Was it really credible that these tried and tested Old Bolsheviks had turned into terrorists and murderers in order to harm their own party and regime? What or who had prompted them to make such

self-accusations? Wasn't the prosecution obviously based on incorrect information on some points, such as the naming of foreign hotels where conspiratorial meetings with envoys of Trotsky were supposed to have taken place? Nevertheless, the prevailing opinion of Western observers was that the testimonies of the accused must have been credible, and prominent English jurists declared the trials completely unobjectionable. Thus, the waves of initial excitement quickly subsided, especially since hopes resulting from the new "Stalin Constitution" were at their peak: the Soviet Union now seemed to have finally entered the circle of democratic powers, and all Western friends of the policy of great resistance were convinced that the expansion of fascism could now be brought to an end by an anti-fascist alliance of all peace-loving powers.

But even the most determined of the *fellow travelers* would probably have been greatly concerned if they had known how many investigations, preparations, party purges and closed-door trials had already taken place in the year and a half since Kirov's assassination and the strange increase in patriotic propaganda, the dissolution of the "Society of Old Bolsheviks" in May 1935, and the further tightening of penal laws (such as extending the death penalty to children over the age of twelve) constituted a unified whole. And they would have been even more alarmed if they had known the telegram which Stalin and Zhdanov had sent from Sochi to some members of the Politburo in Moscow on September 25, 1936. It read: "We consider it absolutely necessary and urgent that Comrade Yezhov be appointed People's Commissar of Internal Affairs. Yagoda has finally proved himself incapable of exposing the Trotskyist-Zinovievite bloc. The GPU is four years behind in this matter. This is noticed by all party officials and most NKVD members." The telegram clearly alluded to the Ryutin affair. What Stalin had been unable to achieve in 1932 would now be realized, but instead of the one Ryutin, many tens of thousands, even hundreds of thousands of party members would be the victims, and even Yagoda, who in 1934 as GPU chief had become head of the Interior Commissariat, would not be spared. The "Yezhovshchina" [*russian, Great Purge/Great Terror*] began.

At first it went almost unnoticed that in the trials of Zinoviev and Kamenev one of the lesser defendants had admitted having contacts with the Gestapo, and that in some testimonies the names of previously unindicted party leaders and senior military figures had been mentioned. But on January 23, 1937, a new trial opened, the trial of the *Trotskyist parallel center*, and now some of these men stood before the barriers. The charge was no longer primarily terrorist acts, but sabotage and association with the German as well as the Japanese enemy. None other than Grigory Pyatakov, whom Lenin had honored by mentioning in his will and who, like no other, had been the organizer of industrialization, was now supposed to have

been willing, together with his co-defendants, to reverse industrialization, to grant territorial concessions to Germany, and to commit sabotage in the event of war. At a meeting with Trotsky in Oslo, Pyatakov had heard from him that a meeting had taken place with Rudolf Hess and that cooperation in war and peace had been agreed upon. The involvement of National Socialist Germany in the trial was further emphasized by the fact that among the accused was Karl Radek, the man who had been Lenin's emissary in the German revolution in 1919 and who, in his 1923 Schlageter speech, had called for an alliance between communists and German national-revolutionaries. Radek explicitly confirmed that Trotsky was seeking a "Bonapartist" regime for Russia and was prepared to cede Ukraine to Germany. Vyshinsky called the defendants "Judases," who had sunk lower than the worst supporters of Denikin or Kolchak, and all were sentenced to death and shot except Radek and Sokolnikov, who was one of the twelve men who had made the decision to revolt on October 23, 1917. Both received ten-year prison sentences, but by all accounts were soon killed in one of the labor camps.

This trial made a deeper impression on the Western public and also on a number of communists than the first one, not least because Trotsky organized a kind of counter-trial in New York, at which serious inaccuracies were proved. Now the question was often asked whether Stalin wanted to physically annihilate all the Old Bolsheviks and Lenin's comrades-in-arms, after he had long since disempowered them politically. Here and there the suspicion was voiced that the GPU must have forced these peculiar confessions by blackmail or promises, or by appeals to deep-rooted party loyalty. It also did not go unnoticed that Nikolay Yezhov had taken Yagoda's place at the end of September. But many Western observers still considered the confessions to be credible and the conduct of the negotiations to be correct, including the new American ambassador Joseph Davies, who, of course, as a Stalin-friendly capitalist, associated the hope for a far-reaching change in the regime with them.

The world first became aware that something monstrous was going on in the Soviet Union only when it was announced on June 11, 1937 that a number of the highest commanders of the Red Army had been arrested on suspicion of high treason, and the very next day it was announced that they had been tried and executed, among them Marshal of the Soviet Union Mikhail Tukhachevsky and Army Commanders Yakir and Uborevich. Although it was obvious that Stalin wanted to definitively end the arguments about the reintroduction of the institution of political commissars in this way, which to all appearances had preceded the corresponding decision made in May, the fact was nevertheless the focus of public attention that the eight commanders, among whom were several Jews, were labeled as traitors and

German agents. The details were never disclosed, there was no public trial, most of the senior officers who acted as judges were also shot shortly afterwards; but from the testimony of SS officers it is known that under the direction of Reinhard Heydrich and obviously with Hitler's approval, a dossier about Tukhachevsky was falsified, who had actually and quite officially had relations with the Reichswehr during the Weimar period, so that his signatures were available in the archives. This dossier was leaked to Stalin via Beneš, and it is possible that he believed it. The motive of Hitler and Heydrich was, of course, the desire to weaken the fighting power of the Red Army; but there are also indications that, conversely, it was Stalin who allowed the Germans to suggest the falsification, so that they got a false picture of their own possibilities and their effects. In any case, Stalin could not possibly have mistaken the huge number of officers for German and Japanese agents who were now being executed by the thousands in a veritable onslaught on the army by the secret police by the end of 1938. Out of 5 marshals only 2 survived, out of 14 army commanders also 2, out of 8 admirals 0 remained alive, out of 67 corps commanders 60 were shot, and out of 199 division commanders 136 were shot. No army in the world ever suffered such losses in the high ranks of the officer corps before the enemy like the Red Army in the peacetime years of 1937 and 1938. But Yakir died shouting, "Long live the party, long live Stalin," and he was far from being the only one to remain loyal even in death to the man and the party, which covered and his comrades with dirt and destroyed them. In any case, the secret reports of the German diplomats there is no evidence whatsoever that in the self-accusations of Radek and Pyatakov or in the accusations against the officers there was even a small kernel of truth. On the contrary, the German Ambassador in Moscow, Count von der Schulenburg, called it "completely absurd" that Germany should bring Trotsky-Bronstein and Radek-Sobelsohn to power in Moscow, after a war with the Soviet Union. The actual purpose of the second trial, the ambassador saw, was to warn all those "who do not want to understand Stalin's policy aimed at increasing Russia's military power and who walk around with Lenin's textbooks under their arms." At the same time, Germany and Japan were also to be denounced by accusing them of meddling in the internal affairs of the Soviet Union, and thus imputing to the opponents "what Moscow is itself doing." As far as the officers are concerned, von der Schulenburg did not rule out in a later report that they were "friendly to Germany," but he considered it more important "that Stalin feared independent leaders in the army as possible focal points of discontent or possible ambitions" and therefore sought to eliminate them in time.

But the persecutors were hardly hit less hard than the persecuted, who in turn had been the victors and persecutors in the civil war. The dismissal of Yagoda triggered a wave of self-accusations and mutual denunciations in the GPU, which Krivitsky has reported a very

vivid account of. In the end, with only a few exceptions, those investigators who, through the system of all-night interrogations or through torture, had obtained the confessions of Zinoviev and Kamenev, Radek and Piatakov, were eliminated and replaced by the worse Yezhov men.

These prepared the third and largest of the show trials, which began on March 2, 1938, against the *right-wing and Trotskyist bloc*. This time three former members of Lenin's Politburo were in the dock, namely Bukharin, Rykov and Krestinsky. Next to them sat several former People's Commissars, among them Yagoda, who was now accused of murdering Kirov and, incidentally, Gorky. Again there was talk of Trotsky's willingness to cede Ukraine to the Germans, and Bukharin confirmed it without identifying himself with it. But the main emphasis was now on criminal crimes such as poisoning, and if the picture that emerged was correct, then one had to indeed confirm the old thesis of the *most reactionary* among the emigres, that the Soviet leadership (with the exception of Stalin and his closest henchmen) had been nothing more than a gang of criminals even in their dealings among themselves. This time, Vyshinsky likened the defendants to "mangy dogs," before asking for the death penalty, which was imposed on all but three. Bukharin, meanwhile, had made only a partial confession, denying to the end the claim that the bloc had been organized on behalf of the fascist secret service. From this and from the overwhelmingly negative response in the West, Stalin drew the conclusion that there was no point in further show trials.

But the terror was far from over, and the Yezhovshchina continued to gain strength. It had long since ceased to be just about the destruction of *leadership cadres*. Even in the lower ranks of the party there was veritable hysteria over the whole country, with accusations against others and self-accusations, with, particularly, *origin*, as if an indestructible brand, playing an important role. Countless proven party members were *exposed* as the sons and daughters of kulaks or merchants, even though they had had no connection with their parents for many years; indeed, allegations such as that a niece had connections with a "Trotskyist element" were often enough to bring about a party expulsion with all its consequences. A friend of Krivitsky's was arrested and disappeared without a trace because he had received a letter from his ex-wife's husband and because his brother had left half of Radek's face be seen on the wall of a workers' clubhouse. In the Smolensk archive there were self-accusations such as the following: "After the Party Central Committee unmasked the gang of Trotskyist-Bukharinist spies in the western district led by Uborevich, Rumyantsev and Zhilman, the Obkom plenum unmasked some enemies of the people and removed them from leading positions, but they allowed them to continue to exist in an office composed of old workers, which was not a strong support in the fight against the enemies of the people. I myself am guilty of this kind of negligence."

In a certain sense, it was logical that a party which had always fought and destroyed its enemies first and foremost should now seek *enemies* within its own ranks. But the ordinary people, who had already suffered so much, were far from being unaffected. The eight million or so people who were deported to "labor reform camps" could not possibly all consist of party members, and a claim as innocuous and correct as that the Soviet shoes were of inferior quality could suffice as the reason for the deportation. These camps, which were subordinate to the main department "GULag" of the NKVD, had long since gained an economic importance that made them almost indispensable, especially in the vast and still undeveloped areas of northern Siberia such as Kolyma, but quite a few of these camps were outright extermination camps in which the average life expectancy was two years, so that after only one year half of the inmates had perished. In the revolutions of this death mill, it was almost no longer a strange occurrence when Yezhov telegraphed the following instruction to the head of the NKVD in a major city: "You are entrusted with the task of destroying 10,000 enemies of the people. Report completion by radio message." Mass graves containing more than 9000 bodies were discovered in Vinnitsa during the war. All of the victims had been shot in the neck; the date was determined to be summer of 1938. Estimates of the total number are around one million executed and at least two million perished in the camps. The entire population was affected, and there was hardly a large family from which at least one member was not deported or shot. The family members of prominent party leaders and officers were treated particularly harshly, although promises to spare wives and children played an important role in extracting confessions. Almost all of Tukhachevsky's relatives died that way. Using the term "wife of an enemy of the people" was enough for indictment. Children were often forced to publicly approve the execution of their parents.

The fate of foreign communists and refugees was also particularly harsh. No fewer than four members of the Politburo of the Communist Party of Germany disappeared, among them Heinz Neumann and Hermann Remmele, who had sung a true hymn of glory to the Soviet Union in a two-volume work in 1932. Hans Kippenberger was also drawn into the death vortex, just like Hugo Eberlein, the only German who had been a co-founder of the Third International. The purge claimed a strikingly large number of victims among Jews, Latvians, Poles and generally among members of national minorities. Zinoviev, Kamenev, Gamarnik, Yakir and numerous others were Jews; General J.K. Bersin, who for many years had headed the intelligence service of the Soviet Army and then served in a prominent position in the Spanish Civil War, was Latvian; almost all Poles working in the Comintern lost their lives, and the Polish party as a whole was dissolved because it had allegedly been infiltrated by fascist agents. The leaderships of the Union republics, which had retained a certain independence or even tried to preserve the traditions and identity of their people, were hardly

less affected. In the Ukraine, the proven communist Skrypnyk, who had distinguished himself in the fight against "bourgeois nationalism," was eliminated, and Nikita Khrushchev eliminated everyone even in the lower ranks who still dreamed of Ukrainian independence within the framework of the "Union of Councils."

By the summer of 1938 Lenin's party had been practically annihilated, with the sole exception of the staunchest Stalin supporters. Around this time, Yezhov's power was curtailed, and in December he was replaced as head of the NKVD by Stalin's compatriot Lavrenty Beria, who in turn now purged the purgers and sent almost all of Yezhov's men to their deaths. When the 18th Congress of the CPSU met in March 1939, of the 1,966 delegates to the 17th Congress of 1934, no fewer than 1,108 were dead or missing. But even of the rest only 59 were back in the hall. No communist party in the world had previously been subjected to such a massacre, not even the Communist Party of Germany under Hitler. No nation had ever inflicted such losses on their own leaders in peacetime. National Socialist Germany in 1937 and 1938, with its few concentration camps and no more than 30,000 political prisoners, almost looked like a normal Western European state in comparison.

And yet, this Soviet Union remained a land of construction and construction pathos in the midst of all the events that had to put everyone, with the sole exception of Stalin, in constant fear for their position and their lives. The second five-year plan, no longer quite as ambitious as the first, was successfully completed. Countless Komsomol members continued to volunteer for duty and enthusiastically went to desolate areas to build new and massive industrial combines under the most difficult conditions; it was no mere propaganda when the newspapers enthusiastically eulogized the great achievements of Soviet aviators and polar explorers; it was hardly a question of mere manipulation when mass meetings of several hundred thousand people passionately demanded the "death of the traitors." The relatively large number of tourists who flocked to Moscow in the summer of 1937 gave the impression of a vibrant and lively city, and Sidney and Beatrice Webb, without much finding much opposition, continued to praise the Soviet Union in the numerous new editions of their book as the beginning of a "new civilization," as a country without crises and without "unearned income" of parasitic existences.

It is therefore probably incorrect to see the cause of the great *Tschistka* [russian, *Stalin's Purges*] merely in Stalin's unrestrained striving for power. In any case, it was the third great revolution with millions of victims that took place in Russia or the Soviet Union, and in this respect one could call it consistent. In the civil war, which it itself provoked by its seizure of power, the Bolshevik party had destroyed those whom it understood to be "class enemies"

and thereby made them into irreconcilable enemies, and these were indeed entire classes: the nobility, the intelligentsia, the bourgeoisie and, moreover, the party enemies of the Socialist-Revolutionaries and Mensheviks. In the period of collectivization, the individually managed and relatively prosperous peasantry was the target of the attack, and it was not unreasonable to assume that this was intended to eliminate Stolypin's by no means hopeless or rootless attempt to inaugurate a Western individualistic line of agricultural development and thus at the same time of industrialization in opposition to the collectivist tradition of the "Mir." [*peasant village communities as opposed to individual farmsteads, or khutors, in Imperial Russia.*] But this western-individualistic tendency also existed in the party. The author of the "Letter of an Old Bolshevik" probably assessed himself and those like him correctly when he wrote: "Unwittingly, we think in a direction that is critical of the existing order; we look everywhere for the weak points. In short, we are all critics, destroyers, not builders... It is impossible to build anything with such human materials, with critics and skeptics."

While Marxism was not individualistic in its content, but it had nevertheless emerged entirely from the Western tradition of *criticism*, and it had very quickly become apparent that Marxist concepts could also and especially be applied with a critical intention to Soviet reality, such as the concepts *class*, *exploitation* and *autonomy of state power*. Stalin had been the embodiment of the party since the mid-1920s; if the party was to be brought to real identity with this embodiment of itself, then the critical and competitive element, as represented in Trotsky and Zinoviev and numerous smaller figures, had to be eliminated. Ultimately, Trotsky's prediction of 1904 that the Leninist party organization would lead to the party members first being incapacitated in favor of the Central Committee and then to the substitution of one dictator taking the place of the Central Committee was realized. The fact that the main representatives of the critical, western or intellectual tendency were predominantly Jews facilitated the elimination, although the Soviet Union was the only country in the world in which anti-Semitism was subject to the death penalty: the xenophobic character of the Great Purge cannot be overlooked. The critical tendency in the party corresponded to the anarchist or at least autonomist tendencies of the population and the various nationalities: the terror that reigned over the heads of each individual at the same time gave an inkling of the power of the closed collective and to that extent its own power, so that it was not merely frightening, but at the same time, fascinating. The corps of commander, in turn, was recruited to a large extent from the civil war veterans, and not a few of these men, with their independent merits, really wanted to see themselves as "comrades" of Stalin and not as the unconditionally obedient children of the "father of the nations" and "greatest man of all time." Eventually, the extensive annihilation of the party and officer

corps created a myriad of vacant positions, as the first and second revolutions had done, and Stalin could count on the unconditional loyalty of these new party leaders and officers. If the monstrous event of the *Tschistka* can be understood at all and does not have to be regarded as the outbreak of collective madness, then it can best be understood, with a Hitlerian phrase, as the creation of an "iron-hard national body" which, in absolute unity is at the service of the will of its own personification, the *Vozhd* [russian equivalent of *Führer*] , so that it is able to endure even the most extreme without falling prey to division or even disintegration.

But what was the purpose of this unity with which (one might say) the national spirit was preparing for an extraordinary test?

The answer seems easy. In all events from 1936 to 1938 the constant reference to Germany and the fascists as well as to the Japanese is palpable. No impression had to force itself more strongly on the ordinary citizen than that the German fascists were ready to attack and that they had numerous helpers in the party and in the army. The Great Purge can therefore be seen as an inevitable measure of preparation for the defensive war of life and death. The measures that foreign observers often judged to be restorative or un-Marxist fit easily into this picture: the strengthening of the family, the positive emphasis on national traditions, not least that of Alexander Nevsky, the victor over the Germans, the elimination of those emphatically Marxist historians who had only ever criticized Russian history.

But besides this prevailing opinion, a second interpretation has existed for a long time, which was apparently first put forward by Walter Krivitsky and has representatives even today. According to this interpretation, Stalin was heading towards an agreement with Hitler from an early stage, whom he both feared and admired. It is obvious that if he seriously aspired to such a turn, he would have to smash the old party and send the heroes of the Civil War to their deaths. A third interpretation sees in Stalin the unshakable world revolutionary who had to eliminate the rhetorical world revolutionaries if he wanted to consolidate the only citadel of the struggle against capitalism and fascism. As a fourth possibility, it is abruptly opposed by the very negative and often Marxist judgment that in this purge Stalin has become an oriental despot or else a kind of National Socialist.

All of these judgmental tendencies were already present in 1938, if only in the form of implications and untheoretical statements. For example, Antonov-Ovseyenko contemptuously hurled the following sentence at the NKVD examining magistrate, who had called him an enemy of the people: " *You* are an enemy of the people. You are a downright fascist." But the examining magistrate was a mere tool. If the accusation made any sense,

then it was directed at Stalin.

If he was correct, it was one of the greatest victories Hitler won in the triumphant year of 1938. If he was wrong, then for Stalin, as the personification of the Bolshevik and world-revolutionary Soviet Union, the most dangerous of all tests began that year.

Chapter III, Section 6

Hitler's Triumphs and the Consensus of the National-Community (Volksgemeinschaft)

While Stalin, according to respected observers, was weakening his army and disorganizing his party, Hitler in 1938 achieved successes that no statesman before him had been able to achieve in peacetime: he united 10 million people with the German Reich, invoking the right to self-determination, by wiping out one state of Central Europe and crippling another. In this way he made Germany by far the most powerful state in Europe, and at the same time eliminated the Soviet Union from the concert of powers to such an extent that the great concord he had always striven for seemed to be established. But the *peaceful means* had nevertheless consisted of threats of war and methods which, by all human judgment, could only be used *once*, and the hitherto greatest triumph of self-determination was self-contradictory. Thus the great year 1938 ended for Hitler in October-November, and the driver quickly became the driven man by his own actions, making Stalin the arbiter of the fate of Europe.

On November 5, 1937, Hitler summoned his closest associates to a meeting in the Reich Chancellery, namely Foreign Minister von Neurath, War Minister von Blomberg, and the Commanders-in-Chief of the Army, Navy and Luftwaffe Fritsch, Raeder and Göring. The Wehrmacht adjutant, Colonel Hossbach, was also present, who soon afterwards produced a transcript, a copy of which ended up in the hands of the Allies after the war, the so-called Hossbach Protocol. Apparently Hitler's intention was to announce to this smallest leadership the imminent transition to an active foreign policy. The objective situation was favorable: although rearmament was far from complete, Germany had spent more resources on it in the last two years than the Western powers, including the USA, combined; Axis friendship seemed firmly established after Mussolini's visit; the victory of the Popular Front in France had to all appearances been accompanied by the victory of laziness, as anyone who had seen

the German and French construction sites at the 1937 World Fair could attest; in England, in May 1937, Neville Chamberlain had taken office as Baldwin's successor, and that meant a considerable advance of "appeasement" mood; the Soviet Union was in the throes of the Great Purge, and Göring, in an interview with the American Ambassador in Paris, William C. Bullitt, was able to argue that the Red Army was no longer a serious force and that, of the 5,000 tractors that were manufactured annually in the Soviet Union, not a single one was fit for use two years later. But Hitler did not say a word about the fact that this happy constellation finally offered the Germans the opportunity to assert their right to self-determination. Nor did he discuss the possibility of settling accounts with Bolshevism as the general enemy of the world. Rather, he spoke exclusively of a "solution to the German question," and by this he understood nothing other than the elimination of the "lack of space," i.e., the acquisition of a larger living space: according to him, a striving that at all times had been the cause of the formation of states and movements of peoples. The present is an age of economic empires, in which the impulse for colonization is again approaching its original state, as the example of Italy and Japan shows, while the "saturated states" are understandably only interested in maintaining their possessions. "Economic motives" were the decisive factor here as well as there; Germany could only in Europe seek the space it needs to secure its food situation. The use of force was unavoidable, Germany was "forced to go on the offensive" and it was therefore his unalterable decision to solve the German spatial question by 1943/1945 at the latest. Earlier action would depend on the circumstances; if necessary, the first objective must be "to crush the Czechs and, at the same time, Austria." The annexation of these two states could mean the "gain of food for 5-6 million people," provided "a forced emigration from the Czech Republic of two million people and from Austria of one million people is carried out." As a thought experiment, Hitler developed the scenario of a war between Italy and France and England, which would offer a favorable opportunity for the realization of these plans.

It was entirely the Hitler of the "political testament" from "Mein Kampf" who spoke here, and at the beginning he actually described his remarks as a "testamentary legacy" in the event of his death. Hitler revealed himself again for who he was: a man completely fixed on 1917/18 and here on the Allied blockade, but who at the same time, probably unconsciously of himself, embodied in a paradigmatic way the position that arises when one detaches the Marxist doctrine of class struggle from the moments of internationalism and humanism, as, by the way, Marx and Engels themselves had occasionally done to some extent. But the biologicistic Marxist or the Social Darwinist was not the whole Hitler. Even here, underneath the conquest-addicted confidence of the protagonist of the "better race," the concern, even fear, with which he pursues a process that does not really fit into the biologicistic worldview, is

noticeable, namely “the economic destruction emanating from Bolshevism” which he parallels with the “dissolving effect emanating from Christianity” that had caused the Roman Empire to succumb to the onslaught of the Germans, the Empire whose greatness and permanence Hitler unmistakably orientated himself with. Obviously, he only had to take a small step to get to the alleged author of this resolution, but the word “Jew” does not appear. A possible “military intervention by Russia” is mentioned, but quickly dismissed with reference to Japan.

The question is why Hitler presented himself to his closest associates in such provocative one-sidedness. The most likely answer is that he wanted to subject these collaborators to some sort of scrutiny. In fact, Neurath and Fritsch objected with some vigor, pointing to French superiority, and Neurath soon fell victim to heart attacks. Hitler thus had to realize that he could not pursue an *active foreign policy* with Neurath, Fritsch and even Blomberg. True, he was the autocrat, but within a system whose elements showed considerable traces of the old autonomy. Therefore, he was far from powerful enough to simply remove these three men from their offices. But he knew quickly and unscrupulously how to seize an opportunity that presented itself a little later, and here too it became clear that the old determination, though checked or modified in its effects by the particular circumstances, but was by no means essentially altered.

The Wehrmacht was still very far from being a *brown army*. Rather, its main components embodied three different periods of German history: the army was Christian-Prussian-conservative, the Navy was bourgeois-German-nationalist, and the Luftwaffe could be called National Socialist. The rivalries between the “Wehrmacht Office” in the War Ministry under General Keitel and the Army General Staff under its chief Ludwig Beck had an ideological undertone. This was even more pronounced for the tensions between the Army and the SS, which gradually built up armed troop units as “state security police.” The National Socialist spirit penetrated from below through the young officers and, as a result of general conscription, into the army as well. The generals of the army, still by far the most important part of the Wehrmacht, were almost certainly not National Socialists, but even Ludwig Beck was hardly a political opponent of Hitler before 1938. All of them were completely occupied with rearmament, which was, after all, their old heart’s desire. But not a single one was inclined to *adventurism*, all were guided by an objectivist picture of *preparation* and had little understanding of psychological and political factors. In this respect Hitler was far superior to them. But the correct feeling that Hitler’s methods could become dangerous for the existence of the German people formed the starting point for a seemingly pragmatic and yet principled resistance.

Blomberg's old-age folly of marrying a woman "with a past life" was a desirable compulsion for Hitler to part with the Reich Minister of War, but a shameful intrigue by Göring and the Gestapo created the opportunity to dismiss the Commander-in-Chief of the Army at the same time and thus to a certain extent to decapitate the Wehrmacht leadership. When the accusations against Fritsch turned out to be baseless, it was too late (except for a formal rehabilitation): the major organizational and personnel changes of February 4, 1938 had already taken place. Hitler personally took over the direct supreme command of the Wehrmacht, and the Wehrmacht office of the former Ministry of War was now directly subordinate to him as "High Command of the Wehrmacht," Colonel General von Brauchitsch is Commander-in-Chief of the Army, the National Socialist Joachim von Ribbentrop has replaced Neurath at the head of the Foreign Ministry. Göring did not achieve his goal of becoming Minister of War, but is now Field Marshal. The Wehrmacht has suffered a new heavy blow to its independence and traditional sense of honor. If it was a purge, it was not remotely comparable in scale and character to the purge of the Red Army: instead of the tens of thousands of shootings, there were only a few retirements, and even in this the difference in social systems came to light. But seven people were able to see the actual result of these changes: the three men who had objected or had expressed uncertainty on November 5, 1937 were eliminated, and the way to an *active foreign policy* was clear, i.e., to a policy of direct warfare or a concrete threat of war, a policy which had corresponded to the origins of National Socialism in the *positive experience of war* and which was also pursued by Soviet Russia for other motives and for other purposes in the immediate post-war period, but had long since been abandoned.

And at the same time, Hitler used foreign policy, which was after all the the end, as a means. This connection is evident from a diary entry by Colonel Jodl on January 31, 1938: "Führer wants to divert spotlight from the Wehrmacht, keep Europe in suspense and, by reassigning various posts, not give the impression of a moment of weakness, but of a concentration of strength. Schuschnigg should not take heart, but tremble..."

That the Austrian question would be ready for a solution in the spring of 1938 had been predicted by many observers. In fact, it was one of the most difficult problems in German history, and its mere existence was a symptom of the unique position of the German people in Europe, for neither the English, nor the French, nor the Italians lived in two states. But no foreign power had forced this situation, but rather the Prussia of the founder of the Empire, Bismarck, as the "successful separate state" that it was, excluded Austria from the German Confederation (or Empire) of which it had been a part for many centuries, and thus completed the "division of Germany." In 1918/19 the time seemed to have come when

German Austria, as the remnant of the destroyed Habsburg monarchy, would unite with the Bismarck Empire, due to the will of the overwhelming majority of the population, freed of its minorities and confirmed in its existence, to form the genuine nation-state of all Germans, but this unification would have meant that Germany, despite the defeat, would have emerged from the World War as by far the largest state in non-Russian Europe, and the Allies, who, according to their proclamations, had fought for democracy and self-determination, placed considerations of power politics higher than principles and, by means of the “annexation ban” (Anschlußverbot) denied the Germans the self-determination they secured for the West Slavic nations of the Poles and Czechs. Although it soon became clear that Austria’s independence was not merely artificial, the Allies had created an irredenta in the German-speaking world and thus created a situation strikingly similar to that which the Soviet Union claimed to have vis-à-vis the workers’ movement throughout the world. National Socialist Germany could support a popular movement in the neighboring state that was obviously revolutionary because it denied the existence of that state; but the charge could also be leveled that the large state was merely using the popular movement, which was unable to gain a majority, as an instrument for overarching objectives. And what the class movement in its cooperation with the Soviet state had failed to achieve up to 1938, or had only achieved in marginal areas, was put into practice by the national movement in a spectacular manner with great attention from the whole world, and there could be no talk of a mere “defeat” of Austria. Even after the agreement of July 1936, the radical National Socialists remained an extremely active opposition, the fascist and pro-Italian Heimwehr lost more and more power in the Schuschniggian state of a militant but also emphatically *German* Catholicism, and foreign political support in Italy became weaker and weaker. The situation was almost hopeless when, on February 12, 1938, Hitler received Schuschnigg for a conversation in Berchtesgaden that bore little resemblance to a conversation between statesmen. Hitler treated the Austrian Chancellor as the leader of a well-established ruling party might treat a recalcitrant opposition figure; he boasted that he had created a people in Germany in which there were “no more parties, classes, divisions” and in which everyone wanted the same thing. Schuschnigg, on the other hand, was a persecutor and oppressor in his small state, who would not be able to hold out for a moment if he, Hitler, perhaps “the greatest German in history,” might overnight be “like the spring storm” in Vienna. After Schuschnigg made major concessions and a last attempt at resistance by means of a planned referendum, this spring storm did indeed break out on March 12, but initially it had the character of a threat and manipulation on the part of Göring, even towards the moderate National Socialists such as the later Reich Governor Seyss-Inquart. But below what was happening at the upper level, the radical National Socialists, as in Germany in February and March 1933, resorted to mass demonstrations and violent actions that no longer met with no

determined resistance. The threat from above and the violence from below, however, quickly became insubstantial when, in an unexpected outburst of almost universal enthusiasm, the advancing German troops were showered with flowers, and when Hitler himself was hailed as a savior by jubilant crowds. History seemed to concentrate all its paradoxes when the biologicistic materialist of the Hossbach discussion led the democratic right of self-determination to the most bloodless of his successes and at the same time destroyed the remnants of Marxism in Austria as well. Mussolini agreed, the Western powers barely stirred, and the Soviet Union lamented the actions of the “aggressive states,” after proclaiming itself the status quo’s greatest enemy for so many years.

If the suspicion was expressed in many places that it was now Czechoslovakia’s “turn,” there were all too good reasons for this. As early as June 1937, Blomberg had signed the “Directive for Uniform War Preparations by the Wehrmacht,” which distinguished between a “Red” case (west) and a “Green” case (southeast); the latter was primarily related to the Czechoslovak Republic and explicitly declared to be an “invasion.” Although the overall planning was defensive, this character was already invalidated by the introductory sentence that Germany could probably not expect an attack. On December 21, 1937, an addition was made, in which there was talk of a “war of aggression” against Czechoslovakia, which would have to be waged even if one or the other great power intervened in the fight against Germany, in order to solve the German space problem. The war objective was “the rapid seizure of Bohemia and Moravia while at the same time solving the Austrian question in the sense of including Austria in the German Reich.” This planning was not changed in essence despite the March events, although Hitler expressed the view that Austria had to be digested first and that he had no intention of smashing Czechoslovakia by military action in the near future without a challenge. The exploitation of a particularly favorable opportunity was always reserved, and an “incident” such as “the assassination of the German ambassador following an anti-German action” was contemplated in a strange way.

But with the simple realization of such military plans, Hitler would have immediately triggered the world war on the basis of the *great resistance*. His chance lay in the fact that here, too, he was not just a military aggressor.

The question of the Sudeten Germans was of a similar nature to that of the German-Austrians, but all the facts were aggravated and pointed. The 3.5 million Germans living in the mountainous outskirts of Bohemia had been the leading group during the period of the Habsburg monarchy, also were also very strong in Prague itself; after the collapse of 1918 they had spoken out in favor of an annexation to German Austria, although in some cases they

had no geographical connection with it. If it had gone according to the will of the population, Austrians and Sudeten Germans would have become citizens of the German Reich at that time. But in the case of the Sudeten Germans, this solution was opposed not only by the will of the Allies, but also by the long history and vigorous reality of the land of Bohemia, which for centuries had been considered a common homeland by its inhabitants. On the other hand, “ethnic struggles” (Volkstumskämpfe) had an old tradition here in particular, and new types of parties calling themselves “National Socialist” had emerged earlier than elsewhere, both on the Czech and German sides.

At least potentially, the disputes were extraordinarily intensified when, immediately after the end of the World War, the Czechs, under the leadership of Masaryk and Benes, managed through clever manipulations to draw into their state the Slovaks, who were related to their ancestors but who were quite different from a social and cultural point of view, from the Hungarian hereditary mass, and make this a pillar of the “Versailles System” directed against Germany. Nevertheless, the hardships and difficulties of the Germans in the Czechoslovak Republic in Weimar Germany and even during the early days of the Third Reich did not receive nearly as much attention as the hardships and difficulties of the Germans in Poland, especially since they were attributed with considerable reasons to the economically unfavorable situation of most industrialized areas of the country. But here, as always and everywhere, business and politics intertwined, and it was also not unjustified to point out the systematic disadvantages that the residents of the Sudeten districts suffered from the Prague government, even though the *activist* German parties had been involved in parliament since 1926.

The demand for full self-determination was thus neither incomprehensible nor illegitimate from the outset, but it encountered far greater difficulties than in the case of Austria: the Germans were only a minority, annexation to Germany would have to destroy the “Bohemian State Law” and with it a centuries-old community, and would seriously impair the Czechs’ right to self-determination in the sense of their claim to an independent state, because how were the 7 million Czechs to retain genuine independence in the *German sea* of 75 million that surrounded them on three sides? All the problems of the right to self-determination, which seemed so obvious, were brought together as if in a burning mirror, and the the most essential question was the following: can the self-determination of the West Slavic peoples, which was secured by the Versailles Treaty, be reconciled with the self-determination of the Germans? Or must one override the other and, if the Germans took precedence, re-establish the old condition of dependence and immaturity of the Poles and Czechs, after they had only just freed themselves from the German (and Russian) rule?

The Sudeten German Social Democrats probably made the answer to the question too easy for themselves when they declared a good relationship with the “emerging Slavic world” to be a central imperative, because they overlooked, in how inconsistent and downright hubristic a manner the self-determination of the Poles and the Czechs had been placed on the basis of a temporary state of weakness on the part of the Germans and Russians, but the opposite view could lead to the even worse consequence that the small peoples’ right to self-determination was denied in principle. A higher concept, however, in which the contradictions of the right to self-determination could have been resolved, as Lenin possessed or believed he possessed in the concept of socialism, existed in Central Europe only as a powerless postulate, and at the latest during the great purge serious doubts were bound to arise as to whether the *higher concept* in the Soviet Union did not merely cloak the old reality of Russian domination. Hitler possessed only one *counter* -concept, namely that of the rule of the larger and stronger nation or race; therefore the concept of self-determination was just as little a supreme maxim for him as it was for Lenin, and he knew how to use it just as successfully.

The fact that Hitler could even think of using the right to self-determination to serve his actual goals was due, apart from the inner strength of the concept, precisely on the fact that that *higher* concept of socialism had prevented the disintegration of the Russian Empire and had created a worldwide claim that was felt in many countries of Europe to be the worst of all threats, and was by no means limited to the narrow circles of the *bourgeoisie*. It is true that there were manifold motives for the Chamberlain government’s “appeasement policy,” which was the policy of the main part of the Conservatives and was supported by the *Times* and not least by the so-called “Cliveden set” of the Astor family: an effort to gain time, striving for the integrity of the British Empire, a love of peace and a sense of the injustices of the Versailles Treaty. But when Lord Edward Halifax, at that time still Lord Privy Seal and shortly afterwards Foreign Secretary, paid a visit to Hitler on November 19, 1937 at Obersalzberg, he must have inwardly agreed with Hitler’s statement: the only catastrophe was Bolshevism, everything else could be sorted out. Right at the beginning of the conversation he had already described Germany as a “bulwark of the West against Bolshevism.” Thus anti-Bolshevism was undoubtedly the central point of agreement between the two politicians, but the serious differences stood out even where the practical question of the next steps seemed to be discussed. While Halifax seemed to concede to his interlocutor “changes in the European order” and specifically included “Danzig, Austria and Czechoslovakia” among the issues in question, he not only tied the solution to the “path of peaceful evolution,” but at the same time encouraged a return of Germany in the League of Nations and on the idea of disarmament.

Halifax, then, was far removed in this conversation from the plans that the Soviet Union in many statements accused the Chamberlain government of and which had to be imputed if the assumption of the essential sameness of Germany and England in *capitalism* and therefore in their hostility to *socialism* was correct: that the British government wanted to encourage *German fascism* to engage in aggression against the Soviet Union. Thus Stalin said to the American Ambassador Davies that the ultimate aim behind the policy of the reactionary elements in England represented by the Chamberlain government was to make Germany strong against Russia. This policy, however was likely to fail, he added, because “the fascist dictators would push the bargain too far.” Almost the same day, the French ambassador in Washington reported that President Roosevelt, in a conversation with him, had given free vent to “his dislike of the totalitarian states and their policy of brutal rapacity” and finally added “in the tone of deepest conviction”: “Should France go down, we would obviously go down with her.” The ambassador derived from this the confidence that America would stand firmly with France and England when they came into conflict “with the fascist powers” in defense of democracy and liberty. Hitler’s policy thus undoubtedly brought about the possibility that all the opponents of the World War, including America, would unite against Germany under the new standard of overarching *anti-fascism*. On the other hand, while Roosevelt evidently understood the term *totalitarian* to mean *fascist*, his sympathy was just as evidently primarily with England and France, and there is little reason to suspect that he held Stalin’s Soviet Union for a *liberal democracy*. The anti-fascist was opposed to the anti-communist and potentially anti-totalitarian conception of world politics, and if the communist ideology was right, the anti-communist conception was bound to prove stronger, since the unity of capitalism was more powerful than internal differences. But if the Soviet Union, England and the USA were primarily *anti-fascist*, then Lenin’s thesis was wrong and the world was in a different epoch than that of the proletarian world revolution.

In any case, Stalin had to apply the prescription that Lenin had given his delegation to the Genoa conference in 1922: try to separate the pacifist part of the bourgeoisie from its activist part. Litvinov did his best to keep the Soviet Union in the game and reinforce the notion of collective resistance *to the aggressive powers*, but just how widespread the anti-Communist conception was among French leaders, a statement by French Ambassador to Moscow, Robert Coulondre reveals: who, after a report by Count von der Schulenburg, said in August 1938: “I hope with all my heart that there will be no Franco-German conflict. You know as well as I do for whom we are working if we come to blows.”

But the Soviet Union held a key position. It was linked to both France and Czechoslovak Republic by pacts of mutual assistance, and the policy of great resistance, which seemed

imperative according to all premises, depended entirely on it. On the other hand, the distrust that it faced even on the part of the Czechoslovak Republic was reflected in the clause desired by the Czechs, according to which the USSR's obligation to provide aid would only come into effect after France had first fulfilled its own. Moreover, the Czechoslovak Republic and the USSR had no common border. Russian troops would have to march through Poland or Romania if they wanted to intervene, and it was certain that neither country would permit a passage. Although some French officers did not shy away from the idea that Poland and Romania would then have to be *forced* to make concessions, Stalin could be confident that, despite all assurances of compliance to the treaty, he would retain his freedom of action once the Western powers and Germany were involved in a war. This, according to Schulenburg, was the opinion of the entire diplomatic corps in Moscow, and this opinion corresponded exactly to Stalin's opinion, which was unknown at the time because he had expressed it in a secret speech in 1925: the Soviet Union would not be able to escape a war, but she will be the last to act.

With this widespread assumption or suspicion, however, the most obvious reaction of any political power, namely to resist the disproportionate gain in power of a rival power, came into serious tension with the overarching anti-Bolshevism, on which all non-Russian states of Europe agreed, albeit to very different degrees. On the other hand, the Sudeten Germans' demands for self-determination, which were becoming more and more radical, were only tentative and seemingly identical to Hitler's idea of solving the *space problem*. Overall, the motives and tactics from the spring to the fall of 1938 merged into a whole that was difficult to understand. Simplifying and with a grain of salt, one could say: the objective interaction of the Sudeten German demand for self-determination with Chamberlain's will to *pacify* or *appease* against the background of fear of Stalin's ultimate intentions made Hitler's greatest triumph possible, which seemed to be the completion of the Greater German right of self-determination and yet was only the basis for an *ultimate intention*, which was opposed to that of Stalin and yet akin to it. The real determining factor was therefore the existence of the two new and hostile ideological states, through which all the enduring problems and tensions of the European power system took on a character that would have been unimaginable before 1914, because at that time two supranational parties, the *philo-fascists* and the *anti-fascists*, did not divide Europe and involve it in a potential civil war.

The most important events can now be summarized quickly: On February 20, 1938, Hitler's speech on the "ten million oppressed Germans," which also contained extremely violent attacks on Communism and the Soviet Union, officially opened the Sudeten question before the Austrian question had been resolved. In March he instructed the leader of the Sudeten

German Home Front, Konrad Henlein, to always demand so much that no fulfillment was possible. The partial Czech mobilization of May 20, which was based on misleading reports in English newspapers, genuinely angered Hitler because it seemed to mean a loss of prestige for him. However, it did not prevent Henlein's party from winning about 90% of the German votes in the local elections that were roughly simultaneous. The German press reports about "Bolshevik Czechoslovakia" as the Soviet Union's aircraft mothership in Central Europe since then took the character of an unbridled campaign, which, however, received some support in the press of the French Right and in the British Rothermere newspapers; even the protests of the Sudeten German party against the "Bolshevik-Hussite elements" which the Prague government no longer had under control, increasingly lost the character of experience and became propaganda barrage. The appointment of Lord Runciman as mediator and various articles in the *Times* prepared President Benes and the Czechoslovak government for a very far-reaching concession in September, which practically fulfilled the autonomy demands of the so-called "Carlsbad Program." On the other hand, Hitler's will to go to war evoked genuine resistance among German generals and diplomats for the first time, which was entirely determined by patriotic motives, i.e. by the fear of a "finis Germaniae" and that brought a military coup d'état against Hitler within reach. Hitler's and Göring's speeches at the Nuremberg Party Congress could only base their unbridled and at the same time haughty emotionality on the sensational reports of *persecution* in German newspapers, invented or trimmed by an official of the Ministry of Propaganda. In truth, the "Sudeten German Freikorps" was already the aggressor, and what had taken place in Georgia in 1921, the support of local rebellion movements by a foreign power, was now a tangible reality in the middle of Europe under completely different circumstances. But Chamberlain's flight to Berchtesgaden on September 15 rendered the plans of the German opposition unreal, and on September 21 the Prague government, under the heaviest pressure, had to accept the proposal to ceding the Sudeten German territories. But when the British Prime Minister met Hitler for the second time in Godesberg on September 23, the latter, again citing alleged atrocities by the Czechs, demanded the immediate occupation of the areas by German troops and a solution to the question of the remaining minorities in Czechoslovakia. The negotiations threatened to fail, and on September 26 Hitler gave a speech in the Berlin Sportpalast that, with its attacks on Benes and the Czechs, was an incomparable piece of uninhibited demagoguery. But when he was surrounded by frenetic cheering from the masses, he had to realize the next day that the demonstrative passage of an panzer division through the streets of Berlin did not arouse any enthusiasm for the war among the population, only horror and fear. An appeal by Roosevelt went unheeded, but Hitler accepted Mussolini's proposal for mediation, and on September 29 he met with Chamberlain, Daladier and Mussolini for the Munich Conference, at which all of his demands were met with minor modifications. A

representative of the Soviet Union was not invited. Hitler and Chamberlain signed a declaration on September 30 in which they expressed in an optimistic tone the desire of both peoples “never again to wage war against one another,” and after his arrival in London Chamberlain spoke of the “honorable peace” which he had brought back from Germany and which gave him hope that peace would reign “all our lives.” Benes left Prague a few days later and went into exile. The advancing German troops were greeted by the population with even more unanimous jubilation than had been the case in Austria. Even Hitler’s fiercest opponents could now hardly doubt that, despite having overcome the fear of war, the overwhelming majority of the German nation stood as a “national-community” (Volksgemeinschaft) behind the man who at that moment could be regarded as the personification of the people’s spirit, that people’s spirit whose will to right the “wrongs of Versailles” Lenin and Lansing, Rosa Luxemburg and *Humanité* had predicted in one way or another twenty years earlier.

From the point of view of world politics, the Munich conference appears in retrospect to be the last opportunity at which the European powers solved a European problem on their own, to the exclusion of both the Soviet Union and the USA. In this concert of the four powers, Hitler undoubtedly had the lead voice. England and France had had to yield, but one cannot say that they were raped, since in the end they had only said yes to the consequence of a principle of their own. Neither Chamberlain nor Daladier warned *pro-German*, but Hitler could not expect in England and France governments that would have been better for him because men like Oswald Mosley and Marcel Déat were separated from power by impassable barriers. His own interest, one would think, should have led Hitler to align his policy on the lines of the Anglo-German and somewhat later Franco-German declaration and endeavored to ensure that the ingredients of brutal threats, lies, hubris and recklessness, which had appeared in the speeches of some of his followers in an even more frightening way than in his own speeches, should be consigned to oblivion as quickly and thoroughly as possible. It is true that there is not the slightest indication that one of the responsible statesmen of England and France ever gave him the slightest hint of encouraging him to wage a war against the Soviet Union in 1938 or 1939. But he might have relied on a strong underlying current in England, which was described in December 1938 by Edward Raczynski, the Polish ambassador in London, as saying that all events and problems in Eastern Europe were viewed below the level of “public opinion” by the population as a “lesser evil” that could be used to avert the danger from one’s own empire. On the other hand, at the forefront of the opposition was the very politician who, according to his precedents, might have been most likely to have been assumed to have embraced the conception of a *crusade against Bolshevism*, namely, Winston Churchill. And Hitler’s diplomats in England and in the USA had repeatedly and

emphatically pointed out to him that it was by no means just “the Jewish press agitation” that filled ordinary Englishmen and Americans with distrust of National Socialist Germany, but that there was a centuries-old tradition that took offense at the suppression of freedom of the press and the anti-Jewish and anti-church measures. No ideologue ever showed moderation in victory, but Hitler did not even show tactical wisdom. As early as October he decided to make a speech that pointed in the exact opposite direction of *sensible* policy, and in November he even allowed anti-Jewish events to take place, which for the first time had the character of a full-scale pogrom. As a result, his great year 1938 came to an end for him several weeks before December 31, and the destruction of *what was left of Czechia* in March 1939 brought about a change in the situation in which Stalin, who had just been something like the “sick man of Europe” and almost a marginal figure, became more and more the target of courtship between two hostile power groups.

Chapter III, Section 7

The Failure of the Anti-Communist and Anti-Fascist Concepts in Great European Politics

It seems that Hitler gave his speech, a sharp emphasis against the Western democracies, in Saarbrücken on October 8, 1938, because he was disappointed by the negative echo that the Munich agreements had produced in much of the English, French, and American press. After such a shift in power no reasonable man could expect unanimous enthusiasm in the states forced to yield, but Hitler was not satisfied with critical remarks; he allowed himself to be carried away into articulating now in their most general form the oldest of his causal explanations, namely anti-Semitism no longer merely as the apex of anti-Bolshevism, but as an indictment of fundamental tendencies in the western world, i.e. of liberalism. Thus, while he spoke respectfully of Chamberlain and Daladier, he sharply objected to the “internal construction” of their countries which made it possible for such men to be replaced at any time by figures like Duff Cooper and Winston Churchill, who spoke of their intention to start a new world war. Hitler did not go into the self-evident assumption *of* Churchill and Cooper— *if* Germany continued to pursue its policy of blackmail and aggression—but he continued with a turn of phrase that was not entirely clear: “We know further that still lurking menacingly in the background is the Jewish-international enemy which has found its state foundation and expression in Bolshevism. And furthermore we know the power of a certain international press that lives only on lies and slander.” This *furthermore* was hardly meant to express a mere addition, but presumably Hitler did not want the thesis of the essential affinity between Bolshevism and this international press to come to light quite bluntly. Instead of this, however, he also directly offended Chamberlain and Halifax when he forbade himself “governess-like tutelage” and recommended that the English concentrate on what was happening in Palestine.

So it was therefore not only the fortuitous event of the assassination of the Legation Secretary

Ernst vom Rath by the 17-year-old Herschel Grynszpan on November 7, 1938 in the Reich Embassy in Paris that explains the striking resurgence of anti-Semitism at the very moment when all the signs of a promising policy seemed to point to the sole emphasis of anti-communism. After the Nuremberg Laws, the German Jews had had a relatively quiet few years in which their emigration was encouraged and in which the large number of those who stayed behind were able to develop a community life of astonishing variety and vitality. In the economy, the Jewish positions seemed to have hardly been touched, and anyone who paid attention to the fact that economic-political laws often had several signatures of Jewish bankers next to Adolf Hitler's signature did not even need to be an economist to believe that the *real* economic powers would easily assert themselves against the *mere ideology* of the party. This party ideology seemed to have retreated even to its most despicable hiding place, Julius Streicher's pornographic diatribe newspaper *Der Stürmer*, which, however, was still posted even to the last backwater and in which the demand could be read again and again "to crush the head of the serpent of international Jewry." But the third phase of National Socialist Jewish policy began in April 1938 with the "Ordinance Against Supporting the Camouflage of Jewish Businesses" and with the order to register Jewish businesses and to declare Jewish assets. To be sure, according to all assumptions, there was no exact planning, and no one can predict what the further course of events would have been like if it had not been for Grynszpan's murder.

But it is just as little certain that the "Reichskristallnacht," as the events were later trivially called, *had to* follow. Certainly there was spontaneous indignation, and not just among radical SA men. But when in 1936 the national leader of the Nazi foreign organization in Switzerland, Wilhelm Gustloff, was murdered by the young David Frankfurter with evidently demonstrative intentions, the state leadership had not allowed any riots to occur out of consideration for the upcoming Olympics, and this time there were more at stake than the undisturbed course of the Olympic Games. This time, however, the leadership displayed the opposite of restraint, and the seemingly spontaneous events clearly had their origins in the gathering of the "Old Guard" in Munich on the anniversary of the March to the Feldherrnhalle, and, in particular, in a whispered conversation between Hitler and Goebbels. Anti-Jewish actions were now taking place almost everywhere in Germany, led by the party and SA leaders, and not always as skillfully and inconspicuously as Goebbels had wished. For one night, Germany is, so to speak, Tsarist Russia: synagogues are set on fire, Jewish shops are stormed and looted, doctor's offices are forcibly opened and medical instruments are thrown onto the streets, many Jews are beaten and tortured, thousands are transported to concentration camps, dozens of people are murdered, damage worth of hundreds of millions marks is done. Unmistakably, there is a moment of class struggle is when, for example,

primarily wealthy Jews are arrested or when threats like these are uttered during the deportation: “We will see to it that your fat bellies disappear.” But much more significant than the events themselves, which, judging by the death toll, of course cannot remotely be compared with the great pogroms in Tsarist Russia and even less with the all-encompassing *class struggles* of the Russian revolution, was the aftermath. The Reich Minister Dr. Joseph Goebbels published an article in the *Völkischer Beobachter* on November 12, in which he wrote that the background to the murder was to be found in the agitation of the major Jewish world newspapers, and he came to the conclusion: “The Jew Grünspar was a representative of Judaism. The German vom Rath was a representative of the German people. Judaism, therefore, shot at the German people in Paris.” On the same day, Field Marshal Hermann Göring imposed a “fine” of one billion marks on German Jewry as a whole, and even confiscated the sums paid out by the insurance companies for the benefit of the Reich, so that the Jews had to pay for the damage done to them themselves. If the events as such were far behind the corresponding events in Russia, they were much more repulsive in character, because they were carried out by the over-strong against the weak and expressly approved by the state leadership. Although the collectivist attribution of guilt, which regards the deeds of individuals as mere outgrowths of a collective mentality or interest, was just as decided in the basic approach of the National Socialist racial theory as it was in the Marxist class theory and the class struggle practice of the Bolsheviks, it now came to light for the first time in widely visible deeds fully accessible to the world public, and the impression abroad was extraordinarily strong. Germany was now frequently no longer counted among the civilized states, and anyone who remembered that the same negation had affected Bolshevik Russia in 1918 and 1919 and, because of the Moscow trials, was often put forward again in 1937 and 1938, could easily conclude that the deviation from the simple norms of constitutional civilization on the basis of still relatively open conditions was something worse than the corresponding deviation in the midst of collapse, civil war and full-fledged total rule, even if the human sacrifices were far fewer.

Hitler, however, took such an obvious opinion as the symptom of a malicious conspiracy, and the anti-Semitic motive, which had always been among his most genuine motives, even if it was sometimes covered up by others, soon came to the fore in a way it had hitherto had never been the case in any public statement by the “Führer and Reich Chancellor.” In the Reichstag speech of January 30, 1939, what was symptomatic and salient was not so much the famous and later repeatedly quoted prediction of the “annihilation of the Jewish race in Europe” (if international financial Jewry should once again plunge the peoples into a world war), the simultaneous statements make it likely that there was no talk here of physical annihilation. Another sentence was far more revealing, namely: “Over the Jewish slogan ‘Proletarians of

all countries, unite' a higher realization will triumph, namely: 'Workers of all nations, recognize your common enemy.'" Hitler had never before made it so clear to the world that anti-Bolshevism, anti-Marxism and anti-Semitism formed a unity for him and his aims were by no means merely the revision of Versailles, the enforcement of the right of self-determination for the German people, or the East European living space of a "Germanic Reich," but that he at the same time proclaiming a doctrine of the salvation of the world, which was addressed fundamentally to all people and which corresponded exactly to Marxist doctrine, although it was opposed to it in spirit.

It cannot be ruled out that Hitler also brought his anti-Semitism into play for tactical reasons, because he wanted to ally himself with the anti-Jewish streams in England and America. He overlooked the fact, however, that in England and America a natural dislike of the Jews was widespread among the upper classes, Chamberlain and Halifax were not and could not be anti-Semites in the ideological sense. If he was now striving for an alliance on the international level in the name of anti-communism, then anti-Semitism would have to have a counterproductive effect, unlike in the case of Hugenberg and Papen in Germany.

But the quite a few listeners to two secret speeches that Hitler gave between Munich and Prague in those months could even have asked themselves whether Hitler's anti-Semitism was really directed entirely or even primarily, against the Jews as a clearly definable group and whether his anti-Marxism was indeed as far removed from Marxism as its allies in the nationalist camp believed.

On November 10, 1938, Hitler spoke to about 400 representatives of the German press at an evening reception in the Führerbau in Munich. He boasted of the successes of the past year and praised the role played by propaganda and, consequently, the press. But the education in self-confidence was far from over, especially since the pacifist record he had to play up to now was no longer worth anything. What had already shaken this self-confidence during the World War was "the hysteria of our intellectual strata." In the event of failure, these "chicken people" will certainly fail again and break the unity of the nation: "When I look at the intellectual strata here, unfortunately, they are needed; otherwise one day, I don't know, they could be exterminated or something like that." Were the Jews, in the end, merely a particularly prominent part of the intellectuals for Hitler, and was the question did not arise as to whether the German intelligentsia under Hitler would ultimately suffer a fate similar to that of the Russian *intelligentsia* under Lenin, although the horror of the "extermination of the national intelligentsia" in Russia had been one of Hitler's most original emotions? Was the fascination hidden in the fear and the role model in the horror?

And could not a similar question be asked with regard to the German bourgeoisie, which had mostly allied themselves with Hitler precisely in order to finally be free from the threats of communism? In any case, many a citizen would have called *Marxist* the conclusion that Hitler drew from the experience he told young officers about in the Reich Chancellery on January 25, 1939: “How often, especially in the bad times, did I drive past road construction crews and there were tar workers standing there, sooty and dirty, and then the cars had to stop there, ten, twelve automobiles. In the cars sat wealthy citizens, merchants, bankers or people like that were sitting in the cars, and on the street stood these proles, and when I compared the heads, there was an eye shining out from under the soot and dirt of so many of these road workers that I had to say to myself: Actually you should put him in the car and order the other one here to work on the roads.” Was Marxism right in the end in its main thesis of the irresolvable opposition between the dying bourgeoisie and the rising proletariat, and was Hitler about to put this main thesis into practice? Presumably Hitler would have answered such a question that he had individual proletarians in mind and not *the proletariat*, and that he was not striving for a stateless society of general equality, but on the contrary for the formation of a “new social elite” capable of exercising rule over Europe. But was Lenin, with his talk of the “grain” of the all-transforming party and of Russia as the “strongest state in the world,” so far removed from this? In any case, it must be clear to all listeners and basically all readers of his books and speeches that Hitler’s anti-Semitism was no mere *hostility to the Jews* and that his anti-Marxism was closer to the real Marxism of the Soviet Union than the doctrinaire Marxists themselves would have admitted.

Now the journalists and writers of England and the United States were certainly not among the listeners to these speeches, and very few of them had read *Mein Kampf*. Nevertheless, the assertion cannot be called into question that in England and America and especially in France, great concern would have spread as a result of the public speeches and actions of the period between October 1938 and March 1939 even if there had not been a single one there Jewish journalists and not a single Jewish financier there. Even the most staunch anti-Communists could not have been able to escape this concern.

But it was Hitler’s destruction of *what was left of Czechia* that created a new quality of criticism and resistance and meant the death blow to the anti-communist concept of great agreement, although it continued to exist in weak remnants. What caused Hitler to switch from the motive of “self-determination” to the motive of “living space” before he had even seriously raised the issue of the oldest desideratum of German self-determination, that of Danzig and the Germans in Poland, has still not been convincingly clarified to this day. Certainly the connection to the Central European conception of Friedrich Naumann and

others as well as to the former Austrian reality was obvious, but the new government in Prague was fully aware that it had to cooperate unconditionally with the Greater German Reich, and the Slovak problem seemed to be solved to general satisfaction when a Slovak Diet elected the priest Josef Tiso as prime minister of an autonomous federal state. But there were Slovak radicals for whom this solution was not enough, and as early as mid-October 1938 Göring gave them his opinion that an “airport base in Slovakia was very important for the Luftwaffe in operations to the east.” However, what was decisive in the narrowest sense of the word was a personal moment that had no equivalent on Stalin’s side: Hitler’s feeling that he didn’t have long to live and that he would therefore have to make the “big decisions” soon. Presumably, the much more banal taste for impressive successes and triumphant entrances also played a role. In any case, by means of barely veiled threats, he pushed the Slovak radicals along the path of separatism, which the central government in Prague opposed only because it did not receive any information about the wishes of the Reich government. The dismissal of Tiso by the new President Hacha on March 10, 1939 was the opportunity Hitler desired and brought about. On March 12, he had the Wehrmacht draw up the “demands for an ultimatum.” The German minority took to the streets in Brno, Iglau and Pressburg and tried to provoke the Czechs, everywhere with relatively little success. Hitler promised the Hungarians Carpatho-Ukraine, which he had refused them in the Vienna arbitration of November 2, 1938, and in Bratislava the radicals of *Rodobrana* took over the leadership of independent Slovakia. On the night of March 15, Hacha and Foreign Minister Chvalkovsky were received by Hitler in the Reich Chancellery. Hacha appears very weak and humble, but the most severe threats are necessary to get him to sign the “treaty” that annexes the Czech Republic as a “protectorate” to the German Reich. This did not merely reverse the state emancipation of 1918, but introduced a new kind of status of inferior rights, which had hitherto been unknown in Europe and which, as a result of the anti-colonial movements, was also in decline in the rest of the world. And the occupation of the Czech Republic was presented by the German press as a campaign of conquest: “Swastika banners are waving over Prague” was one of the headlines, and Hitler took possession of the Hradcany as if he had moved into the enemy’s capital after a victorious war. But this time the advancing troops were not greeted with cheers and flowers and kisses: fists clenched, tears flowed, and women spat in the faces of German soldiers.

The anti-communist conception of the grand agreement had thus collapsed before it could fully emerge, for even those in the West who had been most inclined to think along these lines had assumed tacitly that Hitler would not use violence and would not seek further expansion, i.e. the subsequent recognition of the national right to self-determination was the furthest step that they intended to be take. If the governments of England and France had had

a purely anti-communist, i.e. anti-Bolshevik attitude, they would certainly have viewed the incorporation of Czechia into the German Reich as a further development of the positions required for the forthcoming decisive struggle, and they indeed have had to act that way if they presented themselves as representatives of *capitalism*. But were they allowed to be sure that Hitler was a pure *anti-communist*? Wasn't anti-communism for him in the end just as much an instrument in the service of other purposes as the right to self-determination obviously was? But even if Chamberlain and Halifax had trusted Hitler, the public opinion of their countries would not have given them a free hand, for that public opinion was now predominantly *anti-fascist*, however unmistakable the countercurrents still existing. Very characteristic was the report of the Polish ambassador in Washington, Jerzy Potocki, who, with a clear undertone of dislike and criticism, told his foreign minister as early as March 7 that President Roosevelt and the press were manipulating the American public with the intention of "encouraging hatred of everything that smacks of fascism." In this, he said, the USSR was counted among the camp of democratic states, just as the *Loyalists* were seen as defenders of democratic ideas during the Spanish Civil War. Similar views were held in England by the Labour Party in paradoxical agreement with the conservative oppositionists around Churchill, and in France the parties of the "Popular Front" were still powerful enough to move in the direction of a renewed transition to the policy of great resistance under the banner of anti-fascism. With the occupation of Prague, this tendency was bound to receive a tremendous impetus everywhere throughout the West.

Chamberlain had spoken with striking caution at first, but then, on March 17 in Birmingham, he was forced to express his fears at the prospect of an attempt "to rule the world by force," and he closed his speech with the sentence: "...no greater mistake (could) be committed than that of believing that our nation, because it considers war to be a senseless and cruel thing,...has lost its marrow so much that it cannot exhaust its force to meet a daring challenge, should it ever come." A little later, in even shorter and more evocative words, Halifax told the German Ambassador von Dirksen that he could understand Hitler's taste for bloodless victories, but that next time he would be forced to shed blood. It didn't really matter what the *next time* would be; if one calls the will to resist *war will*, then from the occupation of Prague onwards England was undoubtedly determined to go to war, *provided* that Hitler made further territorial demands and attempted to enforce them by force. But this was at the same time a return to simple state policy; the profound change that this state policy had undergone through the existence of the ideological states was left out without disappearing completely. In any case, events did not make Chamberlain and Halifax *anti-fascists* any more than did Daladier and Bonnet, if only because they did not want to offend Italy.

The peculiar thing was that Hitler had in fact already made new demands, but that they were initially made in a thoroughly friendly, emphatically anti-communist spirit and, strictly speaking, were not *territorial demands*, but on the contrary implied renunciations that Stresemann would never have made under any circumstances. After all, nothing was more painful and unbearable for the Germans of the Weimar Republic than the existence of the Polish “corridor” that separated East Prussia from the Reich, and with it the independent existence of the “Free City of Danzig.” Nowhere could the Germans complain with greater justification about discrimination, even disenfranchisement and persecution of their compatriots. Hitler had radically reversed the course of the Weimar Republic in January 1934, and no one but him could have done it. His motive was evidently anti-communist sympathy with the regime of Marshal Pilsudski, who, after all, might have crushed the Bolsheviks in 1920 had he agreed to support the last Belorussian army. When at the end of October 1938, Hitler had Ribbentrop suggest to the Polish Ambassador Lipski that he agree to Danzig’s return to the Reich and to accept an extraterritorial motorway and a corresponding railway line through the corridor, he had in mind a “general settlement” of all existing frictions, which would be “the culmination of the work initiated by Marshal Pilsudski and the Führer.” The background was quite unmistakably the prospect of a joint fight against the Soviet Union, and in the further talks that Hitler and Ribbentrop had in the following months with Lipski and Foreign Minister Beck, there was often meaningful talk of the Ukraine, and a rejection on the part of the party the Pole was not apparent. But on the other hand, Lipski pointed out from the beginning that Danzig had a special and symbolic meaning for Poland and that an extraterritorial highway represented a serious loss of sovereignty. In fact, for the sake of his higher aims, Hitler had brought about a general settlement with Italy by solemnly renouncing South Tyrol. Here, however, he demanded something, although in the main merely the abandonment of a legal relationship, namely the inclusion of the free city of Danzig in the Polish customs area. Hitler did not consider that a radical fascist state can pursue a policy of renunciation against the backdrop of its much broader ultimate goals, but that fascist-like nationalism was least capable of doing so. Thus the friendly atmosphere of the discussions was lost more and more, the mood of the Polish public deteriorated visibly; there was outrage that Germany had prevented a common border between Poland and Hungary in the Vienna arbitration award, and they took a rather sharp action against the German minority.

But it was March 15 that finally hardened the situation. Now the Polish public was convinced that Poland would be the next state to “take its turn”; and the German *protection* of Slovakia undoubtedly meant an extraordinary deterioration in the strategic position of Poland, if it considered itself an opponent and not an ally of the German Reich. Nevertheless, Beck did

not agree with the most obvious of all proposals now put forward by the British government: that Poland, together with England, France and the Soviet Union, should issue a declaration expressing a willingness to resist any threat to the political independence of any European state. Even a policy of great resistance was bound to be dangerous for Poland's victorious war against Soviet Russia in 1920, and the Polish regime of colonels was even less able to accept the unmistakable tendency towards ideological anti-fascism than the Conservative Party government in England. Thus Beck pleaded for a bilateral agreement, and on March 31st Chamberlain made a statement in the House of Commons that the British Government would give the Polish Government all support it could in the event of action "which clearly threatens Polish independence and goes against which the Polish government would accordingly regard resistance with its national armed forces as indispensable." The wording was not entirely clear, and Hitler's proposals did not necessarily threaten Poland's independence. But this declaration could be seen as a unilateral—and utterly unprecedented in English history—guarantee obliging the British government to intervene in arms, even if only the Danzig government declared annexation to the Reich and Poland opposed it by force of arms. The decision about war and peace was thus placed in the hands of the Poles, although Beck had concealed essential facts in London and although Henderson called the German cause "by no means unjustified or immoral," but the Poles "heroic, but also fools." There were serious concerns even among leading Poles, and the Polish ambassador in Paris, Juliusz Lukasiewicz, spoke very negatively about Chamberlain's domestic motives, which he said amounted to an "ideological struggle against Hitlerism" and aimed to provoking an overthrow in Germany.

Beck, in turn, derived from Hitler's anti-communism the conviction that he was utterly incapable of even contemplating an anti-Polish agreement with the Soviet Union.

Thus, the negotiations about a mutual assistance pact, which were conducted during the summer months between the Western powers and the Soviet Union, would not have been very promising even if they had actually been able to agree on a common line of struggle against *Hitlerite fascism*. First of all, Poland was at stake, and Poland could only expect help against Germany if it allowed the Soviet troops to invade. But that, according to Beck and Marshal Rydz-Smigly, would entail the loss of those eastern territories taken from the Russians in the Peace of Riga, and almost no one was in Poland was willing to hand over Brest-Litovsk and Lemberg to the Soviet Beelzebub in order to be able to defend Danzig against the German devil. Moreover, since the Soviet Union was also raising the question of the *security* of the Baltic border states, the negotiations were more than likely filled with the deepest mutual distrust, for the Russians feared that the Western powers wanted to exhaust

the Soviet Union and Germany on the Polish battlefields, and in the British Foreign Office the opposite and older suspicion was still very much alive, that the Soviet Union wanted to involve the Western powers in a war with Germany in order to be able to dominate the whole of Europe later and subject it to the Soviet system. Thus, negotiations conducted in July and August by an Anglo-French military mission in Moscow with Marshal Voroshilov made slow progress. Then, like a bolt of lightning from a moderately overcast sky, came the news that Reich Foreign Minister von Ribbentrop would be arriving in Moscow on August 23 to conclude a non-aggression pact between Germany and the Soviet Union. The anti-fascist conception, which had never been more than a tendency within the politics of the great resistance, had now also failed. The fifth main possibility of world politics, apparently impossible for ideological reasons and neglected for a long time, had prevailed: an understanding between the enemies, which seemed to be a resumption of the Rapallo policy. This averted the threat of world war, but also broke the more probable imprisonment of Hitler: the starting signal for the partial European war was given, if the Western powers persisted in fulfilling their obligations to Poland.

Chapter III, Section 8

The Hitler-Stalin Pact as the Beginning of the European Prelude to World War II

Of course, the news did not come as a complete surprise. In 1938 and early 1939, the French and English press had repeatedly reported news and comments announcing a rapprochement between Germany and the Soviet Union or portraying it as possible. But these might be expedient reports, and Hitler's hostile statements, such as those in the speech of January 30, 1939, had quickly rendered such expectations or fears, it seemed, irrelevant. France's foreign minister, meanwhile, knew at the beginning of October 1938 that a senior Soviet diplomat had reacted to the Munich agreement by exclaiming: "I see no other possibility for us than a fourth partition of Poland!" And everyone could make up his own mind when Stalin delivered his so called "Chestnut Speech" on March 10, 1939, at the XVIII. Party Congress, which distributed the blame equally between the two sides, but insinuated that the Western powers wanted to incite Germany against the Soviet Union, in order to then appear on the scene with fresh forces and dictate their terms to the weakened belligerents. In any case, he expressed the refusal of the Soviet Union to "pull the chestnuts out of the fire" for the war provocateurs. Three weeks later, Hitler also used the chestnut metaphor in a speech in Wilhelmshaven. On May 3, however, the world was surprised by the news that Soviet Foreign Minister Litvinov had been relieved and replaced by the Chairman of the Council of People's Commissars, Vyacheslav I. Molotov. Why was the most important champion of the Soviet orientation toward the West deposed just at the moment when unity with the Western powers seemed inevitable? Was it not Stalin's way of showing that he was in any case not compelled to close deals with any particular partner, and that he, who had been completely isolated just a few months earlier, had now become the key figure in the fate of Europe and the world?

But even in Germany the "Rapallo line" had never been completely dead, and Hermann Göring had done much to ensure that the tenuous threads between the two powers were not

broken, which the Soviet trade representative in Berlin, David Kandelaki, sought to preserve and to strengthen. Underneath the propaganda drumbeat in Germany, there were for some time considerations that thought to recognize a weakening of the ideological opposition and stated a “nationalization of Bolshevism,” quite in line with the ideas that had been advocated in the Russian emigration 15 years earlier. Thus Hitler himself had already rejected a feeler from Kandelakis at the beginning of 1937, but said to Neurath: “It would be something different if things in Russia were to develop further in the direction of absolute despotism, supported by the military. In that case, however, we should not miss the moment to intervene again in Russia.” And the basic approach of National Socialism included the possibility of emphasizing the contrast to the Jews in the West. If the Polish and Romanian “no” to the Soviet march through were allowed to be taken into account as an established fact, then in the spring and summer of 1939 German-Soviet contacts carried greater weight from the outset.

The initiative came more from the Soviet Union than from Germany, and the risk was indeed far greater on the German side. The fact that Stalin tried to improve his negotiating position vis-à-vis the Western powers by establishing contact with Germany would probably have been regarded by the Western powers as a customary and forgivable ruse in the event of an indiscretion; on the other hand, it could have been disastrous for Hitler’s prestige and for his relations with Japan and Italy if Stalin had announced the feelers and made deals with the Western powers. It was therefore not surprising that the world-historical event was initially prepared primarily at the level of third-rate beamers.

Immediately after Litvinov’s dismissal, the Soviet chargé d'affaires Astakhov contacted Schnurre, the legation counselor of the economic policy department of the Foreign Office, and tried to find out whether the event would lead Germany to change its attitude towards the Soviet Union. Fourteen days later, Molotov spoke personally to the German ambassador in Moscow, von der Schulenburg, about the need to create a “political basis” for the planned economic negotiations, but he did not allow his wishes to be specified. On June 3, the Russians made use of the Estonian envoy, who said in a conversation with State Secretary von Weizsacker that in Moscow mistrust of democratic states was greater than totalitarian ones, and that one seemed to be waiting only for a public gesture of accommodation to give expression to the mood mentioned. Astakhov was even more explicit in a conversation with the Bulgarian envoy on June 15, which was of course immediately brought to the attention of the Foreign Office: The Soviet Union had three possible courses of action before it, among which it “emotionally” preferred a rapprochement with Germany. If Germany eliminated the Russian fear of an attack via the Baltic States or Romania by concluding a non-aggression pact, the Soviet Union would probably refrain from concluding a treaty with England. Since

at the same time German negotiations with Japan about a military pact were faltering, Ribbentrop and Hitler seem to have taken the idea of a non-aggression pact seriously into their considerations for the first time. The next important step, however, was again taken at the lower level, namely at a dinner to which Schnurre invited the chargé d'affaires Astakhov and the head of the trade mission Barbarin to the Ewest restaurant on July 27th. Here Schnurre put forward extremely peculiar views on the relationship between Bolshevism and National Socialism, which in earlier times would certainly have prompted Soviet officials to protest sharply or to flee in horror: despite all the differences, he said, there was common ground in the ideology of Germany, Italy and the Soviet Union, namely, the opposition to capitalist democracies. There could no longer be any question of a sharp antagonism between Germany and the Soviet Union, for the Comintern was no longer dominant, Bolshevism was increasingly merging with the national history of Russia, and the world revolution had been postponed by Stalin *ad calendas graecas*. Therefore he could imagine that the two states would come together in three stages. In his reply, Astakhov emphasized how valuable this conversation had been for him, and no doubt he immediately prepared a report for Molotov.

From the beginning, the initiative passed to the German side and assumed an increasingly urgent character, while negotiations were taking place in Moscow with the Anglo-French military mission arrived by sea. On August 3 Ribbentrop conveyed to Molotov the German desire to place German-Russian relations on a “new and definitive basis” and on August 14 he indicated his readiness to come to Moscow to conclude the non-aggression pact, because was undeniable that “the capitalist Western democracies are irreconcilable enemies” of both Germany and the Soviet Union. Molotov received the message “with the greatest interest,” but he nevertheless emphasizes the need to carefully prepare the Reich Foreign Minister’s trip and speaks for the first time of a “special protocol” that must form an integral part of the planned pact. On the same day, Ribbentrop declared himself ready to negotiate such a protocol and urged rapid action. Such urging, of course, gives the negotiator an extraordinarily strong position, and on August 20 Molotov again reminded the ambassador of the need for “preparation.” But half an hour after the end of the conversation the ambassador was called back to the Kremlin: he was handed the draft of a non-aggression pact and the Soviet government declared its agreement to Ribbentrop arriving in Moscow on August 26 or 27. Obviously, Stalin personally gave the order. And on the same day Hitler intervened personally. In a telegram to “Herr Stalin, Moscow,” Adolf Hitler urgently requested that his foreign minister be received in Moscow as early as August 22, but no later than August 23. On the evening of August 21, Stalin telegraphed “to the Reich Chancellor of Germany, Herr A. Hitler” that “the Soviet government” was in agreement with Ribbentrop’s arrival on August 23.

Thus, in days, even hours, the decision was made which fundamentally changed the world situation and forced the Franco-British military mission to an inglorious departure. The policy of great resistance collapsed after all attempts to keep the policy of small resistance alive which, at least virtually, became obsolete with the signing of the German-Italian “Steel Pact” on May 22. But neither a small nor a large agreement was reached between the Western powers and Germany, although Ministerial Director Wohlthat had been conducted negotiations with Sir Horace Wilson in July that seemed promising, by means of which Chamberlain wanted to pursue in secret, according to Dirksen, “the only important and worthwhile goal of the union with Germany”. But England was not in a position to offer to Hitler what he was now striving for with all his might, the defeat of Poland, and she was equally unable to concede to the Soviet Union what Hitler was now able to offer her. Despite the “general authority” with which he was endowed, Ribbentrop had to ask Hitler from Moscow on August 23 whether he could yield to Stalin’s and Molotov’s surprising demand that the Latvian ports of Libau and Windau be recognized as within their “spheres of interest,” but Hitler’s immediate reply was, “Yes, agreed.” This finally cleared the way for the signing of the Non-Aggression Pact and the Secret Additional Protocol.

The Non-Aggression Pact was based on the Soviet draft, but this was modified in a symptomatic way, apparently at Ribbentrop’s request. In the draft, the Soviet Union and Germany were guided “by the desire to consolidate the cause of peace between nations” while the final text only spoke of consolidating peace between Germany and the USSR. In the draft, the crucial Article II read: “Should one of the contracting parties become the object of an act of violence or aggression by a third power, the other contracting party shall not in any way support such acts of that power.” The final version, on the other hand, spoke only of “acts of war on the part of a third power” which one of the contracting parties would become the object of, and it thus expressly sanctioned aggressive war, just as the “Steel Pact” had done.

The radical difference from the League of Nations ideology and even from the Steel Pact, however, became quite clear only through the “Secret Additional Protocol,” which was exclusively the result of a Soviet initiative, although Ribbentrop had certainly envisaged something similar in substance several weeks earlier with the assurance that Russian interests would be protected. The starting point, internal prerequisite and undisguised goal of the agreement was the “case of a territorial-political transformation” in the areas of the Baltic states and Poland. From this point of view, the spheres of interest of both states were delimited by the northern border of Lithuania and by the Narew, Vistula and San lines. Any possible uncertainty as to what was meant was cleared up by the sentence: “The question of whether the mutual interests make the preservation of an independent Polish state appear

desirable and how this state should be defined can only be finally clarified in the course of further political developments.”

Thus there cannot be the slightest doubt what this pact meant: the Soviet Union cleared the way for Germany to go to war against Poland: it was a war pact. At the same time, this war was supposed to lead to the division of Eastern Europe into spheres of interest: the pact constituted a division pact. At least with regard to Poland, the division was not limited to the definition of zones of influence, but it suggested the disappearance of the country's statehood: the pact was an annihilation pact. As a war pact, a division pact and an annihilation pact, it has no parallel in European history of the 19th and 20th centuries. The two states that concluded it had to be states of a very special kind.

Of a very special kind was also the conversation that took place in the Kremlin on the night of August 23-24 between Ribbentrop and Stalin and Molotov. Stalin blamed the “stupidity of other countries” for England's domination of the world, and Ribbentrop claimed that the anti-Comintern Pact was not really directed against the Soviet Union but against Western democracies. Molotov raised his glass to Stalin, pointing out that it was Stalin who, with his March 10 speech, initiated the turnaround in political relations, and Stalin himself offered a toast “spontaneously” (as the German clerk put it) to Adolf Hitler: “I know how much the German people love their Führer: I would therefore like to drink to his health.” For his part, Ribbentrop had pointed out that in Germany “especially the ordinary people” welcomed the understanding with the Soviet Union. At the farewell, Stalin assured the Reich Foreign Minister that the Soviet government took the new pact very seriously; he could assure on his word of honor that the Soviet Union would not betray its partner.

What was the immediately recognizable significance of this event, which gave the greatest surprise throughout the world and in many places caused sheer horror or left speechless? One result was clear from the first moment: it was no ordinary non-aggression pact. The very wording of Article II indicated this, and the departure of the Allied military mission from Moscow underlined this fact. In any case, a serious shift in the world political balance had taken place, and the first German commentaries pointed out with much satisfaction that the two peoples who had stood together in the wars of liberation against Napoleon and who had signed the Rapallo Treaty only 15 years earlier had found each other again. Here and there one could get the impression that the pact was seen as a return to Bismarck and reason after Hitler's previous and unnatural friendship with Poland. In fact, the Russian-German bloc was unassailable and invincible, and some of Stalin's statements later went in that direction with regretful undertones. But what seemed to have been destroyed, however, was the credibility

of both states as ideological powerhouses. Certainly Lenin had concluded the Treaty of Brest-Litovsk, and certainly in 1923 Radek had advocated cooperation with the German nationalists. But in the first case it had been a matter of bare survival, and in the second it had been clear who would have had the stronger leverage. Even if one accepts that *the revolution* was so feeble that it could only be kept in existence by the existence of the Soviet Union, could this city of revolution simply do anything and shake hands with the worst of its enemies? It was obviously not a question of survival: it is out of the question that Hitler would attack Poland if there was a hostile major power on its eastern border. In fact, for many communists in the West, after the Moscow Trials, this pact was the second deep shaking of their loyalty, which had been so strong until then, and quite a few now finally turned their backs on the man and the great power who betrayed the anti-fascist front for the sake of mere advantage of power. Either the Comintern now had to resort to the truly confusing interpretation that Schnurre and Ribbentrop had offered with reference to the internal kinship between the two regimes, or they had to choose the most obvious and plausible explanation, at least in hints: Stalin had lured his mortal enemy in an exhausting war with those who were *objectively* his friends, and would deal him the deathblow as soon as he was the last to step onto the battlefield with his forces undiminished. This, however, was the concept of a *world revolutionary war*, as it had been outlined by Marx himself occasionally and in passing, but which now had to turn even the last of the *bourgeois pacifists* into enemies of such a warlike state.

But Hitler had definitely lost his credibility as the champion of the anti-communist cause. Never again would it be possible to make a statement like that which Lord Halifax had made to an emissary of Hitler only a year before: the aim of his work was to see the Führer enter Buckingham Palace together with the English king, to the cheers of the crowd. Even Germany's best friends among English and French statesmen had to now perceive Hitler as he presented himself in his two speeches to the generals on August 22: as the ruthless power politician who had "maneuvered" Poland into a situation in which he could proceed to "destroy the enemy" and who believed he had Stalin in his hands because he allegedly had to fear victory for his soldiers just as much as defeat. But even among old and convinced National Socialists, the pact caused a shock that was difficult to overcome. "I have the feeling that this Moscow Pact will eventually take revenge on National Socialism," wrote Alfred Rosenberg in his diary on August 25. This, he said, was a plea from one revolution to the head of another, when it had been the ideal of a twenty-year struggle to defeat it. "How can we still talk about saving and shaping Europe if we have to ask the destroyer of Europe for help?" All the same, Rosenberg wanted to see Ribbentrop as the main person responsible, whom he even declared to be a "criminal" since he had no political views apart from hatred

of England. And mustn't Hitler, if he wanted to stand up to himself, have made the decision for a different kind of *world revolutionary war* when he left Finland and the Baltic states, the eastern half of Poland and Bessarabia to Stalin?

At least, this is indicated by that "most remarkable statement" which he made on August 11, according to the report of Carl J. Burckhardt, the League of Nations Commissioner for Danzig, during a conversation on the Obersalzberg: "Everything I undertake is directed against Russia; if the West is too stupid and too blind to understand this, I will be forced to come to terms with the Russians, defeat the West, and then, after it has been defeated, turn my combined forces against the Soviet Union. I need Ukraine, so that we can't be starved like in the last war." But even this statement pointed more to the "lebensraum" politician than to the revolutionary anti-communist who appeals to the freedom of oppressed peoples and wants to liberate the world from the nightmare of an unprecedented reign of terror. But how much of the old worries and fears remained alive in Hitler, underneath all the power politics and all the confident will to win, was shown by another and even stranger statement that he had already made to the Romanian Foreign Minister on April 19, 1939: "And why this unimaginable killing? In the end, we will all lie under the same rubble, victors and vanquished, and only that one from Moscow will benefit."

For a crucial 10 days, meanwhile, he once again offered the world the face of the mere revisionist, the fighter against the injustices of Versailles. And now Stalin was running a tremendous risk. The immediate purpose of the pact, for Hitler, was to keep the Western powers from intervening in favor of Poland. If he could do that, Stalin would have made the pact for nothing, then he would be alone in facing Hitler's tremendous power. Poland's situation was hopeless. There was much to be said for the correctness of Hitler's prophecy that the British Empire would in no case survive a war. Thus he continued to demand only Danzig and the corridor, indeed, in his most recent and publicly announced proposals, he even offered a referendum in the corridor, which would hardly have turned out favorably for Germany. He assured Henderson, with all subjective sincerity, that he wanted British friendship more than anything else in the world and that he was ready to guarantee England's empire. On August 26 he withdrew the order to attack that had already been given, although this meant a considerable loss of prestige among the military, so that his most resolute opponent among the senior officers, Colonel Hans Oster of the Abwehr, predicted Hitler's imminent demise. Everything he did outwardly these days appeared reasonable and measured. On the side of his opponents there were obvious misjudgments: Josef Lipski expected uprisings in Germany and the march of Polish troops against Berlin; Chamberlain evidently did not take seriously the idea of the fall of the Empire. But all of Hitler's

statements and actions were invalidated by the precedents of “Munich” and “Prague,” and Beck as well as Chamberlain followed the public opinion of their countries, which would not have tolerated any yielding at the last hour. The notion of *honor* had come into its own, and became the boulder that set off the avalanche. Molotov, in turn, postponed the ratification of the pact by one day to August 31.

On the morning of September 1, German troops crossed the Polish borders from the west, north, and south, and Hitler delivered a speech before the Reichstag that resembled more the outburst of a hounded man than the calm confidence of someone convinced of his rights: “Since 5:45 a.m. we have been firing back. And from now on bomb will be repaid with bomb...One word I never got to know, it is called: surrender...But I would like to assure the environment: November 1918 will never be repeated in German history!” Hitler did not find a touching and memorable word as Wilhelm II had found in 1914: “I know no more parties, I know only Germans.” No elated crowds surged in the streets as they had in 1914; a depressing and gloomy atmosphere hung over Germany. For two long days the scales did not seem to have finally tilted in favor of the great war, and Mussolini made one last attempt at mediation. But since Hitler did not want to and probably could not accept the Allied demand that his troops, who had already been victorious everywhere, be withdrawn to the borders of the Reich, the British and French ambassadors handed over the declarations of war on September 3. Hitler had succumbed to a miscalculation, and Stalin had correctly foreseen that the Western powers would not back down again and that Hitler would not be able to resist the lure of the Narev-Vistula-San line. Stalin had thus achieved greater things than Lenin: he had not only played the *capitalist powers* off against one another, he had involved them in a war among themselves which, after the expected mutual exhaustion, would make him the victor over both sides.

Hitler had lost far more than just a cleverly devised stratagem. Like Mussolini, his domestic recipe for victory consisted in crushing the revolutionary enemy with the help of conservative allies and then largely disempowering these allies. He had to follow the same rule in foreign policy if he wanted to prevail. But the revolutionary enemy no longer seemed as threatening to the potential allies after the Great Purge as it had appeared to Papen and Hugenberg in 1933 in view of the 100 Communist Reichstag mandates, and internal agreement was weaker because for Chamberlain and Halifax anti-communism was not synonymous with anti-semitism. So for the sake of a relatively small advantage, Hitler made an alliance with his enemy and attacked his friends. Without an unforeseen way out, he had already lost the war by the time he fired the first shot.

On September 3, Adolf Hitler issued an appeal to the NSDAP, in which he held “our judeo-democratic world enemy” responsible for the war and also characterized this enemy as “the capitalist warmongers of England and its satellites.” Not only had he allied himself with his enemy, but he had also adopted the language of that enemy. How should he ever again be able to credibly talk about the “Bolshevik world enemy” or even about “Jewish Bolshevism”?

Admittedly, Hitler did not yet waging a world war. A European war began with the attack on Poland, and it was to prove to be a kind of half-war at first. It would only become a prelude to a world war if Hitler either allied himself with Stalin for better or worse if he tried to overthrow him, even though the elementary precondition for an understanding with the conservative or established powers no longer existed. That the United States, for the moment still bound by its legislation of neutrality, should stand aside in one case or another was highly improbable.

Two events of a very special kind, however, indicated that this war was already far more than the *normal war* that was being waged between some of the great European powers, as was the case in 1870/71.

On September 1, Hitler had a decree dated, which instructed the Reich leaders Bouhler and Dr. Brandt: “...to expand the powers of doctors to be commissioned by name in such a way that, according to human judgment, incurably sick can be granted a mercy death if their condition is critically assessed.” It could appear as if Hitler wanted to show deliberately and explicitly that with the outbreak of war a new epoch had dawned in which National Socialism would be free of all the shackles which the state of peace had imposed on it in order to advance the *recovery* of the people that was demanded by his ideology. Only with the outbreak of the war, then, did National Socialism arrive at its specific and at least *biological* level of destruction, while Bolshevism had shown its will to social destruction from the very beginning of its rule and precisely as a *struggle for peace* .

On September 5, The *Times* published the text of an open letter that Dr. Chaim Weizmann, head of the Jewish Agency for Palestine, addressed to the British Prime Minister. In it, Weizmann reiterated the declaration made before September 1 that the Jews would stand on the side of Britain and fight alongside the democracies. Certainly the Jewish Agency for Palestine was not the government of a state, but it was by no means a mere private organization either. And if anyone in the world was allowed to speak for all Jews and not just for the Jews of Palestine, it was Chaim Weizmann, who had been Lord Balfour’s negotiating partner in 1917 and who for many years headed the World Zionist Organization. It is

therefore by no means out of place to speak of a “Jewish declaration of war on Hitler. “And Weizmann merely expressed what almost every Jew in the whole world *must* have felt. Hitler had declared war on Jewry much earlier, and not only as a party politician but also as a statesman, at the latest on January 30, 1939. This *declaration of war* was therefore a response, and a fully justified response. But it was not a *negligible quantity* , and it is not appropriate to conceal it, as is done in almost all accounts. Hitler had made his mortal enemy a group of people who, while not nearly as powerful as he repeatedly claimed, undoubtedly wielded great influence in England and America. It remains an open question whether Weizmann’s statement was unwise or, on the contrary, it was not all too wise, because it might have possibly wanted the interment of German Jews and thus their protection, analogously to the difficult but assured fate of German citizens in France and England. However, the possibility that Weizmann even remotely suspected a connection with that biological decree of September 1, of which he was unaware, can be completely ruled out. Weizmann could have known *that* the war of 1939 was fundamentally different from the First World War, not only because of the Hitler-Stalin Pact but also because of Weizmann’s declaration; but how much it would finally differ in the end was still unimaginable for him in September 1939, no different than what everyone suspected for Himmler and Heydrich, who were already preparing to wage a “ethnic struggle” of utmost severity in Poland.

Chapter III, Section 9

The Fragile Alliance: Triumphs, Gains, Tensions

The unexpected occurred immediately, but as such it offered no way out. Within a few days, the concentrated attack of the National Socialist industrial state inflicted decisive defeats on the armies of the nationalist agrarian state, not least as a result of the rapidly won air supremacy, and by September 8 General Hoepner's Panzer Corps had reached the suburbs of Warsaw. So the "congratulations and greetings" that Molotov conveyed to the Reich government that day hardly came from a happy heart, and the Soviet government was apparently found itself embarrassed when it was asked from Berlin to proceed with occupying the intended zone of influence. Only on September 17th, when the bulk of the Polish army was destroyed in the great battle in the Vistula bend, did the Red Army move into the areas of eastern Poland to come to the aid of the "Ukrainian and Belarusian blood kin," but the world could not now deceive itself into believing that the "non-aggression pact" had in fact been a partition pact, and the spirit of the treaties with Poland (though not their wording) should have prompted the Western powers to declare war on the Soviet Union as well as on Germany. If doubts still existed in view of the first reports, they would have been removed by Molotov's speech of October 31, in which the People's Commissar very much emphasized the friendly relations with Germany and proudly emphasized that "two blows, first delivered swiftly by the German Wehrmacht and then by the Red Army" would have left nothing of "this ugly product of the Versailles Treaty."

But the Western Powers did not stir even on their fronts against Germany, and there began that strange war, or "Sitzkrieg," or "Phony War," which was to last until May of the following year. However, since September 28, the date of Ribbentrop's second visit to Moscow, Germany and the Soviet Union had been bound together by a "treaty of borders and friendship" to which several secret and confidential additional protocols belonged. Thus it was decided, in accordance with Stalin's suggestion, that no residual Polish state would

remain and that Germany and the Soviet Union alone would have the task of ensuring to the people living in the former Poland “a peaceful existence corresponding to their national characteristics.” The Soviet Union, as well adapted itself to the language of its allied enemy. A significant change in the Secret Additional Protocol of August 23 was made by stipulating that Lithuania, except for the tip of Mariampol, fell within the Soviet Union’s sphere of interest, while Germany took possession of the bulk of ethnographic Poland, so that, with some deviations, the “Curzon Line” of 1920 formed the western frontier of the Soviet Union. It was a change of extraordinary weight, since it blocked the Germans from even looking into the Baltic States and, on the other hand, gave them the full burden of dominating the Poles, but Ribbentrop agreed in a “Blitz” negotiation, which had analogies to the “Blitzkrieg” from the point of view of, but from the point of view of overwhelming success. So, then, it was an *unequal* provision when both parties pledged themselves “to not tolerate any Polish agitation in their areas that would have a spillover effect on the territories of the other party.” On the other hand, one might see an extraordinary gain for Germany in the joint declaration of both governments that England and France would be responsible for the continuation of the war if they evaded the joint efforts of the two powers to restore a state of peace. Evidently the Soviet government had good reason to believe that the Western powers would *not* give in, and their own actions contributed greatly to this, for the conduct of the Soviet Union had created a storm of indignation in Britain and France, and it was inconceivable that the Western powers could demand less than the re-establishment of the Polish state, including its eastern territories, as a price for peace.

In the realm of immediate realities, on the other hand, was the agreement that the Soviet Union would allow for all Reich- and ethnic Germans within their areas of interest to emigrate to Germany. This practically meant the end of Germanism in the Baltic States and was at the same time an ominous omen for the fate of the peripheral states, with which the Soviet Union initially only concluded “assistance pacts” that meant the stationing of Soviet troops at fixed points. Equally realistic were the economic agreements, which brought great advantages for both sides: raw materials would flow from the Soviet Union to Germany, and Germany would supply numerous high-quality machinery, including a great deal of war material. Just as the Soviet Union had made possible the beginning of the war, so it was now creating the basis for its continuation.

But far more characteristic than the public or secret arrangements was what was happening in the darkness of the two Polish zones of occupation, and to a considerable extent it was not even known to the Polish government-in-exile in London. On the two sides of the Bug [*Bug, the river*] the two revolutions that had written the annihilation of an enemy on their banners

now worked in close proximity, the original one of 1917 and the reactive one of 1933.

East of the border, what had happened in 1917/18 and what Ribbentrop must have expected when he signed the Secret Additional Protocol was happening. The Red Army proclaimed the “liberation” of the hitherto oppressed Ukrainians and Belarusians, the large estates were confiscated and, it was said, handed over to the peasants; a hunt quickly developed, against the landowners, the officers and the intelligentsia, who were almost exclusively Poles and together made up a numerically significant and culturally leading part of the population. Landowners and officers were often killed on the spot, not infrequently with the help of the local population, and the Polish as well as the Jewish bourgeoisie of the cities, who had initially remained untouched, found themselves exposed to the same measures as the Russian ones after incorporation into the Ukrainian and Belarusian Soviet Republics Bourgeoisie after 1917: expropriations and deportations. A total of one and a half million people are said to have been deported to the interior of the Soviet Union; how many of them perished in the process has never been clarified. All officers who could be found were taken to internment camps, and of the many thousands whose last signs of life escaped to the outside world in the spring of 1940, only about 5,000 were found, but as corpses, shot in the neck by the NKVD, when the German troops discovered the mass graves near Katyn in 1943. Thus the small town near Smolensk became a symbol of those acts of extermination that resulted consistently from the concept of the “class enemy” and could easily be extended to foreign national “enemies of the people.”

But underlying these acts of extermination was a social reality. In the German sphere and in German representations, references to this only appeared very marginally. After the Polish campaign, for example, the Berliner *Illustrierte Zeitung* published a drawing depicting the splendid interior of a Polish magnate’s castle invaded by marauding peasants. In the foreground, however, was the *inexorable national struggle* against Polishness as such. In the vast areas of the “Warthegau,” which were annexed to the Reich, countless small farms were confiscated, and the former owners were assigned to large estates as farm laborers or taken to Germany as “leaderless workers.” In the “General Government” the General Governor Frank, who resided at the Wawel in Krakow, expressly made the extermination of the Polish intelligentsia a program item, and “Einsatzgruppen: of the SS carried out “volks-political tasks,” many of which consisted of indiscriminate shootings and abominable tortures of Poles and Jews. None other than the Commander-in-Chief East, Colonel General Blaskowitz, repeatedly raised sharp protests against the “excessive brutalization and moral depravity” underlying the slaughter of “some 10,000 Jews and Poles,” but he only got severe reproaches from Hitler because of his “childish attitude” to the questions of the national struggle

[*Volkstumskampf*] in the East. Apparently Hitler did not take account the General's observation that the large number of smallholders, who could be won over to the German cause or kept neutral, were being driven into the enemy's camp. For him, the old antagonisms of the national struggle from the time of the *Eastern Marches Society* (*Ostmarkenvereins*) , namely "Germans" and "Poles," were the actual reality, although he would soon speak of "Aryans" and until recently had spoken of "Bolsheviks."

Admittedly, Himmler's ideas of robbing the children of "good-bred" Polish families and sending them to the Reich for "Germanization" meant a new quality. This was the only kind of "liberation" he knew, and so the Germans in Poland did not have a *slogan* like the Red Army had, and the SS measures, as shootings and expropriations, were in substance copies of Soviet methods, but copies lacked any kind of appeal and persuasiveness, because they only knew how to set nation against nation and even aroused bitterness among their own countrymen, who even exclaimed like the then Lieutenant Colonel Helmut Stiff: "I am ashamed to be a German." What had once been consternation and demanded an answer, was now in the process of seeking an outlet in a distorted copy. But the original relation always remained clear, even if when Himmler was thinking about the "treatment of foreign nationals in the East" in the summer of 1940, in which he wanted to reduce the Poles to the status of illiterates and described the Ukrainians and the Gorals as "splinter people," he still believed he was justified in rejecting "the Bolshevik method of physically exterminating a people from inner conviction as un-Germanic and impossible." But of the two horrors that had befallen the unfortunate country, wasn't the older more consistent in itself and more promising in a world where propaganda and disinformation, not the spread of illiteracy was *the order of the day* ?

In any case, one thing could not be denied in view of the events in eastern Poland: that Bolshevism had remained the same in its actions and that it still made sense to speak of "Bolshevization." Adolf Hitler, however, in his appeal to the NSDAP on January 1, 1940, turned his anger exclusively against the "plutocratic powers" and the "Jewish-capitalist world enemy" which was in the process of decline, while the future belonged to the "young nations and systems." This could not be understood in any other way than that he also counted the Soviet Union among the "young systems." And indeed, the most positive statements he made about the Soviet Union, and for the first time in his intimate correspondence, came over the next few months. On March 8, 1940, he wrote to Mussolini that, since Stalin's final victory, Russia had undoubtedly been experiencing a transformation of the Bolshevik principle in the direction of a national Russian way of life, and that in view of this epochal turning point, of which the Reich Foreign Minister was able to tell from his own experience, there was, no

doubt, neither interest nor cause for a fight, especially since the two economic areas complemented each other in an extraordinary way. It was Mussolini who now played the role of a *radical fascist* and implored Hitler not to give up “the anti-Semitic and anti-Bolshevik banner” and to continue striving for the destruction of Bolshevism, which would also bring him the solution to his living space problem. But what chances could he expect from his intervention if the Reich Foreign Minister assured him that on his second visit to Moscow he, like Gauleiter Forster, had had the same impression as if he had spoken “with old party comrades.”

In the meantime, one of the unforeseeable contingencies of the war had caused the first of the great alternatives to emerge, namely, the alternative of a genuine alliance, indeed, even a common destiny between Germany and the Soviet Union. The cause was the first of the imitations with which Stalin, in the course of little more than half a year, repeated Hitler’s methods and successes in his own way and, by invoking defense necessities, historical or geographical circumstances or to the right of self-determination, incorporated more countries and peoples into his empire without a major war then Hitler had been able to do by August 1939. The demands made of Finland in October did not differ very much from those to which the three Baltic States had had to agree, but they involved the cession of Finnish territory on the Karelian Isthmus, for which territorial compensation was offered. Compared with the alleged “threat to Leningrad,” German claims about Czechoslovakia as a Soviet aircraft carrier had been understandable and rational, and the Finns had no weaker sense of *honor* than the Poles. So the Soviet Union used the self-created Mainila Incident—a sort of bigger and more genuine “Gleiwitz”—to open the attack on Finland in late November without declaring war. Stalin, however, was able to do one thing that Hitler could not or would not do: he had a “people’s government” formed, close to the border in the little village of Terijoki, under the leadership of a prominent member of the Comintern, the Finn Otto Kuusinen, , so that the fighting was supposedly not directed against the “Finnish people.” However, almost without exception, the men and women of Finland sided with their *bourgeois* and *reactionary* government, and the Red Army suffered heavy defeats at first. Nevertheless, it may be assumed that sincere hopes were placed in Moscow in the left-socialists and that Kuusinen and his people were not merely using propaganda formulas when they called “bourgeois” Finland a “White Guard hell for the working class”: In 1917/18 the Bolsheviks had indeed been very strong in Finland, and it was only with the help of the Germans that the Whites under General Mannerheim had succeeded in crushing the red troops and asserting rule by methods that were at first very brutal—and in 1939 the same Mannerheim, “Baltic landowner” who had commanded the “White Guards” in 1917/18, stood at the head of the Finnish army as marshal. In Moscow, too, below the level of

diplomatic language and the current problems, the basic emotions of 1917/18 were apparently no less alive than in Berlin. But the situation had become quite different. Germany kept to the Secret Additional Protocol and gave the Soviet Union a free hand in its sphere of influence, but in Sweden and Norway, in England and France and last but not least in America the indignation over this “attack” by a great power on a “small, brave nation” was immense. Here, for the first time, National Socialist Germany and Bolshevik Russia were contrasted as “totalitarian” and rapacious states with the peace-loving democracies, not only in individual scholarly studies, but in a wave of emotions, and in many places the demand for armed intervention was in favor Finland’s was raised. Of course, the same difficulties quickly arose as they had a few months before with Poland: Sweden and Norway, despite their sympathy for Finland, did not want to give the Allied troops the right of passage. But the Allied general staffs envisaged a violation of neutrality without much scruple, especially since it harmonized with a much more far-reaching plan: the plan to destroy the Soviet oil fields near Baku by air raids and thereby deprive Germany of that de facto allied supply area without which it could not have continued the war. If these plans had been realized, Germany and the Soviet Union would have been locked together for better or for worse, and the war would have taken an entirely different course. Nothing is more improbable than that it would have ended with a rapid collapse of the two totalitarian states, as was imagined in London and Paris. But after the Soviet Union had thrown enormous numbers of troops into the fray, the war found a happier ending for them in March. The peace treaty of March 12 placed the new frontier at a considerably greater distance from Leningrad, but Kuusinen had to be dropped, and the inglorious course of the war confirmed that underestimation of the Red Army on both the Allied and German sides which was to determine the subsequent history of World War II to a great extent.

At the same time as the alternative in the north, an alternative in the west had also emerged. In autumn Hitler urged a rapid attack on France, violating the neutrality of Belgium and Holland, and strong opposition to this developed among the generals, which was mainly based on the memory of World War I and the high esteem in which the French army was held. A clear awareness of the shortcomings that the hasty rearmament had brought with it, and above all the lack of “deep armament” gave additional weight to the arguments of high commanders such as Colonel General von Leeb and von Rundstedt.

But for part of the opposition, it was precisely the new friendship with the Soviet Union was the strongest argument of all. Never before had Germany been so far from its best traditions and so close to Bolshevism as it was after six years of Hitler’s regime, according to a memorandum written by Hasso von Etzdorf, the Foreign Office’s liaison to the Army High

Command. This regime had succeeded in handing over 20 million people over to Bolshevism, and it had seriously endangered the promising possibilities of a German policy of revision with the nonsensical and superfluous “march on the Hradschin.” Only after the fall of Hitler’s regime was it possible to achieve “moderation in success” along the lines of Bismarck, which alone could secure Germany within its ethnographic borders and its legitimate influence in Central Europe, and at the same time correspond to the most elementary interests of the western powers, namely the interest in a prevent further expansion of Bolshevism in Europe. Contacts were indeed made with the English government which looked promising, and for a time it looked as if Colonel General von Brauchitsch, the Commander-in-Chief of the Army, would put himself at the head of a conspiracy. Next to the alternative of the war alliance of the “young systems” against the worn-out peoples of the West came the other alternative of the great agreement between the civilized states of Europe after the successful conclusion of the revision of Versailles in the sense of the right to self-determination, an alternative within which Hitler and his party advocated would have been a temporarily useful tool. And even the Soviet Union need not have feared such an agreement as much as a possible peace agreement between Hitler and the Western powers, which it seemed to promote through its own statements.

But had not Bismarck also had to fight the battle against Austria before he could show moderation at Nikolsburg? Was Hitler only a politician among other politicians who could be overthrown without his party revolting? Were England and France really only fighting against a hubris that wanted to “conquer the world by force,” or were they not fighting against Germany as the hegemonic power of Central Europe, as von Etzdorf drew it? It was hardly mere coincidences that prevented the second and peaceful alternative from coming about.

Hitler was probably right when he said in his speech to the commanders-in-chief on November 23, 1939 that the chances of victory over France were much better today than at the beginning of the Ludendorff offensive of 1918, and that the whole thing does not mean a single action, but the end of the world war. If one recalls the innumerable predictions made by various quarters in 1918 and 1919, including Rosa Luxemburg, that a violent peace—be it against Russia or against Germany—would only be an armistice and would bring about a new war as certain as the germ takes root in a plant, then the audience really had to ask themselves whether Hitler, in his irrepressible will to win, was not really the embodiment of the will of history and the spirit of the German nation, however great the longing for peace among the Germans and even more so among the French had always been. At the same time, however, the generals must have been horrified by this embodiment of the *spirit of the people* and this *will of history* when they heard Hitler say: “They will accuse me of fighting and

fighting again. I see in the fight the fate of all beings... It is an eternal problem to bring the number of Germans in proportion to the soil... No cleverness helps here, solution only with the sword... Today we can speak of a race struggle. Today we fight for oil fields, rubber, mineral resources, etc... I want to destroy the enemy... I will stand or fall in this struggle. I would not survive the defeat of my people. No surrender on the outside, no revolution on the inside.” Here was a man willing to risk everything and who seemed to know nothing but total victory or total annihilation. How could one expect moderation in victory from him?

And did not the will for such a victory in itself mean a defeat against Marxism? Hitler spoke exactly as the capitalist states acted, according to Marxist thesis, in their struggles for the treasures of the world. And didn’t he nonetheless reveal himself as a semi-Marxist when he attacked especially frequently the “Judeo-capitalist world,” the money magnates, the “Jewish and non-Jewish international bank barons” during these months? Was not his better socialism, the “social people’s community of Germany” with its social welfare and its elimination of class differences, to be based, in his own words, simply on that conquest of living space, since every crowding together of masses in narrow and export-oriented industrial areas must produce communism? Was not his “reasonable solution” which he recommended to the English, because otherwise sooner or later the “solution of madness” would appear, namely Bolshevism (as one undoubtedly had to understand), even unreasonable to a particularly high degree?

And so Hitler showed himself to be only apparently reasonable and moderate when he brought the planned Norway operation of the English to failure, which was supposed to cut him off from indispensable raw materials, by his own enterprise of almost unbelievable audacity and then forced France to surrender in an unprecedented victory run between May 10th and June 23rd. The “peace offer” that he made to the English in his Reichstag speech of July 19 was so vague and framed so much by triumphalism on the one hand and the most violent polemics on the other that it would probably have been accepted only by Oswald Mosley, whom many had believed to be the future Prime Minister of England before his fascist days, but who was now in prison. However, at the head of England was not even Lord Lothian, who might have initiated negotiations, but Winston Churchill, and therein lay one of the strangest paradoxes of this war. Churchill had not only been the most resolute of all anti-Bolsheviks in England, but in his peculiar relationship to the war he was also the most comparable of all Englishmen to Hitler. But now he wanted to deliver the world of “Hitler’s dark curse” with the same persuasiveness as he had once wanted to free it of Bolshevism, and now spoke of the Gestapo in similar terms as he had earlier spoken of the Cheka. Not only had he gone from anti-Bolshevism to anti-totalitarianism, but he also embraced the old

English concept of equilibrium and fought *the Germans* as hard as he did *the Nazis*. How hard he could fight became clear immediately after the armistice, when he did not hesitate to have the main part of the French fleet, which had just been allied, destroyed at Mersel-Kebir because their possible defection to the Germans would have been a “mortal danger” and thus, one may add, would have presented another alternative in the vicissitudes of this war. But if on May 13th, for three days the Prime Minister, he had meant that without victory there would be no survival for the British Empire, then, as it turned out, he was in the wrong vis-à-vis Hitler, who predicted to him on July 19 that if his offer of peace was rejected, a great empire would be destroyed. And the strangest paradox of this war was that Hitler, presumably out of love for the English world empire, had given Churchill the chance of a successful defense of the island when, at the end of May, he ordered the armored troops to stop at Dunkirk, thus saving the English expeditionary force from annihilation. The question is therefore whether the RAF fighter pilots or the weather or, rather, Anglophile Hitler saved England. But when “Operation Sea Lion” had to be postponed indefinitely in September, Hitler found himself in an extremely difficult situation, despite his great victory, and the Soviet Union was primarily responsible for this.

For if it had continued to imitate Hitler, and no longer met with serious censure from England for this, but rather with a desperate effort to improve relations and bring about entry into the war against Germany. After ultimatums, the Soviet Union militarily occupied the Baltic states in June and annexed them after the usual *Sovietization*; in July it forced Romania to cede Bessarabia by threatening to attack and—beyond the wording of the Secret Additional Protocol—Northern Bukovina. This brought it very close to the Ploesti oil field, which was absolutely essential for the German war economy. Various signs indicated that further demands would be made of Finland, which would also entail annexation. Above all, experience had shown that the Soviet Union reduced, interrupted or increased its supplies of raw materials, depending on the circumstances. The suspicion had to arise that while they wanted to keep Hitler in the war, they were trying with all their might to prevent his definitive victory.

Setting aside the specific premises, conditions, and circumstances, and refraining from moral judgement, the situation of the autumn of 1940 was neither accidental nor unnatural. It meant that the Versailles system had definitely come to an end, and that the two largest peoples of the continent, Germans and Russians, together with their client states or dependent territories, now played the pre-eminent role which by their very *nature* they deserved far more than France after 1919. The sentence that Stalin formulated in 1949 could have been said even now, namely that these two peoples “possessed the greatest potential in Europe for carrying

out major actions of world importance.” But there had never been a comparable situation, not even in the Napoleonic era, because other great powers had always existed on the continent, and this was the only way England’s “balance policy” was possible, which helped the weaker powers to assert themselves against the stronger ones.

In principle, the German-Russian system could have been as stable as the 19th century pentarchy had been, provided that the terms of the treaty were observed and neither power intruded, even through propaganda, in the sphere of the other. But one of the two powers was at war, at war against an island on the edge of Europe that was still in possession of a world empire and which was backed by an apparently neutral but in fact already partially belligerent great power. Many Englishmen might think they were fighting for the old balance, but in fact, supported by the United States, they were fighting for the survival of a political-ideological system that had been common to Europe and now seemed to have been eliminated all throughout Europe.

But even if this had not perished in Germany and had prevailed in Russia, since the supremacy of the two powers victorious in 1919 had only come about through a *normal*, albeit warlike, development, the responsible leadership of the German Reich could have acted no than Hitler did now: it would have had contingency plans drawn up by its high command for a war against Russia, and at the same time it would have been working towards a reliable arrangement. The situation in which the neutral state could at any time cut off the basic sources of life of the belligerent state was intolerable. Such sources of life were above all Romanian oil, but also Finnish nickel and the “calmness in the Baltic Sea” in general. At the same time, the Soviet Union, for its part, was undoubtedly entitled to complain about encroachments in its sphere of interest. After the cession of Bessarabia and Northern Bukovina to the Soviet Union and large parts of Transylvania to Hungary, Romania, one of the main winners within the Versailles system, was reduced to its narrowest ethnographic boundaries and the Axis powers, without consultation with the Soviet Union, gave it a guarantee that Moscow was apparently perceived as a breach of contract and an affront. Moreover, German “training troops” were sent into the country. Equally serious was the fact that German troops were also in Finland, albeit supposedly only temporarily and in transit to northern Norway. Other problems were the Straits question and Bulgaria, old targets of Russian politics.

Hitler commissioned his General Staff to work out the military contingency plans for the “elimination” of Russia as early as the end of July 1940, when apparently “Sea Lion” operation was being prepared with all forces; the general arrangement, which after all cannot

be ruled out, was on the program of Molotov's visit to Berlin from November 12 to 14. It provided for the Soviet Union's accession to the Tripartite Pact signed on September 27 between Germany, Japan and Italy, which was a defensive alliance against the United States and contained no territorial provisions, but which was to be revised in such a way to grant each of the four powers vast space as a sphere of influence and secured a share in the "bankrupt estate" of the British Empire. It was thus a plan for the "redivision of the world" among new and emerging great powers, of which there was so much talk in Marxist theory, and to the Soviet Union was allotted the most valuable, yet most remote, part of the loot, namely India. Molotov's attitude was by no means hostile, but he brought the conversation with great emphasis to the problems at hand, and he was honest enough to answer a question from Hitler that he envisaged the "purge" of Finland "to the same extent as in Bessarabia and in the peripheral states." Fourteen days later, the Soviet Union also declared in writing and officially that it was ready to join the four-power pact, but it repeated its demands for Finland, Bulgaria and a military base on the Straits, and in addition it demanded the modification that the center of gravity of its aspirations be recognized as the area south of Batum and Baku in the general direction of the Persian Gulf, i.e., it demanded dominion over the petroleum regions of the Near East. Hitler did not dignify this letter with a reply, and he finally had the operational plan "Barbarossa" drawn up, which envisaged crushing the Soviet Union in a rapid campaign. It is difficult to see why Stalin and Molotov did not regard the absence of a reply for what it was, namely the announcement of the military alternative, but they were engaged in a tremendous effort of preparation for war anyway, and they expected, apparently, that Hitler would eventually make them an ultimate offer of negotiation.

If Hitler's decision had been merely of a power politics nature, one might certainly have expected a final attempt of this kind. But Hitler was like a plant with roots of different lengths. The mere calculation of power politics, which any other statesman could have taken his place in, went just as little deep into the earth as the motive of the revision policy. Deeper layers reached the roots that made him say to Mussolini that he wanted to settle the South Tyroleans in a beautiful area that he did not yet have but would certainly get, while at the same time portraying Stalin as an "absolute autocrat" (and thus a reliable partner).

Most characteristic of him, however, was that towards the end of 1940 he rediscovered Bolshevism and even "Jewish Bolshevism" i.e., as it were from the depths into which he had pushed him back into clear consciousness. Thus, on November 20, 1940, he said to the Hungarian Prime Minister, Count Teleki, that Russia would be either Bolshevik or national-Russian, depending on the situation. And on December 3, in a conversation with the Bulgarian envoy Draganoff, the author of "Mein Kampf" was again clearly recognizable. He

did not want Romania and Bulgaria to become a “Bolshevized desert” like the Baltic States today, where the intelligentsia and the middle class have been wiped out and incompetent commissars put in their place. “He described in a strong way the terrorist conditions, the transportations of intelligentsia that never arrived, being shot in the trains. The conditions there, he said, were simply horrific by European standards. It was the same in Galicia... In Bessarabia, too, while our people were still there, landowners and other members of the leading classes were slaughtered by their own incited people led by the Jews, and the same was flourishing in the Balkans.” Even in the Straits question, the Russians are not just concerned with the bases, they want “to carry out their Bolshevization from the bases.”

Thus by the end of 1940 it was clear that, in view of the continuing war with England, the new European system would not be in the German-Russian system, but that after a decisive struggle either only the Germans or only the Russians would be the supreme power, unless they eventually reached a compromise peace, or the Anglo-Saxons revitalized democracy and an analogue of the Versailles system in part of Europe. But given Hitler’s different motives and the strong traditions on which they were each based, this said nothing about the nature of the warfare. A decisive power politics struggle would look different from an anti-Bolshevik *crusade*, and a war under the banner of *liberation* would have to be essentially different from a campaign to win *living space*. The planning of the last months already gave significant information, but only the events in the second half of 1941 made a final judgment possible.

First, however, some of the strangest coincidences of this war changed the initial situation. At the end of October 1940, just out of an ill ambition, Mussolini attacked Greece without consulting Hitler and suffered an unexpected defeat in the border area of Albania. At the same time, as Italian troops failed to hold their own in North Africa, English confidence rose considerably and German intervention became inevitable. It was now obvious that Italy was no longer the smaller *Axis partner*, but one of Germany’s auxiliary and satellite states. In early April, a small number of officers staged a coup in Yugoslavia against the Cvetković government, which, like Bulgaria before it, had joined the Tripartite Pact, and the Soviet Union immediately backed the new Simovic government by signing a non-aggression and friendship pact. Against this, the German Wehrmacht embarked on one of its triumphant lightning campaigns, and within a few weeks the whole of the Balkans and even Crete were in Hitler’s hands. But he had to use some of the forces that were intended for “Barbarossa” and the scheduled date could not be met.

The European prelude to the Second World War was now coming to an end, even though quite a few on the German side were waiting until the last moment for the start of decisive

talks which, according to all human standards, would have led to major concessions and promises by the Soviet Union. If one abstracted from the circumstances, one might say that not only was the character of this war not settled, but neither fixed was the conduct of the English, nor especially of the Americans. It could not be ruled out a priori that Germany would ally itself with the anti-Bolshevik or anti-Russian forces likely to persist in the Soviet Union, and it was even less unlikely that in America Lenin's thesis of the "robbers getting into each other's hair" would have come to prevail in a paradoxical reversal of meaning.

But it was not *Germany* and *Russia* that went to war on June 22, but Bolshevik Russia and National Socialist Germany, which—in very different ways—were both a nightmare and a role model for each other. It is therefore time, before describing the main features of the war and after describing the history since 1918 and the interactions since 1933, to make some of the structures of the systems a comparative subject. The Soviet Union, as the older of the two systems, will always have to come first, and the supranational appeal that is inherent in every ideology and calls for civil war will have to be emphasized just as much as the national peculiarities, which no ideology can completely eliminate.

Chapter IV, Section 1

The State Parties and Their Leaders

No thought was further from the vanguard of the early *workers' movement* than that one day socialist state parties with a leader or a small governing body at their head would completely dominate a state. At least the representatives of *communal socialism* like Fourier and Owen had drawn the exact opposite conclusion from the rudimentary antithesis between state and society, in that they wanted the state to be completely displaced by society, but by a society that would consist of countless communes, the phalansters, or “villages of unity and cooperation,” where people would lead lives freed from all barriers of nationality, division of labor, and religious superstition, because each of the small communities would a self-sufficient and manageable cosmos. It is striking that this idea was nothing else than a countermove to that *new* thing, which soon after 1800 was often called the “Industrial Revolution”: the emergence of an extraordinarily mobile and agitated system of economic relations that entailed a high degree of risk and uncertainty to everyone involved, but which also opened up unheard-of opportunities for success, which in turn were linked far more tied to organization than to what was traditionally called *work* —the system of the rising world market economy, which is often referred to as the competitive system and later as the capitalist mode of production. To deny this newness and the realities associated with it, such as profit and interest as well as the difference between entrepreneurs and workers, was the main characteristic of the emerging workers’ movement and not just of communal socialism. On the other hand, however, this workers’ movement, which gradually formed as journeyman craftsmen and the peasant population shifted to industrial cities, was itself a new element, and as obviously Fourier and Owen oriented themselves towards a horticultural idyll, their claim to represent a “social science” and to unreservedly approve of the technology insofar as it could be used to make work easier in the phalansters was modern. Other thinkers, however, clearly recognized the backward-looking, past-oriented aspect of communal socialism, and they replaced it with the idea of a state socialism that extrapolated

other characteristics of the Industrial Revolution and postulated a logical completion: in place of the “anarchy of production” was to be a planned economy, in which the state, as the only entrepreneur, would take care of the well-being of all individuals. But here, too, competition eliminated individual profits and any kind of rent-income, so that *society* had to divide and regulate work. Consequently, one could not dispense with concepts such as the *division of labor* and *authority*, and the existence of a governing state party was no longer inconceivable. But even state socialism took up ideas that intended the exact opposite, namely the elimination of the sources of strife between states as well as between individuals, and these sources were considered to be the private property of individuals or groups, the existence of armed and punitive formations within the antagonistic states, greed for money, subordination of individuals to material necessities that limited their *happiness*. In this way, state socialism, like communal socialism, made a connection with the age-old concept of the *state of nature*, in which, according to the teachings of ancient philosophers and also Christian Fathers of the Church, all these marks were present before they were destroyed by a fall or an intrusion of greed. But none of the state socialists, neither Louis Blanc nor Constantin Pecqueur, was able to show convincingly that the states, as the only entrepreneurs, would *not* have private property, and among the opponents of the socialists, indeed among the socialists themselves, the suspicion arose early on that the desired abolition of all power could lead to a hitherto unknown concentration of power. The emergence of a *workers’ movement* was of the highest historical necessity, since it was directly connected with the most revolutionary event in modern European history, the Industrial Revolution; but its further development did not exhibit the same degree of necessity: the workers’ movement could, within the framework of the system to which it owed its origin, seek the best possible conditions for its adherents, as the English “trade unions” did from their inception; it could make itself the champion of a completely different system, the basic outline of which was based on archaic ideas and yet partly pointed to a probable future; it could, finally, rid itself in practice or even in theory of the idea of humanity, to which it was so closely attached to in its early days, and thus become a state socialism of a special kind. It was to be assumed that these tendencies would coexist and wrestle with one another, without the need for the demarcation lines to remain clearly fixed. In any case, the workers’ movement as such and in its various directions had to play an important part in further development if it took up the banner of the demand for the introduction of universal suffrage, which seemed to be the victorious slogan of the century. But weren’t new differences bound to arise within *the* labor movement when the different states had quite different attitudes towards universal suffrage, when absolute, semi-absolute, and democratic-liberal countries had to be distinguished?

It is not possible to show at this point to what extent Marxism wanted to be a synthesis of the

reformist tendencies, aiming at patience and affirming capitalism at least for the immediate present, of the cosmopolitan-naturalist and state-socialist tendencies in the workers' movement, and yet it continued to carry contradictions within itself. But it pointed far into the future that the most determined enemies of the state and of authority among socialists, Bakunin's anarchists, understood Marxism from the outset as a form of authoritarian and dictatorial state socialism. But hardly any Marxists took Bakunin's critique seriously or were troubled by ambivalence when, in 1890, the Second International—a federation of Marxist parties—proclaimed May 1 as the universal Labor Day, thereby claiming to redeem working humanity from the shackles of capitalism and imperialism in the near future.

And yet it quickly became obvious even for the most convinced Marxists that serious distinctions had to be made in the “army of the world proletariat” when social-democratic parties from the sphere of the Russian Empire knocked on the doors of the International. The “Social Democratic Party of the Kingdom of Poland and Lithuania,” founded in 1894 and led by Rosa Luxemburg, Leo Jogiches and Felix Dserschinsky, firmly rejected the demand for national self-determination because they considered the Russian economic area to be progressive and therefore wanted to wage its struggle only within its framework; the “Polish Socialist Party” under Josef Pilsudski, on the other hand, saw the achievement of Poland's independence as the indispensable first phase, since national freedom was the prerequisite for social liberation. Representatives of the two competing *workers' parties*, which understood such a different view of the relationship between the national and the social element and between the economic and the political factors, and which were led by descendants of the petty aristocracy or the bourgeoisie, therefore clashed with great hostility at congresses of the International. Not even the workers' party in Russia proper was free from comparable differences, because in 1897 *The Bund (aka General Jewish Labor Bund in Lithuania, Poland and Russia)* was first founded, the union of the Jewish workers of Ruthenia and the Ukraine, who although had a strongly developed “class consciousness” at their disposal, were almost always in crafts or small industrial firms and differed from the Russian workers in that their rest from work fell on the Sabbath. It was not until a year later that the Russians follow suit with a founding congress in Minsk, which, however, was only attended by a few delegates and was by no means representative. The more striking development took place in emigration, where since the 1880s there had existed the

At this point, neither the internal party disputes after the seizure of power nor the organizational developments can be followed in detail. Rather, some general characteristics of the party should be emphasized, which were repeatedly confirmed, or at least unfolded, in these processes.

The “Communist Party of the Russian Socialist Federative Soviet Republic (Bolsheviks),” as it called itself from the summer of 1918, was from November 1917 the world’s first socialist party to rule alone. Since the spring, taking power alone had been Lenin’s real intention, and it was only for this reason that he allowed the armed insurrection to take place on the eve of the Second Congress of Soviets, which would undoubtedly have installed an all-party socialist government. The temporary alliance with the Left SRs was merely tactical, and by the end of the civil war Lenin’s view that the proper place for Mensheviks and SRs was in prison found little opposition within the party.

This ruling party, however, was and remained a minority party. At the most favorable of times it won barely a quarter of the votes in the Constituent Assembly elections, and when War Communism made the downside of Bolshevik rule all too evident for almost all peasants and for very many workers, even the Mensheviks won back most of the supporters they had lost in the autumn of 1917. But the ruling party had long since established unequal and open suffrage, and it could now jail or shoot its opponents at will. In the Smolensk district in 1921 there were only 10,000 party members out of a population of two million, and it was not until collectivization that observers credibly reported that the party resembled an army in an occupied country.

However, this party was by no means concerned with simply maintaining power. As the “grain” or “little heap” that it was, it remained dominated by the unconditional will for total transformation, which of course was presumably the prerequisite for maintaining power. So it was the party of social annihilation and the protracted civil war. Trotsky characterized Lenin’s ideas as “terrible, astoundingly naive, deadly thoughts,” and the minority appealed to the basic emotions of the vast majority when it directed all the bitterness and hatred that had accumulated in the masses of soldiers and workers during the war against the “Burschui” [*bourgeoisie*] and the officers. But the party could not stop at the destruction of what Lenin called the “flabby” bourgeoisie and the talkative intelligentsia, because there were other *pre-Marxist* realities in the country, and it was by no means merely *Stalinist* when, starting in 1928, they launched the great civil war against the peasants, talking about kulaks and meaning individual management of every kind. Not even the great purge can be attributed to Stalin alone, for since 1921 the party had undergone periodic purges, and the aim had always been to unmask “socially hostile elements” that had wormed their way into the party and acted contrary to the directives of the leadership through sabotage or criticism.

But the party of social destruction saw itself as the party of progress, and in certain areas not even its most determined enemies could dispute that claim. It taught the illiterate to read and

write, it campaigned against filth, “culturelessness” and alcoholism; it did not shrink from “washing, cleaning, ruffling and kneading” the proletarians and ordinary party members, to quote Lenin’s words; it propagated the “scientific spirit” against superstition, and it noted with deep satisfaction that even in Lubavitchi, a center of the “darkest” Hasidic spirit, some craftsmen no longer kept the Sabbath. So it was not surprising that Bukharin and Pyatakov refused to give up their faith in the party even after they had been the victims of the worst slanders and faced death: whoever left the party, left the best part of his own life, slipping out of the streak of history into the brackish waters of an indifferent private existence.

But no determination, no enthusiasm and no progressiveness would have preserved the party’s power and thus the possibility of action if it had not remained the party of the organization Lenin had made it into. The chain of command extended from the Politburo and the Central Committee and its secretariat via the party committees of the regions (*oblast*) and districts (*rayony*) to the committees of the towns and villages, where a “first secretary” played the most important role everywhere, if only because he administered the *nomenklatura* , which contained the positions and names up for *election* to the subordinate bodies. No matter how the composition of the Politburo changed, the decisive directives emanated from it, and no matter how many members of the party were expelled in the purges, “party cells” were nevertheless to be found in every major school, in all factories, in all universities: in all regiments of the Red Army and in all subdivisions of the GPU, reporting to and receiving instructions from the higher leadership. In the army, commissars were assigned to officers, who were politically subordinate to a main department in the army command; in every machine-tractor station there was a “Political Department,” which included a special representative of the GPU. So the party had its eyes and ears everywhere, and all these eyes and ears checked and rechecked each other and were checked by other and relatively independent bodies such as the GPU. Unlike all the other parties in the world, this party not only wielded political power but directed—and in a sense owned—the entire economic life of the country. It therefore had to be omnipotent, and it called this omnipotence socialism, which of course had not yet fulfilled its final task, namely to abolish all power of men over men and all obstacles to the development of each. For the time being, the strongest of all states, the party-economy state, remained the prerequisite for future statelessness, but opponents were not the only ones who might ask themselves whether this most right-wing of all left-wing parties from the outset had remained left-wing in its dreams and mythologies, but in reality had created the most efficient of all state power structures that could ever be found on earth. Thus this party looked Janus-faced with keen eyes in the direction of present realities and took the place in a state-socialist developmental dictatorship which, within a much more relaxed structure, was filled by the economic bourgeoisie of the liberal system;

but it also looked into the distant future with a dreamy look and continued to be the party of militant universalism, which believed that it could sweep away all barriers and bigotries simply by the storm its arguments.

But whether it actually united the extremes or merely made one a pretext for the other, it did not necessarily had to have a *führer* but could be directed by a central body whose members remained anonymous. But when in 1937 Stalin compared the party to an army and equated the approximately 3,000 higher party leaders with the general staff, the 40,000 middle ranks with the officer corps and the 150,000 simple party employees with the non-commissioned officers, it was obviously self-evident for him that he was the generalissimo of this army. Certainly Lenin understood the “leader organization” to mean a collective, but from the very beginning he was the first in this collective, and one might ask, like Trotsky, even in the earliest period, whether he was really the first among equals. As early as 1918, newspaper articles and assembly speeches called him “the leader” [*führer*] (“Vozhdj”) of the Russian proletariat and the world proletariat as a matter of course, and as in the feudal system, his closest followers were also given the title “leader” (*führer*) with a regional limitation; so Zinoviev was called the “Leader of the Northern Commune.” The party rallies gave ovations to “*Führer* Ilyich,” which, of course, always meant “Comrade Lenin.” In fact, throughout his life Lenin could not make any essential decision alone, but always had to secure majorities in the Politburo and at party congresses, often with hard struggles and arguments. But very soon after his death, Trotsky was hailing him as “the greatest man of our revolutionary epoch,” and the same man touched on one of the most peculiar problems of Marxism when he claimed that Lenin was the only genius besides Marx to stand out among the leaders of the working class; to be sure even without these geniuses the class would do justice to its world-historical tasks, “but more slowly.” If another statement of Trotsky’s is held next to it, namely that the Bolsheviks would never have seized power without Lenin’s urging, since the bourgeoisie would then soon have made peace and changed the situation substantially, one might arrive at the conclusion that both the new state as well as the Russian working class were created by this one genius. It is therefore permissible to assert that the Communist Party of Soviet Russia was also a “leader’s party” [*Führerpartei*] in a narrower sense from its early days, indeed that it developed a true leader cult [*Führerkult*] which, in view of the Lenin mausoleum, was often called a by sympathetic observers “the cult of relics” and compared to religious phenomena. But after the death of the “genius leader” could the party now be collectively run by average people? Lev Kamenev found very little favor when he spoke out against the notion of “one-man leadership” and against the “creation of a leader” at the 14th congress. Stalin, in his position as Party Secretary-General, the only one to be a member of the four main upper bodies at the same time—the Politburo, the Central Committee, the

Secretariat, and the Org(anization)bureau—had effectively succeeded Lenin and as early as 1926 his statues could be found in many places in the Soviet Union. It soon became customary to speak of “the party and its leader Stalin,” and public speeches no longer lacked references to the greatness of Stalin’s leadership that were much applauded. Trotsky ingeniously reversed the accusation that had once been leveled at himself and accused *Stalinism* as a Bonapartist regime, but he ignored the fact that Martov had leveled the same accusation against Lenin before the war. It was part of the nature of the party that a single man should be at its head, wielding an unusual degree of power. Nonetheless, both Lenin and Stalin were always seen only as personifications of the party, even formally of the class, no matter how curious the second provision seemed in view of the origins and precedents of both. That the party finally extended its elementary intention of annihilation to itself, i.e. those members who rebelled against the leader were probably decided in the concept of this party, however accidental the extent of the great purge might be. The situation is different, however, with the fact that Stalin finally—probably from 1937 onward—needed the approval of no body for his decisions except formally, and towards the end of his life he often no longer even considered the mere convening of the Politburo to be necessary. This violated the spirit of the party, which always remained collectivist even when submitting to the will of a leader. But the thinking of the National Socialist Party was also collectivist, although it was based on a completely different tradition and was undoubtedly a *Führerpartei* in a different sense.

The workers’ movement, in its largest and most influential part, had placed itself in the tradition that counted the French Revolution and especially its Jacobin phase among its origins. The opposite tradition was that of the Right, which saw the French Revolution as above all dissolution, disintegration and chaos. It was easy to see in Abbé Barre’s conspiracy theory, in Edmund Burke’s defense of organic development, in Joseph de Maistre’s labeling of the Revolution as “satanic” and in Adam Müller’s attacks on the Roman legal concept of private property and private religion nothing more than a defense of *feudalism* and thus the interests of the nobility against *modernity*. But if the Industrial Revolution, though not rootless, was primarily new, the French Revolution was something *old and new*, and as early as 1793 former liberals used to label it terms that had previously applied to quite different opponents, such as “despotic synod,” “missionaries,” and “inquisition courts.” In their eyes, therefore, that which presented itself as progressive was regressive, and conversely the conservative writers soon learned to use pamphlets and demagogic attacks. The historical reality of Europe did not know *pure progress*, which would have been embodied by concrete persons, and *pure reaction*, which could be described by specific names, but was determined by overshooting, polyvalences, mixed forms, appropriations and rethinking, and it therefore

showed, including the French Revolution, only incomplete revolutions and incomplete reaction periods. Who in the 19th century could have accomplished more *objectively progressive* deeds than the *subjective reactionaries* Robert Peel, Louis Bonaparte, Otto von Bismarck and Benjamin Disraeli? Thus, the anti-Semitism of the Wilhelmine period was a modernization of the traditional conspiracy theory, and the Social Darwinist ideas of the turn of the century were not exclusively an instrument of defense of the national-liberal bourgeoisie, but they found support in new scientific findings such as Francis Galton's theory of the heritability of characteristics. But just as the Left, in all its transformations and guises, remained recognizable by an affinity to the doctrine of the liberation of individuals into unstructured *pure* humanity, so the Right was always shaped by the fear of possible social *chaos* as well as the despotism that would eventually result. This fear was the complement of the conviction that tradition-bound order and thus institutionalized hierarchies were the most elementary basis of human coexistence. Therefore, from early on, the Right also tended towards the concept of annihilation, the concept of eliminating the "conspirators" or the originators of the decomposition, and in a man like Eugen Dühring it appeared openly around 1900 in the turn against the Jews as a vermin race. But Dühring in particular came from the Left, and the older the Right became, the more originally leftist traits it absorbed. However, it remained identical to herself in all changes as long as *order* took *precedence* over liberation. Of course, order could never be a concept of humanity in the same sense as liberation to peace and informality, because the term was by no means so supra-temporal and always had to be based on an existing order, but it nevertheless became virulent in all periods of history when the shaking of the existing situation seemed unbearable to a large number of people and the fear of the dissolution of society spread. It was to be assumed that this concept could only become effective on a mass scale in the 20th century if it was combined with the concept of liberation.

Consequently, after the great catalyst of the First World War, unexpected opportunities were bound to open up for a *left-right party* in those countries where the existing order was not as widely discredited as the autocracy in Russia, and where it was not as solid and untouched as that of the victorious Western powers. First to assert itself was a new type of party in Italy, which lamented a "mutilated victory": a party supported by large sections of the middle classes, backed by the upper classes and founded by former Marxists and leftists, Fascism. German National Socialism already indicated the left-wing tendency in its name, and in its program it demanded the "abolition of laborless and effortless income," it adopted the former radical leftist demand for the homogeneity of the people and nevertheless represented the position of extreme liberalism with the idea of free play of forces. But the stronger and more credible was the basic right-wing pattern: belief in the stab in the back of enemies and

conspirators, hatred of the agitators of the Marxist left, orientation towards past greatness, the characterization of the French Revolution as a “terrible volcanic eruption,” and resolute clinging to *one’s own* . Thus the National Socialist party was of a fascist type and more precisely a radical fascist party. But it would probably have remained a group torn apart by factional struggles among other groups, if it had not been headed by a man, who in discussions with his closest confidante, stretched Bolshevism “from Moses to Lenin” and who rejected all compromises, including those with the “völkish wandering scholars” no less decisively than Lenin had done toward the Mensheviks and the Social Revolutionaries. He created the ideology of his party just as little as Lenin created that of his own, but he too set the decisive accents and formulated the most authoritative sentences. Above all, however, in this party of former war veterans who identified with their past and wanted to liberate Germany by destroying the *enemies of the people* he won a different position than Lenin could and wanted to hold in his party of émigrés and war-weary soldiers.

Adolf Hitler was born two notches below Lenin in the social hierarchy and never attended university or college; in terms of origin and educational background he showed similarities with Stalin, if one disregards his artistic inclinations and abilities. But the *German Workers’ Party* , which he joined in 1919, was far removed from the conspiratorial nature of the Bolshevik Party and offered greater opportunities for a popular orator from the outset, since it arose in a comparatively free and liberal society. On the other hand, however, it was characterized by its proximity to the Freikorps, and their principle was not merely military, but far more archaic as the personal and direct attachment of relatively few men to their respective leader. Thus, the democratic principle of decision-making through general meetings and the command principle initially existed side by side, and the story of Hitler, who in the beginning was merely the seventh member of the executive committee as a “head of propaganda,” is a story of the expansion of the leadership power, similar to that of Mussolini.

But even after the transfer of “dictatorial powers” from 1921 onwards, Hitler, in stark contrast to Lenin, was not involved in any kind of central committee; the command principle triumphed very early on over the democratic principle of election and discussion. At first, however, he still had mentors and fellow fighters of equal standing, but the putsch of November 1923 was entirely his own work, which was not decided or even confirmed by any party committee. After the party’s re-establishment, Hitler had to overcome numerous difficulties vis-à-vis the North German wing, but he also won over the protagonist of the Führer cult, Joseph Goebbels, from the ranks of these *leftists* . Until 1930, the “Supreme SA Leader” Franz Pfeffer von Salomon still held a relatively independent position, but then

Hitler personally took over the leadership of what was by far the most important branch of the party. More than any other German party, far more than the Bolsheviks before they seized power, the NSDAP already had the character of a state within a state around 1930, and the cult of the leader (*Führerkult*) was the most important integrating factor of the party, in which very different tendencies had come together. But Hitler's objective superiority repeatedly emerged, to whom men like Hess, Himmler and Goebbels were extremely devoted, while the public still regarded him as a "pale replica" of Mussolini.

Thus Hitler, who was not a member of the Reichstag, was appointed to the state office of Reich Chancellor on January 30, 1933, as the leader of the National Socialist movement. Therefore, from the very beginning, despite his oath to the constitution, he was not only one factor among several factors, but he had a decisive advantage because he was the undisputed leader of the National Socialist popular movement and thus led its state-shielded revolution, which saw itself primarily as a counter-revolution. From August 1934 at the latest, the will of the Führer was the supreme law, and thus the decision on war and peace, for which a Reich law was required according to the Weimar Constitution, fell solely within the competence of Adolf Hitler. Lenin was far from possessing such absolute power, and since 1937 Stalin had, at most, *de facto*. Therefore, in 1939, there could not be the slightest doubt that Hitler alone was responsible for the war against Poland, and only around his forehead was woven the laurels of victory.

The characterization of the Führer's power by the National Socialist jurists was to a good extent quasi-theological and mystical. The leader, they said, is an embodiment of the actual will of the people and thus the advocate of the "objective idea of the nation against the subjective arbitrariness of a misguided popular mood." His office is indivisible, his power is "not restricted by safeguards and controls, by autonomous areas of protection and well-acquired individual rights, but it is free and independent, exclusive and unrestricted." It is not arbitrary, but tied to the fate and task of the people. But *the fate and task of the people* is determined by the leader alone, he directs the "deployment of the people's collective political power for the common great goals." The referendums do not determine his decisions, but have the function of confirmation, of trusting commitment to the decisions of the leader.

Even before the war began, the principle of the Führerstaat (leader-state) was so fully realized that Goering could say that he himself and all other state and party leaders had no more decision-making authority on the big questions than the stones on which they stood. It has been known since the earliest post-war period from the memoirs of those involved that below

this level there were numerous conflicts of authority among the subordinates, but this fact was precisely a prerequisite for the independence of Hitler's decisions in the area of world politics. The National Socialist jurists were therefore right when they rejected the equation of the Führerstaat with a dictatorship or even an absolute monarchy. In fact, no dictator or absolute monarch had ever had as much power as Hitler. Even the will of the military emperor Napoleon I was not directly identical with the will of the state. It is a completely unfounded assumption that something of the sort would have been necessary if the goal had consisted merely in regaining the status of a great power or even in the founding of a Greater Germany. It was probably the only "constitution" under which a defeated state could grasp for "world domination" against all odds and against the concerns of all experts: the archaic simplicity of the formation of will in warlike tribes was combined with the modern efficiency of a state system based on the division of labor. But it was also the only form of government in which a single person could drag an entire nation into total defeat and even physical ruin. From a philosophical perspective, it was the most extreme form of perverted theology: the Führer was considered a god, or at least as a semi-divine savior, and historically speaking, this was the stark opposite of German and European tradition.

But the legal explanations about the constitutional position of the unrestricted leader of the people could not be taken from the fact that this god or demigod was at the same time the pioneer of a "world view" that wanted to appeal to far more people than just the Germans: at least *the Germanic peoples* and maybe even *all Aryans*. And reality was far from consistent with the concepts and postulates. The German people was not a manageable clan that looked up trustingly to their patriarch, but a modern, very complex and historically diverse society. The Führer therefore needed an organ that was not identical with the people, and his world view had to be as much rooted in this organ as it in turn permeated it. If the NSDAP was Hitler's first and foremost creation, he was in a way its offspring. The Third Reich was therefore just as much a party state as a Führerstaat, and the Law for Securing the Unity of Party and State of December 1, 1933 also formally fixed this fact by defining the party as "the leading and moving force of the National Socialist state." If the Führer's character may be interpreted as the unrestricted of traditional monarchical power, the party character of the state was something historically quite new that could be derived even less from the traditions of the right than from the traditions of socialism. But Soviet Russia was ahead of Germany by 15 years.

From the outset, the NSDAP was not a party of dignitaries, but a well-organized mass party, of the kind that had previously only been the Social Democratic Party in Germany and, from 1920, the Communist Party of Germany as well. But not only was the leader's power much

more pronounced, but the membership movement was more powerful than it had been in the Social Democratic Party of Germany and the Communist Party of Soviet Union. At the time of the seizure of power, the NSDAP had over 700,000 members, while the Bolshevik party had numbered little more than 200,000 in the autumn of 1917; in 1935, membership was 2.5 million, about the same as that of the Communist Party of Soviet Union, including candidates. The NSDAP was thus far less of an elite party than the Communist Party of Soviet Union, and extensive party purges were never carried out. Hitler never compared his party to the status of the samurai or to a “sword-bearing order” as Trotsky and Stalin, respectively, did with regard to the Communist Party of Soviet Union. But unlike the Communist Party of Soviet Union, the NSDAP was already organized like a state before the seizure of power, and the Munich Reich leadership had resembled a government since 1930. The SA party army, with its staffs and army-like hierarchy, was far greater in number than the “Red Guard” had been in Petrograd in 1917. However, this party and its army did not have to assert themselves in a genuine civil war, and they destroyed the other parties, but by no means entire social classes, and with regard to the “main enemy,” Jewry, the intention of expelling them was realized only very gradually. Thus the SA did not become the army of the state, as the Red Guard did in a certain way, and the party, while exercising great influence, always remained a state within a state and for many years could not remotely think of subjugating and outright appropriating the economy, as the Communist Party had done in Soviet Russia. Unlike Russia in 1917 and even more so in 1920, Germany had a declining economy that was nevertheless very efficient and well-functioning, which was integrated to the world market in many ways and was to a large extent dependent on it. An attempt to expropriate and reorganize it without the express and overwhelming consent of the electorate would have provoked the chaos and decline that had followed war and civil war in Russia. Precisely because of this, the power of the party was much more limited and social pluralism, in contrast to political pluralism, was largely preserved. At least some leaders of party organizations, such as Joseph Goebbels, managed to get into the relevant state offices, but Alfred Rosenberg was no more successful in taking over the Foreign Office as Ernst Röhm was in taking over the Reich Ministry of the Armed Forces. Although later on there were more and more personal unions between party and state offices, in principle state and party remained separate. The *de facto* situation consisted in a bitter competition between the various party and branch leaders for shares in state power, and this also resulted in a confusing juxtaposition of claims and competences, which one may call *neofeudalism*, but which was by no means a *polycracy*, since there was never the slightest doubt as to who had to make the *big* decisions. A certain confusion was even explicitly promoted by Hitler, just as Stalin and Lenin had promoted the competing coexistence of organs. In Germany, of course, far more stronger remnants of the traditional individualism and greater opportunities

for one's own initiative remained, while in the Soviet Union the multiplicity of authorities served far more pronouncedly the alternating control and thus the rule of the top extending to the smallest detail. The basic difference between the NSDAP and the Communist Party of Soviet Union was that the latter had to create an industrial and warlike society through extreme activity after the devastation of war and civil war, while the former only had the easier task of getting a highly industrialized society out of a peace crisis to prepare for war or at least for the possibility of credible threats of war. Thus the NSDAP shared most of the formal features of the Communist Party of Soviet Union, e.g. activism and the will to exterminate, but only in a much less pronounced form until the outbreak of war.

It was already characteristic that the party, in addition to its branches—the SA, the SS, the NSKK (national socialist motor corps), the Hitler Youth, the NSDStB (National Socialist German students' league) and the NS-Frauenshaft (national socialist women's league)—also had *affiliated organizations* such as the Medical Association, the Association of National Socialist German Lawyers, the Association of Teachers and the Reich Association of German Officials, which clearly showed the continued existence of social pluralism.

The top organization of the party took place through the distribution of functions in the Reich leadership, which retained its seat in Munich as the “capital of the movement.” But Rudolf Hess, who could be compared to the General Secretary of the Communist Party of Soviet Union, actually had far fewer opportunities to intervene in the state sphere, although he had considerable rights to participate in legislation and in the appointment of all officials. During his stay in Berlin on November 13 and 14, 1940, Molotov also paid a visit to Hess, and questions of the organization of both parties are said to have been discussed. If the news is correct, it would be the only “top-level” meeting that ever took place between the Communist Party of Soviet Union and the NSDAP. Whether Martin Bormann had “top-level talks” of a completely different kind, who after Hess' mysterious flight to England became one of the most powerful men in the Third Reich as “Head of the Party Chancellery,” is an open question.

Under Hess and Bormann, the “Reich leaders,” including Robert Ley, head of the “German Labor Front,” but also the leaders of large organizations such as Heinrich Himmler and Baldur von Schirach, were ministers of a kind. There was no “instruction:” of entire state areas by party departments—like by the departments of the Central Committee in the Soviet Union—but the affiliated organizations were each assigned to a specific office in the Reich leadership. The organization of the party extended downwards through the Gau, district, local group and cell lines down to the lowest unit, the *block*, which comprised 40-60 households.

All party officials wore uniforms and insignia, which, unlike the uniforms and insignia of the SA and SS, never became well known, let alone popular.

The block leaders had the task of collecting dues *at the grass roots* , but also of advising, monitoring and, and propagandizing from mouth to mouth, towards the pure “Volksgenossen”. In every apartment building there was a “NSDAP notice board”: “Here speaks the NSDAP. Comrades: If you need advice and help, turn to the NSDAP.” Then followed the name of the block manager and the address of the office. The party’s announcements were pinned in the lower half.

Even before the civil war broke out in 1918 in Petrograd, Moscow and other large Russian cities, the ruling party had already been present among the social base. There “house committees” had been formed, which usually consisted of the household staff or the poorest residents and which very quickly made it their task to evict hostile families, to redistribute living space and at least to exercise extremely strict surveillance of all “Burschui” [*bourgeois*]. For many years there was no analogy to this in National Socialist Germany, not even towards the Jewish residents, no matter how unpleasant the checks and often enough the harassment by the lowest party functionaries might be. The German system was far more a system of control than of change, a capillary system capable of suppressing any spontaneous impulse, but which was also an activating and *democratizing* institution. Many block leaders, a number of district leaders and a few Gau leaders were workers or former workers or came from very humble backgrounds, and a wide field was open to the urge for titles and distinctions. But however uncomfortable the wholesaler and the government councilor might be under the suspicious eyes of the block leader, who might still have been a humble clerk, they remained what they were, wholesaler and government councilor, and against any encroachment they could appeal to the courts, provided that as active members of dissolved parties they did not have to fear denunciation to the Gestapo. In Moscow and Petrograd, on the other hand, the house committees almost sovereignly governed and changed their small areas and more serious defiance was often punished on the spot.

Here, far below the level of the party leaders and even the leaders, the innermost core of the difference between the two parties seems to become tangible: the Communist Party of the Soviet Union was a party of the proletarians, which aimed at the annihilation of all class differences, and the NSDAP was a party of the petty bourgeois who, despite all its political activism, was concerned precisely with the preservation social conditions.

This simple thesis is questionable, however, because at the time when it seized power, the

NSDAP was more than five times as strong as the Bolshevik party in relation to the total population. Accurate and reliable information is not available for the early period of the later Communist Party of the Soviet Union, but it has been calculated that in August 1917 at most 5% of the industrial workers were members of the party. Of the 171 delegates to the 6th Party Congress who filled out the questionnaires, 92 were Russians and 29 were Jews. 94 had higher education, 72 were workers and soldiers. The average age was 29 years. So it was a party of intellectuals and workers and peasants in soldiers' coats. It is not possible to determine how many of the *workers* worked in handicraft workshops or in small industry and therefore showed *petty-bourgeois* traits; in Petrograd the proportion of workers from the large-scale Putilov works was undoubtedly large. But what was particularly remarkable was of course the high proportion of "foreign nationals," not only Jews but also Latvians, and generally the low average age in the party. At the second party congress in London, half the delegates were Jewish and far more than 50% were intellectuals. Here the origin of the talk of "Jewish Bolshevism" is clearly recognizable. A basic feature of the Russian Revolution consisted in the fact that it was not, in the end, an uprising of the oppressed "foreigners" but simultaneously after all, it was: the Jews, Latvians, Lithuanians, Finns, Georgians and many others. Moreover, a good portion of that half of the delegates belonged to the "Bund" and the Mensheviks, and to a similar question any of the Jewish Bolsheviks would have given the same answer that the People's Commissar Mechlis later gave to an anti-Semitic remark by Stalin, he is not a Jew, he is a communist. A high degree of probability can be attributed to the thesis that the Jews in Russia's western provinces—still a clearly recognizable "people" and yet already in the process of detaching themselves from the beliefs that seemed to constitute that people—represented the strongest reservoir of energy and talent, which was ever concentrated in such a small space and suddenly acquired almost unlimited potential for action. This explains why the Jewish share in the top leadership positions was initially extraordinarily high, but this in no way proves that Bolshevism as such was *Jewish* ; it merely makes it particularly clear how little the Bolshevik party, on the eve of its seizure of power corresponded to Marxian scheme of the vast majority of proletarians and the tiny minority of capital magnates. No sociological calculation of percentages can change the result to which the historical view leads: in 1917 the Bolshevik party was still a very undeveloped and relatively small party made up of intellectuals, workers and "foreign nationals" who, in the situation of the still uncompleted military defeat, placed itself at the head of the mass desire of almost all soldiers for peace and almost all peasants for land. However, since it had declared itself Marxist from the beginning, after taking over sole power it could not stop at the mere conclusion of peace and the division of the land of the landowners demanded by the Social Revolutionaries, but it also had to expropriate industry and socially destroy the bourgeoisie of the private owners as well as the old intelligentsia. It

was thus the party of a major social upheaval, and if any kind of substantial change may be called a revolution and is at the same time progressive and historically justified, then it was indeed a revolutionary and progressive party in line with historical development. But it was *not* the party that corresponded to Marx's basic concept.

Sociological data for the years after the seizure of power and the civil war are of little use, since the party was now able to manipulate social reality and its own composition by temporarily only allowing workers and poor peasants to join, while many white-collar workers and relatives of the old intelligence were purged out. But since, with a few exceptions, all important leading positions in the huge state had to be filled by party members, the party, although almost 90% of its members had elementary school education or were illiterate in 1919, became almost identical to the leading elite, and the number of workers or peasants who actually did manual labor amounted to little more than a 10%. The question of whether profound differentiations and the formation of a new class or even caste took place under the cover of the vague concept of white-collar workers or the new intelligentsia could not be reliably decided in view of the lack of a science of sociology.

On the other hand, there is a wealth of material relating to the NSDAP, which, after all, before it seized power, had been developing for 14 years in the bosom of a society that differed from other European societies in no fundamental social characteristic. All of these societies can be characterized as petty-bourgeois societies, i.e. they do not consist in the great majority of peasants and workers, but they have a comparatively very broad middle class, which dedicates itself to mediating and organizing activity. Together with the old classes of the educated bourgeoisie and the petty nobility, below the grand burghers and aristocracy, it constitutes not much less than half the population and forms not so much a class as an all-pervading atmosphere, the filtration basin, as it were, of the nation and of society that never takes a unified political position and is just as closely linked to the upper class of the working class as it is to the "working" part of the upper bourgeoisie. Because of this diversity, the middle class has never developed a heroic image of itself, but rather constantly criticized itself and, in so doing, brought an emotion into society that is as alien to a warlike aristocratic society as it is to a state as small farmers in 1870, and still in 1920 it was a question of whether this basic element of all Western societies was on the decline or on the advance, and Karl Marx not only put forward one thesis, but also the other. One could even claim with a grain of salt that the concept of the revolutionary proletariat, like socialism in general, was an invention of the petty bourgeoisie, because it arose from the aversion of people of petty-bourgeois origin to certain and indeed often obsolete features of their youthful world. In any case, one says nothing of substance when one describes the NSDAP

as a petty-bourgeois movement and repeatedly confirms or slightly modifies statements that can already be found in the official “party statistics” from 1935 and which show that the workers in the party at 32 % are underrepresented compared to the 47% share in the population and that this share has fallen to 8% among the district leaders. Comparable facts, namely deviations from an imagined or postulated equality of representation, can be found in all states and parties where the concept of *representation* has something to say, and what is characteristic of National Socialism is exclusively the comparatively very high proportion of workers within a *middle-class movement*. The thesis of the “declassed,” which to a certain extent applies to every radical party, is equally unfounded. Incidentally, in such cases “declassification” is more often the consequence than the cause of activity for a party, and this was also the case with the NSDAP. The relative number of party members in individual regions depended much less on social composition than on extra-sociological factors such as proximity to the border, denomination, and voluntary participation in the war. Last but not least, the NSDAP, like the Communist Party of the Soviet Union, was a youth party. Far more enlightening than statistical accounts of shares in yet-to-be-defined classes or strata is an early statement by Clara Zetkin in 1923 that fascist parties tended to consist of the strongest and most determined (and, it must be added, most excitable) “elements of all classes.” It might be said with just as much justice that the Bolshevik Party in 1917 consisted of the most energetic and active elements of the Russian and non-Russian intelligentsia and workers. The decisive question, however, as to why these elements formed a party in Russia or in Germany, cannot be explained by sociology, but only by history. It is true that the differences between the two parties can be made somewhat understandable from sociological and historical circumstances, but their development and especially the seizure of power resulted from very specific situations and events.

But even if these seizures of power were by no means mere coups or can be traced back to intrigues or trivial coincidences, the new state parties still found so much resistance in all strata of society that they could not do without organs to enforce and secure their rule. Next to the parties, these organs were the most important structural element of that form of government for which the term *totalitarian* was already in use before 1933.

Chapter IV, Section 2

The State Security Organs and Terror

The first armed formations tasked with ensuring the security of the “Provisional Workers’ and Peasants’ Government” in Petrograd and then in Moscow were the same ones that had fought for power for them: the insurgent units of the old army, especially groups of sailors from the Baltic Fleet and detachments of the Red Guard. They stood guard in front of the Smolny Institute, initially ready for an attack by *counter-revolutionary* troops, and later they shielded the Moscow Kremlin. The dissolution of the old army and the formation of a new one went hand in hand from the end of December 1917; the fundamental difference was first the abolition of all seniorities and ranks as well as all medals and decorations; in the revolutionary army of the Russian Republic, free and equal citizens—proletarians by social origin—were to meet in voluntary obedience and command themselves through soldiers’ committees. It became clear very quickly that this army did not deserve its name and had no chance of prevailing against the resistance of the remnants of the old army or even against the German troops. Thus, from March onwards, the Red Army under War Commissar Leon Trotsky was modeled on the Tsarist army rather than on that of the Red Guards, and soon the majority of its commanders consisted of former officers. But it was a few Latvian regiments of staunch Bolsheviks who, in July 1918, rescued the Lenin’s government from the uprising of the Left Social Revolutionaries, and the army as a whole retained the original party character. For a long time, in the vicissitudes of the civil war, a clear separation between *internal* and *external*, between armed forces and special security forces, could hardly be made anyway. Almost all the senior commanders were party members, and quite a few of them—such as the Lithuanian peasant’s son Jeronim Uborevich—had played a major role in organizing the Red Guards; war commissars had been placed as the party envoys alongside the former officers, and party leaders who, like Trotsky and Stalin, had never had any military training, occupied the top positions. It was Trotsky who, in August 1918, ordered the establishment of the first concentration camps and who, in an attempt to deter former Tsarist officers from defecting to the Whites, had their wives and children treated as hostages and

shot if necessary. Nevertheless, during the first few months after the seizure of power, a distinction had to be made between internal and external security, since during November and December 1917 the government of the People's Commissars was threatened far more by the strikes of ministry officials and bank employees than by military action. Nobody did as much to end this strike as Felix Edmundovich Dzerzhinsky, the co-founder of the Social Democracy of the Kingdom of Poland and Lithuania. A devoted follower of the Catholic Church as a young man, the son of Polish nobles had transferred all the fervor of his faith to the revolutionary movement and, like Rosa Luxemburg, had written very beautiful and sentimental letters from prison or exile; but since, besides children, he loved only humanity, he was not even surpassed by Lenin in determination to defend the proletarian revolution against all its enemies. The Council of People's Commissars was therefore well advised when on December 7, 1917 it created the "Extraordinary Commission for Combating Counter-Revolution and Sabotage," and placed Dzerzhinsky at its head. Called "Cheka" or "Vetcheka" from its initials, the new authority first made a name for itself by arresting large numbers of right-wing Social Revolutionaries and forcibly eliminating anarchist centers in Moscow. For this they needed their own troops and their own executive power. It received both and gave away neither. But until July 1918 it was content with the administrative shooting of criminals, since several of the members of the supreme body were like Social Revolutionaries who objected to the imposition of political death sentences. In fact, Maxim Gorky's newspaper *Novaya Zhizny*, which contains so many accusations and complaints, hardly ever mentions the Cheka until it was banned in June 1918. But it was precisely the left-wing Socialist-Revolutionaries in the Cheka who were responsible for the murder of the German Ambassador Mirbach, and Cheka troops were also involved in the uprising of July 6-7. They even arrested Dzerzhinsky for a short time, but the will to seize power for their party was absent. In this respect, the real history of the Cheka may only begin with the sole rule of Dzerzhinsky and his international circle of collaborators—the Latvians Martin Latsis and Jēkabs Peterss, the Jews Józef Stanisławowicz Unschlicht and Genrikh Grigoryevich Yagoda, the Russian Mikhail Kedrov and the German Roller—but it was probably symptomatic that together with the first criminal, his mistress was executed without further ado. So it was only logically consistent that after the assassination attempts on Uritzki and Lenin on August 30, the Cheka did not act as an investigative authority in order to identify the accomplices of Leonid Kanegisser and Fannija Kaplan among the Socialist Revolutionaries, but rather, with its hostage shootings, represented only the tip of that elementary savagery which, for example, appeared in the following appeal of an army committee, signed by Smilga and others: "We appeal to the arbiters of Petrograd: comrades, beat the right-wing Social Revolutionaries without mercy, without pity, there is no need for courts and tribunals. Let the anger of the workers rage, the blood of the right-wing Social

Revolutionaries and White Guards shall flow, physically exterminate the enemies!” Thus, when the Cheka shot “administratively,” it was only continuing the line of this call, which gives an idea of what was happening in the vastness of Russia in terms of lawless acts of violence that were sanctioned and encouraged from above. And the Cheka only fixed the specific, collectivist thinking of the party when it directed its blows not only against the possibly guilty party of Socialist Revolutionaries, but against the “main enemy” allegedly behind it, namely “the bourgeoisie.” Martin Latsis thus formulated the basic conception of the party in a particularly harsh manner when he wrote: “We are in the process of exterminating the bourgeoisie as a class. You do not need to prove that this or that person acted against the interests of the Soviet power by word or deed. The first thing you have to ask an arrested person is: what class does he belong to, where is he from, what is his education and what is his profession? These questions should decide the fate of the accused. That is the quintessence of the Red Terror.” The pursuit of social being rather than individual action was therefore a distinctive feature of the Cheka only in a technical sense, and Stalin had good reason in 1927 to praise it as the “naked sword of the proletariat.” If the demand “a thousand (of them) for one (of us)” probably remained verbal, proportions of 150:1 were a reality, and it was almost a reconciliatory return to the principle guilt when a priest was shot because he held a memorial service for “Nikolay Romanov.” In all this, Dzerzhinsky and his closest collaborators were not acting out of personal cruelty, but they believed, in the spirit of the quote quoted earlier, that they were serving practical humanism and the highest goals of humanity. By all traditional standards they were criminals and mass murderers, but for them these crimes and mass murders were precisely the postulates of a higher, “revolutionary” morality that would definitively usher in the realm of justice and morality. They could not be dissuaded from their path even by the fact that, by their own admission, sadists and criminals rushed into their service and, full of that completely unlimited power which Lenin declared to be the essence of the proletarian dictatorship, committed deeds of indescribable horror, next to which the worst excesses of the White Terror faded. After 1924, anyone in the West who read the book by the respected historian and popular socialist S.P. Melgunov on the “Red Terror in Russia 1918-1923” must indeed have felt their blood run cold in their veins with horror. But not only the remote torture and killing sites in the provinces, but also the buildings of the Cheka headquarters on the Lubyanka in central Moscow soon became a place of terror, with reports circulating as early as the early 1920s that largely corresponded to Solzhenitsyn’s much later depictions. Even after the years of civil war, the Cheka had by no means disappeared, but had become firmly institutionalized and even increased in size. Certainly, after 1920 the Bolshevik Party regime still faced many and active enemies, and the Cheka uncovered a number of opposing organizations; however, it also violently ended numerous strikes because allegedly “enemies” were behind them. But what had emerged

during the years of the civil war, the intelligence service with its departments assigned to the respective opponents, the border troops, the “internal troops” as an army alongside the Red Army and finally the special departments, from which that “traveling Cheka punitive expedition” was formed, which is said to have shot 6,000 “enemies” within three months in the city of Nikolayevsk on the Amur, which became more and more an end in itself, which no longer had anything *extraordinary* about it, but was a familiar and all-pervasive part of everyday life. Now conspiracies were being provoked instead of just being uncovered; agents and spies were sent all over the world in close if jealous cooperation with the Comintern, the Army Intelligence Service and the industrial commissariats; the borders of the Soviet Union were hermetically sealed and foreigners were arrested to be accused of sabotage or to be exchanged for arrested revolutionaries in Germany and elsewhere; it was considered a crime for a national to have any relations with independent foreigners; the whole country was covered with such a dense network of confidants and informers that even party members dared not say a careless word. As early as 1921, the Cheka controlled more than 100 *concentration camps* with around 60,000 prisoners. With the onset of collectivization, corrective labor camps increasingly became factors of significant economic importance, and great industrialization was driven not only by enthusiastic Komsomol members but also by millions of forced laborers. However, the name of the ultimately directing authority had changed. Not a few party members had expressed their concern when what appeared to be a civil war institution would not disappear after victory had been achieved, and when the People’s Commissar for Culture, Anatoly Lunacharsky, complained that the Communist Party appeared to be a workers’ party having become a warlike party of soldiers, some might go a step further and fear that the party might become an instrument of the secret police. So in 1922 the Cheka was renamed “GPU” and after the founding of the Soviet Union it was renamed “OGPU,” and the authority to carry out administrative shootings was withdrawn. However, almost all reports agree that practically nothing has changed in this matter because the GPU was able to evade the restrictions. Rather, as a result of the temporary factional struggles, new tasks were assigned to it, because party comrades were now obliged to report to the GPU and to the Central Committee on all factional activities of which they became aware. But here, too, the GPU knew how to produce what it wished to discover, and Trotsky bitterly complained in 1928 that a GPU agent contact took up with the opposition and then was “unmasked to be a Wrangel officer.”

In 1934 the OGPU was finally merged with the Internal Commissariat (“NKVD”), but this merger with the ordinary police and internal administration worked out to the advantage of the political secret police, since their chief, Genrikh Yagoda, took over the management of the new agency. The Great Purge all but wiped out the Chekist old guard, as well as the army’s

rival overseas intelligence agency, the GRU. But even though the purgers, Yezhov's people, were almost all executed, the NKVD was as powerful as ever under its new chief, Lavrenty Beria, Stalin's Georgian compatriot. The "reconnaissance department" rebuilt its legal and illegal residencies abroad, the "secret political administration" monitored the entire inner life of the Soviet Union and probably also organized the extensive deportations from the newly acquired areas of Poland and the border states. The GULag department administered the army of millions of enslaved laborers and other prisoners who were scattered across the Soviet Union in about 80 concentration camp-systems of 20-100 individual camps each, and on the eve of the war Beria commanded not only the border and transport troops and numerous NKVD schools, but also those blocking formations designed to operate behind the front lines and shoot down any soldier who might flee the battlefield. But not much of Dzerzhinsky's ascetic belief apparently remained in the higher ranks: reports of the luxurious furnishings of the offices of high GPU officials were already numerous in the early 1930s, and when Beria was called "monster" in Soviet publications after his execution in 1953, this statement apparently referred to his private life as well. In any case, by 1934 the former "Extraordinary Commission" had grown into a gigantic apparatus of professional policemen and special soldiers, and that must have alienated to any reader of Lenin's "State and Revolution," where socialism still was traditionally equated with the abolition of (professional) army and civil service.

The police force of National Socialist Germany also had a particularly close relationship with the party, more precisely with one of its branches, the SS, and it was also a formidable apparatus in 1939, but this fact was not incompatible with the basic ideological approach of National Socialism. The "Reich Security Main Office" which was established in September 1939, in which the "Security Police" (i.e. the Secret State Police and the Criminal Police) and the "Security Service" (i.e. the intelligence organization) were united under the direction of Reinhard Heydrich, was not, like the former GPU, the most important part of the Ministry of the Interior, but had retained its independence and formal authority to issue instructions to Heinrich Himmler as the "Chief of the German Police." Unlike in the Soviet Union, the Wehrmacht was not a party army, and at no time were there calls "from the front" along the lines of appeals of Smilga and others to the Petrograd workers just cited. On the contrary, from the very beginning the Wehrmacht served exclusively for the external security of the state, and as late as 1937 many a general might have been of the opinion that the purpose of the National Socialist movement was to guarantee the security of the Wehrmacht, i.e. it made possible the restoration of military freedom, which Versailles deprived from what was once the best army in the world. Even the victory over France, which was largely Hitler's triumph, did not change the fact that the Wehrmacht was remarkably free from direct influence of the

party and especially of the SS, although numerous young officers felt closely connected to the party.

The existence of the SS, on the other hand, was based on its relationship with the party leader and protagonist of the ideology, and there was no parallel to this in Russia or the Soviet Union either before 1917 or after 1917. In 1923 the “Stoßtrupp Hitler” had been set up as a bodyguard and shock troop, and after Hitler’s release from captivity in 1925 a “Staff Guard” was formed from a few completely reliable people under the leadership of Julius Schreck. A little later, similar squads also existed in other places, and the term “Schutzstaffeln” came into use. The primary task remained securing the leadership of the party, and after the pronouncement of the verdict in the Leipzig “Cheka Trial” and various other revelations about the terrorist and military apparatus of the Communist Party of Germany, protective measures of this kind seemed all too appropriate. However, the realm of pragmatic expediency was soon exceeded. In January 1929, Heinrich Himmler took over as “Reichsführer SS” and quickly gave his organization its own face by emphasizing the idea of elites, races and settlements. The aim was to build up a community of “healthy Germanic clans” for which the so-called “marriage order” was to provide the basis: not primarily the economy, as with the Marxist socialists, but procreation should be wrested from subjective arbitrariness and made the subject of well-considered planning, since the damage and corruption of civilization could not be eliminated in any other way, the high point of which for Himmler, as numerous statements show, was unmistakably the revolution of 1918 with its “bad-breed” of soldiers’ council types. From autumn 1931 onwards, Reinhard Heydrich, a discharged naval officer, set up a “defense service” from the humblest of beginnings, which after the seizure of power was given the name “Reichsführer SS Security Service” (“SD”). As Reich Chancellor, Hitler again set up a very personal protection force, which developed into the “Leibstandarte Adolf Hitler.” More important for the SS’s later position of power was the fact that, unlike the SA, early on it was able to penetrate the state sphere, and more consistently, the police force. The SA, because it was much larger and more important, would have had to take over the Reichswehr, and according to traditional concepts that would have meant a genuine revolution; the far more inconspicuous way of the SS corresponded much better to the new type of fascist revolution. The individual stages of this seizure of power within the larger seizure of power are not to be traced here; in any case, Himmler, as “Reichsführer SS and Chief of the German Police in the Reich Ministry of the Interior,” had been the de facto Minister of Police of the Third Reich since June 1936, and under him Heydrich held the most important powers as the commander of the security police and the intelligence service. Thus, on the one hand, the trend towards centralization that had already been noticeable during the Weimar period had reached a logical climax, albeit one that was

still unimaginable in Weimar, and on the other hand, a merging of party and state offices had already been created according to the official designation, to which only the “Führer and Reich Chancellor” himself was an equivalent. The question was: would the SS become the state or would the police become the party? That the second possibility was the more likely one was already proven by the development of the concentration camps since 1933. Theodor Eicke, as the commander of the nominally state-owned Dachau camp, obviously felt himself first and foremost as an SS leader, and if he sought to fill his men with an inextinguishable hatred of the prisoners as “enemies of the state,” these enemies of the state were for him first and foremost the enemies of the party. When he shot the SA Chief of Staff on Hitler’s direct orders on July 1, 1934, he had become, as it were, a “state murderer” as the executor of an extra-state Führer order, and one may speak of a characteristic parallel to the postulate “no courts and no tribunals,” which was nevertheless different from the Soviet “mass terror” *toto coelo* (i.e. *absolutely*) . After June 30, 1934, as a now independent subdivision of the NSDAP, the SS received permission to set up armed units, which as “disposal troops” were supposed to be a state security police and thus largely corresponded to the *internal troops* of the GPU or NKVD, although out of consideration for the Wehrmacht they were not given heavy weapons. A part of this state security police were the formations, which in April 1936 were placed under Theodor Eicke as the “leader of the SS Totenkopf Units and the KL (*concentration camps*) ” and initially comprised five battalions. Even in 1939, however, the entire German concentration camp system was not even remotely comparable to the NKVD system, either in terms of the number of guards or the number of prisoners, or even in terms of economic importance; only the outbreak of war brought about a significant change. Until the beginning of the war against Poland, the future Waffen-SS was still relatively weak: it included the Leibstandarte Adolf Hitler, the Standarte “Germania” in Hamburg, the Standarte “Der Führer” in Vienna, Graz and Klagenfurt as well as various special assault battalions and the “Junker schools” in Tölz, Braunschweig and Klagenfurt. All in all, there were at most two divisions, and at the beginning of the war all units, with the sole exception of the guards, were incorporated into the Wehrmacht for the purpose of taking on combat tasks.

The general SS, the actual party structure, could not compete in importance with the police and the Waffen-SS, and as a whole the SS already presented a very diverse picture in 1939. But unity was nevertheless secured by basic ideological concepts: the Führer as absolute sovereign, “the Reich” as the goal, the task of destroying the enemy, and cultivating “good blood” as a purpose in life. Like Himmler, Heydrich understood this idea primarily as a counter-ideology to Bolshevism. In his 1935 writing “Changes in our Struggle” he chose the following formulations: “As everywhere in the life of nature, the life of peoples consists of the eternal struggle between the stronger, the noble, racially superior and the inferior, the

subhuman... The struggle of our leader and the movement began at a time of camouflaged rule by subhumanity, which was on its way to open, all-destructive brutal rule through Bolshevism... The driving forces of the enemy remain eternally the same: world Jewry, world Freemasonry and a largely political priesthood... In their various ramifications and forms they persist in their objective of the destruction of our people ... As in every true struggle there are clearly only two options: either we finally overcome the opponent, or we perish.” Here, despite all the unfeigned feeling of strength and all claims to superiority, the defensive underpinning of the National Socialist expansion and its substantive contrast to the Bolshevik, indeed to the Marxist doctrine becomes clear with strong formal similarity: security, protection, preservation, order, but with the impetus of “all or nothing,” which, in conservative opinions, had hitherto only come to light in a verbal way and was far reminiscent of Lenin’s “Who-whom?” But no matter how obviously this view tends to see the Industrial Revolution negatively and equates “healthy life” with “peasant life,” it cannot be taken for granted that the term *reactionary* is sufficient to describe it. In a statement about the Waffen-SS in September 1940, Adolf Hitler once again voiced his very simple basic emotion when he said: “Such an association (as a state troop police force) will never, proud of its cleanliness, fraternize with the proletariat and the underworld that undermines the supporting idea,” and in this came that loss of meaning of the word “proletariat” that has meanwhile asserted itself everywhere in the western world, even where it has been taken up again in sentimental regression. Apparently Hitler did not equate “proletariat” with “workers” and his state troop police could not have been formed without a prior and far-reaching “democratization.” It is more likely, therefore, that two phenomena opposed each other with similar determination, equally distant from the basic Marxist notion of the “overwhelming majority” driven to socialism. In any case, it was an exact and hostile counterpart to Stalin’s quoted statement when Himmler, in his 1935 speech, called the SS a “merciless executioner’s sword” that would destroy the “Jewish-Bolshevik revolution of the subhuman” if it ever unleashed in Germany from without or from within.

Thus, before the outbreak of the German-Soviet war, the two basic emotions of the First World War, the negative and the positive war experience, faced each other in the form of gigantic security and terror apparatuses, and the question was whether they were equally consistent in developing these institutions. But as an apparatus, the Soviet one was older and, by all accounts, more original, for it stood before the eyes of its German enemies as a reality and, in a way, as a model. In a speech in January 1937, Himmler referred to his “most exact knowledge of Bolshevism.” When Walter Schellenberg had to organize the security of Hitler’s visit to Italy in April 1938, he chose for his secret service men “the Russian system of cooperation of three people each,” and in July 1941 Hitler had him ordered to set up a strong

intelligence system in Russia “which is in no way inferior to the NKVD.”

The reports on Bolshevism and the Soviet Union, which could be read in the right-wing press up to 1933, and the books which were distributed in large editions by the “Anticomintern” publishing house after the National Socialists takeover, were propagandistic and one-sided, but they deviated less from reality than most of the *fellow-travelers’* accounts and agreed in the main with a considerable part of the not overtly anti-communist literature. Between 1939 and 1941 there was also direct cooperation between the security organizations of the Soviet Union and Germany, and there is no indication that the Gestapo felt it was the older and more experienced organization.

In fact, it would be unjustified to claim that the SS and the Reich Security Main Office dominated Germany in 1939 or even early 1941 as completely as the NKVD, Stalin’s instrument, dominated the Soviet Union. Not only was the average standard of living of the population considerably higher, but important parts of the liberal system had been preserved in considerable remnants in Germany: one was a regulated but still relatively free economy, which offered shelter to numerous opponents of the regime; a Wehrmacht in which there were no party cells and certainly no “special departments” of the political police; a judiciary that not infrequently still displayed a considerable degree of independence; churches that often meant their own country’s regime when they preached against the concentration camps of the Soviet Union. As *totalitarian* as Germany appeared in 1939 alongside England and France, it had to appear *liberal* to anyone who could make a genuine comparison with the Soviet Union. This also applied to the concentration camps and not only from a quantitative point of view. When the former communist and Deputy People’s Commissar Karl Albrecht was released by the GPU to Germany in 1934 and immediately taken into custody again by the Gestapo, he noticed above all “the exemplary hygiene and cleanliness” and a nightmare fell away from him when he saw that he no longer needed to hear “nightly screams of death.” And Margarete Buber-Neumann, Heinz Neumann’s wife, who was handed over to the Gestapo by the NKVD in 1939 along with many other former communists, asked herself in disbelief: “And this is supposed to be a concentration camp?” when she was taken to the Ravensbrück concentration camp and saw the flowerbeds that had been planted just beyond the entrance. She realized very soon that she had not been placed in a convalescent home, nor even in an analogue of the NKVD model Sokolniki prison in Moscow; the “Siberian conditions” under which she had lived in the Soviet Union were, in her opinion, far worse.

But she might have added that she never saw a poster containing a counter-slogan to the inscription that the German student Kindermann had seen fifteen years earlier in the

Lubyanka: “Long live the GPU, the vanguard of the world revolution!” It was characteristic that Hitler and Himmler saw no advantage in the continued *liberality* of German existence, but only weakness and imperfection. In fact, it resulted to a large extent from the peace that prevailed in Germany after 1933. But the period of peace was only the first half of the National Socialist regime, and probably the less characteristic one. The National Socialist regime had not had to assert itself in any armed civil war, but Adolf Hitler told the generals in no uncertain terms in 1939 that he had not raised the Wehrmacht in order *not* to fight, and the foresight of war, beyond all protestations of peace, was a basic fact already from the years 1933-1937. Admittedly, even the Bolsheviks did not believe that their ultimate goals could be achieved without war, and their “socialism” could be called, with good reason, a continuation of the war economy with different means. Only in war would both regimes become fully comparable and perhaps prove to be unequal in other ways. Therefore, while a comparison of structures and conditions as they existed in 1939 is permissible, it cannot be exhaustive. The strained artificiality of a counter-belief that sought to trace all wars and struggles back to the machinations of “international Jewry,” although it saw in these wars and struggles the essence of life, was already all too evident in 1939. But Hitler and Himmler attributed the difficulties they encountered in reality to the persistence of *reaction* and pinned their hopes on youth. It was therefore no coincidence that there were particularly close ties between the SS and the Hitler Youth. But even Lenin, in the last years of his life, had all but given up hope that his generation would still live to see the “victory of the world proletariat,” and in the Soviet Union the youth organization of the party took over “sponsorships” over certain parts of the Red Army. In addition to the security organs, the youth organizations were the most important subdivisions of both the Communist Party of the Soviet Union and the NSDAP.

Chapter IV, Section 3

The Youth Associations

IV. 3. The youth associations

As an illegal group, the Russian Social Democratic Party understandably did not have its own youth organization until the February Revolution of 1917. But right at the beginning of the few months, which can be compared to the fourteen-year “struggle period” of the NSDAP during the Weimar Republic, the first Bolshevik youth group, “Socialist League of Workers’ Youth,” was formed in the Putilov Works in Petrograd under the young communist V. Alexeyev. One year after the seizure of power, the founding congress of the “Komsomol” took place. According to its statute, it was an “independent organization under party leadership” which extended across all of Russia and later the whole of the Soviet Union and was also a section of the “Youth International.” The term “youth” was interpreted broadly and soon extended to the age of 28, so that the association tended to be a mass organization alongside the elite organization of the party, which sought to include as many members of the younger generation as possible and place them under the leadership of the party. Party members in the Komsomol were therefore in the minority, but since there was no age limit for leadership positions, the party’s leadership role was soon undisputed.

The organizational structure was parallel to that of the party: in the provinces, districts, counties and cities inter-congress committees formed the authoritative body, and at the state level they corresponded to the “Central Committee of the Komsomol.” All committees elected an office and secretariat for their area, headed by a first secretary. In its early days, the Komsomol invoked this democratic structure in its violent polemics against the *bourgeois* youth organizations, especially the Boy Scouts, whose discipline was militaristic because the members did not have the right to vote. Since the Boy Scouts were also accused of leaning towards the Whites, the ban on the competing youth organizations was not long in coming, but the “members’ right to vote” was very soon also considerably restricted in the

Komsomol, following the party model, because all elections had to be confirmed by the higher authorities and even the nomination of the candidates fell completely into the hands of the respective *communist factions* , which formed the skeleton of the formally always independent association.

During the first few years, however, there were noticeable tendencies to ascribe to the youth and thus to the Komsomol both the role of vanguardism and their own class interests. At the first congresses, the goals and hopes of the communists were expressed with particular urgency: the future society of mankind living together in friendship without bosses and rulers, without landowners and capitalists, without loafers and parasites, but also Moscow as the center of the communist world republic , and it caused great enthusiasm when Preobrazhensky apostrophized the Komsomol members as the members of a “great class” which must and will triumph as a whole, even if it must to demand the sacrifice of life from countless individuals.

Admittedly, vanguardism was quickly muted by the party, and the main tone of the demands was soon no longer the protection of youth but the increase of production, but even after the civil war, Komsomol members were not only characterized by a particularly strong commitment, but also by a tendency for criticism, which could go so far as to negatively compare the expenditures of the Soviet government on education with the corresponding expenditures of the tsarist government. It is not surprising that the factional quarrels of the party found a strong echo in the Komsomol and that Trotsky had many supporters. But the fundamentals remained undisputed: that the Komsomol had to undertake a work of *enlightenment* , especially in the villages, and fight the sluggish generation of parents as well as the influence of the priests, for example through “Red Christmas” and “Red Easter,” it had to promote literacy and fight against the prejudice that girls did not need to learn. In the first few years, the Komsomol had indeed fought in the front row for a new sexual morality, and from the “glass of water” theory one had often progressed to the so-called “African Nights”, but Lenin had already taken a stand against these tendencies, and in the second half of the 1920’s “sexual licentiousness” was fought alongside alcohol abuse.

“Physical hardening” as a goal, despite all the hostility, had been adopted from the scouting organizations, , and pre-military education quickly became a central task. In December 1929 the Central Committee of the Komsomol made the following resolution: “The Komsomol takes part in the training of young people who are about to be drafted. Its task is to train the future cadres of the Red Army through physical education and pre-military instruction even before service, to promote and organize pre-military training for young people, to carry out

political-enlightening work among future recruits, and to be an example for them of discipline and fulfillment of obligations.”

The Komsomol had already had a particularly close relationship with certain sections of the Red Army since the time of the Civil War through the assumption of “patronage” and by 1930 it could boast that members of the Party and Komsomol made up no less than 70% of Air Force personnel. But even greater enthusiasm than pre-military training and service in the army were the massive projects of the first five-year plan, which did more than anything else to lure former Trotskyists into Stalin’s camp. Komsomol members were mobilized in their thousands to help build the Stalingrad tractor factory or the gigantic Dnepropetrovsk “electrostation.” They worked as “shock workers” (“udarniki”) and leaders of “socialist competition”; a newly built industrial center on the Amur River was named “Komsomolsk” in their honor. The 29-year-old civil engineer Avraaniy Savenyagin moved to the Urals in 1930 and, together with thousands of enthusiastic Komsomol members, many of whom froze to death in minus 60-degree cold and inadequate clothing, built the Magnitogorsk Iron Combine on the basis of the enormous magnite deposits.

But the Komsomol also took a great part in the collectivization campaign, and when Bukharin had declared at one of the congresses that passionate hatred of the class enemy was the main maxim of the new morality, he was now being violently attacked in the Komsomol for wanting to tone down this hatred and live “in peace with everyone.” Enthusiasm and hatred also radiated from the youth within the youth, the association of “Young Pioneers,” as well as the even younger “Octyabrists,” and 14-year-old Pavel Morozov became a national hero for bringing counter-revolutionary actions of his father to the attention of the authorities and then becoming the victim of a family revenge. Thus the *great class* triumphed over all non-class allegiances, and the old ideal of communist educators to “nationalize” and “forge and harden” all youth seemed to be realized.

By the early 1930s, however, the “class” could hardly be distinguished from the “socialist fatherland,” and so children as early as kindergarten were instilled with love for the Soviet fatherland and its leader, the great Stalin; an impressive induction ceremony was deeply imprinted, in which the Young Pioneers received their uniforms—the white shirt and red tie. In the “pioneer camps” they continued to be instilled with patriotism and communist consciousness by the Komsomol members who acted as brigade leaders, and finally the best among them joined the party as candidates. Thus the circle was closed, and the *new man* perpetuated himself through the generations, leading the increasingly homogeneous Soviet people to ever greater victories. At the same time, of course, it became increasingly difficult

to imagine that he would make himself, his Russian language and his state superfluous in future world society. Wasn't it more of a traditional claim to world domination when Lazar Kaganovich shouted at a Komsomol congress: "You will be the masters of the whole world"?

The Hitler Youth, of course, sang the lines "And today Germany belongs to us and tomorrow the whole world" loudly and confidently on all the streets of Germany, and in 1937 as "state youth" they not only included, like the Komsomol (which had about 10 million members in 1940), a significant percentage of youth, but virtually all youth aged 10 to 18 with the sole exception of Jews. If the Komsomol demanded a "completely clean social composition" for its leadership, the clean racial composition of the Hitler Youth was much less exclusive and, precisely because of this, probably symptomatic of a society in which the exclusion of the *petty bourgeoisie* and *big peasants* would simply have been unimaginable. A similar paradox was evident in the overall character. The Hitler Youth leaned far more strongly than the Komsomol on the tradition of the "youth movement," and just as certainly as there had been "boy scouts" in Russia, the youth movement as such had certainly been something specifically German.

On the one hand, it was a typical emancipation movement, founded by students at a Berlin high school: the revolt of youth against Wilhelmine hypocrisy, against outdated conventions, against the rigidity of German class society, and in this respect it was undoubtedly a very modern phenomenon. On the other hand, however, they sought their ideal of life in medieval chivalry and in a healthy country life, and in this respect they could be called reactionary. But presumably a society is all the more developed, more complex, the more syntheses are made between an imaginable pure progress and an imaginable pure reaction, because a culture without contradiction is poor, however sympathetic and virtuous it may be.

The distinguishing mark of the Hitler Youth, however, was precisely not what it had in common with the youth movement, but the resolute integration into the political mass struggle: their slogan was not the journey of the Wandervogel, but the parade in front of the Führer; not the friendship of the select few around a circle of allied campfires, but the "camaraderie" of a large organization. But especially against the background of the Komsomol, that the similarities with the youth movement are more striking: for example, their principle "youth must be led by youth," their songs, the still quite playful character of their exercises in the field, which in the years of peace could hardly be seriously considered "pre-military training." Despite all the contempt for *social differences*, it never questioned their existence for a moment, and overall it was no less distant from the German "workers' youth movement" than from the Komsomol in its appearance.

The first NSDAP youth groups existed before 1923, and in 1926 the “Greater German Youth Movement” was formed in Plauen, Vogtland. At the Weimar Party Congress, it was officially recognized as the youth organization of the NSDAP and, at Julius Streicher’s suggestion, renamed “Hitler Youth. German Worker Youth League.” At first it was apparently regarded mainly as a junior organization of the SA and was therefore subordinate to the supreme SA leadership. In 1929 the “National Socialist Students’ League” was formed under the leadership of Adrian Renteln, and in 1930 the “League of German Girls.” However, the “National Socialist German Student League” gained much greater political importance. Through actions and demonstrations, it made its presence felt in many universities and, as early as 1931, it seized power as a result of free elections in the Association of German Students. Its leader Baldur von Schirach, son of a theater director, was appointed “Reich Youth Leader of the NSDAP” in October 1931 and in March 1932, in connection with the Brüning-Gröner SA ban, was removed from the subordinate relationship to the SA. At the “Reich Youth Day of Hitler Youth” in Potsdam on October 1st and 2nd, 1932, Hitler watched the march of about 100,000 boys for more than seven hours with his arm raised.

Through its agitation and mass work, the Hitler Youth placed itself in striking contrast to the *bourgeois* youth leagues, and the high proportion of young workers and apprentices in the membership was indeed remarkable: it amounted to 70%. Nevertheless, the Hitler Youth was on the whole only a small minority within the German youth organizations, because the “Reich Committee of German Youth Associations” had 5-6 million members. After January 30, 1933, however, there was a similar surprise as in the case of the unions: on April 5, the office was occupied and the leadership usurped, without serious resistance having to be broken. The political youth organizations were dissolved and banned together with the corresponding parties, the right-wing groups, such as the Bismarck and Hindenburg youth, were partially transferred to the Hitler Youth. The “Youth Alliance” caused greater difficulties. They first joined together to form the “Greater German Youth League” under Admiral von Trotha. However, there could be no question of a fundamental dispute, since the right wing of the youth movement had been racially minded since 1919. Schirach later described the difference as follows: “I was particularly repelled by the ideology of their association. They described themselves as the elite and us as the masses. We were the ‘People’s Youth’ they the ‘Select Youth.’ The National Socialist state could not tolerate such a view .”

This time state power was used. Schirach was appointed “Youth Leader of the German Reich” by Hitler on June 17, 1933, and his first official act was to dissolve the “Greater German Confederation.” Of all the other federations, only the “Artamanen League” was

incorporated into the Hitler Youth and transformed into the “Hitler Youth Land Service.” The Evangelical Youth was transferred to the Hitler Youth at the end of 1933 by an agreement with Reichsbishop Müller without completely losing its identity, but as such it was restricted to the purely pastoral sphere. The Catholic youth organizations such as the student federation “New Germany” were protected to a certain degree by the concordat, but they were paralyzed over the course of a few years by a variety of pressure and censorship measures.

For a while, Saturday was reserved for the Hitler Youth as the “State Youth Day.” On December 1, 1936, the “Law on the Hitler Youth” was enacted, which made the Hitler Youth responsible for the entire physical, mental and moral upbringing of young people outside of school and home. From now on, the Hitler Youth served primarily as a tightly organized registration system for the purpose of pre-military training in a more than just technical sense. Characteristic were the “Marine-Hitler Youth,” the “Motor-Hitler Youth” and the flying units. In 1938 the Hitler Youth even got its own “patrol service,” a kind of security police; it comprised a retinue (150 men) in each regiment. A special relationship with the SS was created by an agreement between Schirach and Himmler: the junior staff of the SS units should primarily be taken from the Hitler Youth patrol service, while the Hitler Youth land service should represent the most important reservoir for military farmers [*wehrbauer: settlers on the frontier against the enemy*] .

The organizational structure corresponded to that of the other National Socialist organizations and was based entirely on the principles of hierarchy and command, with the rejection of decision-making and debating bodies: the chain of command extended from the chief regional leader to the leaders of the territories, regiments, tribes, allegiances and hosts to the “comradeship leaders,” who were a kind of non-commissioned officers. The positions up to Bannführer (regiment commander) were full-time; but the danger of bureaucracy was largely avoided. However, there was no analogue to the Komsomol’s “light cavalry,” which was supposed to fight the bureaucratization in the state, and certainly not to the committees, offices and secretariats. Neither was the Hitler Youth called upon to engage in “production battles” or to build new industrial plants. But during the war they were called upon to help for harvesting and air-raid protection, and they performed auxiliary services for the post office, police and railways and, above all, for the “Children’s Country Dispatch.” Hitler Youth only became active as “flak helpers” from 1941; in the same year Artur Axmann took the place of Reich Youth Leader in Schirach’s place, who was appointed Gauleiter of Vienna.

Overall, the work of the Hitler Youth varied greatly in character, depending on the subdivisions.

Most of the memories of the “youth movement” were found in the “German Young People” [*Jungvolk*] : trips, tents, outdoor games. But here, too, “hordes” no longer wandered, which were characterized by individual spontaneity, but columns marched, which were ordered to “line up” and were subjected to “roll-calls.” The motto “Blood and Honor” was engraved on the sheath knives worn by each of the boys [*Pimpfe*] . For an American, however, a group of the *Jungvolk* and a group of “Young Pioneers” would have been almost indistinguishable at first glance if he could have seen them side by side. But the involvement of children in the class struggle, as undertaken by the “revolutionary children’s movement” in Germany during the Weimar period, would have been completely inconceivable within the *Jungvolk*.

The actual Hitler Youth consisted of 14 to 18-year-olds and was therefore far more of a group of adolescents than the Komsomol. The focus here was on “military training camps” and “Reich shooting competitions,” but of course there could be as few Hitler Youth departments in the Wehrmacht itself as there were party cells in the Hitler Youth; very many Hitler Youth became party comrades and soldiers at the same time, while a member of the Komsomol might have been a seasoned party member and a veteran soldier. The ideological training took up less space than in the Komsomol; important topics were the Nordic heroic sagas, the causes of the German collapse, the measures taken to keep German blood pure, Adolf Hitler and his fellow fighters, the nation and its habitat. But socialist features were also unmistakable, such as the burning of schoolboy caps, the propaganda for vacations for young workers, the “Reich career competitions.” The continuation of the tradition of the youth movement was visible in the music platoons and troops of players, but also in the beginnings of more demanding cultural work such as the “Reich Theatre Day of the Hitler Youth.”

The equivalents on the female youth side were the “Young Girls” and the “German Girls League” (up to the age of 21). The “German Girls League-Work, Faith and Beauty” was attached to this. In some respects a continuation of the youth movement’s “wandering girls” was recognizable in these associations, but on the other hand they were extremely dependent on the model of the “German mother.”

Was the Hitler Youth also a *totalitarian upbringing* ? On the other hand, the fact that the Hitler Youth seemed to qualitatively restrict its quantitatively comprehensive claim seems to speak against it: school and family home were expressly recognized as equal educational powers. It was assumed that school and home were not anti-national socialist, but a positive agreement was not required: countless homes in Germany had considerable reservations about the regime, and in many German schools at most the gymnastics and biology teachers were National Socialists, while the vast majority of teachers tried best to preserve the spirit of

national uplift . In this respect, social pluralism was preserved here, too, and until the end of the Third Reich it was inconceivable in Germany that a twelve-year-old boy, as in the Soviet Union, could demand the death penalty for his own father as part of a purge. But even if no Pavlik Morozov was raised to the status of a national hero, numerous parents were still afraid of saying something hostile to the regime in the presence of their fanatical children, and there were also some break-ins of an organizational nature. For example, the “Adolf Hitler Schools” were run by the Hitler Youth, and they were not subordinate to the Reich Minister for Science, Education and National Education, but to the Reich Youth Leadership. The relocation of children to the countryside [*during the war*] was not only an emergency measure, but it was also directed against the influence of the parental home. Moreover, even the notion of education has apparently been superseded by the principle of the leadership of youth by youth itself. But the goal was not a *youth world* , but preparation for military service, and was more in an internal than in an external technical sense.

Adolf Hitler had described his educational ideal in “Mein Kampf” in clear words: “The entire educational work of the volkish state must find its culmination in the fact that it instinctively and intellectually builds a sense of race and a feeling of race into the heart and brain of the youth entrusted to it... Realizing this, the volkish state must not focus its entire educational work on merely pumping in knowledge, but on cultivating healthy bodies. The training of mental abilities then comes only secondarily...” In truth, it did not take place “only secondarily,” but actually not at all, since on the one hand it was left to a school that was essentially unchanged and on the other hand it was understood in the Hitler Youth at best in the sense of preparation for the Reich professional competitions.

In tendency, therefore, it was a radical counterattack against the “intellectualism” of education, which Hitler evidently regarded as a product of “Jewish disintegration” and which, in truth, is both a consequence and a prerequisite of modern development. In this respect, Lenin was incomparably more modern, trying to hammer the phrase “learn, learn, learn” into the Komsomol. But it was precisely in this way that he proved once again that he was operating in far less modern conditions, where progress and modernity had not yet developed sufficiently to become recognizable in their potential danger. And the subtlest consequence of totalitarian education had already become apparent clearly enough in Lenin’s contempt for the “old intelligentsia”: not only in National Socialist Germany, but even more so in Bolshevik Russia, the possibility of critical comparison and autonomous reflection was cut off at the root and replaced by the unreserved praising the party and its leader. But how, on the other hand, could there have been a greater contrast than that between the Komsomol’s demand to spread the materialistic conception of natural phenomena and the establishment of village reading

rooms on the one hand and Hitler's statement on the other hand that he wanted his youth to be "swift as greyhounds, tough as leather and hard as Krupp steel"?

Thus the Komsomol and the Hitler Youth, like the GPU and the Gestapo, were as dissimilar as they were similar. One might say that the dissimilarity is a consequence of the difference between a younger and less developed society and an older and more complex one. However, the consensus in the orientation towards service in the army could not be overlooked. And if there was undoubtedly a great deal of cynicism and blunt harshness in the GPU and Gestapo, there can be no doubt that the youth in Germany and in the Soviet Union—unlike the bulk of youth in the liberal-democratic states—largely represented a *believing* youth willing to make sacrifices. In neither case can this be adequately explained by the tedious indoctrination during training sessions and home evenings. There had to be something stronger and more intellectual at play, which was not peculiar to the young people, but which they grasped with particular force because it grew directly out of the basic experiences and basic emotions that shaped the *world views* of their parties.

Chapter IV, Section 4

Understanding of Self and Others in Literature and Propaganda

Understanding of Self and Others In Literature and Propaganda

Basic experiences and basic emotions are the basis from which ideologies emerge. Ideologies are never devised by individual thinkers, but in them those experiences and emotions are clarified and articulated which are decisive for many people and inherently designed to take ideal forms. Their roots are in fundamental situations, which may involve people from many countries, several classes and several generations, but which can also be narrower in terms of time and space. If the syndrome of situation, experience, emotion and ideology does not come about, people act merely on interests. Where it exists, groups and parties are formed that are opposed to “the others” and understand both themselves and those others in a certain way, tending to see themselves as “the good” and the others as “the bad” or “the enemy.”

In its subtlest form, the self-understanding of the group or party, which always corresponds to the understanding of others, presents itself as literature and in its crudest form as propaganda. In the following, literature is not to be understood as the *great literature* of Shakespeare, Goethe and Dostoyevsky, which is always much more than ideological party literature, even if it can be interpreted in their terms, but first of all as the songs and the celebrations in which thousands and hundreds of thousands of people assure themselves of their commonality, and finally those novels in which the stirring events and struggles of the time are expressed in words in a committed or relatively distanced way. Both kinds of literature, unlike philosophy and great literature, are not separated by any moat of propaganda and agitation, but a party which can *only* engage in propaganda and cannot produce a song or a novel of any standing is a mere interest-group advocacy or power-acquisition society. A state in which only such parties exist would be neither totalitarian nor liberal, but merely a commercial society.

The best illustration of these considerations is provided by the literature and propaganda of the workers' movement, which at the same time make it evident that the great political struggles of the interwar period were not entirely determined by the experience of the First World War, but were rooted in older soil. Thus, the basic experiences of the workers' movement came from economic life and from what they saw as a purely economic society. The song, written by Eugène Pottier in 1871, appealed to the "damned of this earth" and draws the attention of all those "who are still being forced to starve" to the "ravens" and the "vultures" who must be driven away before the sun will shine "without ceasing" for the poor, for the "army of slaves." How should the "oppressors" and the "idlers" be able to hold out for long, since the poor are "the strongest of the parties" and can "deliver themselves from misery" without needing the help of a "higher being," may it call itself God, Caesar, or tribune? And so the refrain keeps repeating the sentences that express the universal claim of this movement just as clearly as its militancy and its relation to the future:

Peoples, hear the signals! On to the last battle! The Internationale Fight for the human right.

For decades "The Internationale" resounded everywhere in Europe and America, wherever large crowds of workers gathered for a festive occasion. It spread terror among enemies and confidence among friends. Those with a knowledge of history might gain additional confidence from the phrase that those who were now "nothing" would soon become "everything," for in doing so the worker's movement revived the most famous pamphlet of the French Revolution.

Trust in history and certainty about the future were in fact the main characteristics of the workers' movement before the First World War, and nowhere did these emotions find a more beautiful expression than in a song that was written in a Moscow prison cell in 1897 and that became known in Germany, however, only after 1918 in the adaptation by Hermann Scherchen:

Brothers to the sun, to freedom Brothers to the light. Bright from the dark past The future shines forth.

The awareness of being the originator of all wealth and yet suffering bitter hardship came to light even more impressively in a song composed by Johann Most "The Working Men" and first published in 1871:

Who digs up the gold? Who hammers ore and stone? ... Who gives the rich all their bread

And lives in bitter misery? These are the working men The proletariat. Gather your strength
And pledge to the red flag ... Quicken the fall of despots! Then bring peace to the universe!
To the fight, you working men! Up, proletariat!

It is obvious that for this confidence and sense of power, the First World War had to be the most oppressive and yet the most stimulating of all experiences. Hadn't "the working men" of Europe killed each other instead of shaking hands? Didn't the bright future seem much further away than before? How could the "vultures" and the "ravens" plunge the united and international proletariat into such a calamity? If one did not want to make the devastating admission that the proletariat is neither united nor internationally minded and does not comprise the great majority of the population, then the tone had to become much sharper, then one had to make much harsher reproaches, then one not only had a few "ravens" and "vultures" against you, but a powerful and vicious enemy who, above all, had to be hated.

Thus, in the "Red Poems and Songs," which appeared in Berlin in 1924, the experience of the war and the effects of the war emerges more prominently than even the complaint about the monotony of work in the factory, than the contrasting of "fur, jewelry, silk dress" of the bourgeoisie on the one hand and "hunger, unemployment" of the proletarians on the other. A poem "To the Soldiers" says:

You man in the colorful skirt, you must now decide Do you belong to the robbers or to us
who suffer from hunger? Our bitter fight is against the thieves of this world And all who
oppose us. But if you count yourself among us, the starving proles, Then you must fight with
us, we want to kill the robbers.

"Orgesch," [*from Organisation Escherich*] i.e. the Freikorps, and also "Hitler" already play a considerable role in these songs, and if Hitler and Dietrich Eckart and their "Nazis" are still considered ridiculous figures, the deadly serious word is addressed to the Orsch:

Shoot millions, Orsch, you can't, From our blood will sprout The proletarian court.

But the song of the "Young Guard" sounds the most resolute:

We are the first line We go on and on We are the Young Guard We attack, attack. Forehead
sweating with work, The stomach empty with hunger, yes empty, The hand full of soot and
calluses Around the rifle. So stands the Young Guard Ready for class struggle Only when the
burghers bleed Only then will we be free. ... Long live Soviet Russia Listen! We are already

marching We charge in the sign Of the Peoples' Revolution! Jump on the barricades, Out to civil war, yes war, Plants on the Soviet flags To blood red victory.

But all these calls for war and civil war remain ultimately tied to the notion of a peaceful, harmonious, natural, uncomplicated life that seemed so close and was pushed so far into the distance by an enigmatic power called "the robbers" or "the reaction":

The stock exchanges are crashing! And also the banks And everything else that we suffer from. Blow up all the horror. Don't ask what's going to happen; We are sure to have The rich earth. She produces enough To satisfaction and life, For every human child! As bread as vines. ... We know what we're doing When we destroy It is a fervent work A holy judgment. It is the clearest war For the purest right. Hail the the slogan: No master, no servant.

For this early period one can cite German songs without hesitation if one wants to grasp the spirit of the Russian revolution, which was quite internationalist just above the elementary desire for land and peace and its champions had sung "the Internationale" with deep emotion on the evening of November 8 amidst the delegates of the Second Soviet Congress who were still present. Aware of having taken a step in world history, the revolution was then able to stage itself again and again in its great celebrations. In the midst of hunger and misery, Petrograd and Moscow were still very much alive cities in the early 1920s where a great deal of spontaneity was evident, even though the Party direction and control was already omnipresent. Observers thought they recognized a basic trait of the Russian people when improvised scenes in the streets led to a natural interplay between the performers and the audience. There, the workers of a fur factory put dolls in the masks of Mussolini, Lloyd George and other politicians of the capitalist world in a large cage and led them through the city to the great sympathy of the bystanders with the inscription: "Skins of world predators, tanned and processed by the Sorokumoff fur factory." In another cage was a giant spider with the inscription "The Capital." The crowd cheered as the spider was pulled out and burned. But large crowds also gathered when show trials were held against absent criminals, such as the trial of the murderers of Rosa Luxemburg or the trial of Wrangel.

All of this was far more celebration than mere propaganda, as the boundaries between those doing and those watching were erased, but the celebrations culminated in the great mass festivals where the revolution and its actors repeated and celebrated themselves. A huge stage is erected in front of the Winter Palace in Petrograd, and above in bright light fat burghers are dining with their mistresses, while on the square in front and below them a dark crowd, indistinguishable from the audience, begins to stir. Shots ring out, Red Guard detachments

form, armored cars drive up. The feasting “Burschui” [*bourgeoisie*] are speechless with terror, they get up and flee, while revolutionary formations are now rushing in, screaming and shooting. The high wall in the background sinks down, behind it the tree of freedom becomes visible, tied with red ribbons, and the many people in uniform stream towards it and exchange their weapons for scythes, pitchforks and hammers: the great brotherhood of all mankind towards more peaceful work takes the place of war, the Internationale sounds, and fireworks illuminate the entire scene, in which actors and spectators become an indistinguishable unity. Individuals have thus transcended their singleness and narrowness and find themselves elevated to the unlimited power of the mass. Everyday life and the division of labor have disappeared; the *new world* and the *new man* are anticipated in the play, which is at once an after-play and a pre-play.

The celebration became a cult when, after Lenin’s death, the embalmed corpse of the founder of the state found its resting place in the mausoleum on Red Square, and day after day many thousands patiently waited in long lines to be allowed to take a look at the only and highest relic in the Soviet Union.

In this environment *sounded* the songs and poems of Demjan Bedny, who boasted that he was a nobody and an illiterate and therefore reflected the reality of the masses:

Millions of feet: one body. The pavement cracks... Masses of millions: one heart, one will, one step! Lockstep! Lockstep! They march on. They march on. March-march...

In this way celebration and propaganda merged, and the propaganda became all the more pure, the clearer was the effort by individuals or groups to influence others over a distance and to convey the right opinions to them. For many years the Soviet Union seemed to be one blackboard, covered from top to bottom with slogans, pictures, exhortations and accusations, all pointing in the same direction, whether actually on walls and statues or in pamphlets and books. There sits the “enemy capital” as a fat man with unsympathetic features in the midst of countless pieces of gold; there enthroned the League of Nations, embodied by three men in top hats and with bellies of money, identified by the national colors as France, England and the USA, under the inscription “Capitalists of all countries, unite” enthroned on a high stage before a miserable and depressed crowd; but there is also a hovering angel scattering flowers over a large crowd of people gathered for the “Holiday of the Workers of All Countries.”

Civil War era posters show Wrangel as a semi-human figure with animal teeth and a dagger; they have workers towing a giant grenade as a “gift for the white Pan” (the Polish landowners

and capitalists), they render a world map on which the red flag is already waving over all of Europe. The representations and descriptions resemble those of the Whites to the point of being indistinguishable: charnel houses, severed heads, mass shootings, and they also lack any reference to their own terror. A strange and not very credible analogue to their own actions lies in the assertion that the Whites, of those prisoners whom they had arrested under suspicious circumstances shot all those who had calloused working hands without further investigation. A genuine difference is evident in the images of flogging, which in fact appear to have occurred only among Whites. On the other hand, Soviet propaganda became unbelievable for the foreigner when it reported mass shootings of German proletarian women and terrible tortures of captured communists in Germany.

At the end of the 1920s, the image of propaganda changed: large panels now showed only the Soviet Union and the major projects of the five-year plan were drawn in in many places, and everywhere the resolution of the 15th Party Congress was impressed on the people that in the short term the level of industrial development in the most advanced capitalist countries was to be “caught up with and overtaken.” But propaganda also was the carefully prepared trips of foreign delegations who wished to meet the *people* and yet only met agents of the Cheka or the GPU; propaganda was the office hours of the powerless “president” Mikhail Kalinin, and “agitation and propaganda” was the exclusive task of one of the largest departments of the Central Committee of the CPSU. Even as late as 1941 the Soviet Union was the land of propaganda, but even in its most routine and crude forms there remained something of the spirit of those early songs and celebrations in which the basic emotions and beliefs of a major international movement had found expression.

The tradition in which the songs of the National Socialist movement were rooted was completely different. It too went back to the pre-war period. Although nowhere in the songs of the workers’ movement was there any serious mention of “science,” they were, until 1914, overwhelmingly imbued with the optimistic spirit of the age of progress. Meanwhile, eminent philosophers had long since harshly criticized an all too banal and superficial concept of progress, the importance of myth and cult in antiquity had been discovered in literature and science, the “Wandervogel” [*“Wandering Bird,” popular German youth groups protesting against industrialization by going on hikes*] had rediscovered the homeland and its again and drawn them to its heart:

No beautifuler country in this time Than ours far and wide, Where we find each other under lime trees At evening time.

Here the war could not be felt primarily as a collapse of the hopes and works of an evil minority, the ruling class. Rather, millions of Germans had experienced it as a liberation from routine everyday life, as a call for heroic sacrifice, as a confirmation of old convictions, and even for the large mass of the Social Democrats in August 1914 it was a palpable truth that the culturally much superior Germany had to defend itself against the long-standing and now acute threat from Tsarist Russia. And after the defeat it became apparent that precisely in this distress the emotional content that had once had its place in religion were able to unite with patriotism and bring about something like that ancient unity of fatherland and worship to which the longing eyes had already turned to before the war. Rudolf Alexander Schröder's "German Oath" can be cited as an example:

Holy Fatherland, in danger Your sons stand to protect you, Surrounded by danger, Holy Fatherland, Look, every hand flashes with weapons ... By the stars is written what we swear He who guides the stars will hear us Before the stranger robs you of your crowns Germany we fall head by head. Holy Fatherland, lift at this hour Boldly your face in the round See us all inflamed son standing with sons You shall stay, country, we perish.

In view of the horrors of modern battles of material, one might scoff at the hymn-like tone; it might be disputed that this land of factories, banks, and long hours of work deserved such a song of praise. But if Germany had really been nothing more than a specimen of the global society made up of a few exploiters and countless exploited, then the poem could not have found an echo. One might see its effect as limited to bourgeois circles, but then the question arose as to how large or how small these circles were, whose feelings and thoughts were not exclusively concerned with the universal "contradiction between capital and labor." In any case, during the Ruhr struggle, the social democrat Karl Bröger said essentially the same thing as Rudolf Alexander Schröder, even though he emphasized the task of "shaping" more strongly:

Nothing can rob us of love and faith To our country; to preserve it and to shape it We are sent May we die, our heirs Then the duty applies: to preserve and shape it, Germany does not die.

These songs were not created by the National Socialists. The emotions on which they were based were neither artificial nor confined to small circles. Rather, they were the most powerful reservoir from which the new movement drew its strength, and if this source had not existed, nothing more than a new middle-class party to defend the economic interests of handicrafts and small industry would have emerged from all the "social resentment of declassed petty bourgeoisie". What is extremely characteristic of National Socialism,

however, is that it was able to adopt songs from the workers' movement and give them a nationalist as well as an anti-semitic tone. (However, the other side also changed folk and soldier songs and made them subservient to their own songs.) So the Hitler Youth sang "Brothers, to the sun, to freedom" and added a new verse:

Hitler is our leader, he is not worth the golden wages, That rolls from the Jewish thrones at his feet. And the Silesian SA changed the song of the "Young Guard" as follows: We are the assault columns, we go at it and at it We are the first ranks, We attack bravely! The forehead sweating from work, the stomach empty with hunger The hand full of soot and calluses covers the gun ... The hand grenade on the belt, the rifle shouldered So march the assault columns in the ecstasy of victory! The Jew gets the tremors, quickly unlocks the safe, Pays the people's bill down to the last penny.

Nothing would have been more ridiculous than if these songs had only been sung by "bourgeois boys" or "dandies," as the pandering counter-propaganda tried to portray. The Hitler Youth was largely proletarian in composition, and so was the SA. If a group had to *bleed*, then it was very obvious to put the easily recognizable and not too numerous Jews in the place of the *burghers*, of whom nobody knew exactly whether only the financiers or the entrepreneurs or all "value-added consumers" and in the end even the skilled workers were to be included. And had not "Rothschild," for the early workers' movement, been the name in which everything hateful about the system had been embodied?

But after the victory, the solemn and heartfelt solemnity came to the fore again, which probably cannot be found in this form in the songs of any other people, but mixed with the harder and more nervous tone of joy in the fight for the sake of the fight and in the face of the threat of annihilation the "world enemy":

Do you see in the East the dawn, a sign to Freedom, to the sun? We stick together, whether life or death may come, Whatever may come Why still doubt now, stop struggling, German blood still flows in our veins, People to arms, people to arms!—... Young and Old and man for man clutch that Swastika banner Whether burgher, or farmer, or worker, they swing The sword and the hammer. For Hitler, for freedom, for work and bread. Germany awake, Judah to death! People to arms, people to arms!

From the present, however, a distant past was not infrequently referred to:

Long was the night and long was the misery, we laid weary and abandoned. Didn't the plague

and death creep through the streets with a gray face? Tambour, strike, jubilant sound, how the flags are rattling! Tambour, God wants to admonish us, people set out! Raise yourselves and gather together, let the drum woo you, Free and glad, in Norman fashion, to conquer or die... Victory in adversity, show your courage, he who hesitates is already lost. God is the fight, and the fight is our blood, and that is why we were born...

Here, in the middle of the industrial age, the mythical primordial unity of God, battle and blood was invoked. If this was *reactionary*, then the concept had to be redefined and purged of the harmless ideas of the 19th century. But didn't the revolutionaries also orientate themselves towards an even more distant, even less tangible past?

Most characteristic of National Socialism, however, were the songs about the Führer. Will Vesper says:

So let the custom of the forefathers apply again: the leader rises from the midst of the people. Leader of the empire, as we mean it, you have long been in the hearts of your family. They knew neither crown nor throne long ago. The men were led by their ablest son... Whoever came before the army was called a duke. Duke of the Empire...

If one want terms, poems like this are evidence of a Caesarist and populist collectivism. The "Christian-Germanic" conservatives of the 19th century could not have imagined anything more revolutionary and reprehensible. And in the Soviet Union, after 1936, there was no longer any talk of the class, but only of the people, who, as the Soviet Union, still had their world-revolutionary task ahead of them. In the National Socialist songs, only the liberation of their own people is the focus. In this respect they are characterized by particularism.

Thus, these songs lead to a certain type of celebration, which quickly took on the character of a cult: the celebration of the fatherland and the cult of its personal embodiment, the leader as God's messenger or even God himself. The basis of these celebrations was usually the march past; the undertone was the unison of the boots; the environment was flags, standards and pylons; the backdrop was the many-thousand voiced "Heil." Evidently, church celebrations were a model, but so was the "splendor of the Kaiserreich." The Third Reich was an empire of celebrations as an end in itself and self-representation—that sparked sharp criticism from Oswald Spengler. But in these celebrations it presented a stark contrast to the Weimar Republic, which had looked gray and sober, and it could not be ruled out that the celebrations were intended to create the vigor and successes which Spengler felt must be their prerequisites. The dates of the National Socialist celebration year read like the festive

calendar of the Catholic Church:

January 30th of each year was the “Day of the Seizure of Power” with the traditional march of the torchbearers through the Brandenburg Gate; in March, the focus was on “Heroes’ Memorial Day,” as the Weimar Republic’s “National Day of Mourning” was now called; April 20, the “Führer’s Birthday,” was usually celebrated with a huge parade; on May 1st, “National Labor Day,” all of Germany was emblazoned in green and flags, and in Berlin alone a million and a half workers and employees marched to Tempelhofer Feld; on June 21 many party leaders in all parts of the empire addressed the “Summer Solstice” in front of blazing fires; September was the month of the annual Reich Party Rallies, which were also very impressive spectacles for foreigners because they offered moving impressions for all the senses and gave satisfaction to old shivers; at the beginning of October the “Harvest Festival” took place on the Bückeberg near Hamelin; November 9th was the commemoration day of the fallen of the movement, on which in Munich the sixteen coffins of those who died on November 9th were driven from the Feldherrnhalle to Königlicher Platz to the accompaniment of drums, where, following the example of Italian fascism, the dead were called by name and voices of Hitler Youth answered with a loud “Here”; December remained dominated by Christmas, but its transformation into the “Winter Solstice” was planned for after the war.

All this was no mere *carnival*, and even the term *panem et circenses* is hardly an adequate description of it. But since the celebration was so much an end in itself and aimed so exclusively at addressing the irrational forces in people, the distance between the emotional content and the rational staging or organization was far more striking than in the Soviet Union and among the German communists. Hence the propaganda was not a mere continuation of song and celebration. As long as it was primarily a polemic against “Versailles” and repeatedly showed “Germany’s bleeding borders,” it was able to tie in with some activities of the Weimar Republic in schools and in public. But no head of the “Reich Headquarters for Home Service” had ever expressed himself so coolly and cynically about the need for lies, primitiveness and repetition as indispensable means of propaganda as Hitler had done in “Mein Kampf.” Joseph Goebbels would have been perfectly conceivable as general director of a large advertising company and would probably have been very successful. He immediately recognized the extraordinary possibilities of radio and used them wisely: In even 1938, “Reich loudspeaker pillars” were erected. The Führer’s speeches were regularly broadcast on all German channels, and they worked in that medium, too, although their weaknesses in isolating the voice were more readily apparent than in the varied context of mass meetings. Press control was a work of skillful direction on the part of Goebbels, but

even he could tune the German press to only one main tone, and considerable remnants of the old diversity remained, unlike in the Soviet Union, where Party propaganda permeated life to the farthest corners. Great events in German history were heavily emphasized in the films, but not anti-semitism, and it was rather an exception when Goebbels had Veit Harlan produce “Jud Süß” during the war. Although Julius Streicher’s “Stürmer” could be found in countless showcases, it was also considered a cultural disgrace by many party members. Even during the war, the proportion of non-political entertainment remained remarkably large, not only in films but also in illustrated newspapers.

At this point, the basic experiences and basic emotions, which were by no means the only ones but nevertheless were the most important, are to be made clear in the distanced reflection through contemporary novels, namely those associated with the Russian revolution. It is based on three novels and a diary, all of which were written before 1933 and are therefore not subject to any influence by the Third Reich: a work that stands on the Bolshevik side and is still not mere party literature, and three works by authors of the come from the other side, the anti-Bolshevik, not the National Socialist side—only one in the one case, because the views are simple and unambiguous; three in the other, because the complexity and ambivalence of this side should be made at least partially visible.

Mikhail Sholokhov wrote the first parts of his series of novels “The Silent Don” around 1930, and in the present context the second book “War and Revolution” is of particular interest. The story begins in October 1916 with a Cossack unit of the Russian army, on which the shadows of defeat are already falling. War fatigue has spread everywhere, deadly exhaustion dominates the picture, but in the eyes of the officers all machine gunners are “contaminated” because among them are Bolshevik leaflets circulating, calling for an end to the war and to exterminate those responsible for the great murder with fire and sword: the Tsar, the nobles, the international industrial tycoons, the Russian “Burschui,” even the officers, the “dogs,” who issued or carried out the ruthless orders to attack, which cost so much blood. One of the Cossack officers, however, Ensign Bunchuk, feels similarly to the soldiers, so he deserts and joins an underground Bolshevik organization. Impotent anger fills the others against the “cholera bacilli,” the Bolsheviks, who want to hand Russia over to the German enemy. But at home, dejection and defeatism are rampant, and the rich merchant in the Cossack village feels the ground shaking beneath him, having never been able to suppress a guilty conscience because of his exploitative activities. Similarly, when the unit moves to Petrograd to protect the government, the officers sense that the Cossack soldiers are slipping away from them, for they are now willing to engage in discussion, but they know no answers to the soldiers’ “deadly simple views” of the necessity of peace and the punishment of those responsible. And

so it is not the commander-in-chief Kornilov that gains the upper hand, who demands the ruthless extermination of all Bolsheviks as a deadly carrier of germs, but the former ensign Bunchuk, who reappears in the unit as an agitator and for his part raises the merciless demand: "They, us; or we, them... Prisoners are not taken... Such (like Captain Kalmykov) must be exterminated like vermin." And then, after the Bolsheviks seize power, the front dissolves, and the soldiers "rob on the way and roll like a stormy, unstoppable avalanche through their fatherland," gunning down their officers. The Cossack unit also returns to their village, and the men do not suspect "that even more terrible horrors and events than they had experienced during the war were waiting for them on the thresholds of their huts." Very soon those wealthy but respected Cossacks who wanted the independence of the Don region from Great Russia appeal to them, but the Bolshevik agitators also court for their souls. Bunchuk fights near Rostov: neither side takes prisoners. Finally, in desperation, the ataman Kaledin shoots himself, and a procession of 5,000 Whites, including the former parliamentary speaker Rodzianko, tries to reach the Kuban by marching on foot. "Russia is going to Golgotha... the flower of Russia, Listnitsky thought... The same hatred and boundless rage that rages within me, each of these 5,000 doomed bears within them." But the other side feels no less hatred and no less bitter anger. Bunchuk is ordered to the revolutionary tribunal: "Almost every day people sentenced to death were taken out of the city in trucks, the condemned and the Red Guards dug graves in a hurry..." Bunchuk is often depressed, but he consoles himself with the thought: "Before you plant flowers and trees, you have to clean up the dirt." But under this "dirt" there are also many working people and simple Cossacks, and he cannot get rid of this oppression. In the end, his Red Guard detachment suffers a severe defeat in the Cossack area, and they are all shot, including Bunchuk and the most ardent Bolshevik among his comrades, the son of a priest.

In his novel "Between White and Red," Edwin Erich Dwinger tells of much larger battles and a much larger train of people doomed to die—of the battles of Admiral Kolchak's troops, joined by German officers who were prisoners of war, and of the victorious advance almost to the Volga, but also, after the alleged betrayal of the Czechs and the Allies, of the horrific retreat through wintry Siberia, which killed a million people, officers, soldiers, women, children—the flower of the Russian bourgeoisie, as the author puts it. There is no lack of broad descriptions of the atrocities on both sides: the indiscriminate shootings of mere suspects by the Whites, the beating of the commissars to death, the selections of the prisoners, but also the castrations and "rat trials" on the other side. Here, too, a simple world view is formulated, with which the Whites maintain themselves: the fight against the "asiatic chaos," the self-assertion against "Moloch," the "crusade for Western culture." But more strikingly, the Bolsheviks are portrayed as believers who want to bring the "earth to the birth of a new

age,” singing with fervent conviction: “The world has fundamentally changed. The slaves seized power.” Against this background, many of the White officers are seized with deep self-doubt: “We are supposed to win with this? And win against people who proclaim ideals?”— “And are they completely wrong, the Reds?”— “We are unnatural and decadent, rotten in body and soul... So, away with us!” And so the search for an idea of one’s own seems to become a mere postulate, a call to despair. What is most likely to assert itself is the urge even of the simple German soldiers to return to the fatherland, to the homeland, to order, where Russian fanaticism and Russian horror are far away and should remain far away.

Siegfried von Vegesack describes the world of the Baltic and especially the Livonian Germans as a miniature Germany, better: as an miniature of Old Germany. For him, too, the towers of Riga are “warning symbols and guardians of German culture in the extreme east.” He describes this world with affection and love: the natural and cultivated existence of the German nobility on their large estates, the sociable and mostly familial relationships, the vassalage loyalty to the tsar despite all attempts at Russification by the authorities, the inner understanding of the Latvian servants and tenants with the German “grand lords” and “grand women,” because, as one of the maids says, “the earth belongs only to the lords, just as heaven belongs only to God. That’s the way it’s arranged.” But the author also and above all describes the shattering of everything that was taken for granted up to that point: the grumbling and the rebellion of the city workers in the revolution of 1905, after the Mother of God of Kazan had been recognized as the patroness of the empire and driven through the whole of Russia in a special train and was greeted everywhere by the population on their knees, the people becoming “shameless,” finally the burning down of numerous estates and the murders of precisely those most popular among the small Latvian intelligentsia who belonged to German culture.

And as a reaction to this, a new morality is developing among the younger Germans, who want to practice a determined counter-terror against the terror and want to replace the Latvian farm workers with Germans from Volhynia, while the “grand women” of the older generation only cling to their old Christian maxims all the more resolutely: “Should your new morality really take hold of us, that there are two kinds of law for Latvians and Germans, then we ourselves have played out here. Because right remains right, and wrong remains wrong.” But in other younger Germans there is growing doubt about their own way of life, about the meaning of a life of which it is said “one hunted, one rode, one crept, and every evening there one drank heavily,” so that the exclamation of a young count “How I hate this past,” is no longer isolated.

And then the war comes and the revolution breaks out, and finally the German troops occupy Riga until they themselves turn into mere heaps at the news of the revolution in Germany and the Red Army enters Riga and the Red Terror begins: on the ice of a river dozens of Germans who were dragged there have to undress, and they are then thrown into a quickly hacked hole and to a horrible death, in Dorpat the dead dukes of Courland are pulled out of the crypt and killed once again with bayonets, three hundred men and women have to dig mass graves for themselves and stand on the edge where they are shot. But when the Baltic Territorial Army and Belarusian troops liberated Riga without being able to prevent the murder of numerous men and women in the central prison, the counter-terror is hardly less bad: whole clusters of executed Bolsheviks hang from the trees, no prisoners are taken, the defenseless were gunned down. And when with the help of the English a Latvian government is established, the great estates are divided up and justice turns out to be leveling and uglification. The hero, however, who is an anti-hero full of self-doubt and scruples, goes to where he can still be alone at home, to Germany.

Finally, the Russian bourgeois daughter Alexandra Rachmanowa, whose diaries under the title "Students, Love, Cheka and Death" found a large readership in the Weimar Republic, also went to Germany, or more precisely to Austria. She, too, begins with a description of a life that was still carefree and cultivated during the war, the life of a doctor's family somewhere in a provincial town. Here the revolution begins as a promise, and the later fiancé proudly and happily reports on the demonstrations in which he took part as a cadet. The atmosphere changes very quickly, however, with the crowds of drunken soldiers, most of whom have deserted, who are trying to insult the officers in every conceivable way. But the students are also in revolt and are demanding liberation from the yoke of the professors. The servants are constantly running into meetings, and everywhere the "Boschui pigs" and the rich are scolded, whose possessions should be distributed among the poor.

After the Bolsheviks seize power, a house servant is made commissioner of the hospital, whose medical director was Alexandra's father, and then the whirlwind of revolution dragged into the abyss not only the bourgeoisie and the church, but also those intelligentsia which had prepared it with so much enthusiasm. Shooting and being shot become the reality of everyday life. A commissioner proposes marriage to the wife of a privy councilor and, when she responds with a startled reply that she is already married, says lightly: "Well, that's very simple, we'll just shoot him." In order to dispel the *superstitions* of the people, a well-known *starets* is taken from the island where he lives and impaled on a stake to an agonizing end. A priest is brought in to pray for the starets and thereby proving the impotence of his art, and then he, along with his wife and children, is killed with blows from a rifle butt,. After the

assassination (*attempt*) of Lenin, the newspapers officially demanded that a thousand Burschuis must give their lives for the death of a Bolshevik.

Finally, the city is conquered by the White troops. There is not much talk of White terror. And yet, in Alexandra Rachmanova's diary, there is also an analogy to the self-doubt and pessimism that was found in Dwinger and Vegesack. Immediately after liberation all those goods which were sorely lacking under Bolshevik rule reappear in abundance, and immediately a thriving social life is restored. "Most people live like they used to before the Reds ruled, and nobody thinks about the front, everyone has calmed down." Was it not logical then that her rich relatives in Irkutsk gave her and her family no significant help and even wished for an end to the White regime when she arrived at the destination of the White army's terrible retreat? Even Alexandra Rachmanova's book raises the question: had the Russian bourgeoisie, had the Russian intelligentsia deserve their terrible fate in the end, had they not at least to a large extent contributed to it?

Not one of the four books is a mere party publication. Basically, all four, including Sholokhov, paint a unanimous picture of the horrors of this great upheaval, but also of its deep causes. It is striking that almost nowhere do Jews appear, with the exception of a few scenes in Sholokhov; apparently none of the authors think that such events can be explained by the actions of a single ethnic group.

If one tries to survey the whole of these basic experiences and basic emotions, then the conclusion arises that the experiences on which the workers' movement was based and which were adopted or appropriated by the Soviet Union in its war-related modifications as the basis of its self-image and how it was perceived by others, determined a large numbers of people more strongly and lastingly than did any other basic experience of the time. The class situation of ordinary workers was an overwhelming reality, and the consequence of the "call to class struggle" could seem compelling, though not without an alternative. If the *bourgeoisie* consisted in not or only partially sharing this class position of physically exhausting manual labor, insufficient pay, and being excluded from education and culture, then basic emotions could not develop in the bourgeoisie as strong and widespread as among the workers, and the politics of the Wilhelmine time is a vivid proof of this.

But the powerful reality of this class situation in *bourgeois society* was not something unchangeable and superhistorical, however slowly the changes might take place, and it could not remain without consequences for those emotions if *hunger* was at best a metaphor for very many workers, when the working hours were limited by law and when numerous

opportunities for acquiring knowledge and education opened up. Then the revolutionaries, who clung to the old concepts, had to become much more shrill in their polemics against the reformists, and the citizens had to be far more deeply frightened, especially when a world war and revolution in a neighboring country, which until then had been both feared and despised, had created entirely new facts.

Even if one assumed that the Russian bourgeoisie and the Russian intelligentsia brought about their fate themselves and thus deserved it, could one really expect that nowhere within the so extensive and diverse German bourgeoisie would a determined will for preventive resistance develop and find a widespread sympathy? What seemed quite dissimilar might now become much more alike; strong and unified emotions might succumb to fragmentation, weak and scattered counter-emotions might concentrate. The faith of the workers' movement, which had been so tangentially affected by developments and events that for many it now seemed to have become the property of a *Russian* party, might be opposed by a counter-faith, the celebration by a counter-celebration, the understanding of self and others by an opposite understanding of self and others. The dominance of the faith in Russia could then be traced back to the backwardness of the conditions and the power of the counter-faith in Germany to their progressiveness. A blurring of the clear lines and a reversal of the situation was bound to be the result.

But *one* difference, however, always remained clearly visible, and it was essential. In National Socialist literature, the Communist and Soviet opponents were accused and attacked, but they were not ridiculed for commanding too much frightened respect, even if it aroused perplexed anger that a significant number of Germans declared the Soviet Union their fatherland. National Socialism and the Third Reich fared differently on the part of the communist and even the left-liberal writers and propagandists, whether they were in Germany or in exile or in the Soviet Union: For a long time, Hitler and the Third Reich were more a mockery than a horror. Bertolt Brecht parodied the Horst Wessel song as follows:

The calves trot behind the drum They supply the skin for the drum themselves. The butcher calls. Eyes tightly shut. The calf marches with a calm, firm step. The calves whose blood has already flowed in the slaughterhouse They go with him in spirit in his ranks.

Whether this rationalist mockery would prove stronger than the unleashing of irrational forces was an open question; whether it was not itself resting on an irrational foundation of assumptions and hopes was an undecided question, but everything indicated that the cultural differences between the two movements and regimes would become even more pronounced.

Chapter IV, Section 5

The Politicized Culture

The Politicized Culture

At the height of European world dominance, between 1875 and 1900, hardly any conception was more valued than that of culture: the community of civilized states were in the process of raising the backward areas of the earth to a higher level of culture, and Nietzsche counted himself and his kind among the “exempted cultured man.” Culture meant the totality of the *higher* expressions of life, which, of course, was no longer supported by a basic religious attitude, as in Mesopotamian, Greek or medieval high culture, including a common knowledge or belief about the universe and the basis of the world as well as the right life of people. Rather, since the beginning of modern times, it had split into a number of relatively autonomous sub-areas such as religion, philosophy, science and art, which were further differentiated within themselves. What was regarded by some as cultural progress might appear to others as a lamentable dissolution of that common understanding of life in which all members of a people or nation have their unity. But neither the eulogists nor the critics of “contemporary culture” would have admitted by 1900 that any aspect of culture was wholly subordinate to politics, and it was the Marxists who intended to liberate culture from the political constraints to which they are still subject in capitalist society.

Of course, Russia found itself in the most peculiar position among the European civilized states. The great achievements of its culture, such as the works of Pushkin, Dostoyevsky and Tolstoy, were in no way inferior to the greatest works of Western culture and were highly acclaimed in Berlin and Paris, Vienna and London. It was to a large extent a self-confident culture, the culture of the leading stratum of one of the world powers, which made missionary claims and wanted to be considered the “Third Rome.” But the bearers of this culture were almost without exception shaped by the awareness that they were few in number and that the endless land areas of the empire were, in the eyes of their Western partners, filled

with culturelessness, i.e. inhabited by many millions of illiterate peasants. On the other hand, these peasants, with their orthodox belief and their loyalty to the Tsar, were a reality that could be contrasted with the *Western* lack of faith and division with a positive emphasis. Thus, Russian intellectual life was determined far more than German or even French by the struggle for one's own way, by despair at one's own lack of culture and backwardness on the one hand and by the proud self-confidence of a unified existence rooted in religion on the other. But not a few of the *Westerners* adopted the missionary consciousness and sense of superiority of their opponents, and many of the Slavophiles became *Narodniks* [*agrarian socialists*], who turned harshly against autocracy and orthodox religion.

But European socialism was also characterized by criticism of liberalism, individualism, isolation and alienation; and peculiar syntheses or syncretisms became conceivable. A Westerner like the literary critic Belinsky did not shy away from demanding that hundreds of thousands of parasites and reactionaries be eliminated in order to bring happiness to the millions of ordinary people; members of the high aristocracy Bakunin and Kropotkin became the founding fathers of anarchism in Europe, and at the same time envisaged for Russia a prominent role opposed to the West. The longing for the wholeness of life and against atomization and individualistic greed in the West formed a common trait of almost the entire Russian intelligentsia. The only ones who resolutely opposed any kind of separate path for Russia seemed to be the Marxists around Plekhanov, but keen observers doubted early on whether Lenin's intolerant dogmatism and his hatred of everything *petty-bourgeois* might not be keeping him and his group close to Bakunin and even the Slavophiles.

Thus, before the outbreak of World War I, Russian culture was more *political* than, say, German or English; the spheres of *pure art* and *objective science* were smaller; but it was not a culture that was oriented exclusively to the demand for catching up and the destruction of unmodern conditions. All tendencies of European art and European science found a strong and productive echo in Russia: Symbolism and Futurism, Cubism and Constructivism, Empiriocriticism and Pragmatism, Positivism and Lebensphilosophie had no less a place in the studios, academies and universities of Petersburg and Moscow than in the metropolises of the western world.

The Bolshevik revolution confronted all artists and all scientists with a fundamental decision: the decision of approval or rejection, participation or emigration. All *pure art* and all *pure science* were swept away as if by a storm, if only because its representatives no longer knew where to get their daily piece of bread. Writers and poets fought in the red armies, and other poets and writers followed on the side of the Whites; scholars and professors declared

themselves with one side or the other, and when they were among the losers, they tended to seek refuge abroad. Nevertheless, the first years after the civil war were an eventful and lively time for Russian culture. The most famous of the Symbolists, Alexander Blok, extolled the revolution, and the most famous of the Futurists, Vladimir Mayakovsky, even made himself a champion of it. (His idol and teacher, Filippo Tommaso Marinetti, turned to fascism around the same time.) Constructivists and Cubists gave their direction to the actual revolutionary art, and with equal determination they carried out their attacks on everything *old*, *outdated* and *bourgeois*. Mayakovsky expressed the myth of the new collectivism most effectively in his poem "150 Million":

Down with the world of romance! Down with the defeatist lamentations! With the pessimistic faith of the fathers! Down with possessiveness, in whatever form!... The almsgivers, the navel-gazers, Let the ax dance over their bald heads! Kill! Kill!! Bravo: and skull cups go well with ashtrays. We hurl new myths Let's ignite a new eternity... Gather yourselves! Step out of the millennia of darkness! Lockstep! March!... Revenge is the master of ceremonies. Hunger is the steward. Bayonet, Browning, Bomb... Forward! Tempo!

At that time, in the midst of the greatest material need, numerous poems were filled by this fiery breath of shedding the old, conquering the new, immersing yourself in the liberating collective, the dissolution of all artificial separations, building a new unity of life, inspiring many paintings, permeating not a few designs for monumental structures. Now it became possible what had never existed in Europe, that one of the leading statesmen, namely Leon Trotsky, in a manner that was as witty as it was knowledgeable, commented on the poems and novels of the new *proletarian poets*, but also of the *companions* from the old intelligentsia, the *Popuchiki*: on the islanders and the Serapion Brothers, on the "forges" and on the Futurists, on Andrei Belyi and Alexander Blok, on Vladimir Mayakovsky and Boris Pilnjak. And in precisely these essays on "Literature and Revolution" from 1924, the War Commissar formulated a creed that, in its boundless trust in science and in its irrepressible activism, was probably the most extreme and yet symptomatic testimony to that idealism on which "historical materialism" is based: "The socialist man wants and will control nature in its entirety, including the grouse and the sturgeons, with the help of machines... Man, when he has rationalized his economic order, i.e. has filled it with consciousness and subjected it to his purpose, will leave no stone unturned in his present sluggish and thoroughly rotten everyday life... The human race will not stop crawling on all fours before God, emperors and capital, to face the dark laws of heredity and the law of to humbly blind sexual selection... Man will set himself the goal of mastering his own feelings, raising his instincts to the height of consciousness, making them transparent, penetrating with his will to the deepest depths of

his unconscious and thus raising himself to a level—one higher socio-biological type, and if you will—to create the superman... The average human type will rise to the level of Aristotle, Goethe and Marx. And above this mountain range new peaks will rise.”

These enthusiastic hopes, these upsurges, these stirring goals were never entirely lost in Soviet culture. But even their most convincing beginnings were marked by the enormous gap to the miserable and gray reality that prevailed in the vast expanses of Russia and which, compared to the pre-war period, so unmistakably represented a decline and at best stagnation. And neither one nor the other could be combined with subtlety, social culture and everyday academic work. The finer minds such as Anna Akhmatowa or Boris Pasternak withdrew into obscurity as far as they did not emigrate, the *old professors* were increasingly pushed out and replaced by poorly trained young people from the “Institute of the Red Professorship.” In the process of purging the universities of foreign and hostile elements, it became possible for the GPU to accuse a professor of outright sabotage by using 500 rubles of state funds to purchase a copy of the Song of Igor, that “monument to the 12th-century princely chauvinism.” A medical doctor was attacked and removed from his position for holding the “incorrect view” that infant mortality had declined only slightly in the Soviet Union and that the heritability should not be completely disregarded.

A state censorship agency, “Galli,” had already been set up in the early 1920s and watched with eagle eyes to ensure that no *state secrets* or *hostile views* got into the press; the state was the sole publisher from the start. It was taken for granted that all educational and artistic activity must be permeated by the spirit of class struggle and that there could be no pure science. Nevertheless, it was still possible for years that the “Association of Proletarian Writers” rejected direct party influence on literature, and for high-ranking literary journals such as Voronsky’s *Red New Land* or the magazine *Lef* of the “Left Front” to resist the simple identification of art and politics.

But after the beginning of the Five Year Plan, not only did the scientists lose the last chance of individual and dissenting questions, but also the schools of artists and writers, which had been quite diverse until then, were robbed of their autonomy and strictly restricted to serving the construction of socialism. The “Association of Proletarian Writers” was dissolved and a unified writers’ association created; referring to an article by Lenin of 1905 which had stated that all social-democratic literature must become party literature, the Central Committee now decreed that the intensified class struggle did not admit of any neutrality; “cultural armies” swept through the country in “cultural campaigns” in order to bring down the still very high rate of illiteracy. With Gorky’s help, a new standard was created in the form of socialist

realism, which was characterized by partisanship and popularity and made the typical the subject in the sense that it did not describe what happened to be real, but rather what was already future and therefore normal in the present.

Now novels such as Sholokhov's "New Land Under the Plow" came into being, where, in complete contrast to "The Silent Don," the positive and negative heroes were most precisely distinguished, Nikolai Ostrovsky's "How The Steel Was Hardened," whose composition type has been compared with the structure of Byzantine saints' lives, or Gladkov's "Energy," where the depiction of production processes seems to be more important than the portrayal of living people. Mayakovsky committed suicide in April 1930. Everything that was daring, non-objective or constructivist disappeared from the paintings: cheerful shock workers forge iron, kolkhoz women ride behind a caterpillar tractor singing to work in the fields, sturdy girls help with the construction of the subway, and sailors ready for battle stand in front of the gun turrets of their battleships. Thus, in Stalin's Soviet Union of the 1930s, culture with all its spheres had in fact once again become an integral part of the social whole, a servant within the one great task of production, which was certainly a catching up and yet at the same time wanted to be an overtaking, the one turned an ancient agrarian country into a modern industrial state and which, in the exclusivity of its self-glorification, was fundamentally different from all other industrial states and for that very reason had to appear all the more threatening as a military power.

The National Socialist cultural policy began towards the end of the 1920s with an attack on those who came under fire in the Soviet Union at the same time, namely the so-called "cultural Bolsheviks," and it postulated the cultivation of what was cultivated in the Soviet Union a little later: popular art with its roots in national history. Of course, there was no such thing as development pathos, and there was no reason in Germany for "culture campaigns" to combat illiteracy. Until the end of the Weimar Republic, National Socialist cultural policy could hardly be distinguished from that of the German Nationalists.

In 1929 Alfred Rosenberg founded the "Combat League for German Culture," which campaigned against "cultural decline" and for a "spiritual rebirth" of the Germans. The artistic avant-garde was consistently equated with "Bolshevik chaos": Le Corbusier was called the "Lenin of architecture," and the Bauhaus was described as "the enemy's Bastille in the middle of the German fatherland." The architect and art historian Schultze-Naumburg spoke in numerous lectures about the battle of worldviews in art, comparing works by Nolde, Barlach, Heckel and Hofer with photos of physical deformities and "racial degeneration." Wilhelm Frick, as Minister of the Interior and Education in Thuringia, issued decrees such as

“Against the Negro Culture for German Nationality” and, against the will of the faculty, he appointed the racial researcher Hans F. K. Günther to a chair in Jena.

It was therefore consistent that he had modernism excluded from the Weimar Castle Museum: Feininger, Kandinsky, Klee, Barlach, Kokoschka, Marc and others were no longer allowed to be shown. The literary historian Adolf Bartels, whose widespread “History of German Literature” was something of a hunt for Jews and “spiritual Jews,” exercised considerable influence throughout the Reich. The call for a “national dictatorship in art matters” was not uncommon.

In 1933, this demand was also quickly realized. “Art commissars” were deployed in many places, including Hans Hinkel, who later became “Reich Culture Administrator” in the Ministry for Public Enlightenment and Propaganda. Already at the beginning of April, a large exhibition was opened in Karlsruhe entitled “Government Art from 1918 to 1933” which attempted to denounce painters of the “Brücke,” the “Blauer Reiter” and younger Expressionists by simply showing them. The poetry section of the Prussian Academy of Arts underwent a kind of *major purge* : Heinrich and Thomas Mann, Käthe Kollwitz, Alfred Döblin, Rudolf Pannwitz, Franz Werfel and others left and most of them emigrated. The “Law for the Restoration of the Professional Civil Service” provided the means for the dismissal of the entire Bauhaus staff; of the great musicians Arnold Schönberg, Bruno Walter, Otto Klemperer, Fritz Busch and others left Germany. Wilhelm Furtwängler tried to stand in front of the Jewish musicians and wrote to Goebbels in April 1933 that he ultimately recognized only one dividing line, namely that between good and bad art, but the minister answered exactly as Lenin could have put it : “Art in the absolute sense, as liberal democracy knows it, must not exist.” On May 10, long columns of German students gathered in the squares of many German cities to carry out a great book burning, and in Berlin Joseph Goebbels and the new professor for political education Alfred Baeumler delivered impassioned speeches against the intellectual decomposition that had beset Germany for fourteen years. Among other things, books by Sigmund Freud, Friedrich Wilhelm Foerster, Karl Marx, Erich Maria Remarque were burned; some of the “fire sayings” read as follows: “Against decadence and moral decay. For discipline and morals in family and state! I hand over the writings of Heinrich Mann, Ernst Glaeser and Erich Kästner to the flame.”—“The nobility of the human soul. I hand over the writings of Sigmund Freud to the flame.”—““Against literary betrayal of the soldiers of the world war, for the education of the people in the spirit of truthfulness! I hand over the writings of Erich Maria Remarque to the flame.” The Germanist Hans Naumann interpreted the event in Bonn with the words: “We are shaking off foreign rule, we are lifting an occupation,” and Alfred Baeumler said in

Berlin that National Socialism meant spiritually “the replacement of the educated by the soldier.”

Now the burning of documents and books, but also of dolls of political figures, had a long and predominantly *progressive* tradition not only in Germany but also in England, from Martin Luther to the Wartburg Festival and to the burning of symbolic straw dolls in the Chartist era. Some of the branded authors were also inaccessible to the ordinary reader in the Soviet Union, where the “Committee for Public Education” had even indexed Plato and Schopenhauer in the early 1920s, and where large special departments had been set up in public libraries to store unwanted literature. But the entire world press was gathered in Berlin, and its correspondents were not subject to the pre-censorship that from the outset made it unwise for Western reporters in Moscow, even in 1925, to report on the courageous and sharp words with which the German student Kindermann had confronted the judges in the so-called “Student Trial.” Thus what was denounced throughout the world as “medieval” was essentially a consequence of anti-liberal totalitarianism, and Nazi Germany suffered a severe intellectual defeat because it was far more accessible and open than the Soviet Union. The unmistakable conservatism, which with its respect for the Wehrmacht proved to be advantageous in terms of rearmament and readiness for war, in this spectacular and radicalized form made National Socialism alien even among the most conservative English, precisely because Germany was still unquestionably part of the European cultural community.

The period up to early 1934 was, however, a transitional stage, and it was made possible largely by the rivalry between Goebbels and Rosenberg, the first of whom was more liberal or less dogmatic. Some exponents of the National Socialist German Student League tried to save Expressionism as a German movement, and indeed one could point to Hanns Johst, who had once stood alongside Johannes R. Becher as an artist, but now—like Becher on the other side—mainly wanting to be a champion of the party and uttered the infamous sentence when he heard the word “culture,” he would draw his revolver. For their part, the remnants of the National Socialist left polemicized violently against the art reaction and demanded a complete revolution that would also transform art as well. Hitler himself spoke out against both ethnic dogmatism and avant-garde modernism. The most important organizational basis for National Socialist culture was created as early as September 22, 1933: the Reich Chamber of Culture Act made the practice of art at least tendentially an office of the ethnic state. The individual chambers, such as the “Reich Literature Chamber” and the “Reich Chamber of Fine Arts” imposed rigorous discipline on their members, loss of membership was identical with professional, even work bans; the best-known victim was Ernst Barlach. The most important

party official bodies dealing with culture were the office of the Führer's representative for the supervision of the entire ideological training and education of the NSDAP under Alfred Rosenberg and the "Examination Commission for the Protection of NS-Literature" under Reichsleiter Philipp Bouhler. They can be compared with "Glavlit" and partly also with the Central Committee Department for Propaganda and Agitation, while the Reich Literature Chamber corresponded to the Writers' Union.

From the beginning of 1934, only "NS-Art" officially existed alongside the large area of non-political entertainment. But since numerous private publishers were still active, many non-compliant authors could continue to publish their works as long as they did not take a conspicuous position against the regime. But the undisputed dominance was "folk poetry," in which peasant novels held a prominent place. In addition to the "blood and soil" poetry, Werner Beumelburg, P.C. Ettighofer and Hans Zöberlein portrayed the positive experience of war, the mythicization of German history by Hans Friedrich Blunck and Wilhelm Schäfer, the national struggle by Hans Grimm and Wilhelm Pleyer, and German metaphysics with Erwin Guido Kolbenheyer. However, this literature is only inadequately characterized as the "victory of the most flat country": the connection to important figures such as Stefan George, Ernst Jünger and Gerhart Hauptmann was evident in many places. It would be better to say that *a* main tendency of German literature was prepared, which condemned itself to barrenness or isolation, as was particularly vividly shown by the example of Gottfried Benn, who first welcomed the Third Reich and then chose inner emigration in the Wehrmacht. In 1938, inner-German literature counted just as little in the global context as did the literature of "socialist realism": it *only* wanted to be German, and it also proved that literature as such cannot live from *one* root.

A similar development took place in the visual arts. Here Hitler's interest was much stronger. With a negative purpose, he had the "Degenerate Art" exhibition set up, which was supposed to be an "exhibition of 'cultural documents' of Bolshevism" and actually aroused a lot of sincere indignation among the numerous visitors. The "Great German Art Exhibitions," which Hitler usually opened himself in Munich's "House of German Art," were to have a positive effect: in addition to many still lifes, there were the peasant romanticism of Sepp Hilz, Adolf Ziegler's nude naturalism and the monumental sculptures of Josef Thorak and Arno Breker, and a curious example of the Führer cult was Hubert Lanzinger's "Banner Bearer Hitler," where Hitler was depicted in knight's armor. Everything difficult, complicated and surprising had disappeared, simple lines reigned everywhere for a kingdom of a thousand timeless years.

In the area of the theater, the "Thing Sites" were to be seen as an independent National

Socialist attempt. Here too, as in Meyerhold's Moscow experiments, the intention was to abolish the separation between artist and audience. In 1933, Richard Euringer's "German Passion" was performed for the first time in this way. But the transition to the pagan symbolic world did not succeed, and in 1937 the experiment came to an end. The theater of the National Socialist period remained essentially *bourgeois educational theater*, which had its most important protector in Hermann Goering and its most famous actor in Gustaf Gründgens.

Things were quite different in architecture. It was regarded by Hitler as his own field. Huge plans for the reorganization of Berlin were drawn up by Albert Speer on behalf of Hitler, which were not inferior in monumentality to the plans of the early Soviet period; the Nuremberg party rally grounds were at least partially completed. The New Reich Chancellery and the House of German Art were classical, the Ordensburgs somber and threatening, while the model of the "High School" deserves at best the title "mindless-monumental." The later designs for monuments to the dead in the Russian steppe were nightmares of quasi-oriental excess. The "National Socialist desire to build" cannot be understood without the background of cultural criticism and without the will to abolish modern alienation, but it actually implemented the law of all great despotisms.

This atmosphere was particularly paralyzing for philosophy and science. But here, too, there was no mere external collapse. The old antithesis of philosophy and science had been developed from the beginning of the century to the point of antisecularism. Germany's most important philosopher sided with National Socialism, as did the best-known jurist. However, Heidegger had already changed his mind in 1934, and Carl Schmitt also became suspicious of the party in the end. There were a number of points of contact with National Socialism in the specialist sciences, although only a very small proportion of the professors were National Socialists. But even a man like Eduard Spranger welcomed the liberation from Marxism and psychoanalysis, and Karl Jaspers' 1930 "Spiritual Situation of the Present" was hardly likely to lead young readers away from National Socialism, since the writing was close to the spirit of the conservative revolution. The Germanists and historians were overwhelmingly on the *national* side from the earliest Weimar days, and if until 1933 they had tended to counterbalance the encroaching social sciences, they now seemed to dominate the field completely unchallenged. The largest proportion of Jewish professors was to be found in non-political subjects such as medicine and the natural sciences, but also in subjects that were not yet fully recognized, such as sociology and political science. There was very little resistance from German scholars to the dismissal or expulsion of their Jewish and leftist colleagues, but a breach of solidarity had often occurred earlier and not always from just one

side. However, one could by no means speak of a brown university. A kind of university revolution did indeed take place, but it was initiated by the students, and old motives also played a role here, such as the fight against “professorial rule” and for student co-determination. Spontaneity from below, however, was soon replaced by taut authority from above, as the rector and deans now became superiors and “leaders.” However, there was still much dissatisfaction among the young, who were not all young in years, but wanted a *National Socialist science*. These included Ernst Krieck, Alfred Baeumler and Walter Frank. Frank’s attack on one of the most respected men of the guild, Hermann Oncken, which he published in the *Völkischer Beobachter* under the heading “L’Incorruptible,” probably aroused more fear than outrage. But Frank’s “Reich Institute for the History of the New Germany” nevertheless never became an analogue of the “Institute of the Red Professorship” and was essentially limited to “Research on the Jewish Question.” In the influential *Historischen Zeitschrift*, Friedrich Meinecke was replaced as editor by Karl Alexander von Müller, but von Müller was also one of the established scholars, and Frank was not able to penetrate the core area of the journal, where the old scholarly line was still being followed.

National Socialism was in fact harshly opposed to the principle of science, and when the Nobel Prize winner Philipp Lenard highlighted this fact particularly clearly in the title of his book “German Physics,” then the distance to the concept of “objectivity of science” was even greater than in the case of the “science of the proletariat” in the Soviet Union, because the proletariat raised a claim to universality and Germanness did not. And so it was objectively unjust that many intellectuals in the countries of western democracies hardly took any notice of the millions of victims of collectivization and the resulting famine and directed all their indignation at National Socialist Germany, but from the point of view of culture their behavior was justified or at least not incomprehensible.

An agrarian state which carries on its industrialization with all its strength and ruthless use of force, depriving culture of all autonomy and forcing it entirely in the service of the supreme end, may be a terrifying and dangerous state for its neighbors. But a modern industrial nation that celebrates the deeds of war and the gods of its forefathers at thing sites—even if it is just the intention—is an inherently untrue entity that is only temporarily possible under very specific conditions if it does not resort to violent measures of persecution and if one admits that industrial society makes non-industrial forms of life possible.

If, therefore, despite the similar *politicization*, the difference between the regimes in the area of culture is particularly visible, the similarity may become more apparent as soon as the basics of everyday existence are at stake, of law and lawlessness.

Chapter IV, Section 6

Law and Lawlessness

The Soviet conception of law and of lawlessness results from the basic ideas that were self-evident for Lenin and his comrades-in-arms and from which practical consequences could easily be derived.

In October 1920 Lenin said at a Komsomol congress: “Morality is that which serves to destroy the old exploitative society and to unite all working people.” This definition, in turn, results from the objective of socialism, which is defined as “the general disarmament, eternal peace and fraternal cooperation of all peoples on earth,” as stated in the “Decree on Compulsory Training in the Craft of War” of April 1918. Domestically, therefore, as the Chekist Peters put it, a systematic war had to be waged against the bourgeoisie in order to transform it from a parasitic class into a community of workers, and thus to make it disappear as a class; in foreign policy the transfer of the means of production into the hands of the working class had to be promoted in every conceivable way, thus making the international communist movement the “gravedigger of bourgeois society.” Therefore, the proletarian dictatorship could not be bound by laws, not even by its own, since direct use of force could always be necessary to help the “revolutionary sense of justice” to victory. Thus Trotsky was able to describe the “execution” of the Tsar and his family as a “summary justice” intended to show supporters and opponents alike that the leaders of the proletariat were determined to wage the struggle mercilessly and to accept only the alternative of “victory or utter ruin.” Poems such as the following by Demjan Bedny fit seamlessly into this pathos of cleansing the earth of all injustice and wickedness:

On! On! You people, avenger of the suffering of the earth
Wake up, stand up! Strike dead, strike dead!
Kill all those people’s criminals
You all the robbers of our bread.

This demand may have been poetic exaggeration, but the right of the revolution imperiously

demanded the disenfranchisement of its enemies, and Lenin, in a speech to the Central Council of Trade Unions, referred emphatically to Article 23 of the Constitution of the RSFSR, which states that the Soviet Republic deprives individual persons and individual groups of rights that were being used to the detriment of the interests of the socialist revolution, and he continued: “We have openly declared that in the transitional period, in a period of bitter struggle, we not only do not promise freedom to the right and left, but we say from the outset that we will deprive citizens who stand in the way of the socialist revolution of their rights. And who will judge? The proletariat will judge.” But in other statements Lenin made it very clear early on that revolutionary violence must also be directed against wavering and hesitant elements of the working class itself. Law, therefore, could be nothing other than the unrestricted will of the party and consequently of the party leadership, and lack of right was the condition into which all enemies of this will had to be placed by law. Therefore the Cheka also belonged to the sphere of administration of justice; the “people’s judges” were organs of the party that had no independence whatsoever; and the enemies’ lack of rights did not even spare the wives of the long-dead priests, who were deprived of all civil rights and had no right to ration cards. In 1922 the first of the great show trials was held, that of 22 social revolutionaries, and large crowds of children were mustered to chant “death to the social revolutionaries, death to the enemies of the people” in front of the courthouse. Never before in European history had a group of men so completely aligned their will with the will of history and with the salvation of mankind; never before had a ruling class so openly declared its interests to be the supreme criterion of action, since it wanted to be the last of the *ruling classes* and the portent of the end of all rule. So at the Moscow “student trial” the walls of the courtroom were decorated with slogans like the following: “The workers and peasants judge according to the principles of the class struggle.”— “The proletarian court protects the interests of the working class”— “The proletarian court is the organ of the revolutionary dictatorship.”

Therefore it could not be wrong if the Cheka was in sharp contradiction to all the principles of the *rule of law* that had developed over the long centuries of European history: police and state authority, judge and executioner in one. In a narrower sense, however, a legal system developed in which courts and public prosecutor’s offices were special authorities and laws formed the basis of proceedings. But the provisions of the RSFSR Criminal Code of 1926 show how little a fundamental separation was introduced.

The humanitarian objectives were implicit in the assurances that the law envisaged measures of “social protection of a judicial, medical or medically ameliorating nature” and did not set itself the task of retribution and punishment; it refrained from inflicting physical suffering or

violating human dignity. But the “heaviest measure of social protection” was shooting or “declaring the enemy of the working people,” all of which involved confiscation of property. The offenses described in the 14 paragraphs of Article 58 were almost exclusively “counter-revolutionary” crimes against state security, and they were defined with such vagueness that even an attempt to weaken the “fundamental gains” of the revolution was punishable by death. But the same punishment was also provided, according to paragraph 14, for acts of the same kind “if they are directed against another state of the working people not belonging to the Union of the SSR,” namely “by virtue of the international solidarity of the interests of all working people.” “Treason to the fatherland,” which was also punishable by death, was also defined in paragraph 14 as “defecting to the enemy” and “fleeing abroad”; Section 3 also punished “maintaining relations with a foreign state or individual representatives of it with counter-revolutionary intent” and Section 8 “commissioning terrorist acts against representatives of Soviet power or officials of revolutionary organizations of workers and peasants.” Paragraph 14 even threatened the “willful failure to perform certain obligations” with shooting if there were aggravating circumstances and the intention was to impair the power of the government and the functioning of the state apparatus. But not only acts were considered crimes, but also omissions, and paragraph 1c introduced kinship imprisonment in the event of a military person fleeing abroad, and even punished those adult members of the traitor’s family who had been ignorant with five years’ deportation to remote districts Siberia and the loss of voting rights. Until 1929, Article 12 was worded in such a way that it made the death penalty possible for children from the age of 12, even for theft. The paragraph evidently referred to the “Besprisornyyjs,” the neglected children some of whom had formed gangs of thieves, and this article of the law does not invalidate claims that the GPU administratively disposed of such children by the many thousands.

Such an anti-human law with such humanitarian grounds was unique in the world in 1926. And it was followed a little later by the law on the protection of public property, based on which, according to Solzhenitsyn’s report, six collective farmers were shot because they had hayed a meadow that had already been mowed for their own cows. How could there have been a right to strike in such a state, when Lenin, in his last years, had expressly recognized the possibility of a conflict of interests between the workers and the heads of nationalized industry? How could there have been independence of the judges or even a relationship of trust between the accused and their defense lawyers? How could there be any question of *objectivity* of law and judiciary when in 1932 the Prosecutor General Krylenko even demanded to put an end to the neutrality of chess?

Those who did not belong to an “enemy class” by birth and abstained from all

“counter-revolutionary” acts were also granted rights in Stalin’s constitution of 1936 that were missing in the constitutions of Europe: the right to work in Article 118, the right to recreation in Article 119, the right to free education in Article 121. Of course, one could ask whether such a drastic change in the concepts of right and wrong was really worthwhile if in the end only a few rights were created, which were becoming more and more a reality in Western countries on the way to welfare statehood, apart from the right to work, which in practice is a duty to work? And the objections became even more serious if Trotsky was right, who in October 1936 in *the Bulletin of the Opposition* —from abroad, of course—described social conditions in the Soviet Union as follows: “Some live in barracks and walk in torn shoes , others drive luxury cars and live in luxurious apartments. Some struggle to support their families, others have servants, a dacha near Moscow, a villa in the Caucasus, etc.” Then, however, a ruling class would have secured its rule by identifying with the law in an unprecedented way, and the lack of rights would have been the fate of all working people who had been controlled by “domestic passports” since 1932 and since 1940 could be punished with two years in prison for being 20 minutes late. Or was the target provision of the Penal Code of 1926 to be taken seriously, and were all differences in living conditions only of a temporary nature, because the Soviet Union would soon establish the communist social order and finally overthrow the exhausted world bourgeoisie? Or did Stalin make his power identical with law only because his state would soon have to fight for its very survival?

In Germany, the “rule of law” had a much older and more solid tradition than in Russia: the concept of equality of all citizens before the law had long been associated with the concept of the independence of the judiciary, the public administration of justice, the judicial reviewability of administrative decisions, and the principle of “nulla poena sine lege” [*no punishment for things not prohibited*] and thus become a reality. Only in this way could social and political struggles be both “publicized” and “tamed,” i.e. both facilitated and brought to non-violence. According to its intention, however, the liberal concept of law was not limited to domestic conditions: it seemed to imply the equality of all people regardless of race, descent or religion. But in this form it proved to be a borderline concept that did not correspond to reality: nowhere in the world do foreigners have the same rights as citizens, even within a state complete equal treatment is not always possible, because in troubled and even more so in revolutionary times, each state treats the same crime differently, depending on whether it has the intention of undermining or bolstering state power, and the fact of court-martial jurisdiction implies an essential difference between soldiers and civilians. Nor can it be denied that the liberal concept of the rule of law leads to a legal monopoly of the state and, as “legal positivism,” cuts the ties with the anthropological basis which alone can

legitimize something like “inalienable human rights” and set limits to any arbitrariness in majority decisions.

In any case, of all the legal systems that existed after the First World War, the liberal legal order was undoubtedly the one that granted its own enemies the greatest freedom and the greatest scope for action. In tsarist Russia there was as little of this as in the Islamic countries under the rule of “Sharia,” and the revolution of Bolshevism retained precisely this principle of unequal treatment of *believers* and *unbelievers*, indeed it intensified it in a hitherto unknown way.

This fact, which had an impact throughout Europe and especially in Germany, presented the liberal legal system with an elementary decision: should the principle be retained, although the differentness of reality could not be overlooked, or should a new identity of law and reality be sought, by developing principles that better corresponded to the social and state struggle situation? The second alternative was the conception of National Socialism (and before that of Italian fascism): here law was not seen as the only imperfect overcoming of social and state disputes through the peaceful settlement of unavoidable conflicts, so that a coexistence of the different was made possible, but precisely as an expression and instrument of these debates. This has always been at the core of the Soviet and Marxist concept of law, and Carl Schmitt’s doctrine of the state of exception, the insufficiency of the norm and the nature of the political as a friend-enemy relationship was an answer and correspondence. The fate of the Weimar judiciary was decided by the fact that it perceived the communist frontal attack on *civil law* far more strongly than the National Socialist attack from behind, which at first appeared to be a relief effort and yet arose from a more hostile spirit than that frontal attack because it represented lawlessness certain groups not as a temporary emergency measure to achieve a later and more complete equality of rights and life, but as the expression of eternal rights themselves. However, this view was only gradually worked out and fixed institutionally; the traditional concept of law and the existing legal system remained in place throughout the Third Reich, and Adolf Hitler could not say for a moment that he had definitively won the battle against the “reactionary jurists.”

However, already during the first months of the Third Reich great steps were taken towards a legal system in which law and politics would be identical to each other. The Decree of the Reich President for the Protection of the German People of February 4, 1933 created a special political law that had to work in favor of the ruling party, but it did not differ in principle from comparable measures of the Weimar Republic, such as the Republic Protection Act. On the other hand, the so-called Reichstag Fire Decree of February 28th—the

Decree of the Reich President for the Protection of People and State—meant the abolition of the fundamental rights provisions of the Weimar Constitution, and it contained no safeguards for the exceptional character of the measures “to defend against communist acts of violence threatening the state.” In this respect, the rule of law was already been eliminated and permanent martial law was put in its place, which could only be legitimized as a “healthy national order.” Equally important was the abolition of the principle “*nulla poena sine lege*,” which was already demanded in the cabinet meeting on March 7 with reference to the arsonist Van der Lubbe by the Reich Interior Minister Frick, while the State Secretary in the Reich Ministry of Justice Schlegelberger contradicted in vain with the reference only in Russia and China as well as in some smaller cantons of Switzerland this principle did not apply. The April laws for the restoration of professional civil service and the July laws for the prevention of hereditary diseases also entailed a conscious departure from the principles of the rule of law. The introduction of special courts on March 21, 1933 was only one of the steps taken to create political martial justice; the formation of the People’s Court on April 24, 1934, which replaced the Reich Court in matters of high and state treason, was a preliminary highlight. The actions of June 30, 1934 could only be described as *state murders*, but even they were justified by the most outstanding legal teacher in the Reich, Carl Schmitt, with the sentences that the legal blindness of liberal legal thinking had made criminal law the Magna Carta of the criminals the same way it has made constitutional law the Magna Carta of high traitors and national traitors; the Führer’s action was not subject to justice, but was itself the highest justice. Carl Schmitt thus pointed in the direction of an over-equivalence that surpassed the Soviet example in thought, just as Hitler’s conduct had already surpassed it in fact in the Röhm case.

Efforts to reform criminal law, which were primarily promoted by the Reich Legal Leader Hans Frank, had more of the aim of opposing Soviet “class justice” with “national justice,” the aim of which was to “maintain the concrete national community order, to eradicate the vermin, to punish anti-community behavior and to arbitrate disputes among the community members.” A democratic tendency could be seen in the polemics against “jurists who were alien to the people” and in the demand that legal work had to be “close to the people and not close to their class.” The “Nuremberg Laws” could easily be reconciled with this way of thinking, because the orientation towards *blood* as the basic element of the offense had already formed the basis of the Civil Service Act or the “Reich Law on Admission to the Bar” of April 7, 1933, which reduced the number of Prussian Notaries by a full third. The criminal law reform, however, did not get very far as a codified process, and in practice it was carried out more under the table by the Gestapo pushing back the judiciary and by creating a justice-free punishment through administrative incarceration in concentration

camps.

But at the outbreak of the war, the “old justice” had by no means been abolished, and the number of prisoners in concentration camps was far from equal to the Soviet numbers; nor were the Jews completely deprived of rights, however much they were certainly under special law and however much the *Aryanizations* in the economy were no longer very far removed from simple confiscations.

On the contrary, astonishing court decisions were possible in Germany up until the outbreak of war and beyond. As late as May 1935, the contestability of Gestapo decrees was affirmed. Around the same time, the so-called Hohnstein Trial was being held against the SA-Obersturmbannführer Jähnichen and 22 co-defendants who had maltreated prisoners in the Hohnstein concentration camp in the spring of 1933. Despite massive pressure from the party, heavy prison sentences were imposed. As a result, the two lay judges were expelled from the NSDAP, and Hitler remitted the remaining sentence in November 1935.

In the Niemöller trial at the beginning of 1938, the mild sentence of 7 months’ imprisonment in the fortress was imposed, which, moreover, was considered to have been served due to the pre-trial detention. However, the founder of the “Pfarrernotbund” [*Emergency Covenant of Pastors*] was not released, but was taken to the Sachsenhausen concentration camp as a personal “prisoner of the Führer.”

The public prosecutor’s office brought charges against a pastor in the Rhineland because he had exclaimed “Woe to Germany” at the end of a sermon. However, since he had referred to Rosenberg’s “myth,” the court did not open a main hearing on the grounds the Reich leader’s book was a private work.

Even during the war, the punishment of Berlin Jews who, in the opinion of the party, had behaved provocatively by reporting to receive a special coffee allocation, was rejected.

However, September 1, 1939 did not primarily signify a qualitative change because extremely harsh laws were introduced, which threatened even listening to foreign broadcasts with death, but because Hitler’s decree of September 1 made possible the destruction of “life unworthy of life” and thus indicated that the warlike struggle for existence would now bring his conception of law as a way of fighting everything “sick, decadent, harmful and dangerous” into the realm of appropriate realization. The law in the sense of the lack of rights for all enemies and pests thus became a structural feature of the National Socialist state only during the war and to the

full extent after the start of the war against the Soviet Union. Basically, until then there were only beginnings and prefigurations. But as late as April 1942, Hitler was able to deliver a Reichstag speech, filled with seething rage against jurists and civil servants, in which he demanded the authority to disregard “well-earned rights” and even dismiss judges without further ado if, in his eyes, they were not fulfilling their duties. One only needs to imagine for a moment that Stalin made such a speech in the summer of 1942, or even in 1932, to realize how strongly the constitutional basic concept of the rule of law remained in Germany deep into the war.

Thus, a revealing statement by the head of Office III in the Reich Main Security Office, SS Brigadeführer Ohlendorf, dated October 11, 1942, did not coincidentally fall into wartime insofar as it polemicized against the Governor General and Reich Legal Leader Hans Frank, who in several lectures presented himself as a pioneer of legal security and judicial independence, but in principle the statements could have been made during peacetime.

According to the National Socialist view, the individual no longer finds his rights in an isolated position against the state, against the community, but only with the community and as a member of the community of his people. Therefore, only those who do not subordinate themselves to the ties to the national community out of inner obligation, but perceive them as an external compulsion, see legal security as threatened. The influence of the political leadership on the activities of the judge could largely be avoided “if the judiciary had at its disposal a corps of judges with a uniform political and ideological orientation.” Such men would no longer be characterized by alienation from the people, but would be able to draw justice from the people’s living sense of justice, without capitulating to the letter of the law or ignoring political demands. The law would then no longer belong to a caste of jurists as a kind of private property, but through the inclusion of the ideological and political demands of National Socialism it would again have become a matter for the whole people.

But with regard to the present, Ohlendorf stated as late as October 1942 that there was no such ideologically shaped body of judges, and in 1939 he could have made these statements with even greater justification. With regard to the law, too, despite the similarity in the basic collectivist approach, the two regimes were more different than similar during peacetime, but here—in contrast to culture—precisely because in Germany those characteristics were better preserved which were still regarded as the hallmarks of modernity in almost the entire world. However, this was not due to National Socialism, but to the resistance against National Socialism, the character of which was not immediately comparable to the resistance against Bolshevism or Stalinism in the Soviet Union.

Chapter IV, Section 7

Emigration and Resistance

In a broader sense, emigration and resistance already existed in classical antiquity and in the early modern period, while the terms probably cannot be applied to the Middle Ages; however, in a narrower sense, emigration and resistance should only be discussed after the state of the Liberal System has been formed in the most important parts of the world and has become a paradigm almost everywhere. In it, dissent and deviant action are institutionally protected, indeed they are encouraged, and criticism of the government is therefore not resistance but opposition. Since there is no resistance, there is also no politically justified emigration: between 1870 and 1914 there were no groups of English, French or Germans living abroad who would have left the respective country in protest and fought its government. Such an emigration and a corresponding, i.e. forbidden, resistance existed only among Russians or in Russia. But these realities and concepts could only be spoken of because the measuring stick of the *progressive West* was also applied to Russia. In the strictest and truest sense, emigration and resistance should be spoken of only when a state in which opposition was possible is brought back in this or that way to a state in which free decision-making without danger to those involved is no longer permitted in the state because one party, which regards all other parties as “enemies” and seeks to destroy them, has seized power.

Tsarist Russia was in its idea a patriarchal state in which the will of the “autocrat” was identical with the will of the whole, and the unquestionable devotion of the mass of peasants was proof that the idea was firmly rooted in reality. But from the two capitals—under the influence of Western European concepts—the unity of the patriarchal state was more and more questioned, first by parts of the nobility and then by many protagonists of the bourgeoisie and the intelligentsia. The beginnings of an industrial revolution and the advance of social differentiation made Russia, under the cover of tsarist censorship, more and more like the rest of Europe, and with the February Revolution it seemed to have become the freest

country in the world, having finally outgrown autocracy and the state church. The grumbling and the reluctance of the representatives of the ancien régime should not be called *resistance* ; all the forces that mattered politically—from the “Octobrists” and the “Cadets” to the Social Democrats—were united in affirming *the revolution* . Presumably they would have remained united on fundamentals if the situation of the almost-lost war had not played such a large part in the upheaval and if this very situation had not made such profound and extremely controversial decisions necessary.

When the Bolsheviks seized power under the banner of the demand for immediate peace and expropriation of land from the landowners, the “Committee for the Defense of the Homeland and the Revolution” was formed in Petrograd on the evening of November 8, which can be regarded as the first organization of resistance against the Bolshevik “counter-revolution.” To a large extent, it involved the members of the other socialist parties, against whom the coup had been directed in the main. The government of the People’s Commissars, however, asserted itself against this committee with an armed hand just as quickly as against Kerensky’s attempt to retake the capital with the help of loyal troops. The criticism of leading Bolsheviks of the formation of a one-party government is more likely to be subsumed under the concept of opposition than that of resistance. But one act of government which, as an outspoken measure of persecution, was *bound* to create a situation of resistance for a large party was the decree in 1917, declaring the Constitutional Democrats “outlaws.” The first act of resistance that resulted in fatalities was the protest demonstration after the dissolution of the Constituent Assembly, and with this the regime not only definitely crossed the line of legality, but also shed the blood of workers for the first time, whom of course it called “petty bourgeois” in an early act of the semantic war. How could centers of military resistance not have formed after the regime itself had initiated the civil war in May 1918 by attempting to disarm the Czechoslovaks? The government in Samara or Ufa, behind which stood the “Komuch” made up of members of the Constituent Assembly, had some justification for considering itself the legal government of the country, and when Fanny Kaplan was arrested after the assassination attempt of Lenin, she said that Lenin was a traitor to socialism because he had dispersed the Constituent Assembly, and that all of Russia must unite around the government in Samara. But after this very government had been overthrown by a coup by its Minister of War, Admiral Kolchak, there could no longer be any question of legality on either side, and apparently only the weapons of civil war spoke.

Nevertheless, there were still signs of opposition and some forms of resistance on both sides. The ousted Social Revolutionaries played a significant part in Kolchak’s defeat, and behind Denikin a party system seemed to be developing from which only the Bolsheviks would be

excluded. On the Bolshevik side, the Mensheviks had not been banned for some time, and they collaborated with the soviets. However, they were under so much pressure and had so little chance in the open elections to the soviets that when leading Mensheviks published extremely harsh criticisms of the Bolshevik dictatorship in magazines or pamphlets, they were acts of resistance rather than opposition, and in a private letter, Martov even spoke of the “monstrous and belligerent system of Asiatic government” which was taking Russia back even further than Tsarist autocracy to a barbaric past. Nevertheless, Martov and Dan, Liber and Nikolayevsky shied away from the decisive step, namely, the transition to the White side, and this was not least due to the fact that the White armies not entirely infrequently unleashed pogroms against the Jews. Thus, despite all opposition and despite some resistance, the Mensheviks and Social Revolutionaries remained rather a weight on the scales of the Bolsheviks, and only after the end of the civil war were they finally thrown into prison or driven into exile.

They were the last group to join the emigrants abroad as a form of resistance that could no longer articulate itself in their own country, but which remained in contact with the resistance movements in the fatherland in a variety of ways, for example through those of Martov and then “*Socialisticheskiy Vestnik*” magazine, published by Boris Nikolayevsky in Berlin, of which numerous copies made it to Russia for many years to come and found eager readers there.

As an overall phenomenon, Russian emigration was the largest the world had ever seen. In the early 1920s it comprised about one and a half million people, and all of them had left the country for political reasons at immediate risk to life and limb, where hundreds of thousands of their respective party friends or class members had been killed or died of hunger and cold.

This emigration included, above all, the leaders and large sections of the supporters of all non-Bolshevik parties.

The monarchists had formed the backbone of the White armies in Russia; they went into emigration almost without exception, the last being the officers and the men of General Wrangel’s army, which evacuated the Crimea in November 1920 and was initially maintained as an armed force with the reluctant help of the French in Gallipoli and elsewhere. The further fate of these men was terrible: they were turned into free refugees and distributed among various countries. But the living conditions of the other emigrants were also generally deplorable: in Berlin alone in 1923, some 300,000 Russians were dependent on carrying out simple tasks or on support; not a few died of hunger.

During their emigration, the liberals quickly split into a right-wing and a left-wing faction, the second of which, under the leadership of Paul Milyukov, moved more and more closer to the right-wing Socialist-Revolutionaries.

Quite a few of the Socialist-Revolutionaries openly boasted that, through *their* work behind the fronts of the monarchist armies, they had saved Russia from the reactionary “general on the white horse,” and most monarchists therefore hated the “treacherous SRs” hardly less than the Bolsheviks.

A great many Mensheviks had gone over to the Bolsheviks in the course of 1917 and 1918, but Julius Martov and the inner leadership had always opposed the ruling party. But in a certain sense they had legitimized the Bolshevik regime through their criticism, and when they finally emigrated, a characteristic ambivalence remained: as early as 1926 the party demanded *de jure* recognition of Soviet Russia, and it was therefore usually considered “half-Bolshevik” by the monarchists.

The monarchists, however, did not form a cohesive unit either; rather, they divided into the main Entente-friendly section under Grand Duke Nikolai Nikolayevich in Paris and a more German-friendly minority under Grand Duke Kirill Vladimirovich. This minority included the Russian emigrants in Bavaria who had close ties with Max von Scheubner-Richter and later sided with the Third Reich under the leadership of General Biskupski.

But to a considerable extent Russian emigration was not primarily politically motivated, but rather literary and scientific. Entire subjects disappeared very quickly from the universities, such as “bourgeois national economics” and “idealist philosophy,” and in the field of history some particularly distinguished *alumni* only managed to survive with great difficulty until the beginning of the 1930s. Numerous scholars, such as the philosophers Nikolai Berdyaev and Semyon Frank in 1922, were expelled simply because of their worldview. Many of the important poets and writers also emigrated, including Dmitry Mereshkovsky and the later Nobel Prize winner Ivan Bunin. The internal emigration included Anna Akhmatova and Ossip Mandelstam, and also Boris Pasternak; the great poet Gumilyov was administratively shot by the Cheka in 1921 based on an implausible accusation. But the exiled writers were unable to assert their claim to represent Russian literature despite founding numerous publishing houses and important journals. On the one hand, the Western public did not take a very active interest in them because of the language barrier, and on the other hand, some of the most important poets stayed behind in Russia and some even took the side of the revolution. Moreover, new poets appeared in Russia who quickly became known abroad,

such as Isaak Babel and Boris Pilnyak, and quite a few of the emigrants eventually returned home, including Alexei Tolstoy, who became a highly esteemed “Soviet poet.”

The most peculiar phenomenon in Russian emigration was the so-called “change of signs” (“smena wech”). In 1921, six authors published an anthology under this title in which they sharply criticized themselves. The emigrants had so far been guided by the false view that the Bolsheviks were an international gang of robbers alien to the Russian people. But it had now become clear that this party had saved Russia from ruin and that it had deep roots in Russia’s past. It was no coincidence that the most famous general in the tsarist army, Brusilov, had agreed to serve in the Red Army. An international doctrine has become a national reality, and the conclusion must now be drawn from this, namely to change the road signs and return to Russia.

It is true that this return migration did not take place on a large scale, since the ruling party was much less accommodating to the White officers than to the writers. But nevertheless a powerful tendency found its first expression in it, and it formed an ominous omen for the resistance, which was potentially very strong within the country, but which had no nucleus of crystallization after the dissolution of the old army, the nationalization of industry and the expropriation and disenfranchisement the Orthodox Church, and was fought very effectively by the GPU.

Thus, Bolshevism’s most stubborn opponent, Boris Savinkov—formerly a famous terrorist as a social revolutionary and then deputy minister of war under Kerensky—was lured to the Soviet Union in 1924, where he hoped to find resistance organizations. After his arrest, he made a spectacular confession at trial regarding his many activities, which during the Soviet-Polish war had even included the plan to set up a liberation army made up of Russian prisoners of war. A little later he committed suicide in prison under unclear circumstances.

Its end was probably linked to the existence of one of the most peculiar resistance organizations in the Soviet Union, the so-called TRUST, which arose from contacts between an émigré officer and a Soviet official named Yakushev. The organization consisted of numerous tsarist officers and representatives of the former parties, most of whom were in influential positions and worked towards the overthrow of the regime. Contacts were quickly established with leading émigrés, and the organization provided considerable evidence of its knowledge and influence, but always sought to restrain the émigrés from rash actions on the grounds that seizure of power was a certain prospect. It was not until 1927 that it emerged that Yakushev had been arrested after that first contact and “turned” by Dzerzhinsky personally.

Thus the GPU had succeeded in unmasking numerous internal enemies and at the same time deterring the emigrants from taking action. It was not long before it found itself in a position to have the most active of the émigré officers, General Kutieпов, kidnapped and eliminated.

However, a contrary trend arose because the communist party opposition took on the character of resistance since its official elimination in 1927-28, for example Leon Trotsky, who had previously hardly been able to stand “fascist troublemakers”—as he called them—in his meetings, or Christian Rakovsky who still carried out a lively correspondence activity in their places of exile and tried to form an illegal network of followers. But they were soon silenced, and thousands of their followers went to the camps, where they formed nuclei of a fairly active and vocal resistance, as long as remnants of the privilege of political prisoners still existed. However, after a shorter or longer period of time, very many went over to the victorious Stalinists, just as numerous Mensheviks and, above all, the entire “Bund” had joined the Bolsheviks a few years earlier.

The resistance of some national minorities against Moscow’s centralizing tendencies, which soon gave no more signs of life under the heavy hand of Stalin, and above all the resistance of the peasants against expropriation and collectivization, which at times almost resembled a civil war, albeit one highly one-sided civil war, until it died out in the deportations and starvation of many millions, had a different character.

Stalin himself then gave the entire world the impression that there was strong and determined resistance to the regime in the Soviet Union by decimating the party and army through the Great Purge. But the behavior of the high-ranking officers and also of the party leaders does not allow the conclusion that they had hatched conspiracies and made preparations for a coup. On the contrary, they allowed themselves to be led “like sheep to the slaughter.” In fifteen years, Stalin had managed to eliminate any kind of institutional independence and to place every single member of society so completely under the pressure of expectations within the framework of the great tasks or to keep them under surveillance so that organizational or even journalistic starting points for efficient resistance were simply impossible. But the emigrants may well have been right when they claimed that, despite all the concentrated propaganda about reconstruction and unity, after the terrible experiences of collectivization and the Great Purge, a deep discontent and at least a diffuse unease permeated the entire society, from which a tremendous amount of bitterness and hatred would arise if the iron clasp of the regime was ever loosened. During the Finnish War, surveys among Soviet prisoners of war yielded revealing results. The conclusion was obvious that although there was neither opposition nor resistance in Stalin’s Soviet Union, there were all the prerequisites for a restart

of the civil war with a completely changed front line.

There had been no civil war in the strict sense in Germany, and in 1940 no one seriously believed that a civil war could occur if the Reich found itself in a difficult military situation. In 1933, the communists' call for a general strike might have resulted in a civil war if the Social Democrats had joined, but the power of the National Socialist movement apparently already seemed overwhelming to the Social Democratic Party of Germany; and the communists were too focused on the imminent "winding down" of Hitler's government to believe that their call would be successful. The last opposition movements of the other parties should certainly not be described as resistance, and it can therefore be stated that in Germany, unlike in Russia, emigration preceded resistance. This emigration seemed to differ from the Russian one from the outset in that it was not only for political but also for racial reasons. But in early emigration the racial factor played only a minor role, because with the enemy image of "Jewish Marxism" the tone was much more focused on "Marxism," and the persecution fell on Jewish and non-Jewish Marxists indiscriminately. The specifically Jewish emigration was, at least to some extent, an emigration that corresponded to the old postulate of Zionism. Therefore, the early emigration from Germany was no different than the emigration from Russia, primarily political and literary-scientific.

The depth of the opposition of individual parties to National Socialism can be seen almost quantitatively in the percentages by which the leading groups emigrated or fell victim to persecution.

Almost all of the communist leadership emigrated, as far as they were not arrested, like Ernst Thälmann, or died while attempting illegal work, like John Schehr. At first, the events initially did not result in any spiritual crisis or conversion; people continued to talk about the "revolutionary situation" and the guilt of the social fascists; it was not uncommon for communist publications to give the impression that nothing had changed in Germany compared to the Brüning fascism and the Papen fascism.

In the late spring of 1933, the Social Democrats seemed to be on the verge of a party split between the emigrated party executive and the deputies who had stayed at home, until the party ban interrupted developments and many of the German party members chose the path of resignation or an effort to "survive." The party executive emigrated to Prague believed that the intellectual crisis, which could not be overlooked or overplayed, could be solved by resorting to revolutionary Marxism, but the fundamental difficulty came into clear light by the fact that the confident manifesto of June 18, 1933, at the same time said that communism

had been a crime against the German working class. Renewal tendencies of an unconventional kind were most evident among a *young left* that tried to build a bridge between the Communist Party of Germany and the Social Democratic Party of Germany and wanted to change both parties equally. The strongest group was the “Neubeginnen Group,” led by the former communists Walter Löwenheim and Richard Löwenthal. Both published remarkable writings under the pseudonyms “Miles” and “Paul Sering” that were intended to serve as a reorientation by raising the question of the nature of fascism in a different way. But the former reformists also spoke out in the most important organ of self-examination, the “Journal for Socialism,” and the former foreign policy editor of *Vorwärts*, Viktor Schiff, declared precisely not the reformist but rather the revolutionary spirit to be the cause of Fascism.

Hardly any of the leaders of the Center Party emigrated. The prelate Kaas went to Rome, but could hardly be regarded as an emigrant; in June 1934, Heinrich Brüning fled an immediate death threat and kept a very low profile even after that.

Of the liberal parties and the German Nationalists, only a number of artists and scientists who were close to these parties emigrated.

But there was a National Socialist emigration, just as there was later resistance from dissidents or former National Socialists. The central figure was Otto Straßer, who first went to Czechoslovakia, where his close collaborator, the radio specialist Rolf Formis, who in February 1933 had sabotaged an election speech by Hitler in Stuttgart as the technical manager of the station in SA uniform, was killed by the Gestapo agents in early 1935. In 1936, the former National Socialist Senate President of Danzig, Hermann Rauschning, went abroad to the West, where he became world-famous for his book “Conversations with Hitler.” Immediately before the outbreak of war Fritz Thyssen, who for a long time had been Hitler’s only important supporter and financier among the active industrialists, also went into exile.

In comparison to the Russian political emigration, the quantitative proportion among the parties was different, but on the whole, here as there, all the important representatives of the *political class* tended to be expelled, including leading representatives of the ruling party itself.

Consequently, not only the left was represented in the emigration, just as not only the right was to be found in the exile of the Russians. Likewise, the literary and scientific emigration consisted by no means exclusively of Jews, even though the Jewish leftist intellectuals

certainly made up a particularly large contingent.

It is superfluous to enumerate the great names of this emigration. The most remarkable thing is that it succeeded to a far greater extent than the corresponding and quantitatively larger part of the Russian emigration in asserting its claim to be regarded as *the* German literature. With a grain of salt, one could say that leftist, bourgeois-pacifist, and decidedly avant-garde Germany emigrated—from Arnold Zweig and Willi Munzenberg to Thomas Mann and Walter Gropius. What remained behind was the *national*, *provincial* and *metaphysical* Germany from Ernst Jünger through Hans Zöberlein to Erwin Guido Kolbenheyer. Quite a few of them soon withdrew into internal emigration. The names of former socialists and workers' poets such as Paul Ernst, Heinrich Lersch and Karl Bröger show that things were not easy here either. Of a very special kind was the case of Stefan George, who was considered one of the heralds of the new Reich and who nevertheless avoided in Switzerland all honors, before he died in December 1933.

An almost equally sharp and yet equally vague distinction went through science. Particularly moving was the fate of the numerous “national Jews” among the scholars, most of whom would have gladly and sincerely joined the “national uprising,” as their statements indicated. A letter from the mediaeval scholar Ernst Kantorowicz to the Prussian Minister for Science, Art and National Education dated April 20, 1933 was symptomatic: as a wartime volunteer, front-line soldier and post-war fighter against Poland and Spartacus, he was not affected by the new regulations, but he would nevertheless cease teaching, since recently having Jewish blood in one's veins lately involved a moral defect. Among those affected by the first leave of absence in April 1933 included Moritz Julius Bonn, Karl Mannheim and Max Horkheimer, but also non-Jews such as Paul Tillich, Günther Dehn and Wilhelm Röpke. By 1939, no fewer than 800 full professors and 1,300 adjunct professors had emigrated, almost a third of the total workforce, including 24 natural scientists who had either already received or would receive the Nobel Prize.

Here, too, very important scholars and several Nobel Prize winners certainly remained: Martin Heidegger and Karl Jaspers of the philosophers, Friedrich Meinecke and Otto Hintze among many other historians; Max Planck, Werner Heisenberg, Philipp Lenard and Johannes Stark among the natural scientists. But some of them became outspoken opponents of the regime, and in any case it was an enormous bloodletting for German culture and for German science, which deeply degraded Germany's reputation in the world and was a very important contribution to the scientific lead and thus for the later victory of the Anglo-Americans. There was hardly any analogue to the “change of signs” movement in the German

emigration, although the Germans saw their fate far more as *expulsion*, while for the Russians emigration was very often the longed-for rescue from imminent danger of death or from unbearable living conditions.

It is not easy to say what the hour of birth of the inner-German resistance was. In any case, the attempts of the German communists to maintain their organization within the framework of illegality and to prepare for the hour of their own seizure of power should not be counted as resistance. After all, one would hardly speak of Bolshevik resistance if they had lost the civil war in Russia, as in Hungary. They were the initiators and aggressors, and thus differed from anyone willing to coexist with other directions in one system. A trace of initial approval and thus a later change in attitude should be considered a conceptual characteristic of resistance, and one need only to read Julius Leber's contemporary notes to recognize that there were undeniably certain affinities between Social Democrats and National Socialists in their criticism of dogmatic Marxism. The polemic against *formal democracy* is hardly a comparable point of agreement between communists and National Socialists, and one must rather assume a harsh and unalterable enmity as the basic fact within which National Socialism could also be described as militant resistance against communism. The possibility of including the communists to the German resistance arises at all only from the transition to the policy of the popular front, and it is subject to the question whether this transition arose from a change of attitude or was a mere tactical device to achieve complete victory. It is easier to answer the other question, whether the brutality of the suppression of communists and Social Democrats aroused so much indignation on the *the bourgeoisie* that a number of people or entire institutions decided to resist. On the whole the answer must be *no*, and it must even be extended to the first measures taken against the Jews, because obviously the memory of the events of 1917-1920 in Russia and Germany was still so strong that the proverb about the shavings that fall in planing [*translator: i.e. levelling wood, as in, "you must crack a few eggs to make an omelette"*] appeared as a satisfactory explanation, especially since a clear distinction was initially made between *national* and anti-national Jews. It is true that the National Socialist movement also had sharp and bitter opponents on the right from the start, such as Erich Ludendorff and Ewald von Kleist-Schmenzin, but this opposition could be called sectarian or reactionary, and in any case some of the best-known men of the later resistance, such as Claus von Stauffenberg and Henning von Tresckow were on the side of the *nationalist movement* with their sympathies, while Fritz-Dietlof von der Schulenburg and Arthur Nebe even served the party in high positions. The first moral indignation, similar to that of Martov, who in 1918 had said that he felt shame at the bloody deeds of the Bolsheviks towards his former opponents, the cultured bourgeois, resulted from the June 30 murders, and Hans Oster later spoke of the "methods a gang of robbers," which

should have been stopped at the right time. Equally characteristic was the transformation in which Martin Niemöller became an opponent of National Socialism—a man and Freikorps fighter who could hardly have been more *nationalistic*, who was now forced to come to terms with the abysmal contrast between his Christian faith and National Socialist racial doctrine. The third major motive that brought about a change of heart among the friends of National Socialism, or at least of national uprising, was the realization that Hitler was about to involve Germany in a world war and thus to violate the most elementary of all imperatives of national restitution: that the world war situation of multi-front combat must never be repeated. Now a resistance group determined to act formed around the chief of staff, Ludwig Beck, and even Claus von Stauffenberg now said: “The fool is making war.” Ewald von Kleist-Schmenzin and Carl Friedrich Goerdeler no longer shied away from contacts with the English government, which one could call “treasonous”. Former Freikorps fighter Friedrich Wilhelm Heinz put together a shock troop squad to arrest Hitler. The communist groups were all but crushed, but the more cautious Social Democrats, who secretly received the SOPADE reports on Germany from the exiled party executive, could be seen as a network of potential helpers within the masses. But Chamberlain’s flight to Berchtesgaden and then the Munich conference marked the end of the most promising action by Hitler’s German opponents.

The actual outbreak of war in the following year did not meet with any significant resistance, perhaps because even Göring himself was frantically trying to keep the peace, and certainly not least because the opinion was widespread that the Führer was bluffing this time too and would once again win the game. Not unimportant was also the fact that the Polish “corridor” was the oldest and most obvious demand of German nationalism, although it was far less justifiable by the idea of the right to self-determination than the annexation of Austria and the Sudeten territories. The signing of the Hitler-Stalin pact came as too much of a surprise to immediately provoke serious resistance.

The victory in Poland did not in itself create a new situation for the men of the military resistance, but its consequences changed the situation. The moral motive was greatly reinforced by the action of the SS and the Security Police, and from the Commander-in-Chief East to the rank and file, many members of the Wehrmacht now realized for the first time that they were involved in a war very different from the First World War. At that time the Polish Jews had welcomed the Germans as liberators; this time they showed great hostility from the outset, or at least after a short time, and no one could be surprised by this. When during the First World War would a high-ranking German officer ever written that he was ashamed of being a German?

Likewise, the ideological motive, i.e. the insight that Hitler's worldview and actions were strange and becoming more and more alien, was also strengthened. The communists were largely thrown into paralyzing confusion by the signing of the treaty between Hitler and Stalin, but even the French communists did not become friends of *fascism*, no matter how much they helped to paralyze the will to resist. For the anti-communists in the high bureaucracy, in the Wehrmacht, among the people and even in the party, the pact was an absolutely incomprehensible and immoral act, which Stalin handed over to the whole of East-Central Europe and largely reversed the results of German colonization of the East. The negotiations which were conducted with England during the winter, through the mediation of the Vatican, were mainly motivated by the feeling that Hitler must be prevented from playing the Soviet card entirely and separating Germany once and for all from the context of *Europe* or *the West*.

Most of all, however, the motive of avoiding war, i.e. avoiding the world war, gained strength. Never before and never later did the Wehrmacht's top echelon stand so close to disobedience as in the final months of 1939, when Hitler repeatedly issued orders for the attack to begin in the West and repeatedly revoked them for pragmatic reasons. There is no doubt that the memory of the First World War and the conviction of the outstanding quality of the French army were decisive for the reluctance of the generals, but just as strong was the thought that Germany could not cope with a world war in which sooner or later the United States of America would intervene. That Hitler had assessed the military and psychological situation more correctly than the army command was evident to everyone after the six weeks of the French campaign, but concerns about the incalculable duration of the overall war had not diminished. Highly symptomatic was Rudolf Hess' flight to England, in whose preparation the advice of Albrecht Haushofer, a man who belonged to the resistance, had played a role.

However, it would be a shortcut to focus only on those officers and diplomats who were critical of Hitler's policies and worldview. This criticism had, after all, originated in the "church struggle," and in every totalitarian country the mere self-preservation of individual institutions and deviating ways of thinking must be regarded as a special form of resistance. Thus the self-assertion of the churches was an act of resistance, and it was incomparably more successful than it had been in the Soviet Union, not least because Hitler had been met with some sympathy at first. What could come of this was shown most clearly in 1940 and 1941, by the reactions of clergymen and laypeople to the killing of the mentally ill. The party felt compelled to stop its actions, and the conviction spread among the church people that *this* Germany must not win the war. Party officials could therefore claim that political

Catholicism was apparently seeking German defeat. Hitler's deep dissatisfaction with *the judiciary* was a well-known fact. But there were even doubts as to whether the Gestapo, with its considerable number of detectives from the Weimar period, worked and could work efficiently enough in Hitler's sense. For example, Lieutenant Harro Schulze-Boysen, grandson of Grand Admiral Tirpitz, worked in the Reich Aviation Ministry, at whose wedding Göring himself had been best man. Schulze-Boysen had been a nationalist revolutionary until 1933 and had published the journal *Gegner*, in which he and his friends polemicized against the "ossified West" and "American alienation" in a much the same way as the young Georg Lukács had done before his conversion to Marxism. After the seizure of power, he had been terribly beaten up by SA men, and a little later he made contact with the Soviet trade mission. The Gestapo knew nothing about all this or could not put it together properly. Nor did they know anything about Dr. Richard Sorge, who had already become a convinced communist during the First World War and then published articles in communist magazines. He was able to join the NSDAP and become the confidant of the German ambassador in Tokyo. Not to be forgotten is the private sector, where numerous opponents of Hitler found a relatively safe haven.

Hitler had come to power in a country of the European type of society by making public appearances and gaining the approval of large parts of the population and the hesitant support of the ruling class. Thus he was able to carry out a political revolution which until then had only had an analogue in Italy. After that he could arrest the leading groups of his enemies and bend his friends to his will, he could discriminate against a small and supposedly foreign part of the people and bring the culture into line. But in its social structure German society remained essentially unchanged. Although Hitler was an autocrat, he was nevertheless incapable of carrying out large-scale measures of physical extermination in peacetime, which would have been directed against strong and important strata or classes of the people, if only because the German Reich until 1939, despite all the will to change and despite the annexation of 10 million people was undoubtedly regarded as a part of Europe which was not met with any marked hostility from other governments. Therefore in countless places and especially in some of the most important institutions of German society there were potential points of resistance, and if towards the end of 1940 the hopes of an early peace agreement had faded and deep resignation in view of a long war had spread, this Germany was far from wax in Hitler's hands.

The Bolsheviks, on the other hand, had seized power at the moment of defeat and collapse, and their ideology had convinced them that they were destined to cleanse the earth of all the dirt and the filth which they regarded as the inevitable concomitants of the *capitalist system*.

They had waged and wanted to wage a civil war, although they had other and far more numerous enemies than there should have been according to the doctrine, and during the civil war and afterwards they annihilated large classes, strata and groups of their multi-ethnic state, indeed, at the end, even hundreds of thousands of their own party members. Around 1930 they encountered a resistance that was far more comprehensive, but also far more helpless and unorganized than the diverse resistance movements in Germany in 1935. In 1940, by all human judgment, even the most modest organizational starting points for resistance against Stalin did not exist. Much more widespread, however, was a dull resignation from almost the entire population, which was strangely contrasted with the confidence in some party and army circles that the Red Army was superior to all armies in the world and would soon achieve final victory over the mutually weakening enemies.

As long as only domestic politics could be pursued, the Bolshevik system had claimed incomparably more victims, and obviously the protagonists had not known any compunction whatsoever and had actually built a system of planned economy that represented a genuine alternative to the market economy system that had previously been regarded as the only modern system, while National Socialism embarked on a "Third Way," which some of its opponents considered too capitalistic or haphazard and others just too socialistic or coercive. There have been no known protests about excessive harshness in the fight against the enemy from the ranks of the Communist Party or the secret police (apart from objections on the grounds of obvious arbitrary measures), and one unverified report is quite unusual, according to which Dzerzhinsky, drunk at a banquet in the Kremlin, begged those present to shoot him for shedding such rivers of blood. In contrast, a tone of uncertainty, strained brutality, and apologia is unmistakable in almost all of Himmler's statements up to the first year of the war. The Bolsheviks conducted the struggle against their domestic enemies in peacetime with far more rigor and on the basis of an older and more genuine faith than the National Socialists. But both were probably only able to act as they did because the historical and social situation was completely different in each case. The resistance they encountered and which must be counted among the structural features of the regime was itself closely related to the structure of the respective societies. But if the two regimes had a different relationship to war and to the conflicts of the states, then the realities of annihilation might change fundamentally as soon as they entered a war, and especially a great war. Before making this war the subject of discussion, however, it is necessary to look at another structural feature, the *mobilization*, which both regimes wanted to realize above all and in all, and which nevertheless proceeded from quite different premises and showed a different character.

Chapter IV, Section 8

Total Mobilization

Comprehensive mobilization is with good reason regarded as the most general structural feature on which all totalitarian states agree. But it should not be overlooked that a certain kind of mobilization was already a basic characteristic of the liberal type of society which until the outbreak of the world war was generally regarded as the modern one. It stood in contrast to the traditional or static society in which agriculture was by far the most important branch of production, the monetary system was only of secondary importance, traffic was not little developed and the individual estates stood side by side in a largely segregated manner. It was the Industrial Revolution which gradually dissolved this traditional structure, and while the French Revolution was by no means in all its factors and manifestations a direct continuation or consequence of this more original and profound revolution, it nevertheless contributed significantly to the progress of the mobilization by breaking down the class barriers, promoting the banking system, bringing the nobility and church estates into free trade and, above all, by creating a new army organization that replaced the recruitment of mercenaries with general conscription. The freeing of the peasants in Prussia also belonged to this context, as did the incipient formation of the press and the parties. But only the state socialists envisaged a mobilization that would mean the complete service of all individuals by the state, which would be the only entrepreneur to organize vast armies of labor for the benefit of the whole people. The end, of course, was always to be the true freedom of the individual, which liberalism promised but did not realize because it did not get beyond a merely negative and therefore egotistical concept of freedom.

If one disregards the ultimate goals and global hopes, then, according to a few unequivocal statements from Lenin, the Russian revolution was nothing more than a comprehensive mobilization born of necessity, which gathered together through concentration and “forced syndication” the country’s small forces and put each individual into the service, self-assertion, and further development of the state. In the early days, however, the emphasis was still

entirely on the military. Mobilizing all resources and, if necessary, using scorched-earth tactics was what Lenin called for in his February 21, 1918 appeal “The Socialist Fatherland is in Danger,” which had in mind the possibility of the Germans resuming the war. This danger passed quickly because the peace of Brest-Litovsk was signed, but the civil war that soon broke out did not permit relaxation, and by means hitherto unknown a new army was created from the ruins of the old one, which eventually included several million soldiers. The commander-in-chief of the Red Army, S. S. Kamenev, later explained that what was absolutely new in warfare during those years was the demand “to subordinate the whole internal life of the country to the war.”

This was not quite right in the literal sense, as a glance at the German “Hindenburg Program” of 1916 and Ludendorff’s corresponding demands shows. Incidentally, it is well known how much Lenin was fascinated by the example of the German *wartime economy*. What was really characteristic and novel was that the Red Army was not really demobilized even after the end of the civil war and that the war economy continued. At the beginning of 1920, on Trotsky’s orders, a number of Red Army units were reorganized into *labor armies* and deployed en masse in the national economy. But conversely, peasant labor was being militarized, and 6 million peasants with about the same number of horses were being mustered to do a variety of jobs. The urban populace was also called up through the “Communist Saturdays,” which Party members led the way with unpaid work.

Given the character of the Communist Party of the Soviet Union as a party of change, progress and energy, there was no doubt from the outset that the introduction of the New Economic Policy would mean only a limited phase of détente. As early as 1920, a separate department (“Uchraspred”) had been set up within the Central Committee bureaucracy, responsible for “mobilizing, transferring and appointing party members.” Such mobilizations soon extended to Komsomol members, and they might as well have included the obligation to take part in construction work in the Far East as as the assumption of certain tasks in the administration of the party or youth league. What everywhere in the West had been the result of slow development involving many factors was now brought about by orders from the headquarters and by decisions of the will. Another type of mobilization was the new marriage legislation, which made divorce possible through the unilateral decision of one of the partners and seemed to be a consequence of the complete equality of women, an equality that above all brought the labor power of all women into all branches of the national economy.

Like Kemal Atatürk’s Turkey, veils and harems, and then madrasas and mosques disappeared in the Muslim parts of the Soviet Union by the will of the supreme authorities and their party.

Trucks took the place of camels, and textile machines supplanted hand-weavers. But the greatest and most successful of all mobilizations was collectivization and the first five-year plan. The lives of all peasants were fundamentally transformed, industrial plants and settlements grew up in the steppes and virgin forests, office buildings and asphalt roads arose amidst the wooden houses of the old cities. But many ready-made industrial plants were also imported from capitalist countries and set up under the direction of American or German engineers; this resulted in unheard-of demands on the workers, who often had to master in a few months what in America had been the result of many years of work.

The imports, however, had to be paid for, and the dark root of this industrialization was the unthinking deforestation of huge woodlands, the ruthless use of forced labor by the kulaks who had been driven from their homeland, the poorest living conditions, and a rationing which hardly provided the most elementary necessities of life to the individual. The extensive industrial espionage in Western countries must also be counted among the *dark aspects*. From this point of view, the Soviet Union could be viewed as a developmental dictatorship which, through a conscious effort and through very specific sacrifices, reproduced the industrialization and modernization that had taken place in Western Europe and the United States subcutaneously, so to speak, and in any case, in such a way that by no means all forces had been used and *mobilized* for this.

But the Soviet Union differed from all developmental dictatorships in that it was the largest state in the world in terms of area, and that it was ruled by a party which ascribed itself to a world-mission. Thus building heavy industry was at the same time the building of an armaments industry, and it was not surprising that in the eyes of the neighboring countries, the concentration on industry and the mechanization of agriculture was identical with a concentration on rearmament and the threat of war. As early as 1927 the “Ossoaviachime” had been set up, the “Organization for the Promotion of Defense, Aviation and Chemical Weapons,” and every member of the Komsomol came into contact with it. The all-pervasive atmosphere of the country was that of incessant top-down urging and commanding, which had its apex in the Kremlin but which worked its way through the various levels of organization down to the backmost collective farm, on which an almost unimaginably high level of delivery obligations was imposed, so that the peasants were often left with the bare necessities for subsistence. Any privileges granted to the party leaders, the specialists, or the Stakhanov workers were therefore of a highly precarious nature, and they could be considered on the whole as a kind of wartime award, which were withdrawn at the slightest failure.

How much money was allocated to the armaments industry cannot be ascertained with any

degree of certainty, since the ruble was a domestic currency and since the sums shown in the state budget for the army represented only a fraction of the real expenditure, which could be hidden in the budgets of numerous other ministries and thus sectors of the economy. In any case, the sum of 5 billion spent in 1935 was already very considerable and significantly higher than the German armaments expenditure of the same year, and in 1938 it had risen to 23 billion rubles. However, the information in a circular letter from Stalin from the end of June 1937, which was not published and was found in the Smolensk archives, is probably more revealing: since the start of collectivization, 5,616 machine-tractor stations have been created, with a stock of 41,000 caterpillar tractors, 270,000 tractors and 86,000 combine harvesters. In 1939 the Soviet Union was the third largest steel producer in the world after the USA and Germany, and in total industrial production it ranked second behind the USA with a share of almost 20%. That was a remarkable record of success and reason enough for legitimate pride, if one did not count the millions of victims; but it was also alarming news for all other states, especially when they took note of the military doctrine of this country, which, while always speaking of *imperialist aggressors*, as early as 1939 set itself the goal of crushing the armies of these aggressors on several fronts. Not even National Socialist Germany could set itself such a goal, although it too wanted to mobilize all its forces and produced an analogue of the wartime economy of the Hindenburg program even in peacetime.

Leaving aside this possible or probable objective, the mobilization of the Soviet Union was partly a substitute for *capitalist* mobilization, partly a sharpened continuation of it: enormous numbers of peasants were set free, a large percentage of national income flowed into the investments necessary for industrialization, an industrially-minded elite leadership replaced a traditionalist *ruling class*. But what had happened comparatively slowly in Europe was happening very quickly here in the breathlessness of the great catch-up, and entire classes that had merely faded into the background in Europe but had still made significant contributions were annihilated in the Soviet Union. At the same time, certainly, the essential difference between party-state capitalist dictatorship and liberal-capitalist pluralism was increasingly accentuated, but from a purely economic point of view it is still permissible to understand the mobilization of the Soviet Union as the path of a developmental dictatorship.

Germany could not go this way. Around 1930, as in 1910, the German Reich was a fully developed industrial country in terms of world conditions: the first industrial power on the continent and second in the world to the United States, which was immensely favored by the circumstances. Its problem around 1930 was not a lack of development, but a lack of utilization of its production apparatus and thus of employment for its workers. Here it could

not be a question of creating an industry out of nothing or from comparatively weak beginnings, but to get the existing industry going into full swing again. In order to achieve this goal, the NSDAP also believed that it had to destroy obstacles, e.g. the multiplicity of political parties, since these stood in the way of the necessary concentration of will, but this destruction was not an exaggerated continuation of the original mobilization but opposed it in essential points, as the justification of the party's antisemitism, but also show the concepts of race and blood and the example of the hereditary farm law show.

But if National Socialism did not want to be merely a reactionary and thus hopeless middle-class and farmers' movement, then it had to set in motion its own kind of mobilization, which in its tendency was exactly the opposite of that of the earlier mobilization, but still went a long way in common with it. Its peculiarity cannot be recognized by an isolated consideration of the economic measures. The establishment of the sole sovereignty of the leader was just as important as the capillary function of the party, terror as well as the education of the youth. Only in this context do the economic measures prove to be what they were: as consistent preparations for war that did not lag behind the Soviet ones in terms of energy, but did not have the same alternative, namely to switch from the war economy to the peace economy as soon as obvious goals had been achieved and certain fears had not been realized.

The elimination of even the moderate left and the terrorization of their followers meant the elimination of the firmest core of pacifist and internationalist thought, and the fight against church influence opened the way for the autocracy of the spirit, which is expressed in the quoted line of the song: "God is the fight and fight is our blood and that's why we were born." On the other hand, the economic measures were at first entirely within the framework of the old system and were a continuation of measures taken by the Papen and Schleicher governments; not coincidentally, they took place under the direction of the former President of the Reichsbank in the Weimar Republic and now Reich Minister of Economics Hjalmar Schacht.

The decline in production as a result of the world economic crisis had been no less than 47% in Germany from 1929 to 1932, and the loss of national income, though not quite so large as a result of the fall in import prices, was still considerable. The gold and foreign exchange holdings had fallen sharply as a result of the foreign loans being called. Brüning tried to bring about rehabilitation by introducing foreign exchange control and a restrictive fiscal policy, i.e. by deflation. However, this intensified the contraction process and aggravated the political situation, since the strong position of the unions made it impossible to reduce the relative

share of wages. Papen made a significant change of course. Under him began what John Maynard Keynes would later make famous with the concept of “deficit spending”: job creation through government contracts, wage bonuses for entrepreneurs for each additional worker hired, tax vouchers, etc. All these measures were continued under Hitler and supplemented by others such as the construction of highways and the so-called Reinhardt program, which provided marriage loans and large grants for repair work on residential buildings. But Brüning’s tax hikes were not reversed, and the tendency was obviously to curb consumption and to place the emphasis entirely on boosting the capital goods industries. In this context, the armament measures began in 1934 and were largely financed by Schacht’s ingenious artifice of the “mefo bills.” In 1934 4 billion were already spent compared to 750 million in 1933, in 1935 over 5 billion, in 1936 over 10 billion. Of course, there was a corresponding increase in the floating Reich debt, from 3 to 12 billion. Nevertheless, the armaments expenditure was valuable as an initial spark. Around this time, Keynes used plausible arguments to explain the economic benefit of unproductive expenditure such as the building of pyramids or the mere movement of masses of dirt. In this respect, Hitler was the first to tread a path that Roosevelt and Léon Blum followed after him.

In 1936 Germany came to a crossroads. Schacht now apparently wanted to switch gears and achieve a *self-sustaining economy* by curbing armaments expenditure. But it was precisely in 1936 that the *second four-year plan* began, at the head of which Hermann Göring as “commissioner” and thus as Germany’s potential economic dictator. In August 1936, in his memorandum on the tasks of a four-year plan, Hitler, with express reference to the “giant plan” of the Soviet state, demanded that “similar to the military and political rearmament or mobilization of our people” there should also be an economic one, and he concluded with the sentences: “I. The German army must be ready for action in four years. II. The German economy must be ready for war in four years.” He bluntly threatened “some economists” with doom, and a year later he said in even clearer terms that if private industry did not carry out the four-year plan, the state would take full control. Göring, for his part, emphasized the desire for self-sufficiency on which the plan was based, and left no doubt that, in view of the magnitude of the task, both regard for profits and compliance with the law had become irrelevant. Schacht publicly and vehemently opposed such views, and in November 1937 he resigned. Armaments expenditure rose to 11 billion in 1937 and 23 in 1938, or to 17 billion according to other calculations. The entire Reich debt grew to an sum of 42 billion, which was enormous for that time. At the same time, the establishment of the “Reichswerke Hermann Göring” in Salzgitter marked the beginnings of a state or party economy. However, there were no *work levies* comparable to those of the Soviet Union until 1939, not even during the construction of the “West Wall” [*the Siegfried Line*] .

How real the chance of a transition to the welfare state was in 1936 cannot be determined with certainty. In any case, its implementation would have meant settling for national restitution and the establishment of a defense capability. It would therefore have been identical with the aim of the Weimar Republic and was thus out of the question for Hitler. The fact that *his* method promised success was proven by the events of March 1938 to March 1939, which, from the overpowering of Schuschnigg and the incorporation of the Sudetenland to the occupation of Prague and the “rest of the Czech Republic,” were practically bloodless acts of war. But since 1936, as a result of the enormously increasing debts, Hitler and Germany with him had embarked on a one-way street with the telos of war, or at least of bloodless successes through threats of war. Even the Jewish tribute and the occupation of Czechoslovakia were pronounced acts of a *looting economy*. Total expenditure on armaments up to September 1939 was around 60 billion Reichsmarks. In the “Table Talks” Hitler later said that he had invested the entire fortune of the German people in weapons; thus, only by means of a worthwhile war could this fortune be appropriately exploited.

Surely a successful threat of war would have served the same purpose just as well and better. But was it really conceivable that Poland and England would have yielded in the summer of 1939 because, in view of Germany’s astonishing display of strength, it would have seemed inevitable to them that the non-Soviet continent would now have to be ruled by what was undoubtedly its strongest and, moreover, centrally located state? Germany was obviously not strong enough, and above all not popular enough with the other Europeans for such a claim to have been enforceable without decisive resistance. Moreover, there were grave reasons for believing that this “leadership” would mean domination and exploitation by a system which denied the main features of European history and was preparing to eliminate them with ever-increasing determination. Therefore, despite the apparent insignificance of the occasion, nothing was more consistent than the Polish-English-French resistance and with it the war in September 1939. But Adolf Hitler then proved that Germany was the strongest power in Europe, to an even greater extent than anyone but himself in the summer 1939 had assumed, and this could not be solely due to the fact that by 1939 it had spent as much on armaments as France, Great Britain and the USA combined. Thus although the predictions of his opponents, that he would have to go to war, had proved correct, they were correct only because he could not, as the Soviet Union did, demand arbitrary sacrifices from the population and reduce the standard of living of the great masses to subsistence level. The Soviet Union, if it had been unthreatened and had bid farewell to ideologically based plans for world conquest, could have decided in 1941 in view of its wealth of space and raw materials to make use of the industrialization that had finally been carried out to gradually

raise the standard of living of the people. In 1939 Hitler could not do that. He had to wage war, indeed, and a war of conquest, for the sake of plunder. The question was whether he was still in the same position in May/June 1941. His troops were stationed at the North Cape and in the Libyan desert, on the banks of the Bug River and on the Pyrenees border with friendly Spain. The resources of all continental Europe were at his disposal. Germany was now undoubtedly the leading power on the continent. There was hardly any sign of serious resistance even in France. Admittedly, this Germany had made two of the European nations, the Czechs and the Poles, into a kind of colonial peoples, and the positive support of conservative regimes and fascist movements, even Mussolini's Italy, was not too reliable. Hitler's specific type of mobilization, which was equally distant from the methods of developmental dictatorship and that of the welfare state, had brought him to this climax of his power because it restarted an dormant production apparatus for the sole possible purpose of waging war. But as master of continental Europe he was at war with the naval power of England and practically with America, and the Soviet Union, which had spent more than he had spent on armaments and war preparations, faced him on land with a neutrality which prevented him from starting the confrontation to end with England by invading the island. He would have had to resort to war or the threat of war against her, even if Russia had been a democratic state or had been under the rule of a tsar, unless she had offered absolutely reliable guarantees of her own accord. But throughout his political life she had been his nightmare and at the same time and to some extent his role model, as the justification he gave for the four-year plan showed. In the face of her and her ideology, his empire was supposed to be the only adequate answer; against them and their ideology he had appealed to the community of the best forces of all *Aryan* peoples, who were to recognize in Judaism their common enemy. With regard to Bolshevism and the Soviet Union, however, many of his followers and his generals also had very definite views, and it was not a given that he could easily disregard all of them. When, after the Molotov visit, Hitler finally made the decision to "overthrow" the Soviet Union "in a quick campaign," despite the frivolity of this turn of expression and many similar statements, it must have been clear to him deep in his innermost being that this decision had a completely different weight than the decisions to attack Poland, France or Yugoslavia, and just the way in which he had mobilized the German people did not necessarily provide the answer to the most essential of all questions: would this war be a decisive struggle for supremacy in Europe between Germany and Russia, or an anti-Bolshevik war of liberation in an alliance with many Europeans and very many Russians and Ukrainians, or a war of annihilation for the purpose of conquering gigantic "living spaces" and exterminating Jewry as the alleged world enemy of all peoples?

Chapter V, Section 1

The Attack against the Soviet Union: Decisive Battle? —Liberation Campaign? — War of Extermination?

On the morning of June 22, 1941, when the German Wehrmacht had already crossed the borders of the Soviet Union on a front from the Baltic Sea to the Black Sea for an hour and a half, the German ambassador in Moscow presented Foreign Minister Molotov a statement which in its conclusions stated that the foreign policy of the Soviet Union had become increasingly hostile to Germany and that the Soviet government had broken the treaties concluded with the Reich by deploying its armed forces on the borders, ready to jump in order to stab Germany in the back in its struggle for existence. Therefore, the leader of the Wehrmacht had given the order to counter this threat with all available means of power. According to this announcement, Hitler understood the campaign against the Soviet Union as a pre-emptive war. Molotov, on the other hand, in his reply described this justification as an “empty pretext,” because only “special maneuvers” were taking place near the western border, which the Soviet government would have dispensed with if it had received a corresponding request from the Reich government. Therefore, in a historically unprecedented manner, Germany had broken the non-aggression and friendship pact that bound it to the Soviet Union. This sentence was obviously tantamount with the thesis that Germany had launched an unprovoked war of aggression. In fact, by this time a large part of the Soviet Air Force had already been destroyed. It was therefore only consistent that Molotov concluded his remarks with the words: “We didn’t deserve that.”

Thus, even in the first hours of the war, the two opposing theses stood sharply side by side and against each other in the official formulations: Germany was waging a pre-emptive war or a war of aggression; the Soviet Union was an intolerable threat or the unsuspecting victim of an invasion. To this day, the question has not been reliably decided, and each side was able to

put forward considerable arguments immediately before the outbreak of the conflict and during the first weeks of the war. But doubts remained in one case as in the other.

It could hardly be denied that the Soviet Union had violated the letter and the spirit of the treaties when it demanded Bukovina from Romania and not only established *bases* in Lithuania but concentrated a significant number of divisions there. It was also difficult to reconcile with a friendship pact the fact that the Soviet Union had supported the coup in Belgrade and immediately concluded an agreement with the Simović government. In addition, the German troops had found documents in the Soviet Union's Belgrade embassy which all too clearly revealed hostile intentions towards Germany. The strongest evidence, however, soon had to be a fact that had become obvious after the first 14 days of the war: the three army groups North, Center and South under Field Marshals von Leeb, von Bock and von Rundstedt had a total of around 3,500 tanks, and already in the encirclement battles of Bialystok and Minsk, Army Group Center alone had destroyed or captured around 6,000 enemy tanks. Thus, there were far more tanks massed in the protruding arch of Bialystok than the entire German Eastern Army, and the Soviet Major General Pyotr Grigorenko, admittedly a *dissident*, was certainly right when he wrote that such a formation is only justified if it is intended for a surprise offensive. However, he saw this as a serious mistake on Stalin's part, since in reality he did *not* have such an intention to attack. In any case, it is unlikely that there was any sense of imminent threat on the German side. For example, Major General Marcks, who drew up the first operational draft on August 5, 1940, based it on the idea that "the Russians will not do us the kindness of an attack," and Hitler himself claimed even as late as January 1941 that Stalin was a clever man and that he would not act openly against Germany, but would simply cause increasing difficulties. Furthermore, all the planning and preliminary discussions concerning "Barbarossa" testify to an extremely confident sense of strength among almost everyone involved, who believed they could "overthrow Russia in a quick campaign," and even though Hitler warned several times against underestimating the enemy, he occasionally made a statement such as that the Red Army was nothing more than a joke. Pre-emptive warfare cannot be based on objective facts alone; its concept indispensably includes a feeling of immediate threat on the part of the aggressor. But a war of aggression, just because it is not a pre-emptive war, is not necessarily aggression as such. It can be an objectively justified and unavoidable decisive struggle. Just a few weeks later, on September 1, 1941, in one of his "fireside chats," Roosevelt compared the "Nazi submarines and pirate ships" to rattlesnakes that you had to smash before they rushed at you, thus justifying the order to shoot he had given to the American warships. But the German submarines were carrying out the blockade of a country with which Germany was at war, and the USA was a neutral country not involved in a war anywhere. Germany's situation, however, was

completely different. There was also good reason to remember statements such as those made by the head of the Central Political Administration of the Red Army, L. S. Mechlis, at the 17th Party Congress in March 1939: in the now foreseeable “second imperialist war” the USSR would be carry its military operations into the enemy’s territory and multiply the number of Soviet republics. Announcements like these were not uncommon in literature and life and were transmitted to the German government in numerous reports. They had to be regarded as mental acts of war, and one could even ask whether a completely isolated and highly armed country did not pose a dangerous threat to its neighbors just by existing this way.

It seems that Stalin himself was imbued with the feeling that a decision had to be made now and that Germany could no longer accept that the Soviet Union’s attitude would keep it in a state of inability to act vis-à-vis England. The greater probability, however, suggests that he did not believe that this decision necessarily had to be made through a war between Germany and the Soviet Union. His behavior during the last few months before June 22 has continually posed a mystery and given rise to a number of attempts at explanation. Apparently he did not take seriously the warnings that came to him from many quarters and pursued a policy of appeasement towards Germany. This included the much-described scene at the Moscow train station upon the departure of Japanese Foreign Minister Matsuoka in April, when he embraced the German military attaché Colonel Krebs with the words: “We will be friends with you—whatever may come,” but also that the increased supplies of raw materials should not be forgotten either, and at least the German ambassador von der Schulenburg interpreted Stalin’s assumption of the leadership of the government on May 6, 1941 in the sense that he was determined to work with all his might to improve relations with Germany. The fact that Stalin broke off relations with the governments-in-exile of Yugoslavia, Belgium and Holland fit this picture well. Although the leadership of the Soviet Union was by no means in a deep sleep during the night of June 21-22, as Georgy Zhukov’s memoirs clearly show, the mass of troops were undoubtedly surprised by the German attack, as was a large part of the air force was without camouflage on the airfields near the border. Since the revelations that Khrushchev made in his secret speech, Stalin’s conduct has often been sharply criticized in Soviet literature. However, three reasonable explanations suggest themselves.

In Tehran, Stalin said to Churchill: “I would have liked another six months.” From this a certain confirmation of the German pre-emptive war thesis could be derived, but the fact of the surprise would remain unexplained.

It could be that Stalin wanted to appear as the invaded and the unsuspecting victim of a

nefarious attack because only under this condition could he expect unconditional assistance from Great Britain and the USA. He would then have foreseen the actual course of the war very precisely and consciously sought an alliance with the Anglo-Saxon powers. What speaks against this, however, is the fact that he thus ended up in a war against Germany, which would be a single-front battle for at least a few months and which put the Anglo-Saxon powers in the situation that he himself wanted to occupy, namely in the situation of the unweakened third party, which would ultimately gain the upper hand over the two exhausted antagonists. And it seems that, extremely disturbed by Rudolf Hess's flight to England in May, he had little doubt that the main power of capitalism would ultimately throw its weight in favor of the capitalist-fascist military state against the socialist sixth of the world.

The third and most likely possibility may be derived from the striking frequency of the word "negotiations" in these weeks. The famous TASS denial of June 14 stated that Germany had not made any demands on the Soviet Union or proposed a new, narrower agreement to it, and as a result, negotiations on this matter could not have taken place. This sounds like an urgent call to enter into such negotiations, and the impression is reinforced when one considers that Molotov and Stalin later emphasized that Germany had invaded the Soviet Union without initially proposing negotiations. It appears that Stalin expected to receive an ultimate offer of negotiation from the German side until the last moment, and that he was inclined to accept it. Presumably during Molotov's visit to Berlin, he had, using the widespread method, allowed Molotov to put forward maximum demands and was now prepared to abandon them, i.e. to join the planned continental bloc while foregoing European demands, to increase deliveries and, if necessary, even to withdraw the Red Army from the border areas. This version is supported by the fact that, according to Khrushchev's report, when the war broke out Stalin was initially seized by despair and exclaimed: "We have lost everything that Lenin created," and that, according to his daughter's story, he still used say full of deep regret several years later: "Together with the Germans we would have been invincible." In fact, he *had to* choose this path if he wanted to see his basic foreign policy ideas realized: to keep the powers of *capitalism* at war with each other and ultimately to be the laughing third party. No sacrifice was too heavy for this, and he might even have—as contemporaries speculated—leased the Ukraine to the Germans for direct exploitation, because there is no doubt that he assessed the enormous productive power of the USA much more correctly than Hitler did, and that he was convinced that Germany would ultimately lose the war against the Anglo-Saxon naval powers after having previously inflicted enormous losses on them. If, on the other hand, he crushed Germany in alliance with America and took the brunt of the burden, then he could be defeated, and the probability of defeat was all too great according to his own assumptions.

In any case, there are good reasons to believe that Stalin was as convinced as Hitler that a decision had to be made, but that he did not believe that it would now take the form of a war between Germany and the Soviet Union. Then Hitler and Germany were not responsible for the situation in which a decision was necessary—Stalin had contributed to this as much as Hitler—but they were the cause of the decision being made by a German-Soviet war.

But if this path was taken, then another alternative required a clear answer. The war against France had ended with a military victory, and France had given itself a new government willing to cooperate with Germany. The new government had initiated a change of system and installed an authoritarian regime under the most respected man in the country, Marshal Pétain. The fact that Alsace-Lorraine would be lost again was acceptable to this government, but there was no fear of further weakening—at least initially. In any case, a military victory over the Soviet Union would have resulted in a new government and a new system, and a Russian Pétain would have agreed to cooperate with Germany and certainly also made the concession that Soviet sham-federalism would have been replaced by genuine federalism. In the midst of and through the struggles between states, the European civil war would have proved to be the ultimately determining reality. But from a “national German” perspective, there was a tremendous difference compared to France: this new Russia would only have been militarily weaker than Germany, but still stronger in terms of population and raw material wealth. Unless one wanted to be guided by trust in one’s partner and confidence in one’s own abilities, one had to envisage a more thorough weakening of Russia. This was precisely the intention of Alfred Rosenberg, who was appointed “Reich Minister for the Occupied Eastern Territories” by Hitler in July. As early as April 2, he developed a plan in a memorandum to break up the existing Greater Russia into its ethnic parts and “to keep in check” a future “Muscovy” by a ring of independent states, namely Ukraine, Belarus, the Don region and the Caucasian region. Just as in 1919 the Western powers had formed a *cordon sanitaire* around Soviet Russia from states that had belonged in whole or in part to the Tsarist Empire, and just as the same victorious powers had not tolerated the emergence of a Greater Germany, but had surrounded Prussian Germany with hostile states, so Alfred Rosenberg now sought a *Versailles solution* for a core area of Germany’s only rival in Europe that had to be held down. Viewed abstractly, this was a political way of thinking that is characteristic of decisive battles, and it deserves as little or as much moral censure as the actions of the Allied powers in 1919. But from the outset it placed itself in a difficult relationship with one another another aspect of the complex problem, and this fact came out most clearly when Rosenberg said in a speech on June 20, 1941: “Today we are not carrying out a ‘crusade’ against Bolshevism, just for the sake of saving the ‘poor Russians’ from this Bolshevism for all time, but to pursue German world politics and secure the German Reich...

To exchange Stalin for a new tsar or even to install a nationalist leader in this area, that would mobilize all energies against us all the more.” In place of this previously common idea of a unified Russia, there was now a completely different conception of the Eastern question. If the war was a decisive struggle in this sense, then it could not even induce the disenfranchised *former people* and dispossessed *kulaks* of Russia or their children to take the German side. [translator: *former people/byvshiye lyudi* is a phrase popularized by Maxim Gorky, meaning loss of high social status. After the bolshevik revolution it applied to the imperial aristocracy, military, bureaucracy, clergy etc.]

Nevertheless, there was no doubt that this war was also understood by its authors as a resumption of the civil war and that all the emotions that had once prevailed in Russia and Germany came to life anew. They may have been toned down to routine statements, for example when the Foreign Office declared in its note of June 21 that it was the task of the German people to “save the entire cultural world from the deadly dangers of Bolshevism” or when the “German diplomatic-political information” on June 27 claimed that Germany’s fight against Moscow would become Europe’s crusade against Bolshevism, and that it was a matter of preserving and restoring the great basic principles of all human and national coexistence, namely the restoration of the dignity and freedom of the human personality, the family, private property, freedom of religious belief and the cultural independence of peoples and ethnic groups throughout Europe. In such phrases, the spirit of the *national uprising* of 1933 came up once again, as it were, but Alfred Rosenberg expressed the experiences, the bitterness and the hatred of the early post-war period much more directly when he wrote in his General Instructions for the Reich Commissioners in the Occupied Eastern Territories on May 8 the sentence that the Germans of Eastern Europe, who had achieved tremendous feats over many centuries, had their entire property taken away without compensation and that hundreds of thousands were deported or starved to death. However, Adolf Hitler had already descended most deeply into the emotions of the civil war on March 30, 1941, in a speech to the generals. Bolshevism, he said, is anti-social criminality and communism is a tremendous danger for the future. “We must break away from the standpoint of soldierly comradeship. The communist is not a comrade before and not a comrade after... The struggle must be waged against the poison of decomposition... Commissars and the GPU-people are criminals and must be treated as such.” During the civil war, no one actually thought of seeing in the Red or the White enemy a comrade who needed to be treated chivalrously. On the Soviet side too, the memory of the White atrocities had always been kept alive, and even in the Finnish War it had been hardly mere propaganda when the Red Army men were told that they would be tortured to death if they fell into the hands of the “White Finnish butchers.” Ataman Kaledin had also considered the Bolsheviks to be “anti-social criminals” because they

appealed to the most primitive instincts with the slogan ‘Steal what was stolen,’ and the “decomposition” had prevented General Kornilov from entering the capital. Hitler rarely made direct reference to the events of the civil war, and he displayed an unmistakable dislike for the Russian émigrés who had failed in his eyes,. But there is no doubt that the most important events were very present for him, and this was also expressed in random asides, such as (at a later date) that it had been Ukrainians who had murdered the best friend of the Ukrainian people, Field Marshal Eichhorn in Kiev in 1918. Thus, when he spoke of a *battle of annihilation* , he was talking about the annihilation of an ideology and its champions, and such an intention had been self-evident to all participants in the civil war. The “commissioner order” must also be seen in the same context, which was certainly an order “inhumane” and “contrary to international law,” but which proceeded from a premise that had also been a prerequisite for both parties to the civil war: that the enemy would certainly commit criminal acts and actions contrary to international law. Therefore, these “Guidelines” of June 8 stated: “In the fight against Bolshevism, the enemy is not to be expected to behave in accordance with the principles of humanity or international law. In particular, hateful, cruel and inhumane treatment of our prisoners is to be expected from political commissars of all kinds as the actual bearers of the resistance.” Therefore, political commissars could not be recognized as soldiers and they were to be “finished off after separation has been carried out.”

Insofar as this order is to be seen in the context of the *worldview war* , it was not “criminal” but consistent. The crime lies much deeper, namely in unleashing such a war without any compelling reason. In this respect, the question of pre-emptive war or the unavoidable decisive battle must come up again. But the order was in any case a foolish order, because the German leadership had not realized that the Soviet government had in the meantime moved one step beyond the realities and emotions of the civil war. Indeed, it considered all members of the Red Army who were captured alive to be deserters, whose family members were held collectively responsible for this act of cowardice and treason. The captured commissars were therefore criminals worthy of death in the eyes of their own government, and Hitler made himself Stalin’s stooge when he had them “finished off.” In fact, the order was largely disobeyed and rescinded in 1942, and later former political commissars were among Vlasov’s closest associates.

But if the war against the Soviet Union rested on a foundation of emotions that had already been the emotions of the Russian Civil War and the struggle between communists and National Socialists in the Weimar Republic, then it could not be a mere campaign of revenge, nor just a “defensive struggle of the West,” although the Commissioner Order on the one hand

and the announcements of the Foreign Office on the other may suggest such interpretations. Regardless of the will of its author, the war had to be a war of liberation and be perceived as such by large parts of the population, for the party leadership's thesis about the complete moral and political unity of the Soviet people would have been correct precisely because of the collectivization, the great purge and deportations from eastern Poland and the Baltic countries. Although quite a number of units of the Red Army defended themselves with the greatest bravery, indeed with a fanaticism that was deeply alienating to the Germans and which often drove the last defenders of a position to commit joint suicide, hundreds of thousands allowed themselves to be taken prisoners in the first weeks of the war, the incoming German troops were greeted with cheers in all towns and villages in Lithuania and Latvia, in the Ukraine they were welcomed with salt and bread in countless places, and even before they entered Lemberg, a provisional state authority had been formed there that was obviously ready for full cooperation with Germany. Here too, liberation and revenge were closely linked. Thus, NKVD troops in Lemberg and other places had horrifically murdered almost all the inmates of the prisons as well as some German airmen who had fallen into their hands, and the Ukrainian population had taken an equally terrible revenge on those whom they believed to be the originators, so that a new era of Jewish pogroms seemed to herald itself. But it was reasonable could expect that the German Wehrmacht would put an end to such spontaneous actions and that liberation would be a more comprehensive reality than revenge. In any case, this was the tone of the Wehrmacht propaganda, which was directed by the "WPr" department in the Wehrmacht High Command and which in millions of leaflets and posters presented Adolf Hitler as the liberator of the hitherto oppressed.

The fertility of the ground on which this propaganda fell, however, was demonstrated by no one more clearly than by Stalin. On July 3, he gave a radio speech for the second time in his life, and for the first time he addressed his listeners as "brothers and sisters" and "my friends." Of course, he first denounced the Germans' "breaking of word" and "invasion" and asserted that the enemy's best divisions and the best units of his air force had already been crushed. For him, Germany was now "fascist" again, and he called Hitler and Ribbentrop "monsters and cannibals." He left no doubt, however, that a "serious danger had loomed over the homeland." He also drew on the emotions and concepts of the civil war when he claimed that the enemy's goal was to restore the power of the landowners, to restore tsarism, to deprive the free peoples of the Soviet Union of their statehood and to make them "slaves of the German princes and barons." The term "Patriotic People's War" could also be traced back to a phrase by Lenin. What was new was that Stalin remembered with a "feeling of gratitude" Churchill's historic speech on June 22 and the corresponding declaration by the United States government, which had announced its help to the Soviet people after Hitler had exposed

himself “in the eyes of the whole world as a bloodthirsty aggressor.” But the most striking thing was that he spoke with the strongest emphasis of the “defeatists and cowards, the panic-mongers and deserters” and a second time of the “disorganizers of the rear, the deserters, panic-mongers, rumor-spreaders, spies and wreckers” and called for the support of the “military police battalions.” There could be little doubt that he placed his trust not in the unquestioning loyalty of the entire Soviet people, but in the method which he later described to Churchill when he said that in the Soviet Union everyone was a hero, because everyone knew that he could survive if he attacked the enemy, but that he must die if he retreated. After all, he counted on so much reliable support that he announced the scorched earth tactics and called for the “ignition of partisan warfare.”

But Adolf Hitler seems not to have noticed at all that in this speech Stalin was making it clear how fragile the ground on which he stood was and how exceedingly numerous were the people who could not believe his claim that he had led them to “free labor and prosperity.” Rather, in a conversation with the Japanese ambassador Oshima on July 15, Hitler merely referred to the extermination order and drew the conclusion that millions would have to die because of Stalin’s extermination orders because Germany could provide neither coal nor food to the Russian population. Eight days later, he had Keitel expressly announce that the troops had to spread the kind of terror that alone was capable of depriving “the population” of any desire for resistance. If one remembers that Hitler the day before had told the Croatian Marshal Kwaternik that today’s Russian people apparently consisted of 70-80% Mongolians, then it becomes quite clear that he was willing not to content himself with the destruction of a worldview, but that he sought the destruction of the biological substance of the “Eastern peoples” because he wanted to take possession of their land as a living space for German settlers and as a security zone for future wars—as he had already postulated in his early speeches and in “Mein Kampf.” had. In a conversation with Rosenberg, Lammers, Keitel, Göring and Bormann on July 16, he spoke of in this sense of the “giant cake” that had to be cut up handily in order to “firstly master it, secondly manage it and thirdly exploit it.” To be sure, he did not rule out “propaganda” — “that we were the bringers of freedom.” But how could a man and a leadership make credible statements to the Soviet population, who intended to clear Crimea of all foreigners and to settle it with Germans, to incorporate Galicia, the entire Baltic region and even the Volga colony into the Reich, to raze Leningrad and Moscow to the ground and turn the area around Baku into a German military colony? How could even the most German-friendly among the émigrés and the most determined Stalin-haters in the Red Army in good conscience make themselves available to this man who “never” wanted to allow “anyone other than the German to bear arms”?

There could be no doubt at all: the man who had made Germany powerful enough to wage a decisive battle for supremacy in Europe and who shared all the anti-communist emotions of the post-war period nevertheless wanted above all to wage a war of extermination and enslavement against the Slavic peoples, and he had in mind an even more radical war of extermination against the Jews as Jews, as he had already indicated in his speech on January 30, 1939.

This was the beginning of the most astonishing reversal of all. Stalin had had far more Russians and Ukrainians and Jews killed than Hitler had taken the lives of Germans or, after September 1939, even Jews and Poles, and yet he now had to become the personification of the self-assertion and will to survive of all the peoples of the Soviet Union, if Hitler wanted to weaken or even destroy the biological substance of Russians, Ukrainians and Jews; although Hitler had devastated the intellectual and political life of the Germans, he had nevertheless led them to the maximum level of power, and now he would become the author of his nation's self-destruction if other powers intervened in the upcoming decision and if Stalin was guided by his example.

Thus the three aspects of the German-Soviet war cannot be separated from one another, and in Hitler they were even united in such a way that, out of anti-Bolshevik emotion, he only wanted to recognize the physical destruction or definitive weakening *of the Asiatics* united in the Soviet Union as a genuine decision. But these are not mere abstractions, but rather tendencies and possibilities which were multiplicitous in themselves and that could enter into a number of combinations. Even Adolf Hitler was not so powerful that his basic ideas and intentions had to prevail under all circumstances. It therefore makes sense to focus on the course of the war in its main events in such a way that one of the aspects is highlighted at a time. As a final step before the final consideration, we must then ask in what way the eventual victory of the Bolshevik Soviet Union and the defeat of National Socialist Germany are to be most appropriately characterized.

Chapter V, Section 2

Necessities, Coincidences and Alternatives in the German-Soviet War

The terms “necessity” and “coincidence” should not be understood in a philosophical, but in a historical sense: what is considered *coincidental* is something that depends on the decision of one man or a small group of people in such a way that another action by the same person man or the same group, or a man or a group who would have taken their place, would not have encountered insurmountable resistance. An event should also be viewed as coincidental if tendencies of approximately equal strength collide and the decision is brought about by special circumstances or by the activities of relatively few people. Furthermore, in the historical sense, natural events which have major effects on the human sphere are also coincidental, but which could not have been predicted with certainty or even with a high degree of probability. That which is considered *necessary* does not have this character of the coincidental. From the interplay of necessities and coincidences alternatives can be seen which could have been realized according to human discretion had coincidental circumstances had occurred differently. The illness that caused the death of Alexander the Great was in this sense accidental, and therefore it must be considered as an alternative that his army, under his leadership, would have advanced as far as the Ganges instead of flowing back; the defeat of Hannibal was necessary because he had not been able to take Rome in the first onslaught, although it could have come about after a shorter or longer time and in a different way. A further distinction should be made between the “mere chance” and the “accidental necessity” of a particular character’s actions.

Hitler’s attack against the Soviet Union was accidental insofar as the alternative of a new agreement with Stalin was probably present; but, it had the character of “accidental necessity” insofar as Hitler had repeatedly referred to the “confrontation with Bolshevism” and the “solution of the German spatial problem” as his “real task.” The timing of the war decision,

however, was much more influenced by pure chance. Mussolini's impulsive decision to attack Greece had forced the Balkan campaign, and therefore the attack could not begin as planned on May 15 or at least the beginning of June, but only at a date that left less than four months until the earliest possible point in the mud and snow period.

What was necessary, according to all premises, was Stalin's call for partisan warfare (in violation of international law) and the promise of help that Churchill made to the Soviet Union on June 22. However, this promise was only *necessary* because it also proved that the water was not just up to the neck of Great Britain, but up to the very edge of her lips. No man could have spoken with the greatest determination and using even sharper invectives than Churchill did on this occasion: Hitler was a "monster of wickedness," a "bloodthirsty street urchin," over whose "Nazi gang" the "devilish emblem of the swastika" was emblazoned, while "saber-rattling Prussian officers" led the "brute mass of Hun soldiers like a swarm of swarming locusts." He described England's "single, immovable goal" as the destruction of Hitler and every trace of the Nazi regime. So it was an unconditional promise of help, and if, on the one hand, Churchill demonstrated with his speech that it was not only Lenin and Hitler who tended to dehumanize their enemies using expressions such as "insects" and "bacteria," then despite all this passion, hardly anyone in the audience could doubt that Churchill considered Hitler's victory over the Soviet Union to be almost certain and, above all, saw this fight as a breathing space for the beleaguered England, just as did many English and American experts who spoke out in the following weeks. Indeed, if he had believed that a military victory for the Soviet Union was possible, he would indeed have acted in completely incomprehensible manner. After all, the Soviet Union was the country that had destroyed and divided up in its state existence along with Hitler the only ally which Great Britain had gone to war to protect from Hitler's modest demands and the most basic duty of loyalty to Poland should have been that to make aid conditional on the return of the stolen territories. Churchill did not say a word about this, however, but he apparently felt that his own credibility was so endangered that he included the sentence that the Nazi regime "cannot be distinguished from the worst manifestations of communism," and he did not take back a word of what he had said about communism for twenty-five years. It was therefore only too necessary that this alliance, so hastily concluded, must be a most difficult and jeopardized alliance if it were to mean anything more to Great Britain than the prolongation of a breathing space.

But two days later, Roosevelt also announced that the United States would provide all possible help to the Soviet Union. This promise would also have been incomprehensible if the President had considered the Soviet Union to be even a somewhat equal opponent of Germany. Indeed, any American who remembered Napoleon from the standpoint of interests

alone could hardly have come to a different conclusion than Senator Harry S. Truman, who advised that the two robbers who had gotten into a fight should be allowed to fight their battle alone, and if necessary, to intervene at a later point in time. Had not the entire American press just a year and a half before been outraged by Stalin's attack on Finland; was it not known in informed circles that England, together with France, had wanted to open hostilities against the Soviet Union because of Finland and that English military officials had continued to work on plans to turn Baku into a sea of flames through a major air raid? And the pacifist current in the country was very strong. It had drawn much strength from the investigations into the role of armaments interests in the United States' entry into the First World War, and it could not be ruled out that it would now unite with the anti-Bolshevik current, which was particularly powerful among Americans of Italian and Polish descent. On July 18, 1941, the former ambassador to Moscow, Joseph Davies, wrote in a memorandum intended for Harry Hopkins that he was aware of the fact that in the United States "large sections of the population loathe the Soviets to a degree that they are pinning their hopes on Hitler's victory in Russia." Precisely for this reason, he said, Stalin must be supported with all one's strength, since otherwise there would be a danger that he, being the "Oriental and cold realist" that he was, would make peace with Hitler. Fourteen days later, Roosevelt had Hopkins deliver the message to Stalin that he viewed Hitler as the "enemy of mankind" and was therefore determined to help the Soviet Union in its fight against Germany. In this there was undoubtedly more than an opportunistic effort to gain a *breathing space* and time, but rather a genuine tone of ideological conviction. On this basis, Roosevelt did everything he could to lead the United States into war against Hitler and also against Japan, and he did not shy away from the using blatant lies, such as claiming that he had secret maps and documents of the German government containing plans the division of South America and destruction of all religions, including Hinduism. It was not incomprehensible when Hitler saw the "Jewish press power" at work behind Roosevelt, but he did not succeed even with regard to America in suggesting that the undoubtedly existing and even strong anti-Bolshevism was expanding into antisemitism. And if he had been ready to revise his favorite opinions, he would probably have had to say to himself that a *Germanic* America certainly could not have tolerated the formation of a world empire in Europe through acts of war that completely changed the balance of power on earth. If Roosevelt could not follow a straight path and had to resort to lies, slander and violations of neutrality, the main reason was that he did not want to eliminate his domestic political opponents like Hitler had done. As many coincidences played a role in the decisions of the Anglo-Saxon powers, as much insincerity was contained in them and as many opposing forces existed, a deeper necessity ultimately emerged in all of this. Therefore, Hitler had to expect that by crossing the Bug river he would lead not only England but also the USA to the side of the Soviet Union. As far as England and America

were concerned, therefore, there was no genuine alternative because almost no one in England and America believed and could believe that the Soviet Union would be able to resist Germany on its own for more than a few months.

The situation was different with the last of the five world powers, Japan. Since 1937 it was linked to Germany through the Anti-Comintern Pact and since 1940 through the Tripartite Pact. Nothing could have been more obvious than for Germany to have expressed the expectation that Japan would attack the Soviet Union in the east and thus form a *second front* that would have considerably increased Germany's chances of victory. But then one had to make the assumption that there was just one *chance*. Hitler, however, was confident of victory and did not want to allow any equal power to share in his greatest and most important success. It was he himself who encouraged Foreign Minister Matsuoka in April 1941 to conclude a non-aggression pact with the Soviet Union and to look southward to the future "Greater East Asian Prosperity Sphere." Ribbentrop disagreed with Hitler on this point, and he repeatedly urged the confederates to intervene after June 22. There were strong forces in Japan, especially in the army, who thought along the same lines, although the memory of heavy defeats in the 1939 fighting on the border between Outer Mongolia and Manchukuo was a warning sign. It is highly likely that if the Soviet Union had had to fight this two-front war, it would have collapsed before the onset of winter and before the arrival of significant arms shipments from the United States and England. But Hitler did not express himself in clear terms, and the Japanese Navy prevailed with its plan to make one last attempt at negotiations with the United States and then, if necessary, to break the stranglehold of American economic sanctions by reaching the Dutch East Indies and attacking the American fleet.

So Hitler was not completely right when he said to some of his generals on February 3, 1941: "When Barbarossa rises, the world will hold its breath and remain silent." Although the world indeed watched the events breathlessly, because it immediately had the feeling that the fate of the earth was being played for, it remained so silent because the three great powers, on whose decisions the outcome had to depend, immediately made or prepared decisions of the most serious nature. For six months however, Germany and the Soviet Union were apparently alone in the world, and the question was whether the Soviet Union would still exist before the beginning of winter.

The events on the battlefields bore an unmistakable resemblance to those in Poland in September 1939, and yet a very different kind of necessity emerged in them. In Poland, the army of the National Socialist industrial state had triumphed over the army of the nationalist

agrarian state, and apparently with a high degree of necessity. On the plains of Belarus and Ukraine, an army that stood in the tradition of the World War armies fought with an army that had been created against that tradition. The self-confidence of the Red Army was based on the fact that it had once defeated its opponents as a revolutionary force and that it was now commanded by a corps of *commanders*, a significant number of whom had already fought in the Civil War, such as Marshals Voroshilov and Budyonny. The German army, on the other hand, was at its core still the army of the German Empire, despite all the upheavals and changes. And now it became clear that Hitler had done well, within the scope of his objectives, to choose General Blomberg over the Chief of Staff of the SA Röhm. The element of surprise explained a lot, and the popular sympathy for the incoming German troops explained a lot, but obviously the German Wehrmacht was better trained and better led. Army Group North reached Riga on July 2 and continued its advance on Leningrad, whereupon the Finns also advanced from the north. After the encirclement battle of Bialystok and Minsk, Army Group Center defeated Marshal Timoshenko's armies near Smolensk and captured the city, the *key of Russia*, July 16; Army Group South, supported by Romanian troops behind the Prut river and then towards Odessa, penetrated deep into Ukraine and set its sights on Kiev as its next target. The Chief of General Staff Halder thought the war had been won at the beginning of July, but then it became clear that the resistance in many places was tougher than anyone had expected and that the Soviet side was constantly throwing new troops and tanks into the fight, even though by early August the number of Soviet prisoners of war was not far from one million and more than 10,000 tanks had been destroyed. Above all, it had proven that the most modern and powerful Soviet tank types, especially the "T-34" and the "KV," were qualitatively superior to the German tanks. Although there were only about 1,000 of them on the entire front, quite a few of the 3,500 German tanks had been lost, and German armaments production was not able to deliver more than 200 replacements per month. Nevertheless, the will and confidence of the German soldiers for victory was unbroken, and Army Group Center, despite all the difficulties and losses, confidently expected to be able to resume their advance on the basis of this momentum and to give the campaign its decisive crowning achievement by capturing Moscow within a few weeks. But Hitler, who had so often been a psychologist, now turned out to be an economist, who wanted above all to cut off the oil of the Caucasus from the Russians. In addition, he estimated the danger posed by the Soviet troops still in Kiev as very high, and so he kept the Army Group Center to remain on the spot and diverted forces from it for the great encirclement battle in the Dnieper arc, which was extremely successful and once again brought several hundred thousand Soviet soldiers into German captivity. It was not until the beginning of October that Army Group Center received the order to attack again, and now it needed its last forces to slowly advance towards Moscow. In the double battle of Vyazma and Bryansk it prevailed

against strong enemy forces and the advance guards came within a few kilometers of Moscow. From October 16 to 18, panic and almost anarchy reigned in the Soviet capital: party members tore up party books, soldiers threw away rifles, shops were looted, the government left the city, and if the relevant reports are correct, Stalin also drove out on his special train, only to revise his decision at the last moment and return to the Kremlin. The new commander-in-chief, General Zhukov, announced martial law on the 19th, fresh troops from Siberia were on the way, for reassuring news about Japan's attitude had arrived from Tokyo from the German ambassador's confidant, the long-standing party member and agent Richard Sorge, and then the heavy autumn rains began, turning the path and footbridge into an impenetrable morass. For a few days, a tolerable frost made the German troops able to move again, but then the severest winter broke in unusually early, and the Germans no longer only had soldiers and bad roads as enemies, but an overwhelming and unaccustomed force of nature that froze the oil in the engines of the tanks to and sometimes even the rifles in the hands of the infantrymen. In London and Washington, in Tokyo and Paris, people noted in disbelief that Moscow, the center of Soviet life and traffic, had, contrary to all expectations, not fallen into the hands of the enemy and that Hitler might now suffer Napoleon's fate in the icy deserts of Russia.

This brings up the first major alternative, which was unfavorable to Hitler. If the German armies began to flood back, there might be no stopping them, as second line positions were not prepared and safe winter quarters only existed near the German border. The Soviet Army had fallen to its lowest number of personnel since the beginning of the war, 2.9 million men, and a large part of its troops consisted of older or very young, poorly trained soldiers. But the elite Siberian formations might have been able to swept them along, and it cannot be ruled out that a winter war of movement in an east-west direction would have ended in a German catastrophe, and that Russian divisions would have reached Paris and the Channel coast as in 1814. It was Hitler, and to all appearances he alone, who, after assuming personal command of the army on December 19, through extraordinary willpower and ruthless holdout orders, held the front essentially where it stood, although terrain had to be abandoned especially in the middle section, and Rostov, which had just been conquered, was lost again on the southern front. Field Marshals von Bock and von Rundstedt were replaced, Colonel General Hoepner, who had given the order to withdraw to his tank units in front of Moscow, was dismissed from the Wehrmacht, and General von Sponeck, who had failed in the Crimea, was sentenced to death, but to pardoned to prison. (Stalin had more than half of the air force generals, two colonel generals and an entire army staff shot in July.) Thus, news of victory now came out of Moscow, but no news of a German catastrophe. Nevertheless, the events represented the first major loss of confidence among the German population for Hitler. The

fact that a collection of warm winter clothing for the front was carried out at great expense made even the most devout of his followers suspect that Hitler was perhaps the most successful of all generals, but certainly not the greatest, since he was obviously subject to extremely serious errors in judgment. Almost from month to month the people had hoped for a victorious end to the war and thus for peace, and the momentum that had led the German armies to just before Moscow was fueled to a large extent by the expectation that they would be back at home around Christmas. But now no one could be mistaken that the era of lightning campaigns and victories had come to an end and that a long and hard war lay ahead.

Nevertheless, the winter of 1941/42 was full of sensational reports of victories, but these were no longer German victories, but rather Japanese victories. On December 6, the Japanese attacked and largely destroyed the Pacific squadron of the American fleet in Pearl Harbor. This opened the way to Southeast Asia, and a few weeks later Indonesia, the Philippines and Singapore were conquered. But in doing so they had given Roosevelt to entry into the war he had long desired and prepared for, and they presented Hitler with the last, fundamental decision of his life. As at the time of Mussolini's attack against Greece, he was confronted with an independent decision by an ally, for the Japanese had not coordinated their attack with him. To be sure, he had encouraged them to do so several times, but on the other hand he would have had much reason to be angry that the Japanese not only did not enter the war against the Soviet Union, but also did not even prevent the delivery of American military equipment to Vladivostok. The wording of the Tripartite Pact did not oblige him to join in an act of aggression. If he had held back, Roosevelt would have been greatly embarrassed. Roosevelt was primarily concerned with the war against Germany, but public opinion (this time not identical to the published opinion of the major press) would have forced him to turn all war efforts against the perpetrators of the "nefarious attack." But Hitler obviously could not bear the thought that no news of victory would appear in the press for a whole hard winter, and he probably also had a desire to finally settle accounts with Roosevelt after so long putting up with highly unneutral actions. So on December 11 he declared war on the USA and, in a passionate speech in the Reichstag, attacked Roosevelt as the "chief culprit" in this war, who had torpedoed the possible understanding between Germany and Poland with "diabolical unscrupulousness" and who had committed a number of "most serious crimes contrary to international law" and who—as a descendant of plutocrats and from the outset a hater of his antagonist, who was born in poverty—under the influence of his "Jewish followers" directed the problems of his "socially backward state" outwards and against "socialist Germany." But if it satisfied Hitler to be able to confront "the Jew" in both democratic and Bolshevik forms, he should have admitted to himself that he was making on a larger scale the same serious mistake that he had made in 1939, namely, to go to war against

a power whose help or at least neutrality he needed if he wanted to defeat *Bolshevism*. Now he was at war against a world empire and the two great continental powers, all of which had the prospect of becoming world powers of a higher order, superpowers. The production figures that Roosevelt gave as targets at the beginning of 1942 for 1942 and 1943 were so extraordinary that Germany simply had to be swept away by material superiority. Hitler began the campaign against the Soviet Union with 3,500 tanks and 2,000 aircraft, and by 1942 the Americans wanted to build 45,000 tanks and 60,000 aircraft. If only a one-twentieth of this found its way to the Soviet Union, Stalin would have the material superiority that he could no longer gain on his own after the heavy losses in the first year of the war, and from the aircraft carrier England, German industry would be crushed by the incessant attacks of many thousands of heavy bombers.

December 1941 is therefore often referred to as the month of the turning point of the war. It is said that now that Germany was at war with the Soviet Union, the United States and the British Empire, material resources were so unequally distributed that it was only a matter of time before Germany would collapse. This calculation, however, ignores the fact that the Soviet Union had lost a considerable part of its industry and around 70 million inhabitants and that the resources first had to be brought to the battlefields. Furthermore, Germany was the supreme power of Europe, and Hitler had emphasized the idea of a European community of culture and interests in his speech. Japan was, as it would only prove irrefutably decades after the war, not only a military but also an industrial world power, and it occupied almost all of Southeast Asia. If Germany and Japan managed to make full use of all these resources, they would not be significantly inferior in material terms to the three opponents. But it was doubtful whether they would be successful. Factors came into play here that cannot be derived from the mere calculation of raw materials and industrial potential for the purpose of accounting for decisive battles of states and that resulted above all from the difference between *conquered* areas and areas *owned* or possessed from time immemorial. But after Hitler had succeeded in holding the front in Russia, he did not even have to give up the real aim of his struggle in 1942, insofar as it was a political struggle for power and decision: the achievement of the position of a superpower for Germany instead of the Soviet Union.

He could still hope to completely crush the Soviet Union. When the offensive was resumed in May and a counterattack by Timoshenko's Army Group on Kharkov and the Ukraine was repulsed, the German troops advanced, it seemed, inexorably towards the Volga and the Caucasus. The tone of Stalin's orders makes it clear how critical the situation was for him: they were similar to Hitler's orders from the previous winter. Stalingrad seemed to be all but conquered in early November, and the German flag flew on the highest peak in the Caucasus,

Elbrus. The Maikop oil region, although damaged, was in German hands; if Grozny, only 150 kilometers away, was reached and the Volga remained closed to transport, Baku would not even need to be conquered or destroyed from the air, and the Soviet Union definitely would have lost the war.

The island of England had become unassailable, but this did not apply to the British Empire and its lines of communication. German tank troops under General Rommel came to the aid of the Italians in North Africa, and at the end of June the borders of Egypt were crossed. There, all sections of the population were excitedly awaiting the advance to Alexandria and Cairo, including Gamal Abd el-Nasser, then a member of an organization that was described as fascist. East of Egypt, the Arabs of Palestine were facing the decisive hour, and their spokesman, the Grand Mufti of Jerusalem, was in direct contact with Hitler. A call from Hitler might have driven the entire Arab world to revolt against the English, but Hitler was either too cautious or he still loved the English empire too much. Nor did he give any emphatic support to the Indian Subhas Chandra Bose, who seemed to be becoming the leader of the emancipation struggle against the British instead of Nehru.

England itself was still a besieged island struggling for its very existence. In May 1942, German submarines and aircraft sank 170 ships of almost a million gross registered tons, in July they almost completely destroyed an Anglo-American convoy of 38 merchant ships and numerous warships in the Arctic Ocean, and in August three aircraft carriers were destroyed or badly damaged in the Mediterranean along with many merchant ships.

At the end of September, Hitler could actually believe that the war would be won if his tanks advanced to Grozny, if Rommel entered Cairo and if three dozen new submarines were put into service. But as in the previous year, the great victories were achieved using the last reserves. At the decisive moment, the scales tipped in favor of the Allies because they had the *deep armaments industry* that German experts like General Thomas had lamented as early as 1939.

At the end of October, the British counterattacked in Egypt and broke through the El Alamein position, the success of the submarines visibly diminished because the British and Americans developed better means of defense, and Soviet troops shattered the front of the Romanian 3rd Army that was supposed to protect Stalingrad. Once again, as in the previous year, a major goal had to be achieved with the last effort immediately before the onset of winter, and this time not only was some terrain lost, but an entire army under the leadership of a field marshal surrendered in Stalingrad on January 31, 1943. Far larger numbers of soldiers had been taken

prisoner by the Germans the previous year, but this surrender was perceived throughout the world as a symbolic act, an act that marked the turning point of the war. The fact that the British and Americans had landed in North Africa in November was a welcome accompaniment; the fact that Roosevelt was able to demand Germany's "unconditional surrender" in Casablanca in January 1943 highlighted the change in the situation; and the surrender of the German and Italian troops in the Tunis bridgehead in May 1943 was viewed by the Allies as nothing more than an afterthought. It was now beyond doubt that Hitler could no longer win the war.

And yet it would be unfounded to claim that he had already completely lost it. Stalin, for his part, had already announced at the beginning of 1942 that the day was "not far off" when the red flags would again fly victoriously over the liberated Soviet fatherland, and in the summer of 1943 Hitler was still able to fight the biggest tank battle of the entire war in the middle of Russia, near Kursk, in which the newest German types, the "Tiger" and above all the "Panther," proved to be technically superior. Although "Operation Citadel" had to be aborted without success, the Western Allies were apparently still a long way from establishing the promised "Second Front" in France, and it was certainly foreseeable that large parts of the Soviet Union would be under German rule. Thus, strange things happened in the fall of 1943. While in Soviet captivity, German soldiers and officers, together with German communists, formed the "National Committee for Free Germany" or the "League of German Officers," and the publications that were now dropped from airplanes over the German positions were in black, white, and red. Soviet generals acquainted their German partners with ideas from the state leadership that amounted to the coexistence of a Germany, preserved within the borders of 1939, and the restored Soviet Union. At the same time, Moscow put out diplomatic feelers that seemed to have the aim of concluding a separate peace. There are certainly good arguments that both events were clever tactics on the part of Stalin, who wanted to put pressure on his allies. Hitler, for his part, rejected the attempts to contact him. But if one considers the Hitler-Stalin pact and its pre- and post-history, then it is by no means unlikely that in the fall of 1943, for purely political reasons, Stalin preferred to conclude the war that placed the Soviet Union on the continent alongside a half-strong Germany governed by *national* forces rather than an extremely strong America. Only when Roosevelt and Churchill, at the Tehran Conference in November/December 1943, made far greater concessions to him at the expense of Poland and Germany than Field Marshal Paulus or General von Seydlitz could ever have made, does Stalin seem to have abandoned his favorite idea of the Soviet-German superpower in which he would now have played the role of *senior partner*, in contrast to what he had envisioned in the summer of 1941. In this respect, only Tehran was the last and final turn of the war.

Nevertheless, Germany could still have certain hopes for 1944. Of course, Hitler could only link them to the development of *miracle weapons* for himself and his regime. In fact, the foundation for all later development of rocket technology was laid in Germany, and the first jet aircraft were a most promising invention. But it was no coincidence that leading German physicists had complained that German physics had fallen behind American physics. Hitler, after all, had not exactly given scientists or intellectuals any preferential treatment, and the likelihood was high from the start that the more important miracle weapons would be manufactured in the United States. But in the circles of the German resistance, plans for a *Westward orientation* or an *Eastward orientation* of a Germany preserved as a great power without Hitler were being considered, and even in the SS and in the party leadership there seemed to be men who were gradually and cautiously approaching such thoughts. Within the overarching necessity of the Allied victory, there might still be room for final contingencies and alternatives. The most peculiar of all, however, presented itself when one realized that this war was by no means just a decisive battle between world powers over the future picture of the political map of the world, but was also an ideological war between the Bolshevik Soviet Union and National Socialist Germany, thus a civil war in which Russians would choose against "Russia," Germans against "Germany," Italians for Stalin, and the French, indeed, Arabs and Indians would tend to decide for Hitler. In this war, the Anglo-Saxon powers, in which, despite widespread and at least latent antisemitism, almost no one decided in favor for Hitler and against their own states, as the last bastions of liberal democracy, took a position that was not clearly defined from the outset.

World War of Ideologies?

In 1930, a delegation from the German Red Front Fighters' League traveled to Siberia, and their spokesman assured the (later) Marshal Blücher that the German proletariat would stab the bourgeoisie in the back if the Soviet Union was attacked. A year later, the founder of the pan-European movement, Richard von Coudenhove-Kalergi, was so convinced of this view, which had been put forward again and again by communists since 1919, that he wrote in his book "Stalin & Co": "Any European army that would try to fight against Moscow...would have innumerable enemies in its rear." As late as 1936, the chairman of the "Profintern," Losowski, asserted with great confidence that the imperialists, namely Germany, Poland and Japan, could be convinced that a war against the Soviet Union would also mean a war in their own country: "We know against whom the proletarians of these countries will turn their guns. You want to have war, gentlemen, try it. And you will have war in your own factories, mills and colonies." No further evidence is needed to make it clear that, at least until 1939, supporters and opponents of Bolshevism were uniformly convinced that the Soviet Union, as the champion of an ideology, i.e. of a universal doctrine of the nature of historical movement and of the future destinies of mankind, had countless followers in all countries of the world who would not shrink from taking up arms in defense of the Soviet Union and for its victory. These supporters would be a clearly identifiable group, namely the proletariat, which, as the makers of surplus value, would crush the exploiting class of the bourgeoisie in order to establish the classless, non-multi-state and alienation-free state of socialism throughout the world. Even Galeazzo Ciano, Foreign Minister of Fascist Italy and Mussolini's son-in-law, but an Anglophile at heart, anxiously asked the question in his diary on the evening of June 21, 1941: "If the Soviet army had greater power of resistance than the bourgeois countries, what reaction would that provoke in the proletarian masses of the world?" And in fact, as early as September 16, the Wehrmacht High Command had to state that since June 22, communist insurrectionary movements had broken out everywhere in the territories occupied by Germany, which were being uniformly directed by Moscow and required the harshest

countermeasures.

On the other hand, Mussolini, in his reply to Hitler's announcement of the start of the attack, had expressed confidence that "all anti-Bolshevik currents in the whole world" would now turn to the Axis, and Adolf Hitler in his speech on October 3, 1941, characterized Bolshevism and capitalism as "extremes" equidistant from the "principle of justice" for which the Axis powers waged their struggle for a new and better form of Europe. National Socialism thus emphatically raised a supranational claim, as demonstrated by its solidarity with its fascist Axis partner, and not infrequently proclaimed a "world struggle" which would unite all of Europe in the defense against the "Bolshevik monster" and the American "money Moloch." The defensive background and the varying severity of the accusations were of course made clear often enough, because Bolshevism was repeatedly accused of having "slaughtered the entire national intelligentsia" in Russia and of wanting to prepare the same fate to all the leading classes of the world, while the main accusation against *democracy* was that it paved the way for Bolshevism. Sometimes a deep pessimism appeared in Hitler's statements, when he predicted to Churchill and Roosevelt that Bolshevism would one day destroy their peoples as well. But one should not reduce Hitler's *worldview* entirely to the emotions of defensiveness and fear: quite often the focus was on pride in having carried out a different and better revolution than Bolshevism, a revolution that opened up all state positions even to the poorest without limiting "the creative power of the old estates" or destroying national property. Hitler was therefore able to put behind him not only supranational fears, but also supranational hopes. His struggle was also ideological and tended to be supranational, although it could not be overlooked that this ideology was based on a harsh nationalism that placed so much focus on "the German people" and at best, "Nordic blood" so much at the center, that even solidarity with Italian fascism seemed to be on fragile ground.

But what Coudenhove-Kalergi or Losowski had foreseen did not materialize: the proletarian revolution in Europe as a response to Germany's war against the first *workers' state*. Hardly any German soldier defected to the enemy, who claimed to be a friend; not a single strike paralyzed armaments production, even in the "Protectorate" industry worked without disruption, and France remained essentially calm. On the contrary, Hitler could be sure of a millionfold echo when he spoke in a tone of deep contempt that the German soldiers had now become thoroughly acquainted with the so-called "paradise of the workers and peasants."

On the other hand, he could not deny that he himself had made a pact with this regime and that it was he who had opened the way for it to Lemberg and Riga, where so many victims of

the NKVD had now been found. And so, in his speech on November 8, 1941, he had to admit in the previous year he had been “perhaps somewhat burdened” by the martyrs of the movement, and only now did he look at their graves “almost as if redeemed.” After the “Friendship Pact” of 1939, Hitler’s ideology could no longer have the integrity and confidence that it had possessed at the “Party Congress of Honor” in 1936.

But Stalin also expressed himself in a strange way. He in no way called on the European proletariat to revolt against their oppressors and Hitler’s real backers, namely the capitalists; rather, in his speech on the 24th anniversary of the revolution on November 6, 1941, he noted with satisfaction that the “German strategists” had not succeeded in creating a general coalition against the USSR by intimidating the ruling circles in Great Britain and the USA with the “specter of revolution”; rather, Hitler’s people now berated the internal regime of England and America as a “plutocratic regime,” and Stalin no longer saw the contrast as a surface phenomenon, but rather he placed the “democratic freedoms” and the parliaments of these countries in stark contrast to that “party of medieval reaction and darkest pogroms,” which the Hitler party represented. Obviously, he now rejected the equation of *fascism and capitalism*, which had been a main thesis of the communist parties for so long, even more decisively than he had since 1935, because it virtually postulated a coalition which would have been fatal for the Soviet Union.

It would indeed have been impossible for Roosevelt to take up Wilson’s ideas again and proclaim as the goal of the United States “to cleanse the world of old evils and old diseases,” if Stalin, in turn, had brought up Lenin’s ideas of 1918 to the fore. Then he would have had to tell himself that he and his America were by no means merely a world disease and a “disgusting swamp” in Hitler’s eyes, as Molotov is said to have expressed himself in a conversation with the Lithuanian Foreign Minister in the summer of 1940. And in any case, it was far more in keeping with the inner content of the Bolshevik conviction when Molotov had said in the same conversation that the German bourgeoisie would one day come to an agreement with the Allied bourgeoisie against the rebellion of its starving proletariat, and then the Soviet Union would intervene and somewhere near the Rhine “the final battle between the proletariat and the degenerate bourgeoisie” would take place. Nothing like that was allowed to be said by Stalin now, and Roosevelt was not allowed to acknowledge anything like that: just like the National Socialist ideology, the ideologies of the Bolsheviks and the liberal internationalists in America were weakened by the events of the time, and the states that were waging a decisive battle for the fate of the world were indeed ideological states, but they were ideological states that had lost the integrity of 1918 and 1933.

In any case, countless people in Europe and outside Europe sided against the policies of their national governments or traditions on the side of one of these powers, or more precisely, with the Allies or with the *Axis* or, since the fall of Mussolini in July 1943, with Germany.

It would be incorrect to claim that the European resistance movements only came into serious existence after June 22, 1941, i.e. through the reaction of the communists to the attack against the Soviet Union. Rather, it became decisive for the character of the resistance movements in East and West that by June 1941 the communists had practically taken Hitler's side against the *Western imperialists* and were still negotiating with the German occupation authorities in some places, while in London General de Gaulle had already become the symbolic figure of the French resistance. But the Polish resistance movement had also been formed long before June 1941, and it was England with its special organization "S.O.E." ("Secret Operations Executive"), which promoted and nurtured all resistance movements in occupied Europe. But it cannot be denied that, on the one hand, the Comintern had already shown a considerable degree of open hostility towards Hitler's Germany since the beginning of 1941 and, on the other hand, resistance had suddenly increased almost everywhere since June 22. Far more than before, the intention now came to the fore to provoke the harshest possible retaliation through assassinations against German soldiers and to generate ever greater hatred against the occupying power among the population, an intention that also determined the situation in the partisan struggle in the Soviet Union. The best-known paradigm was not a communist attack, but rather the assassination attempt against the incumbent Reich Protector Reinhard Heydrich in Prague, which was prepared by the Czech government in exile and which had the expected and at least calculated consequence of the destruction of the village of Lidice. Most overtly communist, as is well known, was Tito's resistance movement in Yugoslavia, which was supported by the English against the *bourgeois* resistance movement of Draža Mihailovich, but was then internally reprimanded by Stalin precisely because of the openness of its objectives, according to Milovan Djilas' report.

The German resistance was a special case. It was not directed against an occupying power, but against the regime of its own state and, to some extent, against certain objectives of the regime rather than against the regime and its supreme leader as such. The Quakers certainly shared the beliefs of the foreign Quakers, and the Social Democrats, who were active in illegality, shared the goals of the emigrated party executive. Insofar as one may speak of resistance from workers or the youth or the students, it was mainly based on the harsh demands that the regime made even more insistently during the war. But as far as it was a question of resistance in the leading and the only class capable of acting, i.e. primarily in the Wehrmacht, there was mainly resistance from more or less nationalistic patriots, i.e. who

were primarily committed to the principle of national self-determination and who fought Hitler's objectives primarily because they threatened to plunge Germany into disaster. Almost all of them, and most notably Carl Goerdeler, believed until a relatively late date that the successes of Hitler's revisionism, i.e. the annexation of Austria and the Sudeten territories, could be preserved as legitimate consequences of the right to self-determination in a timely compromise peace after the fall of the dictator. Of course, Tresckow, like Stauffenberg, had sympathized with National Socialism in the beginning, but the extent to which events nevertheless led them and those like them away from their inherited nationalism and even from the Prussian state ethos, the negotiations with the English in the winter of 1939/40, Hans Oster's messages about Hitler's intentions to attack with the Dutch military attaché, and finally Stauffenberg's assassination attempt against the supreme warlord, to which there is not the remotest analogy to be found in the entire Prussian and German history, showed most strongly. However, not everyone made their decision in favor of one of the two worldviews, which now tended to rival each other: Ulrich von Hassell wanted to play the western or the eastern card, depending on the circumstances, and not even the men and women of the Kreisau Circle around Helmuth James von Moltke could have counted on the approval of American Democrats with their domestic reform plans.

The overwhelming majority of the prisoners of war, soldiers and officers, who founded the "National Committee of Free Germany" and the "Association of German Officers" in Soviet captivity in September 1943 were also nationally conscious and patriotic. They while they were prisoners of war in the Soviet Union. That Hitler had led Germany into war against an overwhelmingly powerful coalition and that he had to be overthrown if Germany was to be saved was the basic tenor of all the manifestos and appeals signed by Generals von Seydlitz, Korfes, Lattmann and many others, including finally also Field Marshal Paulus. But it was not always based on a narrow and purely political concept of fatherland. Against the system of lies and lawlessness, but also against the forced economy and cultural leveling, already in May 1942, the captain and teacher Dr. Ernst Hadermann gave an impressive speech in the Jelabuga camp, and by joining with German communists in *anti-fascism*, both sides at least tended to accept what had been unthinkable just a few years before: that the opposition between proletarians and bourgeois was not the most profound one of the era. And when, immediately before July 20, even in Germany, the right-wing Social Democrats Leber and Leuschner made contact with communists, they were very surprised to find that the latter seemed to have less radical views than themselves and were apparently even prepared to accept grand burghers as fellow fighters.

The step toward unreserved and active identification with the enemy was taken in Germany

only by the small group of the “Red Orchestra” whose leading figures were the grandson of Grand Admiral Tirpitz, Harro Schulze-Boysen, and the nephew of the most respected theologian of the Wilhelmine period, Arvid Harnack. But even their espionage activities were apparently influenced not least by the old idea of the national revolutionary movement that Germany could only maintain its integrity and independence by cooperating with Soviet Russia.

The fact that the old beliefs and emotions were still alive among the communists was demonstrated most clearly by those who were not or only marginally reached by the instructions from headquarters. “I die as what I lived, as a class fighter,” a member of a communist resistance group wrote to his father before his execution in May 1943, and he added in a postscript: “Better to die for the Soviet Union than to live for fascism.” A year later, another group asserted in a leaflet intended for Eastern workers and captured Red Army soldiers: “The terrible contradictions between the capitalist powers and their wars are setting the proletarian masses of Europe and the USSR in motion. Fascism is only the tombstone that covers the declining class.” This is what Molotov must have meant, if the Lithuanian Foreign Minister rendered him correctly, and this is exactly what Roosevelt could not have known if he wanted to continue to count Stalin as part of his *family*. The new unity among the Allies and among those who felt solidarity with them in their nations or against their nations was probably a deceptive unity.

But whatever the solidity of the extremely paradoxical alliance between the *state of socialism* and the *main power of capitalism*, no one could doubt that Soviet communism was able to evoke a genuine and supranational identification and that Roosevelt was able to rearticulate a conviction which was older than capitalism and which had survived in the midst of all the changes. Such identification was much less obvious in the opposing camp. It is true that there were a considerable number of fascist movements in Europe, and they had consistently sided with Hitler since at least June 22, 1941: in addition to Italian fascism, there were, among others, the Iron Guard in Romania, the Arrow Cross in Hungary, and the Nasjonal Samling in Norway, the Parti Populaire Français in France, the Rodobrana in Slovakia, the Ustasha in Croatia. But all of them, in their origins or traditions, had been initially radical nationalist reactions to the internationalist and mostly socialist ideas and realities of the first post-war period. They could not agree therefore in their “pro” because one aspired to a powerful Greater Romania, the other to a strong Greater Hungary, the third demanded separation from a federation of states, and the fourth and the original wanted to restore the Roman Empire. Only the “anti” formed the common ground, namely the “anti” of a decisive anti-communism. Of course, communism as anti-capitalism for its part arose from an “anti-,”

and through its alleged realization in a large state it entered into a peculiar relationship with facts such as power, structure and professional army, which it nevertheless wanted to eliminate. The more the communist faith gained in menace and lost its persuasiveness through its connection with Soviet reality, the more the mere “anti” of the fascist movements was able to enrich itself with social thoughts and ultimately claim to be the timely “Third Way” between the extremes of Soviet communism and American capitalism. The question was whether and how the supranational solidarity of an ideology could gain the upper hand over the starting point of mere national or ethnic self-affirmation.

An obvious solution presented itself when, after the *opening* of the Soviet Union by the German attack, the entire strangeness of the Stalinist state became apparent to the German, Italian, Romanian and Spanish soldiers. The most trivial and questionable attempt to turn the experience of this strangeness into an ideology was the brochure “Der Untermensch” published by the main office of the SS in 1942. Besides the despicable and foolish attempt to derive the type of *subhuman* or even *Asiatic* from the emaciated faces of some prisoners of war, an early and general horror image was nevertheless conjured up, the horror image of the bloodthirsty commissar and the fanatical female soldiers, and above all the pitiful wooden huts of the Russian farmers and the miserable apartments of Russian workers were contrasted with the far richer and more cultivated living conditions of Europe in a way that reminded the informed observer of the cheerful figures of *socialist realism*, but which, despite its obvious one-sidedness, was not implausible to the ordinary soldiers of many European nations. At any rate, those German *soldiers* saw the situation in this way, whose “Field Letters from the East” was published by an official in the Ministry of Propaganda in 1941 and would undoubtedly not have been published if he had considered them to be mere propaganda, which would have been perceived as distorted or dishonest by the mass of German soldiers. There was talk of the “accursed” or “wretched” country in which one hungers “just for the sight of a clean house or a few well-tended gardens,” in which the farmers, robbed of their land, live in “economic drudgery,” such as had not been worse in the darkest German Middle Ages. The streets were nothing but sandy paths, and villages and towns consist of small wooden huts, between which there rose only a few palaces of the party or the “bigwigs”; an unemployed person in Germany lived “like a king compared to these people.” Of course, the question had to be asked why the rich Germany had attacked such a poor country, and it was answered by pointing to the “good and modern weapons” that the commissioners had squeezed out of this poverty, and the commissioners or even the Jews were held responsible for the horrible pictures that several of the letter writers claim to have seen themselves: men, women and children nailed to the walls, victims walled up in the cellars of prisons and agonizingly suffocated, even torture chambers with gas burners installed inside used to

torture the victims to death. All of this gave rise to the imperative call for European solidarity in the fight against an inhumane and anti-European system. Who knew that an Italian fascism magazine had been called “Anti-Europe” and who wanted to admit that there were concentration camps and torture chambers not only in the Soviet Union? There were very few who, like Lieutenant Colonel Helmuth Groscurth, were of the opinion that the Germans were being completely misinformed about the Soviet Union and that the Russian officers he had to interrogate were for the most part intelligent and educated people.

In any case, volunteers from almost all European countries came together to fight against communism, and from them a large number of foreign-national SS formations were created. The “Freikorps Danmark” was put together from Danes, Walloon volunteers from the Degrelle movement formed the SS Storm Brigade Wallonia, and towards the end of the war an entire SS division made up of Frenchmen was called “Charlemagne.” A significant number of Estonians and Latvians joined the Wehrmacht soon after June 22, and later they also became SS divisions. Just as the Spanish Civil War was an international conflict on both sides, Germany’s war against the Soviet Union was also an international war. If the Soviet Union was obviously not reluctant to allow the Polish army, which it raised from the comrades of the Katyn victims, to go to the Western Allies, before forming its own auxiliary troops from Poles and Romanians at a later stage, the European volunteers fought in the Wehrmacht and the Waffen-SS to the end, and it cannot be doubted that many of them rallied to the banners of National Socialist Germany out of conviction and not out of mere opportunism. However, especially among the most convinced, the motive was palpable to fight for the right to independence of their countries in the future Europe of a “New Order” by contributing blood, the right to an independence which they apparently no longer considered self-evident and inviolable.

Future independence of the Turkestan and Tatar units of the Waffen-SS still had to be won, through which the *Aryan* racial concept was now exploded after the *Germanic* one, so that one could tend to speak of a world movement against Bolshevism, outside of the Jews no one was excluded. (English or American associations, of course, did not exist in the German or German-Italian camp, but there were some important or at least interesting intellectuals such as Ezra Pound and the son of the former India Minister Amery.) But only the question of Russian volunteers could be compared to a litmus test, whereby the supranational character of an ideological claim could be examined.

Russian volunteers were numerous in the German Wehrmacht at an early stage. But they remained without recognized status for a long time, and their inclusion initially took place in a

purely pragmatic manner. During the hardships and difficulties of the first winter of the war, numerous formations had employed Russian prisoners of war who volunteered to serve as auxiliaries, and since the experience was generally good, quite a few of them were equipped with weapons, for example to guard depots or even to fight partisans. In 1942, the first genuine units were formed, such as the “Kaminski Brigade,” and the group leader in the organization department of the Army General Staff, Lieutenant Colonel Stauffenberg—already recognized at the time as a man of outstanding ability and determination—used all his talents to make the formation of Russian volunteer units possible. In doing so, he encountered determined resistance from the Wehrmacht High Command and indirectly from Hitler, who wanted to keep a completely free hand vis-à-vis Russia, but to whom certain events from the civil war were obviously present, namely the defection of entire regiments to the Bolsheviks. If nevertheless, in the fall of 1942, Russians “who were willing to help” already numbered in the hundreds of thousands, this was due to the fact that the individual army groups and also the General Staff still had possibilities for action into which Hitler had no insight. Furthermore, the deployment of “legions” of the other peoples of the Soviet Union took place with his full consent, and the boundaries were often difficult to draw. Why should not the “General of the Eastern Troops” also have Russians under his command?

But all those officers in the staffs of the army groups—among them primarily Colonel Tresckow from Army Group Center—in the general staff and in the Wehrmacht propaganda department, who had a clear awareness of the impending loss of the war acknowledged that only the formation of a National Russian government under the leadership of a man known to the Soviet population could still turn the tide and give a stimulating purpose to the war. For them there was no question that, despite the terrible experiences of the first winter of the war, there were enough peasants among the Russian prisoners of war who hated the collective farm system, and enough officers whose family members had perished in NKVD camps. But they also knew that the successes would be very limited and that the propaganda would not gain any credibility among the soldiers of the Red Army and the population of the Soviet hinterland as long as it was not accompanied by reliable assurances about Russia’s future fate. The leadership of the Eastern Ministry also sympathized more and more with such ideas, although they continued to adhere to the goal of an independent Ukraine.

It was therefore a major event when one of the best-known Soviet military commanders was captured in September 1942 and soon revealed that he rejected Stalin and Bolshevism and was prepared to cooperate with the Germans under certain conditions. Lieutenant General Andrei Andreyevich Vlasov was widely believed to have commanded the best of all Soviet

divisions, and in October/November 1941 he, along with Zhukov, had contributed the most to the defense of Moscow. Then, as deputy commander of an army group and commander of the Second Shock Army, he had tried to carry out Stalin's unrealistic order to liberate Leningrad, but after heavy fighting his army had perished at the Volkhov and he himself was captured after weeks of wandering in a state of complete exhaustion. He owed his brilliant career, in addition to his own ability, to the party he had joined in 1930, but he was the son of a peasant who had been forced to join a collective farm, and he had attended a spiritual seminary in his youth. So he always had certain reservations about Bolshevism and Stalin, but it was only the experience of the war that increased them to hatred. The story of its *discovery* by some German officers, such as the Baltic Captain Strik-Strikfeldt and the head of the "Foreign Armies East" department, Major General Gehlen, reads like a fantastic novel, and Vlasov repeatedly expressed to his German friends a stunned amazement at what extent individual initiative and free speech among intimates was still possible in this Germany. In the spring and summer of 1943 he actually seemed to be rising to the position of leader of a Russian counter-government: his "Open Letter" of March 3, 1943 fiercely attacked Stalin as the murderer of millions of Russian people and called upon the people "to fight for the completion of the revolution, to the creation of a new Russia and to fraternal unity with the peoples of Europe and especially with the great German people." Even if the statements by Vlasov's friends about the enormous and sudden increase in the number of defectors after this announcement were probably exaggerated, it can hardly be denied that Vlasov's appearance made a very deep impression both in the areas still occupied by the Soviets and in the part of Russia occupied by Germany, and caused great anxiety in Moscow. On a trip to the front headquarters of Army Groups Center and North, Vlasov was treated almost as an equal by the commanding field marshals, and the population crowded up to kiss his hands. But it was precisely because of this that he attracted the attention of Hitler and Himmler, and a strict ban was imposed on further promoting "this Russian" except for mere propaganda purposes. Nevertheless, astonishingly, the preparations for setting up a Russian national army continued, and around Vlasov's residence in Berlin-Dahlem and around the Dabendorf camp near Berlin, in a semi-illegal manner, all those forces that had fought each other fiercely in the civil war came together in a few representatives: the farmer's son and general of the Red Army Vlasov, the political commissar Zhilenkov, the Jewish political commissar and former employee of Bukharin Zykov, the son of a clergyman Colonel Meandrow who died in exile, Air Force Colonel Maltsev who had been cruelly tortured by the NKVD, Sakharov the son of the former adjutant of Admiral Kolchak, and the emigrated Cossack generals Krasnov and Schkuro. There was no shortage of tensions, just as in the German resistance, which was also an alliance of various forces that had once fought each other mercilessly and thereby made Hitler's triumph possible. And if one did not know exactly how many people were behind the

men who carried out the assassination attempt on July 20, 1944, there were nearly a million people gathered behind Vlasov's supporters and allies at the same time. It must certainly remain a speculation how many millions there would have been if Vlasov had received the consent of Hitler and Himmler, not only in November 1944, but already in November 1942 or even just at the beginning of 1944, to establish the independent "Russian Liberation Army" under the sign of the white-blue St. Andrew's Cross and to establish the "National Committee for the Liberation of the Peoples of Russia." But it would not be an illegitimate speculation, as already proved by the fate of even the uninvolved Soviet prisoners of war after the end of the war. But the failure and the tragedy at least proved that for many Germans and countless Russians this war had been a liberation struggle after all, doomed to failure only because Hitler despite all the experiences he had rigidly clung to the concept that implied genocides and *final solutions*, because in the total egocentrism of the German *race* the concept was not yet ideological and in the will to destroy *Judaism* it could no longer be subsumed into the usual concept of ideology.

Chapter V, Section 4

Genocides and “Final Solution to the Jewish Question”

The genocides and the “final solution to the Jewish question” for which National Socialist Germany is responsible, cannot be understood in their specificity simply by declaring them to be *singular* and considering distinctions to be superfluous. The incomparable presupposes comparison, and the unity of the designation often conceals the diversity of things.

Genocide is closely related to war, but the two terms do not coincide. Even in classical antiquity, wars between cities or tribes often ended with the killing of all the men of the vanquished and the women and children abducted or sold into slavery: Homer’s epics consistently assume this genocidal character of war. But modern Europe and the Middle Ages were distinguished by the fact that they sought to civilize war, i.e. to make a distinction between combatants and non-combatants. Thus, according to the idea, an entire people could no longer be annihilated, and gradually a right for prisoners of war was established, which guaranteed protection for the defeated and eliminated combatants, as it was done, for example, by the Hague Land War Code of 1907. Most importantly, it stipulated that the will to conclude an armistice or peace created certain rights that precluded the situation from being exploited for the purpose of genocide. Before the outbreak of the First World War, the civilized world considered it normal for the armed forces of two or more states to fight each other with the complete exclusion of the civilian population until a decision was made and peace was concluded through negotiations. The basic requirement was that armies and civilian populations be clearly distinguished. Already at the beginning of the First World War, this condition was jeopardized by the fact that a part of the Belgian population, rightly believing that their country had been invaded, resorted to the *free-shooter’s war* [*francs-tireurs*] and thereby provoked reprisals from the Germans, in particular the hostage shootings. It became conceivable that such reprisals were directed fundamentally and on a large scale against the entire civilian population because they offered protection and assistance to the franc-tireurs. In an extreme case that could be constructed, the entire

Belgian population would have been exterminated in order to take away the basis for the attacks by the franc-tireurs, i.e. in order to achieve preventative security against acts contrary to international law. Thus, literally, genocide have become a reality, namely the killing of all the inhabitants of a country. German politics remained infinitely far from this, but if one extended the lines one arrived at a terrible ideal type. However, even the most ruthless thinker would have taken it for granted that the survival of the people would have been ensured by cessation of resistance.

In another way, the distinction between combatants and non-combatants in the First World War was jeopardized by the fact that both England and Germany resorted to the military tool of blockade. Unlike the war against franc-tireurs or partisans, the blockade was also directed against women and children from the outset; as an extreme case, the possibility arose that the entire population of England or Germany would have starved to death and the armies would have fought on the corpses of women and children. However, nobody thought of that; for everyone there was no question that the defeated state would make peace in time. But the conditions for a radical *dehumanization* of warfare, i.e. for genocides, were nevertheless created in the First World War, and on the fringes, or rather, in its wake, the first genuine or potential genocides in modern history also became reality: the ethnic tensions in a multi-ethnic state led to genocide of the Armenians by the Turks in direct connection with the war, and a little later there was a *population exchange* between the Turks and the Greeks, which did not amount to mass expulsions with mass losses only because the great powers kept a watchful eye on it. Air warfare, on the other hand, was limited to its initial beginnings, although it obviously held the possibility of being directed directly against the civilian population as the most sensitive and yet indispensable element of warfare. *Progress* therefore showed a strange double face: as progress in humanitarian sentiment it sought to contain and humanize war more and more, while as progress in weapons technology it tore down borders that had often meant protection for the non-combatant population even in barbaric times.

Towards the end of the war, however, a completely new element was brought into the world when the postulate of class annihilation gained practical significance. A comparatively harmless manifestation was the Allies' demand for the extradition of 700 German "war criminals," which was closely linked to the propaganda against the *Prussian Junkers*. What was meant was not the punishment of individual offenses—the German government agreed to investigate and possibly punish them—but rather the discrediting of an entire ruling class, and it quickly became clear that this intention generated a broad solidarity in Germany, including even many Social Democrats, even though breaking or limiting the power of the Junkers was also one of their goals. In Russia, on the other hand, the principle of class

annihilation became a comprehensive reality. It made sense to say that it was by no means a genocide if, after a lost war, the population of a state held its ruling class responsible and broke their resistance with violence. But despite the *Armenian massacres*, no one could yet even imagine the complete annihilation of a people, and therefore the attack against entire classes without examining individual guilt was perceived as horrible, as genocidal. Furthermore, the Bolsheviks explicitly proclaimed their intention to continue the destruction of the Russian bourgeoisie until the destruction of the “world bourgeoisie.” How could it have failed to create a climate of general concern and fear, even if the positive solidarity of the European bourgeoisie with the Russian bourgeoisie remained low? Was it not also possible to kill a nation by eliminating its *ruling class*, which in modern Europe included by no means only those feudal lords whom Saint-Simon had called as superfluous in his famous “Parable,” but precisely those technicians and merchants, scientists and financiers, who according to Saint-Simon were to take their place after? And very quickly the opinion arose in some circles that what was happening in Russia was a genocide in the literal sense of the word, because *the Jews* had murdered the leading class of Russians and Baltic Germans and had taken their place.

The immediate consequence of this view was obviously the postulate of an extermination of the Jews as a punishment and preventative measure, and since the Jews of their own accord—and especially in the Soviet Union—more and more no longer or not yet understood themselves as a denomination, but as a people or a nationality, the so-called “final solution to the Jewish question” would have to be described as the ideal-type genocide, which would be founded on the collectivism of assigning guilt to a supra-individual entity. As much as this connection jumps to the eye, it would still be inappropriate to make it the starting point for labeling the Second World War as a war of annihilation, because the beginnings of genocide were already recognizable in the First World War before 1917, and the German genocides were neither the only ones, nor were they limited to the Jews. They nevertheless had specific characteristics, but these can only be discerned through comparison.

The war against Poland began with a tendency towards genocide on the Polish side, namely the so-called “Bloody Sunday of Bromberg,” the slaughter of a few thousand citizens of German origin by enraged Poles. The dive bomber attacks on Warsaw and other cities and the resulting losses of the civilian population, however, were not an *response*, but were included in the war plan from the outset and, after Guernica and Barcelona, were the first, although still very incomplete, realization of the genocidal tendencies in modern warfare.

A mere resumption of the world war meant the blockade that England and Germany mutually

imposed on each other, but as in the world war, the suffering could be made bearable by the even rationing of the available food and, if necessary, ended in a timely manner by a peace treaty. On the other hand, the intention expressed by Churchill in a letter to Lord Beaverbrook on July 8, 1940 was openly and undisguisedly genocidal: there was only one way to defeat Hitler, and that was an "absolutely destructive attack of annihilation of very heavy bombers on the Nazi hinterland." That the Prime Minister meant statements like this very seriously is all too clear from a speech he gave in April 1941, before the German attack on the Soviet Union: "There are less than 70 million malignant Huns, some of whom are curable and others killable." In fact, until the invasion in June 1944, the British and Americans waged the war almost entirely—and still to a large extent thereafter—as a war of annihilation through air raids against the German population, to which around 700,000 people fell victim, much of it under terrible, in earlier times unimaginable agonies and torment. Admittedly, Hitler also wanted to "wipe out their cities." But today it would rightly be considered foolish today to separate these statements from corresponding statements by Churchill or to postulate a one-sided consequence of German cause and English effect.

A few weeks after the beginning of the war, Stalin had the population of the Volga German Republic deported to Siberia. One can assume that not much less than 20% of those deported died during the weeks-long transports in the scorching heat. An even higher percentage can be assumed for the Lithuanians, Latvians and Estonians who were transported into the interior of the Soviet Union in a second wave of deportations immediately before the outbreak of war. As early as 1940, the Soviet General Staff was said to have considered *special measures* against the peoples of the northern Caucasus region, especially the Chechens, Ingush and Kalmyks, since they, who had long resisted Russian expansion under the Tsar, were considered unreliable in the event of war. In fact, many of these peoples joined the Germans, who promised them freedom and independence, and they were *resettled* in 1944 without exception. The Crimean Tatars met the same fate, and the death rates for the first 18 months were, according to Robert Conquest's estimates, not much less than 50%. After collectivization had already claimed particularly large numbers of victims among the nomadic peoples of the Asian districts of the Soviet Union, Stalin now carried out genocides quite openly as preventive measures and as punitive actions. It seems that the battles against the partisans of the OUN [*Organization of Ukrainian Nationalists*] , which the Red Army had to wage after the reoccupation of the Ukraine, also tended to have the character of genocide, and it is extremely significant that Khrushchev was not just joking in his secret speech when he claimed that Stalin would have deported the Ukrainians too if there hadn't been too many of them. And when Marshal Mannerheim informed his German allies that he would conclude an armistice with the Soviet Union, he used the argument that his people

would "without doubt be expelled or exterminated" if he did not take the painful step in time. The Soviet Union's warfare was thus characterized by genocide to an even greater extent than that of England, and one must ask whether even Beneš' plans for a *transfer* of the Sudeten Germans could not be subsumed under the term genocide. There can be no doubt that Churchill's plan to "move Poland westward" and thus to expel the German population from the East German areas beyond the Oder and Neisse can be classified as such.

And yet Hitler's genocides belong to a different category. The difference is not that they were quantitatively more comprehensive throughout. In terms of numbers, it does not appear that significantly more former officers were shot in the "General Government" than in the Soviet-occupied part of Poland. But Hitler made a principle of extermination and demanded early on that "all representatives of the Polish intelligentsia be killed." And most importantly, the relationship between ends and means was reversed here. Victory in the defensive war was no longer the goal, while air raids and resettlements were a means forced by circumstances to bring the war to a victorious conclusion, but the creation of free space was the goal and the war was a mere means. Genocide therefore did not cease with the end of the war, but was precisely to be made possible on a larger scale by the victory. Even surrender did not help the peoples concerned, and their willingness to side with Germany was even considered a danger. As early as January 1941, Himmler had said in a speech at Wewelsburg that thirty million people would have to disappear in the East, and as late as 1944 he still maintained his demand that the ethnic border in the East be pushed back by 500 kilometers. The "General Plan East" envisaged the resettlement of 31 million people to Siberia and the "repopulation" of millions more, and even if the mass death of prisoners of war in the winter of 1941/42 was to a large extent due to the unmanageable circumstances, not least to Stalin's extermination orders, however, Hitler's will to biologically weaken the Russian people was an important factor, a will to which there was no real analogy on Stalin's side, even though Ilya Ehrenburg's call to "Kill" in 1942 corresponded to Hitler's intention of biological extermination. Certainly the "living space policy" had various motives, and it was by no means solely the result of Hitler's will: the fear of the demographic superiority of the "Eastern peoples"; dreams of a healthy rural life that alone could put an end to social conflicts and save the Germans from the "death of civilization"; Anglophilia in the form of the urge for a "German India"; last but not the least, the memory of the English blockade in the First World War and its consequences. But even if one isolates Hitler's most rational thought, the idea of acquiring superpower status for Germany, it is easy to see that Vlasov and his sponsors had no chance as long as Hitler still believed in *his* victory. Just as he apparently considered the "Bolshevik disintegration" to be an inescapable fate unless very special structures could be consolidated for eternity, so too was he also convinced that

possession of weapons would lead to independence and that Vlasov's *national Russia* would in the foreseeable future be stronger than the Greater German Reich, which would have been content with the borders of 1939. And that is why Erich Koch carried out Hitler's policy in the Ukraine, when he pursued a colonial policy as if were "among Negroes," when he knocked the offered bread and salt out of the hands of Ukrainian delegations that wanted to greet him, when he repeatedly had floggings carried out. In doing so, he pursued a policy of mental genocide, genocide through contempt and degradation, and he had the strange experience that disproved him as well as it disproved Hitler: that the population reacted more violently and emphatically to degradation and contempt than to shootings. The Bolsheviks had—as a memorandum put it—shot many people, but had not had a single one publicly beaten, and the cleverest head in the Eastern Ministry, the diplomat Dr. Bräutigam, drew the conclusion in a remarkable memorandum that Russians and Ukrainians were now fighting for recognition of their human dignity against the Germans. And so it came about that no anti-bolshevik struggle for freedom and human dignity of individuals could be waged against Stalin's despotic system could be waged in the Soviet Union, even though countless people—Russians, Ukrainians and even Germans—were ready for it, but that in the end only a struggle for conquest and a war of annihilation was waged, which as such had no ideology because it was nothing more than a lightless *national struggle* and unlimited national egoism. If a nation declares itself to be "superior" and wants to cleanse the earth of everything "inferior," including the mentally ill, mainly in order to exercise a supposedly natural rule and at the same time "push itself back to health" in a quite material sense, then this is not an *ideology*, and this nation must therefore not be surprised if it ultimately turns all other nations against itself and even loses the few friends it still had because of different statements and objectives.

In contrast, the so-called final solution to the Jewish question seems to have been an entirely ideologically determined act, because Hitler and Goebbels repeatedly and apparently with all subjective conviction declared it a "service to humanity" to eliminate the "Jewish danger" or to "stab the Jewish ulcer." Indeed, the connection with anti-bolshevism is much easier to recognize than in the case of the living space policy, but on the other hand it is undeniable that National Socialist anti-semitism represented an extraordinary narrowing and intensification of anti-bolshevism and even more so of anti-Marxism, because it possessed far more the character of interpretation as that of experience. It therefore belongs only to the genus of anti-bolshevism only as a special species, and not even all National Socialists adopted it with equal determination. Nevertheless, it undoubtedly had a supranational appeal and can therefore be described as an ideology. But this subsumption also requires qualification, as will be shown later.

One can let the practical implementation of the *final solution* begin with the boycott campaign of April 1, 1933, and it is certainly worth considering whether the first anticipation of the genocide policy can be seen in the “Law for the Prevention of Hereditary Diseases” of July 14, 1933.

But although it cannot be denied that the physical extermination of the Jews is hinted at even in the very early statements of Hitler, the idea must not be derived from this that Hitler had been guided by a fixed plan since 1933 or even since 1923. He did not make Jewish policy alone although he was certainly the most important of all individual factors, and moreover, like all politics, it depended on many external circumstances. The efforts of individual authors to construct a unified “extermination process” in which the entire German bureaucracy was involved suffer from a lack of differentiation. It is rather appropriate to distinguish between different phases and moments which initially do not fulfill the concept of genocide and ultimately go beyond it by the method, intention and tendential completeness of the destruction.

The first phase lasted until 1941 and can be called the phase of discrimination. The main goal was to impose the characterization of the Jews as a *people* rather than a *denomination*. This tendency was not specifically National Socialist; it was also powerful among the Jews themselves and ultimately resulted from the Jewish self-image, which could not readily come to terms with the millennia-old community reduced to the status of a mere denomination within a religiously neutral state. In this respect, the Zionists were the most genuine Jews, and their desire for a Jewish state was by no means simply the result of a desire to be free of antisemitic hostility. The Zionists’ struggle against the “assimilationists” was therefore a struggle to assert the endangered distinctiveness, while the educated bourgeoisie generally affirmed the decline of the traditional ethnicity, but hoped to be able to imprint some basic features of the Jewish ethos on the modern world. Thus, as early as the second decade of the 20th century, the Zionist and the socialist or communist sons and daughters of the Jewish educated bourgeoisie were opposed to each other as extreme wings in harsh hostility, and Alfred Rosenberg in his 1921 work “The Anti-State Zionism” expressed the suspicion that it was a sophisticated interplay for the purpose of achieving Jewish world domination. In practice, however, the victorious National Socialism sided completely with the Zionists and through the Haavara Agreement of 1935 it promoted the Jewish *colonization* of Palestine more than any other state. Nevertheless, Adolf Eichmann’s later claim that the SS and the Zionists were “siblings” in their objectives was a gross distortion of the facts. For it was never a matter of *discrimination* in the neutral sense of the word, namely separation or divorce, but rather the negative discrimination of demotion and segregation. This was already

made clear by the Nuremberg Laws, which made sexual contact between Jews and Germans a criminal offense, while all other non-citizens were not subject to any specific restrictions in their relationships with Germans. Already in 1933 and 1935 there was a mental genocide comparable to that of Erich Koch in the Ukraine ante festum, admittedly with the serious difference that the basic emotion was not contempt but fear (of *infection* , *poisoning* or *decomposition*). The third factor was the deprivation of a materially privileged minority or, in National Socialist language, the motive of recovering the German national wealth that had been appropriated by parasites, and in this respect discrimination against Jews was the form of class struggle and class expropriation that was visible enough to satisfy old resentments, and limited enough so as not to provoke insurmountable resistance—hence the deficient mode of *expropriation of the bourgeoisie* , but the only one possible in *European* conditions. After the beginning of the war, the promotion of emigration to Palestine was briefly replaced by the plan to settle the Jews in Madagascar, but the development of circumstances soon made it unrealistic.

From the end of 1941, the second phase was the deportation of German Jews and then also Jews from many European countries *to the East* . The question is whether these deportations as such and from the outset were part of a process of extermination. Here too, distinctions are appropriate. The crucial preliminary question is whether the Jews could be characterized as a *belligerent* , i.e., unalterably hostile, group. For a considerable number of German Jews, at least until the pogrom of November 1938, this question must be decisively answered in the negative. By no means only the participants in the war, but they in particular, felt that they were German citizens despite the Nuremberg Laws, and as certainly as German Jews could not be expected to be followers and admirers of Adolf Hitler, they certainly wished no harm to Germany as their fatherland, and there is no evidence that any significant number of them actively supported the Allied cause. However, this statement cannot be the last or only word. Chaim Weizmann's statement from September 1939 about *the Jews* fighting on the side of the Allies has already been cited. In August 1941, a gathering of prominent Soviet Jews made an even more impassioned appeal to Jews around the world to support the just struggle of the Soviet Union and its allies. In 1961, an author like Raul Hilberg, who in his book about on "The Destruction of the European Jews" always emphasized the passivity and lack of resistance on the part of the Jews, formulated the sentence: "Throughout the Second World War, the Jews made the Allied cause to their own...and did their utmost to contribute to the achievement of the final victory." If one remembers that after December 7, 1941, the Americans transported their own citizens of Japanese origin, including women and children, into internment camps and that the British had a significant number of anti-fascist German emigrants transported to Canada as "enemy aliens" one cannot deny a priori that the

deportations as such were considered unavoidable in the eyes of the German population. In the autumn of 1941, there were still an astonishingly high number of over 70,000 Jews living in Berlin alone, and if one bears in mind that Stalin, in his speech of July 3, 1941, also included the "rumor-mongers" in his list of dangerous elements within the Soviet population, then one will certainly not be able to deny the justification of precautionary measures. But just as the phase of promoting emigration as a result of the Nuremberg Laws took on a character other than that of *Zionism*, the next phase, that of deportation, nevertheless had a completely different character, even for the mere spectator, than the American-Japanese or the English case. The Jews were identified by the "Jewish star," and this was a decidedly a *medieval method*. The Reich Propaganda Minister's article, which appeared on this occasion in the weekly newspaper *Das Reich* under the headline "The Jews Are To Blame," therefore took on an ominous resemblance to the "Hep-Hep" of the Jewish pogroms.

And what "the East" meant could not have been completely hidden from any German soldier or civilian working there. In any case, it meant "ghetto" and not merely by analogy of Theresienstadt in Bohemia, where a number of old and privileged Jews led a segregated but tolerable existence, as long as the camp was not used as a transit station for transports to Auschwitz. Although there appears to have been a plan for a short time to reserve a larger area near the Bug for a proper "Jewish state," it was soon abandoned, and the deported Jews had nowhere to go but to the terribly overpopulated, starving areas, typhus-ridden, walled-off ghettos of Warsaw or Łódź, which was now called Litzmannstadt, or to specially constructed concentration camps. There, what had been the starting point of Jewish destiny in modern times became the end point again: the "shtetl," from whose medieval confines hundreds of thousands of Jews had moved out to become Germans, Frenchmen, and Americans, or even Zionists in the *cultivated West*, and which now became their abode again as an all too modern concentration camp.

But where the German Wehrmacht directly encountered Soviet Jewry, with its still largely closed settlement areas, another distinction is in order, which is usually blurred by the term *final solution*. These are the actions of the "Einsatzgruppen" of the SS, which, as is well known, followed on the heels of the advancing armies in the Soviet Union and which "finished off" many hundreds of thousands of Jews, as their leaders used to express themselves in the *USSR event reports [also known as Einsatzgruppen Operational Situation Reports]*, moreover, reports which by no means exclusively or even predominantly contain the repeatedly quoted and cold-heartedly stated sentences about mass killings, but also news about shooting actions by the withdrawing NKVD as well as informative situation reports that often plead for better treatment of the Russian and Ukrainian populations. Here, too,

there is a preliminary question must be asked that is very often passed over in the literature. Not only the Einsatzgruppen themselves, but quite a few members of the Wehrmacht right up to the generals declared in reports that were not intended for the public the Jews to be the main protagonists of the partisan struggle, and therefore they wanted the *jewish actions* to be understood as reprisals. The well-known decrees of Field Marshals von Reichenau and von Manstein and similar official pronouncements are based on this premise and, in part, also reveal how vivid the memory of the time of the German civil war and the struggle between communists and National Socialists during the Weimar period still was. It would have been very strange indeed if many Jews had not obeyed Stalin's orders to become partisans. But what was characteristic of the operations of the Einsatzgruppen was that not only was the civil war proportion of 1:100 was often exceeded, but that the partisans or the extermination battalions of the Red Army were identified with *the Jews* without any further examination. Thus the premises of the bloodbath in the Babij Yar ravine near Kiev, in which 33,000 Jews fell victim, was a large fire and extensive explosions in the city, in which several hundred German soldiers were killed. But the originator had been an extermination battalion of the Soviet Army, and there was not the slightest probability that it would have consisted exclusively or even predominantly of Jews. In the literature, opinions about Jewish participation in the partisan struggle are divided: Western works emphasize the passivity of the Jews, who usually allowed themselves to be shot without resistance; communist literature, on the other hand, is full of reports of heroic activities—not least in the fight against Jewish "collaborators" and "traitors"—while German accounts emphasize sometimes the one, sometimes the other. In numerous cases, however, as is irrefutably clear from the *event reports*, there was no question of *reprisals* at all; instead, thousands and tens of thousands of Jews were rounded up and shot by SS men and sometimes also by local auxiliaries. The total number of victims of the Einsatzgruppen in the USSR is estimated by Gerald Reitlinger at over a million, by Raul Hilberg at 1.3 and by Krausnick-Wilhelm at 2.2 million. Especially when one considers the actions of the NKVD and realizes that Katyn was certainly just one case among others, one must and may come to the conclusion that the actions of the Einsatzgruppen were worse than those of the NKVD. The NKVD had sought to kill *the leading layer* of Poles who, in their eyes, were *counter-revolutionary*; But the Einsatzgruppen now did in a foreign country what was impossible to do in Germany: they tended to exterminate the mass of the population that was viewed as *revolutionary*. If the counter-revolutionaries consistently take the revolutionaries as their role models, they will have to commit far worse, because quantitatively more comprehensive acts. But the fact that communists and National Socialists did not simply embody the ideal types of revolution and counter-revolution here too became clear from the fact that in reality only a portion of even Soviet Jews belonged to the *revolutionary*, i.e. population loyal to Stalin, while conversely,

numerous Russians and Ukrainians also identified themselves with the Soviet state. On the other hand, Stalin also turned against entire *populations* such as the Volga Germans, whom he had deported, in Khrushchev’s words, “together with all communists and Komsomol members” because he saw them as potential helpers of the enemy. Here, too, there was an overshooting, a generalization, a collectivist attribution of guilt, but the number of Volga Germans was comparatively small and it was enough *just* to send them away. Therefore, the actions of the Einsatzgruppen are the most radical and comprehensive example of a preventive fight against *enemies* that goes far beyond all the concrete requirements of immediate warfare, and Nikolayevsk, like Katyn, had to appear as actions of a much far less horror. Above all, however, according to the intention of the originator and in the consciousness of the most important participants, these mass killings were inwardly closely connected to the last and final stage, the quasi-industrial mass killing in extermination camps such as Auschwitz-Birkenau, Treblinka and Belzec.

Now, of course, the factuality of this last and most extreme stage, the killing of around three million Jews, all of whom did not come from partisan areas of the Soviet Union, in the gas chambers of the extermination camps has been disputed by some authors, while the actions of the Einsatzgruppen has not yet been disputed by anyone. This literature by no means comes exclusively from Germans or *neo-fascists*. The evidence usually consists of doubting the authenticity of central documents such as the minutes of the *Wannsee Conference* of January 20, 1942, or of the authors pointing out the inconsistency of witness statements and the large differences between the figures given by the experts. It is not uncommon for it to be claimed that mass gassings of this magnitude was not technically possible with the means available. But even if in view of these arguments one were to withhold judgment and ignore the numerous other testimonies—including those of Eichmann, of the Auschwitz commandant Höss and of numerous inmates of the camps—the fact of the deaths of many hundreds of thousands remains, as does the further fact that a strikingly large proportion of these dead were Jews. There remain public statements such as Hitler’s repeated prophecies or statements about the “annihilation of the Jewish race in Europe” and Julius Streicher’s statement in a 1943 issue of “*Stürmer*” that Judaism was approaching its “extinction” with giant strides. And there are also numerous statements that Hitler made in conversations with foreign diplomats or in the midst of his round table, statements that at the same time bring to light the actual background of his *antisemitism*.

On February 17, 1942, at the Führer’s headquarters, Hitler said to his dinner guests, among whom was Heinrich Himmler: “The phenomenon of antiquity—the fall of the ancient world—was the mobilization of the mob under the slogan of Christianity, although this term

has so little to do with religion as Marxist socialism had to do with the solution of the social question...It took Christianity 1,400 years to develop into ultimate bestiality. We must not therefore say that Bolshevism has already been overcome. But the more thoroughly the Jews are thrown out, the faster the danger is eliminated. The Jew is the catalyst on which the fuel ignites. A nation that has no Jews is returned to the natural order...If the world were given over to the German professor for a few centuries, then after a million years there would be nothing but cretins walking around with us: giant heads on nothing of a body."

What Adolf Hitler actually meant by the word "Jew" is nothing other than what almost all thinkers of the 19th century called *progress* with a positive accent, that complex of growing domination of nature and alienation from nature, of industrialization and freedom of trade, of emancipation and individualism, which Nietzsche first and after him some philosophers of life such as Ludwig Klages and Theodor Lessing first declared to be a threat to *life*. For Hitler, this *life* is identical to the *natural order*, i.e. the simultaneously rural and warlike structure of society, which, in his opinion, still exists in a classic way in contemporary Japan, while in Europe it was endangered first by the peace utopia of Christianity and then by excessive industrialization with its symptoms of crisis and decomposition. Hitler therefore had in mind the same world-historical process that, for Marx, was both progress and decline, the process that could be called the intellectualization of the world. But despite some approaches, Marx and Nietzsche, Lessing and even Klages always remained far from claiming that there was a concrete, human cause for this process. Hitler, however, took this step, which was a radical reversal of all previous ideology, but which itself should no longer be called ideology in the original sense, because he attributed to a group of people the power to bring about a transcendental process. Nevertheless, the thesis was not merely nonsensical, because the Jews, as a "people of the book" and then as a group that seemingly was particularly encouraged by *emancipation* and in reality particularly deeply affected by it, actually had a prominent relationship to that *intellectualization*, but they were not cause, but manifestation. In this respect, it was not without consequence that Hitler, in his defense of war as an indispensable part of the *natural order*, directed the genocidal tendencies of modern war primarily against the Jews. But a genocide carried out with this intention is no longer a mere genocide. How much the reversal of the philosophy of history, the defense of the *natural order* and the revolutionary experience of 1918 went hand in hand for Hitler becomes irrefutably clear if a sentence that he said to the Croatian Marshal Kwaternik on July 22, 1941 is added: "If even one state for whatever reason tolerated a Jewish family with itself, it would become the bacillus hearth for a new decomposition." He did mention Madagascar and Siberia as possible residences for European Jews. But Madagascar was already closed to him, and Siberia would soon to be equally closed to him. If he had brought

Jews from Germany and the rest of Europe to Poland to live in ghettos there, he would have been nothing more than a talker. At the time of his conversation with Kwaternik, he already had German mental patients killed by gas, and it is quite possible that this method seemed particularly "humane" to him. Whoever takes Hitler seriously cannot deny the extermination actions at Auschwitz and Treblinka or the gas chambers. Nor can he equate Auschwitz and Treblinka, Belzec and Sobibor with the extermination measures that the Croatian Ustasha implemented against the Pravo-Slavic population of their state. *Auschwitz* was in an even deeper sense an *overshoot* than the anti-partisan fight aimed at total security and therefore preventative, and that the biological planning socialism of "eradication of everything harmful and unhealthy" to which so many gypsies fell victim and which was also directed against *the Slavs*. The *final solution* is unique in a sense that is not merely trivial. But it is not therefore incomparable, because the right to call it unique only arises from the most comprehensive comparison possible, and the great hiatus of incomprehensibility may only be set at a point that comes into view after a long path of struggle for understanding.

But it cannot be denied that this transcendental extermination took place in the greatest secrecy. Whoever, like Hilberg, holds the opinion or tries to suggest that all members of the SS Economic and Administrative Office or even all the railwaymen who dispatched trains to Auschwitz must have known about the gas chambers should consequently deny that the "Order No. 1," that no one should know more than is absolutely necessary for the execution of their immediate tasks, separated people from one another even more than the division of labor in modern society does anyway, and that a hundred specialists can build armored cars while thousands of other specialists believe that they produced individual parts for caterpillar tractors. Hilberg himself reports that Mrs. Schirach witnessed a nighttime roundup of Jews in Amsterdam and was so upset that she reported it to her husband. He advised her to draw the Führer's attention to such "abuses" on her next visit to headquarters. But Hitler only listened to her "ungraciously" and after an "exchange of words" the Schirach couple left the room. And the most famous of the German tank generals next to Rommel, Guderian, said in March 1945 with obvious sincerity to representatives of the press that he had fought in the East for a long time, but that he had never noticed anything about the "devil's ovens, gas chambers and similar products of a morbid imagination," with which an order from Marshal Zhukov tried to incite the "feelings of hatred of the primitive Soviet soldiers."

The *final solution* is without a doubt the most extreme and characteristic of all deeds of National Socialism, but its concealment is just as essential to it as the reversal of the traditional philosophy of history, which even Hitler was never dared to present publicly. As a tendency to be the complete annihilation of a *world-people*, it differs significantly from all

genocides and is the exact antithesis of the tendency to complete annihilation of a world-class through Bolshevism, and in this respect it is the biologically transformed copy of the social original. But for that very reason it is not just *biological* destruction, but it means a decision with regard to the historical process as a whole, a decision *against progress* but on the basis of progressive realities, while Bolshevism was a decision *for progress* but in close connection with retarded realities. Nevertheless, the *final solution* is not the only perspective in which the relationship between National Socialism and Bolshevism may be seen. Bolshevism and National Socialism were always opposites, and they remained so until the end, but at no point were they opposed to each other in a contradictory way, and the closer the war came to its end, the more clearly a “change of characteristics” became apparent.

Chapter V, Section 5

The Change of Characteristics and the Paradoxical Victory of the Soviet Union

The term “change of characteristics” should not be understood to mean that Bolshevism took on the form of its opponent in the course of the war and conversely National Socialism took on that of Bolshevism. However, in both regimes developments and tendencies could be observed that were aimed at an internal rapprochement with the enemy. However, this did not weaken the enmity, but rather strengthened it, and even if one draws the lines into an ideal type, no identity emerges.

That Bolshevism was in the process of “nationalizing” or “state-controlling” itself was soon claimed or feared by enemies and friends alike: émigrés and unorthodox communists already agreed during the early 1920s that Bolshevism had become the champion of the traditional interests of the Russian state. The continued existence of a cadre army with a professional corps of commanders could be cited as proof, and even the term *people’s commissars* quickly lost the original meaning that these were positions for a short transitional period that were only intended to “close the store up,” as Trotsky might have expressed it regarding the entire bureaucratic apparatus. Stalin’s concept of *socialism in one country* was the next big step, and it provoked fierce opposition from a significant section of the old party guard. Of course, it did not fulfill the hopes of the émigrés at all; a reconciliation between the new and the old Russia did not come about and was not sought by the ruling party: officers returning home were arrested by the NKVD or immediately shot, and the strongest social force that could have formed the basis for reconciliation was destroyed as a class, namely the farmers, by depriving them of their independence. Not even the foreign technicians, who played such an important role in the country’s increasing industrialization, were safe from persecution. The party and its Marxist terminology still reigned supreme, and the strange mutability of the ideological language did not change this, with which the traditional postulate of the greatest

possible equality possible was combated as “petty-bourgeois egalitarianism,” because the differentiation of wages and activities was recognized as an indispensable precondition for further industrialization. But was it still a pragmatic adaptation to changed circumstances when Stalin gave the signal for the persecution and extinction of Pokrovsky’s historical school with two essays in 1934? After all, Pokrovsky had been the most important representative of that genuinely Marxist way of thinking in historiography, which attacked all *ruling classes* and especially the ruling class of old Russia with as much bitterness as contempt and knew not to report enough of despotic tsars, exploitative landowners and cruel generals on the one hand and the exploited and abused masses of the people on the other. But now Stalin and soon numerous historians in his entourage pointed out that the history of the Russian Empire was by no means just a series of atrocities, but rather that a tremendous historical progress had been made, whose helpers, indeed pioneers, were often enough been the Tsars and their collaborators. A new and much brighter picture of Ivan the Terrible was now painted, and even Nicholas I’s regime could no longer be characterized exclusively as “bloody police terror.” In particular, the Tsars’ conquests were now viewed in a much more positive light, and the expansion of the Moscow’s heartland in all directions, which Karl Marx had seen as the most dangerous threat to Europe, was regarded as a paradigm of progress in history. In the Red Army’s new oath of allegiance from 1936, there was no longer any mention of an obligation *to the world proletariat*. *Marshals of the Soviet Union* had been at the head of the Red Army since 1935. The Great Purge significantly weakened the international character of the corps of commanders, and it was mainly young Russians and Ukrainians who rose to the top positions that became vacant. In June 1940, the ranks of general and admiral, which had until then been considered *bourgeois* or *tsarist*, were reintroduced, and the same year saw the decree classifying soldiers and commanders into two separate rations classes.

Nevertheless, the outbreak of war led to a qualitative change. In his speech on November 6, 1941, Stalin accused the German fascists, “who are devoid of conscience and honor,” primarily because they called for “the destruction of the great Russian (!) nation,” “the nation of Plekhanov and Lenin, Belinsky and Chernyshevsky, Pushkin and Tolstoy, Glinka and Tchaikovsky...Suvorov and Kutuzov.” In essence, this meant at least the spiritual reconciliation and unification of the old and the new Russia: the feudal generals, the bourgeois artists and the progressive and Marxist intelligentsia. Indeed, a number of voices could be heard among the émigrés, from Kerensky to Milyukov, advocating for the defense of Russia against the German attack. So it was more than just a name change when some rifle divisions were renamed Guard divisions in September 1941 and when entire Guard armies were formed over the next few years. In May 1942, the Order of the Patriotic War was

established in two grades, and the Order of Suvorov was in turn awarded in three classes, the highest of which was intended “for generals and commanders who succeed in destroying the superior forces of the enemy in an attack.” While in Germany even the highest levels of the Knight’s Cross was awarded to ordinary officers, the Soviet Union’s highest decorations remained reserved for generals, and Wassow complained in German captivity about the *egalitarianism of the Germans*, while a Soviet general traveling in Great Britain in 1914 expressed his surprise that ordinary soldiers were allowed to sit in the same railway compartment as officers. It was therefore once again not a mere outward change in terminology when the commander corps was referred to as *the officer corps* for the first time in January 1943. The reintroduction of the broad shoulder boards of the Tsar’s army confirmed and promoted the development which implied a pronounced class separation between officers and men, although the simplest soldier still addressed the highest officer as “Comrade General.” In Stalin’s study now hung the portraits of Suvorov and Kutuzov, the tsarist generals who had fought and won against Napoleon. He himself assumed the highest military rank and was soon referred to by the Western Allies as “Marshal Stalin.”

The extraordinary esteem which Stalin gave to *the cadres* was probably also reflected in the statement he made in Tehran, provoking Churchill to contradict him: the entire strength of Hitler’s enormous armies consisted of around 50,000 officers, technicians and specialists; if they were shot, the German danger would have been eliminated from the world for an indefinite period of time. From this it was very easy to infer the opinion that the strength of the Soviet Union did not rest primarily on the millions of *working people* and ordinary soldiers, but on the leading layer of the senior officer corps and armaments specialists.

But national traditions were not only fully honored again in the army. In 1943, the Orthodox Church was also accepted as an ally: since the beginning of the war, the leaders of the church had been praying for the victory of the socialist fatherland, and now numerous churches were returned to worship, seminars for theological training were reopened, the newspapers and magazines of the *Godless [also known as League of Militant Atheists]* were reduced or discontinued due to a “lack of paper.” In September 1943, Stalin officially received the head of the Church, Metropolitan Sergei, in the Kremlin, and a short time later he was ceremoniously crowned Patriarch of the Russian Church in the Moscow Cathedral, after the office had been vacant for almost 20 years.

In the same year Stalin took the astonishing step of dissolving the *Comintern*. Two decades earlier, the opinion had been widespread in the Soviet Union and Europe that the Comintern was the headquarters of the world revolution and that the government in Moscow was merely

one of its branches that had first won political power. Now it came to an inglorious end, long after no one had doubted that it had become a mere agency of the Soviet government. Now it no longer fit into the political line, and Stalin justified the dissolution to the Reuter press agency with the argument that it would expose the Hitlerite lie that “Moscow” intended to interfere in the lives of other states and to “bolshevize” them; precisely this dissolution would promote the work of the “patriots of all countries” to come together to form a “unified national freedom camp” regardless of party affiliation and religious beliefs. The *Comintern* thus became a victim of the *popular front policy*, which it had itself inaugurated in 1935 and which, in Stalin’s opinion, was now of fundamental importance for the “struggle against the danger of world domination by Hitlerite fascism.”

However, even now Stalin did not forego a supranational appeal. But this was no longer aimed at the proletariat of the world, but at the Slavic peoples. The announcement on the occupation of eastern Poland had already spoken of *kinship*, and now a “Panslavist Committee” was founded in Moscow, large posters calling for the unity of the Slavic peoples were carried in the usual parades, and Stalin said in a conversation with Milovan Djilas: “If the Slavs stay together and maintain solidarity, no one will be able to lift a finger in the future. Not one finger.” He made a similar statement to de Gaulle in December 1944: “The tsars pursued a bad policy. They wanted to dominate the other Slavic peoples. We have a new policy. The Slavs should be independent and free everywhere.”

De Gaulle also gave a very vivid description of the banquet held in his honor in the Kremlin. He and his companions walked up a monumental staircase, the walls of which were decorated with the same pictures as in the Tsarist times, to the banquet hall where Soviet ministers, diplomats and generals, “all in shimmering uniforms,” had gathered to enjoy an “unbelievably sumptuous meal” where the tables sparkled “in unimaginable splendor.” After dinner and international toasts, Stalin rose thirty times to drink to his closest associates and senior officers. He mixed praise and threats, and for de Gaulle it was a foregone conclusion that the person being called would freeze in fear if he was addressed as follows: “You have to use our aircraft. If you do it badly, you know what will happen to you.” At no time in his life could Hitler have treated his field marshals in the manner of an oriental despot. Numerous other reports—such as those by Djilas, by Svetlana Alliluyeva and Khrushchev—leave not the slightest doubt that the “first workers’ state in the world” had become, at least during the last years of the war, a glamorous and triumphant group of highly decorated dignitaries who obeyed the word of an absolute ruler.

The obvious objection is that all of this was a matter of externals and tactical means that

could be disposed by the ruling party at any time if they seriously jeopardized the unchanged goals and established concepts. With regard to the “Panslavist Committee” the correctness of the argument is obvious, and Stalin’s autocracy was bound to come to an end in the foreseeable future. The Orthodox Church had become a docile instrument, the loyalty of the communist parties all over the world was beyond question, and it therefore must have seemed that the Comintern could be brought back into being at any time. But even if one assumed that Stalin still only lived in three small rooms, that the generals were just waiting to be able to take off their epaulettes and medals in order to become unrecognizable in the classless world society, and that Zhdanov had already written the appeal in which he wanted to call the proletariat of the world to revolt against the capitalists, there was no getting around the fact that the Soviet Union had the help of all those traditions, forces and tendencies in the years from 1941 to 1945 and in to a great extent before had had to appeal to the help of all those traditions, forces, and tendencies on which the enemy had relied on from the very beginning. It had had to present itself as a state-socialist or national-socialist country because it wanted to survive, and there was enough reason to suspect that it actually was such a country and that it could not simply return to its beginnings, even if it wanted to. The suspicion became a certainty for those who saw pictures of the boys of the page corps, who, in uniforms that showed nothing of their youthfulness, lined up among the pictures of generals and marshals, carefully following the instructions of a massive officer. And nothing sounded less like hypocrisy or tactical instrumentality than the words Stalin said to Djilas during the war: “Above all, there was something abnormal, unnatural about the very existence of a general communist dream at a time when the communist parties should have been striving for a national language and fighting under the condition prevailing in their countries.” In Stalin’s opinion, Lenin was obviously mistaken when he believed in 1917 that the *era of world proletarian revolution* was imminent.

Does this insight lead to the conclusion that National Socialism achieved internal victory when it suffered one defeat after another on the battlefield? This conclusion would only be compelling if National Socialism had actually been national or state socialism. Compound words give a clear meaning only when the accent is really on the noun and the added adjective merely expresses an additional, although essential, definition. But National Socialism was never primarily socialism, i.e. a movement primarily determined by the motives of an internal class conflict, but rather a social nationalism of the fascist type, in its most radical manifestation. Even in its final form, it remained in the footsteps of its beginnings, which had brought a political-revolutionary popular movement into a precarious symbiosis with established ruling classes. But precisely because of this it had tendencies within that pointed to a new type. They would have been completed if it had no longer seen

Bolshevism as an image of horror, but primarily as a role model. In the last years of the war, National Socialism took decisive steps in this path, but without bringing it to a conclusion other than in hypothetical considerations.

Bolshevism and communism had certainly been a model for the National Socialists from the beginning, but primarily only with regard to the methods of fighting, i.e. above all propaganda. However, methods and content could hardly be clearly separated when Goebbels noted in his diary in March 1942 that the Führer had a great deal of respect for Russian warfare: "Stalin's brutal crackdown saved the Russian front. We must use similar methods in our warfare in order to be able to hold out own against them. We have sometimes lacked this toughness and we have to try to replace it." Less than a year later, a behavior that had been regarded as proof of blind fanaticism and uncultured bestiality at the beginning of the war had become a model, namely the collective suicide of soldiers who saw themselves in a hopeless situation. Hitler's verdict was unmistakable when he received the news of Field Marshal Paulus' surrender on February 1, 1943. "They surrendered absolutely true to form," he said. "Because in the other case, you get together, form a hedgehog and shoot yourself dead with the last bullet. If you imagine that a woman has the pride to go out, lock herself up and immediately shoots herself because she only hears a few insulting words then I have no respect for a soldier who shrinks away from it and would rather go into captivity." With these words, Hitler equated very different facts and thus brought the war back to primitive conditions which "European civilization" he so often referred had wanted to overcome. A little later he also presented Stalin and Bolshevism as a model for the internal structure of the regime. In a Reich and Gauleiter meeting at the beginning of May 1943, he first praised Stalin's purge of the Red Army, which had eliminated all defeatist tendencies and considerably strengthened its fighting strength, in contrast to the expectations that he initially had himself. Then he continued: "Stalin also has the advantage over us of not having any social opposition. Bolshevism has also eliminated this through liquidation in the last 25 years... Bolshevism got rid of this danger in time and can therefore direct all its strength against the enemy. Internally there is practically no more opposition within the country." In doing so, Hitler was, as it were, wiping out the foundation of his system. Had he and his followers not derived their strongest and most enduring emotions from the "annihilation of the national intelligentsia" that had taken place in Russia and seemed to be threatened for Germany? What else had been the basis of his successes up to 1941 than the intact army and the functioning administration that had come to him from the Weimar Republic and ultimately from the Empire? If the "social opposition" was the fundamental evil, i.e. the entirety of the circles whose sympathy and approval he had tried to gain throughout his life, what then became of his accusations against "Jews and Bolsheviks"? Was the difference

between his regime and that of the Bolsheviks then only that one of the civil war parties, namely the Freikorps, would have prevailed in Germany just as completely as the enemy party in Russia, “liquidating” all opponents and all lukewarm people? In fact, Hitler and his closest followers tended more and more beyond radical fascism to a regime that would be just as radical internally towards the still largely preserved social structure as Bolshevism and that would thereby also create the possibility of pursuing its foreign policy goals with revolutionary ruthlessness. There is no name for such a regime because Hitler was only able to realize it in rudimentary form. The term “National Bolshevism” is unsuitable as a label, because it always had an alliance between Germany and the Soviet Union as its primary goal. Furthermore, “nationalism” must remain the noun, because although Hitler expanded the term to include the *Aryan race*, he never became confused about it. For lack of a better term, one could speak of Bolshevik Nationalism, i.e. of a nationalist or racial biological system which, in contrast to the existing social differentiations, moves just as radically toward *liquidation* and strives just as resolutely for ideological and social homogeneity as Bolshevism had done, although certainly a homogeneity which from the outset requires a strict hierarchy and unconditional discipline. Undoubtedly, remarkable steps towards this kind of egalitarianism were taken in Germany. The relationship between men and officers in the Waffen-SS was much more comradely and informal than the corresponding relationship in the Wehrmacht. But the soldiers of the Wehrmacht also received the same rations, from simple soldiers to field marshals, and this fulfilled the postulate that was one of the most important prerequisites for the revolution of 1918. It was not unbelievable when, in view of the work of the prisoners of war, it was said that the entrepreneurs today were representatives of the German people—a sentence that corresponded to a demand of Karl Marx, who, however, had not spoken of the “people” but of the “workers.” Goebbels’ speech on February 18, 1943, with its call for total war, had elicited such a great response mainly because it seemed to announce the abolition of all “privileges,” and the same was true of Hitler’s speech on April 26, 1942, which, according to a situation report from the SD, had met with enthusiastic applause, especially in “inferior circles” and in “worker circles,” because of its violent attacks against the judiciary and the civil servants. Hitler’s and Himmler’s main demand, however, was “fanaticism,” and the political commissar of the Red Army gradually became the model for this. Hitler now publicly and privately attacked the “lazy, decadent upper classes” or this “vermin of bourgeoisie,” and Himmler explicitly declared it an advantage “of the Russian” that he had “an army that was politicized down to the last coolie, that is, an army imbued and led by ideology.” This is how the *National Socialist Leadership Officer* was created, and although it certainly did not receive the position that the political commissars in the Red Army had had until the office was finally abolished in October 1942, Hitler evidently saw him as the most important factor in the “completely closed worldview

body” into which the people and the Wehrmacht would have to merge. He therefore viewed “intellectuals, scientists” as useless for this position, even as “completely worthless and harmful.” Hitler’s personal esteem for Stalin (which was matched on Stalin’s side by a similar but differently justified high regard for Hitler) was combined with admiration for the power of worldview: this was the only way to explain that the Russians were the “only really great opponents of Germany,” because Russia has a worldview and at its head is an undoubtedly important man, he said to Antonescu in January 1943.

Stauffenberg’s assassination attempt on July 20, 1944 and the discovery of the widespread conspiracy that had been its premise and, despite the accidental failure in the Wolf’s Lair, had nevertheless led to serious consequences at individual points (such as in Paris), now unleashed a flood of measures and invectives, which affected not least the bearers of the most famous names in German and Prussian history: Moltke and Kleist, Yorck von Wartenburg and Tresckow, von der Schulenburg and Schwerin, and furthermore those social forces that had survived as such or in leading representatives under the cover of the political-totalitarian regime: the high bureaucracy and the churches, the trade unions and the parties. After all, Stalin had had the marshals, commanders and generals who had made themselves suspicious in his eyes shot; Adolf Hitler had Field Marshal von Witzleben and the generals von Hase, Stieff and Hoener hanged. And he was not content with punishing the guilty. Rather, he had family imprisonment introduced and thus initiated the destruction of an entire class. In his speech at the Gauleiter meeting in Posen on August 3, 1944, Himmler was able to say: “The Count Stauffenberg family will be wiped out down to the last member.” Although Stalin had allowed several members of Tukhachevsky’s family to die in the camps, he had never accomplished such an *extermination* and had certainly not called for it in a speech. So Himmler felt compelled to defend himself before the Gauleiters against the accusation that such a procedure was Bolshevik: “No, don’t take offense, it’s not Bolshevik at all, it’s very old and was common practice among our ancestors.” But he did not draw the obvious conclusion that Bolshevism was the first to resort to archaic behavior and that National Socialism was now copying Bolshevism. And he did not dare draw the obvious conclusion when he claimed that Germany had triumphed in the West because it had been “revolutionary” towards these bourgeois states. Did Bolshevism achieve victory over Germany because it was the more revolutionary movement than National Socialism? In any case, Robert Ley’s view could be extended to this, who in a speech on July 22 raged against the “blue-blooded pigs” and demanded, to great applause, “that the revolution make up for everything it has failed to do.” The thesis of Vlasov and his German friends that Russia could only be defeated by Russia had been disregarded; did they now have to come to the conclusion that Bolshevism could only be defeated by Bolshevism?

When Hitler held the last conversations with Bormann and Goebbels in February and March 1945, which were later published under the title “Hitler’s Political Testament,” he practiced serious self-criticism for the first time in his life, and it actually amounted to the formation of one term such as “Bolsho-nationalism.” German policy was largely made by generals and diplomats who were “men of yesterday” and “reactionary philistines.” The task would have been to liberate the French workers and mercilessly sweep away a “calcified bourgeoisie, these heartless and unpatriotic fellows.” Germany should also have been willing to call on the Islamic peoples to revolt and liberate them. However, Hitler forgot that proposals of this kind had been made and that he himself had always rejected them because he wanted to show consideration for Mussolini and Petain. And had he not also taken Marshal Antonescu’s side against the “Iron Guard”?

As much as Hitler sought to sketch out the outlines of a more radical and revolutionary path, at least in retrospect, he could not conceal in his last intimate statements and public pronouncements that his strongest emotions remained unchanged and continued to be directed against Judaism as the great power of dissolution of the “natural order” and against Bolshevism as a plague and a monstrosity.

Therefore, he still considered it a credit to humanity for having “lanced the Jewish boil,” because this war, more than any previous one, was an “exclusively Jewish war.” When news reached him after the Anglo-American invasion in 1944 that “Soviets” had been declared in southern France, he said that this communist wave would spread throughout the French territory and that the English and American troops would eventually be infected by it; something similar had happened in Arkhangelsk at the end of the last war, and today the whole of France is inhabited by a completely undisciplined and Bolshevik population. But how vivid and authoritative the memory of the end of the war in 1918 and the Russian Civil War remained was demonstrated in the most astonishing way in that briefing on February 1, 1943. At that time he had predicted that the officers captured in Stalingrad would soon appear as propagandists on Russian radio, and he had given the following reason for this: “You have to imagine: he comes into Moscow, and imagine the ‘rat cage’! Then he signs everything. He will make confessions, make appeals.” The past of the Russian Civil War, which had now become a mere memory for almost everyone else, had not passed for Hitler, and he still perceived that Bolshevism, which stood before his eyes in the form of Stalin’s National Socialist state as an admired role model, as the horror of decay and incomprehensible atrocities that so many people in Germany had seen in 1920.

No idea was more obvious than the fact that only a few of his followers were prepared to

seriously take Bolshevism as a model, but that no one united the opposing sentiments as much as he himself did and that in this respect he was completely alone. But Hitler was not therefore wrong, and at the end of February 1945 he cited a cause for his failure that he had never mentioned before: no longer the “betrayal” of the old officers and the resistance of the “reaction,” nor the social system that had prevented a truly *total* war until the very end, but the German people as such, which was unstable and susceptible to influence more than any, and which had lapsed from one extreme to the other in its past.

This was the first paradox of the Soviet Union’s victory over Germany: in 1917, Maxim Gorky had accused Lenin and Trotsky of seeing the Russian people only as material for their plans for world liberation; Adolf Hitler, on the other hand, had solemnly promised shortly afterwards to serve the German fatherland and only the German fatherland. Now Hitler rejected the German people as bad material, and Stalin praised the Russian people, whose will to assert themselves against Hitler’s and Rosenberg’s plans he had ultimately embodied.

The second paradox is to be seen in the fact that victory was only possible with the help of the oldest enemy, the main Anglo-Saxon powers of capitalism, which only made a significant direct military contribution in the final phase, but nevertheless tipped the scales through their air raids and through the huge deliveries of war material.

The third paradox lay in the fact that Stalin was able to put into his service all those forces and sympathies in his own country and in the countries of the Allies that Lenin had sought to destroy completely and which would have been represented far more genuinely by Vlasov, that he in other words, put his regime on the path of state or national socialism in the time of greatest need, while Hitler was only able to take a few steps on the opposite path to greater social radicalism because it was postulated that mass of *bolsho-nationalist* fanatics did not exist in Germany and could not exist after five years of war.

Thus the German-Soviet War was the most important and decisive part of the Second World War, but as a war of Bolshevism and National Socialism it is inadequately and incorrectly understood if one ignores the changes to which both parties and both regimes were subject. But one final statement must be put in the form of a question because it is connected to the most puzzling of all Hitler’s decisions.

Certainly, the Soviet Army had won new victories since the summer of 1943, the greatest of which was the destruction of Army Group Center in June/July 1944. But in December 1944 the German armies were still on the Vistula, and in East Prussia the Soviet divisions had

succeeded only in making a temporary breach, but this had caused stunned horror among the East German population because it seemed to prove that the Russians were indeed waging a campaign of extermination and revenge against all Germans as such. The starting point for a new attack would undoubtedly be the Baranow bridgehead south of Warsaw. At the same time, the Americans and English had advanced to the western border of the Reich. Then Hitler gathered his last reserves and unleashed his final offensive, not against the Soviet bridgehead, but against the Allied positions in Belgium. The Ardennes offensive, which ultimately targeted Antwerp as the major supply port, was initially such a success that Hitler was able to tell his generals that Germany would undoubtedly deal with each of the three war opponents in no time. But Eisenhower was able to overcome the setbacks quickly, and when at the request of Churchill and Roosevelt the Soviet offensive broke out on January 12, Hitler had no reserves left to throw at it and the Soviet troops made their way to Berlin about as short a time as it took the German armies to get from the border to Moscow in 1941. And what the Japanese had not done in 1941, the Americans and British were now doing: they were advancing on the enemy capital from the other side. There is some evidence to suggest that Hitler launched the Ardennes offensive because he hoped to make the Western Allies willing to make peace. In fact, almost up to the day of Hitler's suicide and the conquest of Berlin, Stalin believed that an agreement between Germany and the USA or England that was directed against himself was possible. In these final weeks of the war, Himmler clearly proved to be the Westerner he had always been at heart. Goebbels, on the other hand, seemed to be seeking an agreement with the Soviet Union. It is therefore not clear what Hitler wanted to achieve with his final decisions and thoughts. Undoubtedly, Germany would have been divided into occupation zones even if Hitler had decided on a Baranov offensive instead of the Ardennes offensive. There is no likelihood that the Americans, who believed they needed Soviet help against Japan, would have given in to Churchill's wishes after the occupation of all of Germany and violated the 1944 agreement on the division of the occupation zones. But the East German population would have been spared the terrible fate that befell them not only as a result of the actions of the Red Army and the Allied extermination attacks on Dresden, but also as a result of the errors and omissions of the German party authorities. Hitler, however, said to his armaments minister Albert Speer when he tried to get him to withdraw the destruction order, which corresponded exactly to Stalin's order of 1941 except that there were no rooms where anything could be transported: "If the war is lost, the people will also be lost. It is not necessary to take into account the foundations that the German people need for their most primitive survival...Because the people have proven to be the weaker, and the future belongs exclusively to the stronger Eastern people." This statement fits in well with similar statements, including the one just quoted, and it at least indicates that for Adolf Hitler, at the end of his life, the former image of terror had completely become a—now

unattainable—role model, albeit within the framework of a nationalistic worldview that cannot be really called an ideology. Nevertheless, he had undoubtedly not stopped hating Bolshevism. But that was only one paradox among many paradoxes, and one contradiction among many contradictions. Paradoxes and contradictions filled the era, but they were more concentrated in Hitler and his National Socialism than in any other figure or phenomenon of the 20th century.

Conclusion

Conclusionary Reflection: From the European Civil War 1917-1945 to the World Civil War 1947-1990

The last battles of the European Civil War were fought in April and May 1945, but no one saw them as anything other than the desperate resistance of the defeated Wehrmacht, whose only goal was to bring as large a part of the population as possible of East Germany to the relative safety of the “West” before the invading armies of the Soviet Union. The “democratic world coalition” celebrated its victory when Field Marshal Keitel and Admiral von Friedeburg signed the surrender document on May 8 and all of Germany was occupied by the troops of the victorious powers. “Fascism” was frequently mentioned as the defeated power, but party affiliations hardly mattered anymore: the population of the German territories east of the Oder and Neisse rivers was expelled as such and as a whole, and no distinction was made between “Nazis” and “non-Nazis”; the same applied with slight modifications to the Sudeten regions. The leaders of the Third Reich—to the extent that they were caught—were for the most part sentenced to death and executed at Nuremberg as war criminals and for “crimes against humanity,” the SS was declared a “criminal organization,” and the NSDAP had already been dissolved; it was taken for granted that National Socialism had lost its power with the complete collapse of Germany and that only its “remnants” remained to be eliminated.

But already in the autumn of 1945, Vacheslav Molotov spoke of the necessity of eradicating the “roots of fascism,” and this turn of phrase made it unmistakably obvious to the connoisseurs of Soviet Marxist ideology that there was by no means—as Franklin D. Roosevelt seemed to think before his death—just the “family” of victors, a democratic power of the East and the two democratic powers of the West, to be distinguished, but that only now, after the interlude of the unexpected phenomenon of fascism, the two world-historical forces, whose final struggle on the Rhine Lenin and Radek had predicted in 1919 as the immediate future, namely “Socialism” on the one hand and “Capitalism” on the other, faced each other

directly,. How had the Soviet system ever see itself as anything other than anti-capitalist, and what so abhorrent to the Americans as the state planned economy, which turned the entrepreneur into a functionary and prevented the free play of market forces?

But the legacy of the Fascist epoch prevented the immediate revival of the traditional opposition, because the Soviet Union had been calling itself as “anti-fascist” in its most important proclamations since 1935, and the Labor Party in England, which came into power in the summer of 1945, and the coalition of parties that governed France under the leadership of General de Gaulle were also anti-fascist. Stalin, in turn, must have had a great interest in continuing to receive material aid from the United States for the Soviet Union, which had been badly smashed, but, however, was overwhelmingly strong in terms of conventional forces. Certainly, an anti-fascist world order of the Eastern and Western democracies would also have included considerable differences in power, and a good part of the friction of the post-war period can be understood from the conflicting powers in the struggle for relative power vacuums: Poland’s internal structure and foreign policy orientation, the peace agreement with Italy and Germany’s other allies, about the status of West Berlin—even the Berlin blockade can be partly explained from this, because even if the Patriarch of the Orthodox Church had ruled in the Kremlin and if a Quaker had been president in Washington, there still would have been many disputes about the American enclave in the middle of the Russian occupation territory.

But very soon after May 1945, dissonances in the anti-fascist harmony had also appeared on the Western side—initially in a rudimentary and half-hidden manner—which resulted from a deeper cause than the mere difference of power interests. As early as the summer of 1945 there were statements and reactions from Anglo-Saxon generals and diplomats that revealed a deep alienation, even hostility, towards the Soviet war ally and there were who even called for a concentration of all forces, including the Germans in the Western zones, for the purpose of self-assertion against the “barbaric” and ideologically hostile Soviet Union. On the other hand, the communist movement outside the Soviet Union did not always follow Stalin’s advice, despite Stalin’s immense prestige: Tito’s partisans behaved much more radically than Stalin thought desirable, and the Greek communists initiated a civil war. But even where Stalin’s will reigned supreme, developments took place that received a great deal of negative attention in the West, not least the “forced union” of the Social Democratic Party with the Communist Party in the Soviet occupation zone of Germany, which was a characteristic example of the communist seizures of power and was imitated a little later in Czechoslovakia and in the other countries of East Central Europe. Churchill made explicit reference to them in his Fulton speech of March 5, 1946, the same Churchill, who in 1919 as British Secretary of

War had been one of the most outspoken of all anti-Communists, and who, although no longer Prime Minister of Great Britain, was still a very influential man. And among the audience was Harry S. Truman, Roosevelt's successor as President of the United States. Stalin reacted sharply, but already in a February 18 speech he had made announcements that could be understood to mean that the Soviet Union was now entering the second phase of confrontation with the secular enemy.

The proclamation of the "Truman Doctrine" by the American President in March 1947 marked the transition to an ideological world conflict, although the immediate cause was only the material support of the anti-communist government in Greece: two ways of life were in a comprehensive conflict all over the world —one based on the will of the majority and characterized by a representative system, free elections, guarantees of individual freedom and the absence of political oppression; the other way of life was based on the terror of a minority, unfree elections and the suppression of personal freedoms. In doing so, the President relied less on the theory of totalitarianism, which had not yet been fully developed, than the experience of totalitarianism that numerous refugees from the Soviet sphere of influence were already able to report on. If Lenin had confronted the world systems of capitalism and socialism, and if Hitler had contrasted his National Socialism as a principle of racial health embodied by Germany with the destructive principles of bolshevik and capitalist universalism, then for Truman the global conflict was now taking place between the freedom of the Western constitutional state and the terrorist oppression of communist totalitarianism.

The new conflict had thus also found the ideological articulation from the American side, without which it would have remained a mere power struggle between large states. The long history of this "Cold War," which was often trivialized as the "East-West Conflict," cannot be sketched here even in the briefest outline; only a few observations will be made, which compare this Cold War, which was in truth a world civil war with many changes, reversals, escalations and relaxations, with the European civil war from 1917-1945.

The challenge, the proclamation of something new, came from the idea of socialism and the revolutionary realization of this idea from 1947, indeed to a certain extent from 1945 as well as from 1917. But the idea had been considerably weakened, not least by the memory of the Hitler-Stalin pact, and former supporters had become opponents in no small numbers. On the other hand, the power base was no longer just Soviet Russia, and outside of it, a strong communist movement strong in Germany alone, but additionally all Eastern Europe occupied by Soviet troops, including the eastern part of Germany, and furthermore the powerful communist parties of France and Italy; in 1948/49 it was also became evident in China that

communism was an autonomous force, and Mao Tse-tung's victory over Chiang Kai-shek in the civil war created a power structure of overwhelming size, which in the West was soon called the "Soviet-Chinese bloc." Although cracks appeared early on, such as with Tito's defection in 1948, on the other hand, communist or socialist parties that sympathized with this bloc gained strength in many parts of the world. The feeling of being threatened was genuine on the part of the "West" and all supporters of economic and intellectual freedom.

In the years 1919 and 1920 Soviet Russia had invaded Hungary, Bavaria and Poland with the help of local communists and then also partly of soldiers. Everywhere these advances had been swiftly suppressed or repulsed, and the Soviet Union had devoted itself to "building socialism in one country," though Stalin continued to be called the "leader of the world proletariat." In the summer of 1950, however, communist North Korean troops had conquered most of the south of the peninsula, and when the American counterattack appeared to be successful, Chinese "volunteers" intervened. In the end, the status quo ante was restored, but communist forces prevailed against the French in Vietnam, and there, too, temporary stabilization was achieved only with great effort and difficulty. The attacking force thus withdrew much less into itself than it had been the case after 1918, and the theater of its activities was now worldwide. Objectively, the West was on the defensive, even though the greater part of Germany and all of Japan were within its sphere of influence.

In the period after World War I, the sense of threat and also the news of the "Red Terror" in Russia had contributed significantly to the rise to power of a new type of party in Italy and then in Germany, which were more intensely hostile to communism than the parties that had existed up to that point and which nevertheless bore striking similarities to the enemy, both as movements and as regimes. Nothing of the sort took place in the countries of the West after 1945: American McCarthyism remained a long way from developing into a party and even from seizing power—certainly also because the established parties developed a determined will to assert themselves and to defend themselves, not least the Berlin Social Democracy under the leadership of Ernst Reuter, who had been General Secretary of the German Communist Party in 1921. However, the most important means of struggle and self-assertion was not political will, but an extremely efficient economy, which broke all previous production records in the USA and brought about the "social market economy" in Germany. Thus, the very concretely experienced sense of distress, even among the initially extremely cautious allies of America in Berlin, was soon mixed with a feeling of superiority, which looked down on the meagre living conditions "in the East" and no longer knew anything about that "world economic crisis," which in 1932 had made the difference that existed at that time almost invisible.

The early Soviet Union had not been entirely free from shocks to its confident self-esteem, for the struggle against Trotsky and Trotskyism was bound to raise critical questions about the October Revolution even among its supporters; but Stalin managed to overcome the crisis. Far more shattering after 1945 was the overthrow of the godlike “leader of all working people” Stalin, which began timidly soon after his death in 1953 and reached a stupendous climax in Khrushchev’s secret speech at the 20th party congress in 1956, confirming almost every criticism that had ever been leveled in the West at the Soviet system. However, Khrushchev and the CPSU managed to steer intra-Soviet criticism away from the system and toward the “cult of personality,” and there is no doubt that Khrushchev remained as enthusiastic a Marxist and convinced of the ultimate universal victory of communism as any of his predecessors.

In 1940 almost the whole of Europe had been divided into a Soviet-communist and a German-National Socialist sphere of power; in 1960, a one third of the world was communist and about one third “capitalist,” while the rest consisted of those “underdeveloped” areas that had already completed the process of “decolonization,” such as India, or were still in the process, such as Algeria and the Congo. In 1940 Stalin and Hitler had pursued a kind of pacification policy which, under the conditions of the undecided war between Germany and England, would very likely have led to war even if Hitler had not been a militant anti-communist and a radical spatial politician; in 1959-1962, during the Berlin and Cuban crises, nuclear war between the “superpowers” seemed to be on the verge of breaking out, but since this war—unlike that of 1941—objectively posed a threat to the physical existence of mankind according to widespread opinion, Khrushchev and Kennedy shrank back from such a dangerous and momentous decision. For almost 30 years the coexistence of the hostile systems stabilized, and what had been a fleeting impression between 1939 and 1941 now became the postulate and conviction of powerful currents of public opinion in the West and the official pronouncements in the East: the “peaceful coexistence,” indeed (according to the liberal opinion in the West) the “convergence” of the hitherto hostile halves of the world.

In 1941 the Soviet Union was under a single will, that of Stalin, just as Germany was under the will of Hitler. In 1963 the Soviet-Chinese conflict had become apparent, while in the West, French President de Gaulle was able to distance himself from the leading power USA far more decisively than Mussolini had been able to do against Hitler in 1940. It is true that the Soviet Union achieved great successes under Brezhnev: it was recognized as an equal nuclear power by the Americans, who were facing a heavy defeat in Vietnam, its extraordinarily enlarged fleet made itself felt on all seas, and in the Helsinki Agreement of 1975 it seemed to have won the definitive fixing of the borders of its sphere of influence. But

in return it had had to make important concessions to the Western concept of “human rights”; those “dissidents” who had endangered Soviet rule in Poland and Hungary in 1956 and in Czechoslovakia in 1968 were also becoming making themselves felt within the country, and above all, the convictions that had guided Stalin and countless other communists as late as 1941 had also become implausible in their own country: that “the bourgeoisie” was a dying class, that “capitalism” was a stagnant and rotting system, that an armed uprising of the impoverished workers was to be expected, and that there was no doubt about the “victors of history.” Although there were still quite a few voices in the West at the beginning of the 1980s that were very pessimistic about the future of the Western powers and considered a definitive defeat to be probable, they did not fear the impetus and enthusiasm of a hostile ideology, but the concentration of the will on the part of the other world powers, and unlike Hitler they did not look with bitterness and hatred at the enemy’s supporters in their own country who were determined to fight, but only with alarm at the many well-meaning and concerned people who were gathering in the “peace movement” and seemed ready to surrender to the Eastern powers and their medium-range missiles.

Thus, at the end of the 1980s, it was not militant anti-communism that sought war, as in 1941, but rather an extremely diverse entity, “the West,” which was geared primarily to the economic well-being of individuals and made “détente” its primary goal. The West sought rapprochement with a system that was still very different, still very powerful militarily, albeit weakened by the engagement in Afghanistan and still formally unyielding in its ideology. If this West or this “capitalist system” could still be called anti-communist at all, then it was a matter of “soft” anti-communism, which was very different from the “hard” anti-communism that had characterized the European civil war. This soft anti-Communism, it seemed, won the great victory of 1989/90, which included the reunification of Germany and the overthrow of the communist regimes in the states of non-Russian Eastern Europe. But the victory would hardly have come about if there had not been a remnant of toughness—principally Ronald Reagan’s decision to launch the “Strategic Defense Initiative” despite its exorbitant cost, and also the German government’s fundamental adherence to the concept of a “duty of care for all Germans” and the reunification of the country, which was so much questioned by many intellectuals.

It is very likely that this remnant of toughness and firmness of principle within a system that no longer “liberal” but “libertarian” in tendency had a causal, albeit by no means solely determining nexus with those developments on the other side that have become generally known since Mikhail Gorbachev took over the Soviet leadership in 1985 under the names “glasnost” and “perestroika.” This time the unavoidable task was to take up anew and deepen

what Khrushchev had initiated and what his successors had then suppressed again, namely the criticism of a “cult of personality” that in the long run could not be kept separate from the question of the “system” that had made it possible. It was a task for which there was no precedent in world history, as it was not a completely defeated state like Germany after 1945, but one of the victorious powers of the Second World War, which had held its own against the USA in the subsequent “Cold War,” the world civil war, after all for decades—and not always only defensively. However, its socialist system had failed to deliver on big promises, such as Khrushchev’s promise to surpass the USA in per capita production within ten years, and for some time the “Golden West,” which had been unmistakably present in its own country in the form of currency stores, had been an ideal and a dream for its countless residents. For western Germans, on the other hand, after 1945 there was an almost absolute necessity to take a highly critical view of the German past and specifically of National Socialism; integration into the West was not, like Jürgen Habermas thought, a “great intellectual achievement” of his generation, but rather it was a process that had been absolutely imperative politically and intellectually, especially since it could also be linked to German traditions, a process, moreover, that brought with it all the greater advantages the more clearly and decisively it was carried out without much “effort of the concept”. In the Soviet Union, however, triumphalism had been natural, even compulsive, and self-criticism, if it took place, must represent a much greater achievement than in Germany. A look at some of the books in which this pre-1990 self-criticism appeared is therefore warranted. I have chosen a novel that, at the time of its publication in 1988, was considered representative of glasnost and perestroika, a historical account that could only be published abroad in 1980, and a novel whose author died in 1964 and which was only made known to the Soviet public in a preprint in 1990.

Anatoly Rybakov’s novel “The Children of the Arbat” would largely fit into the literature of encouragement and glorification that dominated the field in the 1950s and 1960s. In the summer of 1934, almost all students from Moscow’s Arbat district, which had once been a bourgeois and genteel residential area, are convinced that the rousing pathos of reconstruction that permeated their entire lives opened the way to a great future, and that their country as the “shock brigade of the world proletariat” and “bulwark of the future world revolution,” was thus correctly preparing for its world-redeeming task. Nevertheless, the prevailing atmosphere is again perceived as pressure, the atmosphere of unrelenting effort, incessant struggle for the predetermined goals and against the many vermin and saboteurs, to whom such threats as “Expose! Punish mercilessly! Destroy! Eradicate! Sweep off the face of the earth!” are applied. A young student who is very loyal to the party line is expelled from the university and then arrested because his harmless wall-newspaper has given offense to the party leadership. But this incident is part of a larger game that ties the student’s uncle, the head of a

gigantic and newly built industrial plant beyond the Urals, even more closely to the man at the center of all these events—Stalin. Rybakov paints a very unfavorable picture of him: suspicious, power-hungry, vain, vindictive, brutal, skillfully playing off his subordinates against each other, he has risen to become the sole ruler of the huge country, and he now directs all his jealousy towards Sergei M. Kirov, the party secretary of Leningrad, who is so much more open and popular than he is. He sets his Chekists in motion against him, who, under Yagoda and Yezhov, have drawn a comprehensive control network over the entire population, in which everyone becomes a potential defendant, because the questionnaires that have to be filled out for all applications and requests relate to such a wide range of past activities, but also of relatives and friends, that everyone has to entangle themselves in contradictions or give insufficient information and is therefore helplessly at the mercy of the examining judge if even the slightest suspicion falls on him. No one can escape this power, which has its headquarters in the Lubyanka and is directed exclusively by Stalin's will. Kirov also falls victim to it, by clearing the way for a disappointed man's revolver. Hitler is mentioned only once in the book, namely in connection with the reports of the murder of Röhm and high SA leaders. The former opposition members Zinoviev and Radek, who have long since given way and are yet to become Stalin's victims, want to see this as the beginning of the "death throes of the Nazi regime," but Stalin declares them to be fools because June 30, 1934 was a strengthening Hitler, and he expects a corresponding strengthening of his own position when, six months later, he has Kirov eliminated and sets out on the path to the bloody "Great Purge" of 1936-1938. Nevertheless, the author Rybakov does not place himself on a moral judgment seat, but leaves open the possibility that Stalin is right about his rivals because by collectivizing agriculture—albeit with enormous sacrifices—he has broken the peasants' individualistic property instincts and, above all, fulfilled the conviction of the people that only fear of an all-powerful ruler would secure the necessary order, while freedom would lead to general slaughter.

Anton Antonov-Ovseyenko's "Stalin. Portrait of a Tyranny" is not a historical study but a pamphlet against Stalin, but it was written by an author who, through his family connections, had a great deal of inside knowledge of the Bolshevik ruling class. His father, Vladimir Antonov-Ovseyenko, had been one of the key participants in the revolution as the "stormer of the Winter Palace" and as a member of the "Revolutionary War Committee" led by Trotsky, and he had served the Soviet state in high positions, most recently in Spain, until the Great Purge, to which he fell victim. His son had to spend many years in prisons and camps; partly because he refused to call his father an "enemy of the people." For him, Stalin is nothing more than a common criminal who passed off his early bank robberies as service to the party and who distinguished from his peers only in a particularly high degree of cunning,

ruthlessness and hunger for power. “A professional criminal mingled with the professional revolutionaries,” writes Antonov-Ovseyenko. He, too, tells a lot about Kirov’s murder, and the details could hardly be more repellent, because after the crime not only everyone who knew or suspected something was murdered, but also their wives and relatives. So it is not surprising that in the early 1930s Stalin had millions of kulaks and numerous “sub-kulaks” or “kulak friends” killed and that he then set about exterminating Lenin’s guards, towards whom he had feelings of inferiority. But Antonov-Ovseyenko is not a supporter of Trotsky, because in his eyes Trotsky could compete with Stalin “in terms of dictatorship, self-love and belief in one’s own infallibility.” Even on Lenin his judgment is not unreservedly positive, for Lenin showed an incomprehensible degree of weakness and blindness towards Stalin, although he warned against him in his “Testament.” Even industrialization does not justify Stalin, as it was in good part a “hoax” using fake numbers. Cruelty at the center radiated deep into the periphery: when Chechens resisted evacuation orders during the war, they were locked in barns and burned alive; when the Germans approached the town of Oryol, the prisoners of the NKVD prison were herded into the basements and the rooms were flooded, killing all 5,000. (Similar things were reported from Lemberg.) It is said of Hitler that he only came to power through Stalin and his theory of social fascism of the social democrats and that the only medal that the Soviet generalissimo really deserved was a German Iron Cross, because the war had been won not by Stalin, but in spite of Stalin, with enormous losses for which the Supreme Commander was largely responsible. But every reader of the book has to ask himself the question: what kind of party was it that allowed “a filthy criminal to establish himself in the Kremlin”; what kind of regime was that, in which a single “man-eater” could keep many millions of people in constant fear, a mass murderer who, while linked to Hitler through the causal nexus of his crucial support, was compared to the German dictator, must be considered as the “Asiatic” and therefore worse manifestation?! It is hardly the intention, but as a consequence, Antonov-Ovseyenko’s interpretation leads to the self-rejection of an entire Soviet or Russian generation, namely to the thesis that “everyone” was guilty.

A third ideal-typical way of coming to terms with the terrible past is embodied in Vasily Grossman’s book “Life and Fate,” which was completed in 1960, four years before the author’s death and only published in the West twenty years later: the possibility of the radical, but understanding self-criticism. At the center of the book is the great battle for Stalingrad and the Soviet victory that marked the turning point of the war. Grossman tells of the bravery of the surrounded Soviet soldiers, whose leaders are almost without exception tried and tested Bolsheviks like the battalion commissar Krymov or the defender of the legendary house “six dash one,” whose defensive struggle draws the admiration of the whole country. He also tells without hate, although without admiration, of the German attackers and the hardships they

had to endure. Above all, however, he tells of the powerful, well-prepared attack by the Soviet troops, which leads to the encirclement of the German 6th Army within 100 hours and which Stalin closely observed and directed from distant Moscow. Although a particularly bright light falls on the tank commander Novikov, who postpones a decisive attack by eight minutes against the will of his general and Stalin, because that way the enormous losses that would have inevitably occurred at an earlier point in time could be avoided, Grossman obviously has no intention of denying the praise they deserve from the heroic deeds of the officers and soldiers, or from the decisions of Stalin. The victory of Stalingrad remains for him a heroic and world-historical feat, even though it was planned by a man who in peacetime had killed millions of his fellow human beings and was carried out by men who had helped this despot to oppress an entire nation. When Krymov was arrested off the battlefield on unfounded suspicion of anti-Party activity and taken to the Lubyanka, his own past life appeared in a completely new light in the torment of the night-long interrogations and torture. Had he not been all too indifferent when friends and acquaintances told him horrific details of their imprisonment or made a critical remark about Stalin and then begged him in deep terror: “Not a word to anyone, not to your wife, not to your mother; one word, and I’m lost!”? Had he not, too, once “never hesitated to deal with enemies”; had he thought for a minute many years ago how the Mensheviks, Social Revolutionaries, priests and kulaks felt when he threw them into prison? And now a pitiless man, who did not take part in the revolution because he was still a child, interrogates him and coolly refutes some of the statements that he, Krymov, firmly believes are correct, with the help of a thick folder in which all more important events of his life are collected through testimonies from informers—his friends, his relatives, even his wife. Now he recognizes “himself” in the man who interrogated and who had his kidneys smashed—the one who was one of the activists of a revolution of which he must say now: “Maybe it wasn’t a revolution at all, what the hell kind of revolution is that—that’s the Black Hundreds, vermin.” Thus, in the author’s reflections, good turns into evil, and the difference between the communist revolution and the fascist counter-revolution disappears: what Stalin brought into the world is nothing other than what Hitler created, namely “state national socialism,” and this state national socialism is the same monster, whether the supposedly legitimate Soviet question about social origins or the bloody German question about nationality is being asked; as the “totalitarianism” that it is, it has the same terrible effect whether it is currently undertaking the extermination of Ukrainian Jews in an atmosphere of hatred and disgust, or whether ten years earlier it was waging the extermination campaign against the Kulaks as a class on the same ground. Yes, Grossman only makes a slight internal distancing when he has an SS officer address the captured old Bolshevik as “teacher.” And yet the harshness of these statements does not mean the self-rejection of the Russian people, because Stalin appears—unlike Antonov-Ovseyenko—not as a “criminal,” but as a historical

figure of high, if terrible, rank.

However, one could ask whether this is really a Russian self-examination and self-criticism, or whether Grossman does not see himself more as a Jew. Indeed, his sympathy evidently belongs to a large extent to the fate of the Jews, and at the heart of the novel is the moving description of a gassing in Auschwitz. But immediately afterwards he tells of the “starvation camp” in which many Soviet prisoners of war perished, and he makes it vividly clear that slow starvation is a much more agonizing event than rapid death by gas. And this death by starvation in the German camp is not isolated, but the view goes straight back to the Ukraine, where communists handed over the “kulak vermin” to starvation by the hundreds of thousands. One could even claim that Grossman practices a Jewish self-criticism at the same time as a Russian one, because he derives antisemitism from three characteristics of the Jews, each of which can also be found in other minorities, but whose combination he declares to be unique. One of these characteristics is the extensive and highly productive activity in many areas of life and not least in the revolution, where many Jews “made a name” for themselves. At one point Grossman even says that there are considerations by some intelligent Jews that culminate in the realization that the murder of the Jews was necessary for the happiness of mankind and that they should consciously carry out this self-sacrifice. This is an exact and astonishing correspondence to views that were current among the Russian bourgeoisie and which, in Grossman’s case, are certainly not to be derived from “Jewish self-hatred.” Rather, his book is a great example of Russian and Jewish self-criticism that does not involve self-rejection.

The basic possibilities inherent in the Russian “coming to terms with the past,” this unavoidable task of the Russians, which is so similar and yet so unlike that of the Germans, should be brought out through the protagonists’ own words, and it cannot be said that they compellingly pointed ahead to the events of 1991. Under Gorbachev, a historical alternative emerged in the years from 1987 to 1990, which might have moderated the criticism of the past, but also the violent rebellion against development, and assigned a new role to the Soviet Union. With the introduction and assumption of the office of President, the general secretary of the CPSU sent a widely visible signal, and the Cold War came to a definitive end in those final months of 1990, when Germany was reunited, communist autocracy in the states of East Central Europe ended and the declaration of the heads of government of 34 CSCE states on the joint construction of a democratic, pluralistic, market economy in Europe was signed by Gorbachev. The CPSU could no longer have resisted the admission of other parties, having previously given up its claim to sole possession of historical truth, and after overcoming, albeit considerable difficulties it might have become the leading party of Soviet progress and

Russian tradition, so that the regime would have been markedly different from the Western form of pluralism, without opposing it with universal claims and proclaiming a future victory. In terms of attitudes towards its own past, this would presumably have meant that such a balanced portrayal of Stalin as that of the former political general Volkogonov would have become authoritative, but that Solzhenitsyn's "Gulag Archipelago" would also have found its way to the Russian public. Then the Soviet Union—if it had not continued the old policy of repression in the Baltics and elsewhere—may have been called a "free country" it would have remained far removed from rampant licentiousness of a libertarianism driving itself to hedonism and the paradoxically associated urge for prosecutorial approach to history that was unmistakably evident in Germany and even in France.

The clumsy coup by communist traditionalists in the party and army in August 1991 destroyed that possibility by its failure, and thereby the Soviet Union fell into disintegration into its component parts; Russia became a pluralistic state, albeit under the leadership or behind the smokescreen of a strong presidency, which no longer had, or did not yet have, the social foundations of such pluralism. Thus, antisemitism, which, unlike in National Socialist Germany, had been suppressed by the regime and even threatened with the death penalty, re-emerged in public, while anti-Zionism was promoted. It was not just a contradiction when pictures of Stalin were openly carried across the street during demonstrations, or when former Chekists openly boasted about their deeds in letters to the editor. The economy, which had been "privatized" using very questionable methods, entered the process of "capitalist globalization" without much resistance, but the "mafia-like" structures which had already made themselves felt under the Soviet system, now seemed to be on the way to autocracy, albeit no longer totalitarian, but quasi-pluralistic autocracy. The fate of the "Russian Federation" and the territories of the former Soviet Union that have become independent is uncertain and leaves little room for well-founded predictions. But there are favorable possibilities for the dispute over the interpretation of the past, which form a far broader spectrum than in Germany.

Beyond all the differences, however, the following can be said about this century and its epochs at the chronological end of the 20th century:

Born out of the First World War, the Russian Revolution of the Bolsheviks was the most important and momentous event of the century, because it violently attempted to realize socialism, that is, an ancient idea of humanity that had been brought into a modern form by Marx and Engels. The attempt failed simply because Marx and Engels had combined incompatible ideas, namely world unity, family-like character, and the abolition of

apparatuses and objectification. But it gave countless people great hope and aroused a hitherto unknown hatred in many others. This paved the way for a militant counter-movement that could draw on the still unbroken strength of nationalism and which produced an ideology that was based more on assumptions and postulates than on hopes and insights, an ideology which, in practice, was just as much, albeit in a different way, a “human extermination machine” as the Bolshevik system had been before it. Thus the period from 1917 to 1945 did not become the era of the proletarian world revolution, as Lenin had believed, but the era of fascism and the European civil war between radical fascist National Socialism of Germany and the increasingly state-oriented Bolshevism of the Soviet Union.

Soon after the end of the Second World War, in 1947, the era of the Cold War began, in which the countries of Europe played only secondary roles alongside the main antagonists, the planned economy of the Soviet Union and the market economy of the United States. There was talk of a “world civil war” with “conversion potential” on both sides, although non-ideological pragmatism has been gaining ground in the USA since the 1960s and the Marxist ideology of the Soviet Union and its satellites was losing strength and credibility. Economic and intellectual freedom combined with increasing prosperity eventually proved to be stronger and more attractive; the strategy of *détente*, even embrace, was far more successful than the strategy of militant confrontation in the European civil war; the Soviet Union dissolved in 1991, but Russia remained a large, albeit weakened, state. Today one no longer needs to demand that the world must distance itself further and further from the era of fascism and the European civil war, for this distance has long been an unmistakable reality. But this has by no means made it certain that the world is heading towards a future free of conflict, or even one with little conflict; only the war between great powers of equal rank, waged with all technical means, has become unthinkable and practically impossible. A definitive historical judgment on the violent socialism that seized power in Russia in 1917, and also on the violent nationalism that prevailed in Germany under the name National Socialism, will only be possible when it has become clear what the consequences of the unchained “capitalist globalization” and the constantly advancing liberalism have brought about. On the other hand, the question of how to understand the relationship between the two most important totalitarianisms of the 20th century—as a relationship of contradictory opposition, parallelism or a “causal nexus” between original and distorted copy, or as a teacher-pupil relationship, as it is formulated or at least hinted at by Solzhenitsyn and Grossman—can already be left to scholarly debate today, as long as moral and historical judgments are not confused.

Anyone who tries to squeeze the new and major problems of the 21st century into the

questions and emotions of the 20th century, who uses the terms “communism” and “fascism” for example, even though the relevant self-designation is not given by the political opponents and there are significant differences recognizable, is doing the future a disservice. Certainly there are continuities and renaissances in history, but Lenin’s and Stalin’s Bolshevism, and even more so Mussolini’s and Hitler’s fascism, have passed away since 1991 to such an extent that they should now finally become objects of scholarly reflection rather than objects or pretexts for partisan polemics.

Letter from François Furet

Letter from François Furet to Ernst Nolte

CENTER DE RECHERCHES POLITIQUES RAYMOND ARON

Paris, April 3, 1996

Dear colleague,

When I dedicated a long comment to you, I was well aware that I would arouse hostility towards my book in your country and beyond. This is how it happened; the very fact that I quoted you aroused a downright “Pavlovian” reflex on the left. Even Anglo-Saxon historians as diverse as Eric Hobsbawm or Tony Judt have reproached me for the fact that I only quoted your name without considering it necessary to justify this excommunication. One must break the spell of this magical train of thought; therefore I regret my actions less than ever. First of all, simply for professional reasons, as I was discussing questions which you have written about a lot for a long time. Your book “Fascism in its Epoch” (1963) had already interested me thirty years ago when it was published in French. Aside from this respect for the rules of our subject, your books also raise so many problems that are indispensable to understanding the 20th century that it is a great delusion to condemn them wholesale.

Indeed, this delusion finds its most visible origin in the obsession with Nazism that has dominated the democratic tradition for half a century, as if the Second World War would make its historical and moral significance ever more evident. Indeed, this obsession, instead of regressing as one moved away from the events that underlaid it, has grown in the 50 years that separate us from it, as the most important criterion for the good citizens to be distinguished from the “bad” ones (to resort for a moment to the vocabulary of the French Revolution). Yes, it even gave rise to imaginary fascisms because, even after the defeat of Hitler and Mussolini, people still wanted to find later incarnations of fascism.

The crimes of Nazism were so enormous, and so universally evident by the end of the war, that it is undoubtedly useful, and even necessary, to keep the memory of them alive for educational reasons, even long after the generations who committed these crimes have disappeared. Public opinion is more or less clearly aware that there is something specifically modern about these crimes, that they have something in common with certain features of our society and that we must be all the more vigilant in preventing a possible repetition. This horror of ourselves formed the breeding ground for the anti-fascist obsession and was at the same time its best justification.

But it has also been instrumentalized by the communist movement from very beginning. This instrumentalization was most clear and lasting shortly after the Second World War, when history seemed to issue a certificate of democracy to Stalin as a result of the defeat of Hitler, as if anti-fascism, a purely negative determination, would suffice as a guarantee for freedom. In this way, the anti-fascist obsession added an unfortunate effect to its necessary role. It has made an analysis of the communist regimes, if not impossible, at least difficult.

In your view, this delusion is particularly total in the German left and even in Germany in general, and for reasons that are in part very obvious. Nazism was a German apocalypse that robbed your country of its tradition and plunged it into an unprecedented calamity, which was magnified by the general condemnation. It is easy to see why collective political sentiments were almost exclusively mobilized by this national tragedy. It is just as easy to see why the anti-communist argument was subject to a kind of taboo, since Hitler had already made use of it. The same phenomenon can be observed, *mutatis mutandis*, in Italy for the same reasons.

Nevertheless, I ask wonder whether in your letter you are not exaggerating a little the analysis of the exceptional German case in this regard. After all, fascism, in its Nazi form, was a more or less taboo subject for every historian, even in my country and more generally in democratic Europe. By that I mean that the moral condemnation to which the two regimes were subject prevented studying or even realizing the popularity they enjoyed in the interwar period. Equally great was the taboo on any comparative analysis or even any notion of interdependence between communism and fascism, even if it was not for the same reasons. In France, too, such views were dismissed as mere instruments of the Cold War, although they are very common, especially among authors from the 1930s. It seems to me that the difference between your country and my country in this regard is more in degree than in principle. In France, the existence of a time-honored revolutionary and democratic tradition has promoted the communist illusion and has made it less possible to expose its dark points. The victory of the anti-fascist coalition, the “Popular Front,” in 1936 has worked the same

effect. The existence of an “anti-fascist” Marxist tradition is not alien to German culture. It is precisely this tradition that served the former German Democratic Republic for intellectual legitimization.

Whatever the situation of the French and German historians with regard to their understanding of the 20th century, it is clear that the obsession with fascism and thus anti-fascism has been instrumentalized by the communist movement as a means to hiding its own reality from the eyes of public opinion. Hence the need to question this view, which has gained the power of a theology, in order to approach the real history of fascism and communism. You have paved the way in this respect, and as time goes on, in ten or fifty years, when we have gained more distance, this will be clear to everyone.

Although I come from a different direction, I am, like you, trying to understand the strange fascination that the two great ideological and political movements—namely, fascism and communism—have exercised in our century. You focus attention on fascism, while I try to grasp the seductiveness that the communist idea has exerted on people's minds. But nobody can understand either camp without taking the other into account; so much do they depend on one another in their ideas, their passions, and in the global historical reality.

This interdependence can be studied in different ways: from the point of view of ideas, passions and regimes, for example. The first aspect leads us to analyze the extent to which democratic politics has been torn between the principle of the universal on the one hand and that of the particular on the other, or, to use their words, between transcendence and immanence: a philosophical antagonism that has intensified the passions of mutual enmity. The fascist movement was nourished by anti-communism and the communist movement by anti-fascism. But both shared the hatred of the bourgeois world that allowed them to ally with one another. After all, the comparison between the two regimes—the Bolshevik-Stalinist regime and the Hitler regime—provided material for an extensive literature since the 1930s, to which Hannah Arendt gave the most famous (but not the only) arguments after the war.

In my book, I have tried to do justice to all of these aspects. As you have very correctly seen, I am closer to your interpretation in this respect than to that of Arendt. The concept of totalitarianism allows one to compare what is comparable in the regimes of Stalin and Hitler, but it is insufficient to explain their different origins. That which follows the “historical-genetic” development—to use your expression—of the fascist and communist regimes seems to me to be more convincing and of a stronger force of interpretation. Still, I disagree with you on one important point. It seems to me that you overemphasize the *reactive*

character of fascism in relation to communism, that is, the fact that fascism emerged later in chronological order and was determined by the October Revolution. Personally, I see in the two movements two potential manifestation of modern democracy that emerge from the same history.

Lenin seized power in 1917, Mussolini in 1922, and Hitler failed in 1923 and succeeded ten years later. Accordingly, Mussolini's fascism could well be seen as a “reaction” to the threat posed by an Italian Bolshevism that had also emerged from the war and more or less followed in the footsteps of its Russian model. One can just as well make Nazism into a response to the German obsession with the “Comintern,” a response in accordance with the revolutionary and dictatorial manifestation of communism. This interpretation contains a part of the truth, insofar as the fear of communism actually formed a breeding ground for the fascist parties, but in my opinion only a part; for it has the disadvantage that it conceals everything endogenous and special about the individual fascist regimes in favor of all those things which it fight against together. The cultural elements from which they had put together a “doctrine” existed before the First World War and thus before the October Revolution. Mussolini did not wait until 1917 to invent the link between the revolutionary idea and the national one. The German extreme right, and even the right as a whole, did not need communism to abhor democracy. The National Bolsheviks admired Stalin. I will readily admit that for Hitler the hatred of Bolshevism had priority, but only in its capacity as the end product of bourgeois-democratic society. Incidentally, some of his closest followers, such as Goebbels, made no secret of the fact that they loathed Paris and London more than Moscow.

That is why I believe that the thesis of fascism as a movement “reacting” to communism explains only part of the phenomenon. It does not shed light on the Italian or German specialty. Above all, it does not allow us to understand what origins and characteristics the two fascist movements had in common with the hated regime. I explained this in considerable detail in the 6th chapter of my book (especially on pages 197-198), and I can spare you a repetition here. I would add, however, that if you ascribe not only a chronological but also a causal priority to Bolshevism over fascism, you are exposing yourself to the allegation of wanting to excuse Nazism in a certain way. The assertion that “the Gulag existed before Auschwitz” is not false, nor is it irrelevant, but it does not mean a cause and effect relationship.

Nor can I agree with your analysis of the “rational motives” for Hitler's anti-Semitism. It was true that the existence of numerous Jews on the various leadership posts of Communism—first and foremost the Russian Party—is a proven fact. But Hitler and the

Nazis in no way relied on this argument to give substance to their hatred of the Jews, which predated the October Revolution. Moreover, Mussolini, whom they held in such high esteem, had already led an anti-communist fascism that was not anti-Semitic to victory before them,. Here, too, there is a difference that separates me from you, namely with regard to the origins of Nazism, which were older and more specifically German than the hostility towards Bolshevism. Before the Jews were scapegoated for Bolshevism, they were already the scapegoats for democracy. If it is true that their special relationship with modern universalism made them an ideal target for such condemnation, they did so in both roles, both as citizens and as communists, the first conception preceding the second. (Incidentally, you yourself expressly mentioned that there were many Jews in the ranks of the Communists, but that many of them are also to be found among the representatives of liberal anti-communism in this century.)

Here, too, I come back to the particular violence of German culture towards modern democracy as an explanatory element for Nazism, which existed before Bolshevism. What you call the “rational core” of Nazi anti-Semitism, in my view, consisted rather in the imaginary superimposition of two successive, but not mutually incompatible, embodiments of modernity by the Jews. In my opinion, reading “Mein Kampf” confirms this interpretation. In this book, Bolshevism is only the last stage in the endeavor of the Jews to achieve world domination.

But this question is so comprehensive and central that we will come back to it more often in our future correspondence.

With great respect,

François Furet.

Appendix

STATEMENT TO MY READERS

[The two pictures at the end and the beginning are my insertions. The article itself, republished here in full, serves as the gateway and introduction of The Indo-European Friendship Club's book club on the works of Professor John Murray Cuddihy.]

“There is no escape from the self-defeating ethos of exclusivism and intolerance...as long as our fundamental culture is derived from a /Judeo-Christian/ religious tradition that insists upon the dichotomous division of mankind into the elect and the reprobate.” —Richard L. Rubinstein, *The Cunning of History: The Holocaust and the American Future* (New York, 1978), p. 93.

“The problem...dealing with Jewish attitudes toward non-Jews (*goyim*) is the great sleeper issue of contemporary Jewish life. It interacts with almost every aspect of the Jewish situation.” —Michael Wyschogrod, “Love your (gentile) Neighbor,” *Sh'ma* , IX, No. 175 (May 25, 1979), 113.

1) Throughout, I am hardly ever speaking about the Holocaust itself as an historical event. I am speaking about speech about the Holocaust; I am talking about Holocaust ideologies, about debates, and debates about the Holocaust. Historiography, not history.

2) Even so, some of my ideas may offend. Nevertheless, I know this dread and awful murder occurred. It is a matter for grief as well as for study. I, too, grieve with Jews over their irreparable loss. And I too have been moved by the moral radiance of some of its victims. As I came to the end of Chaim Kaplan's *Warsaw Diary* , as the “destroyers” block by block closed in on him — yes, indeed, among them, 70 Jewish policemen, he notes with his usual bitter scrupulousness — and as I read his final words — “If my life ends— what will become of my diary?”— (I don't know what the common reaction is), I cried, —from sadness, from

joy that the *Diary* and its testimony had survived in triumph, that a Pole had been its custodian, and that Kaplan had had the last word, for here was I, now, reading those very words, and crying.

The debate rages. It divides Jewish and Christian scholars, but, not infrequently, Jews and Christians can be found on both sides of the divide. *Is the Holocaust unique?* The argument runs right down into the very nomenclature for debating it. “What problems did the book */Sophie’s Choice/* pose for you initially?” *LOOK* magazine asks author William Styron in the August issue. “There was a kind of sacrosanct quality about Auschwitz,” he replies, “and from now on I’m going to say Auschwitz instead of the Holocaust because I’d prefer it. I fully understand the use of the word Holocaust, but I don’t think it’s applicable to the entire experience of the concentration camp, especially because it applies to a lot of other people who were not Jewish who were victims. So I’m going to use Auschwitz as a generic description,” he concludes bluntly.¹

The argument *for* the uniqueness of the Holocaust, on the other hand, occurs, frequently, in oblique form, in the indignant denial of the legitimacy of comparison, or in the brusque dismissal, say, of the Armenian massacre as an “obscene comparison.” City University of New York historian Henry Feingold, for example, criticizes Marcel Ophuls, film director of “The Meaning of Justice,” for his tendency to rob the Jewish Holocaust of its “horrendous particularity” and thus to “trivialize” it. “Nazism becomes not a *uniquely* demonic force,” he writes, “but the dark side of the human spirit which lurks in all of us.”² The comparisons and equations Daniel Ellsberg formulates in this same film represent an attempt, Dorothy Rabinowitz claims, “to discredit the idea of a *unique* evil perpetrated by Nazism and unequalled in history.”³

Why do so many Jewish and some Gentile scholars insist on the uniqueness of the Holocaust? The obvious first answer is: because it *was* unique. The obvious reply to this is: but every event in any region of space-time is unique. The answer to this, in turn, is given by Roy Eckhardt: but the Holocaust is “*uniquely* unique.”⁴

“Uniquely unique” according to what criterion, in what category? There has been much search—research—invested in establishing such criterion, a criterion that will be positive and not negative, empirical and not mystical, one which will decisively differentiate the Holocaust from all other atrocities and from all other genocides. A quantitative criterion, since scale is a continuous variable, will not do, since it invites, precisely, comparison. The

quarry of this quest is for a property which will place the Holocaust in a *sui generis* category.

Paul Robinson, in the *New York Times Book Review*, in questioning Bruno Bettelheim's conviction that our age has been uniquely terrible and that its unique terribleness found perfect expression in the death camps of the Third Reich, examines three explanations typically advanced from the uniqueness of the Holocaust: it was systematic or total, it was senseless or non-instrumental, and it was specifically death-intending. Each criterion is, in the end, found wanting. But what really troubles Robinson is not the inadequacy of the various criteria, but the search for a category of uniqueness itself. "It serves little intellectual or moral purpose, in my opinion, to insist that the victims of the camps occupy a status ontologically different from, say, the victims of Alexander the Great, Attila the Hun, the Albigensian Crusade, the Thirty Years' War, European imperialism or black slavery." The reason given for "placing the destruction of European Jewry in a distinct category" are important, "but they do not categorically separate the holocaust /sic/ from other historical acts of humanity." Of course there are distinct differences between, say, "the horrors of the holocaust and those of slavery" but "we should resist the temptation to make the distinction categorical."⁵

If we listen carefully to this text "with the third ear," do we not hear echoes of the Jesus Prayer, "...lead us not into temptation?" By yielding to the temptation to make the difference between the Holocaust and, for example, slavery categorical, Robinson continues, "we do not deepen our sense of shame about what we, as a species, have done to another. Just the opposite: We impoverish that sense because we dismiss as relatively trivial all the sins that mankind had to answer for up to 1933." A further consequence: "one would have to set aside as out-of-date the great historical portrayals of human wickedness left to us by, among others, Dante, Shakespeare and Milton, for the simple reason that there was no holocaust in the moral universe of any of these artists."⁶

In the "temptation" to make the Holocaust *sui generis* Robinson detects a sin, the sin of "impoverishing" our sense of shame and guilt by particularizing it. He urges that we "resist" that temptation.

Let us turn now to the other side. How do Jewish proponents of the utter, unique depravity of the Holocaust hear comparisons between the Holocaust and other atrocities? Let us attend to Professor Michael Walzer of Harvard. Walzer listens as Yehudi Menuhin, in the Ophuls film, says, ' "Every human being is guilty..." ' /of the Holocaust/, and Walzer's instant reaction is: "That is a pleasantly Christian pronouncement...."⁷ I think that in this text we must take the

adjective “Christian” as importantly as in Robinson’s case we took words like “resisting,” “temptation,” and “sin.” The unmistakably sardonic undertone of Walzer’s words is inseparable from the conviction that, in Menuhin, he confronts a Jew who, tempted to apostatize from the uncomfortable particularity of Jewish identity and the Holocaust, has succumbed to the lure of a “pleasant” Christian universalism.

Another argument for the uniqueness and centrality of the Jewish victims in World War II is the well-known argument from “reversed” priorities of Lucy Dawidowicz and others. The idea that Nazi anti-Semitism was of “a qualitatively different character than its predecessors in central Europe and that it held a unique primacy in Nazi decision-making is not a new one,” as historian Henry Feingold notes, citing Poliakov, Mosse, and Jacob Robinson. Instances of the diversion of rolling stock and personnel from prosecuting the physical or national war to the ideological “war against the Jews” do not prove that the ideological war against the Jews was necessarily the real or primary war. Feingold writes:

“The absence of even a pretense of being value free history raises questions on the nature of the evidence Dawidowicz used to prove the primacy of the war against the Jews....For Jews and their historians the holocaust is naturally the touchstone of all sensibility. But does that distort a true historical perspective? Ethnocentric readings are not unheard of among Jewish historians....To my knowledge no noteworthy student of European history would deny that a racial fixation was one of the keys to Nazi motivation, but neither would any of them assign to Nazis’ racial ideology the role that Dawidowicz does....the liquidation of the Jews, terrible as it was, was a relatively minor happening. Genocide is neither unprecedented nor metahistorical. The ‘final solution,’ /Feingold concludes/, takes its place with other atrocities in the bloody history of the West. Seen on the larger canvas of European history, the holocaust does not have the importance and uniqueness it has on the canvas of Jewish history.”⁸

Even if the argument from “reversed” priorities or counterproductivity were to prove the priority of the fanatical ideological war against the Jews, this would not of itself categorically distinguish the Holocaust from the Armenian genocide. For example, Helen Fein in her recent, powerful book, *Accounting for Genocide*, notes that the German Ambassador to Turkey, Count Wolf-Metternich, “understood that the Armenian extermination was an end in itself to the ruling /Turkish/ triumvirate and its party...,” and quotes the ambassador’s complaint that the Turkish ally, in its efforts to deport and exterminate the Armenians, “hampered the conduct of the war. These measures...gave the impression as if the Turkish government were itself bent on losing the war.” Professor Fein, noting that “skilled Jewish

workers were killed and railroad cars were diverted to bring the Final Solution into effect rather than to mobilize against the allies,” adds, “just as Armenian workers had been annihilated in Turkey during World War I, hindering Turkey’s mobilization.”⁹

Emil Fackenheim, a philosopher of the Holocaust, defends a version of the centrality thesis in arguing for uniqueness. Refusing what he takes to be Richard Rubenstein’s “extreme technological nightmare” analysis of the Holocaust, that, he maintains, derives from Lewis Mumford and others, in which the Jews become the “waste products” of a radically dehumanized industrial machine,¹⁰ Fackenheim identifies the uniqueness of the Holocaust with the uniqueness of its victims: it was uniquely and directly targeted to Jews.

The text in which he summarizes his conclusion bears close reading: “We must conclude, then,” he writes, “that the dead Jews of the murder camps /and here Fackenheim adds a revealing parenthetical aside/ (and all other innocent victims, as it were, as quasi-Jews, or by dint of innocent-guilt-by-association) were not the ‘waste products’ of the Nazi system. They were *the* product.”¹¹

The Gypsies, Catholic Poles, Christian Slavs, and others are proving to be syntactically awkward for this particular reading of the Holocaust, just as they proved to be juridically awkward, as we shall see, during the Eichmann trial in Jerusalem. If the uniqueness of the Holocaust is demonstrated by the uniqueness of its victims—the Jews—then the *other* victims become a kind of residue, to be mentioned in passing in a parenthesis, and converted to a new, and sociologically anomalous, if presumably honorable, status: “quasi-Jews,” “as if Jews.” “It helps, even if we are not ourselves victims, if we can ‘claim relationship with’ accredited victims.”¹²

The Gentile victims at Auschwitz, then, become what Talcott Parsons calls a “residual category,” whose deaths were somehow the unintended consequences of a purposeful social action, who died as if they were not themselves but stand-ins for another group, the Jews.

Fackenheim’s *als ob* strategy for coping parataxically with the Gypsy and Gentile victims of Auschwitz involves a curious sequel. Two years later, in early June of 1974, a Jewish and Christian symposium on Auschwitz was held at the Cathedral Church of St. John the Divine in New York City.¹³ Eighteen days later there appeared, on the Op-Ed page of *The New York Times*, an essay by the novelist William Styron, in which he protested the symposium’s “overwhelming emphasis on anti-Semitism and Christian guilt.” Noting that more than one million Christian Slavs were murdered in the same way as the Jews, in the same place, he

concluded: "...I cannot accept anti-Semitism as the sole touchstone by which we examine the monstrous paradigm that Auschwitz has become...to place all the blame on Christian theology is to ignore the complex secular roots of anti-Semitism as well.. If /the Holocaust/ was anti-Semitic," he ends, "it was also anti-Christian...it was anti-human. Anti-life."14

Styron's reaction to the Auschwitz symposium provoked, in turn, the notoriously indignant and astonishing counterattack by Cynthia Ozick, "A Liberal's Auschwitz." (It appeared, in a quarterly appropriately titled *Confrontation* .) In this reply of Ozick, defending the uniqueness of the Holocaust, Fackenheim's quasi-victims return, minus their parenthesis. "The Jews," Ozick retorts to Styron, "were not an *instance* of Nazi slaughter; they were the purpose and whole reason for it. Like any successful factory in roaring production," she adds, "the German death-factory produced useful by-products: the elimination of Slaves and most Gypsies."15

A curious transposition occurs in this Ozick text. In the original Fackenheim formulation, which Ozick had evidently read,16 the term "waste product" is vigorously rejected as applicable to Jewish victims. Ozick then picks up the epithet rejected by Fackenheim for Jews, changes it to "by product," and applies it to the non-Jews.

In this Ozickian hermeneutic of the Holocaust, Christian Slavs and most Gypsies are, indeed, *de facto* victims, but they fail to achieve what I have elsewhere called "accredited victim" status.17 They fail to achieve it because, being an ascriptive status, it *cannot* be achieved. For Miss Ozick these "non-Jewish" victims are dead all right, but dead for all the wrong reasons, incidentally dead, mere "by-products" of the Holocaust, as she calls them, lapsing into her revealing and ghastly metaphor.

Styron waits three years and then returns to the thrust of Ozick's "by-product" metaphor in *New York Review of Books* essay entitled "Hell Reconsidered."18 He argues as follows: Yes, he concedes, the vast numbers of Russians, Polish Christians, Gypsies, and others who were exterminated by the Nazis "would possibly seem less meaningful if the victims had been part of the mere detritus of war, accidental casualties, helpless *by products* of the Holocaust; but such was not the case...."19

Hovering over the uniqueness debate as we look back, and haunting it at every turn, there is, I believe, an ancient residual category, viz., that of "non-Jew." It re-emerges at all the great turning points in Jewish history, and in all the great historiographical debates: in the Balfour

Declaration, during the Eichmann trial, in the historiography of the Holocaust. Residual categories are negative categories, and they create not only substantive and methodological problems for the social scientist but they have moral consequences for human beings.

The late Talcott Parsons offered this definition of a residual category (in *The Structure of Social Action*)—by thinking of the category “non-Jew” as you read it:

“If, as is almost always the case, not all the actually observable facts of the field, or those which have been observed, fit into the sharply, positively defined categories, they tend to be given one or more blanket names which refer to categories negatively defined, that is, of facts known to exist, which are even more or less adequately described, but are defined theoretically by their failure to fit into the positively defined categories of the system. The only theoretically significant statements that can be made about these facts are negative statements—they are *not* so and so.”²⁰

Let us take two examples, the Balfour Declaration and the Eichmann trial.

When British foreign secretary Arthur James (subsequently Lord) Balfour, at the instigation of Chaim Weizmann and Nahum Sokolow, wrote his famous 67-word letter to the second Baron Rothschild on November 2, 1917, the two sleeper words among the 67 were “home” and “non-Jewish”: “...His Majesty’s Government view with favor the establishment in Palestine of a national *home* for the Jewish people, ...it being clearly understood that nothing shall be done which may prejudice the civil and religious rights of existing *non-Jewish* communities in Palestine....”²¹ The population of Palestine at the time was 800,000 of which 58,000 were Jews.²² The “non-Jewish” population category was 742,000. With the vast majority of Palestinians thus defined residually, as not being Jews, it was understandable that Herzl could speak of the Jews as “a people without a land” emigrating to “a land without a people.”

In the Eichmann trial, in the eleventh count of the indictment, Eichmann was convicted of the “deportation” of “scores of thousands of Gypsies” to Auschwitz, but he was not also convicted of their murder by the Israeli court, as he was in the case of the Jewish victims. Hannah Arendt comments on this as follows “...the judgement /of the court/ held that ‘it has not been proved before us that the accused knew that the Gypsies were being transported to destruction’—which meant,” Arendt notes, “that no genocide charge except the ‘crime against the Jewish people’ was brought” in the Eichmann trial.²³

The court, Arendt appears to be arguing, embraced the defendant's own alibi—namely, Eichmann's fiction of the separation of deportation from extermination—only when it applied to the Gypsies. For how is the Holocaust to be uniquely Jewish unless a way can be found for juridically confining the crime of genocide uniquely to its Jewish victims?

“This was difficult to understand /Arendt remarks/, for, apart from the fact that the extermination of the Gypsies was common knowledge, Eichmann had admitted during the police interrogation that he knew of it....His department had been commissioned to undertake the ‘evacuation’ of thirty thousand Gypsies from Reich territory, and he could not remember the details very well, because there had been no intervention from any side; but that the Gypsies, like Jews, were shipped off to be exterminated he had never doubted. /Thus/ he was guilty of their extermination /she concludes/, in exactly the same way he was guilty of the extermination of the Jews.”²⁴

Before concluding this section, we will take one more text for analysis. In his second Stroum lecture, “Against Mystification: The Holocaust as a Historical Phenomenon,” Professor Yehuda Bauer of Hebrew University, while conceding that there are certain parallels to the Holocaust—otherwise “the whole phenomenon is inexplicable”²⁵—insists at the same time on the utter uniqueness of the Jewish situation. What is significant for us is that he falls back on two lexicons to argue this position: Marxist and religious.

“Not to see the difference....,” he writes, “not to realize that the Jewish situation was unique, is to mystify history,”²⁶ and he sets his task as the demystification of the mystification. But soon, significantly, he builds to the language of classical, Levitical anathema: “...to say that the Holocaust is the total of all the crimes committed by Nazism in Europe, to do any or all of this is an inexcusable *abomination*”²⁷

Despite the book's title, *The Holocaust in Historical Perspective*, Bauer culminates with a definition of the Holocaust in the perspective of religion, religious not alone from the perspective of the victims but, surprisingly, from the perspective of the perpetrators also: “Holocaust,” he writes, “was the policy of the total, *sacral* Nazi act of mass murder of all Jews they could lay hands on.”²⁸

There is, this suggests, a latent sacred interpretation of the Holocaust that surfaces from time to time, even in academic Jews of impeccable secularity. It is as though the ultimate, evidential proof of the Holocaust's uniqueness had to pass through a process of radically separating one class of Hitler's victims from all the others before appealing to the intention of

Hitler himself as a guarantee, when empirical doubts arise, of the centrality of the class of Jewish victims.

When all else fails, we can fall back on the fanatical purity of Hitler's racial fixation: He, at least, knew what he was doing. Others of us may be misled by trivial comparisons with other carnage; Hitler alone discerned the unique identity of his sacred victim.

Bauer's definition, like Ozick's, validates this eerie latent hermeneutic of the Holocaust. The ultimate, hidden assumption behind the insistent definition of the Holocaust as "uniquely unique"—from Bauer to Eckhardt—involves essentially a Durkheimian division of the Holocaust "product"—its victims—into two kinds: sacred and profane. Thus, to call the Nazi Holocaust, as Bauer does, a "sacral Nazi act," may be—if we may thing the unthinkable—to depict Hitler himself as beholden to the Orthodox Jewish definition of itself as a sacred people, a people apart, a *goy kadosh*? a people *k'khol ha-goyim* that, even in death, is forbidden to mingle with "the nations," with what Cynthia Ozick calls the unintended and profane consequences, the mere "by-products," the—dare we say it?—*trayf* of the "sacral" act of the Holocaust?²⁹ Two ritual categories of victim: the "sacred," intended victims, and the profane "by-products": is this not—as Robie Macauley says³⁰—a way of playing Hitler's game?

Or is it? Suppose Hitler borrowed his game.³¹ Who started this game anyway? Who cares?! The point is to stop playing it. As Richard Rubenstein writes: "There is no escape from the self-defeating ethos of exclusivism and intolerance...as long as our fundamental culture is derived from a /Judeo-Christian/ religious tradition that insists upon the dichotomous division of mankind into the elect and the reprobate."³²

Whatever the merits of the uniqueness claim, we can still inquire into its functions. Even if our contention as to the latent content of the uniqueness debate—viz., that the uniqueness claim is premised on a secularized (and sometimes not so secularized) conviction of Jewish chosenness—should prove to be inadequate or false, as sociologists we can still examine what functions (latent and manifest) the claim to the Holocaust's uniqueness performs for its claimants.

One function, for example, is that by stressing what I have called "sacred particularity,"³³ empirical enquiry into the complex *secular* roots of anti-Semitism is neglected in favor of easy theological deductions. A direct causal emanation from the cultural value system into

the social system spares us the trouble of seeing what conditions in politics, economics, demography, and psychology conduce to anti-Semitism.

Again, the uniqueness claim lends itself to the classical Zionist ideological conviction of the ubiquity and eternity of Diaspora anti-Semitism. A unique Holocaust involves the almost *a priori* symbiosis of Judaism and anti-Semitism. This interpretation claims, according to David Blumenthal, that the Holocaust, “in its truest sense, is a Jewish affair; that is, *therefore* , has its deepest roots in anti-Semitism.... It is more than ironic that both the Zionists and their enemies should perceive the hermeneutic of the Holocaust developed by the Jewish community as being the same.”³⁴ “In this connection,” Peter Berger argues, “the insistence by some that the Holocaust must be the core of Jewish self-reflection today has the *function* of freezing the presence of anti-Semitism in the consciousness of Jews—and this covering up the question of why one should be a Jew.”³⁵ Berger calls this insistence a “strategy” for circumventing the “heretical imperative” of choice immanent in modernity”³⁶

My chief interest in the uniqueness claim is to ask: What, today, is the Jewish community getting out of this claim? What function is the consuming interest in the Holocaust performing for the Jewish subculture and its members? Like all important, deep concerns, even obsessions, this one is “overdetermined,” sociologically speaking. It has many functions to perform, and more than one reason for existing.

I select, as the focus of my interest, the Holocaust and its uniqueness claim as an instance of a cultural status claim. Too often, status is seen in relation to social class alone. My work has explored how subcultures and their minority intellectuals may be viewed as *cultural* status-seekers engaged in an inter-ethnic and intra-social *kulturkampf*.

Like the struggle of scientists over priorities in scientific discovery—which Robert Merton has so brilliantly explored³⁷ —I view the ardent concern for uniqueness as a special case of what Merton calls “the power of the drive for ethnocentric esteem.”³⁸ What he terms “the type of ethnocentric concern with national priority of discovery that turns up again and again...,”³⁹ I regard as a variant form of the concern with uniqueness or specialness. Let us be frank: National priority and national uniqueness (uniqueness) are both covert claims to superiority, parallel paths to the same summit, and that summit is what Merton calls “ethnocentric glory.”⁴⁰ Individuals, like groups, pursue the prestige of the superiority of uniqueness even in the terrible passages of their history. “Jesus Christ, *supreme* victim”⁴¹ may be a paradox; it is not a contradiction.

As in the case of “Symbols of Class Status,” as Goffman has shown,⁴² so in the case of symbols of cultural (and subcultural) status, uniqueness is a pre-eminent cultural value, enabling cultures (and subcultures), and the groups which are their carriers to be invidiously ranked on a scale of prestige.

Of course, much Holocaust attention is a prolonged act of grieving. It is grief-work.⁴³ Some interest in the Holocaust is sheer cognitive desire to know for-its-own-sake “what happened?” Another of its functions is to memorialize, to remember, and at the same time—perhaps paradoxically—to celebrate. There is a genuine effort to participate in—to use the title of William Goode’s recent study— *The Celebration of Heroes* , to which we must add his more sociological subtitle: *Prestige As a Control System*. ⁴⁴

To the profane eyes of a sociologist who is neither a Jew nor a Christian, one of the obvious if latent functions of the appeal to a sacred uniqueness is that it stakes out a subcultural status claim to exclusiveness, setting the claimant’s group and its members apart and making them immune from comparison. Praising the superiority of one’s group becomes a legitimate avenues of indirect self-congratulation. Self-regarding sentiment, improper as egoism, is praiseworthy when it acts out as “us-ism.”

In good part, the status power of the Holocaust symbol derives from the fact that it functions as a double theodicy: in one act, it separates Jews from Gentiles and blames Gentiles, in the person of Hitler, for that separation. This is the function of the uniqueness claim that Jacob Neusner of Brown University has in mind when he writes of the Holocaust not as an historical event, but as an ideology the Holocaust in italics. Neusner writes: “‘The Holocaust’ is the Jews’ special thing: it is what sets them apart from others while giving them a claim upon those others. That is why,” Neusner concludes, “Jews insist on the ‘uniqueness of the Holocaust.’”⁴⁵ What Neusner calls “the claim upon others” that the Holocaust confers is what I call the social control function exercised by the prestige of cultural and subcultural symbols. Like social class symbols, cultural symbols serve “to influence in a desired direction other persons’ judgment” of the group that is the symbol’s carrier.⁴⁶ Think of the aristocratic function of family trees and “patents” of nobility. Symbolic cultural behavior, or social action featuring symbols, is designed to move (and thus to socially control) others, to pay us the old difficult *doxa* : glory, honor, praise, esteem, approval, deference, opinion, repute. The craving for recognition and prestige is ubiquitous. How, when legal sanctions do not apply, prevent the misrepresentative use of class and cultural symbols? A latent function of at least some of the research devoted to the Holocaust symbol is to find, in the absence of *legal* restrictions for the misrepresentative use of it, moral, intrinsic, natural, socialization,

and cultivation restrictions⁴⁷ on the misuse of it.

It is in this light that one should view even the definitional struggle itself, in its focus on uniqueness. Uniqueness is at once a device for conferring status and for preventing “fraud” (i.e., “obscene comparisons”). Hence, cultural items, events, and behavior used to signify cultural prestige—paralleling the case of class and social status—are frequently proposed and defended on the basis of limited supply or natural scarcity. What Goffman calls “historical closure”⁴⁸ is a form of temporal scarcity. An incident a few years back illustrates the importance of this as a device for restricting misrepresentative use of the Holocaust symbol.

The late Shlomo Katz, then editor of *Midstream* magazine, got into an angry exchange with black novelist-intellectual James Baldwin over Baldwin’s comparison of the solitariness of prisoner Angela Davis to that of “the Jewish housewife on the way to Dachau.” “Everybody,” he wrote indignantly, “tries to jump on each other’s bandwagon without regard to fact, to meaning, to consequence....” Then Katz proceeded to instruct Baldwin in the fact “that genocide has happened, once and for all, in the literal sense, and not in the rhetorical misuse of it ‘by fly-by-night self-styled revolutionaries.’” It is the term “fly-by-night” that gives the game away; Katz “considers himself to be addressing, clearly, cultural upstarts” who, in a subcultural status struggle, are violating proprietary cultural rights in a precious and unique symbol.⁴⁹ In the status-politics of subcultures, emulation is experienced as subversion, as, in another institution of the culture system, the art world, supreme value attaches to “originals,” not “reproductions.”

The case of Katz and Baldwin is an early example of the genus “obscene comparison” which Katz seeks to interdict by the devise of “historical closure.” Professor Yehuda Bauer, on the other hand, while insisting on historical uniqueness, shades the position, writing: “We should properly use the term ‘Holocaust’ to describe the policy of total annihilation of a nation or a people,” adding: “*To date*, this has happened once, to the Jews under Nazism.”⁵⁰ This is a modified “historical closure” position.

In part to prevent misuse of the cultural (or class) symbol, a curator personnel of subcultural intellectuals emerges “whose task it is to build and service”⁵¹ the symbol (or symbols) of cultural status. A cultural control system develops to prevent symbol contamination—religiously, syncretism—and to monitor and expose the evasions and circumventions of the devices for restricting misrepresentable uses of the Holocaust symbol. These curator groups seek to prevent what William Goode calls the “subversion of the prestige process.”⁵²

In such “subversion” through imitation, comparison, and, occasionally, outright falsification, other groups seize and manipulate the symbol for their own purposes. A form of such “subversion” occurs when the privileged symbol circulates⁵³ downward—call this “vulgarization”—or outward to other groups—call this “expropriation” by another group (say Blacks)—or upward—call this “elevation” (or universalization).

The drive behind the uniqueness claim—in this perspective, that of subcultural status aspirations—is to place the symbol “beyond comparison,” as, for example, when people exclaim: “Oh, there’s no comparison!”

This exemption from comparison is a heady privilege. This very exemption is itself a symbol of high cultural *yichus* . Among the many items selected by culture to symbolize status, incomparability alone is inimitable.

Henry Feingold, “Ophuls ‘The Meaning of Justice’: The Power and the Muddle,” *Congress Monthly* , XLIII, No. 8 (October, 1976), 8 (my italics).

Dorothy Rabinowitz, “Ophuls: Justice Misremembered,” *Commentary* , LXII, No. 6 (December, 1976), 67 (my italics).

Paul Robinson, “Apologist for the Superego” /review of Bruno Bettelheim, *Surviving and Other Essays*/ , *The New York Times Book Review* , April 29, 1979, p. 63.

Michael Walzer, “The Memory of Justice: Marcel Ophuls and the Nuremberg Trials,” *The New Republic* , LXXV, No. 15 (October 9, 1976), 21.

Henry L. Feingold /review of Lucy Dawidowicz, *The War against the Jews, 1933-1945* (New York, 1975)/, *Jewish Social Studies* , XXXVIII, No. 1 (1976), 83.

Helen Fein, *Accounting for Genocide: National Responses and Jewish Victimization during the Holocaust* (New York, 1979), pp. 16-17, 24.

Emil L. Fackenheim, “The Human Condition after Auschwitz: A Jewish Testimony a Generation After,” *Congress Bi-Weekly* , XXXIX, No. 7 (April 28, 1972), 9.

Ibid ., p. 10, reprinted in Emil L. Fackenheim, *The Jewish Return into History: Reflections in the Age of Auschwitz and a New Jerusalem* (New York, 1978), p. 93.

John Murray Cuddihy, *The Ordeal of Civility: Freud, Marx, Levi-Strauss, and the Jewish Struggle with Modernity* (New York, 1974), p. 212.

The papers are collected in Eva Fleischner (ed.), *Auschwitz: Beginning of a New Era? Reflections on the Holocaust* (New York, 1977).

This is extrinsically probable because—among other reasons—Ozick was herself a much-discussed author in the pages of the *Congress Bi-Weekly*. In the next issue, e.g., carrying the concluding Part II of Fackenheim's essay (May 19, 1974), she is singled out for prominent mention twice (24 and 30). Again in the very next issue (June 30, 1972), a reviewer writes that "Cynthia Ozick has called attention to..." etc. (25).

Part of this article reappears in altered form as the "Introduction" by William Styron to Richard L. Rubenstein, *The Cunning of History: The Holocaust and the American Future* (New York, 1978). /The book is a paperback edition of *The Cunning of History: Mass Death and the American Future* (New York, 1975)/.

William Styron, "Hell Reconsidered," *The New York Review of Books*, XXV. No 11 (June 29, 1978), 12 (my italics).

Talcott Parsons, *The Structure of Social Action: A Study in Social Theory with Special Reference to a Group of Recent European Writers* (Glencoe, Illinois, 1949), pp. 17-18. For another application of this concept, see Cuddihy, *Ordeal of Civility...*, p. 222.

For a different development of this theme—the secularization of Jewish chosenness—see Chap. 5, "Rabbi Arthur Hertzberg and the Metaphoricality of Jewish Chosenness" in John Murray Cuddihy, *No Offense: Civil Religion and Protestant Taste* (New York, 1978), pp. 101-155.

"Letters to the Editor: Who Should Mourn?", *The New York Times Book Review*, August 8, 1976, p. 22.

See the " *Erster Punkt* " in George Steiner, "The Portage to San Christobal of A. H.," *The Kenyon Review*, n.s., 1, No. 2 (Spring 1979), 114-116.

David R. Blumenthal, "Scholarly Approaches to the Holocaust," *SHOAH*, I, No. 3 (Winter, 1979), 23 (my italics).

Peter L. Berger, "Converting the Gentiles," *Commentary* , LXVII, No. 5 (May, 1979), 36 (my italics).

Cf. Peter L. Berger, *The Heretical Imperative: Contemporary Possibilities of Religious Affirmation* (Garden City, New York, 1979).

Cf. Robert K. Merton in Norman W. Storer (ed.), *The Sociology of Science: Theoretical and Empirical Investigations* (Chicago and London, 1973), Chap. 14.

Erving Goffman, "Symbols of Class Status," *The British Journal of Sociology* , II (1951), 294-304. I will quote from the reprint in Howard Robboy *et al* . (eds.), *Social Interaction: Introductory Readings in Sociology* (New York, 1979), pp. 266-276.